

Konstantin Sakaev & Konstantin Landa

The COMPLETE MANUAL of POSITIONAL CHESS



The Russian Chess School 2.0
Opening and Middlegame

NEW  IN CHESS

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The Russian Chess School 2.0 – Opening and Middlegame

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Introduction

This book is based on instructional material created for chess teachers at the DYSS, the special sports schools for youngsters in Russia. Of course, there are a great many such programmes in existence, as well as many good books, covering this or that theme. However, our beloved game is many-sided, and until now, there has not been a single work that covers as many as possible of the numerous aspects we should like to see treated.

In this book, we have tried to 'encompass the unencompassable' – in the first place, to delineate the most important subjects that a properly-educated chess player should master. Undoubtedly, different trainers do, and indeed should, have their own ideas and methods of preparing young players, but I hope my work will be useful to everyone involved in working in this difficult sphere. As I have had many occasions to see, the strong sides of a young player's play do not arise by accident, but depend crucially on the work he does with his trainer, or under the influence of the books he studies. But certain things may have been overlooked, and I hope that my book will help to reduce to a minimum these 'blank spots' in the education of young chess talents.

Now, a word about the material used in the book. There is no need at all to follow the contents of the books religiously in the order presented, and it is perfectly possible to jump from chapter to chapter, depending on the strength of the pupil and the areas that he most needs to work on. Thus, the process of a player's education can sometimes proceed more creatively and with greater variety, but no less effectively. But it is important that, overall, the pupil eventually becomes familiar with pretty much all of the topics. I believe that many trainers have excellent programmes, based on their own experience, but I hope that the material presented by me here will serve as a useful supplement to these programmes.

I would recommend that the trainer go through the games given here on the board with the pupil, including all the variations given. This is especially important because I have tried not to include too many variations, but only give those that are really essential to understand the position. It is important not just to demonstrate and explain what is happening, but also to ask the pupil's opinion on the key moments of the battle, and make him think. After some thought and discussion, you continue analysing the instructive moments. If an example in the book starts from a concrete position (rather than being a complete game), as the majority do, then one should first invite the pupil to assess the position and propose a move or a plan, and only then to start analysing the example in detail.

The book is aimed at players who are already around first category strength [translator's note: approximately 2000-2200 Elo] but some examples will also be useful to players of a higher standard. The book can also be used as a self-tutor. In this case, whenever you see a diagram, do not be in a hurry to read the subsequent text, but first try to assess the position yourself. The diagrams have been placed at the most interesting and instructive moments.

This textbook has been drawn up on the principle of 'from the simple to the complicated'. Easily understood, simple examples, are marked with a single star *, more difficult ones with two stars **, and, finally, the especially complicated ones with three stars ***. At the end of each chapter, we give links to additional material on the chosen theme.

In simple variations, which do not require text explanation, we have used symbol-based assessments, as follows:

I have tried to take an original look at many very famous textbooks, and to systematize and classify the huge amount of material to be found in them. Even so, the categorisations I have used are not totally beyond dispute, because in chess, different aspects of the battle are closely connected. The ability to accurately assess the significance of various different aspects of a position is something that comes with experience. No matter how talented a player may be, only after playing thousands of games and studying numerous books can he become a fully grown player. One can only call someone such a player if they have absorbed chess culture, and are capable not just of landing the occasional one-off blow, but conducting an entire strategical game. When looking at virtually any position, an experienced player can immediately delineate the important nuances, both static and dynamic. Which pawns and squares are weak, which pieces need to be relocated, what tactical motifs there can be in the position. I hope that my work will, among other things, help you to develop such an ability, which is vital for practical success.

As far as the examples given are concerned, these represent a combination of well-known classic positions, supplemented by cases from contemporary practice. I consider the latter element extremely important, because chess does not stand still, but is constantly developing, and one can often learn more from examples from contemporary practice, where the standard of play is higher. The most precious examples from the current generation of grandmasters are precisely those where they succeed in carrying out their plans in the face of the toughest possible resistance from their opponents.

The endgame is only touched on peripherally in this work, as it is a huge subject in itself, which deserves a separate exploration.

I hope that my experience of play at a high level, combined with discussions and creative work with many leading grandmasters, will make the work presented here of interest, and able to exert a permanent influence of the current generation of young players.

I should like to acknowledge the assistance of International Grandmaster Konstantin Landa.

General recommendations

In working with young players, it is essential to strive that they should develop on a rounded basis, to the greatest extent possible. It is useful if you can form a separate group of kids, who really want to perfect their play, as opposed to those who are only interested in playing and who come to lessons just for the sake of it. Having someone in the group who is bone idle has a poor effect on the others. With the ones who are not so interested and do not get the point about the importance of lessons, you can work less seriously. Such children can be left just to play and enjoy themselves, and they should not be stretched.

So, we proceed on the assumption that we have a group of children who are serious about improving their chess, and we wish to help them do so. A basic grasp of the principles of chess needs to be had by all equally, and so the fundamental work is obligatory for everyone. We can include in such work:

1) **The study of game collections.** Number one in importance! In principle, the study and analysis of any high-level games is useful. Collections of games with text annotations are the most valuable element in the growth of young players. Unfortunately, the importance of this component is very often underestimated. It is no accident that practically every great player had a bedside book, with well-annotated games, which he had read from cover to cover and knew practically by heart. The pupil himself can choose whose style of play and manner of annotation he likes best. I would start by recommending the classics – Capablanca, Rubinstein and Alekhine. In the first half of the 20th century, the standard of resistance put up by these players' opponents was not very high, and consequently the plans and combinations they carried out tended to appear in a very clear, clean form, which is easily understandable. Later, the pupil can move on to games by contemporary grandmasters, the World Champions in particular.

Nor should one ignore books in which top players comment on the games of a certain tournament.

2) **Studying good textbooks.** Of the many monographs available, I would single out the following:

In first place, Alexander Panchenko's works *Mastering Chess Middlegames* and *Theory and Practice of Chess Endings*, Shereshevsky's *Endgame Strategy* and *Contours of the Endgame*

Portisch, Sarkosy: *600 Endgames*

Gelfer: Positional Chess Handbook 1-2

Kotov: Think Like a Grandmaster

Euwe: Strategy and Tactics – a course of chess lectures

At a later stage of development, it is worth studying the books of Nunn, Dorfman, Tukmakov, Dvoretsky and also Beliavsky and Mikhalechishin's book *Intuition*. Of course, this list is very short and could easily be expanded.

3) Watching live games from current super-tournaments, at least to a minimum extent. Sometimes, when you have the chance, it can be useful to watch GM games live on the internet and ask yourself what you would play. In doing so, you should not switch on a chess engine, but rely on your own opinion. If you lack self-control and constantly switch the engine on, then it is better to remove the program from the computer. If you lack the time for live coverage, it is still useful to look through games from super-tournaments after the events. Pay special attention to those games that feature openings you play. Even if certain things remain hard for you to understand, they will stay in your sub-conscious and can grow over time.

4) Solving all different types of puzzles. The habit of playing positional battles is increased by thinking seriously about positions in which there are no tactics, or only a minimum amount thereof. Studies are useful for improving the depth and accuracy of calculation, and solving combinations helps cure you of the tendency to commit simple oversights. Those who solve a lot of combinations usually see tactical motifs immediately, if they appear in a position. You can find positions for solving in the books of Slavin, Ivashenko and Konotop, whilst to older and more experienced students I can recommend:

Hort + Jansa: *The Best Move*

Volokitin: *Perfect your Chess*

Dvoretsky's oeuvre.

5) Careful analysis of your own games, especially those in which you have experienced problems. It is desirable to do this with a trainer, if possible, and better still if the pupil can show the trainer his own (non computer-assisted!) analysis of the game.

Different types of lessons should be combined, so as to avoid a one-sided development and concentration only on one specific component of play. At the same time, lessons should not be a chore for the pupil, and one should try to create interest in those aspects that may not naturally attract the pupil.

As far as possible, one should try to control the pupil's fulfilment of his work tasks. To combat the natural laziness of youngsters, one must

constantly reiterate the important lesson that without constant hard work, they will not achieve the highest results. Of course, they can achieve certain successes in junior events, just on the basis of experience and talent, but they will not become top grandmasters without serious work.

Many youngsters study relatively little, but at the same time play blitz night and day. With care, rapid games can have benefits, but an excessive liking for blitz only spoils a player.

Now, we turn to the individual characteristics of the young player. The ability to make a clear and correct diagnosis in each individual case is the single most important job of the trainer. On the basis of an analysis of the player's games, plus conversations with him, one can determine which problems are the main ones preventing him progressing. These problems can be **physical**, **psychological** and **purely chess-related**.

One should look at a lack of **physical stamina** if the player habitually tires noticeably towards the end of a tournament or even of a single training session. In this case, one should recommend that the pupil pay more attention to maintaining a healthy lifestyle and playing sport. This is especially important nowadays, when chess requires more physical energy than ever. Those who pay no attention to physical fitness start to decline significantly in their play even once they reach the age of 25-30, whereas those who look after themselves physically can maintain top form into their 40s. As an example, one can cite Veselin Topalov, who spends 1.5 hours a day in the gym. During tournaments, he is able to put more and more energy into his games, and frequently comes through with a strong finishing spurt, when many of his opponents are starting to suffer with tiredness. One can also mention Vishy Anand, who is another who regularly goes to the gym, or Vladimir Kramnik, who maintains his fitness with tennis and swimming. Even amongst children, physical fitness can influence results, especially in the second half of tournaments.

Psychological problems can include most of all a lack of self-confidence, which in turn brings a whole raft of problems in its train. A player can start to fear his opponents, get nervous before crucial games, and, most of all, start getting into chronic time-trouble. To overcome these problems, he needs first of all to raise his opinion of himself. This means convincing himself of the slogan 'I can do anything'. He needs to understand that these are not just empty words, and ideally they should be strengthened by some definite successes, even if just in local events. For example, after solving a certain problem of studying a book of games, he should tell himself: 'I have learnt something and become stronger'. This improves one's self-confidence, and allows one to take difficult decisions more easily and avoid time-trouble.

Mikhail Moiseevich Botvinnik argued that players should play special ‘anti-time-trouble’ training games, in which the principal attention is paid to efficient time usage. In practice, nobody does this, but I would recommend keeping a note of time taken per move, and afterwards analysing the reasons for any long thinks. Of course, here the most important thing is self-control, the ability to tell yourself at a certain moment that it is time simply to make a move. No trainer can help with this problem, if the pupil is not himself willing to fight it. Thus, the main task of the trainer in such a situation is to be a good psychologist and raise the pupil’s self-esteem. Of course, there is such a thing as the so-called ‘justified time-trouble’, when time shortage is the result of definite problems over the board. If this happens only occasionally, this can be considered perfectly normal time-trouble.

Finally, **purely chess** problems. Of course, these can cause time-trouble. If a young player spends little time solving studies and combinations, he will have great problems calculating during a game. If he spends little time studying GM games, he will just be unfamiliar with many types of positions, which can also lead to additional long thinks and to mistakes. One such mistake is the incorrect evaluation of positions, whilst when the assessment is changing move by move, extra thought is required over each successive move. Objectivity in assessments is a mixture of chess elements and psychological stability. Even among very strong GMs, there are those who tend to overestimate their position, always thinking it is better than it is. Of course, much depends on the player’s character, but any extremes in this matter are undesirable, and one should always strive to assess the position as objectively as possible.

The opening is a component, the importance of which grows with the growth in the pupil’s strength. At first, it is preferable for pupils to begin the game with 1.e4, because open games help to develop their appreciation of rapid development, and also their tactical sharpness. But the main thing is the importance of a ‘correct’ approach to the game. Trappy, offbeat openings should be excluded from the pupil’s repertoire at an early stage, so as to avoid bad habits. Quick development and fighting for the centre are the most important things to learn, and this is especially clear in open positions. Over time, especially once the pupil has reached first category (c. 2000 Elo) or candidate master (c. 2200 Elo), it is useful to start introducing closed openings into one’s repertoire, and to start to be able to play ‘with either hand’, with the point that such variation in openings is a significant plus at GM level. A player who has reached master level without ever having played closed/open games, will find it much harder to add them at such a stage – the basics should be established at a young age.

The middlegame is usually the part that most interests children, and lessons on this part of the game tend to be received by them with particular

enthusiasm. It is in the middlegame that one faces with particular clarity the question of how to teach the pupil to **calculate variations** cleanly, and which criteria should apply in taking decisions. We will speak about this in detail in Chapter 8. As far as training calculation is concerned, the methods are well-known – one should regularly solve combinations and studies, and then the tactical motifs that arise in a game will not pass unnoticed.

Chess is not chequers and capturing is not obligatory. When one of your pieces is attacked, first of all ask yourself whether you have to move the piece, or whether you can sacrifice it or attack an enemy piece in turn. **Intermediate moves** are something every first category player should be capable of finding. And the converse applies – when you attack an enemy piece, ask yourself whether the opponent has to retreat it.

Speaking of the middlegame, young players are often too willing to trust generally-accepted assessments, based on material, without taking account of the specifics of the position. Their play is often hampered by a **fear of disturbing the material balance**. In such cases, it is useful to remind the pupil that every position is unique. And there are in chess as many exceptions as there are rules. To emphasise this, one can revisit the subjects ‘Positions with a non-standard material balance’, ‘Positional sacrifices’, and ‘Intuitive sacrifices’. One must be willing to take a risk sometimes, as without defeats, there are no victories. There is nothing to be afraid of!

I would also like to draw attention to the subject of ‘**Prophylactic thinking**’. This is a method employed by all top-class players. On every move, one should not forget to ask oneself: ‘What does my opponent want?’. Having answered this question, one can choose one’s reply. The habit of using this technique of choosing one’s move is something that should be inculcated from the very earliest lessons.

Endgame technique is more difficult to develop than middlegame play, because most pupils lack a fondness for this aspect of the game. However, those few youngsters who study the basics of the endgame and those best-seller textbooks on this area of the game have a colossal advantage over their rivals. In my experience, even the most talented youngsters play the endgame quite weakly when they start in adult events, and lose many points because of elementary mistakes at this stage of the game.

Another very important element is the **amount of chess** the pupil plays. His graph of tournaments should be balanced – on the one hand, there should not be long breaks between events, but at the same time, nor should he play non-stop. It is essential to be objective in assessing what he can do and what he can’t, and then work to eliminate his weaknesses. A badly-thought-out tournament calendar brings additional problems, blunders and time-trouble. Of course, one must take into account the individual characteristics of the pupil – the ease with which he plays, and his keenness

on analytical work and self-analysis. I think the optimal number of games per year is between 80 and 120.

Yet another important quality in a chess player is the ability during a game to **maintain concentration**. Unfortunately, this is a quality that tends to come with experience. Sometimes, too much emotion is wasted looking at the positions in other players' games. Another factor is patience, the ability to sit for a long time and think about one's position. In the main, blunders result from problems in this area. The young player needs to absorb the lesson that even the apparently simplest of positions can contain hidden resources. The most difficult thing of all is to maintain concentration in winning positions, or those in which one has a great advantage. It can seem that one has already finished the job, and there is a tendency to relax prematurely. However, many children also lack the ability to concentrate sufficiently on the problems in such positions. They do not like to defend, and prefer to be done with such a game as quickly as possible. An important part of maintaining concentration is maintaining a cool head. This quality is especially precious when you are in time-trouble. Even in a critical situation, with a bad position and time-trouble, one should try to ensure that all of one's decisions are rational. As a rule, young players panic when short of time, and at the last moment will make a move that they have already seen is bad, or one they have not even considered at all. It must be said too that even experienced grandmasters sometimes make such mistakes. Despite the apparent hopelessness of the situation, pupils should constantly remember the importance of maintaining concentration.

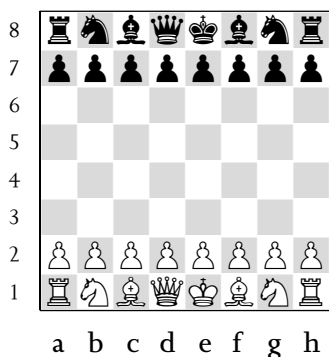
I wish you all success on this thorny path!

Konstantin Sakaev

This is Volume 1 of a two-volume work. Volume 2 will be about the middlegame – pawns and dynamics.

Explanation of Symbols

The chessboard with its coordinates:



- White to move
- Black to move
- ♔ King
- ♚ Queen
- ♖ Rook
- ♗ Bishop
- ♘ Knight

- ± White stands slightly better
- ∓ Black stands slightly better
- ± White stands better
- ∓ Black stands better
- +− White has a decisive advantage
- −+ Black has a decisive advantage
- = balanced position
- ∞ the position is unclear
- ∞ with compensation for the material
- ! good move
- !! excellent move
- ? bad move
- ?? blunder
- !?! interesting move
- ?! dubious move
- ↔ with counterplay
- with attack
- ↑ with initiative
- △ with the idea of
- a forced move

Part I

The Opening

Chapter 1

An advantage in development

The main principle in playing the opening is rapid development. Following this simplest of chess rules often proves the basis for success. Everyone is aware of the rule, but when it comes to practical play, one often sees players struck by 'amnesia'. As I have observed many times, in a normal situation, young players will develop their pieces sensibly, but if there are no convenient squares for development, they start messing around. If one's pieces are not well developed, one needs to address this issue, and not ignore it and occupy oneself with other things. Positions with blocked pawn chains may be a relative exception, but even in those, one needs gradually to bring all one's pieces into action. And in open positions, any delay in mobilising one's forces can quickly lead to disaster.

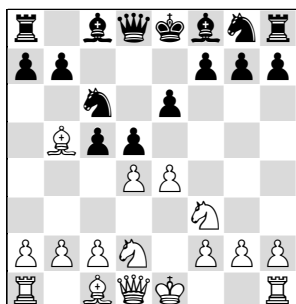
1

Mikhail Tal

Wolfgang Uhlmann

Moscow 1971 (6)

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3
♘c6 5.♙b5



5...dxe4?!

This move is dubious: Black surrenders the centre and allows the white knight to take up residence there. In addition, he opens a path for the bishop on c1.

6.♘xe4 ♙d7 7.♙g5

White does not miss the chance to develop with tempo. Admittedly, on his next move, he has to retreat

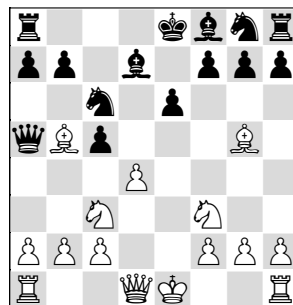
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2620

2570

somewhat, to defend the light-squared bishop, so this bishop lunge does have its downside. An interesting alternative is the pawn sacrifice 7.0-0!? ♘xd4 8.♙xd7+ ♗xd7 9.c3, with good compensation.

7...♗a5+ 8.♘c3

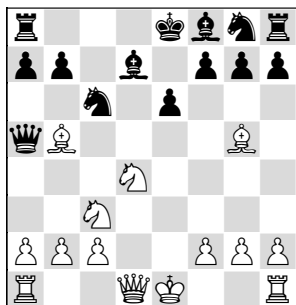


8...cxd4?!

Yet another non-developing move. It made sense to resolve the piece situation on the queenside: 8...a6! 9.♙xc6 ♙xc6 – because of the threat ...c5xd4, White has to help Black's development. Then, after 10.d5 exd5 11.0-0 f6 12.♗e1+ ♘e7 13.♘xd5 fxg5 14.♘xe7 ♙xe7 15.♘xg5,

Black has the problem-like move 15...c4!! – the queen is included in the defence along the fifth rank (15...♖f8 16.♗e6+ ♖g8 (16...♖f7 17.♖g4 g6 18.♖c4 ♖b4 19.♗g5+ ♖f6 20.♖e6+ ♖xg5 21.♖xe7+ ♖h6 22.♖e3 ♗xg2 23.♖xg2 ♖g4+ 24.♖g3 ♖he8 25.♖xb7 ♖ab8 26.♖xa6±) 17.♖g4 ♗f6 18.♗xg7 ♖f7 19.♖e3→ and White's attack is very dangerous): 16.♖h5+ (unclear consequences result from 16.♖g4 h5 17.♖g3∞) 16...g6 17.♖g4 ♖f5 18.♖d4 ♖xg5 19.♖xh8+ ♖f7 20.♖xh7+ ♖f8 – the game ends in perpetual check.

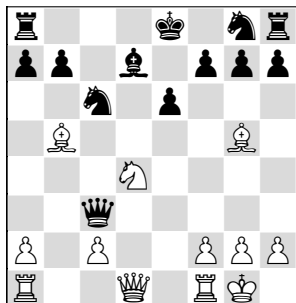
9.♗xd4



9...♗b4?

Even when so far behind in development, Black goes after a pawn, and in the process gives up a key piece, the main defender of his dark squares. Now, 9...a6 was simply essential.

10.0-0 ♗xc3 11.bxc3 ♖xc3



12.♗f5!!

If the knight is not taken, it lands on d6 with decisive effect. On the other hand, if it is taken, the central lines are opened up for the white major pieces.

12...exf5 13.♖e1+ ♗e6 14.♖d6 a6 15.♗d2 ♖xc2 16.♗b4 axb5 17.♖f8+ ♖d7 18.♖ed1+ ♖c7 19.♖xa8

Black resigned.

2

**

Mikhail Tal

Roman Toran

Oberhausen Ech-tt 1961 (9)

1.e4 c5 2.♗f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♗xd4 ♗f6 5.♗c3 e6 6.f4 a6 7.♗e3 ♗bd7

Not a very good move in this position, because White can defend e4, whilst at the same time driving the black knight from f6. The black pieces lose harmony.

8.g4

More precise is 8.♖f3 ♗c5 9.0-0-0, preventing not only ...b7-b5, but even the preparation of this move. Thus, after 9...♖c7, there is the strong move 10.e5! dxe5 11.fxe5 ♖xe5 (11...♗fd7 12.♗f4 ♗e7 13.♖g3 (he can also take a piece with 13.b4, although Black gets certain compensation) 13...g5 14.♗xg5! ♖g8 15.♗xe7! ♖xg3 16.♗d6 – thanks to his active pieces, White's compensation for the sacrificed queen is more than sufficient) 12.♗f4 ♖h5 13.♗db5 axb5 14.♗xb5+ ♗cd7 15.♖xd7 ♖xf3 16.♖c7+ ♖c6 17.♖xc6 ♗d7 18.♖b6 – White gets serious pressure on the queenside.

8...♗c5 9.♖f3 ♖c7

He should have played 9...b5! 10.g5 ♘fd7, with hopes of organising counterplay on the queenside.

10.g5 ♘fd7 11.a4 b6

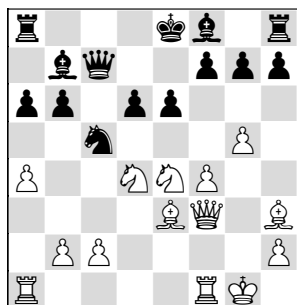
With this move, Black gives up the chance of activating his queen, so he should have preferred 11...♙e7.

12.♙h3 ♙b7 13.0-0

White threatens not only 14.b4, but also the quiet strengthening of the position with a move like 14.♖ad1, so Black decides on a desperate sacrifice:

13...♜xe4 14.♜xe4 ♜c5

If Black's pieces were mobilised, such play might have a chance of succeeding, but in this position, White has a simple blow, which flows from the logic of the position.



15.♜xe6! ♜xe6

15...fxe6 16.♙xc5+—.

16.f5

An armada of white pieces is bearing down on the lone black king, which is trapped in the centre.

16...♜c5 17.♙xc5 bxc5 18.f6!

Shutting in the bishop on f8 and preventing queenside castling.

**18...g6 19.♖ad1 c4 20.♖fe1 ♙d8
21.♜xd6 ♙xd6 22.♖xd6+ ♙xd6
23.♙xb7 ♖b8 24.♙xf7 ♖xb2
25.♙g7 ♖xc2 26.♙xh8+ ♙c7
27.♙c8+ 1-0**

3

Mikhail Tal

2560

Tigran Petrosian

2640

Moscow tt 1974 (1)

**1.♜f3 g6 2.e4 ♙g7 3.d4 d6 4.♜c3
♜f6 5.♙e2 0-0 6.0-0 ♜c6**

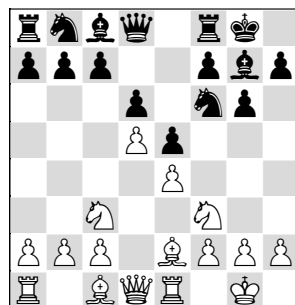
The pawn advance Black provokes is not one White would have chosen to make, but with a tempo gain, he can permit himself it.

7.d5 ♜b8 8.♖e1

White intends to play in the centre, so his rook belongs on e1 and his bishop on f4 or g5.

8...e5

If Black plays 8...c6, White simply continues development, with a move such as 9.h3 – in the event of a pawn exchange on d5, White obtains pressure on the half-open e-file.



9.dxe6!

The knight on c3 is poorly placed for a plan of gaining space on the queenside, whilst the rook on e1 is ineffective if the centre stays closed. Consequently, White opens lines.

9...♙xe6

On 9...fxe6, the reply 10.e5! is strong.

10.♙f4 h6

Distracted by play against the white dark-squared bishops, Black forgets about developing. He should have

preferred 10...♘c6, agreeing to a slightly inferior position.

11.♘d4!

White favourably exploits this central square, which Black omitted to protect last move.

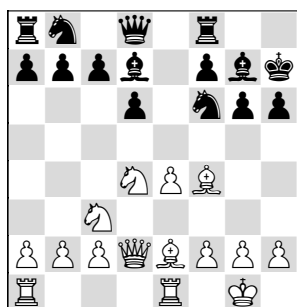
11...♙d7

Black preserves the bishop from exchange, but grants White yet another tempo.

He should have preferred 11...♘c6 12.♘xe6 fxe6, with the idea of ...g6-g5 and counterplay on the dark squares.

12.♚d2 ♖h7

It was already essential to settle for 12...♘c6!, although the variation 13.♘xc6 ♙xc6 14.♙xh6 ♘xe4 15.♘xe4 ♙xh6 16.♚xh6 ♙xe4 17.♙c4 ♙xc2 (in the rook ending arising after 17...♙f5 18.g4 ♙xc2 19.♚ac1 d5 20.♚e3 ♚f6 21.♙xd5 ♚ad8 22.♚h3 ♚g7 23.♚xg7+ ♖xg7 24.♚xc2 ♚xd5 25.♚xc7, White has excellent winning chances) 18.♚ac1 d5 19.♚e3 ♚f6 20.♙xd5 ♙f5 offers White excellent chances of developing his initiative.



13.e5!

This move is strong solely because of White's advantage in piece activity.

13...dxe5 14.♙xe5 ♘e4

Of course, the exchange of knight for bishop favours Black, but it

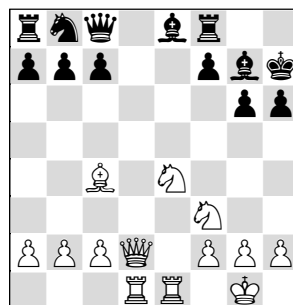
involves exchanging off one of his few developed pieces, leaving him only undeveloped ones remaining.

15.♘xe4 ♙xe5 16.♘f3! ♙g7

16...♙xb2 17.♚ad1, followed by ♙e2-c4.

17.♚ad1 ♚c8 18.♙c4 ♙e8

After 18...♖h8, White develops a decisive attack by means of 19.♘f6! ♙f5 20.♙xf7!+–.



19.♘eg5+! hxg5

19...♖h8 20.♚f4+–.

20.♘g5+ ♖g8 21.♚f4

There is no defence against the transfer of the queen to h4.

21...♘d7

White wins in beautiful fashion in the variation 21...♙h6 22.♚xe8! ♚xe8 23.♚f6 ♙xg5 24.♚xg6+ ♖h8 25.♚h5+ ♖g8 26.♚xg5+ ♖h8 27.♚d4 ♚e1+ 28.♙f1+–.

22.♚xd7 ♙xd7 23.♙xf7+

Black resigned.

4

Training game

Konstantin Sakaev

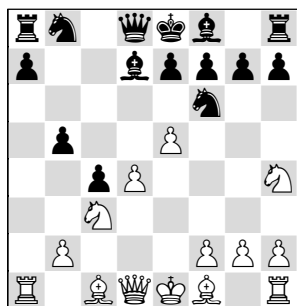
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 dxc4 5.a4 ♙f5 6.♘h4 ♙d7 7.e4 b5

A rare move, hoping to hang onto the extra pawn.

The usual continuation is 7...e6, 'eyeing up' the knight on h4.

Admittedly, after 8.♙xc4! (otherwise Black keeps the extra pawn with ...b7-b5, or undermines the white centre with ...c6-c5) 8...♘xe4 9.♘xe4 ♙xh4 10.♙f3 ♙b4+ 11.♙f1, White obtains an initiative which is more than sufficient for the sacrificed pawn.

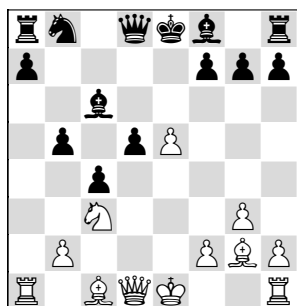
8.axb5 cxb5 9.e5



9...♘d5!

Here's the trick! Of course, Black was not intending to retreat the knight to g8. Even so, his ingenuity is not faultless.

10.♘xd5 e6 11.♘c3 ♙xh4 12.g3 ♙d8 13.♙g2 ♙c6 14.d5 exd5



15.0-0!

The point of White's idea! Development above all! Black changes from being the hunter to the hunted.

15.♘xd5 allows Black to bring his bishop out with tempo and also stops White castling. After 15...♙b4+

16.♙f1 ♙c5, Black's chances are not worse.

15...d4

Otherwise, White takes on d5 in comfort and Black does not get to complete his development.

16.♘xb5 ♙xg2 17.♙xg2 ♙d5+ 18.♙f3 ♙xf3+ 19.♙xf3 ♙d7 20.♘xd4 ♘c6 21.♙e4

The pawn on c4 will soon drop and, once he has taken it, White will have good winning chances.

5

Yasser Seirawan

Anatoly Karpov

Hamburg 1982 (3)

2595

2700

1.♘f3 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 d5 4.d4 ♙e7 5.♙g5 h6 6.♙h4 0-0 7.♙c1 b6 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♘xd5 exd5 10.♙xe7 ♙xe7 11.g3

White's desire to fianchetto the bishop is understandable – on g2, it is more effectively placed than on e2, since from g2 it can exert unpleasant pressure on the long diagonal. However, White fails to see that Black has the possibility of pressurising e2 and making it hard for White to complete his development.

He should have preferred 11.e3, after which there follows 11...♙e6 (it is slightly less accurate to put the bishop on b7; after 11...♙b7 12.♙e2 c5 13.dxc5 bxc5 14.0-0 ♘d7, it obstructs Black's pressure down the b-file).

11...♙e8 12.♙c3

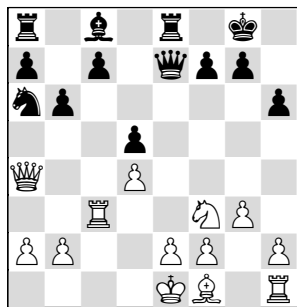
A general strengthening move, which defends against a check on b4. White waits, so that he can

choose his scheme of development, depending on where the black knight goes.

On the previously-intended 12. ♖g2, there is the unpleasant 12... ♙a6, and White has problems castling.

12... ♙a6 13. ♖a4

He needs to complete his development come what may, although Black has a good game after 13. ♖g2 c5 14. e3 c4 15. ♗e5 ♙e6, since he has the simple plan of developing play on the queenside with ...b6-b5-b4. Meanwhile, White's central play with e3-e4 is not so dangerous.



13...b5!?

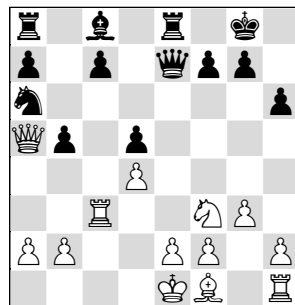
Seeing that White is behind in development, Black switches from positional means to tactical play, weakening his pawn structure but at the same time creating piece play with tempo.

14. ♖a5?

Now, the queen is cut off on the queenside, whilst the action is taking place in the centre.

It was still possible to complete development, if White swallows his pride and retreats the queen. After 14. ♖d1! c5 15. dxc5 ♗xc5 16. ♖g2 ♗e4 17. ♖b3 b4 18. 0-0, the game is roughly equal. White would even

have the advantage, were his rook on c1, rather than exposed on c3.



14... ♖e4!

The threat of 15... ♖b1+ appears, and White will lose castling rights. But Black must play accurately, and energetically, to justify the weakening of his pawn structure with ...b6-b5.

15. ♗d2 ♖e6!

A multi-purpose move, both meeting the threat of ♖c3-e3, and at the same time indirectly defending the pawn on b5.

16.b3?

Losing a tempo. True, the pawn on b5 is now hanging, but White should forget about that and worry about how to fight off the approaching attack. In addition, every additional pawn placed on a light square further restricts the white light-squared bishop.

He should strive for exchanges: 16. ♖e3! ♖b1 17. ♖a3 b4 18. ♖b3 ♖xe3 19. fxe3 – Black has the initiative, but White is holding his lines.

16...b4!

Another good way to develop the initiative was 16...c5 17. dxc5 (White also comes under a serious attack after 17. ♖xb5 cxd4 18. ♖c1 ♖e8, for example: 19. ♖d3 ♖e7 20. ♖xd4 ♙f5

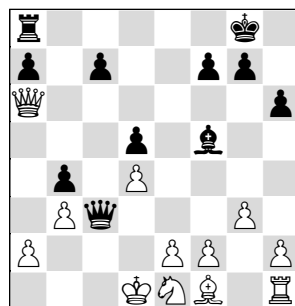
21.e3 ♖a3) 17...♟b4 (also strong is 17...♙d7 18.♞e3 ♖b1 19.♞xe6 ♖b2+ 20.♙d1 ♖a1+ 21.♙c2 (if 21.♙d2 ♟xc5 22.♞e3 ♞c8 White is mated) 21...♙xe6 22.♙h3 ♖xh1 23.♙xe6 ♟xc5 24.♙xf7+ ♙xf7 25.♞c7+ ♙g8 26.♞xc5 ♙h8 – play takes place across the whole board, and in such a position, the rook is much stronger than the knight. In addition, White's king is still unsafe) 18.a3 ♟c6 19.♞xb5 d4 20.♞c2 ♙a6! 21.♞xa6 ♟e5 22.♞a4 ♟xf3+ 23.exf3 ♖e1+ 24.♙d3 ♖d1+ 25.♞d2 ♖xf3+ 26.♙c2 ♖xh1 – Black has a clear advantage.

17.♞e3

If he retreats, e.g., 17.♞c1, then White stands badly, since his queen remains stranded on the edge of the board.

17...♖b1 18.♞xe6 ♖b2+ 19.♙d1 ♙xe6 20.♖xa6 ♖a1+ 21.♙d2 ♖c3+ 22.♙d1 ♙f5 23.♟e1

White is completely tied down to the first rank, and the inclusion of the rook settles the game.



23...♞b8 24.♖xa7 ♞b6 25.e3

He also loses after 25.♖a8+ ♙h7 26.♖xd5 ♖a1+ 27.♙d2 ♖xa2+ 28.♙c1 ♖a1+ 29.♙d2 ♖c3+ 30.♙d1 ♙e6 31.♖e4+ g6, and a quick mate is unavoidable.

25...♞c6 26.♙c4 ♖a1+ 27.♙d2 ♖b2+ 28.♙d1 dxc4 29.♖a8+ ♙h7 30.♖xc6 c3

White resigned.

Additional material

Keres-Botvinnik, Leningrad/Moscow 1941

Svidler-Dreev, Elista 1997

Kasparov-Polugaevsky, Tbilisi 1978

Karpov-Kasparov, Linares 1993

Chapter 2

The centre and its significance

It is hard to overstate the importance of the centre in chess: from there, pieces can quickly reach every other part of the board. Therefore the player who controls the centre usually has the advantage. Many beginners play the opening in such a way as to group their pieces on the first two ranks – a sure-fire way to lose! Against a serious opponent, such an approach offers no chance at all, not even with a bit of luck. In modern-day chess, there are several different approaches to the problem of the centre. The traditional approach is for each side to fight for the centre, ‘pawn by pawn’, and such a method is in general the easiest and the most reliable. But sometimes one allows the opponent to occupy the centre, as happens for example in such popular openings as the Grünfeld Defence or the King’s Indian Defence. There is also the English Opening, the Semi-Tarrasch, the Pirc-Modern and the Réti... As you can soon establish, a fianchettoed bishop is an essential piece in almost all of these openings, without which it is impossible to exert any serious pressure on the enemy centre. Exchanging this bishop is as a rule highly undesirable.

The player usually needs to think very early and very seriously about his strategy for fighting for the centre.

6

Robert Fischer

Samuel Reshevsky

New York ch-USA 1958 (6)

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4
4.♗xd4 g6 5.♙e3 ♗f6 6.♗c3 ♙g7
7.♙c4 0-0 8.♙b3

*

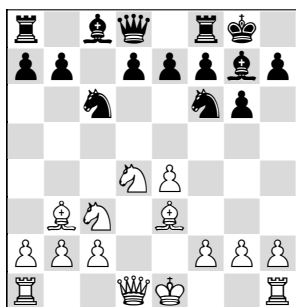
So far both players have brought their pieces to sensible squares, and now Black should either continue developing with 8...d6, or, with the aid of the extravagant-looking 8...a5 9.0-0 a4 10.♗xa4 ♗xe4, exchange his wing pawn for the white central one, albeit with some lag in development. However, Black instead decides to hunt down the white bishop, forgetting about control of the central squares.

8...♗a5?

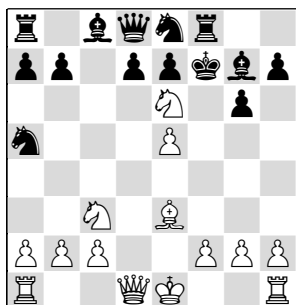
The punishment followed at once:

9.e5! ♗e8?

Losing at once. After 9...♗xb3 10.exf6 ♗xa1 11.fxg7, the two pieces are stronger than the rook, but Black could still fight.



10. ♖xf7+! ♔xf7 11. ♘e6!



White wins the queen, and although realising the advantage took some time, it was not difficult.

11...dxe6 12. ♖xd8 ♘c6 13. ♖d2 ♖xe5 14. 0-0 ♘d6 15. ♖f4 ♘c4 16. ♖e2 ♖xf4 17. ♖xc4 ♔g7 18. ♘e4 ♖c7 19. ♘c5 ♖f6 20. c3 e5 21. ♖ad1 ♘d8 22. ♘d7 ♖c6 23. ♖h4 ♖e6 24. ♘c5 ♖f6 25. ♘e4 ♖f4 26. ♖xe7+ ♖f7 27. ♖a3 ♘c6 28. ♘d6 ♖xd6 29. ♖xd6 ♖f5 30. b4 ♖ff8 31. b5 ♘d8 32. ♖d5 ♘f7 33. ♖c5 a6 34. b6 ♖e4 35. ♖e1 ♖c6 36. ♖xc6 bxc6 37. b7 ♖ab8 38. ♖xa6 ♘d8 39. ♖b1 ♖f7 40. h3 ♖fxb7 41. ♖xb7+ ♖xb7 42. ♖a8

Black resigned.

7	*
Valery Loginov	2525
Konstantin Sakaev	2600
St Petersburg 1996 (6)	

1. ♘f3 ♘f6 2. g3 b5!?

Such a move with a flank pawn is perfectly justified here, as White has not occupied the centre with pawns. However, aggressively seizing the centre is fraught with danger for Black, as White can often use it as a target and break through.

3. ♘a3?!

Original, but dubious. I should add that I chose this opening variation as Black, precisely because Valery Loginov regularly played this decentralising knight move.

3...a6 4. c4 e5!

Black is ready for a fight in the centre!

5. b3

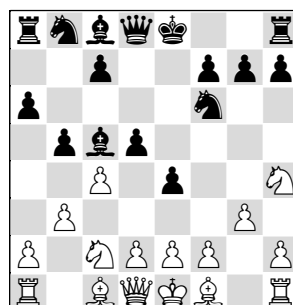
5. ♘xe5 ♖b7 6. ♘f3 ♖xa3 7. bxa3 bxc4 8. e3 d5.

5. cxb5 e4 6. ♘d4 ♖c5.

5...e4 6. ♘h4 ♖c5

Also good is the immediate 6...d5! 7. cxd5 ♖c5, and now 8. ♘c2 transposes to the variation 6...♖c5 7. ♘c2 d5 8. exd5.

7. ♘c2 d5



8. d4?

The white queen comes into the game, which, with its bishops still at home, is bad. In addition, the white knights are also badly placed.

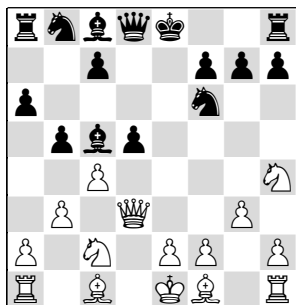
It was better to refrain from a sharp conflict between the pawns and to choose the modest 8. cxd5. In reply, Black has a whole range of possible responses, but the most promising is the variation 8...♘g4 9. e3 ♖e7, going over to a battle for the light squares.

8...exd3!

8...♙e7 ♖ ‘only’ ensures Black a comfortable position, but that is not much in this situation.

9. ♖xd3

After 9.exd3 0-0 10.d4 ♖e8+ Black has a strong initiative.



9...♜c6!

Black immediately exploits the exposed position of the white queen. The preliminary exchange 9...bxc4 10.bxc4 gives the queen a convenient retreat square: 10...♜c6 11.cxd5 ♜e5 12.♖b3!

10.cxd5?

Much more tenacious was 10.♙f4, taking the square e5 from the black knight.

10...♜e5 11.♖c3?

An oversight, but even after 11.♖d1 ♜eg4 12.e3 ♜e4 13.f3 ♜gf2 14.♖e2 ♜xg3 15.hxg3 ♜xh1, it is hard for White to put up serious resistance.

11...♙xf2+ 12.♙d1 ♖xd5+ 13.♙d2 ♜e4

White resigned.

8

Bent Larsen

Boris Spassky

Belgrade tt 1970 (2)

1.b3?!

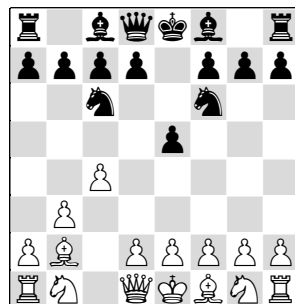
*

With this move, White does not take action in the centre, so it must be considered a mistake.

1...e5 2.♙b2 ♜c6 3.c4

Preferable is 3.e3, followed by ♙f1-b5 – that is the only way to exert pressure on the e5-pawn.

3...♜f6



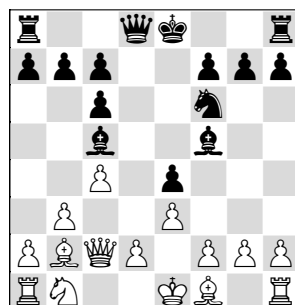
4.♜f3?!

Here the knight is attacked with tempo, so this move is also unfortunate.

4...e4 5.♜d4 ♙c5! 6.♜xc6 dxc6 7.e3 ♙f5

Only seven moves have been played, and already Black has a significant advantage in both space and development.

8.♖c2



8...♖e7!

After queenside castling, the rook will immediately assume a threatening

position, and thus Black wins another tempo for development.

9. ♖e2 0-0-0 10. f4?

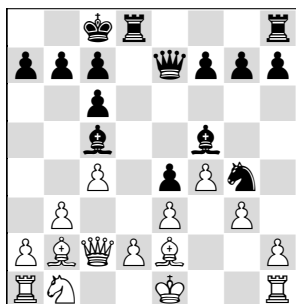
Now, the white kingside becomes an object of attack, even though his king is not there. Another minus of this move is that it contributes nothing to development. He should have chosen 10. ♖c3, preparing a possible evacuation of the king to the queenside.

10... ♗g4

Now, as well as everything else, there are possible tactical blows on e3.

11. g3

The attack with the rook's pawn



11...h5!

Black manages to include in his initiative his last piece – the rook on h8. As a result, his advantage becomes decisive.

12. h3

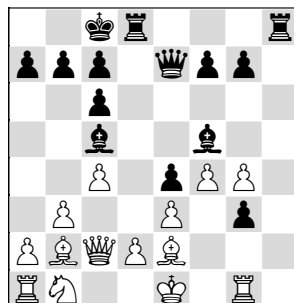
It is already too late to develop – on 12. ♖c3, Black wins with 12... ♖xd2! 13. ♖xd2 ♖xe3–+.

12...h4! 13. hxg4

Or 13. ♖xg4 ♖xg4 14. hxg4 hxg3 15. ♖g1 ♖h2–+, with the threats ... ♖c5xe3 and ... ♖e7-h4.

13...hxg3 14. ♖g1

Dynamics – opening lines



14... ♖h1!

A simple tactical blow that decides.

15. ♖xh1 g2 16. ♖f1 ♖h4+ 17. ♖d1 gxh1 ♖+

White resigned.

9

Nikolay Spiridonov

Garry Kasparov

Skara Ech tt 1980 (4)

2470

2595

1. ♖f3 g6 2. d4 ♖f6 3. ♖g5 ♖g7 4. ♖bd2

White has chosen a harmless opening, the main point of which is usually to shift the weight of the struggle to the middlegame.

4...c5!

The most energetic, although by no means an obligatory reaction. Black immediately takes action in the centre and underlines the passivity of the knight on d2.

5. ♖xf6

The fashion for this exchange has now passed – the sharp plan with queenside castling, which it involves, is not dangerous.

On 5.e3, Black has a choice of two good set-ups. The most concrete and direct is 5...cxd4 (slower play results from 5...b6 – Black fianchettoes

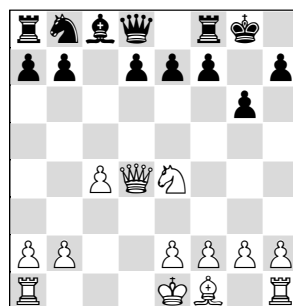
his queen's bishop, puts his pawn on d6 and develops the queen's knight to d7) 6.exd4 ♘c6 7.c3 d5 – a complicated strategic battle for the central squares lies ahead.

If White were to strengthen his central pawn with the move 5.c3, then after the typical exchange 5... cxd4 6.cxd4 0-0, the knight on d2 is passively placed. The pawn exchange on d4 also potentially lengthens the long diagonal for the black bishop on g7. The most cautious move is 7.e3 (nothing good comes from the attempt to seize the centre with 7.e4, since Black is able to play the blow 7...d5! 8.e5 ♘e4, and White must spend another tempo securing his bishop on g5. Black has free development, whilst he can break up the pawn duo d4-e5 with the move ...f7-f6), after which Black does best not to commit his d-pawn just yet, but instead plays 7...♘c6!, first waiting to see where White puts his king's bishop. After 8.♙e2 (on 8.♙d3 Black equalises with 8... d5 – the light-squared bishop can be attacked or exchanged with ♙f5), as well as 8...d5, Black can also choose the double-edged 8...d6!? 9.0-0 h6 10.♙h4 g5 11.♙g3. The bishop on g3 is blocked in by the wall of black pawns, so Black can either exchange it with 11...♘h5, or develop his bishop to e6 or f5, in all cases with a complicated battle. Such are the subtleties of the opening battle.

5...♙xf6 6.♘e4 ♙xd4 7.♘xd4 cxd4
8.♙xd4 0-0 9.c4

On 9.0-0-0 ♘c6 10.♙d2, with the idea of starting an attack by advancing the h-pawn, Black has a

choice between an equalising line and a double-edged one. 10...♙a5!? (less sharp is the sacrifice 10... d5 11.♙xd5 ♙c7 12.♙c5 b6 13.♙c3 ♙f4+ 14.♙e3 ♙xe3+ 15.fxe3 ♙b7 – Black's positional compensation for the pawn is sufficient for equality). The exchange of queens leads to equality, whilst 11.♘c3!? (or 11.♙h6 f6 12.♘c3∞) 11...b5!?∞ leads to a position in which Black's chances are not worse.



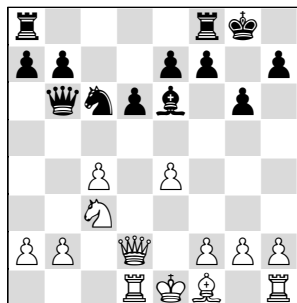
9...♘c6 10.♙d2 d6 11.♘c3 ♙e6
12.e4

This outwardly active move proves to be an inaccuracy – White provokes a pawn conflict in the centre, for which his lack of development means he is not ready. His queen is already in the centre. More cautious is 12.e3, after which the position is roughly equal. The bishop can come to e2, and the c4-pawn can be strengthened with b2-b3 – White would be able to complete his development, without giving Black objects of attack.

12...♙b6 13.♙d1

Yet another inaccuracy – White still has ambitious plans, rather than concentrating on completing the development of his kingside as soon as possible. On 13.♙e2, White

probably didn't like the immediate equalizing possibility 13...♖d4, but it was better to go in for this position than the one arising in the game.



13...♖e5 14.b3 f5!

White's kingside is undeveloped, and this is where Black starts operations, bringing the rook on f8 into the game.

15.♗e2 f4!

Now, the knight has a square on e5, whilst the space gained on the kingside should help Black develop his initiative.

Only a draw by perpetual check would result from 15...fxe4 16.♖xe4 ♗f5 17.♖c3 ♗c2 18.♖xc2 ♖xf2+ 19.♗d2 ♖f4+ 20.♗e1 ♖f2+.

16.♖d5

White's last poor strategic decision in this game – he is left with a bad bishop against a good knight.

Correct is 16.f3 ♖ac8 17.♖a4, completing his development. Nothing terrible should follow here – the knight on e5 can be exchanged by means of ♖a4-b2-d3.

16...♗xd5 17.♖xd5+ ♖g7 18.0-0 ♖ac8

Possibly, 18...a5 is more precise, securing the dark squares.

19.b4!

White finds a chance to activate somewhat, with the only alternative being to mark time. Now, Black must reckon with a possible c4-c5.

19...♖xb4

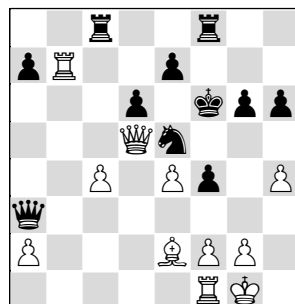
Now White gets another pawn island, but in return, activates his rooks.

20.♖b1 ♖a3 21.♖xb7 ♖f6

Very striking, but not entirely safe, since all of the major pieces are still on the board.

On 21...♖f7, there could follow 22.♖e6 ♖e8 23.c5! ♖xc5 24.♗b5 ♖ef8 25.♗a4, with chances of equalising.

22.h4 h6



23.♖d1?

The rook does nothing here and it belongs instead on the open file!

Correct was 23.♖d2 g5 24.♖fb1! – thanks to his control of the open b-file and the possibility of transferring a piece to the square h3, White has sufficient counterplay to hold the balance.

23...♖b8 24.♖c7 ♖fc8 25.♖xc8 ♖xc8

The game has simplified, and the strategic defects of White's position start to tell.

26. ♖b7 ♜c5 27. ♖b2 ♖b6 28. ♜c1
g5 29. ♜d5 e6 30. hxg5+ hxg5
31. ♜d1 ♞e7 32. ♜c2

On 32. ♜c3, there would have followed 32... ♜h8, not allowing White to bring his queen to the h-file, and planning himself to organise an attack along this line.

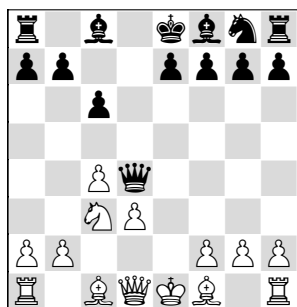
32... ♜b8 33. ♜a4 g4! 34. ♜a3 ♜c5
35. ♜c3 g3 36. ♜f1 gxf2+ 37. ♜xf2
♜b1+ 38. ♜f1 ♜e3 39. ♜xe3 fxe3
40. ♜c2 ♞xc4 0-1

10	**
Arkadij Naiditsch	2716
Christian Bauer	2638
France tt 2011 (2)	

1. ♞f3 d5 2. c4 d4 3. e3 ♞c6 4. exd4
♞xd4 5. ♞xd4 ♜xd4 6. ♞c3

White is somewhat ahead of his opponent in development. It seems obvious that the advanced black queen will come under the attack of the white forces, losing precious time by having to retreat. But in this instance, Black finds a very concrete idea, allowing him to 'fasten his teeth' onto the d4-square, and create on this square a powerful piece centre.

6...c6 7.d3



7... ♞h6!

This idea, which to a large extent breathed new life into the system with 2...d4, was found relatively recently in chess terms, in 1996, and immediately became popular. The black knight heads for d4. White does not succeed in comfortably advancing his pawn from d3, to create a pawn centre.

8.h3

After 8. ♞e3 ♜d8 9.d4 ♞f5 10. ♜d2 g6 11. 0-0-0 ♞g7, Black can always exchange on e3, obtaining the advantage of the two bishops: 12. ♞e2 0-0 13. h4 c5! 14. dxc5 ♜a5! 15. h5 ♞e6 – in the game Dzhakaev-Navara, Pardubice rapid 2011, Black obtained a wonderful attacking position.

8. ♞xh6, although it spoils the black structure, opens lines for Black, and he obtains the advantage after 8... gxf6 9. ♞e2 ♜g8 10. ♞f3 ♞f5.

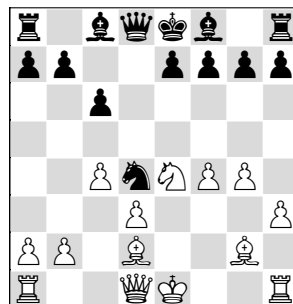
8... ♞f5 9.g4 ♜e5+!

An important intermediate check, freeing the square d4 for the knight.

10. ♞e4 ♞d4

Black has created his piece centre. White will not manage to drive the knight away from the d4-square. He already stands worse.

11.f4 ♜a5+ 12. ♞d2 ♜d8 13. ♞g2



13...g6!

The bishop comes to g7, strengthening control over the square d4.

14.♖c3 ♗g7 15.0-0?!

He had to try queenside castling, where his king is on a better-defended flank. After 15.♞d2 h5 16.0-0-0 hxg4 17.hxg4 ♗xg4 18.♞xh8+ ♗xh8 19.♞h1 ♗g7 20.♞h7 ♗f8 21.♗f1!, White, with the idea of sacrificing the exchange on g7, could get reasonable practical compensation for the pawn.

15...h5! 16.g5 0-0

Now, White's position is strategically lost – Black cannot be prevented from strengthening his position, and attacking White's weaknesses. Thanks to the powerful knight on d4, White cannot develop any activity at all.

17.♞d2 ♗f5 18.♞ae1 ♞c7 19.♗g3 ♞ad8 20.♗h2 h4 21.♗e4 ♗e6 22.♗h1 ♞d7 23.♗xg7 ♗xg7 24.♞d1 ♞fd8

Black has developed and brought up his reserves. Now the white pawns begin to fall like ripe apples.

25.♞f2 ♞xd3 26.♞xd3 ♞xd3 27.♞xh4 ♞d4 28.♗g3 ♞xf4

White resigned.

11

Viswanathan Anand

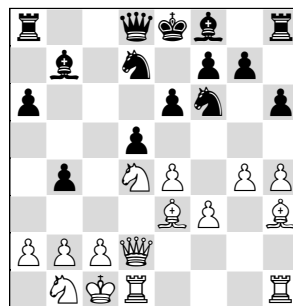
2781

Garry Kasparov

2812

Linares 1999 (10)

1.e4 c5 2.♗f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♗xd4 ♗f6 5.♗c3 a6 6.f3 e6 7.♗e3 b5 8.g4 h6 9.♞d2 ♗b7 10.0-0-0 ♗b7 11.h4 b4 12.♗b1 d5 13.♗h3



In the battle for the group of central squares, the black pieces are coordinated better. However, his king is unsafe, and opening the central lines is fraught with risk. Now, there is a threat of g4-g5. If he allows this advance, the black knight will be forced to retreat to a bad position. In addition, a threat to sacrifice on e6 will arise, as well as the advance g5-g6. The king cannot find safety on the kingside, so there followed

13...g5!!

Black sacrifices a pawn, but slows up the white attack for several moves.

14.hxg5 hxg5 15.exd5

Now, the black knight gets an excellent square. It was worth considering the counter-sacrifice 15.e5!? ♗xe5 16.♗xg5 ♗e7 17.♞de1 ♗fd7 18.♗xe7 ♞xe7 19.g5 0-0-0, with a roughly balanced struggle.

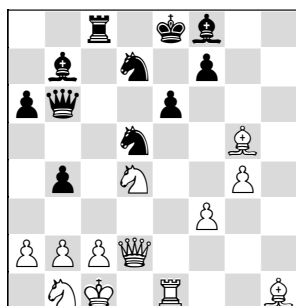
15...♗xd5 16.♗xg5 ♞b6 17.♗g2 ♞xh1 18.♗xh1

White cannot penetrate along the h-file with his rook: 18.♞xh1 ♗g7 19.♗e2 (19.♗b3 comes under attack after 19...a5, followed by ...a5-a4. Another possible development of the black attack is as follows: 19.♞d1 ♞c8 20.♗h6 ♗e5 21.♗f1 ♞c7 22.♞f2 ♞d8!!). The queen heads to

f6, after which White has problems defending his minor pieces, for example 23.f4 ♖f6 24.♙g5 ♜g6!! (24...♙xf4+ 25.♙xf4 ♜xf4+ 26.♜xf4 ♙xf4 leads to an equal endgame, but that is a small profit from such a position) 25.♙d3 ♜g7 26.♙f1 ♘c5! 27.♙g2 b3! 28.♘xb3 ♙xb3+ 29.axb3 ♙xb2+ 30.♙d2 ♙d4, with a decisive attack) 19...♞c8 20.♞h7 ♙e5 21.f4 ♘e3 22.fxe5 ♞xc2+ 23.♜xc2 ♘xc2 24.♞h8+ ♘f8 25.♙xb7 ♜xb7 26.♙h6 ♜c6 27.♙d2 ♘a1!, and Black wins.

18...♞c8 19.♞e1!

White tries to implement his own play, at the same time defending against ...♘d5-c3, and ...♙f8-g7.



19...♜a5!!

Black regroupes and finds a new object of attack, when White was ready for an attack on the d4-knight: 19...♙g7 20.♘f5 ♙e5 simply turns out to be bad, because of 21.f4.

Nor does Black achieve anything after 19...♞c4 20.♘f5 – the rook does nothing on c4.

20.f4

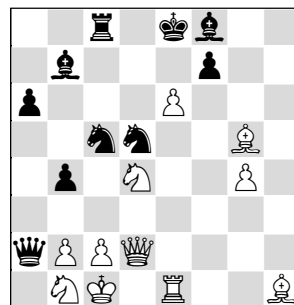
Moving the pawn from under attack, inviting the opening of further lines, is even more dangerous: after 20.a3, both 20...♜b6, and 20...♘c5 are promising.

20...♜xa2 21.f5 ♘c5!

Black also has the advantage after 21...e5, keeping the approaches to his king closed. However, with 22.♜h2 ♜c4 23.♘f3, White retains counter-threats.

22.fxe6

Quiet moves / prophylaxis in the middle of an attack



22...♙g7!

Calculating all the variations is impossible, so this decision to complete the mobilisation of all the pieces, at the cost of the king's pawn cover, was taken largely intuitively.

23.exf7+ ♙xf7 24.♙xd5+?

Out of the ocean of possibilities, it is practically impossible over the board to find the narrow path that leads to a draw: 24.♜f2+! ♙g8 25.♜f5 ♜c4 (25...♙xd4 26.♜g6+ ♙g7 27.♞e8+ ♞xe8 28.♜xe8+ ♙h7 29.♜h5+ is also a draw) 26.♙xd5+! ♜xd5 27.♞e7!! – in all variations, White saves himself, thanks to the threat of perpetual check.

24...♜xd5 25.♞e7+ ♙g8 26.♞xg7+ ♙xg7 27.♘c3!

The best practical chance.

27...bxc3 28.♘f5+ ♙f7 29.♜xd5+ ♙xd5 30.♘d6+ ♙g6 31.♘xc8 ♙xg5

and Black realised his extra piece, although not without further adventures.

12

Vladimir Kramnik

2800

Magnus Carlsen

2826

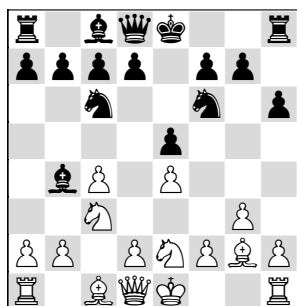
Moscow 2011 (3)

We will now look at one of the most acclaimed games of 2011, between the leader of Russian chess, Vladimir Kramnik, and the world rating number one of the time, Magnus Carlsen. Chess has many exceptions to the rules! It would perhaps be more accurate to say that there are many factors which influence the assessment of a position, as this game shows.

1.c4 e5 2.g3 ♘f6 3.♙g2 h6

Black neglects the received wisdom about tempi right from the start. Carlsen seeks to avoid established theory.

4.♘c3 ♙b4 5.e4 ♘c6 6.♘ge2



6...♙c5!

And this is a 'real' tempo loss. Black reacts to the fact that White is threatening d2-d4, which would give him control of the centre. White would have control over both d4 and d5, and his e4-pawn would be securely defended.

7.d3 d6 8.h3 ♘h7!?

Again moving a piece twice in the opening! But in this case, Black intends to keep the position closed. In closed positions, a loss of tempi in the opening is not of such great significance. In addition, Black has the idea of putting a knight on d4.

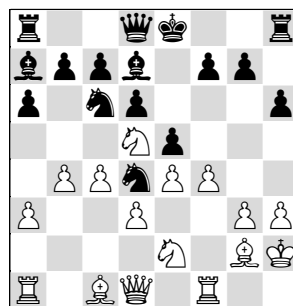
9.a3 a6 10.0-0 ♘g5 11.♙h2 ♘e6

12.f4 ♙d7 13.b4 ♙a7 14.♘d5

White is attacking on all fronts, seizing space on a board full of pieces. Black has only one trump – his control of d4.

14...♘ed4

The 'superfluous' piece



15.♘ec3!

An important moment – White does not allow Black to exchange a pair of knights. After the exchange, Black's other knight would occupy d4 and then the move ...c7-c6 would kick the white knight from d5.

15...♙e6 16.f5 ♙d7 17.♙b1 ♘b8

The knight makes way for the pawn.

18.c5

Starting the storm! It turns out that the knight on d4 suffices for Black to resist White's pressure.

A cunning and strong continuation was 18.♙g4 ♙f8 19.♙d1!, inviting Black to commit himself. After

19...c6 20.♖e3, on his next move, White will exchange off the knight on d4, and then we see the great difference – the other black knight is stuck on b8 and can only dream of getting to the coveted d4-square. In this variation, White would retain a considerable advantage.

18...dxc5 19.bxc5 ♖c8

Another piece retreats to its starting position. It was also worth considering 19...♙xc5 20.♞xb7 ♖d6, gradually developing his pieces.

20.♞h5

Here too, White should consider the move 20.♞g4!, drawing the king to a bad square. After 20...♙f8 21.♞h5, the subsequent variations could be something like the following:

A) 21...f6 22.♖xf6 gxf6 (22...♞xf6 23.♖d5 ♞f7 24.♞xf7+ ♙xf7 25.♖xc7 ♙xc5 26.♖xa8 b5 27.♙b2 ♖bc6 28.♞fc1 ♖d6 29.♖b6+–) 23.♙xh6+ ♙e7 24.♖d5+;

B) 21...c6 22.f6 cxd5 23.fxc7+;

C) 21...♙xc5 22.f6 g6 23.♞xe5 ♖bc6 24.♞xc7+–;

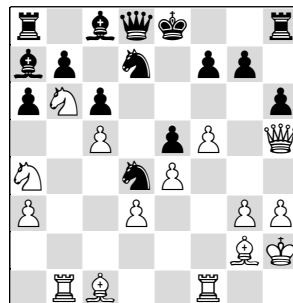
D) 21...♖bc6 (seemingly Black's best reply) 22.f6 g6 23.♙xh6+ ♙e8 24.♞xg6 fxg6 25.f7+ ♙d7 26.f8♞ ♞xf8 27.♞xf8 ♞xf8 (27...♙xc5 28.♖f6+ ♙e6 29.♞xd8 ♖xd8 30.♖cd5 ♞b8 31.♖e8 ♙f7 32.♖exc7±) 28.♙xf8 ♖e6 29.♞f1±;

E) 21...♖d7 22.f6 g5 (22...g6 23.♙xh6+ (check! This is the point of the move 20.♞g4) 23...♙g8 24.♖e7+) 23.♙xg5. Unfortunately, Vladimir Kramnik decided that, on the contrary, f8 would be a good square for the black king, not seeing the concrete tactical motifs after the move 20.♞g4!.

20...♖d7 21.♖a4

After 21.f6 g6, White cannot take the h6-pawn with check.

21...c6 22.♖db6



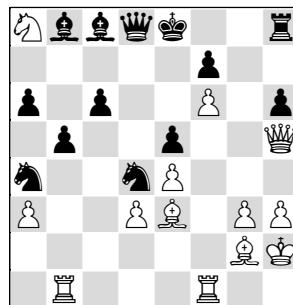
22...♖xc5!

Black's pieces, passively placed on the back rank, start to develop activity.

23.f6 g5 24.♙xg5

It was worth considering 24.♖xc8 ♞xc8 25.♖xc5 ♙xc5 26.h4, activating the bishop on g2.

24...♖xa4 25.♖xa8 b5 26.♙e3 ♙b8



As a result of the operation just carried out, White has won the exchange, but the black pieces can look forward to the future with confidence, and the knight on d4 has retained its position.

27.g4 ♞g8

The position remains unbalanced, as proved by the variation 27...♙e6

28.g5 c5 29.♙xd4! ♖xd4 (29...cxd4 30.♙f3!) 30.gxh6 ♕d7 31.♖g5, with unclear consequences.

28.♖xh6

28.♖bc1! was significantly stronger, not allowing 28...♙e6 29.♙xd4 exd4+ (29...♖xd4 30.♖xc6+–) 30.e5±.

28...♙e6 29.♖bc1 ♕d7!

Black has managed to regroup his pieces successfully.

30.♙xd4 exd4+ 31.e5 ♖c3

32.♖xc3! ♙xe5+ 33.♕h1 dxc3

34.♖e3 ♖b8 35.♖c5?!

White should have played 35.d4! ♙d6 36.d5 cxd5 37.♖b6+ ♕d8 38.♖xd5 ♙xd5 39.♙xd5 ♖c7 40.♖c1

♙f4 41.♖e7+ ♖xe7 42.fxe7+ ♕xe7 43.♖xc3.

35...♖d6 36.♖a7+ ♕d8 37.♖xa6 ♙d4 38.♖a5+ ♕c8 39.♖a6+ ♕d8

Both players were tired after such an extremely complicated game and Black preferred to repeat moves. However, after 39...♕b8 40.♖b6 ♙c8! 41.♖xc8 ♖xc8 42.a4 b4, he would have obtained excellent winning chances.

40.♖a5+ ♕c8 41.♖a6+

Draw. A game where Black only managed to hold because of the powerful knight on d4, and White's powerful attacking potential did not suffice for victory.

Additional material

Alekhine-Rubinstein, Carlsbad 1923

Botvinnik-Tal, Moscow Wch (match/7) 1961

Smyslov-Euwe, The Hague/Moscow Wch (match-tournament) 1948

Lputian-Malaniuk, Sverdlovsk 1987

Chapter 3

Do not make unnecessary pawn moves if you have not completed your development

Unnecessary pawn moves are a favourite diversion of young players. Instead of rapid development, we too often see unnecessary prophylactic measures or defence against non-existent threats. No matter how many times they are shown what this leads to, or experience the consequences in their own games, the habit continues. But one must not lose hope of curing this weakness, one must just correct, correct, correct... Eventually, the water will wear away the stone.

13

Konstantin Landa

2614

Kay Hansen

2230

Vienna 2003 (4)

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.♘c3 b5?!

Despite the undoubted strangeness of this move, Black does create a concrete threat to drive away the knight and then take on e4.

The normal continuation is 3...dxe4, followed by developing the pieces.

4.e5

Here it is essential to consider in which variation of the Caro-Kann the move ...b7-b5 will be least useful. For example, it is not easy to demonstrate a white advantage after 4.exd5 b4 5.♘e4 ♔xd5 (5...cxd5 6.♘c5 e6 7.a3 bxa3 8.♖xa3 ♘f6) 6.♘g3 e6!?

Also less than entirely clear is 4.♙d3 b4 5.♘ce2 dxe4 6.♙xe4 ♘f6 7.♙f3 e6 – the white pieces are somewhat unusually positioned, and meanwhile, the black bishop can come to a6 and the knight to d5.

However, it was worth considering 4.a3!?, preventing ...b5-b4.

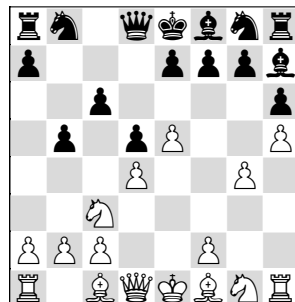
4...♙f5 5.g4 ♙g6?

Correct was 5...♙d7. Then White simply obtains a convenient version of the Caro-Kann with 3.e5 after 6.♙e3! h5 7.gxh5 ♘h6 8.♘ge2±, Tischbierek-Weiss, Aschach 2001.

6.h4 h6

The move 6...h5 does not change White's plans much; there follows 7.e6! fxe6 8.♙d3 ♙f7 9.g5 g6 10.♘f3 ♘d7 11.♘e2 ♖h7 12.♘f4 ♗g7 13.♞e2±.

7.h5 ♙h7



8.e6!

A standard blockading pawn sacrifice, shutting in the ♙f8 for a long time to come. White will easily

be able to regain the e6-pawn, with the aid of his major pieces down the e-file.

8... ♖d6

Taking does not help Black much: 8...fxe6 9. ♔d3!. The battle is for the light squares and the point g6, which White will win: 9...e5 10. ♔xh7 ♜xh7 11.dxe5 e6 12. ♖d3 ♜h8 13. ♘ce2 ♘e7 14. ♘f4, with a large advantage.

9. exf7+ ♜xf7 10. g5 ♕f5 11. ♖f3 e6 12. ♔d3

It is already clear that the early move ...b7-b5 has turned out to be at best a tempo loss, and, in the worst case, also a serious weakening of the entire black pawn structure.

12... ♖d7 13. ♘ce2!

The knight on c3 has nothing to do. Its colleague on g1 has good prospects of activating itself from the squares f3 or h3.

13... hxg5 14. ♔xg5 ♕e7 15. ♘h3 ♘h6 16. ♘g3 ♘a6 17. 0-0-0

Storm clouds are gathering over the black king.

17... ♕f6 18. ♔xh6!

Removing the blockade on the f-file, the only thing stopping the white pieces breaking through.

18... ♔xd3 19. ♔xg7 ♜xg7 20. ♜xd3 ♜af8 21. ♖g4+ ♜f7 22. f4 ♜e7 23. ♘g5 ♘c7 24. ♘f1 ♘d6 25. ♘d2 ♖g7 26. ♘df3 ♜e8 27. ♜e1 c5 28. dxc5+ ♜xc5

The black king is active, but the position on the board is far from being an endgame.

29. ♘e5 ♜b6 30. ♖g1+ ♜b7 31. ♜h3 ♜ef8 32. ♖g4 ♕e7 33. ♘g6 ♜f5 34. ♘xe6

Black resigned.

14

Nikola Kovacevic

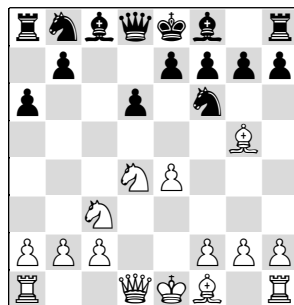
2120

Slavko Petrovic

2104

Andrijevic ch-MNT 2012 (8)

1. e4 c5 2. ♘f3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. ♘xd4 ♘f6 5. ♘c3 a6 6. ♕g5



On the board, we have one of the sharpest opening variations one can see in modern chess, the Najdorf Variation of the Sicilian Defence. The most ambitious response is the move 6. ♕g5 – placing his pieces in the most aggressive positions, White prepares a breakthrough in the centre. Both sides need to know an enormous amount of theory on these lines, otherwise either can suffer what happens in this game.

6...b5?!

This generally standard move should be postponed until Black has developed further. The main continuations here are the classical 6...e6 and the trendy 6... ♘bd7.

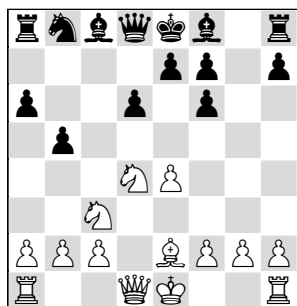
7. ♔xf6!

Seizing the chance to spoil the black pawn structure.

7...gxf6 8. ♕e2

An instructive move. The bishop threatens to come to h5, from where it will not only effectively attack the pawn on f7, but also

block the advance of the black h-pawn, one of Black's main ideas in this position.



8...♙b7?

Continuing development, but ignoring the weakening of the light squares around his king.

The preliminary 8...e6 looks more logical, but even here Black has his problems: 9.0-0 ♖g8 (9...♘d7?! 10.♙h5 ♘b6 (10...♘e5 11.f4 ♘g6 12.f5!±) 11.a4!. An important moment – the black pawn, which advanced so early, becomes the decisive object of attack. For example, after 11...b4 12.♘d5! exd5 13.♘c6, White has a decisive attack: 13...♙c7 14.exd5 ♙h6 (14...♘c4 15.♙e2+ ♘e5 16.f4 ♙g7 17.fxe5 dxe5 18.♙e4 a5 19.d6 ♙xd6 20.♘xe5) 15.♙e1+ ♘f8 16.♙e7 ♙xe7 17.♘xe7 ♘xe7 18.♙e1+ ♘d8 19.♙xb4) 10.♙f3 (10.b4 ♙b7 11.a4 bxa4 12.♙xa4 ♘d7 13.g3 ♙c8 14.♙a3) 10...♙a7! (10...♙b7 11.e5 d5 12.♙h5 fxe5 13.♘xe6 ♙d7 14.♘xf8 ♘xf8 15.♙d3 f5 16.♙fe1 is very dangerous for Black) 11.♘ce2 ♙b6 12.c3 ♘d7 13.a4 ♘e5 14.♙h5!±.

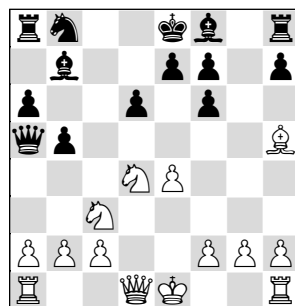
9.♙h5!

White seizes on the enemy weaknesses.

9...♙a5?

Losing by force, although, admittedly, even after 9...♙c8 10.♘d5 ♙xd5 11.exd5 ♙c4 12.a4, Black is not to be envied.

Dynamics – the attack on f2/f7



10.♙xf7+!

The black king is lured out for a fatal wander around the board.

10...♙xf7 11.♙h5+ ♙g8 12.0-0 ♘c6 13.♙d5+ ♙g7 14.♘f5+ ♙g6 15.♘h4+ ♘h6

15...♙g7 16.♙d3.

16.♙d3

There is no defence at all against the threatened mate.

16...b4

16...♙c8 17.♙xc6.

17.♘f5+ ♘h5 18.♙h3+ ♙g5 19.♙g3+

Black resigned.

15

**

Max Euwe

Alexander Alekhine

the Netherlands Wch match 1937 (25)

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♙b4 4.e3 0-0 5.♘e2 d5 6.a3 ♙e7 7.cxd5 exd5 8.♘g3

Not the most active square for the knight, which has spent two tempi getting there.

If the knight were going to move, then it was better to choose 8.♘f4, exerting pressure on the pawn at d5.

But the strongest move was 8.g3. Then White's plan is ♗f1-g2, 0-0 and often f2-f3, with the intention of seizing the centre with e3-e4. And if Black plays ...c7-c5, then the pawn d5 becomes a weakness.

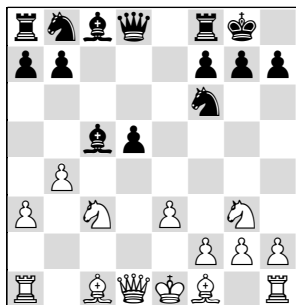
8...c5!

Exploiting White's lack of development, Black easily solves his opening problems.

9.dxc5 ♗xc5 10.b4?

The passive 10.♗e2 ♘c6 11.0-0 d4 12.♘a4 ♗e7 leads to a slightly more pleasant position for Black.

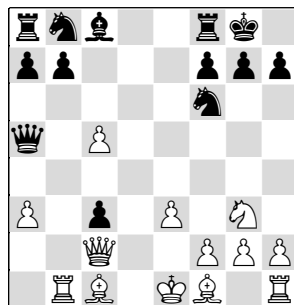
Correct was 10.♗d3, and then a possible continuation is 10...♘c6 11.0-0 ♗e6 12.♘ce2 (otherwise Black plays ...d5-d4 in favourable circumstances) 12...♖c8 13.b4 ♗d6 14.♗b2 a5 15.b5 ♘e5. Chances are roughly equal, because by way of compensation for the isolated d-pawn, Black controls the c-file and also has a nice outpost on c4 for his knight.



White has neglected his development and Black strikes a blow in the centre, opening lines.

10...d4! 11.bxc5 dxc3 12.♖c2 ♖a5 13.♞b1

It is far from simple to capture the audacious pawn which has broken into White's camp on c3. Thus, after 13.♘e2, there follows 13...♘d5 14.e4 ♘b4!.



13...♗d7!

Not only intending ...♗d7-a4, but also defending against ♞b1-b5 in the process.

14.♞b3

White decides to part with the exchange at once.

14.♞b4 ♖c8 15.♖c4 ♖xc5 16.♞xc5 ♖xc5 17.♘e2 ♘a6 18.♘xc3 ♖c8 19.♗b2 ♖c6 would leave White no fewer problems, despite his two bishops – the lack of development tells.

14...♗a4 15.♖xc3 ♖d8 16.♗c4 ♘a6

Provoking White into parting with his light-squared bishop. However, Black spoils his pawn structure and White obtains a passed pawn, which will not be captured.

Stronger was the more direct 16...♗xb3!, followed by ...♘b8-d7, and the pawn on c5 is won.

17.♗xa6 bxa6 18.0-0 ♗xb3 19.♖xb3 ♞b8

On 19...♖c8, there is the ingenious defence 20.a4!, freeing the square a3 for the bishop.

20. ♖c2 ♖d5 21.e4

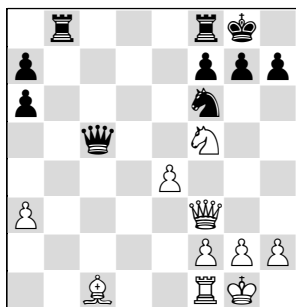
Also possible is 21.♘f5!?, with the idea of advancing the pawn to c6, when the knight comes to d4.

21... ♖b3 22. ♖e2 ♖b5 23. ♖f3?

He should not give up the pawn so readily. Better was 23.♖c2, with the idea of ♗c1-e3.

23... ♖xc5 24. ♘f5

More tenacious is 24.♗f4, but after 24...♖b5! 25.♘f5 ♘xe4 26.♘xg7 ♖d5 27.♘h5 ♖xh5 28.♖xe4 ♖f5, Black should gradually realise his extra exchange.



White cannot get at the square g7, as Black's counterattack arrives first:

24... ♖b1! 25. ♖f4

On 25.♖g3, the cold-blooded 25...g6 wins.

25... ♘xe4 26.h4 ♖e8 27. ♖e1 ♖c3 28. ♖d1 ♘d2 29. ♖xd2 ♖xc1+ 30. ♗h2 ♖c7 31. ♖d6 ♖c5 32.g3 ♖f8 33.g4 f6 34. ♗h3 h5 35. ♖d2 hxg4+ 36. ♗xg4 ♖f7 37.h5 ♖xf5 38. ♗xf5 ♖xh5+ 39. ♗f4 ♖h4+ 40. ♗f3 ♖h3+ 41. ♗e4 ♖e8+ 42. ♗d5 ♖b3+ 43. ♗d4 ♖xa3

White resigned.

16

Andor Lilienthal

José Raul Capablanca

Hastings 1934 (5)

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.a3 ♗xc3+ 5.bxc3 b6 6.f3 d5

In our day, going after the pawn on c4 is considering a more promising plan: 6...♗a6 7.e4 ♘c6, followed by ...♘c6-a5.

7. ♗g5

Modern theory also condemns this bishop move. Stronger is 7.cxd5 exd5 8.e3, followed by ♗f1-d3, ♘g1-e2 and 0-0. Later, without fearing the possible bishop exchange on a6, White prepares e3-e4.

7...h6 8. ♗h4 ♗a6 9.e4 ♗xc4

Black does not win material, whilst the white centre remains intact. He should have decided on 9...dxe4! 10.fxe4 g5! 11.♗g3 ♘xe4, and after Lilienthal's 12.♗e5 f6! 13.♖h5+ ♖d7 14.♗d3 ♗b7 15.♗g3 ♘xg3 16.hxg3 ♘c6, we have a doubled-edged struggle. In time, Black will castle by hand on the queenside.

10. ♗xc4 dxc4 11. ♖a4+ ♖d7 12. ♖xc4 ♖c6 13. ♖d3 ♘bd7 14. ♘e2

Thanks to his firm centre, White has a clear advantage.

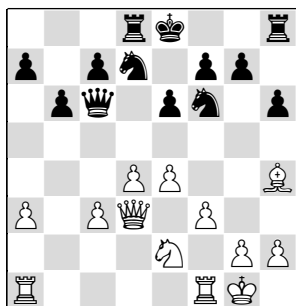
14... ♖d8

By setting up an x-ray attack along the d-file, Black stops e4-e5, thereby meeting the threat to set up a bind on his position. However, the problem soon returns and it will be more difficult to solve, because now the ♘f6 is pinned, whilst Black has also deprived himself of the chance to castle queenside.

One of the possible ideas in the position is 14...b5, fixing the c4-square. It would not be favourable then for White to play 15.e5, because after 15...♘d5, the advance c3-c4 is impossible.

Another, radically different idea is 14...g5!?, followed by queenside castling. Then Black can consider ...g5-g4, trying to weaken the light squares in the enemy camp.

15.0-0



15...a5?

Black did not like the look of castling, but his king is even more vulnerable in the centre. He should have settled for 15...0-0! 16.♖c2 ♗c4! (he also has an inferior, but defensible position after 16...e5) 17.e5 g5 18.♙xg5 hxg5 19.exf6 ♘xf6 20.♗d2 ♝d5! 21.f4 c5!. The black king is not terribly safe, but he has managed to exchange a couple of pieces and establish some pressure in the centre. White has the initiative, but there is nothing decisive, and Black's possibilities of counterplay are excellently illustrated in the variation 22.fxg5

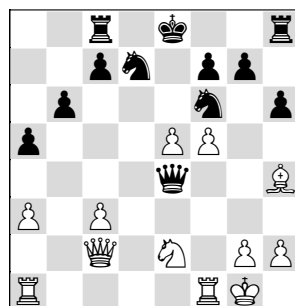
♘e4 23.♗e3 ♘xc3! 24.♗xc3 ♗xe2, maintaining the balance.

16.♗c2

White intends to play for an attack, but he could also strengthen his central position with 16.c4, since then it is bad to reply 16...♘e5? 17.♗c3 ♘xc4 18.♝fc1 b5 19.a4+-.

16...♗c4 17.f4 ♝c8 18.f5 e5 19.dxe5 ♗xe4?

This runs into a beautiful refutation. The defensive resources in chess are extremely great! Despite the mistakes he has already made, it was still possible for Black to defend with 19...♘xe5! 20.♘f4 (there is also nothing decisive after 20.♙xf6 gxf6 21.♘f4 ♗c5+ (on 21...c6, there is the unpleasant queen transfer 22.♗f2) 22.♙h1 ♝d8 – Black wants to put his pawn on c6 and his king on e7) 20...♘fg4 21.♗d2 ♗c5+ 22.♗d4 ♘e3 23.♗xc5 bxc5 24.♝fb1 ♘d7 25.a4. White retains the advantage, but the win remains a long way away.



20.exf6!! ♗xc2 21.fxg7 ♝g8 22.♘d4 ♗e4 23.♝ae1 ♘c5 24.♝xe4+ ♘xe4 25.♝e1 ♝xg7 26.♝xe4+ ♘d7

Without waiting to lose the f7-pawn as well, Black resigned.

Chapter 4

Do not develop the queen too early

In the majority of cases, bringing the queen out to an active position in the early stages of the game is even worse than unnecessary pawn moves or even just purposeless moves. This is especially so if the aim of the queen development is to grab a wing pawn. As a rule, the opponent can just ignore the threat and continue developing, obtaining in return for a minimal material investment at least three tempi (the queen comes out, takes a pawn and then retreats – and sometimes even gets attacked again). There are only rare exceptions, such as in closed openings like the French Defence, or in some very well-developed lines of the Sicilian Najdorf.

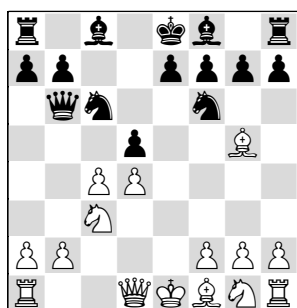
17

Mikhail Botvinnik
Rudolf Spielmann

Moscow 1935 (1)

1.c4 c6 2.e4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.d4
♟f6 5.♟c3 ♟c6 6.♟g5 ♖b6

Black does not develop, nor strengthen the d5-square, but instead sends his queen on an adventure. The normal continuations are 6...e6 and 6...♟e6.



7.cxd5 ♖xb2?

In an open position, Black has made two of his first seven moves with his queen, the second of which leads to fatal consequences.

*

Essential was 7...♟xd4, although after 8.♟f3 (if 8.♟e3 e5 9.dxe6 ♟c5 10.exf7+ ♟xf7 11.♟f3 ♟xf3+ 12.♖xf3 ♜e8 13.♟c4+ ♟e6 14.♟xe6+ ♖xe6 15.0-0 ♟xe3, White's advantage is minimal) 8...♖xb2 9.♜c1 ♟xf3+ 10.♖xf3 a6 11.♟d3, White's initiative is very strong.

8.♜c1!

Development above all else!

The direct attempt to win a piece does not work, as after 8.♟a4? ♖b4+ 9.♟d2 ♖xd4 10.dxc6, there follows 10...♟e4!.

8...♟b4

8...♟b8 9.♟a4 ♖b4+ 10.♟d2+–.

8...♟d8 9.♟xf6 gxf6 10.♟b5+ ♟d7 11.♟xd7+ ♟xd7 12.♟ge2+–.

9.♟a4 ♖xa2 10.♟c4 ♟g4

10...♖a3 11.♜c3+–.

11.♟f3 ♟xf3 12.gxf3

1-0

18

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Mikhail Tal
Georgi Tringov

Amsterdam izt 1964 (2)

1.e4 g6 2.d4 ♟g7 3.♟c3 d6 4.♟f3

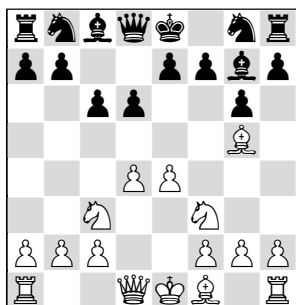
Opening – do not make unnecessary pawn moves

4...c6

Black makes an unnecessary pawn move, before he has finished developing. Stronger is 4...♘f6.

5.♗g5

The other active bishop move, 5.♗c4, was not so effective, since there the bishop could become an object of attack by a later ...b7-b5 or ...d6-d5.



5...♝b6?

And this is already a serious mistake. It was essential to play 5...♘f6.

6.♝d2!

Instead of passively defending the pawn, White prepares its sacrifice and gains additional tempi for development.

6...♝xb2 7.♞b1 ♝a3 8.♗c4 ♝a5

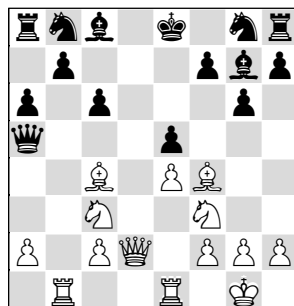
The black queen, stranded on her own in the enemy camp, hurries back home, but it is too late – the difference in development between the two sides is already overwhelming.

9.0-0 e6 10.♞fe1 a6 11.♗f4 e5

More tenacious is 11...♝c7, not provoking the opening of additional lines. But even in this case, White achieves his aim by energetic play: 12.d5! e5 13.dxc6! exf4 (in the event of 13...bxc6 14.♗e3 ♘f6 15.♞ed1, White

regains the pawn, retaining all the advantages of his position – Black has not developed his queenside) 14.e5 dxe5 (14...♗xe5 15.cxb7 ♗xb7 16.♞xb7 ♝xb7 17.♝xd6+–) 15.♗xf7+ ♝xf7 16.♘e4, with a winning attack.

12.dxe5 dxe5



13.♝d6!

The queen penetrates the enemy camp with decisive effect.

13...♝xc3 14.♞ed1 ♘d7

14...♗f6 15.♘xe5 ♗e7 16.♗xf7+ ♖f8 17.♝c7+–.

15.♗xf7+! ♖xf7 16.♘g5+ ♗e8 17.♝e6+ 1-0

19

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Konstantin Sakaev

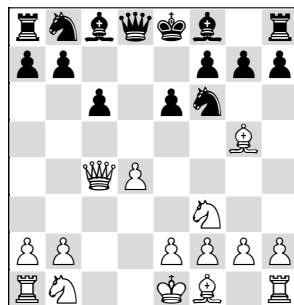
2620

Pavel Tregubov

2560

St Petersburg ch-RUS 1998 (2)

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c6 3.c4 e6 4.♝c2 dxc4 5.♝xc4 ♘f6 6.♗g5



6...♝b6?!

Black attacks b2, and is counting on White spending a tempo defending it, when Black can get in ...c6-c5. Much safer was the typical 6...b5 7.♖c2 ♖b7. Then Black plays ...♗bd7 and tries to achieve ...c7-c5.

7.♗bd2!

In return for the pawn, White gains several tempi for development. After 7.♖c2 c5, Black's idea would be justified.

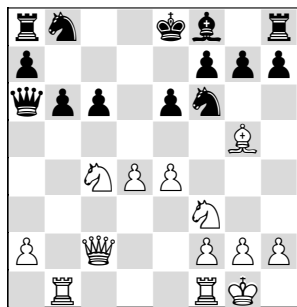
7...♖xb2 8.♞b1 ♖a3 9.e4 b6

It is not so easy for Black to defend. If he brings the bishop to e7, later White gets in e4-e5, and after the exchange of bishops, he can pressurise the weak dark squares. In addition, he can build a battery along the b1-h7 diagonal, supported by the advance of the h-pawn.

10.♖c2 ♖a6 11.♖c4!

White furthers his own development and hampers Black's.

11...♖xc4 12.♗xc4 ♖a6 13.0-0



13...♗xe4?

Black is already seriously behind in development, and now he goes after another pawn. Also bad is 13...♗bd7 14.♗ce5 – the weakening of the light squares tells.

It was essential to develop at all costs, although White retains the advantage in any event: 13...b5! and now:

A) 14.♗e3 ♗bd7 15.♞fc1 ♖a3! (15...♞c8 16.e5 ♗d5 17.♗xd5 exd5 18.a4! b4 (completely bad is 18...bxa4 19.♖f5 c5 20.e6 fxe6 21.♞e1 ♞c6 22.♖xd5 ♖e7 23.♖a2 – White has a decisive attack) 19.♖d2 – White regains the pawn, with a clear advantage) 16.♖xc6 ♖xc6 17.♞xc6 ♗xe4 18.♞xb5 0-0 – Black retains chances of a successful defence;

B) 14.♗ce5 h6! (on 14...♖e7, strong is 15.d5! cxd5 16.exd5 ♗xd5 17.♖xe7 ♗xe7 18.♗g5) 15.♖xf6 (on 15.♖h4, a possibility is 15...♖e7, and then after 16.d5 cxd5 17.exd5 ♗xd5, the pawn on h6 controls the square g5) 15...gxf6 16.♗d3 – White has a strong initiative, but it is possible to defend.

14.♖xe4 ♖xc4 15.♞bc1 ♖a4 16.♗e5 ♖d6 17.♗c4

White could win in nice style: 17.♗xc6! 0-0 (or 17...h6 18.♗e7! ♗c6 19.♗g6! ♗d7 20.♗xh8 ♞xh8 21.♖e3 – with the king in the centre, the game will not last long) 18.♗d8 ♖b5 19.♗xe6 fxe6 20.♖xe6+ ♞f7 21.♞c8+ ♖f8 22.d5! – and Black is completely busted.

17...♖c7

White wins in beautiful fashion after 17...♖a3 18.♞c3 ♖b4 19.♖e5! ♖xc3 20.♖xg7.

18.d5 0-0 19.dxe6 ♗a6

Black underestimates the strength of the central white pawn.

It was essential to play 19...fxe6 20.♖xe6+ ♖h8 21.♖e7 (if 21.♞fd1 ♗a6 22.♖e7, there is 22...♗c5!) 21...♞e8, retaining defensive chances, despite the undeveloped queenside. White has a choice between 22.♞fe1 c5 23.♖f7 and 22.♖f7 ♗d7 23.f4, with a dangerous initiative in both cases.

20.♖e7 f5 21.♖d3 ♞fe8 22.♖d7

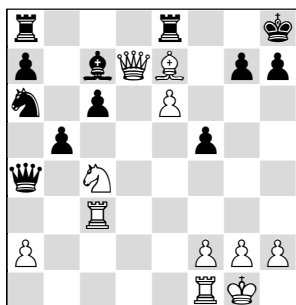
The passed pawn on e6 decides the outcome of the game.

22...♖h8 23.♜c3

Again, he could win in style: 23.♙d6 ♜ed8 24.♞f7 ♙xd6 25.♘xd6 ♜xd6 26.e7.

23...b5

On 23...♙f4, White wins with 24.g3 ♙c7 25.♞fc1, followed by penetrating to d6. Similarly, there is 23...h6 24.♙d6 ♜ed8 25.♞e7 ♜ac8 26.♞g3 ♞g8 27.♙e5.



24.♙f6 ♞g8 25.♙e5 ♙xe5 26.♙xe5 ♞e4 27.f4 ♙c5 28.♞d6 ♙b7 29.♞e7

Black resigned.

20

Stefano Tatai

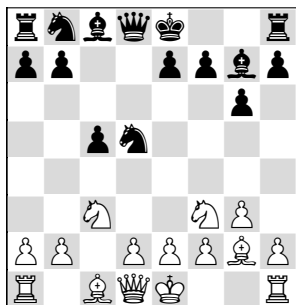
2480

Anatoly Karpov

2690

Las Palmas 1977 (13)

1.♙f3 c5 2.c4 ♙f6 3.♙c3 d5 4.cxd5 ♙xd5 5.g3 g6 6.♙g2 ♙g7



With the bishop on g7, the pawn on c5 is undefended, and White starts an extremely risky operation to go after it.

7.♞a4+

It was more solid to continue development by castling.

7...♙c6 8.♙g5 e6 9.♙ge4

It is hard for Black to defend the pawn, but he does not have to – his trump is the lead in development that White's last few moves have granted him.

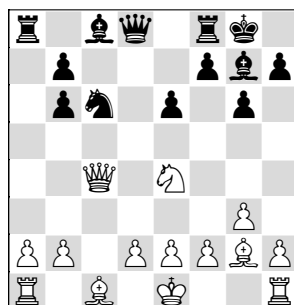
9...♙b6 10.♞b5

Now, the queen gets attacked, losing further tempi. He should have chosen the more cautious 10.♞a3 0-0 11.0-0 c4 12.b3 (12.d3 cxd3 13.exd3 ♞e7! leaves Black a small static advantage – an isolated pawn is an isolated pawn...) 12...♙d4 13.♞b1 cxb3 14.axb3. White's pieces occupy unstable positions, so one cannot speak of him having any advantage, but he can at least count on equality.

10...c4 11.♙a4 0-0 12.♙xb6 axb6!

This is even stronger than 12...♞xb6 13.♞xc4 ♙d7, with active play for the pawn.

13.♞xc4



13...e5!

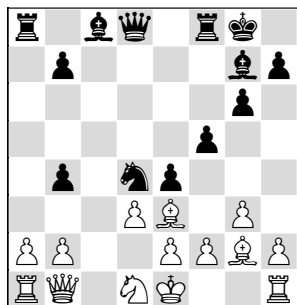
Black goes over to a mass attack in the centre. He could also have

started play on the queenside, but this is less effective: 13...♙d7, with the idea of ♘c6-d4. In this case, if the white knight retreats to c3, then the advance ...b6-b5-b4 is unpleasant.

14. ♖c2 ♘d4 15. ♖b1 f5 16. ♘c3 e4 17. d3

Better was 17.0-0, although after 17...b5 18.b4 (18.e3 ♘f3+ 19.♙xf3 exf3) 18...♖f6 (also good is 18...♙e6 19.♙b2 ♖d7, with more than sufficient compensation for the pawn) 19.e3 ♘f3+ 20.♙xf3 exf3, Black's initiative on the light squares is quite strong.

17...b5! 18.♙e3 b4 19.♘d1



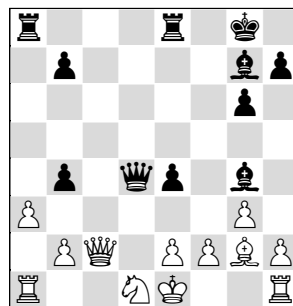
19...♙e8!

White is completely under the cosh, and his pieces have no scope.

20.dxe4 fxe4 21.♙xd4 ♖xd4 22.a3

More tenacious is 22.0-0, after which Black has many tempting possibilities. Little comes from 22...♖d2 23.♙xe4 ♙h3 (23...♖xe2 24.♘e3) 24.♖d3! (bad is 24.♙g2 ♙xg2 25.♖xg2 ♖xe2 26.♖c1 ♖d5+ 27.♖g1 ♙d4) 24...♖xd3 25.♙xd3 ♙xf1 26.♖xf1 – the endgame is close to equality. Interesting is 22...♙f5!?. The most promising line of all looks to be 22...♙g4 23.♖e1 ♖h8!, increasing the pressure.

22...♙g4 23.♖c2



All of Black's pieces are mobilised and active. It is time to remember that White has 'forgotten' to castle.

23...♖d3! 24.exd3

24.♘e3 ♖xc2 25.♘xc2 ♙xb2.

More tenacious is 24.♖d2, but here too, after 24...♖xd2+ 25.♙xd2 ♖ad8+ (25...♖ac8! 26.axb4 ♖ed8+ 27.♖e1 ♖c2 28.f3 exf3 29.♙xf3 ♙xf3 30.exf3 ♙f8, Black has a decisive advantage – the rook on h1 has never managed to get into play) 26.♖e1 ♖c8.

24...exd3+ 25.♘d2

The picture is much the same after 25.♘e3 dxc2 26.♘d2 ♖ad8+ 27.♖xc2 ♙f5+ 28.♘xf5 (or 28.♖b3 ♙e6+ 29.♖xb4 ♖d3) 28...♖e2+ 29.♖b3 ♖xb2+ 30.♖c4 ♖c8+ 31.♘d3 ♖c3+ 32.♖e4 gxf5+ 33.♖xf5 ♖xf2+.

25...♖e2+ 26.♖xd3 ♖d8+ 27.♖c4

27.♙d5+ ♖xd5+ 28.♖c4 ♖xc2+ 29.♖xd5 ♙f3+–+.

27...♖xc2+ 28.♖xb4 ♖cd2! 29.f3 ♙f8+ 30.♖a5 ♙d7

White resigned.

21

Alexander Lastin

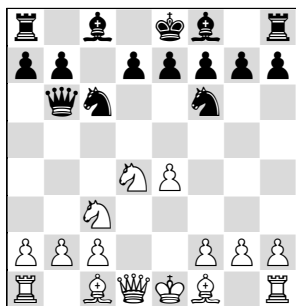
Dmitry Kononenko

Russia tt 2009 (2)

2650

2569

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♖b6?



In the Sicilian, there are a number of variations where the black queen appears on b6, either to drive the enemy knight from d4 or to force its exchange on c6. Having achieved this task, the queen calmly retreats to c7. It seems that this is a loss of tempo (in some lines, White voluntarily retreats his knight to b3 or f3 anyway), but in many cases, the absence of the knight in the centre significantly reduces White's attacking possibilities. In particular, after the standard advance f2-f4-f5, the white knight does not pressurise e6.

6. ♖e3!

In this version, White exploits Black's lack of caution, defending his knight and developing with tempo. As we will see, taking the pawn on b2 leads to a position with a strong initiative for White.

6... ♜xb2 7. ♘db5 ♜b4 8. ♙d2 ♜b8!

Other moves do not help:

- A) 8... ♜a5? 9. ♘d5+—;
- B) 8... ♘xe4? 9. a3! ♘xc3 10. axb4 ♘xd1 11. ♘c7+ ♖d8 12. ♘xa8 ♘xf2 13. ♖xf2 e6 (the white knight on a8 does not get taken! 13...b6 14.b5!) 14.c3 b6 15. ♙b5 ♙b7 16. ♙xc6 ♙xc6 17. ♜xa7+—;
- C) 8... ♖d8 9. ♜b1 ♜c5. (9... ♜a5 10.f4 (also good is 10.a3 a6 11. ♘d5 ♜a4 12. ♘bc3 ♜d4 13. ♙d3) 10...a6 11. ♘d5

♜a4 12. ♘bc3 ♜d4 13. ♜f3 ♘xd5 14. ♘xd5 ♜c5 15.c3+— Minchev-Teichmann, Email 2008). This position was seen in Tudela-Garcia, Tenerife 2006, and here the simplest win was 10. ♘d5! e5 11. ♙e3, trapping the queen.

9. ♜b1 ♜a5 10. ♘d5 ♜a4 11. ♘bc7+

With the help of the computer, we can see that after 11. ♘b4! a6 (11...e6 12. ♘c7+ ♖d8 13. ♙b5 ♜a3 14. ♙xc6 bxc6 15. ♘xe6+ fxe6 16. ♘xc6+ dxc6 17. ♙b4+ ♘d7 18. ♙xa3 ♜xb1 19. ♜xb1 ♙xa3 20. ♜b3 ♙c5 21. ♜xe6±) 12. ♘c7+ ♖d8 13. ♘cxa6 ♜a8 14. ♙b5! ♜xb5 15. ♘xc6+ ♜xc6 16. ♙a5+ b6 17. ♜xb6 ♜a4 (17... ♜xe4+ 18. ♜e2 ♜xa6 19. ♜xa6+ ♖e8 20. ♜xe4 ♘xe4 21. ♜a8 ♘d6 22. ♙c7) 18. ♜b5+ ♜xa5+ 19. ♜xa5 ♜xa6 20. ♜xa6 ♙xa6 21. ♜d4 ♘e8 22.h4! ♘c7 23. ♜h3 e6 24. ♜c3, White wins.

11... ♖d8 12. ♘c3 ♜d4 13. ♘7b5 ♜e5 14.f4 ♜e6 15.f5

The black queen continues to come under the blows of the white pieces and pawns.

15... ♜e5

Here White had another chance to end things cleanly with a knockdown of the black queen after

16. ♜c1!

Defending the c2-pawn. The game saw the logical, but less strong, 16. ♜f3 d6 17. ♙d3 a6 18. ♙f4 ♜c5 19. ♘a4 ♘e5 20. ♜d1 ♜c6, and the battle flared up with renewed intensity.

16...d6

16... ♘xe4 17. ♙f4 ♜xf5 18. ♙c7+ ♖e8 19. ♜e3 d5 (19... ♘xc3 20. ♘d6#) 20. ♙xb8 ♘xb8 21. ♘xe4 ♜xe4 22. ♜xe4 dxe4 23. ♘xa7 ♖d8 24. ♙c4 e6 25. ♘xc8 ♖xc8 26. ♜f1±.

16...g5 17.♔xg5.

17.♔f4 ♖c5 18.♘a4
winning.

22

Anish Giri

Mateusz Bartel

Rhodes tt 2013 (6)

2749

2638

1.♟f3 d5 2.d4 a6

This rare move with the rook's pawn is played in anticipation of 3.c4, so as after 3...dxc4 to transpose into a reasonable line of the Queen's Gambit Accepted. In that opening, the move ...a7-a6 is very useful, and is worth the tempo expended on it. In some lines, Black can play ...b7-b5, defending the c4-pawn, and in others, he plays ...b7-b5 to kick a white bishop on c4, and with tempo to prepare the development of his own bishop on b7. However, White can delay or dispense altogether with the pawn advance c2-c4, either as he does in the game, or with 3.g3, fianchettoing his bishop on g2. In both cases, the move ...a7-a6, although still of some use, is not worth the tempo it has cost.

3.♔g5

A normal square for this piece. White intends e2-e3 and c2-c4, simultaneously preventing ...e7-e6.

3...c6

Trying to play symmetrically does not solve the problems: 3...♔g4 4.e3 ♘d7 5.c4, and there is still not the move ...e7-e6.

4.e3 ♖b6?!

Black escapes the pin on the e7-pawn and attacks b2. In the event of the slow 5.♖c1 ♔g4 and then ...e7-e6, his strategy would prove justified.

However, he underestimates his lack of development.

More solid is 4...♔g4 5.c4 (less energetic is 5.♘bd2 ♘d7 6.c4 ♘gf6 – the knight on d2 is passive) 5...♘d7 (5...♔xf3 6.♖xf3 ♖a5+ 7.♘d2 e6 8.c5!±; 5...dxc4 6.♔xc4±; 5...h6 6.♔h4±) 6.♘c3 ♖a5 (6...♘gf6 7.♖b3±) 7.♖b3 ♔xf3 8.gxf3 dxc4 9.♔xc4 e6± – White retains a small advantage, but Black has a solid position.

5.♔d3!

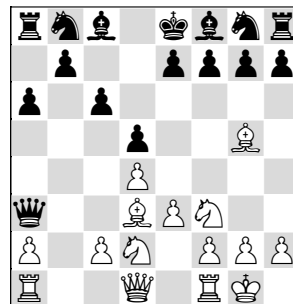
White chooses a move order which deliberately leaves the b2-pawn undefended.

A transposition would arise after 5.♘bd2 ♖xb2 6.♔d3.

5...♖xb2 6.♘bd2

The bishop cannot come to g4 because of ♖b1, so Black makes another move with his queen.

6...♖a3 7.0-0



White has made five developing moves, Black not one. In addition, the early exit of the queen could result in her being attacked further. The queen would be better on d8 than a3.

7...♔g4 8.♖b1!

White attacks b7 and defends the bishop on d3, preparing to open lines with c2-c4. He had already

seen that Black's next move does not hinder this plan.

8...b5 9.c4! ♟xf3

Otherwise, he has to reckon also with the knight jumping to e5.

10.♟xf3 dxc4

White has a decisive advantage in development after 10...e6 11.cxd5 exd5 (11...cxd5 12.♟e5!+–, with the threat of ♟d3xb5) 12.e4 h6 13.♟d2+–.

11.♟xc4 e6 12.e4

White strives to open the centre as quickly as possible. Also possible was 12.♞c1, not only playing against the backward pawn on c6, but also threatening the break d4-d5!. The only defence against this is the unlikely-looking 12...♟e7!, and here White has a pleasant choice between the aggressive 13.♟e5 and the quiet 13.♟b3, retaining all the advantages of his position.

12...♟e7

On 12...♟d7, there could follow 13.d5!, with a strong attack.

13.♟c1 ♞a5 14.d5

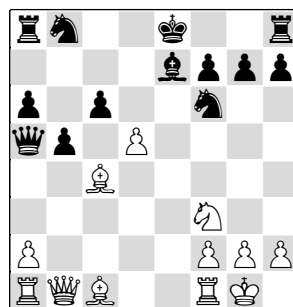
Even stronger is the more subtle 14.a4!, weakening the light squares before breaking through. There could follow: 14...b4 15.♟b2 ♟f6 16.d5 exd5 17.exd5 0-0 18.d6! ♟d8! (18...♟xd6 19.♟xf6 gxf6 20.♞d1→ – the attack on the light squares is very strong) 19.♞c2 ♟bd7 20.♟d4 ♞c5 21.♞ad1↑, with a strong initiative.

14...exd5?

The quick opening of the e-file is the equivalent of suicide, given that the black king is stuck there.

Correct is 14...cxd5! 15.♟b3! (if 15.exd5 bxc4 Black beats off the attack) 15...♟f6 16.exd5 exd5 17.♞e1 ♞d8 18.♟b2 0-0 19.♟g5 ♟bd7 (the character of the struggle is much the same after 19...g6 20.♞d3!) 20.♟xd5 ♞c8 21.♞f5 ♟b4! – White has a strong initiative, but Black can put up some defence.

15.exd5 ♟f6



16.d6!

Black faces an open position, with his king uncastled and no pieces developed. All he has to show for this is a pawn, which is of no relevance at all.

16...♟xd6 17.♞e1+ ♟f8 18.♞f5 ♟bd7 19.♟xf7! ♟e5

More tenacious is 19...♞xe1+, although after 20.♟xe1 ♟xf7 21.♟f3+– Black has few realistic hopes of surviving.

20.♞xe5! ♟xe5 21.♟b3 ♞e8 22.♟e3 b4 23.♟f4 1-0

Additional material

Boleslavsky-Bronstein, Moscow 1950

Hübner-Kasparov, Hamburg (match/1) 1985

Alekhine-Nimzowitsch, Bled 1931

Chapter 5

Do not move the same piece twice

A piece does not always land immediately on its ideal square, and often we want to improve its position. But it should be remembered that the tempo spent doing this is extremely important, and more often than not, it is more useful to spend it bringing another piece into play.

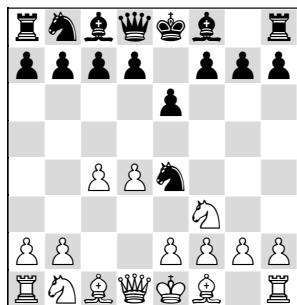
23

Alexander Alekhine

Frank Marshall

New York 1927 (18)

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 ♘e4?



Black strives for piece control of the central light squares. After posting his knight on e4, he intends to support it with ...f7-f5, and also with the help of a fianchettoed bishop on b7. However, this move has a serious drawback, which is more important than its advantages – the knight is already developed, and in the opening, one should try not to make multiple moves with the same piece.

4.♘fd2!?

It may look as though White is guilty of the same sin, but one must take note of the difference – Black will either have to create holes in his position by playing ...f7-f5 and ...d7-d5 to defend his knight, or else

exchange it off and completely lose his central outpost. Meanwhile, White foresees the possibility of a black pawn appearing on e4, and so frees his f-pawn, for a later break.

A good alternative was 4.g3 – the bishop on g2 will exert strong pressure down the long diagonal.

4...♗b4

To fight for the e4-square, Black is ready to exchange his dark-squared bishop, but this proves insufficient.

5.♖c2 d5

It would have been better not to stick stubbornly to his intention, and instead play 5...♘xd2 6.♘xd2 0-0 7.a3 ♗e7 – here White's advantage is minimal.

6.♘c3 f5

And here he should have preferred the developing move 6...♘c6, forcing 7.e3 and so preventing the enemy dark-squared bishop coming out to an active position.

7.♘dxe4 fxe4 8.♗f4 0-0 9.e3 c6 10.♗e2

White only needs to castle to complete his development, whereas the whole of Black's queenside remains undeveloped.

10...♘d7

Now, Black will face additional problems, because White's dark-

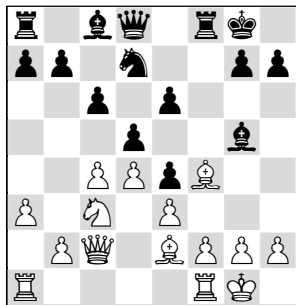
squared bishop is more active than its opponent.

He should prefer 10...♔d6, although after 11.♔xd6 ♖xd6 12.0-0 followed by f2-f3, White has a stable plus.

11.a3

Also good is 11.0-0.

11...♔e7 12.0-0 ♔g5



13.f3!

White not only breaks up Black's principal central strongpoint, but also opens lines, exploiting his lead in development.

13...♔xf4 14.exf4 ♖xf4

If 14...e3 15.g3, the daring pawn on e3 is doomed to extinction.

Relatively best was 14...exf3 15.♖xf3 ♗f6, but Black's bad light-squared bishop and backward pawn on e6 give White a stable plus.

15.fxe4 ♖xf1+ 16.♖xf1 e5

Original, but still bad – Black's pieces are not prepared for the opening of lines.

17.♗d2 c5

Also bad is 17...♗b6 18.♗g5+–, creating the threat of ...♗g5-e7.

18.dxe5

A more prosaic path to victory was 18.exd5 exd4 19.♗e4+–.

18...d4 19.♗f4 dxc3 20.♗f7+ ♔h8 21.bxc3!

Black is totally paralysed, with his queenside taking no part at all in what is going on.

21...♗g8 22.♗e7 h6 23.♔h5 a5 24.e6 g6

24...♗f6 25.♔f7+–.

25.exd7 ♔xd7 26.♖f7

1-0

24

Konstantin Sakaev

2634

Arkadij Naiditsch

2652

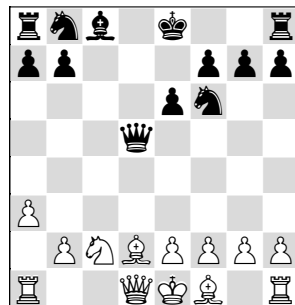
Serbia tt 2007 (9)

1.d4 ♗f6 2.c4 e6 3.♗f3 ♔b4+ 4.♗bd2 c5

This move does not enjoy a great theoretical reputation.

5.a3 ♔xd2+ 6.♔xd2 cxd4 7.♗xd4 d5 8.cxd5 ♗xd5 9.♗c2!?

The idea of this knight retreat is to play the pawns to f3 and e4, restricting the black knight on f6. The usual continuation 9.e3 somewhat restricts White's own dark-squared bishop, although, in return, it allows the knight to remain on its fine central square.

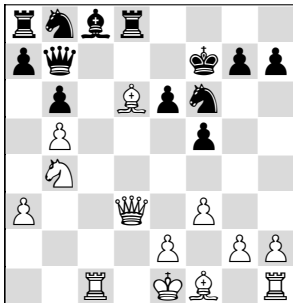


9...♗e4?

This attempt to sow disharmony in the white position is not good, because it loses precious time, which would be better spent on developing his pieces. Black overrates the strength of the two bishops, which would remain

behind the protection of the pawns on f3 and e4. Nothing terrible happens to Black after the simple and natural 9...0-0 10.f3 (a complicated, roughly equal game results from 10.♙c3 ♖g5 11.h4 ♖g6; nor is there any danger in the endgame arising after 10.♙b4 ♜d8 11.♖xd5 ♜xd5 12.♙d2 e5 13.e4 ♜b6 – the advantage of the two bishops is compensated for by the free development) 10...♖h5 11.e4 ♜d8. The unpleasant pin on the d-file prevents White completing his development comfortably. An interesting variation is 12.♖e2 (a double-edged game also results from 12.♙e2 ♖h4+ 13.g3 ♖h3) 12...♜c6 (also interesting is 12...♙d7, with the idea of harassing the enemy knight by ...♙d7-a4, and keeping at the back of his mind the dream of ensconcing his knight on the weakened square d4) 13.h4!? e5!? (more solid and stronger is 13...♖c5, but romantics prefer the text, even in analysis!) 14.g4 ♜xg4 15.fxg4 ♙xg4 16.♖e3. An interesting position, but it seems to me that White is likely to beat off the attack and realise the extra piece.

10.♙e3 ♖a5+ 11.b4 ♖c7 12.♖d3 f5 13.f3 ♜f6 14.♙c5 b6 15.♙d6 ♖c6 16.b5 ♖b7 17.♜c1 ♜f7 18.♜b4 ♜d8



19.e4!

Bringing the light-squared bishop into the game with tempo, and at the same time preparing to strengthen the position of the bishop on d6. I had seen this move when playing 17.♜c1, and now Black is in trouble. White can retain the advantage with 19.♖c3, but the position deserves more than that.

19...♜e8

The pawn cannot be taken: 19...fxe4 20.fxe4 ♖xe4+ (20...♜xe4 21.♜c7+ ♖xc7 22.♖f3++-) 21.♖xe4 ♜xe4 22.♙xb8 ♜xb8 23.♜c6+-.

20.e5 ♙g8 21.♖c3 ♜xd6 22.exd6 a5 23.bxa6 ♖d7 24.♖e5 ♖f7 25.♜c7 ♜d7 26.♖c3 ♖f8 27.♜c6

Black resigned.

25

**

Mikhail Botvinnik

Lajos Portisch

Monaco 1968 (7)

1.c4 e5 2.♜c3 ♜f6 3.g3 d5 4.cxd5 ♜xd5 5.♙g2 ♙e6 6.♜f3 ♜c6 7.0-0 ♜b6

Black has not yet developed all his pieces, but voluntarily moves his knight from the centre. Why? The truth is that, in the event of quiet development with 7...♙e7, there is the strong reply 8.d4 – after several exchanges, White will achieve preponderance in the centre. Now, however, White does not have any particular sharp continuations, and Black manages to complete his development.

8.d3 ♙e7 9.a3 a5

An unnecessary weakening of the light squares – the advance b2-b4 need not be greatly feared. Good is

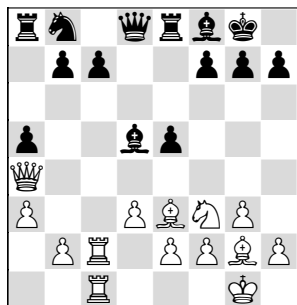
9...0-0 10.b4 f6, with a normal, solid position.

**10.♟e3 0-0 11.♞a4 ♞xa4 12.♞xa4
♟d5 13.♞fc1 ♞e8 14.♞c2 ♟f8
15.♞ac1**

The game has opened with a quiet line of the English Opening, in which Black should strive at all costs to strengthen his centre, whilst White tries to exert pressure down the half-open c-file, in conjunction with play on the light squares. From Black's viewpoint, a logical move is the prophylactic 15...h6, depriving the white knight of the possibility of jumping to g5. Instead of this, there followed

15...♞b8?

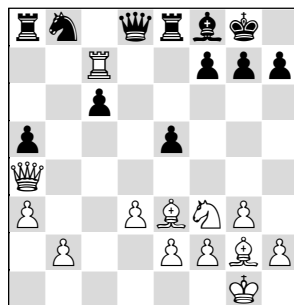
Black's idea is to play ...c7-c6, and shut off the enemy play down the c-file. However, once again the black pieces are undeveloped, and lose coordination, which White exploits effectively:



16.♞xc7! ♟c6

If 16...♞c6 17.♞xb7 (also strong is 17.♟b6) 17...♞d4 18.♞xd4! (after 18.♞d7 ♟b3 19.♞xd8 ♞exd8 Black can still resist) 18...♟xb7 19.♟xb7 exd4 20.♟xd4 ♞b8 21.♟f3, White's pawn phalanx is so strong that Black can do nothing to oppose it.

17.♞1xc6! bxc6



White could simply move the rook to b7, keeping a strong initiative, but he exploits Black's lack of development and his weakened light squares:

18.♞xf7!

Winning without any complicated variations.

18...h6

18...♟xf7 19.♞c4+ ♟g6 20.♞g4+ ♟f7 21.♞g5+ and Black has to give up the queen to avoid mate.

19.♞b7 ♞c8 20.♞c4+ ♟h8 21.♞h4

The most effective, although the simple 21.♞f7 also wins.

**21...♞xb7 22.♞g6+ ♟h7 23.♟e4
♟d6 24.♞xe5+ g6 25.♟xg6+ ♟g7
26.♟xh6+! 1-0**

Additional material

Kasparov-Andersson, Belgrade (match/3) 1985 – Black's 9th move

Chapter 6

Do not leave the king in the centre

The vulnerability of the king should never be underestimated in the opening. Evacuating it in good time to one of the flanks (usually the kingside) is one of the hallmarks of a successfully played opening. Castling is essential, not only for the sake of the king's safety, but also to connect the rooks and establish coordination between them.

26

Konstantin Sakaev

Dmitry Lavrik

Moscow 2009

**1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.c4 c6 4.e3 a6
5.♗c3 b5 6.b3 ♕g4 7.♕d2**

The idea of this modest move is to defend in advance against the pin on the knight. For example, the sharp variation 7.h3 ♕xf3 8.♖xf3 e5 9.dxe5 ♕b4 10.♕d2 ♕xc3 11.♕xc3 ♗e4 12.♕b4 bxc4, according to the verdict of modern theory, leads to equality.

**7...e6 8.h3 ♕xf3 9.♖xf3 ♗bd7
10.♕d3 ♕b4 11.0-0 ♖e7?**

Without having connected his rooks, Black brings out the queen. Correct was the natural 11...0-0, with a minimal advantage to White.

12.cxd5!

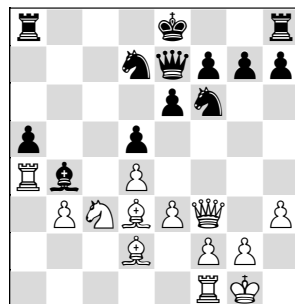
White realises that, thanks to Black not having castled, the rook on a8 is undefended, and he exploits this.

12...cxd5

After 12...exd5, Black is just a bit worse, because of the backward pawn on c6, but has a really bad position, because here too, his lack of castling tells: 13.a3!, and he has to give up the bishop for the knight by 13...♕xc3 (after 13...♕xa3 14.e4 dxe4 15.♗xe4

0-0 16.♕g5 ♕b4 17.♗xf6+ ♗xf6 18.♖fc1 h6 19.♕h4, White regains the pawn and obtains an attack) 14.♕xc3 a5, accepting a difficult and cheerless position.

13.a4 bxa4 14.♖xa4 a5



How should White continue?

**15.♗xd5! exd5 16.♕xb4 ♖d8
17.♖fa1 ♖b6 18.♖d1 ♖b8 19.♕xa5
♖xb3 20.♕c2 ♖b7 21.♖b1 ♖c8
22.♖xb8 ♗xb8 23.♕b4**

Black resigned.

27

Rinat Jumabayev

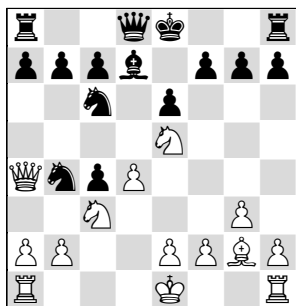
2547

Konstantin Sakaev

2607

St Petersburg 2010

**1.d4 ♗f6 2.c4 e6 3.♗f3 d5 4.g3
dxc4 5.♕g2 ♗c6 6.♖a4 ♕b4+
7.♕d2 ♗d5 8.♕xb4 ♗xb4 9.♗c3
♕d7 10.♗e5**



To regain the sacrificed pawn on c4, White initiates piece play in the centre, trying to save a tempo on castling. The punishment follows at once:

10...d3+! 11.dxd3 cxd3 12.e3

White is lucky that in this way, he can maintain his pawn structure whole and not lose at once. However, the pawn on d3 creates disharmony in White's camp.

12...e5! 13.dxe5

Black also has better play after 13.0-0-0 exd4 14.exd4 0-0 15.fxd3 f8 – the white king is insufficiently well defended.

13...0-0 14.fxe4 d2+!

The pawn is ready to die in the future, but for the moment it sows chaos in the white camp, preventing him castling.

15.fxe2 f8 16.f4 g4+

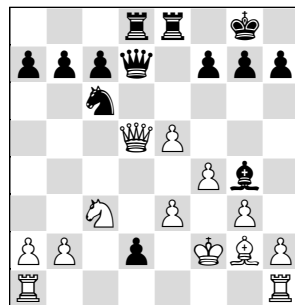
More accurate is 16...f6! 17.f5+ f6 18.fxd2 f4+ 19.f3, and here Black has a whole selection of continuations which enable him to develop his initiative: 19...f7, 19...f8, 19...b4, or even the simple 19...fxe5.

17.f2 f7 18.f5

It was necessary to drive the bishop from g4 immediately: 18.h3! f5 (an unclear game also results from

18...f6 19.fad1) 19.f5 fad8 20.fxd7 fxd7, with a double-edged endgame.

18...fad8



19.h3

In this line, White cannot go into the endgame, as after 19.fxd7 fxd7 20.h3, there follows 20...d1f!

19...f7 20.f4 f6 21.fhd1 f5 22.f1 f6

Prophylaxis against the knight transferring via e4 to g5. There were also other tempting continuations: 22...b4 23.f4 f6 24.fxd2 d3+!, taking on e3 and keeping the initiative. The break 22...f6!? is also interesting, as is the prophylactic 22...h6!? 23.f4 f5.

23.fxc6

On 23.f4, as well as 23...b4 and 23...d4!?, Black can also counter in the centre: 23...f6!? 24.exf6 f7 25.fxg7 b4, winning.

23...fxc6 24.f4 f6 25.f2 f3

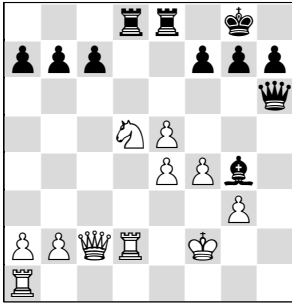
It was stronger to break up the white pawns with 25...f6!, but Black's chosen plan of playing on the dark squares, without weakening his own king, is also logical.

26.fxd2 f6 27.e4 f4

Black wants to keep the queens on, so as to exploit the weakened position

of the white king, but another good choice was 27...♖xd2+ 28.♗xd2 ♗b6+ 29.♕f3 h5 30.♗f2 ♕g4+ 31.♕g2 ♖d8 32.♗xb6 axb6 33.♖f1 c6 – the more active pieces promise Black the advantage in the endgame.

28.♘d5 ♗h6



29.♖g1

Now, the white rook ends up in trouble.

Essential was 29.♕g1 – Black has the initiative, but a great battle still lies ahead.

29...♗h2+ 30.♖g2 ♗h1 31.♗xc7

After 31.♘e3 ♕h3 32.♖g1 ♖xd2+ 33.♗xd2 ♗xe4, White remains a pawn down.

31...♕h3 32.♘e7+

Time trouble. More tenacious is 32.♕f3 ♕xg2+ 33.♖xg2 ♗f1+ 34.♖f2 ♗d3+ 35.♘e3 ♖d7 36.♗c4, although Black should win in any case.

32...♕f8 33.♖xd8 ♗xg2+ 34.♕e3 ♗xg3+ 35.♕d2 ♗xf4+ 36.♕d3 ♕f1+ 37.♕c2 ♗xe4+ 38.♕d2 ♗b4+ 39.♕e3 ♗xe7 40.♖xe8+ ♕xe8 0-1

28

Mikhail Tal

Geza Füster

Portoroz izt 1958 (9)

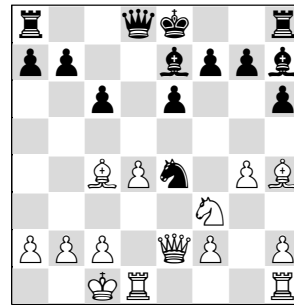
1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.♘c3 dxe4 4.♘xe4 ♘d7 5.♘f3 ♘g6 6.♘xf6+ ♘xf6

7.♕c4 ♕f5 8.♗e2 e6 9.♕g5 ♕e7 10.0-0 h6 11.♕h4 ♘e4

Here the knight is not stable, so more exact is 11...♘d5. If White declines the exchange of bishops, after 12.♕g3 0-0, it is hard for him to develop the initiative on the kingside, because his own bishop stops him advancing his pawns.

12.g4 ♕h7

Battle strategy – a space advantage



13.♕g3!?

The black bishop is not all that strong, but White decides against exchanging it off, preferring to exchange the black knight instead – a typical device in positions with more space.

He could prevent kingside castling by 13.♕xe7 ♗xe7 14.♕d3 ♘f6 15.♕xh7 ♘xh7 16.♘e5. Castling queenside also fails to solve all of Black's problems, as White can play h2-h4, and transfer the rook via h3 and along the 3rd rank, creating some initiative.

13...♘xg3 14.fxg3!?

A non-standard decision – one usually recaptures with the h-pawn, so as to strengthen the position in the centre. In this case, White takes aim at f7, exploiting also

the additional pressure down the diagonal, from his bishop.

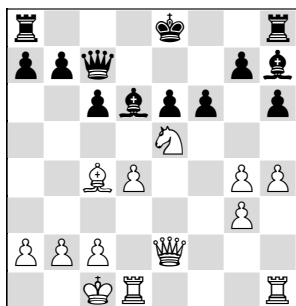
14...♖c7 15.♘e5 ♘d6

More accurate is 15...♘f6, blocking the f-file.

16.h4 f6?

Black counts on White moving the knight, although even in this case, the weakening of the light squares would have been bad. He doesn't fully solve his problems with 16...♘e5 17.dxe5 – White controls the d-file.

But 16...♖f8! is a strong positional decision, defending against the capture on f7 and preparing queen-side castling. Then, he can fight for space in the centre by playing the bishop to g8(!), when, having covered e6, he can drive the knight away with the move ...f7-f6.



17.♘xe6!

White is only too happy to get his hands on the centralised king.

17...fxe5 18.dxe5 ♘e7 19.♖hf1!

White brings his reserves up into the attack, building a decisive attack.

19...♖f8 20.♖xf8+ ♘xf8 21.♖f3! ♖e7 22.♖b3! ♖b8 23.♘d7+ ♖xd7 24.♖xd7 ♘xd7 25.♖f7+ ♘e7 26.e6+ ♘d8 27.♖xg7

Black resigned.

29

Efim Geller

Andrzej Filipowicz

Budapest 1970

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 d6 6.♘e2 ♘e7 7.0-0 a6 8.f4 ♖c7 9.♘h1 ♘c6 10.♘e3 ♘d7 11.a4 ♖c8

It is still not clear if the rook should occupy this square. For example, if White plays his knight to b3 and then advances the pawn with g2-g4, Black often retreats his queen's bishop to c8, so as to free d7 for the knight. More logical was 11...0-0, delaying a decision about his queenside development.

12.♘b3 ♘b4

It is already impossible to prevent the bind on the queenside, because 12...♘a5 allows the strong reply 13.e5!.

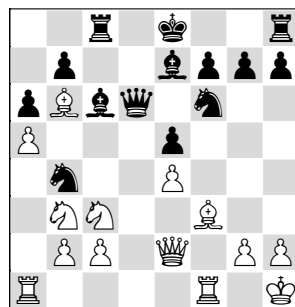
13.a5 ♘c6 14.♘f3 e5

It would still be better to play a developing move, so he should have preferred 14...0-0.

15.fxe5 dxe5 16.♘b6 ♖d6

So the queen does not get hit, it would be better to play 16...♖b8.

17.♖e2



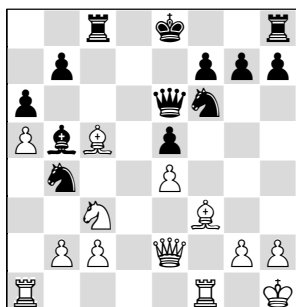
17...♖e6

With this move, Black misses his last chance to castle.

It was absolutely vital to play 17...0-0! 18.♖fd1 (on the natural 18.♖ad1,

Black has 18...♖e6! 19.♘c5 ♘xc5 20.♙xc5 ♙b5 21.♗f2 ♙xf1 22.♙xb4 ♙b5 23.♙xf8 ♚xf8 24.♘xb5 axb5 25.c3 g6, with a defensible position) 18...♗b8 – White has the advantage, but all the battle lies ahead. The middlegame is blazing, and the black king is in the centre. White carries out the attack in style.

18.♘c5! ♙xc5 19.♙xc5 ♙b5



20.♗f2!

But not 20.♘xb5 ♖xc5, and Black manages to complete his development.

20...♙xf1 21.♙xb4

Of the two pieces which are attacked, White chooses the one which could take part in the fight for the central squares and moves the bishop from the attack of the rook. On 21.♖xf1, there would have followed 21...♘xc2, with the idea of ...♘c2-d4.

21...♙c4 22.b3 ♙b5 23.♘xb5 axb5 24.♙e2

The second bishops joins the attack, with decisive effect.

24...♘xe4

On 24...♗a6, White wins with 25.♗g3.

25.♙xb5+ ♘d8 26.♗a7 ♗d5 27.♗b6+ ♖c7 28.a6 bxa6 29.♗b8+ ♖c8 30.♗a7 ♖c7 31.♙a5 axb5 32.♗xc7+ ♙e8 33.♙b4 ♘f2+ 34.♙g1 ♘h3+ 35.♙f1 1-0

30

Elmar Magerramov

Garry Kasparov

Baku 1977

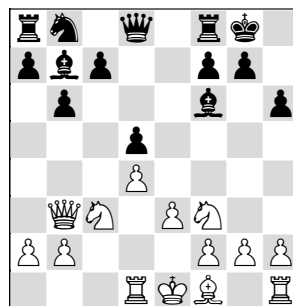
1.♘f3 ♘f6 2.d4 e6 3.c4 d5 4.♘c3 ♙e7 5.♙g5 0-0 6.e3 h6 7.♙h4 b6 8.♗b3

White waits for the black bishop to occupy the square b7.

The immediate 8.♙xf6 ♙xf6 9.cxd5 exd5 10.♗b3 makes no sense, because of 10...♙e6! – on this square, the bishop is better-placed than on b7.

After the simplifying 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♙xe7 ♗xe7 10.♘xd5 exd5 11.♖c1, Black again develops his bishop with 11...♙e6!, and modern theory considers this position to be equal.

8...♙b7 9.♙xf6 ♙xf6 10.cxd5 exd5 11.♖d1



White has given his opponent the advantage of the two bishops, with the aim of stopping the advance ...c7-c5. For this purpose, he has brought his rook to d1, indirectly strengthening the pressure against d5. If Black refrains from the advance ...c7-c5 in the near future, White will place his pieces on convenient squares and develop some pressure. This is the strict positional discussion, but the young Kasparov spotted that

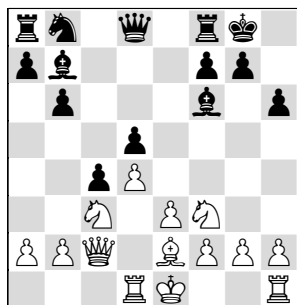
the white set-up has only one, but an important, drawback – the white king has not yet castled! Therefore, there followed

11...c5!

A very specific and strong move.

12.dxc5

Maybe White should have taken care of his king with 12.♔e2, but then there follows 12...c4! 13.♖c2. Here Black has two ways to develop his play:



analysis diagram

A) 13...♘c6 14.b3 (14.0-0 ♖d7 (Black has convenient development) 15.b3) 14...cxb3 (by exchanging his advanced pawn on c4, Black counts on piece play on the queenside) 15.axb3 (after 15.♖xb3 ♘a5, Black is definitely very active, and his knight heads to c4) 15...♘b4 16.♖d2 ♗c8 17.0-0 ♗e8 18.♗c1 a6 19.♘e1 ♙e7 20.♘d3 ♘xd3 21.♖xd3 ♗c7, with excellent play;

B) 13...a6 (trying to secure the advanced pawn on c4) 14.♘e5 (otherwise, Black gets his way free of charge) 14...b5 15.0-0, and now the continuation 15...b4!? promises a sharp battle, in which Black's chances are nonetheless superior. 16.♘a4 ♙xe5 17.dxe5 ♘d7 18.f4 ♙c6 19.♙f3 ♖a5 20.b3 ♗ac8.

12...♘d7! 13.c6

The complexity of White's problems is shown by the variation 13.cxb6 ♘c5 14.♖b4 (even after 14.♖c2, things are still not quite clear with the white king, e.g., 14...axb6 15.♙c4 ♙xc3+ 16.♖xc3 ♖e7 17.♙xd5 ♗fd8 18.♙b3 ♙a6 19.♙c2 ♗xd1+ 20.♙xd1 ♗c8! – the black attack against the white king, stuck in the centre, is very dangerous) 14...♖d6! 15.a3 a5 16.♖c4 ♗fd8 17.♖a2 ♖xb6 18.♙e2 d4! 19.♘xd4 (19.exd4 ♘e6 20.0-0 ♗ac8! 21.♖b1 ♘xd4 22.♘xd4 ♙xd4, and Black is a little better) 19...♙xg2 20.♗g1 ♙b7, with a very strong initiative for the pawn.

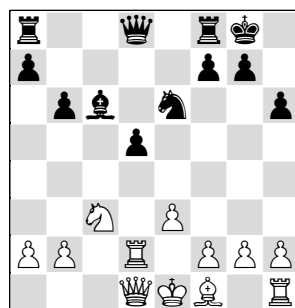
13...♙xc6 14.♘d4

Correct is 14.♘xd5, but after 14...♘c5 15.♘xf6+ ♖xf6 16.♖c3 ♖xc3+ 17.bxc3, the white pawns on the queenside are weak and one of them will be lost. The position is roughly equal.

14...♙xd4 15.♗xd4

On 15.exd4, there follows 15...♖g5!, and again White cannot get his king out of the centre: 16.g3 ♖f5! 17.♙e2 ♖h3!, not permitting the king to flee.

15...♘c5 16.♖d1 ♘e6 17.♗d2



17...d4!

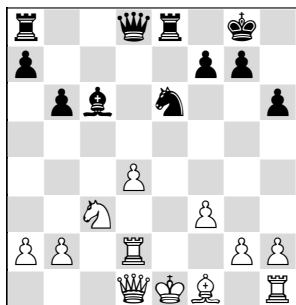
This is the way to treat kings that are stuck in the centre of the board! In addition, this advance is one of the basic plans in IQP structures anyway. Black obtains great activity. White, meanwhile, finds himself trying to hang on to his material gains, and his pieces are forced into passive positions. Just look at the bishop on c6. But of course, such a pawn sacrifice needs to be combined with accurate assessment of the position and calculation of variations.

18.exd4

Black is somewhat better after 18.♖e2 ♜e7 19.♗xd4 ♘xd4 20.♝xd4 ♞fd8.

18...♞e8 19.f3

In the variation 19.d5 ♘f4+ 20.♙e2 ♘xg2+ 21.♖f1 ♙d7! 22.♖xg2? ♜g5+ 23.♖f1 ♙h3+ 24.♖e1 ♜g2 25.♝f1 ♜xf1#, we see the point of Black's idea.



19...♙xf3!!

Additional material

Tal-Hecht, Varna 1962

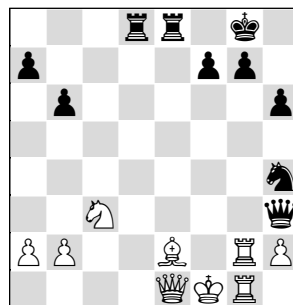
Smyslov-Fischer, Palma de Mallorca 1970

A brilliant tactical blow.

20.gxf3 ♜h4+ 21.♞f2 ♘xd4+ 22.♙e2

22.♘e2 ♘xf3#.

22...♘xf3+ 23.♖f1 ♜h3+ 24.♞g2 ♘h4 25.♞g1 ♞ad8 26.♜e1



26...♞d3!

Bringing up the reserves for the final blow. At the same time, White is tied up and can do nothing.

27.♜f2 ♘f3 28.♞h1 ♞de3 29.♞g1 ♘h8!

Prophylaxis. The opponent has no moves, so Black does not force events, but simply strengthens his position. He could also win with 29...♝xc3 30.bxc3 ♘xh2+ 31.♖e1 ♜xc3+.

30.♞h1 b5

White resigned.

The knight on c3 soon has to move, after which the bishop on e2 drops. A brilliant game by the future 13th World Champion.

Chapter 7

An unprepared attack

One should not launch an attack when one has not completed development. Or, at least, one should be well ahead of the opponent in this regard. After all, defence is easier, so one needs to have some basis for the attack, some superiority in forces.

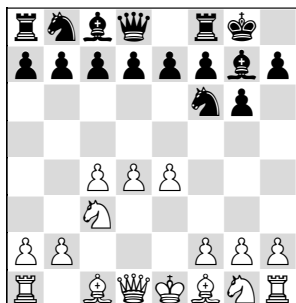
31

René Letelier Martner

Robert Fischer

Leipzig ol 1960 (8)

**1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 g6 3.♘c3 ♗g7 4.e4
0-0**



In principle, this move is a provocation. But for 1960, it was a real challenge! If the knight is attacked, it has to go to e8. But now, with the aid of experience collected over time, we can say that White's next move is the start of an insufficiently-prepared attack in the centre.

5.e5?!

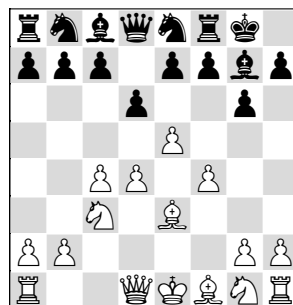
He should have prepared quiet development with 5.♗e2, 5.♘f3 or 5.f3 – in any event, Black would play 5...d6, transposing to a well-known variation of the King's Indian Defence.

5...♘e8 6.f4

The parade goes on. But look at the potential threats to the white centre. The pawn on c4 is already unable to protect its d4-colleague from c3, which means that if Black plays ...d7-d6 and ...c7-c5, the white centre is incapable of being supported by pawns, whilst in a piece battle, Black outstrips his opponent in development.

6...d6 7.♗e3

7.♘f3 dxe5 8.fxe5?! (stronger is 8.♘xe5) 8...♗g4 9.♗e2 c5 10.♗f4 cxd4 11.♖xd4 ♘c6 12.♖xd8? (12.♖e3 ♖a5 13.0-0 ♗xf3 14.♗xf3 ♘xe5 15.♗xb7 ♘xc4 16.♖xe7 ♖d8, Black's chances are superior) 12...♖xd8+ Schoen-Fischer, San Francisco 1957.



**7...c5! 8.dxc5 ♘c6 9.cxd6 exd6
10.♘e4?!**

After the developing move 10.♘f3, there follows 10...♗e6 11.♖b3 (better is 11.♗e2) 11...dxe5 12.♖xb7 ♖c8

13.fxe5 ♖xe5 14.♗xe5 ♙xe5 15.♖e4 ♖f6 16.♞d1 ♗d6 17.♖f3 ♙xc3+ 18.bxc3 ♖xc3+ 19.♕f2, Kobryn-Wojciechowski, Email 2008. Here, the strongest move appears to be 19...♗f5 20.♙f4 ♖b2+ 21.♞d2 ♖b6+ 22.♙e3 ♖b1+.

10...♙f5 11.♗g3?

Black is also better after 11.♗xd6 ♗xd6 12.♖xd6 ♖xd6 13.exd6 ♙xb2 14.♞d1 ♗b4!+.

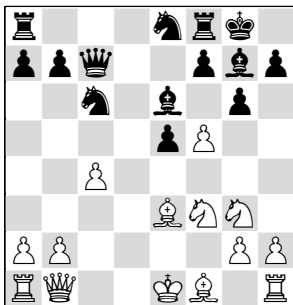
11...♙e6 12.♗f3 ♖c7

Maybe even stronger was 12...dxe5! 13.♖xd8 ♞xd8 14.♙c5 exf4 15.♗e4 ♙f5 16.♗c3 (16.♙xf8 ♙xf8 17.♗c3 ♗b4 18.♞d1 ♗c2+ 19.♕e2 ♞c8 20.b3 ♗f6+, and it becomes very hot for the white king in the centre) 16...♙xc3+ 17.bxc3 ♗f6 18.♙xf8 ♕xf8 19.♞c1 ♞e8+ 20.♕f2 ♞e3 21.♕g1 ♗e4+.

13.♖b1

After 13.f5 gxf5 14.♙d3 ♗xe5 15.♗xe5 f4!, Black saves a tempo: 16.♙xf4 dxe5 17.♙d2 f5, and White has a very dangerous position.

13...dxe5 14.f5



14...e4!

This pawn move is not only tactically justified, but also opens lines for all the black pieces.

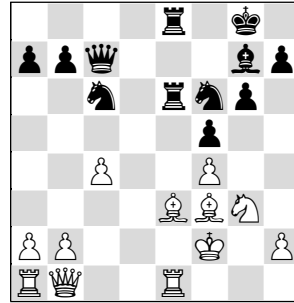
15.fxe6

No better is 15.♖xe4 gxf5!, with the idea 16.♗xf5? ♖a5+.

15...exf3 16.gxf3 f5! 17.f4 ♗f6 18.♙e2 ♞fe8 19.♕f2 ♞xe6

White's centre has been destroyed and the black pieces dominate the board.

20.♞e1 ♞ae8 21.♙f3



21...♞xe3!

A simple but beautiful combination by the 11th World Champion.

22.♞xe3 ♞xe3 23.♕xe3 ♖xf4+!!

White resigned.

32

Valentina Gunina

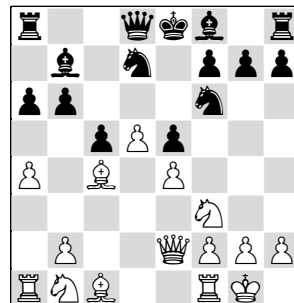
Joanna Majdan

Halkidiki Ech tt W 2011 (6)

2514

2386

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♗f3 ♗f6 4.e3 e6 5.♙xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♗bd7?! 8.♖e2 b6? 9.e4 ♙b7 10.d5 e5



There is nothing special about the opening. It is simply a class player quickly getting a large positional advantage. Normally, in such structures, for Black to have any counterplay, the white pawn is on a2 and the black ones on b5 and c4. Then, the dark-squared bishop can cement the d6-square, the knight on d7 can come to c5, and the light-squared bishop can go to d7 and operate on both flanks. In this example, though, the bishop is terrible on b7 and all of Black's pieces are terribly passive. She also lacks space and White is ahead in development. No doubt understanding all of these plusses in her position, Valentina Gunina decided it was time to give mate, and 'forgot' about the development of her queenside.

11. ♖h4?!

But what about the knight on b1? White has two good set-ups at her disposal.

The first is 11. ♖bd2, with the idea of ♗c4-d3 and ♘d2-c4. Black has no 'civilised' way to defend the e5-pawn and the bishop on d6 will have to remain under attack from the white knight. Later, there will most probably come a strong ♗f3-h4, with the threat of ♗h4-f5 and f2-f4, and in some cases one can see the unhurried b2-b3 and ♗c1-b2, strengthening the pressure on e5.

The second logical possibility is 11. ♖c3. Depending on Black's play, White can later choose between a direct attack, involving ♗f3-h4 and sharp play along the f-file, or continuing in more positional vein,

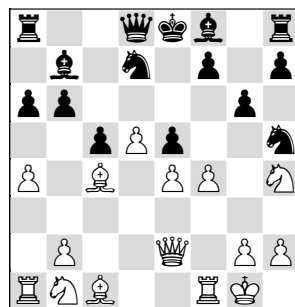
with ♗c4-d3, ♗f3-d2-c4, and then f2-f4.

11...g6 12.f4

It was not too late to correct the mistake at the previous move, by playing the developing move 12. ♖c3. After 12... ♗d6, (on 12... ♗g7, White can go over to the plan with the advance of the d-pawn, although the knight on h4 is not so well placed: 13. ♖d1 0-0 14. ♗f3, followed by d5-d6 – White retains the advantage) 13. ♗h6 ♗f8 14. ♗e3 ♗d6 15. ♗f3, going over to the plan ♗f3-d2, ♗c4-d3 and ♘d2-c4.

12... ♗h5

Black also has another possibility – 12...exf4 13. ♗xf4 ♗h5, with counterplay.



13. ♗f5?

But this is already a serious mistake. From f5, the knight attacks nothing, and is itself under attack from the pawn on g6, which is not a key pawn in Black's defensive barriers and can very well move from its square to take the unfortunate knight.

The most important factor in assessing the position is control of the square e5. White could fight for this, whilst also moving her knight from under attack: 13. ♗f3!. Now, 13...exf4 can be refuted, although

only by exceptionally accurate play: (on 13...♔d6 or 13...♔g7, strong is 14.f5!, seizing yet more space: 13...♖xf4 14.♗xf4 exf4 15.e5 ♗g7 16.♖c3 0-0 17.e6 ♗e8 18.♗ad1, with a strong initiative) 14.e5 ♗g7 15.♖c3 0-0 16.e6 ♗e8 17.g4! fxe6 (otherwise Black is just a piece down, without getting sufficient compensation for it) 18.dxe6 ♖h8 19.♖d5! (19.gxh5 ♗d4+ 20.♖h1 ♖e5, with unclear complications) 19...♖df6 (also bad is 19...b5 20.axb5 axb5 21.♗xa8 ♗xa8 22.♗xb5) 20.♖e5 ♗b8 21.♖f7+ ♖g8 22.♖xf4 – the white king is exposed, but Black's is even worse.

13...♖xf4 14.♗xf4 exf4

A piece is lost and the attack comes to nothing, as the white queenside is not developed.

15.e5

Or 15.♗xf4 ♗g5, also taking a knight.

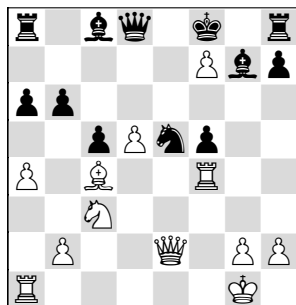
15...gxh5 16.♖c3 ♗g7

Also possible is 16...♗g5 17.e6 fxe6 18.♗xe6+ ♖d8.

17.e6 ♖e5 18.exf7+ ♖f8

It is safer for the king not to come into the daylight, although this is also possible: 18...♖xf7 19.♗xf4 ♗e8 20.d6+ ♖g6, with an easy win.

19.♗xf4 ♗c8



White has no open lines along which to attack and the extra piece gradually tells.

20.♗e1 ♗a7

She also wins after 20...♖xf7 21.d6 ♖xd6, but Black plays as pragmatically as possible, avoiding unnecessary opening of lines, and consolidating her extra piece.

21.d6 h5!

Now, the king's rook gets the square h6.

22.♗f3 ♖xf7 23.♖d5 ♖xd6 24.♖f4 ♗h6 25.♗g3 ♗d4+ 26.♖h1 ♗g7 27.♗xg7 ♖xg7 28.♖xh5+ ♖h8 29.♗d5 ♖e4 30.♗xe4 fxe4 31.♗f1 ♗g8 32.h3 ♗e6 33.♖f4 ♗c4 34.♖g6+ ♗xg6 35.♗h5+ ♖g7 36.♗f4 e3

White resigned.

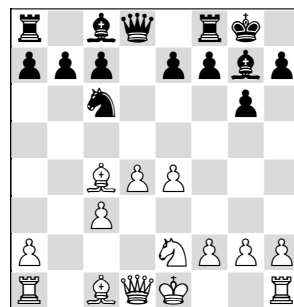
33

Boris Spassky

Leonid Stein

Moscow ch-URS playoff 1964 (1)

1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 g6 3.♖c3 d5 4.cxd5 ♖xd5 5.e4 ♖xc3 6.bxc3 ♗g7 7.♗c4 0-0 8.♖e2 ♖c6



9.h4

The centre is still not by any means secure, but White embarks on a flank attack – very risky!

9...♖a5 10.♗b3 c5!

Black begins to attack the strong-looking white pawn centre.

11.h5 ♘xb3 12.axb3 cxd4 13.cxd4 ♙d7! 14.hxg6 hxg6! 15.♖d3

Other moves also do not provide any great cause for optimism:

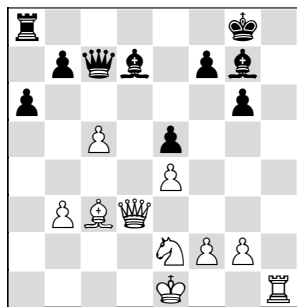
15.♙e3!? ♖b6 16.f3 ♙b5 17.♗f2 ♙xe2 18.♗xe2 ♜fd8.

15.♙h6?! ♙xh6 16.♞xh6 ♖g7 17.♞h1 ♞h8, and Black is first to occupy the h-file.

15...♖b6! 16.♙d2?!

Too slow. Stronger is 16.♖g3!, and White has chances of maintaining the balance: 16...f5 (also interesting is 16...♞fc8!? 17.♖h4 ♞xc1+! 18.♞xc1 ♖b4+ 19.♗f1 (but not 19.♞c3? ♞c8 20.♞h3 ♞xc3 21.♞xc3 ♙xd4—) 19...♙b5 20.♖h7+ ♗f8 21.♖h3 ♖d2 22.♞c8+ ♙e8 23.♞c1 ♙b5) 17.♙h6 fxe4 18.♙xg7 ♗xg7 19.♖h2 ♞h8.

16...♞fc8 17.♞a5 a6 18.♞c5 ♞xc5 19.dxc5 ♖c7 20.♙c3 e5



As a result of his flank operation, White has lost time. His centre is destroyed and Black has the two bishops. The situation is a complete fiasco for White.

21.b4 ♞d8

21...♙b5 22.♖e3 ♙d8.

22.♖g3

Hastening the defeat.

But even after 22.0-0 ♙b5 23.♖e3 ♖c6, Black is strategically winning.

22...♙b5 23.f4 ♖d7 24.♗f2 ♙xe2 25.♗xe2 a5! 26.♗f2 axb4 27.♙xe5 ♙xe5 28.fxe5 ♖d4+ 29.♗f3 ♖d3+ 30.♗f4 ♖d2+ 31.♗g4 ♞d4! 32.♞f1 ♞xe4+ 33.♗h3 ♖h6+ 0-1

34

Baadur Jobava

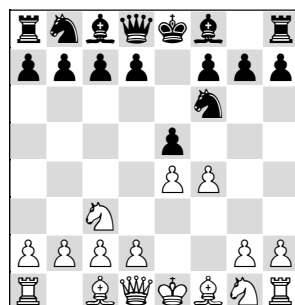
2695

Shakhriyar Mamedyarov

2757

Warsaw Ech tt 2013 (6)

1.e4 e5 2.♘c3 ♘f6 3.f4?!



Although well known to theory, this move is already experimental and objectively weak. 3.f4 is an attempt to exert pressure on the dark squares, but the early development of the knight to c3 does not help with this. Despite its outward activity, in reality White loses all chances of the initiative and, indeed, soon he is the one who is likely to find himself on the defending side.

In the opening, one should develop, whilst at the same time exerting pressure on the centre. In this case, White pursues activity, but slows up the development of his pieces – his bishops in particular suffer, as they have not yet come to active positions.

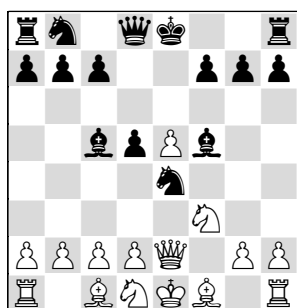
3...d5 4.fxe5 ♘xe4 5.♟f3 ♕c5!

A splendid idea, although one containing some degree of risk – Black places his pieces as actively as possible, but takes away the retreat square for his knight. Given White's initial moves, this is something he can permit himself.

A well-known option is the modest 5...♕e7 – this leads to a roughly equal game for Black, with no problems, e.g., 6.♖e2 (6.d3 ♘xc3 7.bxc3 0-0 8.d4 f6 9.♕d3 fxe5 10.♘xe5 ♘d7 – the doubled pawns give Black a slight advantage) 6...f5! (a double-edged game results from 6...♘xc3 7.dxc3! 0-0 8.♕f4, followed by queenside castling) 7.d3 ♘xc3 8.bxc3 0-0. Black wants to play ...c7-c5, ...♖b8-c6 and ...♕c8-e6, developing play on the queenside. His chances are in no way inferior.

6.♖e2 ♕f5

Interesting is 6...♘f2, but Black is following different tactics – he is mobilising his pieces!

7.♘d1

Covering the square f2 and intending with his next move to drive away the black knight. But the latter is not thinking of moving away!

7...♘c6!?

Of course, he could have moved the knight out of danger with 7...♕b6 8.d3 ♘c5, with a good game, but Black wants more!

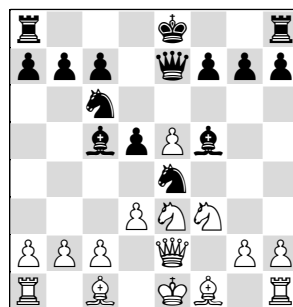
8.d3 ♖e7

8...♕g4 9.dxe4 ♘d4 10.♕g5 ♖xg5 11.♖b5+ ♘xb5 12.♕xb5+ c6 leads to a double-edged endgame.

9.♘e3?

Out of nine moves, White has made two with his f-pawn, put his pawn passively on d3, played the move ♖d1-e2, which blocks up his development, and moved his queen's knight three times, just to end up on a bad square.

It was vital instead to develop with 9.♕e3 0-0-0 10.dxe4 ♕xe4 11.♕xc5 ♖xc5 12.♖e3, when Black has numerous attacking possibilities, but White can defend, and his bishops are finally ready to leave their initial positions.

**9...♕e6**

A clear advantage results from 9...♕e3 10.♖xe3 ♖b4+ 11.♔d1 d4 12.♖e1 ♖xe1+ 13.♔xe1 ♘c5 – the pawn on e5 is cut off from its camp.

10.c3

Attempting to cover the weak squares, but this costs yet another

tempo, and Black responds by continuing to mobilise his forces.

10.dxe4 dxe4 11.♘d2 0-0-0 12.♗xe4 ♖h4+ 13.♗f2 ♗xe5 14.g3 ♖b4+ 15.c3 ♖a5 16.♙g2 (16.♗fd1 ♙b3 17.♙h3+ ♙b8 18.0-0 ♙c4—, with a decisive attack) 16...♙xe3 17.♖xe3 ♙c4— White cannot evacuate his king form the centre.

10...0-0-0 11.d4 ♙b6

Also strong was the resolute 11...♙xd4 12.cxd4 ♗xd4 13.♗xd4 ♖b4+ 14.♙d2 ♖xd4 15.0-0-0 ♖xe5—, but there is no need for such extreme measures – Black has a huge lead in development, without any sacrifices.

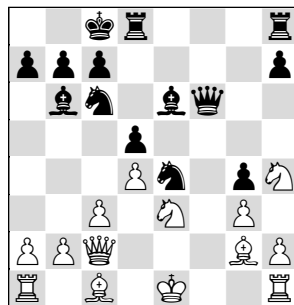
12.♖c2 g5!

Now, it gets bad for White's only well-placed piece – the threat is ...g5-g4.

13.g3

It was more tenacious to think about development, by playing 13.♙d3 g4 14.♙xe4 dxe4 15.♗d2 ♖h4+ (a very strong attack also results from 15...♙xd4 16.cxd4 ♗xd4 17.♖xe4 f5!→) 16.g3 ♖h5—, threatening blows on e5 and d4.

13...f6 14.exf6 ♖xf6 15.♙g2 g4 16.♗h4



16...♙xd4!

White's position collapses.

17.♖f1 ♖e5 18.cxd4 ♗xd4 19.♖a4 ♙b8 20.♙xe4 ♙d7 21.♖a5

He can only prolong the game by 21.♖d1 ♖xe4 (21...dxe4 22.♖f4— Black has many attacking ideas, but no forced win) 22.♖f4 ♖h1+ 23.♖f1 (23.♙f2 ♖xh2+ 24.♗eg2 ♗e6—) 23...♖xh2 24.♖xd4 ♖xg3+ 25.♙d1 ♖xh4 26.♙d2 ♖h5 – the better coordinated pieces and mass of pawns promise Black a decisive advantage.

21...♖xe4 22.♖f4 ♖h1+ 23.♙f2 ♗f3 24.♗xg4 b6 25.♖c3 ♗xh4 26.gxh4 ♙xg4 27.♙e3 ♖xh2+ 0-1

Additional material

Christiansen-Kasparov, Moscow 1982 – White's 11th move.

Part II

The Middlegame

Chapter 8

Calculation of variations and methods of taking decisions

It is especially in the middlegame that one encounters the questions of how to learn to calculate variations efficiently and effectively, and of the criteria necessary to permit the taking of correct decisions.

In textbooks, the favourite method is that involving identifying candidate moves, and then beginning to work through these, calculating as deeply as possible and gradually discarding the unsuccessful continuations. However, this approach uses a lot of energy, and leads to a situation where the player finds it impossible to maintain the same level of work. As a result, there follow blunders, or else, at a comparatively early stage, time-trouble and defeat. I think it is impossible to separate out calculation into an individual component, and work must instead be organised into a complex. Every time, many factors must be taken into account and nothing forgotten.

So, you have a position before you. Before beginning to calculate this or that variation, you have to assess the position. It must be said that many formulae have been offered by which one can take into account every possible factor in building one's assessment, but I (and not only I – Vladimir Kramnik confirmed my opinion, in a personal conversation with me) consider these approaches to be fundamentally flawed. There is no scientific way to balance up all the various factors – this has to be done intuitively, telling 'by eye' the importance or otherwise of specific factors. How does one do this? Only by accumulating practical and theoretical experience, so as to achieve accuracy in one's positional judgement. The greater your store of knowledge and the higher your class of play, the fewer variations you need to calculate.

In a real game, it is essential to use one's positional judgement to help one's calculations, by reducing the number of candidate moves from, say, 4-5 to 2-3, which is much more manageable. Having reduced a position to a sensible number of plausible moves, one can then set about concrete calculations, which is always going to be necessary, however good one's judgement. Having chosen 2-3 candidates, it makes little sense to analyse one of them really deeply. Rather, it is more efficient to jump to and from one to the other, spending a little time on each and returning to moves again. This is especially true, because tactical motifs often recur across similar variations, so having spotted an idea in one line, there is always a chance that it may be applicable in another too. Such a consideration of 2-3 continuations will usually enable you to choose the most promising continuation. Having done so, it is important to recheck the variations

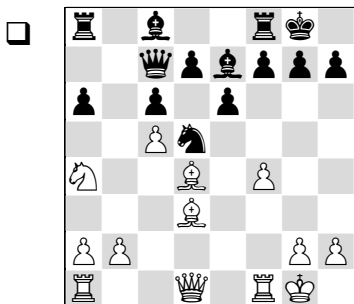
once or twice (depending on the complexity of the position), and to assess the position somewhat more deeply. If all is well, you should make the move without further unnecessary doubts, so as to avoid time-trouble.

35

Gennady Kuzmin

Evgeny Sveshnikov

Moscow ch-URS 1973 (14)



Let us try to follow in detail the assessments and calculations of the white player. White has strong positional compensation for the pawn, since Black is cramped and his pieces are passive and undeveloped. Advancing ...d7-d6 will give White a strong point on c5. So, the compensation seems adequate, even if White simply defends the pawn on f4. But undoubtedly, White needs also to assess his attacking chances, since so many of his pieces are pointing at the kingside.

We can quickly convince ourselves that we are not giving mate after the immediate 16. ♖xh7+ ♜xh7 17. ♚h5+ ♜g8 18. ♖xg7 ♜xg7 19. ♚g4+ ♜h7, and the queen has to give perpetual check, since after 20. ♜xf4 21. ♜xf4 f5. So, we note that we can force a draw, and then we move on.

16. ♖e5 looks sensible, attacking the queen with tempo. We can see that

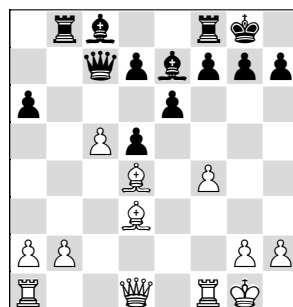
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after 16...d6, the blow on h7 gains in strength: 17. ♖xh7+ ♜xh7 18. ♚h5+ ♜g8 19. ♖xg7 ♜xg7 20. ♜f3. The pawn on d6 deprives the black queen of the diagonal needed for the defence, and after 20...♜xf4 21. ♜xf4 f5 22. ♜f3 dxc5 23. ♜g3+ ♚xg3 24. hxg3, White has the advantage – a queen is a queen, after all. Now, let us look at 16...♚d8. Here, White can start bringing up further reserves with 17. ♜f3. Black has many defensive resources – 17...g6, 17...f6 or 17...f5. There is no need to analyse these any further – in all cases, White has compensation for the pawn, but no more.

Returning to the initial position, the question occurs: can we include in the attack a piece which is not doing anything? Thus is born the idea of the tempo move

16. ♜b6!

If the rook moves, White exchanges a valuable defender and wins: 16...♜b8 17. ♜xd5 cxd5



analysis diagram

18. ♖xh7+ ♜xh7 19. ♚h5+ ♜g8 20. ♖xg7 ♜xg7 21. ♚g4+ ♜h8 22. ♜f3

♖xc5+ 23.♔h1 ♖c2 24.f5! (this move could be missed at a distance, but we can note that White is attacking 'with the draw in hand') 24...♗xf5 25.♜xf5 exf5 26.♗h3+ ♔g7 27.♗g3+, and taking on b8.

16...♟xb6

Black has few chances after 16...♟b7 – as well as the exchange deficit, he remains with a bad pawn structure. And now, everything is ready for the decisive combination:

17.♟xh7+! ♔xh7 18.♗h5+ ♔g8
19.♟xg7 ♔xg7 20.♗g4+ ♔h7
21.♜f3 ♟xc5+ 22.♔h1

Black resigned. Of course, if during the game the idea of 16.♟b6 occurs to you before 16.♟e5, you need not waste time on the latter idea, since you have already identified a winning move.

36

Viswanathan Anand

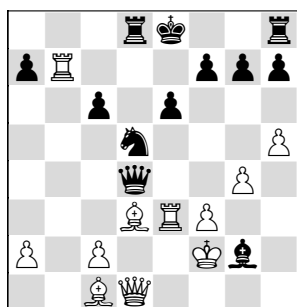
Joel Lautier

Biel 1997 (1)

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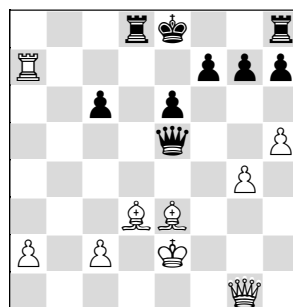
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White has the initiative. The bishop on g2 will probably fall for the pawn on f3, and thanks to the broken black pawn structure and strong white bishop on d3, White will have the advantage.

In the first instance, 20.♗e1 is tempting, defending e3. However, this move is not good – after 20...♟xf3 21.♔xf3 (it is not really worth examining in detail the zwischenzug 21.c3 – the bishop on d3 will be loose) 21...♗f4+ 22.♔g2 ♟xe3+, Black also takes on g4 and has too much.

So, let us consider another way of rounding up the ♟g2: 20.♗g1. The variation 20...♟xf3 21.♔xf3 ♗f4+ 22.♔e2 ♟xe3 23.♟xe3 ♗e5 24.♜xa7



analysis diagram

looks quite attractive for White, and we can take this as being promising. But can't we ignore the bishop and try to attack the black king, which is trapped in the centre? One is attracted by the idea of some sort of blow, followed by a move of the ♟d3, hoping to exploit the discovered attack on the black queen. Tempting is 20.♜xf7, but we can quickly see that here Black has many counterattacking ideas, and once we have seen 20...♟c3, we can end our consideration of this idea, as the black queen is defended and the rook on f7 attacked.

The next idea is: can we make 20.♟g6 effective? Unfortunately,

here Black has 20...♔xd1 21.♖xe6+ ♕f8 22.♙a3+ ♜e7, and the variation turns out in his favour. White is just missing something to complete his mating construction.

But there is also the move

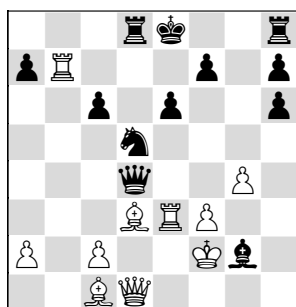
20.h6!

This doesn't spoil anything, because it creates a further weakness in the black position and the bishop on g2 still hangs. But what should we do after the simple

20...gxh6

or 20...g6 ?

We can return to the ideas 20.♖e1 and 20.♖g1, but it turns out that the insertion of the pawn moves does not bring White any benefits. But what if we play for mate?



21.♙g6!

On 20...g6, the same idea wins: 21.♙xg6 ♔xd1 22.♖xe6+ ♕f8 23.♖xf7+ ♕g8 24.♖g7+ ♕f8 25.♙a3+.

21...♜e7

The main line of White's calculations is as follows: 21...♔xd1 22.♖xe6+ ♕f8, and the bishop now comes in from the other side: 23.♙xh6+ ♕g8 24.♙xf7#.

22.♔xd4 ♖xd4 23.♖d3 ♖d8

24.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 25.♙d3

Black resigned.

37

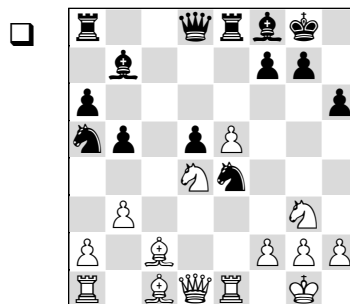
John Nunn

2615

Paul van der Sterren

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Germany Bundesliga 1995/96 (1)



The knight on a5 has very limited possibilities, and in view of the conflict in the centre, it is unlikely to have time to return via c6. In addition, White has a lead in development and the better pawn structure, so the advantage should be on his side.

First, we answer the question of whether we should look at taking the pawn with 19.♜xe4 dxe4 20.♙xe4. With the help of our positional judgement, it should be clear that after 20...♙xe4 21.♖xe4 ♜c6, Black has got rid of his bad knight, the ♜d4 is pinned, and the pawn on e5 attacked, whilst the white queenside is undeveloped. We need not waste any more time looking at this.

The knight at e4 is undoubtedly somewhat unpleasant for White, so we can rightly spend a bit of time looking at 19.f3 ♜xg3 20.hxg3. However, a well-educated player will note that although this is playable, the one weakness of the line is that f2-f3 weakens the diagonal a7-g1.

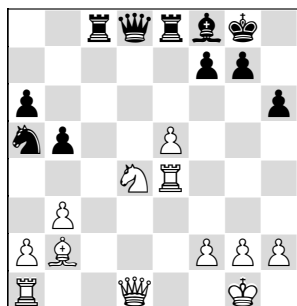
So, what do we decide? Having seen

19. ♖b2!

we need have no further doubts. This move is good for several reasons. It develops, and also strengthens a whole complex of dark squares, and also the bishop is now pointing at the less than entirely safe black king. There are potential possibilities of an attack down the diagonal, and we also create a threat now to take on e4 without weakening our own pawn structure.

It is not hard to see that 19... ♖xe5 loses to 20.f3 ♖b4 21.fxex4 ♖xe1 22. ♖xe1 – either of the white knights lands with decisive effect on f5.

The developing move 19... ♖c8 is bad because White takes the pawn in comfort after 20. ♖xe4 dxe4 21. ♖xe4 ♖xe4 22. ♖xe4,



analysis diagram

and Black has no compensation at all.

We can quickly assess 19... ♖b4 20. ♖e3 – Black has achieved nothing and e4 still hangs.

19... ♖b8

This attempt to attack the pawn on e5 looks almost like a sign of desperation. The queen is now far from the centre and also shuts in the rook. White does not need to

have seen such a move in advance, as such artificial play can always be refuted.

White has a large advantage, so it is completely unnecessary to analyse such complicated variations as those arising after 20. ♖g4 ♖xe5 21. ♖df5 ♖xb2 22. ♖xh6+ ♖h7 23. ♖xf7 – White's attack is obviously dangerous, but Black has many defensive resources.

White should quietly develop his initiative, exploiting the difference in the two sides' piece activity. The most promising move looks to be 20. ♖df5 – many tactical ideas are then in the air, involving play down the long diagonal. In addition, the move also attacks e4 again, whilst the black queen is cut off a long way from the centre

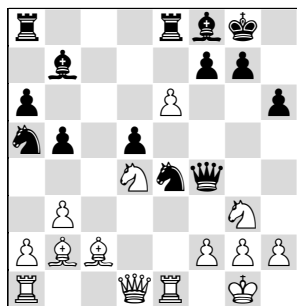
Another strong possibility is

20.e6

which is what was played. White breaks up the black king's pawn cover, opens the game and exploits the black queen's absence from the centre, and that of the knight on a5. Admittedly, in this case Black has a chance to include his queen in the defence. When you see more than one good possibility, it is important to choose the one you like best, and which accords best with your chess style and preferences. Thus, lovers of attack might prefer 20. ♖df5, whereas those who prefer clarity should find the text more attractive.

20... ♖f4!

The queen hurries to the defence of the weakened kingside. 20... ♖xe6 21. ♖xe4 dxe4 22. ♖xe4 leads to an obvious advantage for White.



21. ♖xe4

From a positional viewpoint, White does not want to shift the pawn from d5 to e4. Even if he wins the pawn, this may not be decisive. One should always pay attention to the possibility of eliminating the ♖e4 in another way, as the ♙b7 is hampered by the d5-pawn, whilst the ♙c2 can help in giving mate on h7.

Therefore, it was again worth considering 21.f3! ♖xg3 22.hxg3 ♖xg3. Thinking about this position reveals that after the tempting 23.♖d3 g6 White's initiative is very strong, but a convincing winning line is not obvious over the board (although it exists). If we compare this variation with the game line of taking on e4, we can see that the latter is more pragmatic, since White will probably win the e4-pawn, and although a win is not guaranteed, there are good chances.

But if we return to the position after 21.f3! ♖xg3 22.hxg3 ♖xg3, we can consider also 23.♖f5!. The check on c5 is not so terrible, and the threats against the black queen and the king down the opened diagonals become decisive. This is easy to convince oneself of, the only line worth calculating being 23...♙c5+ 24.♖h1 ♖g5 (24...♖f4 25.♙e5 ♖g5 26.f4+-) 25.f4!, which is not elementary, but all the same, is capable of being found. This means that if the white player is able and willing to find the move 23.♖f5, this is the path he should prefer, as it gives Black no chances.

21...dxe4 22.g3 ♖e5

More tenacious is 22...♖f6!, although after 23.♙xe4 fxe6 24.♖d2 e5 25.♖xa5 ♙xe4 26.♖xe4, White is closer to winning than Black is to drawing.

23. ♖g4

Creating a threat to capture on e4 and so forcing new concessions.

Also sufficient was 23.♖d2 b4 24.exf7+ ♖xf7 25.f3 ♙c5 26.♙xe4+-.

23...h5 24.♖e2 fxe6 25.♙xe4 ♖xe4 26.♖xe4 ♙xe4 27.♖xe4 ♖ac8 28.♖ae1 ♙b4 29.♖1e2 ♙c3 30.♙xc3 ♖xc3 31.♖xe6

Black resigned.

Chapter 9

The piece and pawn centre and the fight against it

The middlegame is a continuation of the opening, and so the importance of the centre and its occupation by pieces and pawns is just as great. If you have the centre, you should protect and secure it, and eventually set it in motion. If your opponent has it, it is essential to take action against it, and somehow locate its weak spot.

38

Suat Atalik

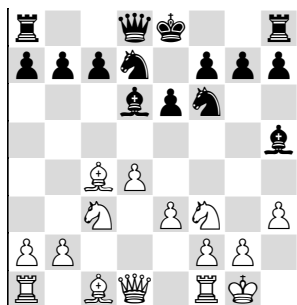
Gerlef Meins

Bad Wiessee 2003 (7)

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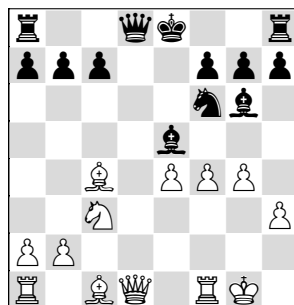
White has a mobile pawn centre. With its help, he begins to disturb the currently well-placed black pieces.

9.e4! e5 10.g4

A committal move. White exposes his king somewhat, but creates an active pawn mass.

10...g6 11.dxe5 fxe5 12.fxe5 e5 13.f4

The critical position. If Black does not find some antidote, the white pawns will sweep all before them. Black faces a difficult choice.



13...Wd4+

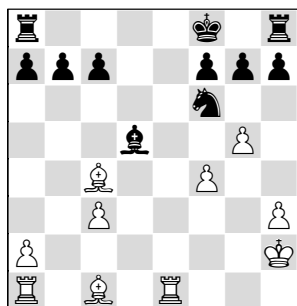
The alternative was the sharp 13...Wd4+ 14.h2 h5 (14...xc3 15.bxc3 Wxd1 16.Rxd1 Qxe4 17.g5 Qd7 18.Rc1 f5 19.gxf6 Qxf6 20.Wd3 0-0 (20...cf7 21.Rxe4±) 21.Qxe4 Qae8 22.Qa3 Qxe4 23.Qxf8 Qxf8 24.Rc3± Littlewood-Muir, Chester ch-UK 1979) 15.f5 (15.g5!?) 15...hgx4 16.fxg6 fxg6 17.h4! Wd6+ (17...Qe5+ 18.Qg2 Wxd1 19.Qxd1 Rxb4 20.Qf4±) 18.Qg2 Rxb4 (the threat is 19...Qg5) 19.Qf4 Wc5 20.Qd5! 0-0-0 (20...Wxc4 21.Rc1+—) 21.Rc1 Qxe4 22.b4!, with a decisive attack for White, Lipiridi-Rusakov, corr 1981.

14.Wxd4 Qxd4+ 15.h2 Qxc3 16.bxc3 Qxe4 17.g5 Qd5

17...Qd7 18.Rc1 transposes to the game Littlewood-Muir, quoted in the previous note.

18. ♖e1+ ♜f8

On 18...♜d7, White replies 19.♞d1! ♜c6 20.♞d4 b5 21.♙xb5+ ♜xb5 22.gxf6 ♜c6 23.fxc7 ♞he8. This position was seen in the game Flear-K.Norman, London 1979 (23...♞hg8 24.c4 ♙e6 25.f5 ♙xf5 26.♞f4 ♙e6 27.♙b2±; the pawn on g7 is very dangerous). Now, a large advantage results from 24.♞d2! ♞e3 25.♞f2 ♞xc3 26.♙b2±.



19. ♙b5! a6

Black does not manage to defend all his weaknesses after 19...♙e4 20.c4 ♘d6 21.cxd5 ♘xb5 22.♞b1 ♘d6 23.♙a3 b6 24.♞ec1±.

20. ♙a4 b5 21. ♙a3+ ♜g8 22.gxf6!

Now, Black is effectively playing without his rook on h8, and in addition, his king is in a mating net.

22...bxa4 23. ♞e5 c6?

Relatively best is 23...♙e6 24.f5 ♙d7 25.♞d1 ♙c6, although after 26.♞e7 h5 27.♞xc7 ♙e8 28.♞g1 ♞h7 29.c4±, Black is not to be envied.

24. ♞g1

He also wins with 24.c4 ♙xc4 25.fxc7 ♜xc7 26.♞g1+ ♜h6 27.f5 ♞ae8 (27...f6 28.♞e4+→) 28.♙c1+ ♜h5 29.♞g5+ ♜h4 30.♞g4+ ♜h5 31.♜g3 ♞xe5 32.♞h4#.

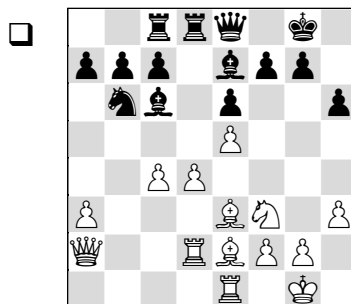
24...g6 25. ♞e7 ♞d8 26.f5 1-0

39

Konstantin Sakaev
Adrian Mikhalchishin
Yugoslavia tt 2002

2645
2530

*



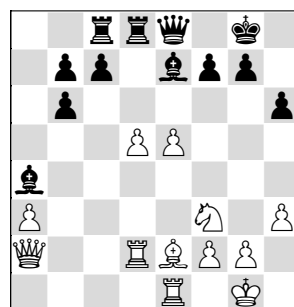
The white pieces have occupied ideal positions, and so it is time to set the centre in motion.

24.d5! exd5

On 24...♙a4, the strongest reply is 25.dxe6 fxe6 26.♘d4 – the e6-pawn becomes a chronic weakness.

25. ♙xb6 axb6 26.cxd5 ♙a4

Preferable is 26...♙b5, reducing the attacking potential of the white pieces by exchanges. Admittedly, after, for example, 27.♘d4 ♙xe2 28.♞exe2, White has a very strong position all the same.



27. ♙d3!

This move underlines the weakness of the light squares in the black camp. This is much stronger than, for example, the attempt to create

a passed pawn on the d-file. The bishop comes onto a diagonal, where it can start to work with full effectiveness.

27...♖a8 28.e6!

Continuing the chosen strategy.

28...♙d6

28...fxe6 29.♖xe6 ♙d6 30.♙de2 ♖xe6 31.♖xe6+–.

29.♘e5

A decisive attack was also promised by 29.♘h4, intending the jump to f5.

29...♙xe5 30.♖xe5 f6 31.♖e3 ♖e7

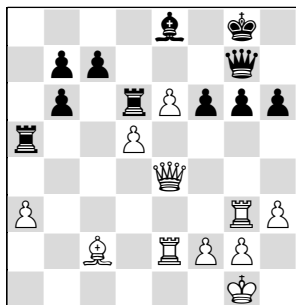
32.♖c4 ♙e8 33.♖e4 g6

On 33...g5, there is the excellent prophylactic move 34.♙c2!, preventing the rook coming to a4, and then h3-h4!, breaking up the defences of the black king.

34.♙g3 ♖g7 35.♙c2

An even more convincing win was 35.e7 ♙d6 (35...♙d7 36.♖e6+ ♙h8 37.♖xg6 ♙xg6 38.♖xd7+–; 35...♙dc8 36.♖e2+–, with the idea of ♙d3-f5) 36.♖xg6 ♙xg6 37.♖xg6+– – the e-pawn promotes.

35...♙d6 36.♙e2 ♖a5



37.♖xg6! ♙xg6 38.♖xg6 ♖xg6

39.♙xg6 ♖xa3 40.e7 ♖a8 41.e8♖+

♖xe8 42.♖xe8+ ♙g7 43.♙e4

Black resigned.

40

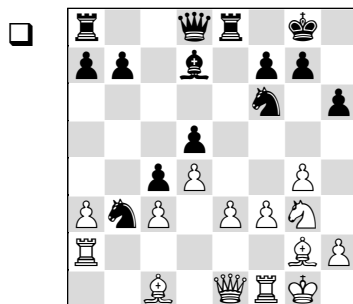
Garry Kasparov

Judit Polgar

Tilburg 1997 (2)

2820

2670



The black pieces are poorly coordinated, and the fact that she has relieved the pressure on the white centre by playing ...c5-c4 allows White to achieve a central breakthrough in the maximum comfort.

16.e4! dxe4 17.fxe4 ♘xg4

Such trivialities as the g4-pawn pale into insignificance alongside White's total domination of the centre.

18.♙f4

Now, the knight on b3 remains a mere spectator of White's growing attack.

18...♖h4

On 18...♖b6, with the idea of ...♘g4-e5, the strongest reply is the prophylactic 19.♙h1!.

19.h3 ♘f6 20.e5 ♙ad8

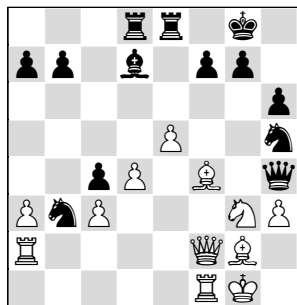
On 20...♙xh3, strong is 21.♙xh3 ♖xh3 22.♖h2 ♖e6 23.♙xh6! ♘g4 24.♙xg7! ♘xh2 25.♙xh2 – and White's attack assumes a decisive character.

21.♖f2

He also keeps a large advantage with 21.♙e3 ♘h7 22.♘e4 ♖xe1 23.♖xe1, but of course it is nicer to

keep the queens on, since White has attacking prospects on the kingside.

21...♖h5



22.♗xh6! ♖e7

More tenacious is 22...♗e6, after which there follows 23.♖xh5 ♗xh5 24.♗e3, gradually preparing the transfer of the major pieces to the g-file.

23.♖f5 ♗xf2+ 24.♖xf2 ♖e6 25.♗e3 ♗c6 26.♗f1 f6 27.♗xc4 ♗d5 28.♗e2 fxe5 29.♗xh5 exd4 30.♗g5 ♖d7 31.♖ae2 ♗e4 32.♖xd4 1-0

41

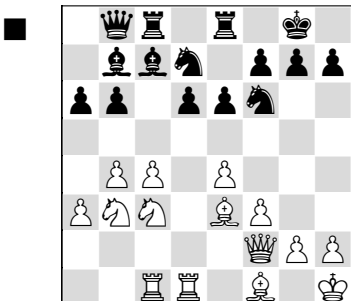
Anton Korobov

2705

Vasif Durarbeyli

2584

Baku 2012 (8)



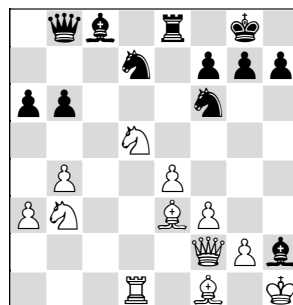
We have a typical Hedgehog structure. White controls the centre and more space, but Black is not bothered! In the Hedgehog structure,

his pieces are very harmoniously placed on the first three ranks, and if the opponent blinks for a moment, one of the standard counterblows ...b6-b5 or ...d6-d5 can occur. White must constantly monitor these possibilities. With his next move, Black bursts open the centre and sets a tactical conflagration going.

19...d5! 20.cxd5 exd5 21.♖xd5 ♗xh2

It is far from easy over the board to calculate the consequences of 21...♖xd5 22.exd5 ♗xh2 23.♖xc8 ♗xc8 24.f4, but now Black has 24...♖f6! 25.♗e2 ♖e4 26.♗f3 h5!. The key move (an interesting repetition arises after 26...♖f6 27.♗f2=). 27.♖xh2 ♗g4 28.♗f1 ♗xe2 29.♗xe2 ♖c3±.

22.♖xc8 ♗xc8



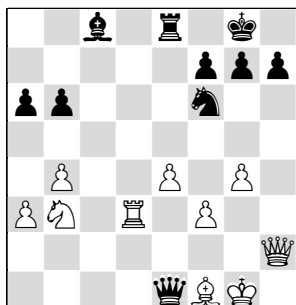
23.g4

The computer suggestion is 23.♖xf6+ ♖xf6 24.♗xb6 ♗g3 25.♗e3 ♗e5 26.♗c4 ♗h5+ 27.♖g1, with the promise of a minimal advantage, although this is unpleasant to defend for a human.

23...♖xd5 24.♖xd5 ♖f6 25.♖d3 ♗f4

Even stronger is 25...♗g3!.

26.♗xf4 ♗xf4 27.♗d2 ♗g3 28.♗h2 ♗e1 29.♖g1



Another critical position. The queen on e1 is very strong, but Black's other pieces are rather passive. Black finds a way to activate them.

The attack with the rook's pawn frees squares and opens lines for attack

29...h5! 30.gxh5

Bad is 30.g5 ♘h7 (30...♘e4? 31.fxe4 ♜xe4 32.♜d8+ ♔h7 33.♞xh5#) 31.♞f2 (31.♞xh5 ♞g3+♣) 31...♞xf2+ 32.♔xf2 ♘g5 33.♜d5 f6♣.

30...a5

Black plays all over the board! Having just sacrificed the h-pawn to activate his knight, now he frees the a6-square for his bishop! But White has a serious retort to Black's last move. Chess is not checkers and capturing is not obligatory.

Instead, Black can be recommended to play the unexpected 30...♘e4! 31.fxe4 ♜xe4, reaching the key position, in which White has many possibilities, but the strongest of them allows him only to hold equality:

A) 32.♜g3 ♜e3 33.♜xe3 ♞xe3+ 34.♞f2 ♞xb3 35.♞xb6 ♞g3+ 36.♔g2 ♔h3 37.♞c6 ♔xg2 38.♞xg2 ♞xa3 39.♞a8+ ♔h7 40.♞e4+ ♔h6 41.♞f4+ ♔xh5 42.♞xf7+ ♔h6♣; or 32.♘d2? ♜g4+ 33.♔h1 ♔b7+; or 32.♞c2? ♜g4+ 33.♔h2 ♞e5+ 34.♔h1 ♔b7+; or

B) 32.♜d4! ♞e5 (32...♜e3 33.♞f4+), and now:

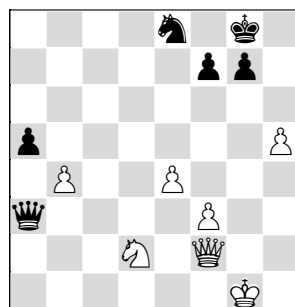
B1) 33.♜d8+ ♔h7 34.♞c2+ g6 35.hxg6+ ♔g7 36.♜d2 ♔h3 37.♞d3 ♜g5+ 38.♔h2 ♔xf1 39.♞c3+ ♞e5+ 40.♞xe5+ ♜xe5 41.gxf7 ♜h5+ 42.♔g1 ♔c4=;

B2) I have also not found a win after 33.♞h4 ♞e3+ 34.♔h2 ♜g5 35.♔g2 ♔b7 36.♜g4 (36.♔xb7?! ♞e2+ (36...♞g1+ 37.♔h3 ♞f1+=) 37.♔h3 ♜xh5♣) 36...♜xg4 37.♞xg4 ♔xg2. In this line, we get a curious draw carousel after 38.h6! g6 39.♞c8+ ♔h7 40.♞f8 ♞h3+ 41.♔g1 ♞h1+ 42.♔f2 ♞f1+ 43.♔g3 ♞f3+ 44.♔h2 ♞h3+=.

31.♞f2 ♞b1 32.♘d2 ♞a1 33.♞xb6 ♞e5 34.♜d8

34.♞c5!? ♞g3+ 35.♔g2 ♞h4 – Black has full compensation. The knight joins the attack via h5.

34...♞g5+ 35.♔g2 ♔h3 36.♜xe8+ ♘xe8 37.♞f2 ♔xg2 38.♞xg2 ♞e3+ 39.♞f2 ♞xa3



And now the desire to win overcame the objective features of the position.

40.b5?!

This move does not actually lose, but it poses problems only for White. It is clear that the b-pawn will be held up, but not so clear whether this will be true of the a-pawn.

40...♞b4 41.b6 a4

41...♘f6 42.h6 ♘d7 43.hxg7 ♞xb6=.

42. ♖c4

The computer helps us find a subtle positional draw: 42.e5!? (playing to limit Black's scope) 42...a3 43.♖e3 a2 44.♜b3 ♖xb3 45.♖xb3 a1♖+ 46.♔g2 ♖xe5 47.b7 ♖b8 48.♖a4 ♜c7 49.♖c6 ♖d8 50.♖b6 ♖b8 51.♖c6 ♔h7 52.♖e4+ ♔g8 53.♖c6=.

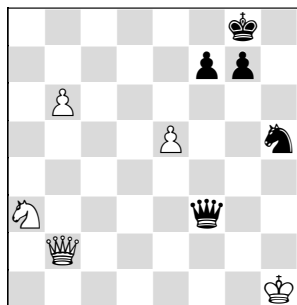
42... ♜f6

42...♖xc4 43.b7 ♖c7 44.♖a7 ♖g3+ 45.♔h1 ♖xf3+ 46.♔g1 ♖g3+ 47.♔f1 ♖f3+ 48.♔g1=.

43.e5 ♜xh5 44.♖b2 ♖e1+ 45.♔h2 a3!?

45...♖g3+ 46.♔h1 ♖xf3+ 47.♖g2=.

46. ♜xa3 ♖g3+ 47.♔h1 ♖xf3+



48. ♔g1??

A blunder. After 48.♔h2!, Black has nothing but perpetual check: 48...♖g3+ 49.♔h1 ♖h4+ 50.♔g1 ♜g3 51.♖c2=.

48... ♜g3 49. ♖g2

49.b7 ♖h1+ 50.♔f2 ♖h2+ 51.♔f3 ♖xb2+-.

49... ♖xa3 50.b7 ♖a7+ 51.♔h2

51.♖f2 ♜e2+ 52.♔f1 ♖xb7 53.♖xe2 ♖h1+ 54.♔f2 ♖h2+-+.

51... ♜f5 52. ♖c6 ♖f2+ 53. ♖g2 ♖b6 54. ♖c2 ♖xb7?

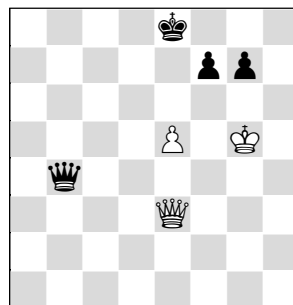
He wins at once with 54...g6! 55.♖c8+ ♔g7 56.♔g2 ♜e7 57.♖a8 ♜c6 58.♖c8 g5!. It turns out that the queen and knight represent such a powerful force against the white king that White is

not able to obtain the desired drawn queen ending of 2 pawns vs 1: 59.♔h2 (59.♔f1 ♖b5+ 60.♔f2 ♖b2+ 61.♔f1 ♜d4+-) 59...♜e7 60.♖a8 ♖f2+-+.

55. ♖xf5 ♖c6 56. ♔g3 ♔f8 57. ♖g5 ♖d5 58. ♖e3 ♔e8 59. ♔f4

59.♖c3!?

59... ♖c4+ 60. ♔g5 ♔e7 61. ♖a3+ ♔e8 62. ♖e3 ♖b4



The ending is probably winning for Black, but he would need to demonstrate some technique. But now there followed

63. ♔f5??

which sharply simplifies the task. The only chance was 63.♖e2!.

63... ♖h4

White resigned, because of 64...g6#.

42

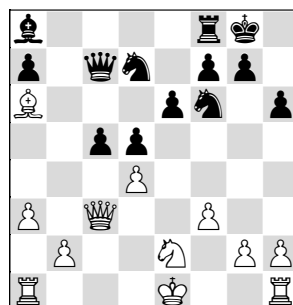
Joel Lautier

Anatoly Karpov

Linares 1995 (8)

2655

2765



For what has Black sacrificed the exchange? A mobile pawn centre!

19...e5! 20.♙d3

Black also gets a decisive attack after 20.dxe5 d4! 21.♖d2 ♜xe5 22.0-0 ♗b6 23.♙d3 c4 24.♙xc4 d3 25.♖f2 ♜d8.

The most tenacious was 20.dxc5!, so as to keep the e-file closed, along which Black is prepared for a decisive attack. Admittedly, after 20...d4 21.♖d2 ♜xc5 22.♖c1 ♗b6 23.♙c4 ♜d5 24.b4 ♜e6 25.♙xd5 ♙xd5 26.♜g3 ♗a6 Black's advantage is unarguable – his central position is very strong, whilst White has trouble castling.

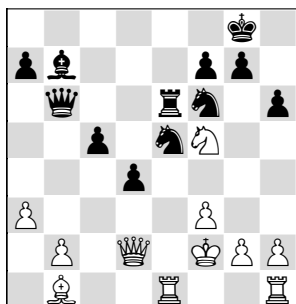
20...exd4 21.♜xd4 ♜e8+ 22.♚f1 ♗b6 23.♜f5 d4 24.♖d2 ♜e5 25.♜e1 ♜e6

White's pieces lack coordination and his rook on h1 is completely cut off. Black can realise his positional advantage in various ways, e.g. 25...♙c6 26.♙b1 ♙b5+ 27.♜g1 d3 followed by ...c5-c4.

26.♙b1 ♙b7

26...♖b3 27.♖c2 ♖b5+, followed by ...d4-d3.

27.♜f2



27...d3!

Black includes the queen in the attack, and shuts out the ♙b1.

28.♜hf1+ c4 29.♜g3 ♜h5+ 30.♜h3 ♜g6 31.g3 ♙c8 32.♜e4 ♗c5 33.g4 ♜gf4+ 34.♜xf4 ♜e2 35.♗c1 ♜xf4+ 36.♗xf4 ♙xf5 37.gxf5

37.♗xf5 ♗c7 38.♜h1 ♜e5 39.♗f4 ♜h5+ 40.♜g3 ♜h3+–+.

37...♜xb2 38.♜e1 ♗f2 39.♗g3 ♗xg3+ 40.hxg3 ♜xb1

White resigned.

43

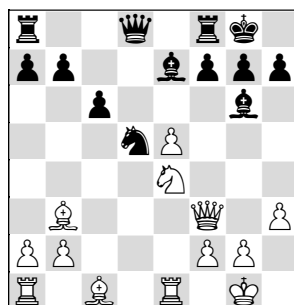
Anatoly Karpov

Jan Timman

Amsterdam 1991 (7)

2725

2630



White's pieces look more active and he also has some space advantage. White strengthened his piece and pawn centre with the move

16.♙f4!

It is not so often that one sees a bishop voluntarily offer itself for exchange by a knight, but here White has realised the subtleties of the position – the piece on d5 is not a mere knight, but an important element in preventing White developing play in various directions.

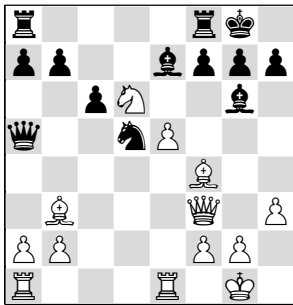
Of course, instead of the developing move, White could also have chosen 16.♜d1, strengthening the pressure on the d-file. The decision taken in the game is more pragmatic – the

chosen move is good, and Black may not see a subtle defence in this non-forcing line.

16... ♖a5

Black resists the temptation, and wrongly! 16... ♘xf4! 17. ♖xf4 ♖c7! 18. ♖ad1 ♗h8 19. ♘d6 ♖ad8, with the idea of ...f7-f6, leads to an inferior, but double-edged position.

17. ♘d6



Now, it is hard to find anything against White's growing pressure on the central lines.

17... ♕xd6

The passed pawn, supported by its pieces, decides the result of the game. Relatively best was to acknowledge the mistake on the previous move by 17... ♘xf4 18. ♖xf4 ♖c7 19. ♖ad1 ♖ad8, when he can still put up some resistance.

18. exd6 ♖fe8 19. ♖xe8+ ♖xe8

20. ♕xd5 cxd5 21. d7 ♖e7

21... ♖d8 22. ♖e3 f6 23. ♖e7+–.

22. ♖c1 ♖xd7 23. ♖c8+ ♖d8 24. b4!

A important zwischenzug, depriving Black of a check at e1.

24... ♖b6 25. ♕c7 ♖xc8 26. ♕xb6 axb6 27. ♖xd5

The queenside pawns are indefensible, so there is no chance of a fortress.

27... h6 28. ♖xb7 ♖c1+ 29. ♗h2 ♖c2

30. ♖xb6 ♖xa2 31. ♖d4 1-0

44

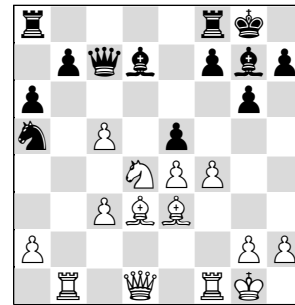
Konstantin Sakaev

Vladimir Belov

Krasnoyarsk ch-RUS 2003 (5)

2655

2553



On the board, we have a typical Grünfeld structure. The white centre has just been subjected to a blow, and he has to decide how to react.

16.f5!

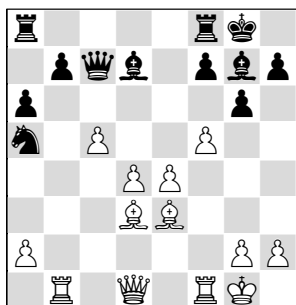
White sacrifices a knight, obtaining in return a powerful pawn group and also good attacking chances on the queenside. The sacrifice is of an intuitive character, as it is not realistic to calculate fully all of the many forcing variations here. There is also a pragmatic element here – it is easier for White to play the position than for Black, who has just suffered an unexpected blow. Mind you, for such a blow to be genuinely effective, rather than merely psychologically, it needs to be correct. In this concrete case, in order to maintain the balance, Black needs to find a decision that is far from obvious, which is extremely difficult in such a complicated position.

Black's idea is revealed by the line 16. fxe5 ♕xe5 17. ♕h6 (on 17. ♘f3, the reply 17... ♕g4 is good) 17... ♕xh2+

18.♖h1 ♕e5! 19.♗xf8 ♜xf8 – despite the exchange down, Black has full positional compensation.

Nor is it very attractive for White to consider the march of the knight via d4-e2-f4-d5, which just takes too much time: 16.♘e2 ♜ad8! 17.fxe5 ♕xe5 18.♘f4 (after 18.h3 ♕e6 19.♖c2 ♘c4 20.♕xc4 ♕xc4, White faces a battle for equality) 18...♕xf4! 19.♜xf4 ♕b5.

16...exd4 17.cxd4



17...♜fe8

A risky but possible alternative is 17...gxf5!?, breaking up the white centre, even at the cost of a marked weakening of the black king, when there are these possible variations: 18.exf5 and now:

A) 18...♜ae8! 19.f6 (interesting is 19.♖d2!?, with sufficient compensation for the piece) 19...♜xe3 20.♖h5 h6 21.♜f5 (equality results from 21.fxg7 ♖xg7 22.♜f6 ♖xf6 23.♖xh6+ ♖e7 24.♖xe3+ ♖d8 25.d5 ♜e8 26.♖g5+ ♖c8 27.c6 ♘xc6 28.dxc6 ♕xc6) 21...♖d8 22.fxg7 ♖xg7 23.♖g4+ ♖h8 24.♖f4 ♜e6 25.d5 ♜g6 26.♜xf7 ♜xf7 27.♖xf7 ♜g7 28.♖f2 – Black needs to defend accurately, because his king is weak;

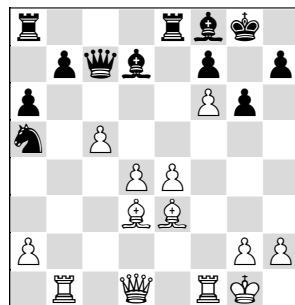
B) Black can also blockade the f5-pawn with 18...♕f6!?. The

position is very rich in possibilities, e.g., 19.d5 (or 19.♜f3 ♜fe8 20.♖h1 ♕c6 21.♜h3 ♜xe3 22.♜xe3 with an unclear struggle) 19...♖e5 20.♖f3 ♜fe8 21.♕f2, with compensation.

18.f6 ♕f8?!

This tempting retreat is a mistake, after which Black is balancing on the edge of the precipice.

Going into the corner with 18...♕h8! does not look very nice at all, because the bishop will remain there, shut in by the f6-pawn, for the rest of the game. However, this was the move he should have chosen. Firstly, White no longer has the idea of exchanging dark-squared bishops via h6, creating mating threats, and secondly, it is far from simple to hold together the white pawn centre. For now, White can play 19.♖e2 or 19.♜b6, supporting the centre, but in both cases, the battle retains a tense and unclear character.



19.♖c1!

Intending to give mate via h6. The move 19.♖d2, with the same idea, fails because of 19...♕b5 20.♕h6 ♕xc5! 21.dxc5 ♜ed8!, and the roles are reversed – Black becomes the attacking side.

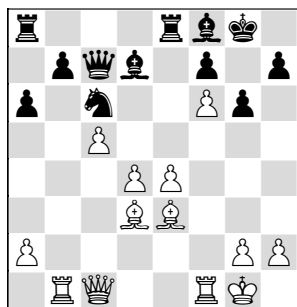
19...♘c6

Let us consider other continuations:

A) 19...♔h8 20.♙h6 ♙g4 (20...♙xh6 21.♖xh6 ♖g8 22.♗f4 g5 23.e5+–) 21.♙xf8 ♖xf8 22.♖h6 ♖g8 23.♗f4 ♗d7 24.e5 ♖ae8 (24...♘c6 25.♗xb7 ♖xb7 26.♗xg4) 25.h3 ♙h5 26.♗e1, followed by ♗h4;

B) 19...♙b5 20.♙xb5 axb5 21.♙h6 ♖e6 (on 21...♗xe4, there follows 22.♙xf8 ♙xf8 23.♖h6+ ♙e8 24.♗be1, with a decisive attack) 22.♙xf8 ♙xf8 23.♖h6+ ♙e8 24.♖xh7 ♘d8. White has a rich choice, with both the aggressive 25.d5, and a quiet, centre-strengthening continuation such as 25.♗fe1 or 25.♖h4, deserving attention.

Quiet moves / prophylaxis in the middle of an attack



20.♙h1!

The king steps away from possible checks, a necessity clearly demonstrated by the variation 20.♙h6 ♘xd4 21.♙xf8 ♖xf8 22.♖h6 ♘e6, and there is not 23.♙c4 because of 23...♖xc5.

20...h5

Freeing the square h7 for the king; there is no other defence to the threat of 21.♙h6.

21.♙f4!

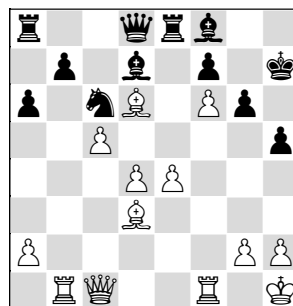
The dark-squared bishop enters the black position from the other side.

White gets nothing from 21.♙h6 ♙h7 22.♙xf8 ♖xf8 23.♖e3 ♖ad8.

21...♖d8

The 'active' 21...♖a5 is most effectively met by 22.♙d6 ♙xd6 23.cxd6 ♙h7 (23...♘xd4 24.♖h6 ♘e6 25.e5, and 26.♙g6) 24.♖xb7 ♗d8 25.♗f5!! ♖g8 26.♖g5, with the irresistible threat of e4-e5 and ♖g5xh5.

22.♙d6 ♙h7



23.♖e3

It is hard for Black to do anything about the mass of white pawns and pieces on the dark squares, behind which White can prepare a decisive attack.

Objectively, even stronger was 23.e5, and if 23...♘xd4, then 24.♗xb7. However, White was very reluctant to give the opponent a chance to break up his pawn centre.

23...♙xd6

On 23...♙h6, there would follow the simple 24.♖f2, followed by 25.e4-e5.

24.cxd6 ♙c8?

Passive, and the result of an oversight.

A) White wins beautifully in the event of 24...b5 25.e5 ♖b6 26.♖g5 ♙g4 27.♗f4 ♖h8 28.♗xg4! hxg4 29.e6!;

B) The most tenacious is 24...♖b8 25.e5 ♖xd6 and now:

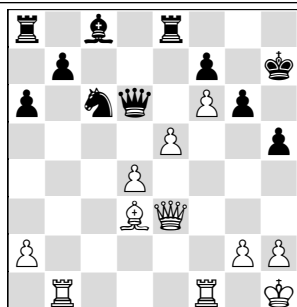
B1) 26.♖xb7 ♖ad8 27.♗f3 ♘xe5 28.♗xh5+ ♔g8 29.♗h6 ♗f8 30.♗xf8+ ♔xf8 31.dxe5 ♖c8 32.♖b3 ♖xe5 33.♔g1 – White's winning chances are about the same as Black's chances of drawing;

B2) a similar endgame arises after 26.♗f3 ♘xe5 27.♗xh5+ ♔g8 28.dxe5 ♖xe5 29.♗h6 ♗f8;

B21) on 30.♗h4 ♖h5 (the threat was 31.♖g6) 31.♗g3, there is 31...♗b8! (31...♖h6 32.♖fe1! (after the tempting 32.♖xb7, there is the unexpected defensive resource 32...♖h3!) 32...♖c6 33.♖e7, and Black is in trouble) 32.♖f4 g5, with counterplay;

B22) 30.♗xf8+ ♔xf8 31.♖xb7 ♖c6. 25.e5 ♖xd6

Breaking up the king's pawn protection



26.♖xg6+!

A simple deciding tactic.

26...fxg6 27.f7 ♗e7 28.fxe8 ♗xe8 29.♖f6

Black lacks coordination among his pieces, so a mating attack is unavoidable.

29...♗e7

On 29...♔g7 there could follow, for example, 30.♖bf1 ♖e6 31.d5! ♖xd5 32.e6.

30.♖bf1 ♖e6 31.♗e4 ♖f5

Or 31...♖g8 32.d5.

32.♖1xf5 gxf5 33.♗xf5+ ♔g8 34.♖g6+ 1-0

45

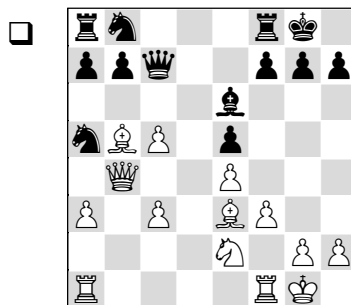
Viswanathan Anand

2810

Wang Hao

2731

Wijk aan Zee 2011 (4)



The game has only just left the opening stage, and we can draw some preliminary conclusions. White has a greater concentration of pawns and pieces in the centre, but his coordination is not ideal – the ♘e2 has limited scope, the weakness of c4 is noticeable, and the doubled pawns may soon become an object of attack. For these reasons, such positions have for a long time been considered fine for Black, but a brilliant idea from the World Champion forced a complete re-evaluation of such positions.

16.♘d4!!

Not moving the knight when it is attacked (as in the previous example) is striking enough, but actually putting it en prise is even more so. Just magnificent! White's assessment is roughly as follows: Black will have to return the piece (probably on d5, for a pair of central pawns), and then

the two bishops and the weakness of the b7-pawn will start to tell.

16...exd4 17.cxd4 ♖bc6 18.♗c3
♜e7

Black is already prepared to return the piece on the square d5, but White can afford not to hurry, and to strengthen his position to the maximum, behind the cover of his pawn centre.

19.♞fd1 ♞ad8 20.♙f2 a6

It was more tenacious at least to take some sort of action against the white centre with 20...b6 or 20...f5.

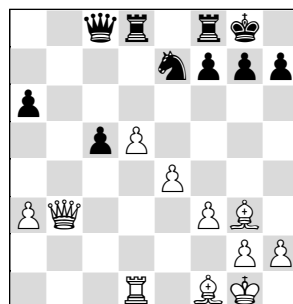
21.♙g3 ♗c8 22.♙f1 b6 23.♞ab1

Due to the hanging position of the knight on a5, Black has no chances.

23...♜b3 24.♞xb3

Also winning is d5 ♜xc5 25.dxe6 – Black loses his pawns.

24...♙xb3 25.♗xb3 bxc5 26.d5



White's central dominance is absolute.

26...♜g6 27.♗b6 f5 28.♙xa6
♗d7 29.♙b5 ♗f7 30.exf5 ♗xf5
31.♗xc5 ♞c8 32.♗d4 ♞fd8 33.a4

Black resigned.

Additional material

Botvinnik-Euwe, The Hague-Moscow Wch (match-tournament) 1948

Bronstein-Boleslavsky, Moscow 1950

Bronstein-Ljubojevic, Petropolis 1973

Euwe-Smyslov, The Hague-Moscow Wch (match-tournament) 1948

Geller-Smyslov, Zurich 1953

Geller-Smyslov, Amsterdam 1956

Botvinnik-Capablanca, Amsterdam 1938

Botvinnik-Keres, Moscow 1952

Denker-Botvinnik, USA-USSR 1945

Tal-Ghitescu, Miskolc 1963

Kasparov-Timman, Hilversum (match/4) 1985

Kasparov-Timman, Hilversum (match/6) 1985

Kasparov-Andersson, Belfort 1988

Jussupow-Kasparov, Barcelona 1989

Karpov-Kasparov, Amsterdam 1988

Karpov-Kasparov, Belfort 1988

Kasparov-Karpov, Seville Wch (match/2) 1987

Kasparov-Karpov, Seville Wch (match/4) 1987

Karpov-Kasparov, Seville Wch (match/5) 1987

Karpov-Kasparov, Seville Wch (match/7) 1987

Karpov-Kasparov, Seville Wch (match/9) 1987

Karpov-Kasparov, Lyon Wch (match/17) 1990

Chapter 10

Coordination and piece activity

There are certain pairs of pieces which are traditionally very strong together. For example, the pairing of queen and knight is very dangerous in an attack on the king, whilst two bishops usually complement each other superbly. On the other hand, if you have individual units on the board, which are cut off from the rest of their forces and contribute nothing to the battle for the key objectives, they can be forgotten about as far as cooperation is concerned. On the contrary, to work harmoniously with one another, pieces need to be actively placed and pointing the right way, complementing each other.

46

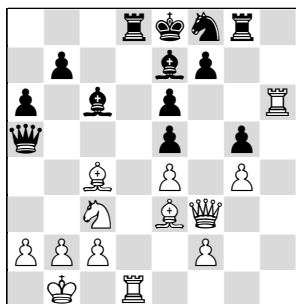
Michael Adams

Ivan Sokolov

Sarajevo 1999 (3)

2716

2624



The queen on a5 is a long way from the centre, the knight on f8 is passive, and the rook on g8 is in a simply dreadful position. With the aid of a temporary sacrifice, White goes over to the attack.

23. ♖d5!

The knight cannot be tolerated here, but after its capture, Black finally loses what remains of his piece coordination and his light squares are irretrievably weakened.

23... exd5 24. exd5 ♖b4

More tenacious is 24... ♗b5, although after 25. ♗xb5+ ♖xb5 26. ♖b6 e4 27. ♖xe4 ♖e2 28. ♖c1 ♖g6 29. ♖xb7 ♖d7

30. a3, White retains a domination, which should lead to victory.

25. dxc6

Also winning is 25. ♗b3.

25... ♖xd1+

Nothing is changed after 25... ♖xc4 26. ♖xd8+ ♗xd8 27. cxb7 ♖d7 28. b3.

26. ♖xd1 ♖xc4 27. b3!

A useful zwischenzug, driving the queen from her good position, with tempo.

27... ♖b4 28. a3 ♖a5 29. cxb7 ♖d7

30. ♖c6 ♗d8 31. ♖c8 ♖e7 32. ♗c5+

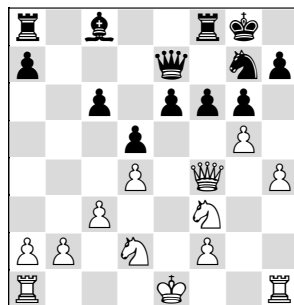
Black resigned.

47

Luc Winants

Konstantin Sakaev

Rethymnon tt 2003 (1)

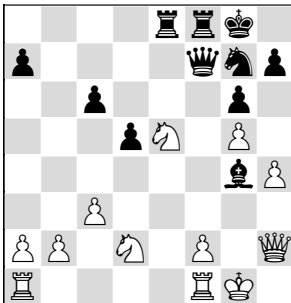


It is obvious even to a rank beginner that Black must not now play 16... f5 – his light-squared bishop would be too bad. But the banal opening of the f-file also brings Black no dividends, because the f-file by itself is too little with which to develop the initiative. Furthermore, in this case, the bishop would have to come out via a6. Therefore, Black sacrifices a pawn.

16...e5! 17.dxe5 fxe5 18.♖xe5 ♖f7

Of course, White defends against the threat to his queen, but just look at the black bishop now! And immediately behind it, the black rook will join the attack.

19.♖h2 ♘g4 20.♝e5 ♜ae8 21.0-0



21...♜xe5! 22.♖xe5 ♘h3

The position has simplified somewhat, but White's position is still hard to defend. He has many holes in his kingside, which the black knight can exploit.

23.♖h2 ♘xf1 24.♝xf1

On 24.♜xf1, there also follows 24...♝h5, heading to f4.

24...♝h5 25.♝e3 ♖e6

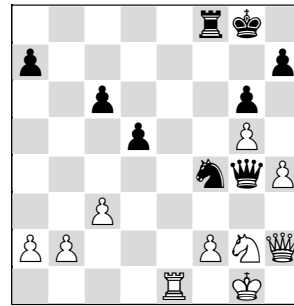
From here, the queen controls many squares, intending in the future to come closer to the white king, via g4 or e4. At the same time, the road is opened for the black rook.

26.♝g2

The attempt to cover f4 in such artificial style does not help.

The only possible hope of defending is the completely impossible-to-find idea 26.♜e1 ♝f4 27.♖g3!!.. Black then has nothing decisive, e.g., 27...♝h3+ (after 27... c5, White has 28.♖g4! ♖f7 29.♜d1) 28.♝h2 ♝xf2 29.♜e2 ♝d3 (and here, after 29...♝e4, he is saved by 30.♝g4!) 30.♜g2. Having activated his knight via g4, White should hold the draw.

26...♖g4 27.♜e1 ♝f4



Black's small but well-coordinated force creates a decisive attack. The queen and knight working together are a powerful force! It is no coincidence that in many endgames, queen and knight prove stronger than queen and bishop, whereas a bishop on its own will often be stronger than a knight.

28.♜e3 ♖d1+ 29.♜e1

On 29.♝e1, Black wins with 29...♖d2, with numerous threats.

29...♖g4

Repeating moves to gain time before the time control is a typical pragmatic device, which should not be neglected! Of course, it makes particular sense when you have the

advantage and the opponent can do nothing.

30.♞e3 ♖d1+ 31.♞e1 ♜d2 32.♞f1 ♜e2+ 33.♞h1 ♜d3 34.♞e1

On 34.♜e3, there follows 34...♞e4+ 35.♜g2 ♞f3, setting up the threat of ...♜e2-g3+.

34...♞xf2 35.♞e5 ♞h3+ 36.♞h2 ♞g4 37.♞b8+ ♞f8 38.♞e5 ♞h3+ 39.♞h2 ♜g3+ 40.♜g1 ♞g4 41.♜e3 ♜e2++ 42.♞h1 ♞e4+ 43.♜g2 ♞f3 44.♞e5 ♜f4 0-1

48

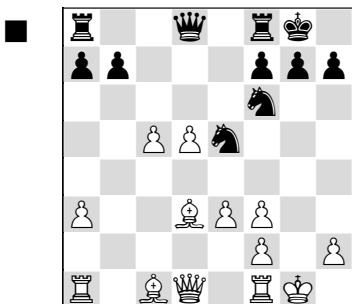
Artur Jussupow

2570

Konstantin Landa

2613

Germany Bundesliga 2008/09 (1)



14...♜xd5!?

Playing for piece activity. If White is given a free move to develop, then Black's activity will come to nought and it will be possible for him simply to resign. But all the while the knights are in the centre and the white king is somewhat exposed, Black has counterplay.

Prior to this game, Black had preferred the materialistic approach 14...♞xd5 15.♞e2 ♞xc5, regaining both pawns, but White manages to develop his pieces conveniently after 16.♞b2, retaining a small advantage.

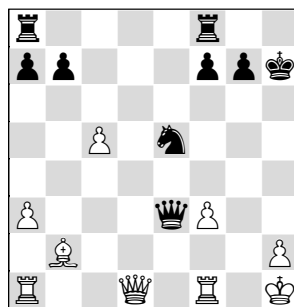
15.♞b2

On 15.f4 Black maintains the balance with 15...♜xd3 16.♞xd3 ♞f6! (playing for activity!) 17.♞b1 ♜c3 18.♞b3 ♞e6! 19.♞xc3 ♞g4+ 20.♞h1 ♞f3+ 21.♜g1 ♞g4+=.

15...♜xe3 16.♞xh7+

On 16.fxe3 ♜xd3 17.♞d4, the reserve black knight lands a simple tactical blow: 17...♜xc5! 18.♞xc5 ♞g5+ 19.♞h1 ♞xc5.

16...♞xh7 17.fxe3 ♞g5+ 18.♞h1 ♞xe3



19.♞c2+

After 19.♞e1 ♞xf3+ 20.♞xf3 ♜xf3 21.♞e3 ♜h4 22.♞e7 ♞ae8 23.♞xb7 ♞e2, Black manages to create threats to the white king.

19...♞d3 20.♞g2 ♜g6 21.♞ad1

It would be too ambitious to play 21.f4 ♞f5 22.♞xb7 ♜h4! 23.♞ad1 ♞ab8 24.♞e7 ♞xb2 25.♞xh4+ ♜g8. The white king is very exposed, whilst the extra pawn is easily regained: 26.♞f2 ♞b1+ 27.♞xb1 ♞xb1+ 28.♜g2 ♞e4+ 29.♞f3 ♞c8.

21...♞f5 22.♞d4?

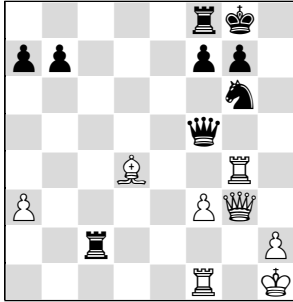
White directs his rook to h4, but on that square, it does absolutely nothing.

Stronger is 22.♞g4 ♞xc5 23.♞d7!?, with counterplay.

22...♞ac8 23.♞h4+ ♜g8 24.♞d4 ♞xc5! 25.♞g4

He also loses after 25.♔xc5 ♖xh4
26.♖f2 ♜c8! 27.♔xa7 ♖d3! 28.♙g1
♖xa3 29.♖xh4 ♖xa7+.

25...♜c2 26.♖g3



26...b6!

There is no hurry! Black quietly defends the pawn on a7. White does not have a single constructive idea.

27.♜g1 ♔e8 28.♜h4 ♔e2 29.♔a1
♔e3 30.♜h3 ♜ce2 31.♔d4 ♔e8
32.a4 ♜a4 33.♜h4 ♜xa4 34.♜g4
♜a3 35.♙g2 ♜a2+ 36.♙f2 ♔e2
37.♜f1 ♖e5 38.f4 ♖f6 39.♙g1
♖e7 40.f5 ♖xf5 41.♖f3 ♖e5
42.♜c4 ♖d6 43.♜h4 ♖e4 44.♜d1
♖g5+ 45.♜g4 ♜xf2 46.♖xe4 ♜fd2
47.♜xd2 ♜a1+ **0-1**

49

Sergey Movsesian

2688

Romain Edouard

2686

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (5)

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♖d2 c5 4.♖gf3
cxd4 5.exd5 ♖xd5 6.♔c4 ♖d7
7.0-0 ♖c6 8.♖b3 ♖f6 9.♖e2

A rare continuation.

9...♔d6 10.♜d1 0-0 11.♖bxd4
♖xd4 12.♜xd4 ♖e7
12...♖c7 13.♔g5! ♔e7 14.♜ad1 a6 15.a4
b6 16.♖e5 ♔b7? 17.♜d7+.

13.♖e5 ♖d5

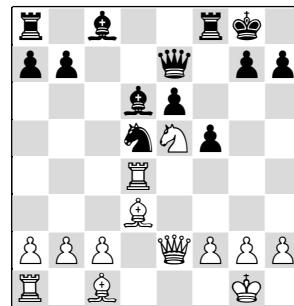
Black cannot develop normally:

13...b6 14.♔g5 ♔b7 15.♜ad1 ♜fd8

16.♔xf6! gxf6 17.♖g4+ ♖f8
(17...♖h8 18.♖xf7+ ♖xf7 19.♜xd6
♜g8 20.♖xe6 ♜xg2+ 21.♖f1 ♖f8
22.♜d7+–) 18.♖h4! fxe5 19.♖h6+
♔e8 20.♔b5+–.

14.♔d3 f5

It was worth considering 14...b6!?
15.c4 ♔xe5 (he loses after 15...♖b4?
16.♔xh7+! ♖xh7 17.♖h5+ ♖g8
18.♜h4 ♖xh4 19.♖xh4 ♔xe5
20.♖e4+–) 16.♖xe5 ♖b4 17.♔e4 ♔b7
18.♔xb7 ♖xb7 19.♔h6 f6 20.♖g3!
♜f7 (20...♖c2 21.♔xg7+–) 21.♜ad1
♖c6 22.♜d6±.



15.♔c4!

The bishop has done its job on d3 and returns to c4, attacking the black knight.

15...♖f6 16.♔g5!

White develops maximum activity. Otherwise, the advantage will disappear the moment Black develops his pieces.

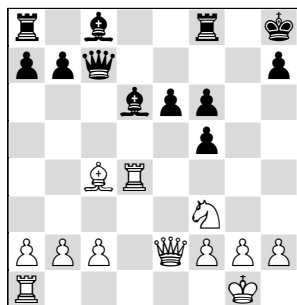
16...♖c7

Black is again unable to develop the light-squared bishop. 16...b6? 17.♜ad1 ♔c5 18.♜f4±.

17.♔xf6 gxf6

After 17...♜xf6 18.♖f3, White has a stable advantage thanks to the weakness of the pawn on e6.

18.♖f3 ♔h8



19. ♖h4!

19. ♖ad1?.

19...e5 20. ♖h5 e4

After 20...♖d7 21. ♘h4 ♖e8 22. ♖h6 ♖d7 23. ♖d1 ♖d8 24. ♖b3±, Black hardly has any moves, and White can slowly strengthen his position.

21. ♘h4 ♖e8 22. ♖h6!

Freeing the square h5 for the queen. White is not settling for small gains – the black king will never survive such a concentration of forces against him.

Less effective is 22. ♘xf5 ♖xf5 23. ♖xf5 ♖xh2+ 24. ♖f1 ♖ad8±.

22...♖xh2+ 23. ♖h1 ♖f4 24. ♖h5 ♖g8 25. ♘g6+ ♖xg6 26. ♖xg6

Black resigned.

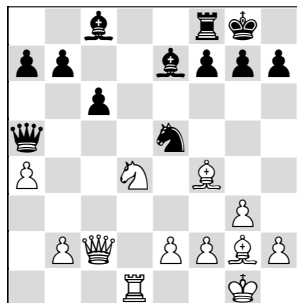
50

Alexander Alekhine

Max Euwe

the Netherlands Wch match 1935 (1)

**



White constantly exploits the hanging position of the black knight, attacking Black from one side and then the other.

19.b4! ♖c7

Taking the pawn does not solve the problems, but it does liven the game and permits some sort of counterplay: 19...♖xb4 20. ♘b3 ♖c7 21. ♖e4 ♖d6 (even worse is 21...♖c3 22. ♖c1 ♖b2 23. ♖b1 g5 24. ♖xg5 ♖a3 25. ♖f6 ♘g4 26. ♖d4 f5 27. ♖c2 – the weakening of the black king counts for more here) 22. ♖d4 g5 23. ♖xg5 f6 24. ♖f4 ♖e6 – White has several excellent possibilities, involving winning the pawn on a7 or obtaining the advantage of the two bishops. But in any event, a big battle still lies ahead.

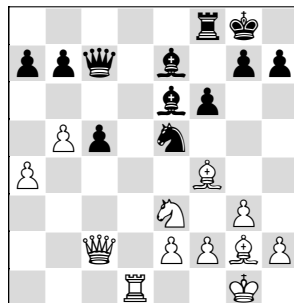
20.b5 c5 21. ♘f5 f6

Now, the bishop on e7 loses the chance to play a full role, and the light squares are irretrievably weakened.

He loses after 21...♖f6 22. ♘e3 ♖e6 23. ♘d5 ♖xd5 24. ♖xd5 b6 25. ♖f5 ♖e8 26. ♖e4. The most tenacious is 21...g5! 22. ♖c1 ♖d8 23. ♘xe7+ ♖xe7 24. ♖xd8+ ♖xd8 25. ♖e4 h6, although even here, the two bishops should bring White victory.

22. ♘e3 ♖e6

The problem of exchanging



23.♙d5!

The exchange of light-squared bishops underlines how catastrophic the move ...f7-f6 has been for the ♙e7.

23...♙xd5 24.♞xd5 ♖a5 25.♜f5 ♖e1+ 26.♔g2 ♙d8 27.♙xe5 fxe5 28.♞d7 ♙f6 29.♜h6+ ♔h8 30.♞xc5 Black resigned.

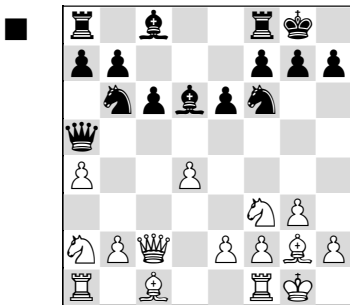
51********Anish Giri**

2720

Fabiano Caruana

2781

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (11)



Failing to sense the danger, Black starts going after material at just the wrong moment.

12...♞xa4?

Correct is 12...♞f5!.

13.b3! ♖a5 14.♜e5

Another good-looking line is the direct 14.e4 ♙e7 15.♜g5! with the possible variation 15...h6 16.♙d2 ♖b5 17.♜c3 ♖b4 18.♜f3! ♙d8 19.♜d5 ♖b5 20.♜xf6+ ♙xf6 21.♞a5+-.

14...♜bd7 15.♜c4 ♖c7 16.♜xd6 ♖xd6 17.♞d1

Black has managed to return the queen home, but his position is extremely dangerous after the exchange of dark-squared bishops. White's pieces cooperate beautifully and control the whole board.

17...e5

Playing within his own camp fails: 17...♞e8 18.♜c3 a5 19.♙a3 ♖b8 (19...♞c7? 20.♜b5+-) 20.h3 h6 21.e4 b6 22.e5 ♜d5 23.♜e4±, and Black is not to be envied.

18.♜c3 exd4 19.♙a3 c5

Possibly the best decision was 19...♞e5 20.♙xf8 ♜xf8 21.♜e4 ♜e6!, retaining practical chances.

20.e3! d3 21.♞xd3 ♖b8

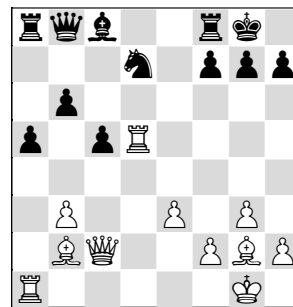
21...♞e5 22.f4 ♖h5 23.♜b5±.

22.♜d5 ♜xd5 23.♞xd5 b6 24.♙b2!

A logical move, but even so, I feel it deserves an exclamation mark. White not only brings the bishop to the long diagonal, but he also prepares to bring the ♞a1 into the game.

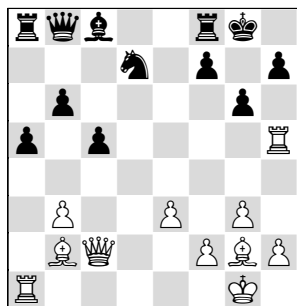
24...a5

Transferring forces

**25.♞a4!**

Bringing his final piece to the area where the game will be decided. The queen, two rooks and two powerful bishops are too much for one poor king.

White has such a strong position that he can also win with the computer line 25.♞h5 g6 (25...h6 26.♙d5, with the threat of 27.♞g6+-; 26...♞d6 27.♞d1, and the queen is lost!)



analysis diagram

26. ♖f5!.. Not only does he not retreat the rook, but he puts another piece en prise to the same pawn! 26... ♙d6 (26...gxf5 27. ♖g5#) 27. ♖xh7 ♙xh7 28. ♙h3+ ♙g8 29. ♙h8#.

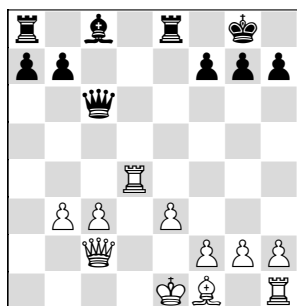
25... ♖e8 26. ♖g5 g6 27. ♙d5 ♙f8 28. ♖f4

Black resigned.

52

José Raul Capablanca
Alexander Alekhine

Buenos Aires Wch match 1927 (7)



White has an extra pawn and excellently-centralised pieces. With his next move, he allows Black to spoil his pawn structure, which could have given the white king excellent cover. In return, the sleeping white pieces on the kingside come into active play.

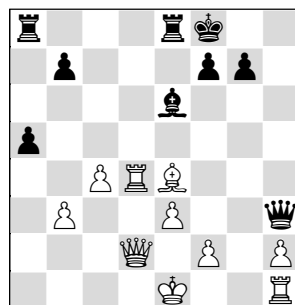
19. ♙d3! ♙xg2 20. ♙xh7+ ♙f8 21. ♙e4 ♙h3 22. ♙d2!

Now the queen is activated. Also strong, with the same idea, was 22. ♙d3, with the idea of ♙d3-b5.

22... ♙e6 23.c4

This move limits the bishop on e6, whilst at the same time, the queen gets the square b4.

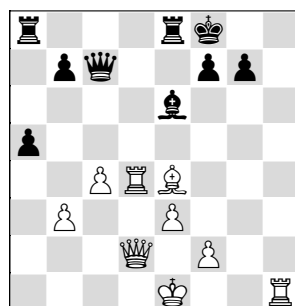
23...a5



24. ♖g1!

The time has come to bring the last piece into play, even at the cost of the rook's pawn. The white pieces enjoy complete harmony, and are even located in the centre.

24... ♙xh2 25. ♖h1 ♙c7



26. ♙b2!

The queen finds a new position, from where she can exert pressure on the black position. From here, she can both attack g7 and come to a3.

26... ♙c5 27. ♙d5!

Now, there is the possibility of swinging the rook along the fifth rank to the kingside.

27...♖a6

He also loses after 27...♖ad8 28.♙xe6! ♖xd4 29.♗xd4! ♗xd4 30.♖h8+ ♙e7 31.♖xe8+ ♙xe8 32.♙xf7+ ♙xf7 33.exd4.

28.♗e4 ♖d6

After 28...♙g8, White wraps things up with 29.f4!, with the threats of f4-f5, and ♗b2-h2.

29.♖h7 ♙e7 30.♗xg7 ♙d8
31.♙xe6 fxe6 32.♗xb7 ♗b4+
33.♗xb4 axb4 34.c5 ♖c6 35.♖xb4
♖xc5 36.♖a7 1-0

53

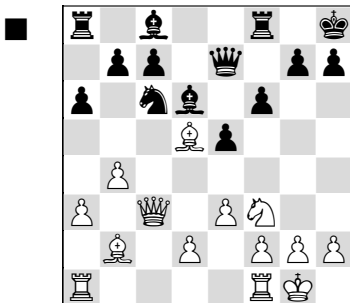
Maxim Turov

Arkadij Naiditsch

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (3)

2630

2708



We have a complicated position on the board. Those with a wide opening erudition will notice that we have a Paulsen Sicilian, with colours reversed. Black has set up a powerful barrier against the ♙b2, and he should now seek play on the queenside.

13...a5! 14.b5 ♘a7 15.♙c4

The move 15.a4 gives the square b4 to the black pieces after 15...e4 16.♘e1 c6 17.bxc6 ♘xc6!.

15...♙d7 16.♗b3

Another possibility was 16.a4 c6! 17.bxc6 ♘xc6 18.d4 ♖ac8 19.♗b3 ♘b4 20.♖fc1 ♖c7 – Black is slightly better.

The attack with the rook's pawn



16...a4!

An unexpected pawn advance, which determines Black's advantage.

17.♗xa4 e4 18.♘e1

The continuation 18.♘d4 ♘xb5 19.♗b3 (after 19.♗c2 ♘xd4 20.♙xd4 ♖xa3, White remains a pawn down) runs into the nice refutation 19...♘xd4 20.♙xd4 b5!, and the pawn cannot be taken because of the pin on the b-file: 21.♙e2 ♖xa3 22.♖xa3 ♙xa3.

18...♘xb5 19.♗b3 ♘a7!

Black avoids the unequal exchange of the pawn on b7 for the weakness on a3. The simplification with 19...♘xa3 20.♙xa3 ♖xa3 21.♖xa3 ♙xa3 22.♘c2 ♙d6 23.♗xb7 was satisfactory for White.

20.f3

Black also has the advantage after 20.d4 b5 (the knight transfer to b6 is interesting: 20...♘c8!?) 21.♙e2 ♘c6 22.♙c3 ♘a5 23.♙xa5 ♖xa5 24.♘c2 ♖fa8.

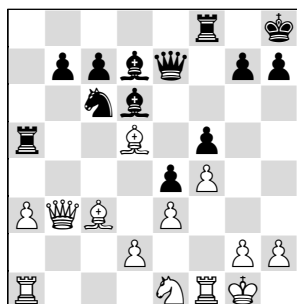
20...♘c6 21.♙d5 f5

By securing the pawn on e4, Black fixes the enemy knight on e1.

22.f4

White cannot get the knight out via c2: 22.♖c2 exf3! 23.♙xf3 ♘e5±.

22...♙a5 23.♙c3



23...♙c5!

The black pieces cooperate excellently with one another, which cannot be said of White's. The knight on e1 is especially bad.

24.a4 ♘a5 25.♙xa5

Nor does he escape his problems after 25.♙a2 c6 26.♙b3 ♘xb3 27.♙xb3 ♙e6 28.♙b2 ♙c4 29.♙f2 ♙a8±.

25...♙xa5 26.♙xb7 ♙b5!?

Also possible was the simple 26...♙xa4 27.♙b2 ♙xd5 28.♙xa4 ♙c5 29.♙f2 ♙d7 30.♙a2 ♙d8± – it is not easy for White to bring the knight at e1 into play.

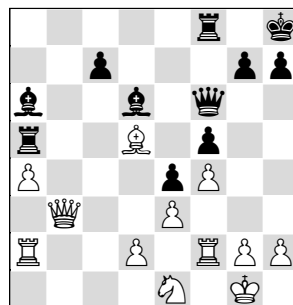
27.♙f2 ♙f6 28.♙a2?

Fatally weakening the back rank. White could only stay in the game with 28.♙b1! ♙xa4 (28...♙a6 29.♙c6) 29.g3±.

28...♙a6! 29.♙b3

If 29.♙c6 ♙b8! and there is no defence against the entry to b1.

Back-rank weakness



29...♙c5!

The rook returns to the c-file to enter via c1.

30.♙c2

30.♘c2 c6–+.

30...♙a1 31.♙f1 ♙xc2 32.♙xc2 ♙xf1 33.♙xf1 ♙b8 34.♙f2 ♙b2 35.♙c3 ♙b4 36.♙c6 ♙xd2+ 37.♙g3 ♙xe1+ 38.♙h3 ♙xe3+ 39.g3 ♙c5 0-1

54

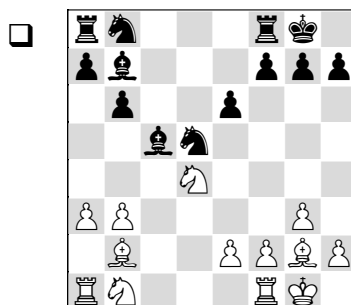
Anatoly Karpov

Viktor Kortchnoi

Biel 1992 (3)

2715

2575



The pawn formation is almost symmetrical, but thanks to his slightly more coordinated pieces, White has the advantage. Particularly unpleasant for Black is the typical pressure from the Catalan bishop down the long diagonal.

15.♘b5!

White moves the knight from under the attack of the black bishop, at the same time creating threats of knight jumps to c7 or c3.

A) 15.♖c3 ♗xd4 16.♘xd5 ♗xf2+ 17.♗xf2 ♗xd5 18.♗xd5 exd5 leads only to equality;

B) 15.b4 ♗xd4 16.♗xd4 ♖c6 17.♗b2 gains the advantage of the two bishops, but at the cost of tempi and a weakening of the light squares.

15...♘c6?!

He should not place another piece under the 'x-ray' of the ♗g2.

A) He loses after 15...♗c6? 16.♗xd5+–;

B) Also bad, because it does not assist his development, is 15...a6 16.♘c7 ♖a7 17.♘xd5 ♗xd5 18.♗xd5 exd5 19.♘c3±;

C) Black should have chosen 15...♘d7, although after 16.b4 (Black is close to a draw after 16.♘c7 ♖ac8 17.♘xd5 ♗xd5 18.♗xd5 exd5 19.♖d1 ♖fe8 20.e3 ♗f8 21.♘c3 ♘c5 22.b4 ♘e4; although here White can choose the even more cunning 16.♖d1!?, not forcing events) 16...♗e7 17.♖d1 ♖fd8 18.e4 ♘5f6 19.e5 ♘d5 20.♘1c3 ♘xc3 21.♗xc3 ♗xg2 22.♖xg2 ♖ac8 23.♗b2 White retains lasting pressure.

16.b4!

The pawns begin to chase the black pieces, driving them from their favourable positions.

16...♗e7 17.e4 ♘f6 18.e5 ♘d5 19.♘1c3!

Black cannot hold d5 as a safe outpost, so his position is bad.

19...♘xc3 20.♗xc3 ♘d8

Resolving the opposition of the bishops, but now the knight stands badly.

On 20...♖fd8, there follows 21.♖fd1, with the threat of bringing the knight to d6.

21.♗xb7

Even stronger was the developing move 21.♖ac1! – after the exchange of the bishops, the black knight cannot come to c6, because of 21...♗xg2 22.♖xg2 ♘c6 23.♗b2, and the knight cannot be maintained.

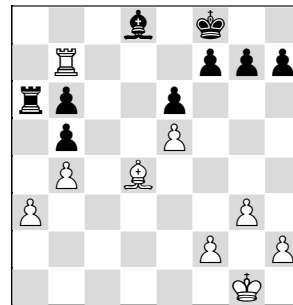
21...♘xb7 22.♖fd1 ♖fd8 23.♖xd8+ ♗xd8

On 23...♘xd8, there follows 24.♖c1, not allowing the black knight to come to c6.

24.♖d1 a6 25.♖d7 axb5 26.♖xb7 ♖f8

More chances of a successful defence were offered by 26...h5!, with the idea of ...g7-g5!, and followed by activating the king via g7 and g6.

27.♗d4 ♖a6



28.h4!

An important subtlety. White blocks any possible development of activity by Black on the kingside.

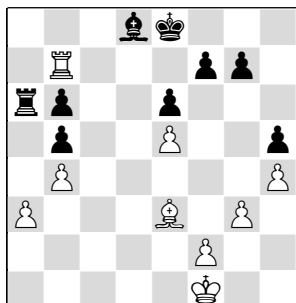
28...h5 29.♖f1 ♖e8 30.♖e2 ♖f8

31.♖b8 ♖e8 32.♖b7 ♖f8 33.♖f1

Does White not know what to do? No, he simply is in no hurry, and is awaiting the optimal moment for decisive action. Probably, he wanted to pass the time control at move 40,

so as to obtain additional time for thinking. Black is paralysed and can do nothing, so why not?

**33...♖e8 34.♗g2 ♕f8 35.♞b8 ♖e7
36.♞b7+ ♕f8 37.♙e3 ♖e8 38.♖f1**



38...♖f8?

A move which shows how unpleasant it is to defend a passive position for

a long time – Black allows a rook endgame in the worst possible form. 38...♞xa3 39.♙xb6 ♙xb6 40.♞xb6 ♖d7 41.♞xb5 (41.♞b7+ ♖c6 42.♞xf7 ♞b3 43.♞xg7 ♞xb4 gives Black chances of holding, thanks to the creation of a passed b-pawn) 41...♖c6 42.♞c5+ ♖b7 still allowed Black to fight.

39.♞b8 ♖e7 40.♙g5+ f6 41.exf6+ gxf6 42.♙xf6+ ♖xf6 43.♞xd8 ♞xa3 44.♞h8! ♞b3 45.♞xh5 ♞xb4 46.♖g2

The white rook is able to get behind the black passed pawn, and the connected pawns decide the game.

46...♖g6 47.♞e5 ♖f6 48.f4 ♞b2+ 49.♖f3 b4 50.♞b5 b3 51.♖g4! ♞b1 52.♖h5 b2 53.g4 1-0

Additional material

Petrosian-Smyslov, Moscow 1961

Timman-Kasparov, Hilversum (match/1) 1985

Kasparov-Hübner, Brussels 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, Amsterdam (4th cycle) 1988

Kramnik-Speelman, Biel 1993 – White's 48th move

Psakhis-Kasparov, La Manga (match/1) 1990

Kasparov-Karpov, London Wch (match/2) 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, London Wch (match/4) 1986 – White's 23rd and 29th moves

Kasparov-Karpov, London Wch (match/10) 1986

Karpov-Kasparov, London Wch (match/3) 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, Seville Wch (match/24) 1987

Kasparov-Karpov, New York Wch (match/2) 1990

Karpov-Kasparov, New York Wch (match/1) 1990

Chapter 11

Developing the initiative

This theme is a continuation of the previous one on 'coordination and piece activity'. The difference is that here we look at how pieces can cooperate and develop their activity under the influence of dynamic factors. Often, the side developing the initiative will sacrifice a pawn or allow pawn weaknesses to be created in his position.

55

Zdravko Milev

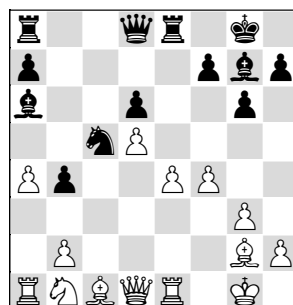
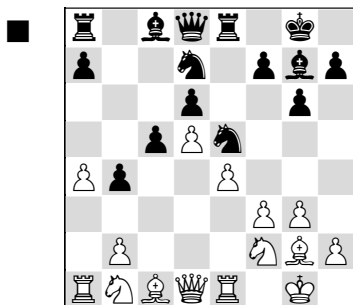
Tigran Petrosian

Bucharest 1953 (7)

*

superior pawn structure and more active pieces.

18...♘c5 19.♚d1 ♙a6



20.♙f1

White is clearly late in developing his queenside, and Black energetically exploits this, not being afraid to sacrifice a pawn:

15...c4!

If he wishes, Black could play the offensive more prosaically: 15...♙a6 16.f4 ♘c4 – sooner or later, the knight on c4 will move, making way for the pawn.

16.f4 ♘d3 17.♘xd3 cxd3

18.♚xd3

This looks obvious, but now White does not manage to complete his development. More tenacious was 18.♙e3, although after 18...♙xb2 19.♖a2 ♙g7 20.♚xd3 a5 Black has a large advantage, thanks to his

It is impossible to continue developing whilst keeping material losses to a minimum, since after 20.♙e3, Black wins with 20...♘d3!–+. White can cover the d3-square against entry by 20.♖e3, but this move does not develop anything and does not ease the position. For example, quite a simple reply is 20...♖c8 or 20...♚f6, with the idea of ...♚f6-d4.

20...♘xe4 21.♙xa6 ♚b6+ 22.♙e3 ♚xa6 23.♙d4

On 23.♖a2, the simplest is 23...♘c5 24.♙xc5 ♖xe1+ 25.♚xe1 ♚c4–+.

23...♙xd4 24.♚xd4 ♘g3 25.♘c3 bxc3 26.hxg3 c2 27.♚f2 ♖ac8 28.♖e3

28. ♖xe8+ ♖xe8 29. ♖xc2 ♖e2 30. ♖c6 ♖d3 31. ♖c8+ ♖g7 32. ♖c3+ ♖xc3 33. bxc3 ♖e3 leads to a winning rook ending for Black.

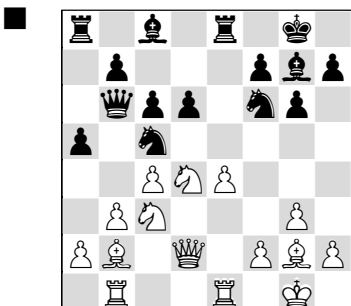
28... ♖xe3 29. ♖xe3 ♖c4 0-1

56

Frantisek Zita

David Bronstein

Moscow/Prague 1946 (6)



The set-up of white pieces is far from ideal: he has not made the important prophylactic move h2-h3, taking the g4-square from the black knight, the queen would be better on c2, and the bishop on e3. The lack of harmony in the white camp allows Black to take advantage of combinational motifs.

14... a4! 15. ♕a1

Here, the bishop comes under attack, so he should have decided on a capture on a4, although after this, the white pawn structure would become vulnerable.

15... axb3 16. axb3 ♖g4!

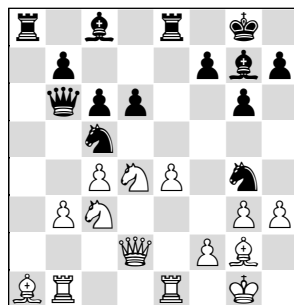
Now, the dark squares in White's camp start to creak, and in addition, Black has in reserve the idea of bringing his knight to d3, via e5.

17. h3?

Losing immediately.

After 17. ♖a4 ♖xa4 18. bxa4 ♖a5, White cannot hold the queenside pawns.

It was essential to play 17. ♖ed1, although here too, after 17... ♖xa1! 18. ♖xa1 ♖xb3 19. ♖xb3 ♖xb3 20. ♖ac1 ♖e5, Black gets a pair of passed pawns for the exchange, and a strong initiative – his advantage is beyond doubt.



17... ♖xa1! 18. ♖xa1 ♖xf2! 19. ♖e3

On 19. ♖xf2 Black wins with 19... ♖xb3, whilst after 19. ♖xf2, 19... ♖d3!.

19... ♖xh3+ 20. ♖h2 ♖f2!

The white pieces are so unstable that it is impossible for him to avoid large material losses.

21. ♖f3 ♖cxe4 22. ♖f4 ♖g4+ 23. ♖h1 f5 24. ♖xe4 ♖xe4 25. ♖xd6 ♖xd4 26. ♖b8 ♖d8 27. ♖a8 ♖e5 28. ♖a7 ♖b4 29. ♖g1 ♖f8 30. ♖h3 ♖h6 0-1

57

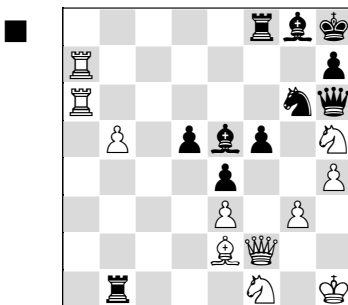
Sergey Tiviakov

2700

Konstantin Sakaev

2668

Khanty-Mansiysk 2005 (2)



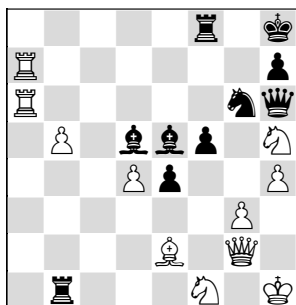
The position is sharp, with each side having his trumps. White has the rooks, the bishop on e2 and the knight on h5, which occupy active positions. All of Black's pieces stand very well, apart from his queen, which is trapped in its own camp, and his light-squared bishop, which is only fulfilling defensive functions. Black's next move is directed precisely at the idea of bringing the bishop into the attack:

45...d4! 46.exd4 ♖d5

He could first retreat with tempo by 46...♖b8.

The immediate 46...f4 also gives a decisive attack.

47.♟g2



47...f4! 48.gxf4 ♖xf4

Black has all of his pieces in the attack, which ensures him a decisive advantage.

**49.♜d7 ♖c4! 50.♜xf4 ♖xe2
51.♜xg6 ♟xh4+ 52.♟h3 ♟xh3
53.♜xh3 hxg6**

White resigned.

58

Konstantin Sakaev

2656

Igor Kurnosov

2524

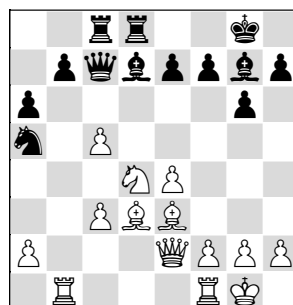
Moscow 2004 (1)

**1.d4 ♟f6 2.c4 g6 3.♜c3 d5 4.cxd5
♜xd5 5.e4 ♜xc3 6.bxc3 ♖g7**

**7.♖c4 c5 8.♜e2 ♜c6 9.♖e3 0-0
10.0-0 ♖d7 11.♜b1 a6 12.dxc5
♟c7 13.♜d4 ♜a5 14.♖d3 ♜fd8
15.♟e2!**

A multi-purpose move. The queen steps off the d-file, supports his bishops and connects his rooks. So as to regain the pawn on c5, Black will sooner or later have to play ...e7-e6, followed by ...♖g7-f8. White waits for the move ...e7-e6, since after the immediate 15.f4, there follows 15...e5.

15...♜ac8



Black also waits for 16.f4, so as to answer 16...e5 in one step, but White has one more prophylactic move, which is no less useful than his last.

16.♟h1!

Now, Black does not have further really useful waiting moves, since after 16...e6, the reply 17.f4 is strong, whilst on 16...e5, there is 17.♜c2, followed by 18.♜b4.

16...♖a4

Black now wants to play 17...e5, so as to exchange his light-squared bishop on c2, and with the aid of the manoeuvre ...♖g7-f8 to regain the pawn on c5, but White provokes a conflict in the centre, now that the bishop on a4 is out of play.

17.f4! e5 18.fxe5 ♖xe5 19.♜f3!

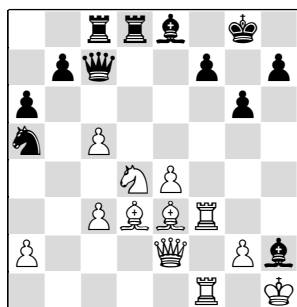
A great square for the rook, because the black bishop can no longer reach g4.

19...♖e8

The bishop on e8 defends the square f7, but weakens the back rank, and in general prevents Black strengthening the group of weakened dark squares on the kingside.

Bad is 19...♖xh2 20.g3 (20.♖bf1+—) 20...♖xg3 21.♗f5+—, with a decisive attack.

20.♖bf1 ♖xh2



White has set up a battery along the f-file, and he has a powerful piece configuration in the centre. In addition, the pawn on f7 is barely hanging on, and the lack of black control over the square f8 creates tactical motifs.

21.♗e6! ♖b8

The knight cannot be taken: 21...fxe6 22.♖f8+ ♖g7 23.♖f3 ♖e7 (23...♖e5 24.♖g8++—) 24.♖h3 g5 25.♖xh2, and White has a decisive attack.

22.♖f2!

The simplest and most pragmatic. White wins a piece, transposing the game into the technical stage.

Less clear is 22.♗xd8 ♖xd8, when because of White's broken pawn

structure, Black still has a defensible position.

22...♖d7

Black has no other way to defend against 23.♖xf7, but he simply loses the bishop in prosaic fashion.

23.g3 ♖e5 24.♗f4

The bishop is trapped, and White will retain almost all of his pawns. The rest requires only minimal accuracy to convert the advantage.

24...♖xc3 25.♖xh2 ♗c6 26.♖d2 ♖g7 27.♖g2 ♗e5 28.♖c3 ♗g4 29.♖xg7 ♗xf2 30.♖1xf2 ♖xg7 31.♗d5 ♖dd8 32.♗f6 ♖a4 33.♖c2 ♖b5 34.♖c3 ♖d4 35.♖b3 b6 36.a4 ♖d3 37.c6 ♖d6 38.e5 ♖cxc6 39.exd6 ♖xc3 40.d7

Black resigned.

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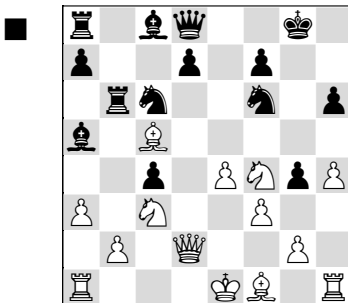
Sergey Volkov

Konstantin Sakaev

New Delhi rapid 2000 (1)

2554

2627



The position is exceptionally sharp, with pieces and pawns scattered all over the board. Both kings are exposed, with the white monarch being a particular cause for concern. In such a position, calculating clearly to a position with a definite verdict is extremely difficult, and one must trust one's intuition. If

one asks what Black should do, there is no room for argument – there is simply no time to retreat the rook! This is even more so because the bishop, which is attacking it, is a full equivalent for the rook, since without it, the dark squares in the white camp will be very vulnerable. Therefore, Black just brings his sleeping rook into the game:

16...♖ab8! 17.♙xb6 ♖xb6 18.0-0-0

A) 18.♙xc4 ♖xb2 19.♖c1 ♖xa3 20.♘d3 d5 21.exd5 ♘d4 22.♙e5 ♙f5 23.0-0 ♙b6 24.♙h1 ♙e3 25.♖e1 ♖d6, winning;

B) After 18.♖c1, both 18...♙e5 and the more direct 18...♖xb2 19.♙xc4 ♖xa3 are promising.

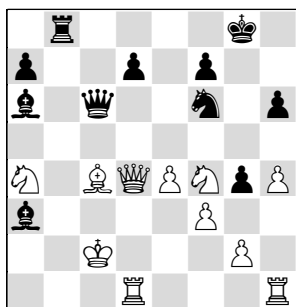
18...♘d4! 19.♙xc4 ♙a6!

All of Black's pieces are taking part in the attack! Understanding this factor enables one to assess the position as in Black's favour.

20.b4 ♙xb4 21.♖xd4 ♙c5

21...♖xd4 22.♖xd4 ♙xc3 23.♙xa6 ♙xd4 also leads to an advantage for Black, but it may not suffice for victory.

22.♘a4 ♙xa3+ 23.♙c2 ♖c6



The pin on the ♙c4 decides the game.

24.♙d3

A) 24.♙d2 ♙xc4 25.♖b1 ♖c8 26.♘c3 (26.♖hc1 ♖xa4 27.♖xf6 ♖a5+ 28.♖c3 ♙f8 29.♖bc1 ♙b4) 26...♙c5 27.♖e5 ♙b6 – the white king is exposed, and the numerous black threats cannot be resisted;

B) 24.♖b1 ♖xa4+ 25.♙d2 ♙b4+ 26.♙e3 ♙xc4 27.♖xc4 ♙d2+ 28.♙xd2 (28.♙d3 ♖xc4+ 29.♙xc4 ♖c8+ 30.♙d4 ♙xf4) 28...♖xc4 29.♖xb8+ ♙g7 30.♖c1 ♖d4 31.♘d3 ♖d6 32.♖b4 ♖g3 – White loses his kingside pawns.

24...♖b4 25.♙xa6 ♖xd4+ 26.♙xd4 ♖xa6

Now, Black has both the initiative and the extra material. His position is winning.

27.♘c3 ♙b2 28.e5 ♖a4+ 29.♙e3 ♙xc3 30.exf6 g3 31.♘d5 ♙b2 32.f4 a5 33.♙f3 ♖b3+ 34.♙g4 a4 35.♖he1 a3 36.♙e7+ ♙h7 37.♙f5 a2 38.♘g3 ♖a4 39.♙f5 a1 ♖ 40.♖xa1 ♙xa1 41.♖e7 ♙g6 42.h5+ ♙xf6 43.♖e1 ♖a5 0-1

60

Vassily Ivanchuk

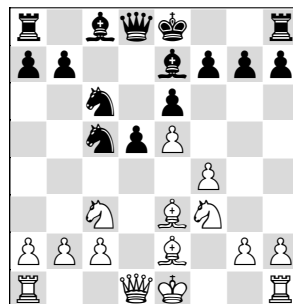
2730

Alexander Morozevich

2610

Amsterdam 1996 (10)

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘c3 ♙f6 4.e5 ♙fd7 5.f4 c5 6.♙f3 ♘c6 7.♙e3 ♙e7 8.dxc5 ♘xc5 9.♙e2



9...0-0

Black has less space, so exchanges favour him. However, it is risky to spend further tempi on this, e.g. after 9...♖a5 10.0-0 ♘a4 11.♘xa4 ♖xa4 12.c4 ♖xd1 13.♗fxd1± he has problems with his lack of development.

10.0-0 ♕d7?!

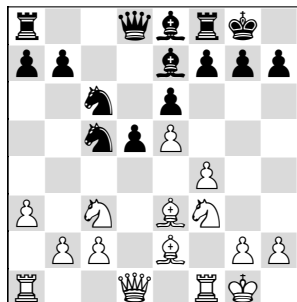
Here, the bishop is badly placed, and Black remains with the bad piece for a long time. It made sense to choose 10...b6±, and then either to exchange a pair of bishops with the aid of ...♕c8-a6, or to play ...♕c8-b7, supporting the possible knight jump ...♘c5-e4.

11.a3!

Now, Black must constantly reckon with the threat of b2-b4, which is not easy to prevent – the advance ...a7-a5 significantly weakens the square b5.

11...♕e8

Freeing the square d7 for the retreat of the knight, and planning, after the future break ...f7-f6, to activate the light-square bishop via g6 or h5. Bad is 11...♗c8 12.b4! ♘e4 13.♘xe4 dxe4 14.♘d2 f5 15.♘c4±.



12.♖e1!

The queen heads to the kingside, at the same time as the rook frees the excellent square d1 for the rook,

after which the black queen will feel uncomfortable.

12...♗c8

Risky is 12...d4 13.♗d1 ♖b6 14.♘xd4 ♖xb2 15.♗b1! ♖xa3 16.♘db5 ♖a5 17.♘d6± – the dark squares are weak and the bishop on e8 passive.

So as to activate the light-squared bishop, it looks logical to play the immediate 12...f6, but after 13.exf6 ♗xf6 14.♘d4 ♘d7 15.♕g4, White's position is preferable all the same.

13.♗d1

Promising is 13.f5!?, but White tries to conduct the game in solid positional style, strengthening the position of his pieces.

13...♖c7 14.b4 ♘d7 15.♘b5 ♖b8

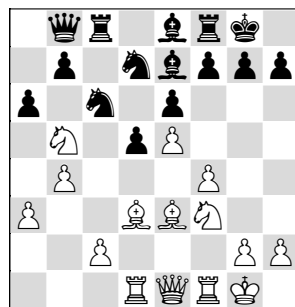
16.♕d3

Having seized space on the queenside, White turns his attention to the other flank – play on the whole board!

16...f6?

An unfortunate attempt to break the positional chains.

A) Also bad is 16...a6,



analysis diagram

because of 17.♘d6! (17.♘bd4±) 17...♗d8 (17...♕xd6? 18.♕xh7+!+-) 18.c4 dxc4 19.♘xc4±;

B) The best defence was the patient 16...g6, although the remaining

problems of the bad bishops and weak dark squares around the black king make his position difficult.

17. ♖h4!

An important intermediate move, forcing a weakening of the black kingside.

17... f5

17...h6 18. ♖h3+- – e6 cannot be defended.

18. ♖h3

More convincing than the fleeting chance to win a pawn: 18. ♕xa7 ♖a8 (18... ♕xh4 19. ♕xb8±) 19. ♖f2±.

18... ♗b6 19. ♕xb6

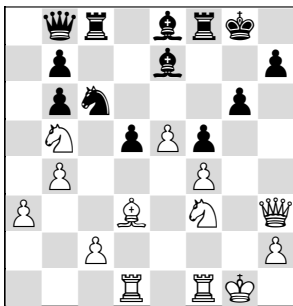
Also strong is 19.g4 ♗c4 20. ♕xc4 dxc4 21. ♗bd4, breaking through to the pawn at e6.

19... axb6 20.g4! g6

20... ♕g6 21. ♗bd4 ♗xd4 22. ♗xd4+-.

21. gxf5 exf5

21...gxf5 22. ♖h1 ♖h8 23. ♖g1, with a decisive attack on the open lines.



22. ♖f2

The rook heads to the g-file. Another good move, with the same idea, was 22. ♖h1.

22... ♗d8 23. ♗bd4 ♖h8 24. ♖g2 ♖c3

On 24... ♖g8, there follows 25. ♗xf5! ♕d7 (25...gxf5 26. ♖xg8+ ♖xg8 27. ♕xf5+-) 26. ♗3h4!+-, sweeping everything from White's path.

25. ♗h4 ♗c6 26. ♗e6

26. ♗b5 ♖xd3 27. cxd3+-.

26... ♖g8 27. ♗xf5! ♖c8

A) 27... ♕d7 28. ♗xe7 ♗xe7 29. ♖h4 ♕xe6 30. ♖xe7+-;

B) 27...gxf5 28. ♖xg8+ ♖xg8 29. ♖h6+-.

28. ♖g3!

On top of everything else, creating the nice threat of ♖h3xh7.

28...h5 29. ♗h6 ♖g7 30. ♕f5 ♖xg3+

31. ♖xg3 ♖b8 32. ♖xd5 ♖h7

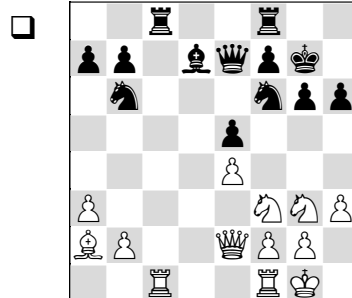
33. ♕xg6 ♖xh6 34. ♕f7 1-0

61

Alexander Alekhine

José Raul Capablanca

Buenos Aires Wch match 1927 (34)



The pawn formation is virtually symmetrical, but White's position is slightly more preferable, because of his more active pieces. The a5-square is the ideal landing-place for the white queen, from where it can attack the enemy pawns:

21. ♖d2! ♕e6!

If the bishop moves in the other direction, the f5-square becomes vulnerable: on 21... ♕c6 or 21... ♕b5, there is the strong move 22. ♗h4!.

Instead, Black exchanges off the actively-placed white bishop, which is a sensible decision. The other

possibility was the immediate activation of his passive pieces with 21...♖a4, tying White to the defence of the b2-pawn. In this case, White can retain a small advantage with 22.♖fd1.

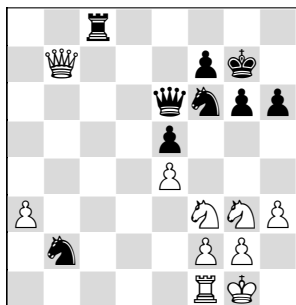
22.♙xe6 ♖xe6 23.♚a5 ♘c4

The most natural continuation, but inaccurate. The following alternatives offered better prospects of damping down White's initiative:

A) 23...♗b3 24.♘xe5 (24.♗xe5 ♖fe8 25.♗d4 ♖cd8 26.♗c3 ♗xc3 27.♖xc3 ♘xe4 28.♘xe4 ♖xe4) 24...♖xc1 25.♖xc1 ♗xb2 26.♘d3 ♗d4 27.♗xa7 ♗xd3 28.♗xb6 ♘xe4 29.♘xe4 ♗xe4 30.♖c7 ♗e5 31.♖xb7+ ♗a1 32.♙h2 ♗xa3 leads to a draw;

B) As well as the counterattack on the b2-pawn, Black could have defended the a7-pawn indirectly: 23...♘fd7 24.♖xc8 (the a7-pawn is immune: 24.♗xa7? ♘c5 25.♗a5 ♘b3-+) 24...♖xc8 25.♗xa7 ♗c6 (less convincing is 25...♗b3 26.♗xb7 ♗xb2 27.♖d1) 26.♗a5 ♗c2 27.♗b4 ♖c4 28.♗b5 ♖c5, which could lead to a repetition of moves.

24.♗xa7 ♘xb2 25.♖xc8 ♖xc8 26.♗xb7



26...♘c4

Here, the only way to equalise was the unlikely-looking 26...♘d3!, ignoring

the outside passed a-pawn. In this case, the c-file remains open, and Black takes aim at the pawn on f2, intending if appropriate to transfer the knight to f4: 27.a4 ♖c3! 28.a5 (28.♖a1 ♖c2 29.a5 ♖xf2, with the threats of ...♖f2xg2+ and ...♖f2xf3) 28...♖a3 29.♖d1 ♗c4 30.a6 ♘xf2! 31.♘xe5 (31.♙xf2 ♗c2+ 32.♖d2 ♗c5+ 33.♙f1 ♗c1+ 34.♙e2 ♗c4+ leads to perpetual check) 31...♗e6 32.♘xf7 ♘xh3+ 33.♙h2 ♗xa6 34.♖b1 ♗xb7 35.♖xb7 ♘f2 36.♘e5+ ♙g8 37.♖b8+ ♙g7 38.♖b7+, with a draw.

27.♗b4 ♖a8 28.♖a1 ♗c6 29.a4 ♘xe4 30.♘xe5

White also keeps a large advantage after 30.♘xe4 ♗xe4 31.a5 – the outside passed pawn, supported by its pieces, becomes a serious threat.

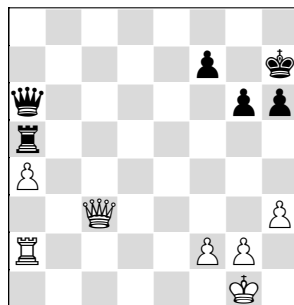
30...♗d6 31.♗xc4 ♗xe5 32.♖e1 ♘d6 33.♗c1 ♗f6

Little changes after 33...♗a5 34.♘e4 (also good is 34.♖d1 ♘e8 35.♖d4) 34...♘xe4 35.♖xe4.

34.♘e4 ♘xe4 35.♖xe4 ♖b8

On 35...♖a5, there follows 36.g3 followed by h3-h4, ensuring a home for the king and the f4-square for the rook.

36.♖e2 ♖a8 37.♖a2 ♖a5 38.♗c7 ♗a6 39.♗c3+ ♙h7



40.♖d2!

The time has come to activate the rook.

40... ♖b6

40... ♖xa4 41. ♖d8 g5 42. ♖h8+ ♔g6
43. ♖g8+ ♔h5 44. ♖e5+.

**41. ♖d7 ♖b1+ 42. ♔h2 ♖b8+ 43. g3
♖f5 44. ♖d4**

The queen has occupied a dominating position in the centre, which is the key to success.

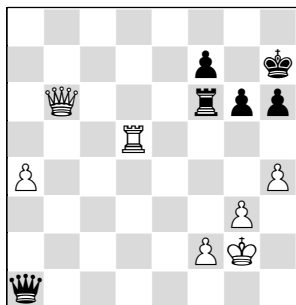
**44... ♖e8 45. ♖d5 ♖f3 46. h4 ♖h8
47. ♖b6!**

After the immediate transformation into the rook ending, the black rook gets the chance to go behind the passed a-pawn.

47... ♖a1

47... ♖a8 48. ♖d8 ♖xf2+ (48... ♖xa4
49. ♖b2+–) 49. ♖xf2 ♖xd8 50. ♖xf7+
♔h8 51. ♖xg6+.

48. ♔g2 ♖f6



49. ♖d4!

But now the rook ending is easily winning.

**49... ♖xd4 50. ♖xd4 ♔g7 51. a5 ♖a6
52. ♖d5 ♖f6 53. ♖d4 ♖a6 54. ♖a4
♔f6 55. ♔f3**

The black king has to go to the queenside, and the kingside is left undefended.

**55... ♔e5 56. ♔e3 h5 57. ♔d3
♔d5 58. ♔c3 ♔c5 59. ♖a2 ♔b5**

**60. ♔b3 ♔c5 61. ♔c3 ♔b5
62. ♔d4 ♖d6+ 63. ♔e5 ♖e6+
64. ♔f4 ♔a6 65. ♔g5 ♖e5+
66. ♔h6 ♖f5 67. f4 ♖c5 68. ♖a3
♖c7 69. ♔g7 ♖d7 70. f5 gxf5
71. ♔h6 f4 72. gxf4 ♖d5 73. ♔g7
♖f5 74. ♖a4 ♔b5 75. ♖e4 ♔a6
76. ♔h6 ♖xa5 77. ♖e5 ♖a1
78. ♔xh5 ♖g1 79. ♖g5 ♖h1
80. ♖f5 ♔b6 81. ♖xf7 ♔c6 82. ♖e7**

Black resigned.

62

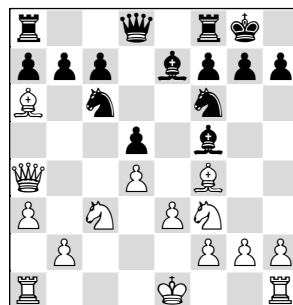
Vladimir Kramnik

Evgeny Bareev

Kazan tt 1997 (2)

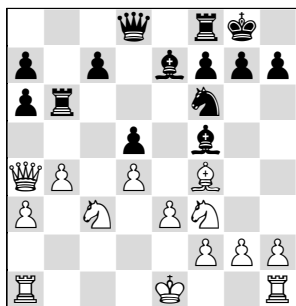
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2670



With his last move, White counted on forcing Black to defend the b7-pawn, putting at least one of his pieces on a bad square. However, Black does not wish to defend passively, and bases his next, ‘anti-positional’ move on the dynamic factors in the position: the white king has not yet moved to a safe position, and the black pieces start to show a degree of activity. The main actor in this drama is the rook, which gets some open lines.

**10... bxa6! 11. ♖xc6 ♖b8 12. b4 ♖b6
13. ♖a4**



White has cemented the queenside, so Black turns his attention to the kingside.

13...♖h5! 14.♗g3

More cautious was 14.0-0, getting the king out of danger at the cost of a small weakening of his pawn structure. After 14...♗xf4 15.exf4 c6 16.♖fe1 ♗d6 17.g3 f6, Black has sufficient counterplay – White has a group of weakened squares on the kingside, as well as the pawn on d4.

14...♖h6!

Otherwise, White will not hurry to castle. For example, he has the possibility of developing the rook to c1.

15.0-0

White underestimates the danger down the h-file, believing that moving the black queen there will take too long. More solid was 15.♗d2 – the king would be rather safer in the centre.

15...♗xg3 16.hxg3 ♗d6 17.♖fe1!

A good defensive resource – White sets up the possibility of counterplay with e3-e4, at the same time freeing a path for the king to come to the centre via f1 and e2.

He cannot solve his problems with 17.♗e5, with the idea of freeing the f-pawn and giving the king an

escape via f2. After 17...♗g5, Black's initiative is very strong.

17...♗e4

Only a mere repetition arises after 17...♗g4 18.♗h2 ♗f5 19.♗f3=.

18.♗xe4 dxe4 19.♗d2 f5 20.♖xa6

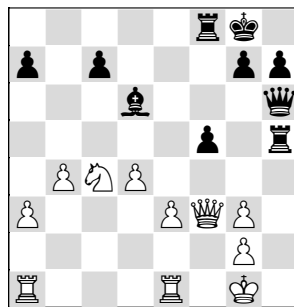
20.♗c4 ♖g5 21.♗xd6 cxd6 22.♖ac1 ♖h5 23.♗f1 ♖g4 24.♗g1 also leads to a draw.

20...♖g5 21.♖e2 ♖h5! 22.♗c4?

When your position is passive, choosing an accurate move is especially difficult.

It was essential to play 22.♖c4+ ♗h8 23.♖e6, preventing the black queen arriving on h6. After 23...♖h6 24.♖d7 ♖h5 25.♗f1 ♖h1+ 26.♗e2, Black would have been able to give perpetual check with 26...♖h5+, or retain the tension by choosing 26...♖xg2!? 27.♖g1 ♖h3 – in the resulting double-edged struggle, his chances would not be worse.

22...♖h6 23.f4 exf3 24.♖xf3



24...♗xg3! 25.♖xg3 f4 26.♖g4

26.exf4 ♖xf4 27.♖e8+ ♗f7-+.

26...fxe3 27.♖xh5 ♖xh5 28.♗xe3 ♖h4 29.♖e2 ♖xd4

The white knight has no secure outpost, and with play on both flanks, the queen is very strong – realising the extra material does not present any particular difficulties.

30.♖d1 ♖c3 31.♘d5 ♖xa3
 32.♘h2 h6 33.♞e3 ♖a6 34.♘xc7
 ♖c4 35.♘d5 ♘h7 36.♞ed3 ♖h4+
 37.♞h3 ♖g4 38.♞d2 ♞f5 39.♞hd3
 ♖h4+ 40.♞h3 ♖c4 41.♞hd3 ♖h4+
 42.♞h3 ♖e4 43.♞e3 ♞h5+ 44.♚g1
 ♖b1+ 45.♚f2 ♞xd5

White resigned.

63

Vassily Ivanchuk

2730

Veselin Topalov

2750

Novgorod 1996 (8)

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4
 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♙e2 e6 7.0-0 ♙e7
 8.f4 0-0 9.♚h1 ♖c7 10.a4 ♘c6
 11.♙e3 ♞e8 12.♙f3 ♞b8

One of the popular continuations.

It is well-known that the exchanging operation 12...♘xd4 13.♖xd4 is premature. The queen lands on d4 in a single jump, so compared with the lines where White has already played the queen to d2 first, here he has gained a tempo. For example, after 13...e5 14.♖d2 exf4 15.♙xf4 ♙e6 16.♞fd1 ♞ad8 17.a5±, the black knight cannot transfer via d7 to e5, in view of which White retains the initiative.

The most common choice is 12...♙d7, with the idea of exchanging on d4 and placing the bishop on c6. However, in this case, Black must reckon with 13.♘b3 or 13.♘de2, followed by a kingside attack with g2-g4-g5, when the bishop on d7 takes away the retreat square from the knight on f6.

13.g4

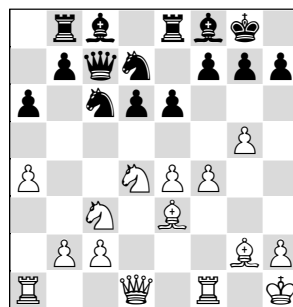
White's standard idea consists of the transfer of the bishop to g2 and the further advance of the f- and

g-pawns. Quite often, he also uses the third rank to transfer his rook via f3 to h3.

13...♙f8

From the viewpoint of current theory, the following sharp variation is satisfactory for Black: 13...♘xd4 14.♙xd4 e5 15.fxe5 dxe5 16.♙a7 ♞a8 17.g5 ♞d8 18.♖e2 ♘e8 19.♙e3 ♙e6 20.♙g4 ♘d6 21.♙xe6 fxe6.

14.g5 ♘d7 15.♙g2



15...♘xd4

This position has been seen many times in practice, and all sensible moves have been tested. Possible, for example, is 15...♘a5, with the idea of putting a knight on c4. Also possible are 15...g6 or 15...b6, continuing to develop and maintaining the tension.

16.♙xd4 b5

On the slow 16...b6, a promising reply is 17.♖h5, with the threat of ♞f1-f3 – the bishop on d4 helps the attack.

17.axb5 axb5

The direct attack on the king does not look dangerous, because Black is already prepared to play ...b5-b4, driving the white knight to a passive position. Therefore, taking account of the character of the position, which has become more

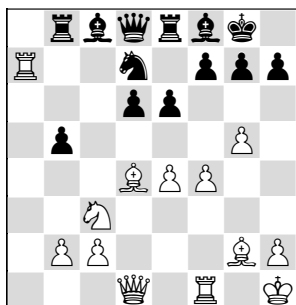
open, White uses all the scope of the board.

18. ♖a7!

Firstly, the rook enters the enemy camp with tempo.

18... ♖d8

18... ♖c6 allows an energetic assault on the light squares: 19.f5! ♖e5 (White also has the advantage after 19...b4 20.fxe6 fxe6 21.e5 d5 22.♗xd5! exd5 23.♖f3 ♖h8 24.♖f7 ♖g6 25.♖xg6 hxg6 26.♙xd5 ♖c5 27.♖xf8+ (27.♙f7 ♖e7 28.♖f4 ♖xf7 29.♖axf7 ♙b7+ 30.♙g1 ♖e6 31.♙a7 ♖xf4 32.♙xb8 ♙c5+ 33.♙f1±) 27...♖xf8 28.♙xc5 ♖f1+ 29.♙g2±) 20.g6! fxg6 21.fxg6 hxg6 22.♙xe5 dxe5 23.♖g4↑.



19.b4!

This way, the active square c3 is preserved for the knight.

19...e5 20. ♙e3

20.fxe5 ♖xe5 21.♙xe5 dxe5 ♖, with full compensation for the pawn sacrificed on f7.

20...exf4 21. ♙xf4 ♖e5 22. ♖d5 ♙g4

This move is made with the idea of dropping the bishop back via h5 to g6 – from there, the bishop both attacks e4 and defends f7.

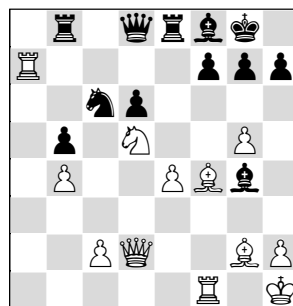
More natural is 22...♙e6 or 22...♙b7, with the idea of taking on d5 – White's advantage is minimal.

23. ♖d2 ♖c6?

Black probably counted on the rook moving away, in order simply to return to e5. However, the fact that f7 is undefended creates combinational motifs.

The logical follow-up to his previous move was 23...♙h5.

Nor was there anything wrong even with losing a tempo to put the bishop on its 'rightful' square e6: 23...♙e6±.



24.g6!! ♖xa7

Let us consider other possibilities:

A) 24...fxg6 25.♙g5 ♙e7 (25...♖c8 26.♖c7 ♖a6 27.♖c3+–) 26.♖xe7+ ♖xe7 27.♖f4+–;

B) 24...hxg6 25.♖xf7! ♙e6 26.♙g5 ♙e7 27.♖xe7+ ♖xe7 28.♖f4 ♖d7 29.♖xg7+! ♖xg7 30.♙f6+–;

C) The most tenacious is 24...f6, but here too, after 25.gxh7+ ♖h8 (25...♖xh7 26.♖a3+–) 26.♖a3!±, the weakness of the light squares around the black king allows us to consider White's advantage as close to decisive.

25.gxf7+ ♖h8

Zwischenzug

26. ♙g5!

Before taking back the rook, White exploits the chance of clearing the f-file with tempo.

26.fxe8 ♖ ♗xe8 27.♞e3±, followed by ♞f5, leads to a stable advantage, but White can justifiably count on a decisive attack.

26... ♗d7

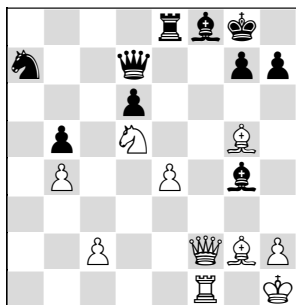
26... ♖e7 27.♞xe7 ♙xe7 28.♗f4+ – after the exchange of a pair of bishops, the passed pawn reaches the promotion square.

27.fxe8 ♖ ♖xe8

27... ♗xe8 28.♗f4 h5 29.♞f6!+–.

28. ♗f2 ♙g8

Dynamics – freeing lines and squares for the attack



White needs either to conclude the attack with the pieces he has involved in it, or else bring up some reserves. All of White's pieces are

taking part, except his light-squared bishop, so this is the one that needs to become involved:

29.e5!

A complicated and not very technical way of winning was offered by 29.♙e7 ♙xe7 30.♗f7+ ♞h8 31.♞xe7 ♙e6 (31... ♗d8 32.e5! dxe5 33.♙e4! – the threat of ♞e7-g6+ is unstoppable) 32.♗f8+ ♙g8 33.♞xg8 ♗d8 34.♗f7 ♞c6 35.♗b7 ♞e5 36.♞f6 gxf6 37.♗xb5+–. White is winning, but still has some work to do.

The same idea as in the game could also have been executed by 29.♞b6, and then 30.e5.

29...h6

A) 29... ♙e6 30.♞b6 ♗c7 31.♙d5 ♙xd5+ 32.♞xd5 ♗b7 33.♗f3+–;

B) 29... ♞c8 30.♞c7+–;

C) 29... dxe5 30.♞b6 ♗c7 31.♙d5+–.

30.♞b6 ♗c7 31.♙d5+ ♞h7

31... ♞h8 32.♗xf8+ ♖xf8 33.♖xf8+ ♞h7 34.♙e4+ g6 35.♙f6+–.

32.♙e4+ ♙g8 33.♞d5 ♗d7

34.♞e7+

Black resigned.

Additional material

Kasparov-Andersson, Tilburg 1981

Kasparov-Larsen, Tilburg 1981

Anand-Karpov, Las Palmas 1996

Karpov-Kasparov, Moscow Wch (match/16) 1985

Kasparov-A.Sokolov, Belfort 1988

Timman-Kasparov, Reykjavik 1988

Kasparov-Karpov, Linares 1992

Kasparov-Karpov, London Wch (match/6) 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, London Wch (match/8) 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, Leningrad Wch (match/16) 1986

Chapter 12

Prophylactic thinking. Fighting against the opponent's ideas

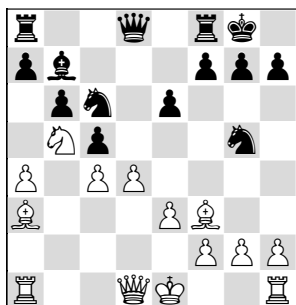
When playing a game, one must constantly ask oneself what the opponent wants. Even if everything is going swimmingly, one must bear in mind that the opponent never wants to be just a spectator, and will in any event seek whatever chances he can find. The ability to anticipate these plans and prevent them is what we mean by prophylactic thinking. This method of thinking is often very effective.

64

Mikhail Botvinnik

Vassily Smyslov

Moscow Wch match 1957 (13)



Black's main strategic aim is piece control of the light squares in the centre. White, naturally, has his own ideas about this:

15. ♖xc6! ♜xc6 16. f3

Now, the pawns on g2 and f3 restrict not only the black light-squared bishop, but also the knight on g5, which suddenly turns out to be very badly placed.

16... a6 17. ♘c3 f5 18. 0-0 ♚f6

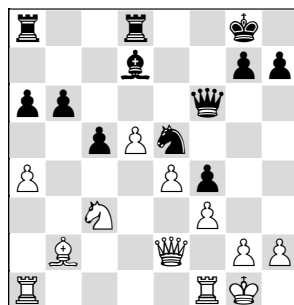
19. ♚d3 ♜fd8 20. d5 ♘f7 21. e4

All in accordance with the unwritten rule: place your pawns on the colour squares of your opponent's bishop,

*

so as to give your own bishop the maximum freedom. In addition, White has seized space.

21... exd5 22. cxd5 ♙d7 23. ♙b2
♜e5 24. ♚e2 f4



The blockade of the white central pawns does not look very secure.

25. ♘d1

White chooses a positional approach, but a tactical solution was also possible: 25. d6 ♚xd6 26. ♜fd1, followed by ♘c3-d5.

25... b5 26. ♘f2 c4

26... ♚d6 27. ♜fc1 ♘c4 28. ♜xc4 bxc4 29. ♚xc4±, with complete domination in the centre.

27. axb5 axb5 28. ♚d2

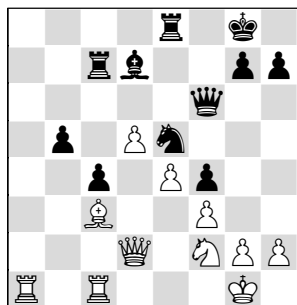
White has solidly blockaded his opponent's pair of connected

passed pawns, but Black has not done the same with White's. It is all a question of the difference in strength between the bishops.

28...♖ac8 29.♖fc1

Also good is 29.♖c3, and if 29...b4, then 30.♖xe5 ♖xe5 31.♖xb4 – the c-pawn is not going far.

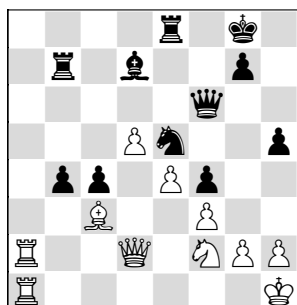
29...♗e8 30.♖c3 ♖c7



31.♗h1

White is in no hurry. This move is prophylaxis against ...♖f6-g5, when White no longer has to worry about the defence of f3.

31...♖b7 32.♖a2 h5 33.♖ca1 b4



This desperate attempt at counterplay does not succeed, but Black cannot do anything against the white rook's entering at a6 or a7 anyway.

34.♖xb4 ♖b6 35.♖c3 ♖e3 36.♗d1

♖xd2 37.♖xd2 ♗d3 38.♖d4 ♖eb8

39.♗c3 ♖b3 40.h4 ♖b7 41.♖a8+

Black resigned.

65

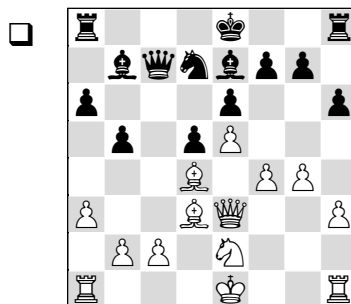
Konstantin Sakaev

2580

Andrei Sokolov

2580

Ulcinj 1997



Black's idea is simple and obvious – he wants to transfer his knight via c5 to e4. Under its cover, he will have sufficient counterplay, and the bishop on b7 will be fulfilling a very useful supporting function.

17.b4!

Now, White loses the chance of castling queenside, but he limits the scope of the black pieces, which is the most important factor in the position. The king, according to circumstances, can castle kingside or stay in the centre, as happens in the game.

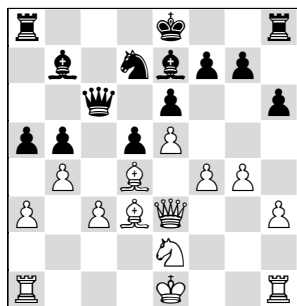
17...a5

On 17...♗b8, with the intention of fighting for the central files, there could follow 18.0-0! ♗c6 19.♖b6. Later, White is ready to exchange the knights on d4 and then put his bishop there, followed by the advance f4-f5.

18.c3!

18.♖b1 leaves Black with the a-file, and after the plausible variation 18...axb4 19.axb4 ♖h4 20.♗g3 ♖c6 21.0-0 0-0, he obtains definite counterplay.

18...♖c6



19.♔d2!

A far from obvious and not obligatory decision, but a strong one. The simple 19.0-0 also looked promising, and after 19...0-0, White has a whole range of ideas to develop his initiative. One possibility is 20.♖h2, preparing g4-g5, or 20.♘g3, planning f4-f5. He can also start a storm without castling, by playing 20.g5 or 20.f5. By comparison with castling, the advantage of having the king on d2 is that here, he does not interfere with operations on the kingside, and is still relatively safe.

19...0-0

Very risky, but it is hard to see another useful move for Black. On 19...axb4, there would follow 20.cxb4, and White starts to exert pressure on the c-file as well.

20.g5! hxg5

Bad is 20...h5, in view of 21.g6 fxg6 22.♗xg6 – the black king is in great danger.

21.fxg5

Black needs a great many moves to develop any play on the queenside, whilst White's play is quite simple – he wants to start an attack after the preliminary ♖h1-f1.

21...axb4 22.cxb4 ♖xa3

Black decides on a desperate sacrifice, but White easily extinguishes the initiative and retains his extra piece.

23.♖xa3 ♗xb4+ 24.♖c3 ♘b6
25.♗f3 ♗xc3+ 26.♘xc3 ♘c4+
27.♔e1 ♗c7 28.♔e2 b4 29.♗b5
♗d7 30.♖f1! g6

On 30...♗xb5, there follows 31.g6, and mate.

31.♗xg6 ♗a6 32.♗h5 fxg6
33.♗xg6+ ♗g7 34.♗xe6+ ♖h8
35.♖xf8+ ♗xf8 36.♗xa6 1-0

66

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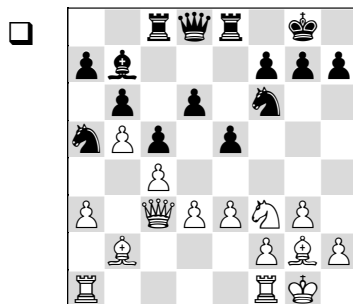
Konstantin Sakaev

2649

Sergey Azarov

2581

Moscow 2006 (5)



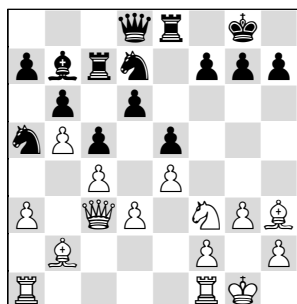
The knight on a5 is out of play and its only hope of returning is by means of the break ...d6-d5, so there followed

15.e4! ♘d7

The key moment in the game. What should White play? Black's second, active knight, is intending the route d7-f8-e6-d4. The knight cannot be tolerated there, and if White exchanges it on d4, Black will take with the c5-pawn, after which his knight on a5 can relocate via a5-b7-c5, and again become a worthwhile piece. Therefore, I took the decision to eliminate the knight,

even at the cost of my light-squared bishop. An important element in this decision was to realise that Black cannot play ...f7-f5, and exploit the weakness of the long diagonal a8-h1.

16. ♖h3! ♜c7



17. ♙xd7! ♜xd7 18. ♘h4 f6 19. ♘f5

The only real advantage White has here is the superior placement of his knight over that of Black's, but this turns out to be decisive. Black's position is lost.

19... ♙a8 20. ♘e3 ♘b7 21. f4 ♜b8 22. f5!

Continuing to play for the limiting of the black knight – now it is deprived of the square e6.

22... a5 23. ♜f2

White does not hurry to prepare the decisive advance of the g-pawn, as Black can do nothing to stop this.

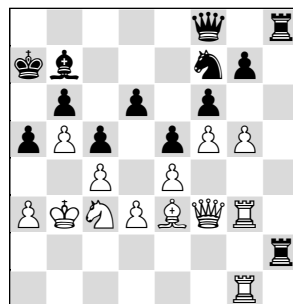
23... ♘d8 24. ♜c2 ♘f7 25. g4 ♘e7 26. h4 h6 27. ♜af1 ♘f7 28. ♙c1 ♜h8 29. ♘d1 ♜dd8 30. ♘c3 ♜h7 31. ♜f3 ♜dh8 32. ♘f2

Before the decisive breakthrough, it is useful to transfer the white king to the other flank, out of harm's way.

32... ♜d8 33. ♘e1 ♙b7 34. ♜g2 ♘d7 35. ♜g3 ♘c7 36. ♙d2 ♘b8 37. ♜f3 ♘a7 38. ♜fg1 ♜f8 39. ♘d1 ♜e7 40. ♘c2 ♜f8 41. ♘b3 ♜e7 42. ♙e3 ♜f8

All of White's pieces have been transferred to ideal positions, and it is time for the breakthrough.

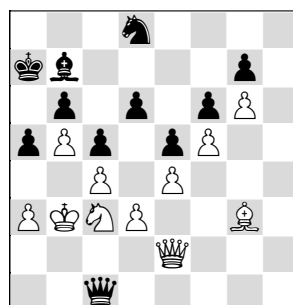
43. g5 hxg5 44. hxg5 ♜h2



45. g6!

Now, the black knight lacks any decent squares. White is not bothered by the fact that the position is so blocked, as after the exchange of major pieces, he will calmly go after the g7-pawn, which is undefended.

45... ♘d8 46. ♜g2 ♜h3 47. ♜g3 ♜h2 48. ♙f2 ♜h5 49. ♜g2 ♜xg2 50. ♜xg2 ♜h8 51. ♙g1 ♜h1 52. ♜e2 ♜h6 53. ♜h2 ♜xh2 54. ♙xh2 ♜c1 55. ♙g3



55... a4+

A desperation sacrifice.

56. ♘xa4 ♙c8 57. ♜e1 ♜g5 58. ♙h4 ♜h6 59. ♘c3 ♘b7 60. ♘c2 ♘a5 61. ♜g3 ♜h8 62. ♙xf6

The g-pawn promotes. Black resigned.

67

Loek van Wely

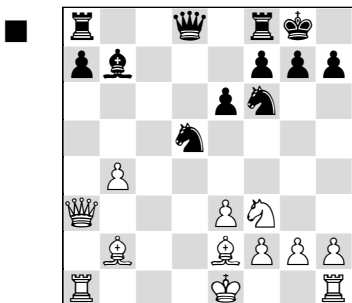
Ruslan Ponomarev

Khanty-Mansiysk 2005 (1)

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2648

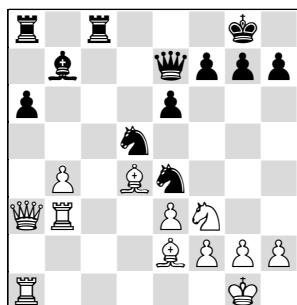
2704



If White manages to castle and activate his pieces, things could become difficult for Black, because White has the bishop pair. The pawn on b4 would like to advance at the first convenient moment. If this is permitted, the pawn on a7 will be fixed as a weakness and White will obtain the advantage. Therefore, Black frees his rook from the defence of the a7-pawn, and ensures that his pieces have possibilities of counterplay on the light squares.

15...a6! 16.0-0 ♖e7 17.♟f3 ♜fc8

18.♞d4 ♞e4 19.♞b3



19...♞c7!

On account of his excellent control of the light squares, Black's position

is slightly more pleasant, despite White's bishop pair.

20.♞b2 ♞d5 21.♞ba3 ♞ab8 22.♞b1 ♞b5 23.♞xb5

After 23.♞xa6 ♞xd4 24.♞xd4 ♞c3 25.♞ba1 ♞xb4 26.♞d2 ♞g5 27.♞f3 (27.♞f1? loses to 27...♞xd4! 28.♞xd4 ♞e2) 27...♞xe2+ 28.♞xe2 ♞g6, White still needs to show some accuracy to make a draw, despite the complete elimination of all the queenside pawns.

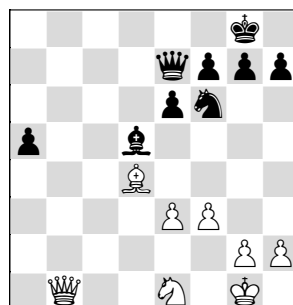
23...♞xb5

As well as tactical ideas involving the pin on the b-file, White also has to concern himself with positional threats, such as Black posting his pawns on dark squares with f6 and e5.

24.♞e1 ♞cb8 25.♞a4 a5 26.f3

Problems also remain after 26.♞d3 ♞g5 – the weakness of the light squares tells.

26...♞xb4 27.♞xb4 ♞xb4 28.♞c2 ♞xb1 29.♞xb1 ♞f6



30.♞b5

Correct is 30.♞a1! ♞c7 31.♞e5 (31.♞c3 a4 32.♞xf6 gxf6 33.♞xa4 ♞c1+) 31...♞c5 32.♞d4 ♞b5 33.♞xf6 gxf6 34.♞xf6 – because of the threats of perpetual check, Black has only limited chances of realising his advantage.

30...♖b4! 31.♗xb4 axb4 32.♘d3
b3 33.♙f2 ♘c4 34.♙b2 ♘b5 35.e4
♘d7 36.e5 h5 37.h4 ♘h7 38.g4
♙b8 39.♘d1 ♘c6 40.♘c3 g5!

With the help of this exchanging operation, Black opens the path for his king.

41.hxg5 hxg4 42.fxg4 ♘g6 43.♘g3
♘xg5 44.♙d2+ ♘g6 45.♘c3 ♘e2
46.♙b2 ♘e7 47.♙a4 ♘d5 48.♘b2
♘d3 49.♙d4 ♘c2 50.♘b2 ♘g7
51.♙d4 ♙f8 52.♙f2 ♙e7 53.♙e2
♙d7 54.♘d2 ♙c6 55.♘b2 ♘f4
56.♙e3 ♘d3 57.♙d4 ♙b5 58.♙b2
♙b4 59.♘d2 ♘c6 60.♘c3 ♙c5
61.♙a4+ ♘d5 62.♙e3 ♙d1 63.g5
♘h5 64.♘b2 ♘g6 65.♙b6+ ♙c5
66.♙c8 ♙b4 67.♙d6 ♙d3 68.♙d4+
♙d5 69.♙b5 ♙c4 70.♙d6+ ♙b4
71.♙xf7 ♙e1 72.♙d2 ♙f3+ 0-1

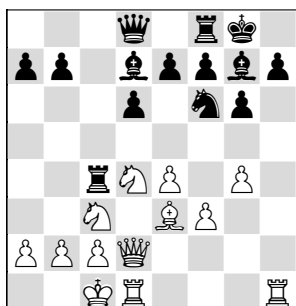
68

Anatoly Karpov
Viktor Kortchnoi

Moscow ct match 1974 (2)

2700

2670



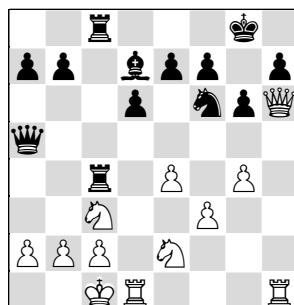
White's plan is understandable – to exchange dark-squared bishops and mate down the h-file. But some cunning is needed – the knight on d4 is attacked, and in many variations, Black will sacrifice the exchange on c3, destroying the white king's pawn protection.

16.♘de2!

A multi-purpose move, which combines attack and defence. From here, the knight defends its colleague and opens the d-file. It also has the prospect of jumping to g3, so as to exchange the Black knight, should the latter respond to g4-g5 by moving to h5, blocking the h-file.

Direct play does not achieve its goal: 16.♘h6 ♘xe4 17.♖e3 (17.♘xe4 ♗xd4 18.♖h2 ♘e5 19.♖h4 ♗xd1+ 20.♙xd1 f5 21.♙xf8 ♙xf8) 17...♗xc3 18.bxc3 ♘f6 leads to a position where Black is not being mated, whilst the doubled pawns on the c-file give Black good counterplay.

16...♖a5 17.♘h6 ♘xh6 18.♖xh6
♗fc8



19.♗d3!!

A brilliant prophylactic move. By strengthening the ♘c3, White frees the other knight for the attack.

19...♗4c5

The rook is a poor helper in defending the kingside.

More tenacious was 19...♘e6, although after 20.g5 ♘h5 21.♙f4 ♖e5 22.♙xh5 gxh5 23.♖xh5 ♖g7 24.f4, White retains a strong initiative.

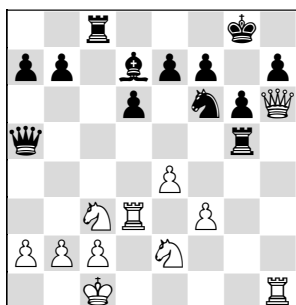
20.g5!

On 20.♙f4, there follows 20...e6!, and there is nothing immediately decisive (White wins nicely after

20...♙e6 21.♘xe6! fxe6 22.e5! dxe5
(22...♗xe5 23.f4 ♖ec5 24.g5 ♘h5
25.♗xh5 gxh5 26.g6 hxg6 27.♗xg6+
♙f8 28.♗g3+-) 23.g5 ♘h5 24.♗xh5
gxh5 25.g6 hxg6 26.♗xg6+ ♙f8
27.♗h6+ ♙f7 28.♗h7+ ♙f8 29.♖d7
♗e8 30.♗h8+ ♙f7 31.♗xh5+ ♙f8
32.♖d1 ♗xc3 33.♗h1 ♗xc2+ 34.♙xc2
♗c8+ 35.♙b1+-).

20...♗xg5

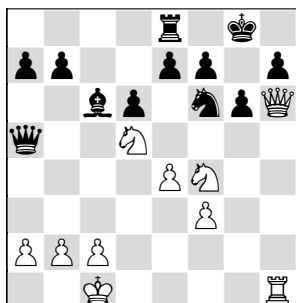
Nor has he any saving hopes after
20...♘h5 21.♘f4 ♗xc3 (21...♗xg5
22.♖d5+-) 22.bxc3 ♗e5 23.♘xh5
gxh5 24.♗xh5 ♗g7 25.f4.



21.♖d5! ♗xd5 22.♘xd5 ♗e8
22...♗d8 23.♘xf6+ exf6 24.♘f4+-.

23.♘ef4 ♙c6

23...♙e6 24.♘xe6 fxe6 25.♘xf6+ exf6
26.♗xh7+ ♙f8 27.♗xb7+-.



24.e5! ♙xd5
24...dxe5 25.♘xf6 exf6 26.♘h5+-.
25.exf6 exf6 26.♗xh7+ ♙f8
27.♗h8+ 1-0

69

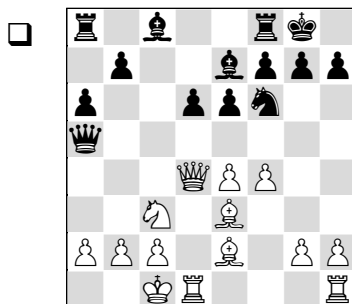
Viswanathan Anand

2715

Gata Kamsky

2710

Las Palmas match 1995 (11)

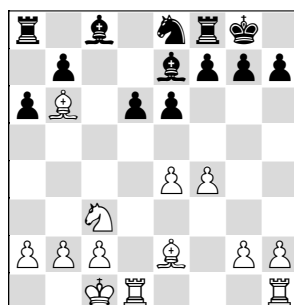


Black wants to play ...b7-b5, after which the standard threat of ...b5-b4 arises. The black pieces would then also acquire some convenient squares for development – the bishop can come to b7 and the rook to b8. White stops this:

12.♗b6! ♗xb6 13.♙xb6

Black cannot bring the bishop to d7, because of the break e4-e5, so he has to move backwards.

13...♘e8



If White now delays, Black will put his bishop on c6 and then return the knight to f6. So...

14.e5!

Not only demonstrating his advantage in development, but also limiting the scope of the knight at e8.

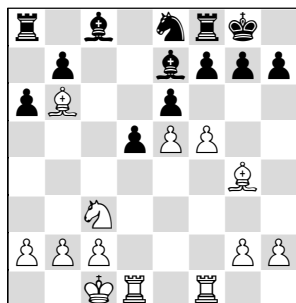
14...d5 15.f5!

White develops a middlegame initiative, even though the queens have been exchanged.

15...♙d7 16.♙g4!

By threatening to take on e6, followed by a blow on d5, White forces Black to retreat.

16...♙c8 17.♞hf1



The white pieces have developed maximum activity, whilst Black's still cannot get off the bank rank.

17...a5 18.♞a4 f6 19.fxe6 fxe5

20.♞c3 ♙g5+

20...♞xf1 21.♞xf1 ♞f6 22.♞xf6! ♙xf6 23.♞xd5 ♙g5+ 24.♙b1 h5 25.♙e2 ♙xe6 26.♞c7 also leaves no hope of survival.

21.♙b1 ♞f6 22.♞xd5 ♞xg4

23.♞xf8+ ♙xf8 24.♞c7 ♞a6

25.♙c5+ ♙g8 26.♞xa6 ♙xe6

26...bxa6 27.e7+–.

27.♞c7 ♙f5 28.h3 ♞f6 29.g4

♙e4 30.♞e6 ♙h4 31.g5 ♞d5

32.♞f1 h6 33.gxh6 gxh6 34.♞f8+

♙h7 35.♙d6! ♞b4 36.♙xe5

♙xc2+ 37.♙c1 ♙e4 38.♞f4!

♞d3+ 39.♞xd3 ♙xd3 40.♞h8+

♙g6 41.♙f4 ♙g5 42.♙xg5 ♙xg5

43.♞d2 ♙b5 44.♞a8 ♙a6 45.♞c8

♙h4 46.♞c5 a4 47.♞a5 h5 48.♙e3

♙f1 49.♞xa4 ♙xh3 50.♙f2

Black resigned.

70

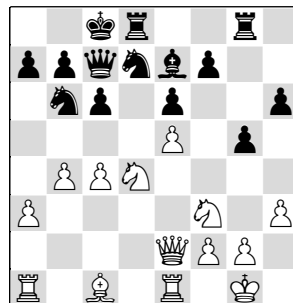
Yuri Balashov

Artur Jussupow

Minsk 1982 (1)

2595

2555



Black is short of space, but he only needs to get in ...g5-g4 for his pieces to come alive – the g-file would be open and his bishop would have some scope. White cuts off this active plan at the very roots, by observing the nuances of the pawn structure.

19.g4!

White exposes his king, but his strategic achievements are very substantial – the g-file is barricaded and the g5-pawn obstructs Black's own pieces.

19...h5

To open lines on the kingside, many tempi are needed, and White's attack is quicker.

20.♙d2 hxg4 21.hxg4 ♞f8 22.a4

♞g6 23.a5 ♞d7

Bad is 23...♞f4 24.♙xf4 gxf4 25.axb6 ♞xb6 26.♞c2 ♞xg4+ 27.♙f1 ♞h8 28.♞d3 – the king runs to e2.

24.a6 b6 25.♙c3 ♞h8 26.♞e4

♞h3 27.♞xc6 ♞dh8 28.♙d2 ♙c5

29.bxc5 ♞xc5 30.♞xa7+ ♞xa7

31.♞c6+

White has a decisive advantage.

71

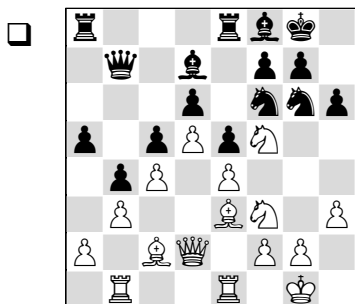
Nigel Short

Sergey Azarov

Calvia ol 2004 (12)

2687

2556



An example of what can happen if one follows one's own plans, without paying sufficient attention to the opponent's. In this position from the Spanish, White's typical plan involves advancing the g-pawn, and attacking along the opened lines on the kingside. Even so, Black's position is pretty solid, and his hopes are based on counterplay on the a-file, which he will seize in the future.

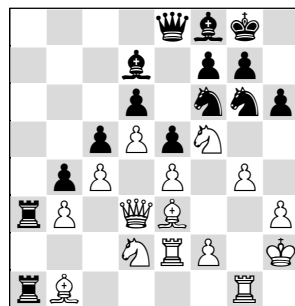
22.g4?!

Extremely direct. He should not have allowed the black rook to penetrate on the a-file, as this makes it very hard to attack on the kingside. He should therefore engage in prophylaxis: 22.a4!. Now, if Black does not react, there follows g2-g4!, whilst after 22... bxa3 23.♖a1 a4 (on 23...♗b4, there follows 24.♗d1, and then ♕e3-d2, driving the queen back) 24.♖xa3 axb3 (here, after 24...♗b4, a good move is 25.♖ea1, with tempo, enhancing the pressure on the queenside) 25.♖xb3 ♗a6 26.♗c3, thanks to his greater space, White retains a small, but lasting advantage.

22...a4 23.♖b2 axb3 24.axb3 ♖a3

Now, White has to combine his kingside initiative with defence on the queenside, and this is doomed to failure, as the game shows.

25.♖h2 ♖ea8 26.♗b1 ♖a1 27.♖g1 ♖8a3 28.♗c2 ♗c8 29.♗d3 ♗e8 30.♖e2 ♗a4 31.♗d2 ♗d7



32.♗c2?!

It was more sensible to agree to the repetition proposed by Black with the move 32.♗f3, but White is determined to stick with his planned attack.

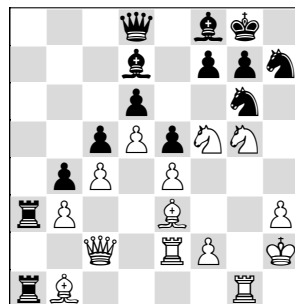
32...♗h7 33.♗f3 ♗d8 34.g5

The threat was ...♗h7-g5, starting play on the weakened dark squares on the kingside.

A) Slightly better was 34.♗c1 ♖a8 35.g5 hxg5 36.♗xg5 ♗f6;

B) The following sacrifice is incorrect: 34.h4 ♗xf5 35.exf5 ♗xh4 36.♗d2 ♗e7 – the knight on h4 is far from badly-placed.

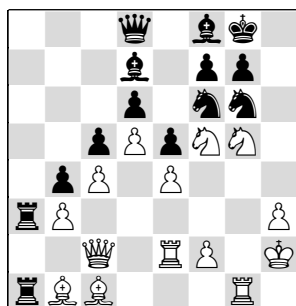
34...hxg5 35.♗xg5



35...♟f6!

The knight on g5 merely blocks White's play on the g-file, whilst the black knight is heading from f6, via h5-f4.

36.♙c1



36...♟h5!?

Not obligatory, but a correct exchange sacrifice, and very unpleasant for White.

37.♞e3

On 37.♙xa3 both 37...♞xa3 and 37...bxa3! are strong. Now, 38.♞c3 is not possible, because of 38...♞xb1 39.♟xf7 ♟xf7 40.♞xb1 ♟gf4, followed by ...g7-g6.

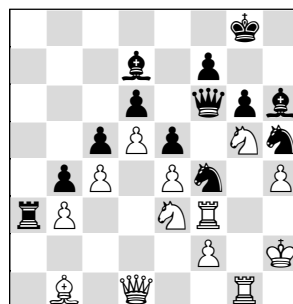
37...♞f6

One must always remain attentive! 37...♟gf4? would be a blunder, because of 38.♟h6+!

38.♞f3 ♟gf4 39.♟e3 g6 40.♙xa3 ♞xa3

Despite his exchange deficit, Black dominates completely.

41.♞d1 ♟h6 42.h4



42...♞h8!

The final element. White has no way to defend the h-file.

43.♙c2 ♟f6 44.♟h3 ♟xh3 45.♞xh3 ♟f4+ 46.♟g2 ♟xh3+ 47.♟xh3 ♟f8 48.♟g4 ♟g5 49.♟xf6 ♞xh4+ 50.♟g2 ♟xf6 51.♞h1 ♞g5+ 52.♟f1 ♞f4 53.♞h3 ♟g5 54.♟g2 ♟h4 55.♞f3 ♞g5+ 56.♟f1 ♞h5 57.♟d3 ♟g5 58.♙c2 ♞a1 0-1

Additional material

Gavrikov-Jussupow, Tunis 1985

Winter-Alekhine, Nottingham 1936 – Black's 13th move

Aronian-Jakovenko, Khanty-Mansiysk 2010 – Black's 21st move

Rowson-Cooper, Walsall 1997

Vaganian-Nogueiras, Montpellier 1985 – White's 20th move

Euwe-Alekhine, the Netherlands Wch (match/20) 1935 – White's 30th move

Kozlov-Kholmov, Bryansk 1987 – Black's 23rd move

Kortchnoi-Radulov, Leningrad 1973 – White's 23rd move

Chapter 13

Limiting the opponent's counterplay and piece manoeuvrability

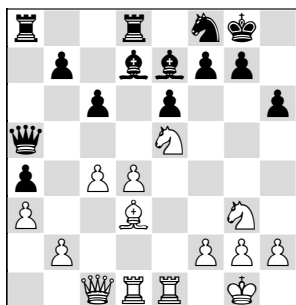
It sometimes happens that all of your pieces are well placed, but it makes no sense to create direct threats, since the opponent can easily meet them. In such cases, one needs to look at the board from a different standpoint – does the opponent have any concrete ideas? Let us assume that he does, and the position is totally quiet. In this case, it is useful to think about what potential break might prove unpleasant for you, and which enemy piece is the most active and represents the greatest threat to you. By cutting off at the roots some possible freeing break or limiting the scope of a key opponent's piece, one solves an important strategic task.

72

Alexander Alekhine

Lajos Asztalos

Kecskemet 1927 (2)



With his next move, White liquidates a possible line-opening break on the queenside and limits to a maximum the scope of the enemy pieces, especially his bishops.

19.c5! b5

If 19... c7 , with the idea of ...b7-b6, 20. d4 e8 21. b6 a7 22. c2 , winning the a4-pawn.

20. e4 c7 21. c3

White strengthens his position in the centre, not forcing events.

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21... e8 22. d2

From here, the knight can transfer to one of the squares where it will be extremely well placed, namely f4 or b4. Alternatively, it is ready to occupy e5, in the event of the other knight being exchanged.

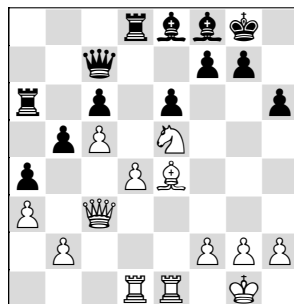
22... a6

He should have preferred 22...f6, ensuring at least a little bit of space.

23. d1 $\text{d7}??!$

On f8, the knight covered several light squares, so it should not have been exchanged.

24. xd7 xd7 25. d3 d8 26. e5 f8



27.h4!

Under cover of his strong centre, White starts an offensive on the kingside.

27...♖a8 28.♗b1 h5 29.♖f3 g6 30.g4! hxg4 31.♖xg4 ♗g7 32.♗a2!

Now, the pawn on f7 loses the chance to move forward. In addition, motifs arise, involving a knight sacrifice on g6.

32...b4 33.♗c4!

The bishop takes up an invulnerable position.

33...bxa3 34.bxa3 ♖a5 35.♖e4 ♖c7 36.♖f4 ♖ab8

Significantly stronger was 36...♖e7, and then ...♖e7-f6.

37.h5 gxh5 38.♖h1

The white attack is irresistible.

38...♖b7

38...♖h7 39.♖d3 f6 40.♖e4+ f5 41.♖h4+-.

39.♖g1 ♖e7 40.♖xg7+ ♖xg7

41.♖g1+ ♖h7 42.♖xf7

Black resigned.

73

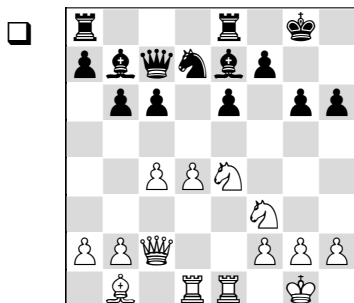
Predrag Nikolic

2490

Dragan Paunovic

2320

Yugoslavia-ch 1983



17.c5!

Now, the black bishop has no chance to get into the game, and White is

able quietly to develop his offensive on the kingside.

The hasty 17.h4 would be met by the bishop on b1 being restricted: 17...f5! 18.♖c3 ♗f6 – and many pieces are defending the black king. In addition, one would have to reckon the whole time with ...c6-c5, opening the diagonals for the two black bishops.

17...♖ad8

The attack with the rook's pawn

18.h4! h5

Not allowing h4-h5, but now White gets the square g5 for his knight.

19.b4 a5 20.♖eg5 ♗xg5

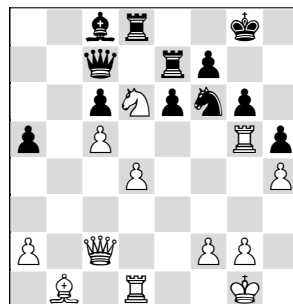
On 20...♖f8, White can strengthen his position with 21.a3, but even stronger is 21.♖b3!, after which the threat of ♖g5xf7 hangs over Black. For example, after 21...axb4 (White keeps extra material and a strong initiative after 21...♖d5 22.♗e4 axb4 23.♗xd5 cxd5 24.c6) 22.♖xf7 ♖xf7 23.♖e5+ ♖g7 24.♗xg6 ♖xg6 25.cxb6 ♖b8 26.♖g3 ♖xe5 27.♖xe5, White has a decisive advantage.

21.♖xg5 ♖f8 22.♖e4 ♖h7 23.♖d6

♖e7 24.bxa5 bxa5 25.♖e5

White prepares a decisive attack, with all his forces.

25...♖f6 26.♖g5 ♗c8



27.♖d3! ♘e8 28.♖dg3 ♖xd6
29.♖xg6+ fxg6 30.♗xg6+

In view of the unavoidable mate, Black resigned.

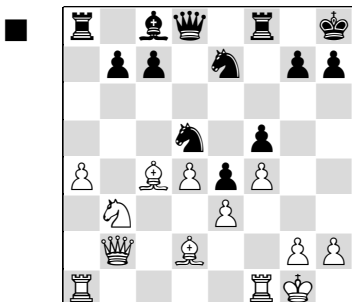
74

Alexey Sokolsky

Vassily Smyslov

Kuibyshev 1942 (10)

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White's knight and dark-squared bishop are poorly placed. The bishop belongs on the a3-f8 diagonal, and the knight should either be exchanged off as part of the fight for the square d5, or else head via c4 to e5. From Black's viewpoint, the exchange of light-squared bishops is clearly favourable, and with the move

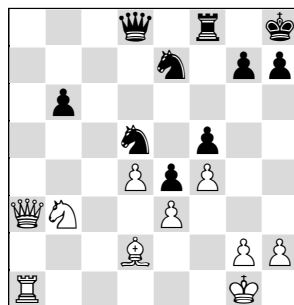
18...b6!

he not only prepares this, but also limits the scope of the knight on b3.

19.a5 ♕a6 20.♕xa6 ♖xa6 21.axb6
♖xa1 22.♖xa1 cxb6

The pawn on b6 is not a weakness, because it does a great job of limiting the white pieces, and is also a passed pawn with the potential to become a great strength.

23.♗a3



23...h6!

Both 'making luft' and preparing ...g7-g5 at the same time.

24.♗b4 ♘xb4 25.♗xb4 ♘d5
26.♗e1 g5 27.g3 gxf4 28.exf4 ♖g8
29.♖h1 ♗e8 30.♗e2 h5 31.♗f1
h4 32.♗h3 ♖g4 33.♘c1 ♗b5
34.♗g2 ♘xf4 35.♗f2 ♗c6 36.d5
♗xd5 37.♗b2+ ♖g7 38.♗b3 hxg3
39.hxg3 ♖h7+ 40.♖g1 ♗d4+

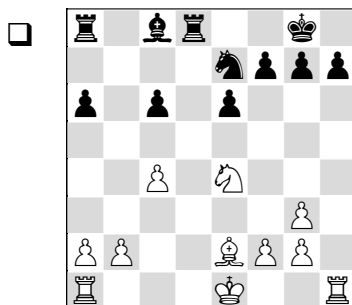
White resigned.

75

Training position

Konstantin Sakaev

*



White has the advantage, because Black has a bad bishop and several weak squares. The only possible counterplay is to transfer the knight to d4, and then strengthen it with the move ...e6-e5. This idea is prevented by the prophylactic

16.g4!

White now plans ♖a1-d1 and ♘e4-c5. If Black attacks the b2-pawn, White can just play b2-b3, with a clear advantage.

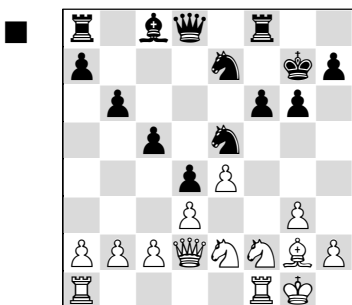
76

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Mark Taimanov

Leonid Stein

Tbilisi ch-URS 1966 (9)



The white knight is heading to f4. Under its cover, White can prepare an attack on the kingside, or stir up play in the centre with ♘f4-d5. Black exploits his chance to stop this plan.

15...g5!

The weakening of the king's cover is not felt at all, whilst at the same time, the white minor pieces remain passive for a long time.

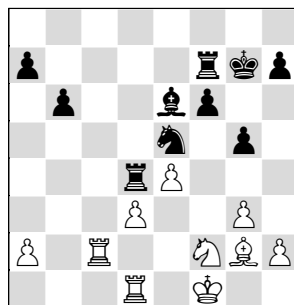
16.b4

This break is not supported by pieces, but White has no other counterplay.

16...cxb4 17. ♖xb4 ♘7c6 18. ♖b2 ♖d6 19. ♖ac1 ♙e6 20. c3 dxc3 21. ♖xc3 ♖ad8

The blockade of d4 is eternal and, thanks to the dreadful positions of his pieces on f2 and g2, White has no real hopes of saving the game.

22. ♖fd1 ♘d4 23. ♘xd4 ♖xd4 24. ♖xd4 ♖xd4 25. ♖c2 ♖f7 26. ♙f1



26...f5

It was also possible to strengthen the position even further, without sharp breaks: 26...♖fd7 27. ♙e2 ♖a4 28. ♖dd2 h5, increasing the pressure.

27. exf5 ♙xf5 28. ♙e2 ♘g4 29. ♖b2 ♘xh2 30. ♙e3 ♖a4 31. ♙e4 ♙xe4 32. ♘xe4 ♘g4+ 33. ♙d2 ♘f2 34. ♘xf2 ♖xf2+ 35. ♙c3 ♖a3+ 36. ♖b3 ♖axa2 37. ♖b5 ♙g6 38. ♖d5 ♖f5 39. ♖d6+ ♖f6 40. ♖d7 ♖g2 41. d4 ♖xg3+ 0-1

77

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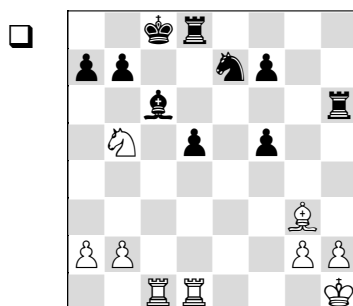
Sergey Rublevsky

2685

Bartłomiej Maciejka

2490

Polanica Zdroj 1998 (1)

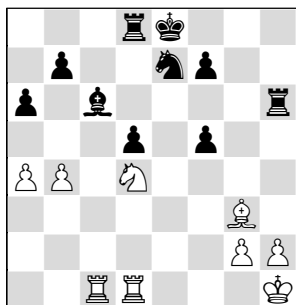


The linchpin of Black's defences is the bishop on c6, and Rublevsky starts to go after it.

27. b4! a6 28. ♘d4 ♙d7 29. a4 ♙e8?

A) Black loses after 29...b5 30. axb5 axb5 31. ♖e1, with various threats;

B) The best defence is attack, so Black should not go entirely passive, but should look for counterplay with 29...♖g8! 30.♙f4 ♜h4 31.g3 ♜xf4 32.gxf4 ♙xa4 – thanks to the limited amount of material remaining on the board, Black's chances of a draw are very high.



30.♙e1!

Black is completely tied up, and material losses are unavoidable.

30...♙d7 31.♜c7 ♙f8 32.♜xe7 ♙xe7 33.♜xf5+ ♙f6 34.♜xh6 ♙g6 35.♙h4 ♜c8 36.♜xc8 ♙xc8 37.♜g8

Black resigned.

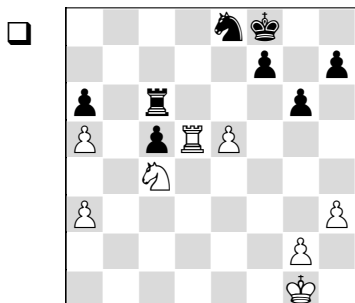
78

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Mikhail Botvinnik

Grigory Levenfish

Moscow match 1937 (8)



Black is ready to bring his king to the centre, after which he can activate the remainder of his pieces.

41.♜d7!

Preventing Black's plan.

41...♜c7

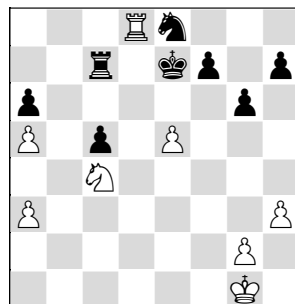
A) 41...f6 42.♜xh7 ♜g7 43.exf6 ♜xf6 44.♜h8+ ♙f7 45.♜c8±;

B) On 41...♜c7, there follows 42.♜d8+ (but not 42.♜d6 c4!) 42...♙g7 (42...♜e8? 43.♜d6+–; on 42...♙e7, White has prepared the cunning 43.♜d6!+–) 43.♜c8±, with a deadly pin on the black pieces.

42.♜d8

He should not be seduced by the pawn win 42.♜b6 c4! 43.♜xc7 ♜xc7 44.♜xc4 ♙e7 45.♙f2 ♙e6, with approximate equality.

42...♙e7



43.♜d6! ♜a7

A sad necessity, as the black rook moves to a passive position.

He cannot activate his position at the cost of the a6-pawn: 43...♜d7 44.♜xa6 ♜d4 45.♜b6 ♜c7 (45...c4 46.♜a8 ♜c7 47.♜c8+–) 46.♜a7 ♜d8 47.a6 c4 48.♜xc7! ♙xc7 49.a7 ♜d8 50.a8 ♜ ♜xa8 51.♜xa8+ ♙b7 52.♙f2 ♙xa8 53.♙e3 – the 'reserve' pawn at a3 plays a decisive role in this variation!

44.♜c6! ♙d7 45.♜b6!

Not 45.♜xc5? ♜c7!, and the black pieces activate sharply.

45...♙e7

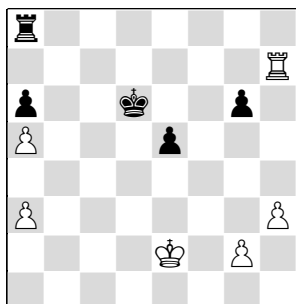
The purpose of luring the king to d7 is seen in the variation 45...♖c7 46.♙f6! ♜e7 47.♘d6±.

46.♜f2 f6! 47.♜e2 ♖a8 48.♙c6 fxe5 49.♙xc5

Black loses a pawn, whilst his pieces remain passive.

49...♘d6 50.♙c7+ ♜e6 51.♘xd6! 51.♙c6? ♜d5!.

51...♜xd6 52.♙xh7



52...♖b8?

For strict correctness, I should point out that there were still serious drawing chances available after 52...♜e6!. Now, I have not found a mathematically precise path to a win for White. He can immediately fasten onto the pawns on the 6th rank by 53.♙c7! (he should not fix the kingside, especially not the pawn on h3: 53.g4 g5!? 54.♙g7 ♜f6 55.♙c7 ♖h8!) 53...♖b8 54.♙c6+ ♜f5 55.♖b6 ♙c8 56.g4+ (56.♙xa6 ♙c2+ 57.♜f1 ♙c1+ 58.♜f2 ♙c2+ 59.♜g1 ♙c1+ 60.♜h2 ♖a1=; 56.♜d2 ♙d8+ 57.♜c2 (57.♜e3 e4=) 57...e4!) 56...♜g5 57.♙xa6 ♙c3 58.a4 ♙xh3 59.♖b6 ♙a3 60.♖b4 ♙c3 61.a6 ♙c6 62.a7 ♖a6=.

53.♙g7

After the fall of the g6-pawn, it is hard for Black to count on drawing the game.

53...♖b2+ 54.♜f1 e4 55.♙xg6+ ♜e5 56.♙xa6 ♖a2 57.♖a8 ♜f4 58.a6 ♖a1+

58...♜e3 59.g4 ♙xa3 60.a7 ♖a2 61.g5 ♙f2+ 62.♜g1 ♙f7 63.g6 ♙g7 64.♜h2+.

59.♜e2 ♖a2+ 60.♜d1

White has too much extra material.

60...♙xa3 61.a7 ♜e3 62.h4 ♙d3+ 63.♜c2 ♙d7 64.g4 ♙c7+ 65.♜b3 ♙d7 66.♜c3 ♙c7+ 67.♜b4 ♙d7 68.♜c5

Black resigned.

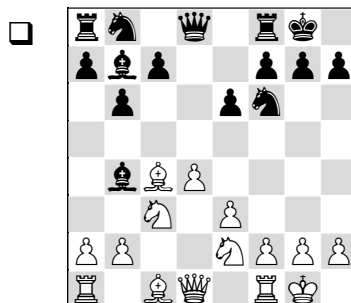
79

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Tigran Petrosian

Boris Spassky

Moscow Wch match 1969 (10)



In such pawn structures, the white knight is usually on f3 rather than on e2, and Black then has piece control of e4. In this example, however, White has the chance to limit the scope of the black bishop on b7, and this allows us to assess the position as being in White's favour.

9.f3! c5 10.a3 cxd4

10...♙xc3 11.bxc3 allows White to strengthen his pawn centre.

11.axb4 dxc3 12.♘xc3 ♘c6

On 12...a6, with the idea of ...b6-b5 and ...♘b8-c6, there would follow 13.♙xd8 ♙xd8 14.b5 axb5 15.♙xa8 ♙xa8 16.♘xb5 ♙d5 17.♙e2 ♙c8

18.♙d2 ♖c2 19.♖c1 – Black will not manage to exchange light-squared bishops, which means that, once he has played e3-e4, White will increase his advantage.

13.b5 ♘e5

Little changes after 13...♘a5 14.♙e2 – the black pieces are as restricted as in the game.

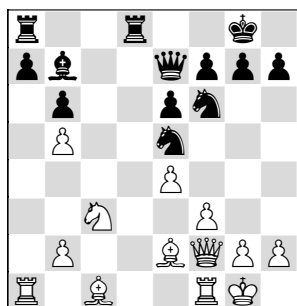
14.♙e2 ♖c7 15.e4 ♗fd8 16.♖e1 ♖c5+

If 16...♘fd7 17.♖g3, the pin on the knight looks unpleasant;

However, it made sense at the first opportunity to exchange one of the white bishops, by playing 16...♘d3 17.♙xd3 ♖xd3 18.♖e2 ♗d7 19.♙g5 ♘e8, and although Black's position is worse, it is fully defensible.

17.♖f2 ♖e7

Here, the strategy of simplifying does not work, as after 17...♖xf2+ 18.♙xf2 ♘d3+ 19.♙xd3 ♖xd3 20.♙e3, White is ready to strengthen the pressure on the a-file.



18.♖a3 ♘e8

More tenacious is 18...♘fd7, aiming to get the knight to c5.

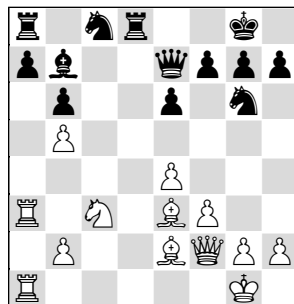
19.♙f4 ♘g6

19...♘d3 20.♙xd3 ♖xd3 21.♖fa1 leads to the loss of the pawn on a7, and then that on b6 as well.

20.♙e3 ♘d6

The attempt to go active does not bring anything; after 20...♖b4, the simplest reply is 21.♖b1, and then ♖a3-a4, driving the queen back.

21.♖fa1 ♘c8



22.♙f1!

Such moves, lacking any concrete threats, are especially unpleasant for the defender, who lacks counterplay. Black has to fight not against any specific threats, but just with the consequences of the irreparable weaknesses in his pawn structure – his queenside is under attack, and his minor pieces lack normal squares for operation.

22...f5

As often happens in such cases, Black cannot stand the pressure and lashes out in search of activity, despite his own pieces not being ready for it. As a result, such play just accelerates the defeat.

It was essential to be patient; more tenacious was 22...e5, with the idea of transferring the knight from g6 to e6.

23.exf5 exf5 24.♖a4

Yet another defect has appeared in Black's camp – the pawn on f5, which exposes his king and weakens a group of dark squares.

24...♖e8 25.♙d2 ♖c5

Accelerating the defeat, but Black's position was already very bad.

26. ♖xc5 bxc5 27. ♜c4 ♜e5 28. ♘a4 a6 29. ♘xc5 axb5 30. ♘xb7 ♜xa1 31. ♜xc8+ ♚f7 32. ♘d8 ♚e7 33. ♘c6+ ♚d7 34. ♘xe5+ ♚xc8 35. ♘xg6 hxg6 36. ♙c3 ♜b1 37. ♚f2 b4 38. ♙xg7

Black resigned.

80

Peter Svidler

Jeroen Piket

Tilburg 1998 (2)

**

2710

2605



All of Black's pieces are passively placed. The only possible plan to activate his position is to transfer the knight via a6 to c5, and the bishop via d8 to b6. As for the white pieces, the only one which is not playing actively is the light-squared bishop. It is 'looking' at the kingside, but it can only exert real pressure there by means of the pawn sacrifice e4-e5, which is not yet possible. Therefore, White agrees to exchange it, obtaining in return unopposed pressure on the c-file and the square c6 for his rook, from where it stops the enemy bishop activating.

29. ♙d3!

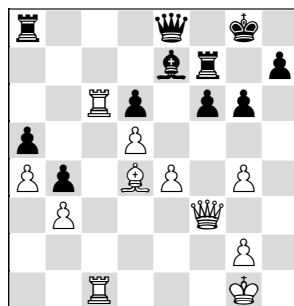
If 29. ♙h6, Black should sacrifice the exchange with 29... ♘a6! 30. ♙xf8

♜xf8 – White's material advantage means he still stands better, but Black can count on activating his pieces and getting counterplay on the dark squares. When one has a choice of how to realise an advantage, it is best to choose the line in which the opponent has fewest counterchances.

29... ♘a6 30. ♙xa6! ♜xa6 31. ♜c6 ♜a7+ 32. ♙e3 ♜d7 33. ♜fc1 ♜a8 34. ♜c7 ♜e8 35. ♙d4 ♙d8 36. ♜7c6 ♙e7 37. ♜c7

White saves time before the time control by repeating moves, a typical device in situations where the opponent has no counterplay, and there is no need to rush with a decisive strengthening of the position.

37... ♙d8 38. ♜7c6 ♙e7



39. ♜1c4

With this move, White over-protects the pawn on e4. In addition, when the queen comes to f4, Black will have to reckon on the threat ♜f4-c1 and ♜c6-c8.

39...h6

Black wants to put his king on h7, off the dangerous back rank, at the same time defending against the possible break g4-g5. However, this does not help, as with his pieces so

passive, Black always has some other problem to worry about.

40. ♖c7 ♘d8 41. ♗f7 ♖c6 ♘e7 42. ♖c7 ♘d8 43. ♖xf7 ♗xf7 44. ♗f4 ♗d7

No better is 44... ♗f8 45. ♖c6 ♘e7 46. ♘b6, with the threat of ♘b6-c7.

45. ♖c6 ♘e7 46. ♗xh6 ♗xg4 47. ♖c7

Black resigned, since on 47... ♗xe4, there follows 48. ♘xf6.

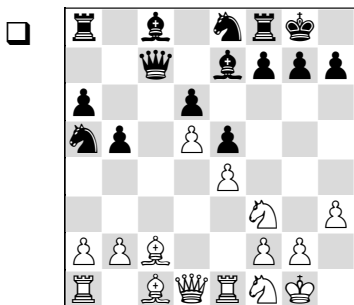
81

**

Isaak Boleslavsky

Igor Bondarevsky

Soviet Union tt 1951



White's chances are associated with play on the queenside, in particular the idea of seizing the c-file. But first, it is useful to limit the knight, which is stuck on the edge of the board:

16.b3! g6

Black, in his turn, counts on getting in ...f7-f5 – he has no other source of counterplay.

17. ♘e3 ♘g7 18. ♘d2 ♘b7 19. ♖c1 ♘d7 20.b4!

Continuing the strategy of restricting the black knight.

20... ♖ac8 21. ♘g4!

White plays all over the board, preparing to meet ...f7-f5 with all measures.

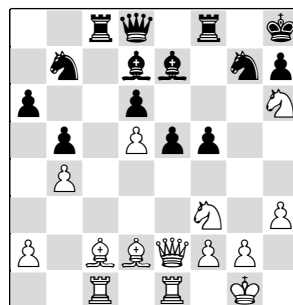
21... ♗d8 22. ♗e2 f5

Black has no other active plan, but the opening of lines proves to be in White's favour, principally because of the bad position of the knight on b7.

23.exf5 gxf5

In the event of 23... ♘xf5, White also retains a clear advantage, thanks to his firm control of the light squares.

24. ♘h6+ ♘h8



25.g4!

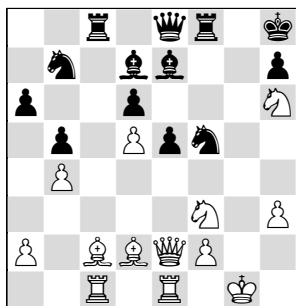
Opening up the light squares in Black's camp is White's primary strategical goal. In doing so, the exposure of his own king turns out not to be important, thanks to the excellent coordination of his pieces. White's security is enhanced by the misplaced black knight on g7.

25... ♗e8

Attempting to bring the rook over to the battle on the kingside does not help: 25... ♖c4 26.gxf5 ♘xf5 27. ♘xf5 ♘xf5 28. ♘xe5! dxe5 29. ♗xe5+ ♘f6 30. ♗xf5 ♘d6 31. ♗e6, with a decisive advantage.

26.gxf5 ♘xf5

26... ♗h5 27. ♘g5! ♘xg5 28. ♗xh5 ♘xh5 29. ♘xg5+–.



27. Qxe5!

White also wins with 27. Qxf5 Qxf5 28. Qxe5!+–.

27... Qd4

A) 27... dxe5 28. Qxe5+ Qf6 29. Qxe8 Qxe8 30. Qxf5;

B) 27... Qxh6 28. Qxd7 Qxd7 29. Qxe7+–;

C) 27... Qxc2 28. Qxc2 Qd4 29. Qef7+ Qxf7 30. Qxf7+ Qxf7 31. Qxe7+–.

28. Qe4! Qxc2 29. Qxd7 Qxe1

30. Qxf8 Qxf8 31. Qxc8 Qxc8

32. Qxe1 Qg7 33. Qe6

Black resigned.

82

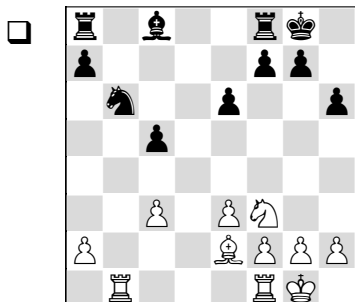
Anatoly Karpov

Garry Kasparov

Moscow Wch match 1984 (27)

2705

2715



The pawn structure is practically symmetrical, whilst White's advantage in piece activity is barely perceptible, as there are no

penetration squares available on the open files. So, the position is close to equality, but Black still needs to show accuracy to achieve this completely. White's task is make it as hard as possible for the opponent to find the best set-up for his pieces.

17. Qfc1!

A non-concrete, but at the same time, multi-purpose move. White over-protects c3, against a possible future attack from the black knight. Later, the rook will support the pawn on c4, from where it will restrict the black bishop. The rook move also frees a path to the centre for the white king.

The move 17. Qfd1 would just provoke exchanges, which would lead to a draw after the obvious 17... Qb7 18. Qe5 Qfd8.

17... Qb7

From here, the bishop surveys the kingside and centre, but Black's potential problems are on the queenside. Therefore, more accurate was 17... Qd7 18. Qe5 Qfd8, not fearing the exchange on d7, and freeing the square e8 for the bishop, whilst the king can come to e7.

18. Qf1 Qd5

Here, the bishop will be attacked with tempo, and therefore Black should have preferred 18... Qfc8 19. Qb5 Qc7, when his rooks occupy excellent defensive positions.

19. Qb5 Qd7

On 19... Qfc8 there would follow 20. c4, with the unpleasant idea of transferring the knight via d2 to b3.

20. Qa5 Qfb8

If 20... Qfc8, 21. Qd2. Then, White plays either c3-c4, or e3-e4 and

f2-f3, limiting Black's light-squared bishop, and preparing ♖d2-b3.

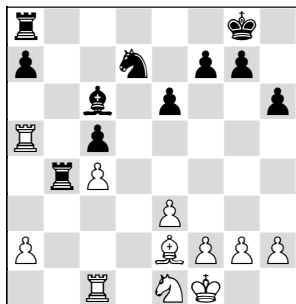
21.c4 ♖c6

**Schematic thinking –
determining the best position for
one's pieces**

22.♗e1!

Here already, after 22.♗d2, Black was ready to penetrate with 22...♞b2, so the white knight heads not to b3, but to d3.

22...♞b4



23.♙d1!

Of course, White does not allow his active rook to be exchanged off, as would happen after 23.♗d3 ♞a4.

23...♞b7 24.f3!

Continuing the strategy of containing the black pieces, especially his bishop.

24.♗d3 ♙e4 25.♗xc5 ♗xc5 26.♞xc5 ♞b2 allows Black to equalise, thanks to the activity of his rook on b2.

24...♞d8 25.♗d3

The pawn on c5 is annexed, and the game moves into the technical phase.

**25...g5 26.♙b3 ♗f8 27.♗xc5 ♗xc5
28.♞xc5 ♞d6 29.♙e2 ♙e7 30.♞d1
♞xd1 31.♗xd1 ♗d6 32.♞a5 f5
33.♙e2 h5 34.e4!**

The kingside, where Black will try to organise counterplay, now becomes an object of attack.

**34...fxe4 35.fxe4 ♙xe4 36.♞xg5
♙f5 37.♙e3 h4 38.♗d4 e5+
39.♗c3 ♙b1 40.a3 ♞e7 41.♞g4 h3
42.g3 ♞e8 43.♞g7 ♞f8 44.♞xa7 ♞f2
45.♙b4 ♞xh2 46.c5+ ♗c6 47.♙a4+
♗d5 48.♞d7+ ♙e4 49.c6 ♞b2+
50.♙a5 ♞b8 51.c7 ♞c8 52.♙b6
♙e3 53.♙c6 h2 54.g4 ♞h8 55.♞d1
♙a2 56.♞e1+ ♗f4 57.♞e4+ ♗g3
58.♞xe5 ♗xg4 59.♞e2 1-0**

Additional material

Alekhine-Bogoljubow, Wiesbaden Wch (match/5) 1929

Gurgenidze-Polugaevsky, Tbilisi 1956 – White's 17th move

Garcia-Sigurjonsson, Cienfuegos 1975 – Black's 21st move

Amos-Karpov, Mayaguez 1971

Shirov-Adams, Wijk aan Zee 1996 – White's 19th move

Miles-Nikolac, Wijk aan Zee 1979 – White's 48th move

Navara-Kramnik, Prague rapid (match/8) 2008

Gelfand-Miles, Amsterdam 1988 – White's 16th move

Hort-Karpov, Amsterdam 1981 – White's 14th move

Dorfman-Nogueiras, Moscow 1990 – White's 11th move

Zakharov-Dvoretzky, Ordzhonikidze 1978 – Black's 29th move

Hübner-Kortchnoi, Solingen (match/1) 1973 – Black's 18th move

Szabo-Petrosian, Stockholm 1952 – White's 26th move

Suetin-Polugaevsky, Sarajevo 1965 – White's 28th move

Chapter 14

Prophylaxis, strengthening one's own position

This theme is closely connected with the previous one, because prophylaxis and strengthening one's own position frequently entail limiting the opponent's potential possibilities. But it happens here not so much for the specific purpose of containing the opponent, but with the aim of improving one's own position. To do this, one often has to improve an unstably-placed piece, sometimes 'make luft', or simply correct one's structure. It is important to be able correctly to identify the element which needs improving.

83

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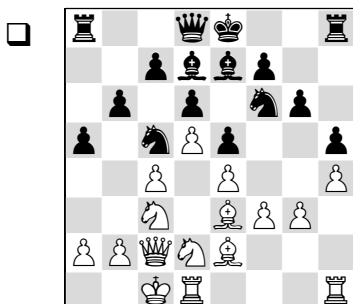
Artur Jussupow

2665

Ivan Hausner

2400

Germany Bundesliga 1996/97 (1)



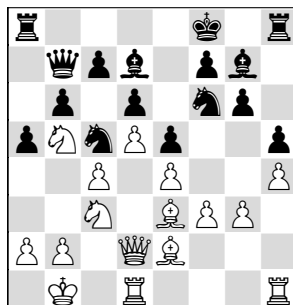
17. ♖db1!

Improving the position of his worst-placed piece. The knight heads on the route b1-a3-b5. The move 17. ♖b3 was also possible, but why exchange pieces when the opponent's position is cramped?

17... ♜c8 18. ♘a3 ♙f8 19. ♚d2!

Not allowing the bishops to be exchanged via h6.

19... ♙g7 20. ♘ab5 ♙f8 21. ♙b1 ♜b7



22. ♙f1!

But it is useful for White to exchange the light-squared bishops.

22... ♜e8 23. ♙h3 ♙xh3 24. ♜xh3 ♘g8 25. g4!

Beginning a direct attack on the king. On the queenside, Black completely lacks counterplay, because of the position of the knight on b5.

25... ♘f6 26. ♚g2 ♘d7 27. gxh5!

It is essential for White to open lines on the side where he is attacking. The weakening of his structure is purely temporary in this case. It is obvious that Black cannot eventually prevent the advance h4-h5, with a final demolition of his kingside.

27... ♜xh5 28. ♘e2 ♙h6 29. ♙xc5

29.♙xh6 ♖xh6 30.h5! looks equally strong.

29...bxc5 30.♘g3 ♜f6 31.♞hh1 ♜a8
32.♞d3 ♞e7 33.♞b3 ♞c8 34.♞a3
♜d8 35.♞f2 ♞a6 36.♞e1

White is in no hurry to grab the exchange, so as to prevent the activation of the black forces. The rook is not going anywhere!

36...♞a8 37.♞a4 ♙f4 38.♜xh5
♜xh5 39.♞g1 ♙h6 40.♞g2! ♙f4
41.♞c2

White has identified a weakness in Black's camp – the pawn on a5, and so he brings his second rook to a3.

41...♙g3 42.♞h1 ♞c8 43.♞c3 f5
44.♞ca3 fxe4 45.fxe4 ♞g4 46.♞xa5
♞xa5 47.♞xa5 ♞e2 48.♜c3 ♞d3+
49.♞a1 ♜f4 50.♞d1 ♞xd1 51.♜xd1
♙xh4 52.♞a8+ ♜d7 53.a4!

The pawn on a4 will soon become a queen. Black resigned.

84

Lev Polugaevsky

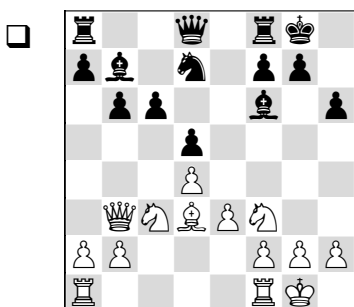
2645

Anthony Saidy

2425

Tallinn 1973 (4)

**



Black regroup his forces, but too late. Relatively best was 16...♘f6 17.e4 dxe4 18.♘e5 ♘d5 19.♙xe4 ♖d6 20.♙b1! (20.♖c2!? ♙f6 21.♙h7+ ♔f8 22.♘e4 ♖c7 23.♘xf6 ♘xf6 24.♙d3±; but not 20.♘xc6? ♘xc3 21.♖xc3 ♙f6, and the initiative passes to Black) 20...g6! (he loses after 20...♙f6? 21.♖c2 g6 22.♘xf7 ♔xf7 23.♖xg6+ ♔f8 24.♖xh6++-) 21.♖c2 ♔g7 22.♙a2 ♙f6 23.♘e4 ♖e6 24.♘xf6 ♖xf6 25.♙xd5 cxd5 26.♞e3, with a clear advantage to White.

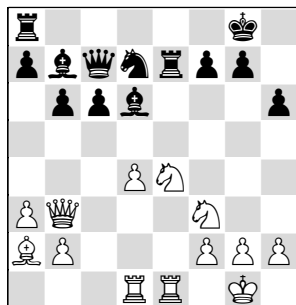
17.e4! dxe4 18.♘e4 ♞e7

Other moves do not save the game either:

A) 18...♘f8 19.♙a2 ♘e6 20.♘e5 ♙xe5 21.dxe5 ♞e7 22.♘d6±;

B) 18...♞f8 19.♖d3! g6 20.♘e5! ♙xe5 21.dxe5 ♘xe5 22.♘f6+ ♔g7 23.♖c3 ♔xf6 24.♞xe5 ♖xe5 25.♙d6++-.

19.♙a2 ♖c7



20.♘eg5!

An easy tactic to find, arising naturally out of the plan White has implemented, and Black's unsuccessful defensive manoeuvres.

20...♘f6 21.♞xe7 ♖xe7 22.♖xf7+ ♔h8 23.♘e5

Black resigned.

85

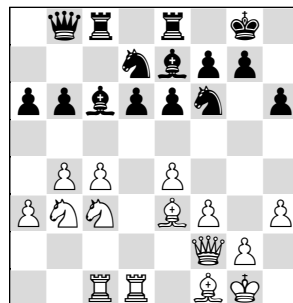
Lev Polugaevsky

2635

Ljubomir Ljubojevic

2590

Bugojno 1980 (5)



We have a position of the type known as the 'Hedgehog'. Black arranges his pawns along the 6th rank, and is ready for any breakthrough. White's usual plan in such positions is to organise a break on the queenside, in particular starting with the advance of his a-pawn. At the same time, White must never forget that the hedgehog is an active animal, ready at any moment to break out with ...d6-d5, or ...b6-b5. To prepare the advance of the a-pawn, Polugaevsky regroup his forces.

20.♞b1!

The rook moves opposite the black queen, reminding her of the possibility of the b-file opening up.

20...♖c7

20...b5? 21.cxb5 axb5 22.♘a5 leads to material losses.

21.♞dc1! ♖a7?!

The queen dithers about, but the a7-square is not the one for her.

A) 21...♖b8 22.a4 ♙b7 23.a5±;

B) The correct plan was to start counterplay on the opposite side of the board, although admittedly, after 21...♖d8! 22.a4 ♘h5!? 23.a5

bxa5 24. ♖xa5 ♕a8 25. ♖d1±, White still has the advantage.

22.a4! d5

This attempt to exploit the fact that the b4-pawn is undefended does not work.

On the other hand, it is not easy to know what to suggest for Black: 22... ♖b8 23.a5 bxa5 24. ♖xa5 ♕a8 25.b5!± makes the black queen understandably nervous.

23.exd5

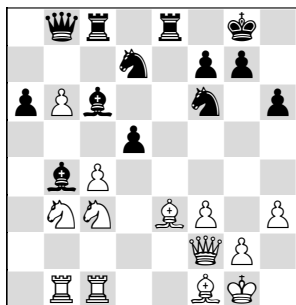
Even stronger was the immediate 23.a5! dxe4 (23... dxc4 24.axb6 ♖a8 25. ♖a5±) 24.axb6 ♖a8 25. ♖a5 exf3 26. ♖xc6 ♖xc6 27.c5±.

23...exd5 24.a5 ♕xb4?

More tenacious was 24...dxc4! 25.axb6 ♖b8 26. ♕xc4 ♕xb4 27. ♕xa6 ♕b7, with chances of regaining the b6-pawn.

24... ♕d8 25.cxd5±.

25.axb6 ♖b8



26.c5!

Black's position is hopeless.

26... ♕b7 27. ♕d4 ♕e6 28. ♖a2! ♕a3 29. ♖c3 ♖d8 30. ♖a5 ♕xc5 31. ♕xc5 ♖xc5 32. ♖xc5 d4 33. ♖xb7 ♖xb7 34. ♖c7 ♖b8 35. ♖xb7 ♖xb7 36. ♖c8+ ♖h7 37. ♕d3+ g6 38. ♖c7 ♖xb6 39. ♖xf7+ ♖g8 40. ♖b7 ♖xb1+ 41. ♖xb1

Black resigned.

86

Konstantin Sakaev

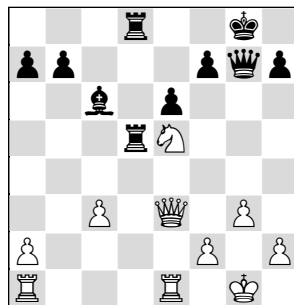
Lars Schandorff

Copenhagen 2005 (7)

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2669

2519



White's advantage is minimal. The pawn on g3 definitely weakens the light squares, but Black is not currently able to exploit this. Black, in his turn, has a somewhat weakened king, which is also impossible to exploit right now. In addition, one can assess the position as safe for White, partly because the black rooks do not have squares to infiltrate.

21. ♖f4!

Not allowing the black queen to f6, where she will be significantly more active. White does not have to exchange on c6, creating a symmetrical position and effectively agreeing to a draw.

21...a5?!

Black places the pawn on a defended square, but this proves to be a mistake, as later, the weakening of the b6-square tells.

A) The dangers Black can face are illustrated by the variation 21... ♖d2 22. ♖ab1 ♖xa2 23. ♖ed1 ♖f8 24. ♖xc6 bxc6 25. ♖b8 h6 26. ♖dd8 ♖xd8 27. ♖xd8+ ♖h7 28. ♖d7 ♖a1+ (he loses after 28... ♖g8 29. ♖b8+ ♖h7 30. ♖b1+!)

29.♔g2 ♕g8 30.c4 – Black risks losing the c6-pawn, which, combined with his weakened king, causes him problems;

B) It was essential to remove the tension between knight and bishop, by playing 21...♖e8!. Then, play might continue along lines such as 22.♖ab1 b6 23.♘g4 ♕h8 24.♘f6 ♖f5 25.♘xe8 ♖xc3 26.♖c7 ♖f3 27.♖xd8 ♖xf2+ 28.♕h1 ♖f3+, with a draw by perpetual check.

22.h4!

A typical device. The h-pawn is not needed to defend the white king, but it can do a good job in the attack. Now, the threat of h4-h5-h6 hangs in the air, and if Black himself plays ...h7-h6, the knight could appear on g4 at any moment.

22...h5?!

The further advance of the white h-pawn is stopped and the g4-square denied to the white knight, but this move weakens his king further. In addition, with a light-squared bishop, Black should try to avoid fixing pawns on light squares. So, it would be good to play something like ...b7-b6, ...h7-h6, or ...f7-f6 and ...e6-e5. Furthermore, the previous move with the a-pawn is out of place, since on a7, the pawn would perform the important task of defending b6.

23.♖ab1

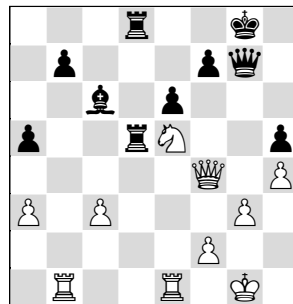
Now, the white rook can penetrate along the b-file at any moment.

23...♖d2 24.a3

White is in no hurry, and can quietly place this pawn on a safe square, as Black has no active moves anyway.

24...♖d5

Black simply waits for White to go over to active operations.



25.♕h2!

The king steps off the back rank, where he may be subject to checks.

25...♖d2 26.♖b6!

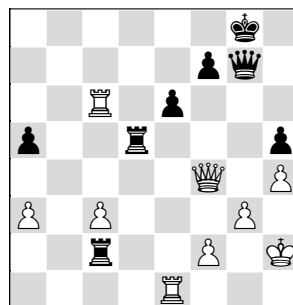
This is where the move 21...a5 is felt – White is able to approach one of the linchpins of the black position, the ♖c6.

26...♖c2

Bad is 26...♖d6 27.♖eb1, and White also threatens the sacrifice 28.♖xb7!.

27.♘xc6 bxc6 28.♖xc6 ♖d5?

Black's desire to put the rook on f5 is understandable, but this loses at once. Correct was 28...♖dd2 29.♖c8+ ♕h7 30.♖f1, and Black faces a long battle for a draw.



29.♖xe6! fxe6

No better is 29...♖xf2+ 30.♖xf2 fxe6 31.♖xe6.

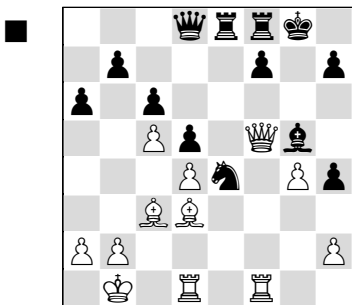
30.♖c8+ ♕h7 31.♖e4+

On 31...♖g6, there follows 32.♖c7+ ♕h6 33.♖f4+. Black resigned.

87

Sergey Iskusnikh
Vladimir Malakhov
Russia tt 2012 (1)

2480
2705



The bishop on g5 cements the black kingside, and by strengthening it with

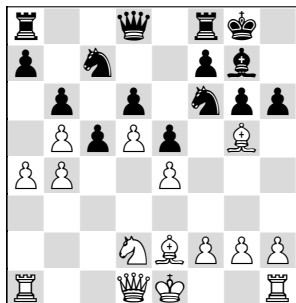
28...h6!

he could have prepared to improve his whole position subsequently, with ...f7-e6, ...g8-g7, ...d8-e7, ...f8-e8, etc. In this case, Black's advantage would grow with every move.

In the game, Black rushed things, and after 28...f6, White, with the help of the neat tactic 29. g4! fxe4 30. g5! e7 31. g6!, managed to get his bad bishop into play and equalised the game.

88

Tigran Petrosian
Herman Pilnik
Amsterdam ct 1956 (6)



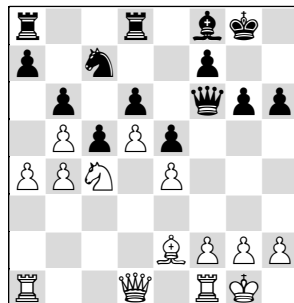
White's dark-squared bishop is attacked. He decides to exchange it.

14. gxf6!

In parting with his bishop, White has subtly realised that its opposite number cannot become active, as even ...h6-h5 followed by ...g7-h6 does not help much. Meanwhile, the exchange eliminates the knight, which could exert pressure on e4. Strengthening e4 is important in this particular position, as well as being a key idea in King's Indian positions generally.

If the bishop retreats, 14. g3, Black replies 14...d7, preparing ...f7-f5, whilst after 14. g4, one must reckon with 14...g5!? 15. g3 cxb4, followed by ...a7-a5 – Black creates counterplay while the bishop is currently out of play.

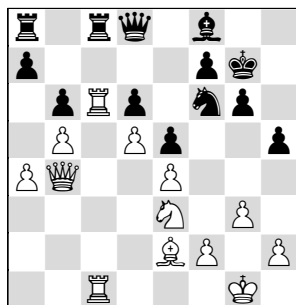
14...xf6 15.0-0 f6 16. g4 f8



17.g3!

White has exchanged his dark-squared bishop, so he should put his pawns on dark squares, covering the dark squares on the kingside.

17...cxb4 18. b3 g7 19. f1 h5 20. e3 e8 21. xb4 dc8 22. c6 d8 23. ac1 f6



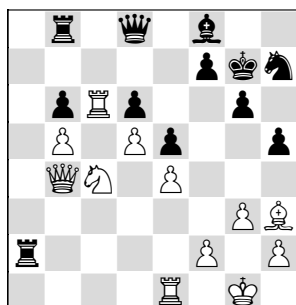
24. Bf1!

By transferring the bishop to h3, White seizes total control of the c-file.

24... Bcb8 25. Bh3 a6

The ideal square for the white knight is c4, but it cannot go there at once, since the e4-pawn would hang. White therefore defends the pawn in advance.

26. Be1! axb5 27. axb5 Bh7 28. Bc4 Ba2



In the near future, the knight will probably appear on g5, which is why Black brought the knight to h7. The bishop has done its work on the h3-c8 diagonal, and now it can switch to a defensive, prophylactic function.

29. g2! Bf6 30. Bf1 Bg5 31. Bb3 Ba8

All the squares in the white camp are solidly defended. Now, he drives

back the knight, and then starts to harvest pawns.

32. h4 Bh7 33. Bxb6 Ba1 34. Bc6 Ba2 35. Be3 Bd8 36. Bxa1 Bxa1+ 37. Bh2 Bf6 38. f3 Bb8 39. Bb3 Bd7 40. b6 Bc5 41. Bb2 Ba4 42. Bb5 Ba2 43. Bc7 g5 44. Be3 gxh4 45. Bf5+ Kg8 46. gxh4 Ba6 47. b7 Ba7 48. Bc8 Bxb7 49. Be8 Bd7 50. Bxd6

Black resigned.

89

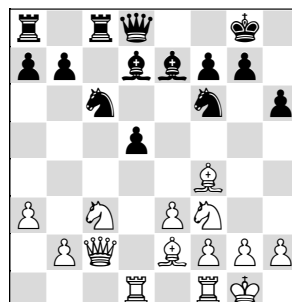
Anatoly Karpov

Boris Spassky

Montreal 1979 (4)

2705

2640



Black's pieces are insufficiently active, which is especially important in positions with an isolated pawn. With his next move, White has several ideas:

1) Exchanges are usually favourable to the side playing against the IQP. This example is no exception.

2) By exchanging the knight at c6, White makes it hard for Black to use the d4- and e5-squares for manoeuvring.

3) The f3-square is freed for the bishop, from where it attacks the IQP.

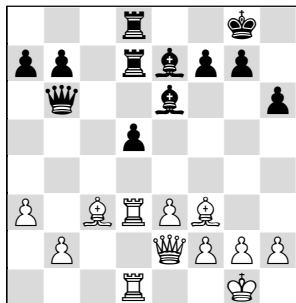
16. Be5! Be6 17. Bxc6 Bxc6 18. Bf3 Bb6 19. Be5!

The time is right to strengthen the ♖c3, because there are ideas of Black playing ...♙xa3 at some point.

19...♘e4 20.♚e2 ♘xc3 21.♙xc3 ♜d8

On 21...♙xa3, strong is 22.♙xg7 – with queens still on, it is very dangerous to deprive the king of pawn cover.

22.♜d3 ♜cd6 23.♞fd1 ♜d7



24.♞1d2!

Now the queen will stand behind the rooks.

24...♚b5 25.♚d1 b6 26.g3!

All the white pieces have occupied ideal positions, which means it is time for some cosmetic improvement in his pawn structure.

26...♙f8 27.♙g2 ♙e7 28.♚h5

From here, the queen attacks the pawn on d5, but already from a more active square.

28...a6 29.h3 ♚c6 30.♘h2 a5 31.f4!

White starts seizing space on the kingside.

31...f6 32.♚d1 ♚b5 33.g4 g5?

While the white king is well defended by its pieces, Black's is completely alone. It was essential to continue to wait, with the move 33...♚c6. In reply, White would probably have chosen 34.♙d4, combining threats to seize the c-file with the possibility of a breakthrough with g4-g5, assisted by

♙g2-f3 and h3-h4. This break could become strong if Black plays ...♙e7-c5, and exchanges a pair of bishops.

34.♘h1

Even stronger is 34.♙d4 a4 (threatening ♜d3-b3) 35.♜c3, seizing the c-file.

34...♚c6 35.f5

White wins a pawn, continuing to hold a space advantage.

35...♙f7 36.e4 ♘g7 37.exd5 ♚c7 38.♞e2 b5?

An oversight, but even after 38...♙d6 39.♜de3! ♙c5 40.♞e6! ♙xe6 41.fxe6, White has a decisive advantage.

39.♜xe7 ♜xe7 40.d6 ♚c4 41.b3 1-0

90

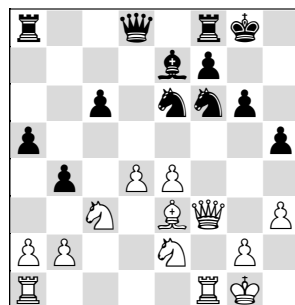
Magnus Carlsen

Levon Aronian

Wijk aan Zee 2012 (3)

2835

2805



19.♘b1!

From the d2-square, the knight supports the centre excellently, whereas from a4, it only holds up the advance ...c6-c5. It is important to realise that the extra tempo Black gets from this knight manoeuvre cannot be used by him to create counterplay.

19...♘h7

There is pressure down the f-file, and Black tries to reduce it. In the

process, he also sets up a possible attack on the white queen from g5.

20. ♖d2 ♜c8

Exchanges usually ease the defender's position, when he has less space, so Black should have chosen 20... ♕h4!, first weakening the white kingside with the threat of ... ♖h7-g5, and after 21.g3 (unfortunately for White, he cannot play 21. ♕f2 ♕f6 22.e5, because of 22... ♗xe5!) forcing the exchange of bishops by 21... ♕g5 22. ♜ac1 ♜c8 23. ♖c4 – White is still better, but the slight weakening of his kingside hampers him.

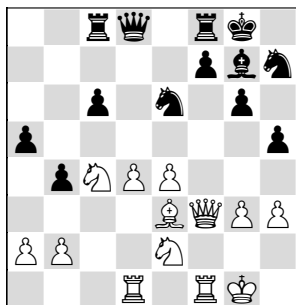
21. ♜ad1 ♕h4 22.g3

In this line, White can do without the weakening of the kingside: 22. ♕f2 ♖hg5 23. ♗e3 ♕xf2+ 24. ♜xf2, with advantage.

22... ♕f6

Somewhat better is 22... ♕g5.

23. ♖c4 ♕g7



On c4, the knight occupies an excellent position – it attacks a5, and if Black plays ...c6-c5, White replies d4-d5, when the knight fulfils the function of blockader of the black queenside pawns. Black must also face the unpleasant threat of e4-e5, followed by the knight jumping into d6. Of course, White could now choose the energetic 24.e5, but

usually, when the opponent lacks counterplay, one does better to go for some sort of strengthening move, and invite the opponent to initiate a sharpening of the position, which will rebound on him. In this case, such a useful move is

24.b3!

A multi-purpose move – White strengthens the position of the ♖c4, fixes the weakness on a5, and gets the pawn out of the way of the ♕g7.

24... ♗e7

24...f5 25.e5 ♖hg5 26. ♕xg5 ♖xg5 27. ♗g2 ♖e4 28. ♖f4 ♗e8 29.g4, and having opened the g-file, White will organise an attack along it.

Maybe he should have brought the knight closer to the centre with 24... ♖f6, so that it takes some part in the game, since if White plays e4-e5, the ♖h7 will remain completely out of play.

25. ♗g2

Continuing his strategy of prophylaxis, but there was also the more aggressive 25.e5 – the pawn on a5 is hanging and at the same time there is a threat of h3-h4, after which the knight on h7 has no moves at all.

25... ♖c7

Black's pieces lack coordination, so it is hard to suggest anything satisfactory for him. His last move is an attempt to find some chances by sharpening the play.

26. ♖xa5 ♗fe8

On 26... ♖d5, the most precise line is 27. ♕c1! (Black has more chances to muddy the waters after 27. ♕d2 ♖c3 28. ♕xc3 bxc3) 27... ♖c3 28. ♖xc3 bxc3 29. ♖c4 – the pawn on c3 is alone in White's camp, without the support

of its pieces, so Black's position is bad.

27.e5 ♘d5 28.♙d2 ♚ed8 29.♘f4

Exchanging Black's most active pieces.

29...♚a7

Slow, but Black is suffering without any particular chances after 29...♚c7 30.♘c4 ♚a8 31.♙e3!, since after 31...♘xe3 32.♘xe3 ♚a7, White plays 33.♘c2! ♙xe5 34.♘xb4, with decisive threats against c6.

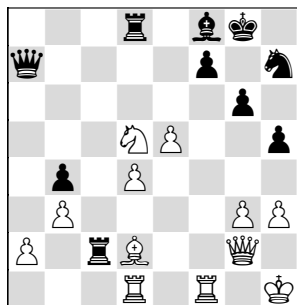
30.♘xc6 ♚xc6 31.♘xd5 ♚c2

32.♙h1

He could also just centralise his pieces with 32.♚e4 ♚xa2 33.♙f4.

32...♙f8

After 32...♚b2 33.♘xb4 ♚xd4 34.♙c3 ♚xd1 35.♙xb2 ♚d7 36.♘c6 ♚c8 37.♚c1 the connected queenside pawns should decide the outcome of the game.



33.e6!

Additional material

Karpov-Kasparov, London Wch (match/5) 1986

Petrosian-Yukhtman, Tbilisi 1959

Hertneck-Karpov, Germany Bundesliga 1993/94 – Black's 16th move

Botvinnik-Lilienthal, Moscow 1936 – White's 12th move

Kramnik-Carlsen, Bilbao 2010 – White's 15th move

Kasparov-Bukic, Skara 1980 – Black's 24th move

Alekhine-Znosko-Borovsky, Birmingham 1926

Geller-Bertk, Belgrade 1961 – White's 24th move

The decisive blow – the black king lacks protection.

33...♚a8 34.exf7+

Even simpler is 34.e7 ♚xd5 35.e8 ♚xe8 36.♚xd5.

34...♙h8 35.♘f4 ♚xg2+

Here, White could win quickly and easily with

36.♘xg2

In the game, White played a long combination, as a result of which, after 36.♘xg2 ♚xd4 37.♚f2 ♚d6 38.♙c1! ♚xf2+ 39.♙xf2 ♚xd1 40.♙b2+ ♘f6 41.♙xf6+ ♙h7 42.♘e6 ♙d6 43.♙e5 ♙e7 44.f8 ♚ ♙xf8 45.♘xf8+ ♙h6, he faced some technical difficulties, which after 46.♘e6 (the main problem here is the weak pawns on c3 and g3, which need defending. Therefore, to win, he needed to fix the pawn structure on the kingside. This could be done by 46.♙e2 ♚h1 47.h4 g5 48.♙f6 gxh4 49.♙xh4, solidly defending the pawn on g3 and directing the king towards the queenside) 46...g5 became even more difficult. However, after great effort, he did eventually manage to realise his advantage.

36...♚xd4

Otherwise, ♘g2-f4, or ♙d2-f4-e5.

37.♙c3

Winning even more material.

Chapter 15

Schematic thinking. Regrouping one's forces, transferring pieces to more favourable positions

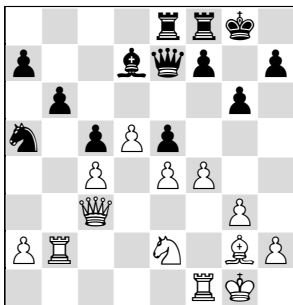
In positions that are not filled with tactics, one can often form short-term plans to fulfil strategic objectives. For example, a player may think: the rook would be good on that square, the knight on that one, and the bishop on this. Having thus determined his plan, he can choose the most accurate way of carrying it out.

91

Lev Polugaevsky

Efim Geller

Riga ch-URS 1958



So far, Black has managed to contain White's central play, thanks to the blockade on e5. But White retains the advantage, because the knight on a5 is far away from the centre. If it stood on d6 or e5, in the event of the pawns there being exchanged, Black's position would be very pleasant.

22. dxc1!

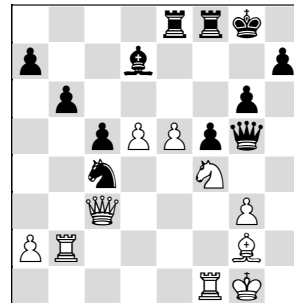
The knight transfers to d3, from where it strengthens the pressure on the key square e5. Once this blockading point falls, Black will be in trouble. At the same time, White's last move also opens the second rank, so his rook can transfer to the kingside.

*

22...f5 23. d3 exf4 24. e5! fxg3 25. hxg3 g5 26. d4

With the aid of a pawn sacrifice, White has managed to create two powerful passed pawns in the centre.

26...dxc4



27. e6

White also wins without any problems after 27. dxc4! ex5 28. d6+ g7 29. a6 xg3 30. xa7 f7 31. xb6+.

27...dxb2 28. exd7 d8 29. de6 f6 30. xf6 fxf6 31. dxd8 d6 32. db7 dxd7 33. d6!

Black has three pawns for the piece, but is unable to set them in motion. The passed d-pawn decides

33...c4 34. d5+ g7 35. dxc4 xb7 36. e1 b8 37. d7 1-0

92

Igor Drozdov

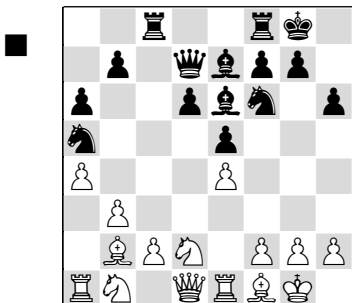
Konstantin Sakaev

Kazan tt 1995 (7)

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2450

2570



White wants to play c2-c4, after which the advance ...d6-d5 becomes impossible, and the bishop on e7 is restricted. Therefore, Black solves the problem of his 'bad bishop' in advance:

15...♙d8!

A deep positional decision.

The alternative was the break-out with the pawn sacrifice 15...d5!? 16.exd5 ♖xd5 17.♙xe5 ♔fd8, with strong compensation on account of the advantage in development.

16.♘a3

In the event of 16.c4 ♙b6, there is a threat of the ♘f6 moving away, followed by ...f7-f5.

16...♙b6 17.h3 ♘c6 18.♘ac4 ♙c5

19.a5 ♖c7

Black is ready to bring his rook from f8 to e8 or d8, after which the advance ...d6-d5 at a convenient moment will become unavoidable. At the same time, the dark-squared bishop, which is exerting pressure on f2, is one of Black's most active pieces. Black's advantage is indisputable.

93

Mark Tseitlin

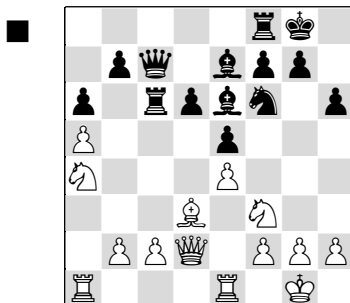
Konstantin Sakaev

Ubeda 2001 (6)

**

2494

2639



There is no play on the c-file and ...d6-d5 is presently impossible. How does Black strengthen his position?

17...♙d8!

In the absence of an opponent, the bishop switches to a better position.

18.♘b6

Better was 18.b4, although this is a concession, since now White's intended plan of b2-b3 and ♘a4-b2-c4 becomes impossible. After this, it makes sense for Black to play 18...♘h5, and after forcing another weakness with 19.g3 to retreat 19...♘f6.

18...♖b8 19.♘a4 ♙c7

Now, the pawn on e5 is defended, and the break ...d6-d5 starts to hang in the air.

20.♘c3 ♔d8 21.♖e2

Currently, it is still not easy to achieve ...d6-d5 in comfort. So how can we strengthen the position now?

21...♖c8!

The bishop is heading even further away to a7, with an attack on f2.

22.♔a3 ♙b8 23.h3 ♙a7 24.♘h2?

Extremely meek, but White has a difficult position anyway, lacking counterplay.

24...♙d4

Before landing the decisive blow in the centre, it is useful to drive the white pieces into the most passive positions possible.

25.♘d1 d5

Effectively, Black has won the game with a series of prophylactic, preparatory moves.

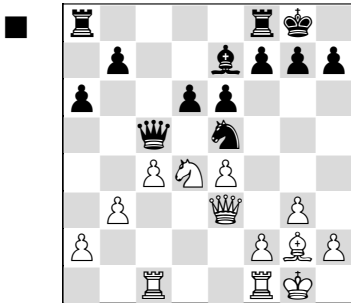
26.exd5 ♘xd5 27.♙e4 ♘f4 28.♖f3 ♜c7 29.c3 ♙c5 30.b4 ♙d6 31.♙b1 f5 32.♙a2 ♙xa2 33.♞xa2 e4 34.♖e3 ♘d3 35.♞f1 ♙f4 36.♖e2 ♘c1 37.♖c2 ♘xa2 38.♖xa2+ ♔h7 39.♖b1 ♖d7 40.g3 ♙d2 41.g4 ♖d3

0-1

94

Andras Adorjan
Alexey Suetin

Budapest 1970 (1)



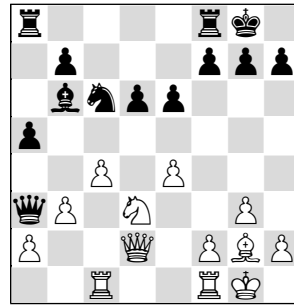
Black exploits the weakening of the dark squares in White's camp with the aid of the transfer of his bishop to an active position:

17...♙d8! 18.♖d2

There was no need to place his pieces so passively, but even after 18.♞fd1 ♙b6 19.♖e2 ♖c7, Black establishes his bishop on c5, and with the aid

of a subsequent ...♘e5-c6, is able to fight successfully for the dark squares, ensuring himself the more pleasant game.

18...♙a5 19.♖d1 ♙b6 20.♘f3 ♘c6 21.♘e1 a5 22.♘d3 ♖a3 23.♖d2



23...e5 24.♖b2 ♙c5 25.♞b1 ♖xb2 26.♞xb2 ♙d4 27.♞bb1

Now he starts to have problems with his queenside pawns.

He should have preferred 27.♞c2, although after 27...♘b4 28.♘xb4 axb4, White has to put both rooks on the second rank, so as to defend the a2-pawn. Black, in his turn, places his pawn on c6, and a rook on a7. Later, he can consider ...g7-g6 and ...f7-f5, retaining the initiative.

27...♘b4 28.♘c1 ♞fc8

More precise was the immediate 28...a4!.

29.♞d1

Correct is 29.a4! – at least then Black will find it hard to attack the queenside pawns. He would have to play ...g7-g6 and ...f7-f5, but here things are not so terrible, and White should hold the position.

29...a4! 30.bxa4 ♞xa4 31.a3

Preferable is 31.♘b3, after which Black can choose between 31...♘c6, 31...♙c5 and 31...♙a7, retaining the initiative in all cases.

31...♖a6

Stronger is 31...♖c6!, and if 32.♙xb7, then 32...♖a5.

32.♖b3 ♖a7

This allows White to achieve some activity and solve his problems. More accurate is 32...♙c5 33.♖xc5 ♖xc5 34.♙xd6 ♙xc4 – Black's position is still somewhat more pleasant.

33.♙xd6 ♙xc4 34.♙f1

Equality results from 34.♙h3! ♙a8 35.♖d2 ♙c7 36.♙f1.

34...♙c2 35.♙d2 h5 36.h4?

An oversight – White misses the attack on the g3-pawn.

36...♙c3! 37.♖g2?

Panic. 37.♙e2 ♙xd2 38.♖xd2 ♙xg3+ 39.♖f1 ♙xa3 40.♖c4 still retained chances of saving the game.

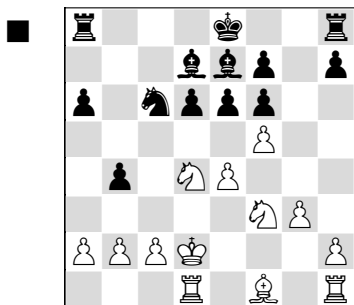
37...♙xb3 38.♙d8+ ♖h7 39.♙xb3 ♙xf2+ 40.♖h3 ♙xf1 41.♙xb7 ♙d4 42.♙dd7

White resigned, without waiting for 42...♖c5 43.♙xf7 ♙h1+ 44.♖g2 ♙g1+ 45.♖h2 ♖xb7.

95

**

Josef Cucka
Vlastimil Jansa
Ostrava 1960 (12)



When in such structures, the white king is on b1 and the queens are still on the board, then dynamic factors

tend to predominate. It is hard for the black king to find a safe refuge, and his light squares are weak. Here, however, Black has the possibility of carrying out a typical regrouping, as a result of which his bishop reaches a strong post, and the king gets a great spot in the centre.

16...♙f8! 17.♙c4

By contrast, White should have taken his king out of the centre with 17.♖c1 and then ♖c1-b1, getting it away from the threatening bishop's diagonal.

17...♖e7 18.♖e2 ♙h6 19.♙he1

It looks slightly better to play 19.♙hf1, but White still has essentially the same problems.

19...♖e5 20.♖xe5 fxe5 21.fxe6 fxe6 22.♖f3 a5

Black is stronger in the centre, as well as on both flanks.

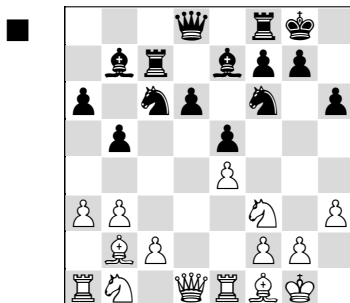
23.♖f2 ♙hf8 24.♖g2 ♙c6 25.♙d3 a4 26.♖d2 ♙g7 27.♖c4 d5 28.exd5 ♙xd5+ 29.♖h3 ♙f2 30.♙e4 ♙d8 31.♙xd5 ♙xd5 32.♙xd5 exd5 33.♖b6 ♖e6 34.♖xa4 ♙xc2

And Black won.

96

**

Wolfgang Unzicker
Mark Taimanov
Saltsjöbaden izt 1952 (8)

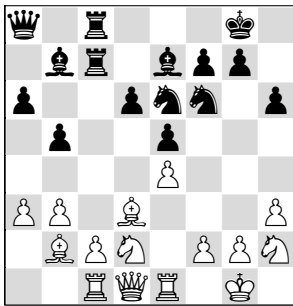


As always in such structures, piece control of the central light squares is a major factor in the assessment of the position. White does not control these, so Black has an excellent game. Furthermore, with his next moves, Black not only strengthens control of d5, but also builds pressure against the e4-pawn, which allows him to seize the initiative.

15...♖a8! 16.♘bd2 ♘d8!

The knight transfers to e6, from where it can go to c5, intensifying the pressure against e4, or else occupy the square f4.

17.♙d3 ♘e6 18.♞c1 ♞fc8 19.♘h2



19...♘d7!

Black can permit himself to bring the knight from f6 to c5, so as to strengthen the position of his pieces to the maximum, before breaking with ...d6-d5 – from e6, the other knight can jump to f4, whilst the bishop on e7 can emerge on g5.

20.♘hf1 ♘dc5 21.♙g3 g6!

Useful prophylaxis – the white knight has the square f5.

22.♘e2 ♙g5

Black does not even consider the variation 22...♘xe4 23.♘xe4 ♙xe4 24.♙xe4 ♞xe4 25.♘c3 ♞b7 26.♘d5 ♞c5, in which White has no compensation for the pawn.

23.♘c3 ♘d4 24.♘cb1 d5

Another way to win was 24...♘dxb3 25.♘xb3 ♘xb3+.

White is also completely paralysed after 24...♘xd3 25.cxd3 ♞xc1 26.♙xc1 ♞c2+.

**25.exd5 ♘xd3 26.cxd3 ♞xc1
27.♙xc1 ♙xd5 28.f3 ♞c2 29.a4 b4
30.♙h1 ♞c6 0-1**

97

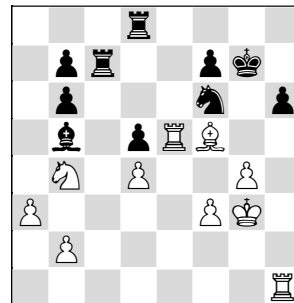
Peter Leko

2717

Michael Adams

2752

Dortmund 2002 (6)



Each white piece is more active than its counterpart, and one hardly needs to say anything about the pawn structure – Black's is riddled with weaknesses. Two paths are possible now, but that chosen in the game is the most technical and the most convincing over the board. After asking himself the question of which of his pieces he can improve even further, Leko found the answer:

41.♘c2!

The knight simply heads to f5. When a position is so strategically winning, White should choose the path that involves the least number of unfavourable changes to the pawn structure. Another good possibility was 41.♙b1 – it turns out that there is no satisfactory defence to the

threat of g4-g5, despite the many possible moves. Black would have to surrender his central pawn in one way or another, and after, for example, 41...♔d7 (41...♔c6 42.g5 hxg5 43.♖xg5+ ♔f8 44.♖h8+ ♔e7 45.♗e5+ ♔d7 46.♕f5+-) 42.♗xd5 ♗xd5 43.♗xd5 ♗e8 44.♗dh5, White should gradually win.

41...♗e8 42.♗e3 ♗ce7 43.♔f4 ♔c6
44.♔c2 ♔d7 45.g5 1-0

98

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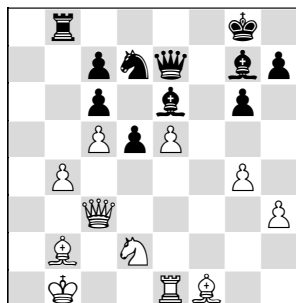
Konstantin Landa

2645

Peter Leko

2720

Russia tt 2012 (5)



White was hoping to exploit the pawn on c6, planning to bring his knight to d4 or a5, but Black finds an important regrouping of his pieces, which fights off White's threats, and Black's advantage becomes obvious.

30...♗f8! 31.♗b3 ♔d7!

The bishop defends the weakness, whilst freeing an excellent blocking square for the knight.

32.♗a5

32.♗d4 ♗e6 33.♗xe6 ♔xe6+ is completely cheerless for White.

32...♗e6 33.♔a6 ♖g5 34.♔c1

There is nothing to be gained by 34.♔b7 ♗d8 35.♔a6 ♖f4 36.♔a3 ♗f7+.

34...♖h4 35.♔b7 d4?

Now, a series of mistakes in mutual time-trouble follows. Black could have won with 35...♗d8 36.♔a6 d4 37.♖d2 ♔h6.

36.♖d2 ♖xh3?

36...♔h6-+.

37.♔xc6 ♔xc6?

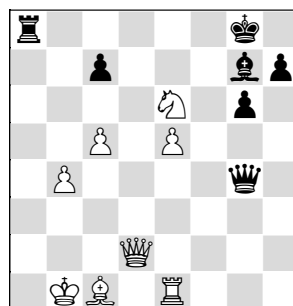
37...♔h6-+.

38.♗xc6 ♗a8 39.♗xd4

White has to be brave in this situation

39...♖xg4 40.♗xe6

The zwischenzug



Despite a series of sub-optimal moves, on the last move of the time control Black finds an important check, which increases his advantage.

40...♖f5+!

White had been expecting 40...♖xe6 41.♔b2!.

41.♔b2

41.♖c2 ♗a1+-+.

41...♖xe6 42.♖d4 ♗e8 43.♔c3?

Overestimating the chances offered by the passed pawns.

After 43.♔f4? g5 44.♔h2 h5, the black pawns advance unstoppably.

Correct was 43.♖d3! ♔xe5+ 44.♔b1 ♗a8 45.♔a3 h5 46.♗e3!, with hopes of saving the game.

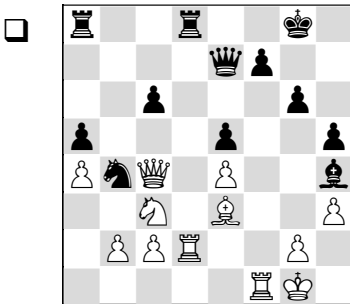
43...♙xe5 44.♖xe5 ♜xe5 45.♚xe5
♜xe5 46.♙f4 ♞e7 47.♙d4
47.b5 ♙f7 48.♙d4 ♙e6! 49.c6 ♜f7–+.
47...c6!

The simplest. White lacks the forces
for a breakthrough.

48.b5 cxb5 49.c6 ♙f7 50.c7 ♞e8
51.♙d5 b4

White resigned.

99 ******
Anatoly Karpov 2700
Boris Spassky 2650
Leningrad match 1974 (9)



Black has various gashes in his
queenside, but the knight on
b4 defends one weak pawn and
attacks c2. The white knight on c3
is ‘dominated’ by the pawn on c6.
Taking these factors into account,
White sets about regrouping his
forces:

24.♘b1!

Now, the knight on b4 cannot
maintain its position, whilst the
white knight gets more freedom to
manoeuvre, via d2.

24...♚b7 25.♙h2 ♙g7 26.c3 ♘a6
27.♞e2

Black cannot exploit the d-file, and
so White does not mind abandoning
it. This decision is supported by his

desire to keep as many pieces on
the board as possible, because Black
is cramped, and White also has the
possibility of defending the b2-pawn
comfortably.

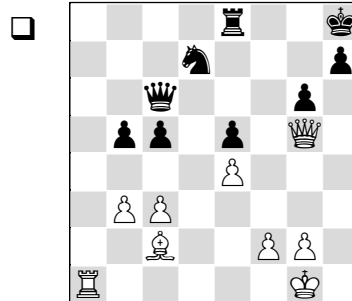
27...♞f8

More tenacious was 27...♞d7, not
with the idea of occupying the d-file,
but of preventing White seizing this
file himself in the near future.

28.♘d2 ♙d8 29.♘f3 f6 30.♞d2
♙e7 31.♚e6 ♞ad8 32.♞xd8 ♙xd8
33.♞d1 ♘b8 34.♙c5 ♞h8 35.♞xd8

Black resigned.

100 ******
Robert Fischer
Wolfgang Unzicker
Zurich 1959 (8)



The f7-pawn is ‘missing’ from
Black’s camp, which weakens not
only his king, but a whole group of
light squares in the centre. White’s
advantage is also enhanced by
his control of the a-file, and the
superiority of his bishop over the
black knight. The bishop is currently
not so well placed, being blocked
by its own pawn on e4, so White
arranges to transfer it to a more
active square:

33.♙d1!

The bishop is ready to come either to e2, tying Black down to the defence of b5, or to g4.

33...♟f6 34.♞a7!

The pawn on e4 is immune, because of the weakness of the seventh rank.

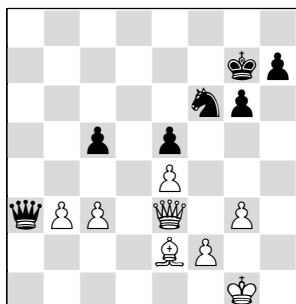
34...♞d6 35.♞e2 ♞e7 36.♞xe7 ♞xe7 37.♞xb5

White not only has extra material, but also an excellent pawn structure, which enables him to create a passed b-pawn.

37...♟g7 38.♞e2 ♞c7 39.♞e3 ♞a5 40.g3!

When a bolthole is needed for the king, the pawn should stand on a dark square, so as not to hamper the white bishop.

40...♞a3



41.♟g2!

Yet another excellent piece of prophylaxis – the king gets away from possible checks.

41...♞a5 42.♞d3 ♞b6 43.♞c4 ♞c6 44.♞d3 ♞b6 45.b4 cxb4 46.cxb4 ♟g4 47.♞c5 ♞xc5 48.bxc5 ♟f7 49.f4 ♟e7 50.♟f3 ♟f6 51.♞b5 ♟e6 52.♞c4+ ♟e7 53.c6 ♟e8 54.fxe5 h6 55.♟e3 ♟c7 56.♟d4 h5 57.♟e3 g5 58.♞e2 h4 59.gxh4 gxh4 60.♞c4 ♟e8 61.♟f4

♟d8 62.♟g4 ♟c7 63.♞f7 ♟g7 64.♟xh4 ♟xc6 65.♟g5

Black resigned.

101

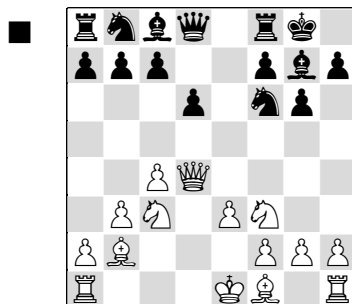
Ljubomir Ljubojevic

Leonid Stein

Las Palmas 1973 (13)

2550

2620



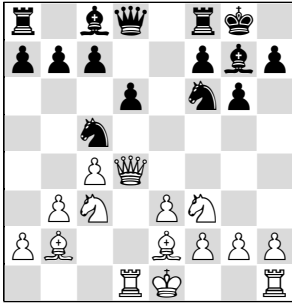
The great majority of players would bring the knight to c6, attacking the queen. However, in that case, the queen would retreat to d2, and then the knight would not be ideal on c6 – it would be better on c5, from where it might jump to e4, and also supports queenside counterplay with ...a7-a5-a4. Black realised that the white queen cannot remain on d4 forever, because of the x-ray from the ♞g7, and will have to move away at some point anyway. Consequently, there followed

8...♟bd7!! 9.♞e2 ♟c5 10.♞d1?

Now the white queen comes under attack.

The active knight could have been driven away with 10.b4! ♟e6 (the variation leading to an unusual material balance after 10...♟fe4 11.♞xg7+ ♟xg7 12.♟xe4+ f6 13.bxc5 ♞e7 14.♟c3 dxc5 15.♟d5, is in White's favour) 11.♞d2. Admittedly,

the queenside pawns are too far advanced to allow White to count on an advantage, for example: 11... a5 12.a3 b6 13.0-0 ♖b7 14.♙c2 ♘e4, with equal play.



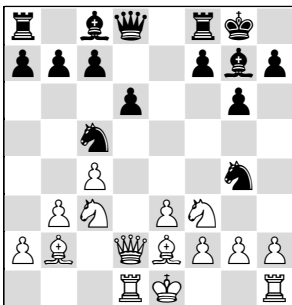
10... ♘g4!

Black avoids the primitive trap 10... ♘fe4? 11.♙xg7!+ ♔xg7 12.♘xe4+, and ♘e4xc5.

11. ♙d2

11.♙d5 ♖e6—+.

More tenacious is 11.♙f4, but even here, after 11...f5! 12.♘d4 g5! 13.♙f3 ♘e4!, White cannot avoid material losses, e.g., 14.0-0 ♘xh2!.



11... ♘xf2! 12.0-0 ♘xd1 13.♖xd1 ♖g4 14.h3 ♖xf3 15.♖xf3 a5 16.♘d5 c6 17.♖xg7 ♔xg7 18.♙d4+ f6 19.♘f4 ♙e7 20.♘h1 ♖fe8 21.♙d2 ♙xe3 22.♙xd6 ♙e5 23.♙d2 ♖ad8 24.♙xa5 ♘e4 25.♘e6+ ♙xe6

White resigned.

102

Vladimir Kramnik

Vadim Zviagintsev

Tilburg 1998 (10)

2780

2650



Black has a bad bishop and his knight is out of play, so White has a clear advantage. Neither player wants to liquidate the tension on the e-file and so present his opponent with tempi. So how can White strengthen his position? Looking at the queenside, we can see a wonderful outpost for the white queen on b4 – from there, it can attack Black's weaknesses. At the same time, the knight has a route from d1-e3-f5.

25. ♘d1!! g6

Preferable is 25...♙d6, although after 26.♖xe8 ♖xe8 27.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 28.♘e3, Black still has a difficult position, because the white queen is ready to penetrate the black camp.

26. ♙b4 ♘d7 27. ♖b5

White exchanges bishops, because after this, Black will find it hard to defend his queenside pawns.

27... ♖xe3 28. ♘xe3 ♘f6

He also loses a pawn after 28...♘b6 29.♘g4 ♖g7 30.♖xc6 bxc6 31.♙e7 ♙d8 32.♙b7 ♘c4 33.♙xc6 ♘xb2 34.♖e5.

29. ♖xa4

The rest is fairly simple technique.

29...♙xa4 30.♖xa4 ♜e8 31.♗d1
 ♜e4 32.♘g4 ♘xg4 33.hxg4 ♜f4
 34.g3 ♜f6 35.♗b3 ♗d8 36.♗xb7
 ♜b6 37.♜e8+ ♗xe8 38.♗xb6
 ♗e1+ 39.♙g2 ♗e4+ 40.♙h2 ♙g7
 41.♗c7

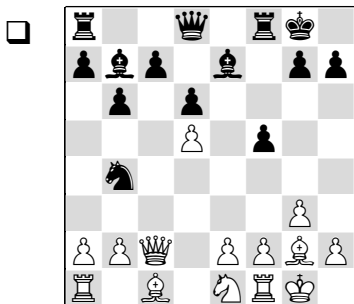
Black resigned.

103

Andor Lilienthal

Mikhail Botvinnik

Moscow ch-URS 1940 (17)



White has to decide where to retreat his queen. He could play 14.♗b3, for example, although in this case, Black replies 14...a5, and later, after the manoeuvre ...♘b4-a6-c5, the queen will be attacked again. Lilienthal reasoned in roughly this way: the undeveloped white QB stands best of all on the long diagonal, since on any other square, it will be hampered by the pawn structure. White is quite happy for it to be exchanged for its opposite number. At the same time, the black knight will sooner or later have to retreat to a6, in which case it would be useful to be able to restrict its movements by answering b2-b4, so as not to allow it to reach c5. Therefore, there followed:

14.♗d2!!

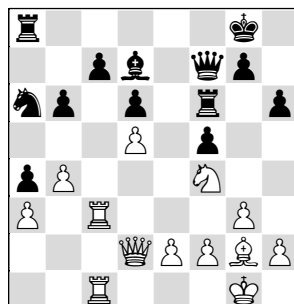
White realises that this guarantees that his bishop will be able to develop to b2. If the black bishop were on f6, rather than e7, the queen retreat to d2 would make no sense.

14...a5 15.a3 ♘a6 16.b4 ♙f6
 17.♙b2 ♗d7 18.♙xf6 ♜xf6
 19.♘d3

The position has stabilised: thanks to the backward pawn on c7, the space advantage and the restricted Black minor pieces, White has a decisive positional advantage.

19...a4 20.♜ac1 ♗f7 21.♘f4 ♙c8
 22.♜c3 ♙d7 23.♜fc1 h6

The attack with the rook's pawn



Having established total superiority on the queenside, White switches the battle to the other wing, exploiting principally the fact that the ♘a6 is so far away.

24.h4! ♜a7 25.h5 ♜a8 26.♜e3 ♙h7
 27.♜cc3 ♜b8 28.♗d3 ♜a8 29.♘g6
 ♜xg6 30.hxg6+ ♙xg6 31.♜e6+
 ♙h7 32.g4 c5 33.b5 ♘c7 34.gxf5
 ♘xb5 35.f6+ ♙g8 36.♜c4 ♜e8
 37.♜g4 g5 38.♜xe8+ ♙xe8 39.♜e4
 ♙f8 40.♜e7 ♗g6 41.♙e4 ♗h5
 42.♙f3 ♗g6 43.♜xe8+

Black resigned.

104

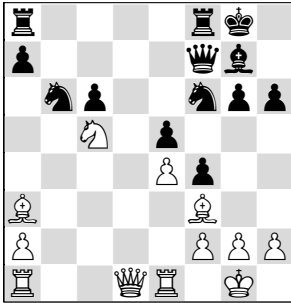
Vladimir Kramnik

Boris Gelfand

Belgrade 1997 (6)

2770

2695



The white light-squared bishop is clearly misplaced, and his queen occupies a vital transfer square. White wants to transfer the bishop to b3:

23. ♖c1!

Here, the queen does not get in the way of the bishop's transfer to the queenside. Otherwise, the queen would have gone to c2.

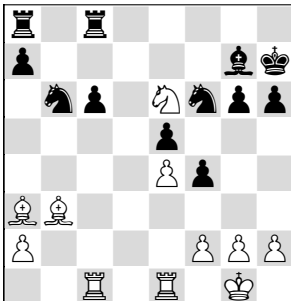
23... ♜c4

He cannot prevent the bishop transfer: 23...a5 24. ♕d1 a4 25. ♘xa4! ♙xa4 26. ♕xf8 ♕xf8 27. ♖xc6 ♙b4 28. ♕b3 leads to a decisive advantage to White.

24. ♕d1 ♖xc1 25. ♙xc1 ♙fc8

26. ♕b3+ ♖h7 27. ♕e6

The most natural possibility. A less obvious way is 27. ♕a6, blockading the a-pawn, and depriving Black of even the most minimal counterplay.



27...a5!

An excellent defensive resource. The light-squared bishop now becomes vulnerable, and Black also seizes some space, of which he is catastrophically short.

28. ♘xg7 ♖xg7 29. ♕e6 ♕bd7

30. ♙ed1 ♙a7 31. ♕b2

It was also possible to tie Black to the defence of e5 from the other direction, with 31. ♕d6, which looks equally strong.

31... ♙cc7 32. f3 ♖f8 33. ♙d6 ♙ab7

34. ♕a3 c5 35. ♕xd7 ♕xd7 36. ♙xg6

♖f7 37. ♙xh6 c4

The passed pawn advances, but Black has no access to the square b2, so he has no compensation for the pawn.

38. g3 fxg3 39. hxg3 c3 40. ♙c2 ♕f8

41. ♕d6 ♙b1+ 42. ♖f2 ♙b2 43. ♕xc7

♙xc2 44. ♖e3 ♙xa2 45. ♕xe5 c2

46. ♙c6 ♙a3+ 47. ♖e2 ♙a2 48. ♕d2

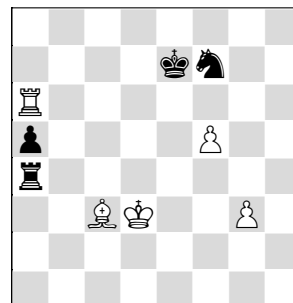
♕e6 49. f4 c1 ♖+ 50. ♖xc1 ♙a4

51. ♕d2 ♙xe4 52. ♕c3 ♖e7 53. ♕d3

♙a4 54. f5 ♕d8 55. ♙a6

There was a much simpler win with 55. ♙g6!, followed by g3-g4. With connected passed pawns, White wins easily.

55... ♕f7



56. ♙a7+

Here the win is already not so obvious: 56. ♕d4!, closing the fourth rank.

Now the pawns cannot be stopped:
 56...♖a3+ 57.♔c4 ♜xg3 58.♙c5+ ♕e8
 59.♖a8+ ♔d7 (59...♙d8 60.♙b6+–)
 60.♖a7+ ♕e8 61.♞e7+, winning.

56...♕e8 57.♖a8+ ♕e7 58.♖a7+ ♕e8

59.♖xa5 ♜g4 60.♙e1 ♕e7 61.♙f2

Nothing is achieved by 61.♖a6 ♙d6
 62.f6+ ♔d7, and White has few
 chances to hold the f6-pawn.

So as to retain winning chances, it
 was essential to bring over the king:
 61.♕e3! ♙g5, and now 62.♞b5! – in
 view of the threat ♞b5-b4, Black has
 to leave the blockading squares on
 the kingside.

61...♙g5 62.♖a6 ♕f7 63.♕e2 ♙e4

64.♖a5

The rook ending arising after 64.♕f3
 ♙xf2 65.♕xf2 ♜g5 66.f6 ♞f5+ 67.♕e3
 ♕g6 is drawn.

64...♜g5 65.♕f3 ♙xf2 66.♕xf2 ♕f6

Draw.

105

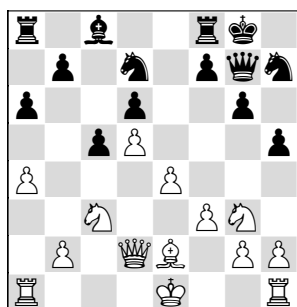
Vassily Ivanchuk

Vladimir Kramnik

Las Palmas 1996 (5)

2730

2765



The pawn structure is not totally
 open, and White has only one move
 to make to complete his development
 – castling. But then there is a danger
 that Black will drive the knight from
 g3 back to a passive square. White

accurately realises that he has time
 to transfer the knight to the active
 e3-square, before castling, from
 where the knight can then come to
 its ideal attacking c4-square.

16.♙f1!

After 16.0-0 h4 17.♙h1 f5 18.♙f2
 ♙e5, the knight on f2 is not terribly
 active and White's advantage would
 be minimal.

16...f5

Black has no other active plan, whilst
 the attempt to sow disharmony in
 White's camp with 16...♞d4 can
 simply be ignored; White continues
 his plan with 17.♙e3, not avoiding
 the exchange of queens.

17.exf5 gxf5

Bad is 17...♞xf5 18.♙e3 and ♙e3-c4 –
 the d6-pawn is lost.

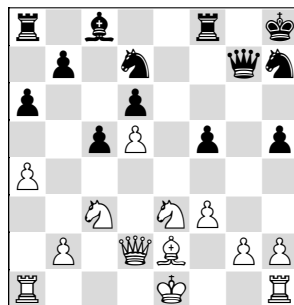
18.♙e3 ♕h8

However he plays, Black cannot
 secure e5 for his knight:

A) 18...f4 19.♙c4 gives White e4 for
 his other knight;

B) 18...♙e5 19.f4 ♙g4 20.♙c4± –
 White completely dominates;

C) Finally, after 18...♞b8, there is
 the strong reply 19.f4 (also good is
 19.♙c4±) 19...♙df6 20.0-0 – White does
 not allow ...b7-b5, whilst his knight
 comes to c4 at a convenient moment.



19.♙c4! ♞f6

Too adventurous is 19...♖xg2? 20.0-0-0 ♖g6 21.♗f4 ♜f6 22.♞hg1 ♗h6 23.♗xh6 ♞xh6 24.f4+- – Black is virtually stalemated.

20.0-0 ♞b8

20...♟e5 21.♟b6 ♜b8 22.f4 ♟d7 23.♟xc8 ♞bxc8 24.♟xh5+-.

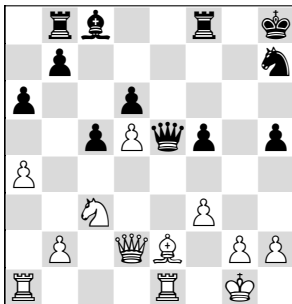
If Black moves the h5-pawn from under attack, then after 20...h4, there follows 21.f4, followed by ♞f1-f3. Besides, Black's play on the g-file can always be blocked with ♟e2-f1, whilst the rook on f3 can either attack the h4-pawn from h3, or switch to the open e-file. White also has the non-obvious plan involving switching the object of attack to the pawn on c5! No less striking is 21.a5!?. The idea is that after the exchange of knights at e5, White can take the d6-pawn, laying bare the weakness at c5. For example, 21...♞b8 22.♗f4 ♟e5 23.♟xe5 dxe5 24.♗c4±, winning material.

21.♞fe1!

The most energetic way to realise the advantage. A more academic approach is 21.f4.

21...b5

More problems could be posed by 21...♟e5 22.♟xe5 ♗xe5 (22...dxe5 23.♟d3 ♜e8 24.♗f2 ♗d6 (24...b6 25.a5+-) 25.♗c2 ♗g6 26.♟e2+-)



analysis diagram

23.♟f1!, a modest but problem-like move – White opens the e-file for his rook, and frees a square for the knight to transfer to f4 (23.f4 ♗d4! ±) 23...♗f6 (23...♗d4 24.♗xd4+ cxd4 25.♟e2+-; 23...♗g7 24.♟e2+-) 24.♟e2 f4 25.b4! cxb4 26.♞ac1!! (26.♗xb4 h4 27.♞ac1 h3 28.♞c4±) 26...a5 27.♞c7 ♟g8 28.♟d4+- – White's attack assumes a decisive character.

22.axb5 axb5 23.♟a5 b4 24.♟b5 ♟a6

24...♞a8 25.♟c4+-.

24...♟b6 25.♗f4 (25.♟c6 ♞b7 26.f4±) 25...♟d7 26.♗xd6 ♟xb5 27.♗xf6+ ♟xf6 28.♟xb5 ♟bxd5 29.♟c6+- – Black's position is full of weaknesses and White should win.

25.♟c7 ♟xe2 26.♞xe2 ♞g8 27.♟c6

♞bc8 28.♟e6 ♞a8 29.♞ae1 ♞a2

30.♟f4 ♗g5 31.h4 ♗g3

31...♗xh4 32.♟e7+-.

32.♞e6 ♟df6 33.♟e7 ♞ga8 34.♟fg6+

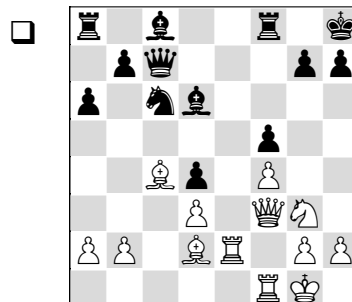
Black resigned.

106

Aron Nimzowitsch

Akiba Rubinstein

Dresden 1926 (5)



White has an advantage in development, but the closed nature of the position and lack of prospects for the knight at g3 make it hard to

develop the initiative. There are no obvious penetration squares in the black camp, so White has to look at which piece is least successfully placed. The answer is obvious – the knight. It is also obvious that its best square is g5, but how can it get there?

18. ♖h1!

The route is a long one, but there is enough time for it. Besides, there are no other obvious constructive ideas.

18... ♗d7 19. ♘f2 ♖ae8 20. ♗fe1 ♗xe2 21. ♗xe2 ♘d8

21... ♖e8 22. ♗xe8+ ♗xe8 23. ♖d5 ♘e7 24. ♖xd4 leads to the loss of a pawn.

22. ♘h3 ♗c6

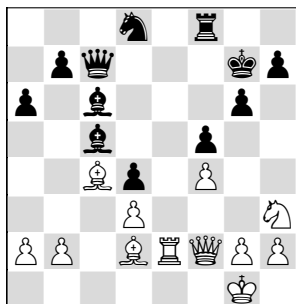
It is impossible to maintain the opposition on the e-file: **22... ♖e8 23. ♗xe8+ ♗xe8 24. ♖d5 ♗f7 25. ♖xf5.**

23. ♖h5 g6

On **23... ♘f7**, it looks promising to seize space with **24.b4!**, limiting the bishop on d6. Later, when the isolated d4-pawn drops off, Black will not have the c5-square.

24. ♖h4 ♗g7 25. ♖f2! ♗c5

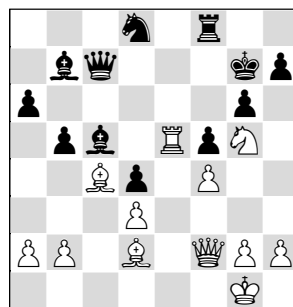
On **25... ♖b6**, strong is **26. ♖e1!**, with the threats of ♗d2-a5 and ♖e2-e7+. There is no compensation for the pawn after **25... ♗e7 26. ♖xd4+** (also unpleasant is **26. ♗a5**) **26... ♗f6 27. ♖c5 b6 28. ♖a3!**, followed by ♗d2-c3.



26.b4

The bishop has just moved to c5 from d6, so White probably did not even consider that it might retreat back the same way.

In the meantime, piece play would have led to success: **26. ♘g5! b5** (he cannot chase the knight: **26... h6 27.b4! ♗b6 28. ♖e1!**) **27. ♖e5! ♗b7** (**27... ♗e7 28. ♖e1 ♗xg5** (**28... ♗f6 29. ♗a5+—**) **29.fxg5 ♗e4 30. ♗f4 bxc4 31. ♖xe4+—**)



analysis diagram

28. ♖xc5 (**28. ♗b3 h6 29. ♘f3**) **28... ♖xc5 29. ♗c3 ♖f6 30. ♗xd4 ♖d6 31. ♗b3 h6 32. ♖e3!**, winning.

26... ♗b6

The weakness of the dark squares on the black kingside could have been immediately fatal.

Black misses the chance of a positional pawn sacrifice, which gives chances of a successful defence: **26... ♗e7! 27. ♖xd4+ ♗f6 28. ♖f2 ♗b5**, with compensation – White's ♗d2 is restricted, and his knight on h3 is not yet in play.

27. ♖h4

Immediately winning was **27. ♖e1!**, and then after the sharp **27... ♗e4**, there follows the prosaic **28. ♘f2**.

27... ♖e8 28. ♖e5

Instead of maintaining the tension, White could force the play: **28. ♖xe8 ♗xe8 29. ♘g5 h6 30. ♖e1 ♗b5 31. ♘e6+**

♟xe6 32.♞xe6 ♔xc4 33.dxc4, with good winning chances.

28...♟f7

Allowing direct play, with penetration into his camp.

28...h6 is bad, because of the far-from-obvious 29.a4!! ♔xa4 30.b5 ♞d7 31.♞e1 ♜xe5 32.fxe5, with the threats of e5-e6, ♔d2xh6+, and ♟h3-f4.

He had to cling on patiently, the only defence being 28...♞d7!, although after 29.g4! h6! 30.gxf5 gxf5 31.♞h5!, White retains the initiative.

29.♔xf7 ♞xf7

29...♜xe5 30.♟g5! h6 31.fxe5 hxe5 32.♔xg5+.

30.♟g5 ♞g8 31.♜xe8 ♔xe8

32.♞e1

A mating net on the dark squares is inevitable, and the outcome of the game decided.

32...♔c6 33.♞e7+ ♔h8 34.b5 ♞g7

35.♞xg7+ ♔xg7 36.bxc6

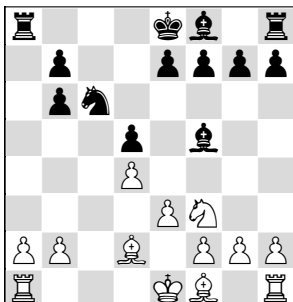
and White won.

107

Dawid Janowsky

José Raul Capablanca

New York 1916 (3)



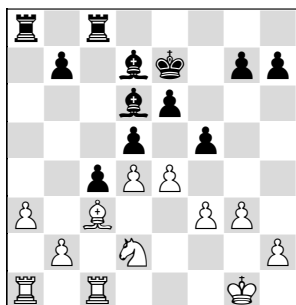
A serious mistake. White gives his opponent the advantage of the two bishops and concedes space.

It was essential to play 19.♔f2, although after 19...g5, Black would obtain the more pleasant game, thanks to the greater freedom of manoeuvre of his pieces.

19...bxc4 20.e4

This advance is just a blow at the air, because it is not supported by the white pieces, and White is unable to exert any pressure on the black position.

White also fails to achieve full equality with 20.f4, followed by transferring the knight to e5. Black would reply 20...♖a4, preparing to double rooks on the a-file, and then ...b7-b5-b4.



20...♔f7

More accurate is 20...g5!, not giving White the chance available on his next move.

21.e5

In such a position, this advance does not really represent a significant space gain, because the black pieces have sufficient space in which to manoeuvre, and his bishops can operate on both flanks.

White misses his fleeting chance: after 21.exf5! exf5 22.f4!, his knight would reach e5, practically

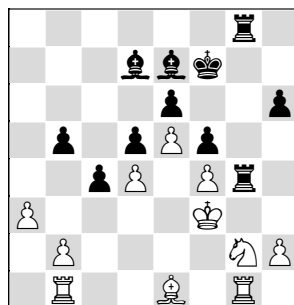
equalising the position. The exchange of pawns and opening of the e-file helps White, because he later has the chance to double rooks, and threaten to use the e-file.

21...♙e7 22.f4 b5

On the queenside, Black wants to play ...b5-b4, and on the kingside ...g7-g5 – it is very hard for White to defend on both flanks simultaneously.

However, more consequential was 22...g5!, not rushing with ...b7-b5. In this case, as well as play on the g-file, Black would have the plan of bringing his bishop into the heart of the white position via a4, without the preliminary pawn sacrifice ...b5-b4.

23.♔f2 ♖a4 24.♙e3 ♖ca8 25.♖ab1 h6 26.♘f3 g5 27.♙e1 ♖g8 28.♔f3 gxf4 29.gxf4 ♖aa8 30.♘g2 ♖g4 31.♖g1 ♖ag8 32.♙e1



32...b4 33.axb4

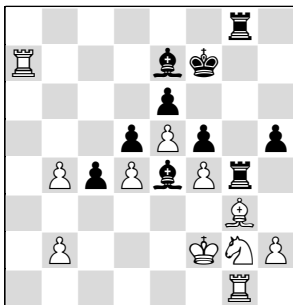
Exchanging dark-squared bishops should suit White from the point of view of the pawn structure, but it does not help here, as after 33.♙xb4 ♙xb4 34.axb4 h5! there is a threat to advance the pawn to h3, whilst after 35.♔f2, there follows 35...♖b8! (here, 35...h4 does not bring success, because of 36.h3 and the h4-pawn is under attack) 36.h3 ♖gg8, and Black switches to play on the b-file.

33...♙a4 34.♖a1 ♘c2 35.♙g3

The last chance of saving the game was 35.♖a7! ♙e4+ 36.♙e3 ♙e8! (direct play does not bring success: 36...♖xg2 37.♖xg2 ♖xg2 38.♙h4 ♖xh2 39.♖xe7+ ♙f8 40.♙f6 ♖xb2 41.♖xe6) 37.♖a8+ ♙d8 38.♙g3 ♙d7 39.♙e1 h5! (it is important for Black to retain a pair of rooks; 39...♙b6 40.♖xg8 ♖xg8 41.♙f2 ♖xg1 42.♙xg1 ♙c6 43.♙d2 ♙b5 44.♙c2 ♙a4 45.♙c3 ♙d8 46.♙f2 – in the bishop ending resulting from Black taking on c2, there is no way to break the white fortress) 40.♖f1 ♙b6 41.♖xg8 ♖xg8 42.♙f3 ♙xf3 43.♖xf3 ♙c6 44.♙e1 ♖g1 45.♙c3 h4 46.♙f2 ♖h1 47.♖h3 ♙d8 – White is condemned to passivity, and Black has excellent winning chances.

35...♙e4+ 36.♙f2 h5 37.♖a7

More tenacious is 37.♙e3, after which the most precise winning line is as follows: 37...h4 38.♙xg4 hxg3+ 39.hxg3 fxe4 40.♖a7 ♖b8 41.♖ga1 ♖xb4 42.♖c7 ♖xb2+ 43.♙e1 ♙d3! 44.♖aa7 ♖e2+ 45.♙d1 ♙g6 46.♖xe7 ♙f5, and the black king is ready at any moment to break into White's camp, helping to create a mating net.



37...♙xg2 38.♖xg2 h4 39.♙xh4 ♖xg2+ 40.♙f3 ♖xh2 41.♙xe7 ♖h3+

42.♙f2 ♖b3 43.♙g5+ ♙g6 44.♖e7 ♖xb2+ 45.♙f3 ♖a8 46.♖xe6+ ♙h7

White resigned.

108

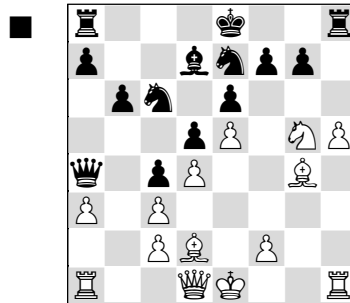
Sergey Karjakin

Predrag Nikolic

Wijk aan Zee 2005 (7)

2599

2676



The main events are taking place on the kingside. Black's chief problem is the pawn f7, which is attacked by the white knight, preventing Black's king escaping to the queenside.

19...♙g8!

A multi-purpose move. The knight goes to h6, from where it will defend f7 and also cover the dark squares, which are weak. If need be, the other knight can come to e7, and take up the crucial blockading f5-square.

20.♙e3 ♙h6 21.♙d2 ♙d8 22.♖f3 ♙c7 23.♙h3 ♖af8 24.♙xh6 ♖xh6 25.♖e3

Strong is:

25...f6!

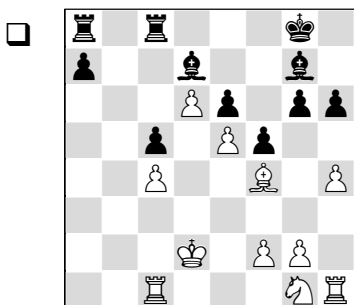
In the game, there followed 25...♖fh8 26.♖hg1 g6 27.hxg6 ♖xg6 28.♙f4 ♖gh6 29.♖f3, with a complicated battle in which Black's chances were not worse. With the forced

26.f4

White deprives his knight of the excellent square f4, and

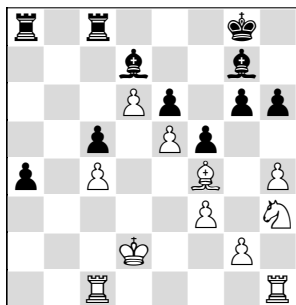
26...f5 27.♟f3 ♟e8 28.♞g1 ♞g8
leads to a position in which White is risking more, as he will be tied to the defence of his rook pawns.

109 ***
Anatoly Karpov 2705
Garry Kasparov 2740
London Wch match 1986 (5)



White needs to be able to play f2-f3, to limit the black light-squared bishop, which at any moment can come to c6. As for the knight, its best square is d3, from where it defends e5 and attacks c5, as well as protecting the square b2 from incursion by the black rooks. To prevent any possible counterplay by ...g6-g5, the knight does best to transfer via h3. Therefore:

20.♞h3! a5 21.f3 a4



22.♞he1!

White does not begrudge a tempo to over-protect the e5-pawn. The a-pawn, which lacks the support of its pieces, is not a serious threat. On 22.♞f2, there would follow 22...g5.

22...a3 23.♞f2 a2 24.♞d3 ♞a3 25.♞a1 g5

More tenacious is 25...♞b8, after which White, to maintain his advantage, would have to play 26.♞ec1! g5 27.hxg5 hxg5 28.♟g3! f4 29.♟f2.

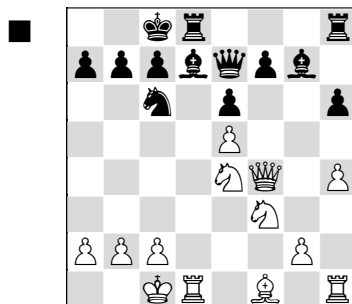
26.hxg5 hxg5 27.♟g3 ♟f7 28.♟f2

Also strong is the immediate 28.♞ec1, going after the a2-pawn.

28...♞b8 29.♞ec1 ♟c6 30.♞c3 ♞a5 31.♞c2 ♞ba8 32.♞c1

Black resigned.

110 ***
Michael Adams 2660
Anatoly Karpov 2740
Las Palmas 1994 (9)



The bishop is passively placed on d7, and interferes with Black's planned regrouping on the d-file. It would like to come to c6, but the knight is in the way...

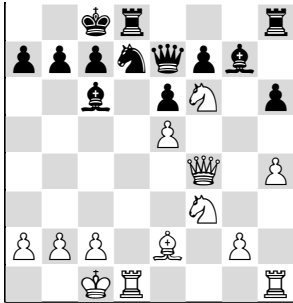
14...♞b8!

That is the square! The bishop intends to come to c6, and then

the knight will move to d7. This is a particularly good square for the knight, from where it attacks the e5-pawn and can be directed to the queenside.

White is better after 14...♖b4 15.♘d6+ cxd6 16.♙xb4.

15.♙e2 ♙c6 16.♘f6 ♘d7



Thanks to the bishop pair, Black's position is the more pleasant.

17.♘h5

White's tactical operation is bad, and he should have preferred 17.♘xd7.

17...♙xf3 18.♙xf3 ♙xe5 19.♙e4 c6 20.♙xd7 ♙xb2+ 21.♙xb2 ♙xd7

White has an exposed king and lacks good squares for his minor pieces, whilst Black has seized the only open file.

22.♙e3 ♙hd8 23.a3 ♙d4 24.g3 ♙c5 25.♙e1 ♙c4 26.♙xc5 ♙xc5 27.♙e2 ♙d1 28.♘f4

On 28.♙xe6, there would follow 28...♙d2.

28...♙b5+ 29.♙a2 ♙bb1 30.♙h5 ♙a1+ 31.♙b3 ♙db1+ 32.♙c4 ♙xa3 33.♙xf7 ♙xg3 34.♙xe6+ ♙c7 35.♘d3 a5 36.♙f2 ♙e3 37.♙f7+ ♙b8 38.♙e7 ♙e4+ 39.♙c3 ♙b5 0-1

Additional material

Bacrot-Bologan, Poikovsky 2005 – White's 18th move

Dreev-Ni Hua, Moscow tt 2004 – White's 11th move

Keres-Benko, Yugoslavia ct 1959 – White's 20th move

Beliavsky-Dorfman, Vilnius 1978

Kasimdzhanov-I.Sokolov, Pamplona 2002 – White's 34th move

Kasparov-Georgadze, Minsk 1979 – White's 15th move

Kasparov-Vallejo Pons, Linares 2004 – White's 22nd move

Geller-Reshevsky, Palma de Mallorca 1970 – White's 14th move

Chapter 16

A space advantage

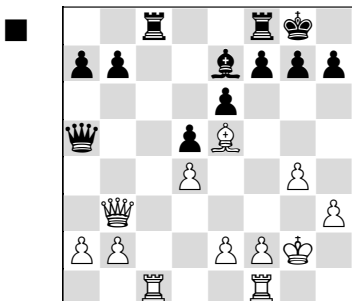
Space can be seized by advancing one's pawns. Behind these, one's pieces then obtain plenty of space for manoeuvring, and a space advantage usually ensures a lasting initiative. The opponent, on the other hand, lacking space, is unable to transfer his forces quickly from one part of the board to another. Admittedly, there are many exceptions, these usually being positions where the side with less space has particularly excellent piece coordination. One sees this picture most often in openings such as the King's Indian, French and Caro-Kann defences.

111

Alfred Tarnowski

Mikhail Botvinnik

Leipzig ol 1960 (8)



Thanks to the superiority of his bishop, Black stands better, but in order to turn this advantage into something real, he needs either to create some weakness in White's position or else seize the open c-file. With this idea, there followed

17...b5!

The pawn not only moves from under attack, but also ensures the rook an outpost on c4.

18.♖xc8 ♜xc8 19.a3 ♖c4 20.♗d1

♜b6 21.♗d2 ♜c6 22.e3

The white bishop is totally cut off from the queenside, and Black

*

continues to develop his offensive on this side of the board.

22...a5! 23.♗g3 ♜c1 24.f3 f6

Ensuring the f7-square for his king in a future endgame.

25.♗f2 ♜c4 26.♜d3 a4

The white queenside pawns, now fixed on squares of the same colour as his bishop, become an object of attack.

27.e4 ♜xd3 28.♗xd3 b4 29.axb4

♗xb4 30.exd5 exd5 31.♗e3 ♜c2

White resigned.

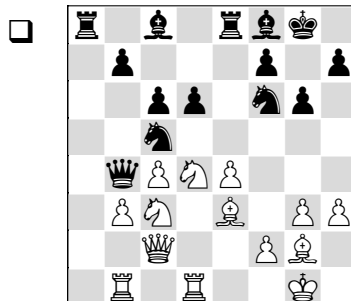
112

Viktor Kortchnoi

Borislav Ivkov

Hastings 1955

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20.♜d2!

White creates the unpleasant threat of ♖d4-c2 followed by b3-b4. It is striking that in two subsequent games, White passed by this strong move. One must know the classics!

20... ♖b6

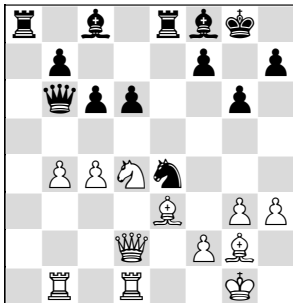
Other moves are even worse:

A) 20... ♖fxe4 21. ♖xe4+-;

B) 20... ♖a6 21. ♖c2 ♖a5 22. ♖d5! ♖d8 23. ♖b6+-;

C) 20... ♖g7 21.e5! (only a small advantage results from 21. ♖c2 ♖fxe4 22. ♖xe4 ♖xd2 23. ♖xd2 ♖f5! 24. ♖bc1 ♖d3 25.g4 ♖xc1 26. ♖xc1 ♖xc2 27. ♖xc2±) 21...dxe5 22. ♖c2 ♖xb3 23. ♖xb4 ♖xd2 24. ♖xd2±.

21.b4 ♖cxe4 22. ♖xe4 ♖xe4



23. ♖d3 ♖xf2

A) 23...f5 24. ♖e6+-;

B) 23...d5 24. ♖e6 c5 25. ♖xf8 ♖xf8 26.cxd5+-;

C) The queen sacrifice is incorrect: 23... ♖f6 24. ♖e6 ♖xe3 25. ♖xe3 ♖xe6 26. ♖b6!±.

24. ♖xf2 ♖c7 25. ♖e1

The piece is stronger than two pawns, and White has a decisive advantage.

25... ♖xe1+ 26. ♖xe1 ♖d7 27.b5!

Creating new objects of attack in Black's camp.

27...h5 28.bxc6 bxc6 29. ♖b5 ♖b8

29... ♖d8 30. ♖c3!± (or 30. ♖a7 ♖c7 31. ♖a1±; 30. ♖xd6? ♖f5!).

30. ♖xd6! ♖xd6 31. ♖xd6 ♖xd6

32. ♖d1 ♖e6 33. ♖xd6 ♖xc4 34. ♖d4

♖e6 35. ♖xc6 ♖c8 36.h4

Black resigned.

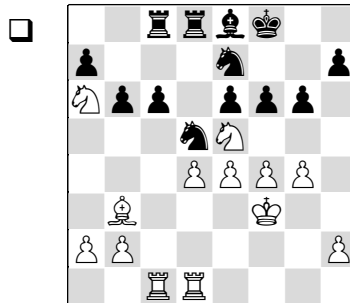
113

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Alexander Alekhine

Karel Treybal

Baden-Baden 1925 (9)

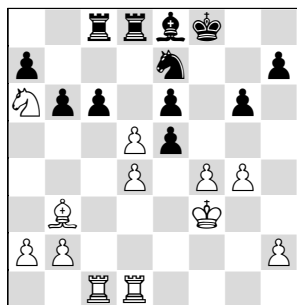


Black has an extremely passive, but solid position. To break down such positions, one must sooner or later cross the demarcation line, but which is the best way to do so? Very often, it involves a strong strategical decision, based on a small tactical point. In this case, Black has a bad bishop, limited by the pawns on c6, e6 and g6. This means that one must examine ideas connected with the weak dark squares. In particular, the pawn on f6 is crucial, covering the e5-square. Alekhine found a striking decision.

28.exd5!

If White chooses a more prosaic path, then after, say, 28. ♖c4 ♖c7 29. ♖xc7 ♖xc7 30.g5! f5 31. ♖e5 ♖d6, Black's defences remain solid.

28...fxe5



29.d6!

Without this *zwischenzug*, White's entire idea would fail, because after any recapture on e5, Black takes on d5 with the knight, retaining a rock-solid position.

29...♖xd6

Black follows the path of least resistance. He had, in his turn, to exploit a *zwischenzug*: 29...e4+!, although even in this case, he suffers from the insufficiently-defended pawn on e6: 30.♔xe4 ♕xd6 31.♔e5! (the king marches boldly into the heart of the battle, itself taking part in eliminating the e6-pawn. There are still many pieces on the board, so this decision requires courage and accurate calculation from White) 31...♖cd8 32.♖c7 (if White is not careful, then after 32.♕xe6? ♖xe6 33.♔xe6 ♕d5 34.f5 ♖g8, he is mated) 32...♕f7 33.♖xe6+ ♕xe6 34.♕xe6 ♖d5 35.f5 ♔e7 36.h3!. With this timely prophylactic move, covering g4 against a check from the knight, the king is now ready to enter f6. White retains great chances of realising his extra pawn.

30.fxe5

The rest is simple.

30...♕d5 31.♕xd5 ♖xd5 32.a3 g5 33.♖b4 ♖e7 34.♖d3 ♖d5 35.h4

gxh4 36.♖f4 ♖xf4 37.♔xf4 ♕d8 38.♔g5 ♖g7 39.♔xh4 ♕d5 40.♔g5 ♕d8 41.♖f4 ♕d7 42.♔e3 ♖b7 43.b4 a6 44.♖f1 ♕a7 45.♖f6 ♕e7 46.a4 ♔g8 47.a5 b5 48.d5 exd5 49.e6 ♔g7 50.g5 h5 51.♖d4 ♖c7 52.♔c5 ♖c8 53.♖d6 d4 54.e7

Black resigned.

114

Alexey Yuneev

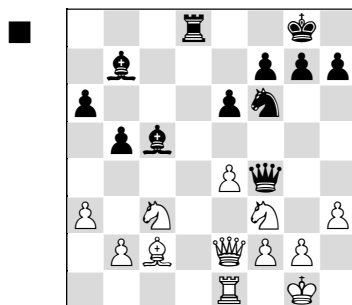
Anatoly Donchenko

Simferopol 1989

**

2345

2370



All of Black's pieces are ideally placed, but White has met all the direct threats, so Black needs to strengthen his position further. The experienced player immediately notices that the pawn chain f7-g7-h7 does not give the black king a bolthole from a back-rank mate. White has no dark-squared bishop, so it will be impossible for him to exploit any weakening resulting from the g7-pawn moving. So, if Black's pieces were less active, the prophylaxis ...g7-g6 would be useful, but in this case, thanks to his hyperactive pieces, Black chose

21...g5!

The threat ...g5-g4 breaks down White's last defensive barriers.

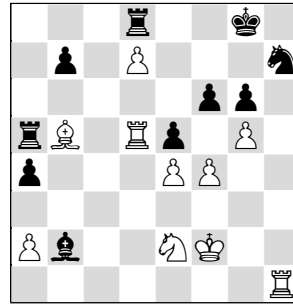
White cannot move the knight from f3 to a still more passive position, nor can he exchange on g4, allowing the black knight to recapture.

22.e5

This desperate attempt at counter-play fails, as the black pieces are too well prepared.

22...g4! 23.♖d1 ♖xd1+ 24.♔xd1 gxf3 25.♔d8+ ♜e8 26.♔xe8+ ♞g7

White resigned.



Allowing a small combination, as a result of which the passed pawns decide the game.

27.♖xh7! ♜xh7 28.gxf6 exf4 29.e5 ♜h6 30.♜xf4 ♜xe5 31.♖xe5 ♖xd7 32.♜xd7 ♖xe5 33.f7

Black resigned, since he has to give up a rook for the f-pawn.

115

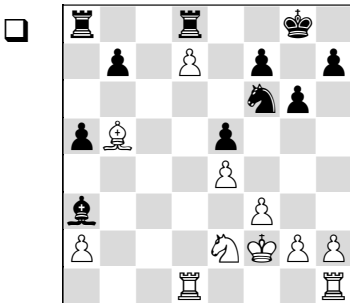
Vladimir Kramnik

2590

John Nunn

2615

Manila ol 1992 (14)



The pawn on d7 cramps Black severely, but if he manages to play ...b7-b6, ...♖a8-a7, and bring the king to e7, the pawn will be hard to maintain. Therefore White plays energetically, driving away the black knight and beginning a storm on the kingside.

20.g4! h6 21.h4 a4 22.♖d3 ♜b2

After the counterattacking blow 22...♖a5, there would follow the strengthening 23.♖b1.

23.g5 hxg5 24.hxg5 ♜h7 25.f4 ♖a5

If 25...exf4 26.♖d5, White also retains domination in the centre.

26.♖d5 f6

116

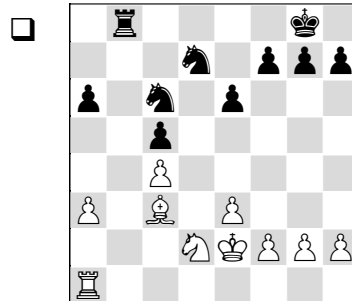
Artur Jussupow

2665

Joel Lautier

2645

Amsterdam 1994 (3)



At first glance, Black's position does not look worse. By playing ...f7-f6 and then ...e6-e5, he is ready not only to bring his king closer to the centre, but also to severely restrict the white bishop. Before this happens, White must enter the battle energetically and immediately!

19.g4!

Jussupow begins a kingside pawn advance, with the aim of preventing a complete plugging of the a1-h8 diagonal.

19...f6

The computer's recommendation looks strange: 19...f5?! 20.♖d1! ♜f6 (20...fxg4 21.♜e4 ♖b7 22.♖d6±) 21.g5 ♜e8 22.h4! – Black has only worsened his position as a result.

20.h4 ♜f7 21.h5 ♜b6

More principled is 21...h6!, but here too, White retains a solid advantage after 22.f4! e5 23.♜e4 (23.f5!?) 23...exf4 24.exf4 ♜b6 25.♖d1 ♖e8 26.♜f3 ♜xc4 27.a4±.

Even worse is 21...e5 22.♜e4 ♜b6 23.♜xc5 ♜xc4 24.♜d3 ♜d6 25.♜xa6±.

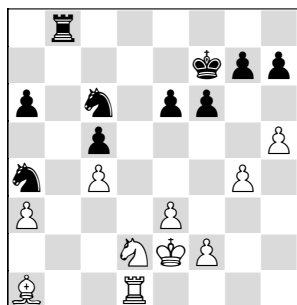
22.♖d1!

An important preparatory move. White frees the a1-square for his bishop.

22...♜a4

22...♖d8!?±.

23.♞a1



23...♜a5??

A blunder. Black is also no closer to equality after 23...♖d8 24.f4 e5 25.fxe5 ♜xe5 (25...fxe5? 26.♖b1±) 26.♞xe5 fxe5 27.♖f1+ ♜e7 28.♜e4± – the difference in piece placement guarantees White a large advantage.

And after the suggestion of game annotator Ftacnik, 23...♜e7?, the game could end at once: 24.h6! gxh6 (24...g6 25.♜e4 e5 26.♖d6+–) 25.♖h1+–.

Even so, things are not so bad for Black. It was essential to shut off White's powerful bishop with 23...♜b2!. Now:

A) 24.♖g1 h6 25.f4 ♖b6! (after 25...e5? 26.♖b1! ♜a4 27.♖xb8 ♜xb8 28.fxe5 Black loses a pawn);

B) 24.♖b1 ♜a4 25.♖g1 h6 26.f4 e5 27.fxe5 ♜xe5 28.♞xe5 fxe5 29.♜e4. In this variation, the black rook is well-placed on the b-file, which affects the assessment of the position: 29...♖b3! obtains counterplay, which may suffice for a draw: 30.g5 (30.♜f3 ♜b6!; 30.♖d1 ♜c3+ 31.♜xc3 ♖xc3) 30...♜c3+!;

C) The best reply appears to be 24.♖c1!. White defends the pawn on c4, freeing the knight at d2. 24...h6 25.f4 ♜a4 (25...♖b6? 26.♜e4 ♜a4 27.g5±) 26.g5± – White has only a small advantage.

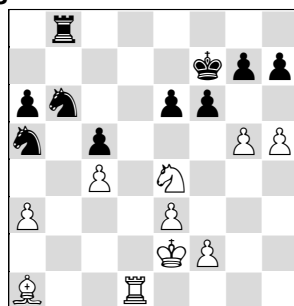
24.♜e4 ♜b6

Other continuations do not help:

A) 24...♜xc4 25.♖d7+ ♜f8 26.h6+–;

B) 24...♜e7 25.h6 f5 26.gxf5 exf5 27.♜c3 ♜xc3+ 28.♞xc3+–.

25.g5



Finally cracking open the a1-h8 diagonal.

25...f5

25...♖axc4 26.gxf6 gxf6 27.♗xf6 h6
28.♗g4+–.

26.♗xc5 ♖axc4 27.♗d7! ♜c8

Other continuations are no better:

A) 27...♜b7 28.♗xb6 ♗xb6 29.♜b1
♜b8 30.♙e5+–;

B) 27...♗xd7 28.♜xd7+ ♙e8
29.♜xg7+–.

28.♗xb6 ♗xb6 29.♞d6 ♜c2+

29...♜b8 30.♙d4+–.

30.♗f3 ♜a2 31.♙xg7 ♗c4

31...♗xg7 32.♜xb6 ♜xa3 33.♜b7+
(33.♜xe6+–) 33...♗g8 34.♗f4 ♜a5
35.g6 hxg6 36.hxg6 ♞d5 37.♗g5+–.

**32.♞d7+ ♙e8 33.♜a7 ♗d6!? 34.g6
hxg6 35.h6**

The passed h-pawn decides.

35...♗e4 36.♗g2 ♞xf2+

36...♗g5 37.♙f6+–.

**37.♗g1 ♞d2 38.h7 ♞d1+ 39.♗g2
♞d2+ 40.♗f1**

Black resigned.

117

Viktor Kortchnoi

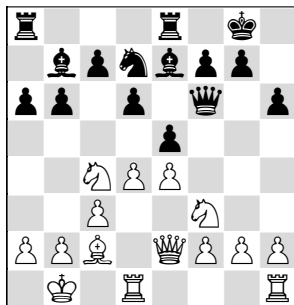
Anatoly Karpov

Hastings 1971 (14)

2670

2540

□



14.d5!

Seizing space in the centre, and
shutting out the ♙b7 with the pawn
duo e4–d5.

14...c5?

Signing the death warrant of the
♙b7, and later of his king as well.

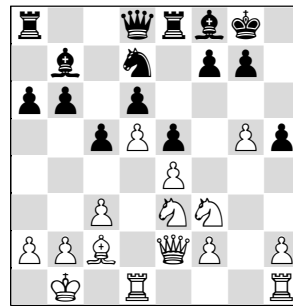
Having the two bishops, Black
should strive to open the position.
Undoubtedly, the best move was
14...c6!, with the idea of ...b6–b5 and
...♗b6.

15.♗e3 ♙f8 16.g4 ♜d8 17.g5!

White conducts the attack brilliantly.

17...h5

17...hxg5 18.h4!±.



18.g6!

The pawn battering ram leaves no
stone untouched.

18...fxg6 19.♞hg1 ♜f6 20.♗g5

A powerful alternative was doubling
rooks by 20.♞g3! ♙e7 21.♞dg1 ♗f8
22.♗g5 ♙c8 23.h4! (the queen
starts to feel uncomfortable)
23...♜f4 24.♗g2 ♜f6 25.♜e1 ♙d8
(25...♙g4 26.♗e3 ♙d8 27.♗xg4 hxg4
28.♙d1+–) 26.♜f3 ♜e7 27.♜f7 ♜xf7
28.♗xf7 ♗xf7 29.f4±.

20...♙e7 21.♗e6 ♗f8

He also loses after 21...♜ac8 22.♞g2
♗f8 23.♞dg1+–.

**22.♗c7 ♜f7 23.♞df1 b5 24.♗xa8
♙xa8 25.c4 ♜b8 26.♙d3**

White has the advantage, which he
managed to convert to victory.

**26...♜e8 27.♜c1 ♙f6 28.♞g2 ♜b6
29.♜cg1 ♜b8 30.♜f1 b4 31.♙e2
h4 32.♜xg6 ♜xg6 33.♜xg6 ♗xg6**

34.♙g4 ♘f4 35.♚d1 b3 36.axb3
♙b7 37.♘g2 ♙c8 38.♙xc8 ♚xc8
39.♚g4 ♚e8 40.♘xf4 exf4 41.♚xf4
♙e5 42.♚xh4 ♚f8 43.b4 ♙d4
44.bxc5

Black resigned.

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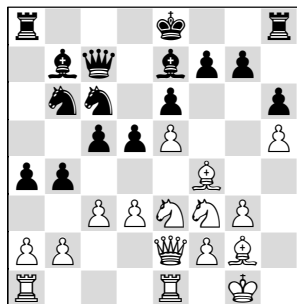
Konstantin Sakaev

Sergey Tiviakov

Khanty-Mansiysk 2005 (1)

2668

2700



This is a position from the so-called King's Indian Attack, where White plays as though he is Black, but with an extra tempo. Black's chances are connected with an attack on the queenside, especially with the move ...a4-a3. White stops this idea at the roots, along with Black's whole queenside play, by

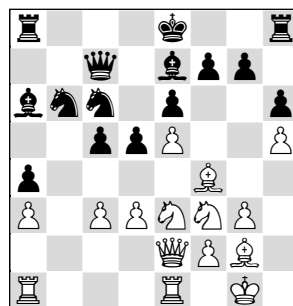
17.a3!

This move is typical in such positions. Because on the kingside and in the centre, White has a bind with the pawns on h5 and e5, and on account of his more active pieces, White stands better.

Weaker is 17.c4, since this weakens the d4-square. In this case, Black can play 17...dxc4 (playing 17...d4 and closing the d-file is unfavourable, and after 18.♘g4, the transfer of the knight from f3 to e4 gives White

the advantage) 18.dxc4 ♚d8, with a roughly equal position (even 18...0-0-0!? is possible, although the king is more comfortable on the kingside).

17...bxc3 18.bxc3 ♙a6



19.♘f5!!

Tactics in the service of strategy! Calculation of some fairly simple variations shows that the knight cannot be taken, so White gets to exchange Black's important dark-squared bishop. Effectively, the game is decided.

19...c4

A) Taking the gift is impossible: 19...exf5 20.e6 ♚c8 (no better is 20...♚d8 21.exf7+ ♙f8 22.♚ab1) 21.♚ab1 (21.exf7+ ♙xf7 22.♚ab1 ♘d7 23.♚e6+ ♙e8, and here White has numerous promising attacking ideas, e.g., 24.♚xf5 ♘f6 25.♚g6+ ♙f8 26.♘h4 or 26.♚b6, in both cases retaining a powerful attack) 21...fxe6 (21...♙d8 allows a nice mate with 22.exf7+ ♙xf7 23.♚xb6 ♙xb6 24.♘g5+ hxg5 25.♙xd5+ ♙f6 26.♚e7+ ♘xe7 27.♙e5#. Admittedly, the beauty is not necessary, and White has other ways to win) 22.♚xb6 ♘d8 23.♘e5 – Black will only last 4-5 more moves;

B) Black has clearly insufficient compensation for the exchange in

the variation 19...0-0-0 20.♖d6+ (the direct 20.♖xe7+ definitely retains a solid advantage also) 20...♖xd6 21.exd6 ♖xd6 22.♖xd6 ♖xd6 23.♖ab1 ♖c7. For example, White can prepare the doubling of the rooks on the b-file with 24.♖b2, or adopt a more subtle strategy, removing his queen from the x-ray of the ♖a6 with the move 24.♖e3;

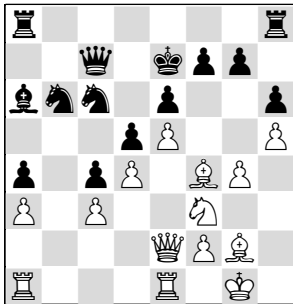
C) Also bad is 19...0-0 20.♖xe7+ – White will advance the g-pawn, and open lines for an attack on the kingside;

D) The most stubborn is 19...♖c8 20.♖xe7 ♖8xe7, and Black is still holding his defensive lines.

20.d4 ♖f8

20...exf5 21.e6 is even worse for Black than a move earlier.

21.♖xe7 ♖xe7 22.g4



There are no direct threats, but Black's position is lost – White is too strong on the kingside and the weakness of the dark squares must tell.

22...♖a5 23.♖h4

Even stronger than 23.g5. White prepares the advance of the f-pawn.

23...♖b3 24.♖a2 ♖d8 25.♖g3 ♖e7

26.f4 ♖c8 27.♖f1

White is in no hurry.

27...♖c7 28.f5 ♖g5

The best practical chance. There is no hope from 28...♖b7 29.fxe6 ♖xe6 30.♖f5 ♖xf5 31.gxf5.

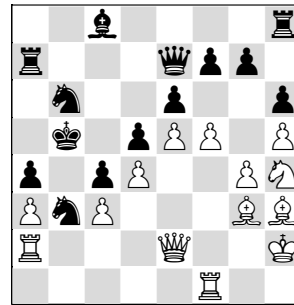
29.♖c2

There is no need to allow the knight to jump from b3 to c1.

29...♖c6 30.♖h2

White's victory is just a matter of time, but he could have ended Black's sufferings at once: 30.fxe6 ♖xe6 (30...fxe6 31.♖g6 ♖g8 32.♖h4, trapping the queen) 31.♖f5 ♖xf5 (otherwise 32.♖h4) 32.♖xf5 ♖e7 33.♖xd5+ (33.e6 fxe6 34.♖xd5+ ♖xd5 35.♖xd5) 33...♖xd5 34.♖xc4+ ♖c5 35.♖xf7 ♖xf7 36.♖xc5+ ♖d7 37.♖d6+ ♖c8 38.♖c6+ ♖c7 39.e6, winning.

30...♖e7 31.♖a2 ♖b5 32.♖h3 ♖a7



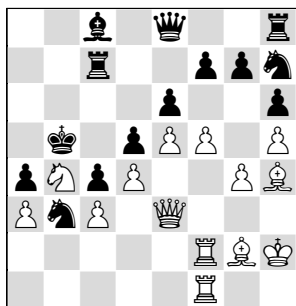
33.♖g2!

Before storming the citadel, White strengthens the position of his pieces to the maximum.

33...♖d7 34.♖h4 ♖e8 35.♖e3 ♖f8 36.♖g2 ♖c6 37.♖c2 ♖h7 38.♖b4

Now, there are constant threats of a sacrifice on d5, and the a3-pawn is protected from the attack by the black queen. White can undertake a new series of manoeuvres.

38...♖d7 39.♖e3 ♖c7 40.♖af2 ♖e8



Thus, White has brought all of his pieces to their ideal positions, except the light-squared bishop. Wanting to avoid radical measures such as a sacrifice on d5, he transfers the bishop to c2, from where it will operate on the b1-h7 diagonal.

41. ♖f3! ♜b7 42. ♜d1

Black cannot survive the bishop landing on c2, so he decides on radical measures, but they do not bring any relief.

42... ♜xf5 43. ♜xf5 f6 44. e6

Of course, it was not essential to close the whole position, but the black pieces totally lack coordination, and there can be no question of his building a fortress. Now, a new, this time final, series of manoeuvres begins, which eventually settles the game.

44... ♜e7 45. ♜g3 ♜cc8 46. ♜f4 ♜g5 47. ♜g2 ♜hd8 48. ♜h1 ♜b6 49. ♜g1 ♜h8 50. ♜g4 ♜cd8 51. ♜h2 ♜a8 52. ♜e2 ♜c8 53. ♜f1 ♜a5 54. ♜g2

Since Black has played ...e6xf5, the pawn on d5 became one of his main weaknesses, and White's bishop now attacks it.

54... ♜cd8 55. ♜h1 ♜b7 56. ♜f1 ♜b3 57. ♜g3 ♜a8 58. ♜e2 ♜he8 59. ♜f3 ♜a5 60. ♜g2 ♜b7 61. ♜h4 ♜b3 62. ♜h2 ♜h7 63. ♜e3 ♜a5

The white pieces are ideally placed. If 63... ♜g5, White is already prepared to open lines with 64. ♜xg5 hxg5 65. h6 gxh6 66. ♜xh6, winning.

64. e7! ♜xe7 65. ♜xd5 ♜xd5 66. ♜xd5

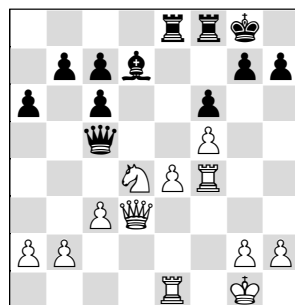
Black resigned.

119

Robert Fischer

Wolfgang Unzicker

Siegen ol 1970 (7)



White cannot exploit the d-file to develop his initiative, but Black too needs many tempi to be able to use it to create counterplay. White should therefore seize space on the kingside.

19. g4!

The pawn on f5 is further strengthened, and the black bishop's scope reduced. White's plan in the near future is the advance e4-e5, or g4-g5, according to the situation.

19... ♜d6 20. ♜g3 ♜e7

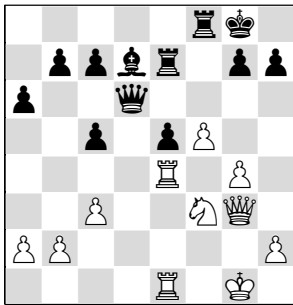
Black passively awaits the white offensive, whereas he could have secured sufficient counterplay by freeing some space for his pieces: 20...g6!. There is an unpleasant threat of ...c6-c5, when the white knight cannot retreat to f3, because of ...g6-g5.

21. ♖f3 c5 22. e5!

A deep penetration into the secrets of the position. Black cannot exploit the opening of the long diagonal, because of the powerful centralisation of the white pieces.

The text is stronger than 22. g5 ♖h8 23. gxf6 gxf6 24. ♖g4 ♙c6, with a complicated battle.

22... ♗xe5 23. ♖fe4



23... ♙c6

Once again, it was essential to take the chance to break up the white pawn duo g4/f5, although this time, there are two ways of doing so:

A) 23... h5 24. ♖h4 ♙c6 25. ♖e4e3 ♙e8 26. g5 e4, with counterplay;

B) 23... g6 24. fxc6 (24. ♖xe5 allows Black to exploit the g-file for counterplay with 24... ♖g7!) 24... hxc6 25. ♖xe5 ♖fe8 26. ♖xd7 ♖xd7 – on account of his extra pawn on the kingside, White is better, but he has few chances to realise this advantage, as it is hard in the resulting queen ending to avoid perpetual check.

24. ♖xe5 ♖fe8 25. ♖xe7 ♖xe7

26. ♖e5 h6 27. h4 ♙d7

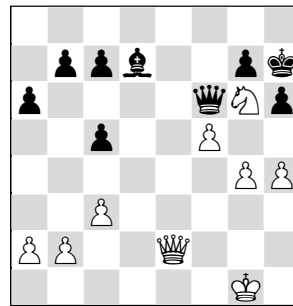
After 27... b6 or 27... ♖d5, there is the unpleasant 28. g5!. More accurate is 27... ♖d2! 28. ♖f2 ♖d5! 29. ♖xc6 ♖xe1+ 30. ♖xe1 ♖xc6 – Black is slightly worse, but he should not lose.

28. ♖f4 ♖f6 29. ♖e2 ♙c8 30. ♖c4+ ♖h7 31. ♖g6 ♖xe2 32. ♖xe2 ♙d7?

This allows the queens to be exchanged, after which the exposed position of the white king ceases to be so important.

It was essential to play 32... ♖d6!, still retaining chances of a successful defence.

Exchanges/ Simplification



33. ♖e7! ♖xe7 34. ♖xe7 g5 35. hxc6 hxc6 36. ♖d5 ♙c6 37. ♖xc7 ♙f3 38. ♖e8 ♖h6 39. ♖f6 ♖g7 40. ♖f2 ♙d1 41. ♖d7 c4 42. ♖g3 1-0

120

Vladimir Kramnik

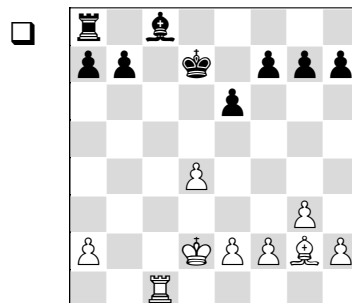
Joel Lautier

Belgrade 1995 (9)

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2730

2645



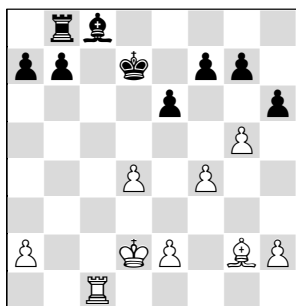
The ending looks almost equal: there are no entry squares on the c-file, and no play in the centre.

But Black needs time to develop his play, by means of ...a8-b8, ...b7-b6 and ...c8-b7. This gives White the chance to seize space and create something to 'bite on' on the kingside.

18.q4! h6

Otherwise, g4-g5 is unpleasant, followed by the transfer of the rook along the third rank.

19.f4! ♖b8 20.g5



20...b6?

Now, an island is created on h6, which White successfully attacks. Black would be close to making a draw after the correct line 20...hgx5

21.fxg5 b6 22.h4 g6! – the black pawns are on the same colour squares as his bishop, but Black will be able to play ...♗c8-b7 and solve this problem.

21.gxh6 gxh6 22.♖c3 ♔b7 23.♕xb7
♕xb7 24.♖h3 ♖c7 25.♖xh6 ♖c4
26.♖h3 ♖xd4+

Despite his pawn minus, 26...♖a4 27.a3 ♖a5 would still retain drawing chances.

27. ♖d3 ♜xd3 28. ♔xd3

Evidently, Black wrongly assessed this pawn ending. But the outside passed pawn, as so often, brings White the victory.

28...f6 29.♔c4 a6 30.f5

The preliminary 30.e4 also wins.

30...d6

30...exf5 31.♔d5 would allow White to take the opposition.

31.fxe6 ♖xe6 32.♔d4 ♕f5 33.♔d5
 ♕f4 34.♔e6 f5 35.e3+ ♕g4 36.h3+
 ♕g5 37.h4+ ♕g6 38.h5+ ♕g5
 39.h6 ♕g6 40.h7 ♕xh7 41.♔xf5
 ♕g7 42.♔e6

Black resigned.

Additional material

Alekhine-Nimzowitsch, San Remo 1930

Karpov-Salov, Linares 1993

Alekhine-Capablanca, the Netherlands 1938

Tarrasch-Lasker, Düsseldorf Wch (match/4) 1908

Karpov-Andersson, New York 1969

Geller-Hort, Skopje 1968

Alekhine-Chajes, Carlsbad 1923

Petrosian-Bondarevsky, Moscow 1950

Kasparov-Smirin, Moscow 1988

Ehlvest-Kasparov, Reykjavik 1988

Karpov-Kasparov, London Wch (match/7) 1986

Chapter 17

The problem of exchanges. Simplifying positions

To exchange or not? Which pieces should be kept on the board? Such questions are asked by a player many times in the course of a game. In general, one can formulate a few main principles.

One should not exchange:

- a) an already developed piece for an opponent's undeveloped one.
- b) an active piece for a passive one.
- c) a piece on the flank where you are weaker, if this piece is fulfilling defensive functions.

d) queens, if you are attacking or are about to attack the enemy king.

e) pieces, if you have a space advantage.

It is useful to exchange:

a) pieces, if you have a material advantage or the opponent has weaknesses in his pawn structure.

b) strong pieces and pawns of the opponent.

c) your own weak, doubled or backward pawns.

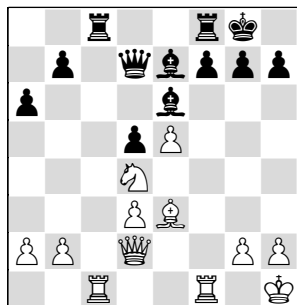
d) queens, if you are defending.

121

Alexey Suetin

Alexander Cherepkov

Minsk 1962 (3)



When the opponent has a pair of bishops, even the 'bad' one of the two is potentially dangerous. After

20. ♖g5!

★

the light-squared bishop risks being left without its partner and relatively impotent for the rest of the game.

20... ♗xg5?

Underestimating the future danger. Black probably understood that this exchange is unfavourable for him, but did not want to risk declining it. But wrongly, because after 20... ♗c5!, although the squares g7 and f6 become weak, White is not able to exploit this: 21. ♖f6 (21. ♗f3 d4 22. ♖f6 ♗f5=; 21. ♗xe6 fxe6=; 21. ♗f4 ♗xd4 22. ♗xd4 ♗xc1 23. ♗xc1 ♗c8=) 21... gxf6 22. ♗xc5 ♗xc5 23. ♗h6 fxe5 24. ♗g5+ ♗h8 25. ♗f6+ ♗g8 leads only to perpetual check.

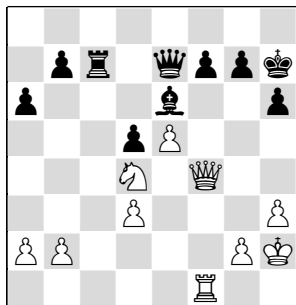
21. ♗xg5 h6 22. ♗f4 ♗xc1 23. ♗xc1 ♗c8

After the rooks come off, it is not clear how Black's fortress can be taken, since if the knight moves anyway, the bishop activates itself via f5. White therefore turns his attention to the kingside.

24. ♖f1! ♜e7 25. h3!

Necessary prophylaxis. Before starting the storm with the g-pawn, the king prepares a flight on h2.

25... ♜c7 26. ♘h2 ♘h7



27. g4! ♘g8

The queen sally does not work: 27... ♜b4 28. ♖xe6 ♜xb2+ (28... ♜xf4+ 29. ♖xf4+-) 29. ♖f2 ♜c2 30. ♖f8+ ♘h8 31. ♘g2+-.

28. ♘g3!

The white king takes part in developing the initiative!

28... ♜g5?!

Black decides to exchange queens, which is a dubious decision. After all, with his previous moves, White has exposed his king, and thanks to this, Black has good chances in the future to give perpetual check.

29. h4 ♜xf4+ 30. ♘xf4 ♘f8 31. g5 hxg5+ 32. hxg5 ♘e7 33. ♖h1

With the help of a nice tactic, White could have pulled out the carpet from under the ♘e6: 33.g6! fxg6 34. ♖g1! ♘f7 35.e6! ♘e8 (35... ♘xe6

36. ♖e1+-) 36. ♘e5, with absolute domination.

33... ♜c8 34. ♘e3 ♘d7 35. ♖h7

If possible, it is usually good to drive as many enemy pawns as possible onto squares of the same colour as his bishop, so as to hamper it.

35... g6 36. ♖h1

White does not force events, relying on the principle 'Do not hurry'. Also strong was 36. ♖e2, heading to f4.

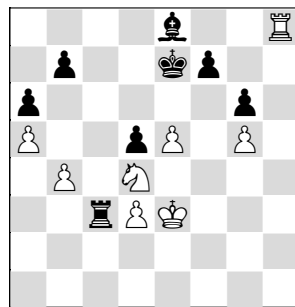
36... ♘g4 37. ♘d2 ♖e8 38. ♘e3 ♜c8 39. a4 ♘d7 40. a5

Yet another pawn is fixed on a light square.

40... ♜c5 41. ♖a1 ♜c8 42. ♖h1 ♜c5 43. b4 ♜c3 44. ♖h8 ♘e8

The bishop, which stops the enemy rook using the back rank, is now as passive as it could be. It is time for the decisive blow:

The breakthrough



45. e6! fxg6 46. ♖h7+ ♘d6

Nor are there any hopes from 46... ♘f7 47. ♖f3 ♘f8 48. ♖e5 ♜c7 49. ♖h1, transferring the rook to h6.

47. ♖xb7 e5 48. ♖b6+ ♘c7 49. ♖e6+ ♘c8 50. ♖c5 ♘b5 51. ♖xg6 e4 52. ♖g8+ ♘c7 53. g6 ♘xd3 54. g7 ♘c4+ 55. ♖d4 ♖g3 56. ♖a8

Black resigned.

122

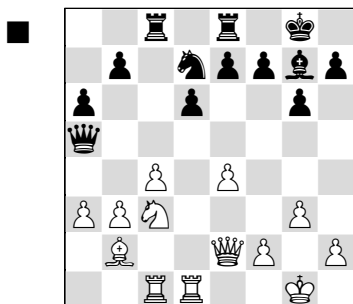
Predrag Nikolic

Vigen Mirumian

Yerevan ol 1996 (2)

2670

2430



White's pawn structure is compromised, with b3 being especially weak. However, the queen on a5 prevents Black attacking b3 with the move ...♘d7-c5, whilst the white queen, by contrast, cements a group of central squares. Therefore, without fearing a slight weakening of his kingside structure, Black played

20...♙h5!

White fell for it, and after

21.♙xh5

(he should have preferred 21.f3)

21...gxf3 22.♙a1 ♘c5 23.♞b1

♙xc3! 24.♙xc3 ♘xe4 25.♙a1 ♞c6

26.♞d4 f5 27.♞bd1 ♙f7

Black obtained a healthy extra pawn, which he gradually realised. There followed:

28.f3 ♘c5 29.♞b1 ♞ec8 30.♙g2

♞b6 31.b4 ♘e6 32.♞d5 ♞xc4

33.♞xf5+ ♙g6 34.♞d5 ♞c2+ 35.♙h1

♘g5 36.♞d3 ♞bc6 37.♙d4 ♞e2

38.h4 ♘f7 39.♙g1 ♞cc2 40.♙f1

♘h6 41.♞e1 ♘f5 42.♞xe2 ♘g3+

43.♙e1 ♞xe2+ 44.♙d1 ♞h2 45.♞c3

♞xh4 46.♙f2 ♞h1+ 47.♙d2 ♘f5

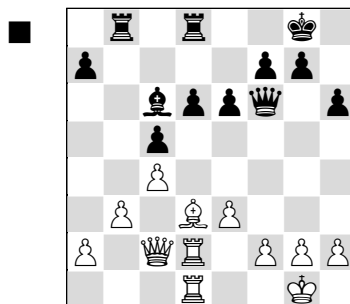
White resigned.

123

Friedrich Sämisch

Alexander Alekhine

Dresden 1926 (1)



Black has a plan to undermine the white pawn structure with ...a7-a5-a4. But before proceeding with this, he should think about what his opponent intends. What does White want to do here? He wants to play ♙d3-e4, exchanging his bad bishop and increasing the pressure against d6. Black prevents this by activating his queen:

19...♙e5! 20.♙b2?

After the exchange of queens, Black gets the chance to bring his king to e7, eliminating any worries over the defence of d6. White should have preferred 20.♞e1, with the idea of driving the enemy queen out of the centre with f2-f4.

20...♙xb2 21.♞xb2 a5 22.♞bd2

♙f8 23.♙c2 ♙e7 24.f3

If 24.a4, then 24...d5!, and the white queenside pawns become an object of attack all the same.

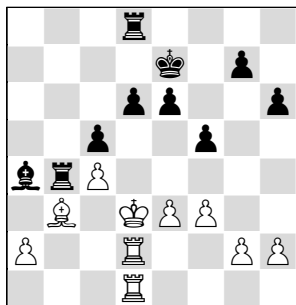
24...a4 25.♙f2 axb3 26.♙xb3

26.axb3 would leave fewer pawn 'islands', but would not solve all the problems – White has a bad bishop, and the b3-pawn is weak.

26...f5 27.♙e2 ♞b4

It looks stronger first to seize space on the kingside with 27...g5, intending ...h6-h5 and ...g5-g4.

28.♔d3 ♖a4

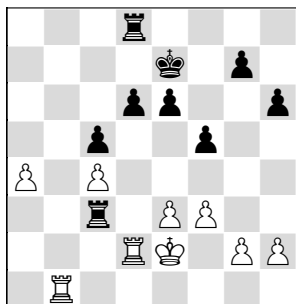


29.♙xa4?

Now the weaknesses are even harder to defend. He had to play 29.♙c3! ♖db8 30.♖b1 (but not 30.♖xd6? ♖xb3!-+). Sooner or later, Black will have to retreat the bishop into his own camp.

29...♖xa4 30.♖b1 ♖a3+ 31.♙e2 ♖c3 32.a4

Rook ending



32...♖a3!

The rook should go behind the enemy passed pawn! This rule almost always applies.

32...♖xc4 33.♖a2 allows White to obtain counterplay.

33.♖b7+ ♖d7 34.♖db2 ♖xa4

35.♖xd7+ ♙xd7 36.♖b7+ ♙c6!

37.♖xg7 ♖xc4 38.♖g6 ♔d5 39.♖xh6 ♖c2+ 40.♙f1 c4 41.♖h8 c3 42.h4

42.♖c8 f4! 43.exf4 ♔d4 – the king penetrates to the heart of White's position, after which the d-pawn decides.

42...♖d2 43.♙e1 ♖xg2 44.♖c8 c2 45.h5 ♖h2 46.h6 ♖xh6 47.♖xc2 ♖h1+ 48.♙d2 ♖h2+ 49.♙d3 ♖xc2

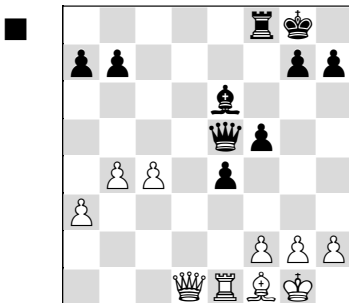
White resigned.

124

Frederick Yates

Alexander Alekhine

The Hague 1921 (8)



Black's position is preferable, thanks to his active pieces and space advantage. If there were knights on the board, he would have good chances of penetrating the white position, or starting a kingside attack by posting his knight on f4, but in this position, his attacking chances are not so great. The most important factor for the assessment of the position is control of the d-file. Black seizes the only open file, even being willing to exchange major pieces to do so, and this is all because his queen is much more actively placed.

23...♙c3! 24.♙c1

On 24.♖e3, there would follow 24...♗f6 and ...♖f8-d8.

24...♗xc1 25.♖xc1 ♖d8 26.g3

Fixing a favourable kingside pawn structure for Black.

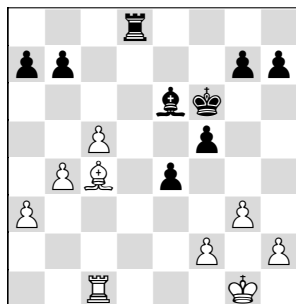
White misses a brilliant defensive resource of a counter-exchange, but this time of pawns: 26.f3! exf3 (or 26...e3 27.f4 – the pawn on e3 cannot be held) 27.gxf3 ♖f7 28.c5 – Black has lost his space advantage and has only slightly more centralised pieces, which should not suffice for victory.

26...♖f7 27.c5 ♖f6!

The white c-pawn is not supported sufficiently by pieces and so does not represent a danger. Black simply strengthens his centralisation, underlining the difference in the activity of the kings – the white king, shut in on g1, does not take any active part in the battle.

28.♙c4

His problems are not solved by 28.c6 bxc6 29.♖xc6, on account of 29...♖c8! (the hasty 29...♖d1 30.♖g2 ♖e5 31.♙c4 leads to a draw) 30.♖a6 (30.♖xc8 ♙xc8 – the black king goes to d4 and then to the queenside) 30...♖c1 31.♖g2 ♖e5 32.♖xa7 ♙d5, and because of the passive position of his king, White stands badly.



28...♙c8!

Here, the bishop is ready to block the c-pawn effectively, the latter being White's only hope of counterplay. Black also needs to retain some pieces on the board, especially as the white bishop is firing into the air.

29.a4 g5 30.b5 f4 31.♖f1 ♖d2 32.♖e1 ♖b2 33.gxf4 gxf4 34.♙e2 ♖e5 35.c6 bxc6 36.♖xc6?

It was essential to play out his trumps, in the form of the far-advanced passed pawn. After 36.bxc6! ♖b4 (on 36...f3 37.♙d1 e3 there is the saving resource 38.♖c2!), 37.♙d1 retains every chance of a successful defence.

36...♙e6 37.♙d1 ♖b1

White falls into a deadly pin, which decides the outcome of the game.

38.♖c5+

38.♙d2 e3+ 39.fxe3 fxe3+ 40.♖e2 ♙g4+ leads to the loss of the bishop.

38...♙d4 39.♖c2 e3 40.fxe3 fxe3 41.♖c6 ♙g4 42.♖d6+ ♖c5 43.h3 ♙h5

White resigned.

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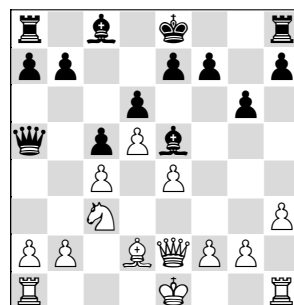
Konstantin Sakaev

Igor Kurnosov

Moscow 2006 (8)

2669

2549



13.♘b5

A sensible decision. Black's dark-squared bishop is significantly more active than its opposite number, so the exchange favours White. The alternative is 13.f4 ♖g7 14.e5 0-0 15.0-0. The white centre looks very good. White probably has the advantage, but Black also has his trumps – the bishop pair and the prospect of playing ...b7-b5. White is also unable to advance his centre, without giving the black bishops too much scope. White's task over the next few moves is to further strengthen the pawn on e5, transferring the bishop to c3 and play ♖ae1.

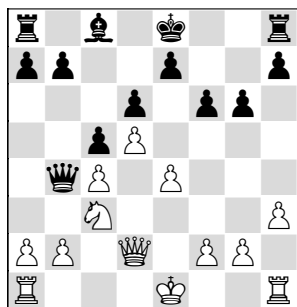
13... ♖b6 14. ♖c3 f6!

A very good move – in the event of the immediate exchange on c3, the threat of e4-e5 would hang over Black's head.

15. ♖d2

By creating the threat of ♖c3-a5, White manages to force Black to exchange on c3.

15... ♖xc3 16. ♖xc3 ♖b4



The advance ...b7-b5 is Black's only active plan.

17.b3 a6 18.0-0

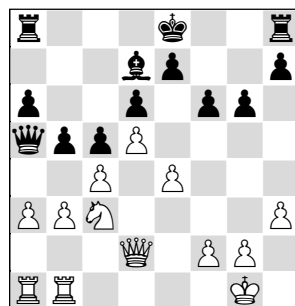
He could prevent ...b7-b5 by playing 18. ♖b2 ♖a5 (18...b5 is bad because of 19.a3 ♖a5 20.b4) 19.a3, whilst the immediate 19.a4 is also interesting:

19... ♖c7 20.a4, retaining a small advantage.

18...b5 19. ♖fb1!

Indirectly defending the pawn on c4 – on 19...bxc4, there follows 20.a3, regaining the pawn on the next move.

19... ♖d7 20.a3 ♖a5

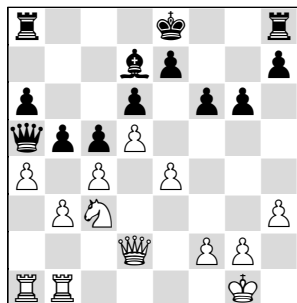


21.a4!?

An unexpected decision, posing Black a dilemma. Tempting is 21.b4, but in this case, after 21... ♖c7 22.cxb5 axb5, mass pawn exchanges on the queenside simplify the position, and a drawish position approaches with the speed of an express train: 23. ♖d3 (or 23. ♖e3 cxb4 24. ♖xb4 ♖a5 25. ♖ab1 ♖xa3 26. ♖4b3 ♖a7 27. ♖h6 ♖f7 28. ♖xb5 ♖xb5 29. ♖xb5 ♖d4 30. ♖5b4 ♖e5, with rapid further exchanges and a draw) 23... ♖f7! (in the case of 23...c4 24. ♖d2 0-0 25. ♖e1 ♖a6 26. ♖e3 ♖fa8 27. ♖b2, White has a small but stable advantage. He plans to put his king on h2, after which there follows f2-f4, and a further unhurried preparation of the advance e4-e5) 24. ♖xb5 ♖xb5 25. ♖xb5 cxb4 26. ♖xb4 (weak is 26.axb4 ♖hb8 27. ♖d3 ♖xa1 28. ♖xa1 ♖xb4, and Black already has a small advantage. His plan is simple – to exchange queens, and then

undermine the white d5-pawn with ...f6-f5) 26...♖hb8 27.♗e1 ♜xb1 28.♗xb1 ♜c4.

Nor does anything special result from 21.♗e3 ♜c7 22.♗h6 ♔f7.



21...bxc4?

A positional mistake. Correct was 21...b4! 22.♖e2 g5! (otherwise, there follows f2-f4, preparing e4-e5) 23.♖g3 0-0-0. The white knight goes to f5, but Black's defences are very solid, and accurate defence should earn him a draw.

Now, however, White has the open b-file, which, in conjunction with the rapid opening of the e-file, should bring him a strong initiative.

22.bxc4 0-0 23.♖b7 ♖c8 24.♖b3 f5

An attempt to open the position somewhat. No better is 24...♖d7 25.♗b2 – White takes control of the b-file, and prepares f2-f4 and e4-e5.

25.exf5 ♖xf5 26.♗e1 ♖ae8 27.♖b7 ♖f7 28.♗e3!

Before the decisive storm, the white pieces occupy ideal positions.

28...♖c8 29.♖b8 ♖ef8 30.f3

Continuing the strategy he has been following for a long time. In such positions, the pawn is excellent on a light square, whilst the enemy light-squared bishop is ineffective.

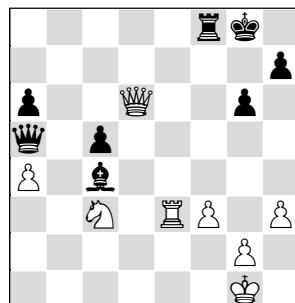
30...♖d7 31.♖b7 e5

Already in serious time-trouble, Black tries to break out, but now his light squares are irretrievably weakened.

32.dxe6 ♖xe6 33.♖xf7 ♖xf7

34.♗xd6 ♖xc4

Dynamics. Quiet/ prophylactic moves in the middle of an attack



35.♖h2!

The king steps out of checks on the first rank (the queen covers the b8-h2 diagonal, and White can also always play f3-f4), emphasising the hopelessness of Black's position. Quite often, when direct threats are not available, it pays to ask yourself which of your pieces or pawns is not ideally placed, and improve it.

As it happens, White can also win with the direct 35.♖e4 ♗xa4 (there are very few chances of saving the endgame after 35...♗d8 36.♗xc5 ♗d1 37.♖h2 ♗d5) 36.♖f6+ ♖g7 37.♗e7+ ♖f7 38.♖d7, but from a practical point of view, the course chosen by White is more reliable – now there will not be a sudden mate at the end of a variation.

35...♖f7 36.♖e4 ♗xa4 37.♖f6+

♖g7 38.♖d7 ♖c8 39.♗f6+ ♖g8

40.♗e7 ♗b3 41.♖e5 ♖f8 42.♖xf7

Black resigned.

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Evgeny Bareev

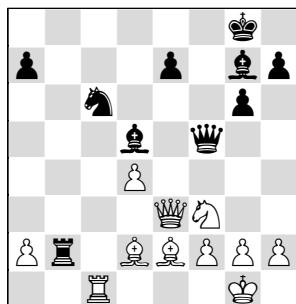
Ilya Gurevich

Hastings 1992 (2)

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2670

2510



The bishop on d5 is the pride of Black's position. It defends the knight at c6, covers the light squares around its own king, and exerts pressure on the white position.

20. ♖c4!

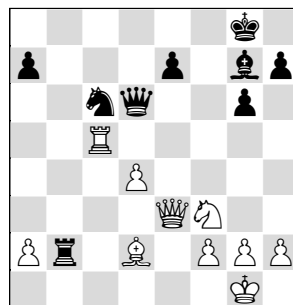
After the exchange of the key piece, the black position collapses.

20... ♗xc4 21. ♖xc4 ♖d5

Black cannot exploit the lack of a bolthole for the white king: 21... ♖b1+ 22. ♖e1! (White loses his advantage after 22. ♖c1? ♖d5, because on 23. ♖c5?, Black has the zwischenzug 23... ♗xd4!, and after 24. ♖xd5 ♖xe3 25. fxe3 ♖xc1+ 26. ♖f2 ♖a1, White already has to fight for a draw). The knight on c6 is hanging, and it cannot be strengthened: 22... ♖d5 23. ♖c5 ♖d7 24. ♖e4 ♖b6 25. d5+.

22. ♖c5 ♖d6

More tenacious, but still not saving the game, is 22... ♖d7 23. ♖d3 e6 24. h3!. An important prophylaxis. White has a decisive advantage, because the pawn on d4 is untouchable: 24... ♗xd4 25. ♗xd4 ♖xd4 26. ♖e3 ♖b4 27. a3 ♖a4 28. ♖b5 – the rook reaches the 7th and 8th ranks, with a decisive attack.



23. ♖e4! ♗xd4

On 23... ♖b6, the most technical response is 24. g3!, with the threat of ♗d2-f4 (the immediate 24. ♖f4? is too hasty because of 24... e5!, and Black can still defend).

24. ♖c8+ ♖f8

24... ♖f7 25. ♗g5+ ♖f6 26. ♗xh7+ ♖f7 27. ♗g5+ ♖f6 28. ♖c3+.

25. ♖h6 ♖b8

Nor is there any hope from 25... ♗xf3+ 26. gxf3 ♖b8, because of 27. ♖c4+! e6 28. ♖xb8! ♖xb8 29. ♖xe6+ ♖h8 30. ♖e3, winning the a7-pawn.

26. ♖xf8+ ♖xf8 27. ♗xd4 ♖d8

28. ♗f3 ♖d1+ 29. ♗e1 ♖f7

To obtain saving chances, Black needs to exchange queens, but White does not allow this:

30. ♖g5! ♖d7 31. h4

The king is ready to go to h2, after which the knight joins the attack decisively.

31... h6

31... ♖d5 32. ♖f4+ ♖f5 33. ♖e3 ♖e6 34. ♖c3 ♖xa2 35. ♗f3+.

32. ♖xh6 ♖d6 33. a3 ♖a1

33... ♖e6 34. ♖f3+ ♖xf3 35. ♗xf3 ♖a6 36. ♖c1+-. White has won a pawn on the kingside, and the win does not pose any great difficulties.

34. ♖d2

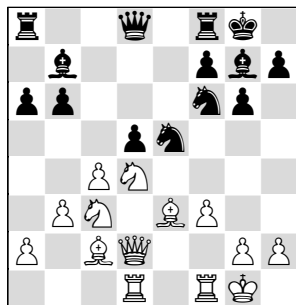
Black resigned.

127

Lev Polugaevsky

Leonid Stein

Moscow ch-URS 1961 (1)



17. ♖h6

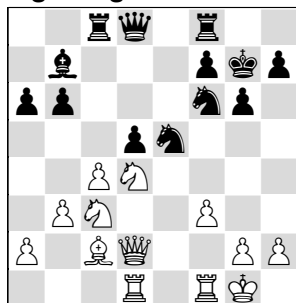
After the exchange of dark-squared bishops, Black is left with a badly limited light-squared bishop and various weak dark squares on the kingside.

Another, more academic approach, exploits a small tactic: 17.cxd5 ♘xd5 (Black can play for the initiative with 17...♙c8, but after, for example, 18.♗de2 it is not worth the sacrificed pawn) 18.♗c6! (18.♗xd5 ♙xd5 19.♙b4 ♙c5!=) 18...♙xc6 19.♗xd5 ♙xd5 20.♙xd5 ♙xd5 21.♙xd5 b5 22.♙fd1 ♙ac8 23.♙b1 ♙fe8 24.♙f2, retaining pressure on the black position.

17... ♙c8

In the event of 17... ♙xc6 18.♙xc6, the threat of ♗c3-e4 hangs over Black.

18. ♙xc6 ♙xc6



**

19. ♙g5!

Combining pressure on the d-file with the threat ♗f5+ leads to a win.

19... ♗c6

19... ♗ed7 20.♗f5+ ♙g8 21.♗d6 ♙c7 22.♗xb7 ♙xb7 23.♗xd5+.

20. ♗f5+ ♙h8 21. ♗xd5 ♗xd5

22. ♙h6 ♙f6 23. ♙xd5

An even more convincing way to win was 23.cxd5 ♗e7 24.♗xe7 ♙xe7 25.d6 ♙d7 26.♙e4.

23... ♙fd8 24. ♙xd8+ ♙xd8 25. ♙e4

♗d4 26. ♗g3 ♙xe4 27. ♙xe4

Also good is 27.♗xe4, not creating weaknesses in his camp. But as well as his extra pawn, White also wants the initiative.

27... ♙e7 28. ♙f4 ♙g8 29. e5 ♗e6

30. ♙f6 ♙xf6 31. ♙xf6

This pawn in Black's camp is a strength not a weakness.

31... ♙d2 32. ♙f2 ♙d1+ 33. ♗f1 g5

34. ♙d2 ♙xd2 35. ♗xd2 h6 36. ♗e4

♙h7 37. b4 ♙g6 38. g4 ♗f4 39. c5

bxc5 40. bxc5 1-0

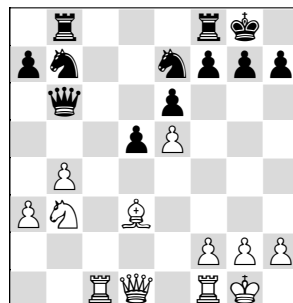
128

**

Anatoly Karpov

Vladimir Bagirov

Riga ch-URS 1970 (12)



Black's main problem is the ♗b7, which has no prospects. The queen defends against the rook's entry on

c7 and the bishop's on a6, so White plays to exchange queens, having in mind the possibility of later creating a passed pawn on the queenside.

27. ♖g4! f5

Black could also defend against the threat of ♕d3xh7+ by provoking White to exchange off his bishop with 27...♗g6, but after 28.♕xg6 hxg6, White can seize the c-file: 29.♖c3! ♜bc8 30.♖fc1 ♜xc3 31.♖xc3 a5, and here, instead of 32.♖d4, even stronger is 32.h4!, with the additional threat of h4-h5.

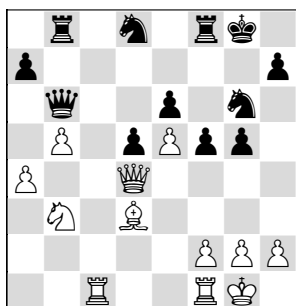
28. ♖d4! ♗d8 29.b5

White creates a passed pawn, as well as taking the square c6 from the black knight.

29...g5

A desperate attempt at counterplay against the pawn on e5 – now White cannot defend it with f2-f4. But White can manage without this, as his pieces dominate.

30.a4 ♗g6



31. ♖a1!

The situation has changed somewhat, and White changes plans – with the queens on, the weakness of the black king, caused by the move ...g7-g5, can still be important.

In addition, the black queen is hit with tempo.

31... ♖b7 32. ♖fe1 ♖g7 33. ♗c5 ♖f7 34.a5 ♖e7 35. ♗a6 ♖a8 36. ♗f1 ♗f7 37. ♗c7 ♖d8 38. ♖c6 ♗f8 39.b6 axb6 40.a6

Now, White also controls the promotion square of the passed pawn, so this is more technical than the capture 40.axb6. However, there is no great difference, and the position is simply winning.

40... ♗h6 41. ♖ec1 ♗g4 42.a7 ♗xe5 43. ♖6c2 ♗c4 44.a8 ♖ ♖xa8 45. ♗xa8 b5 46. ♖a2 ♖b7 1-0

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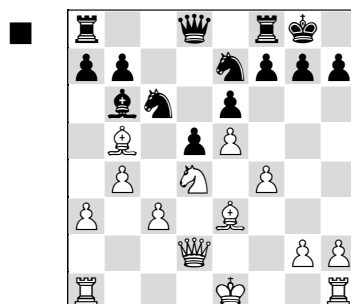
Viktor Bologan

2585

Rafael Vaganian

2640

Groningen 1997 (2)



White's central pawn structure is compromised, and the weaknesses created by the advance b2-b4 allow us to assess the position as somewhat better for Black.

14... ♗xd4!

If Black instead takes with 14...♗xd4, then after 15.cxd4, his bishop on b6 is passive, and White's position would suddenly look preferable.

Black could of course attack the white pawn structure with 14...a5, but in this case, White would have the opportunity to simplify by exchanging his ineffective light-

squared bishop: 15.♙xc6! bxc6 16.0-0 c5 17.bxc5 ♙xc5 18.a4. Having the outpost on b5, White is close to equality.

15.cxd4 a5

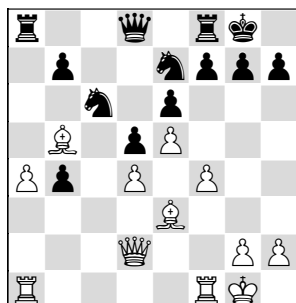
The position is closed, and as well as his weakened structure, White also has a hole on c4. In time, the black knight may land there.

16.0-0

At minimal material cost, White completes his development.

16.bxa5 ♘xa5 17.♖d3 ♘c4 18.♙xc4 dxc4 19.♗xc4 ♘d5 20.♙d2 ♗h4+ 21.g3 ♗h3 leads to a position where White faces a passive defence, despite his extra pawn.

16...axb4 17.a4



17...b3!

Black prepares to bring his knight to a5, keeping his extra pawn.

18.g4

An attempt to sharpen the game. White intends f4-f5.

18...f5!

With this typical device, Black kills the attack in advance.

19.exf6 ♗xf6 20.♗d3 ♘a5 21.♖ae1 h6!

Excellent prophylaxis against g4-g5.

22.♙f2 ♗xf4! 23.♗xe6 ♘ec6!

Now, White is tied to the defence of d4, and the black queen has free-

dom of movement. White cannot simultaneously attend to a battle in the centre and guard against the black passed pawn.

24.♗g3 ♗d7 25.♗xf4 ♗xe6 26.♙d3 ♘c4 27.♙f5 ♗f6 28.♗f3 ♖d8 29.♗d3 b2 30.♖e1 ♗g5 31.♗e2 ♖f8 32.♗e6+ ♔h8 33.h4 ♗f6 34.♗xd5 ♘d2 35.♙e3 b1♗ 36.♙xb1 ♘f3+

White resigned.

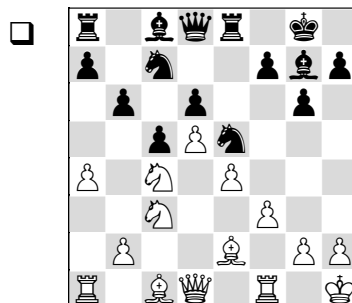
130

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Svetozar Gligoric

Dragoljub Minic

Yugoslavia tt 1972



White has more space, so exchanges in themselves do not favour him. In addition, the knight on e5 lacks retreat squares, as all possible squares are controlled by White. It is easy to see that if it is attacked, the knight will have to retreat to its own camp.

15.♘e3!

Of all the possibilities, this is the most active retreat square.

15...♖b8 16.♙d2

It is also essential to complete development and connect the rooks.

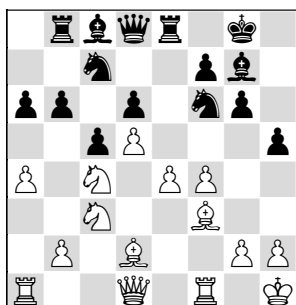
16...a6 17.f4 ♘d7

Now, the white knight can return to an active position, since its

opponent has been driven from the centre. In addition, the advance ...b6-b5 is nothing to be frightened of, as White is prepared for it.

18. ♖c4 ♘f6 19. ♙f3 h5?

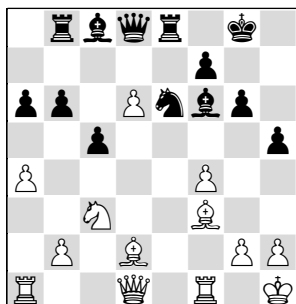
Such a move can only be good if there is a knight ready to jump to g4. But Black is unable to implement this idea, so he should play 19... b5, although after the preliminary 20. axb5 axb5 21. ♖xd6! ♙xd6 22. e5 ♙d7 23. d6! ♘e6 24. exf6 ♙xf6 25. f5 gxf5 26. ♖d5, White's attack is very dangerous.



20. ♖xd6! ♙xd6 21. e5 ♙d8 22. d6!

A very important move, opening a path for his pieces.

22... ♘e6 23. exf6 ♙xf6



24. f5!

A transposition could result from 24. ♙c6 ♙f8 25. f5 gxf5.

24... gxf5 25. ♙c6 ♙f8 26. ♙xf5

The even more energetic 26. ♖d5 also ends the game.

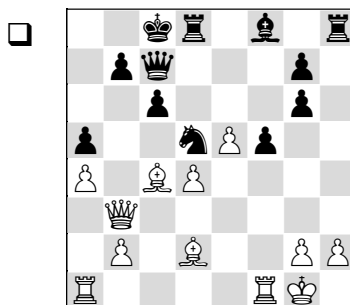
26... ♖d4 27. ♙xh5 ♙xd6 28. ♙d5 ♙f5 29. ♙xf5! ♘xf5 30. ♙g4+ ♘g7 31. ♖e4 ♙d8 32. ♙f1 ♙e5 33. ♙c3

The f7-pawn is pinned, and White exploits the square f6 as a jumping-off square for his pieces. Black resigned.

131

Training position

Konstantin Sakaev



White has more space, a strong pawn on e5 and the two bishops. He has the advantage. However, Black has organised a blockade in the centre, and it is not easy to open lines on the queenside. Therefore, White voluntarily surrenders his two bishops, obtaining in return new objects of attack:

19. ♙xd5! ♙xd5 20. ♙xd5 cxd5 21. ♙ac1

Black has to deal not only with a possible entry down the c-file, but also with the defence of the pawn a5 – this is impossible.

21... b6 22. ♙xc7+ ♙xc7 23. ♙c1+ ♙d7 24. e6!+ ♙xe6 25. ♙c6+ ♙d7 26. ♙xb6

The a5-pawn is lost, and White is close to winning.

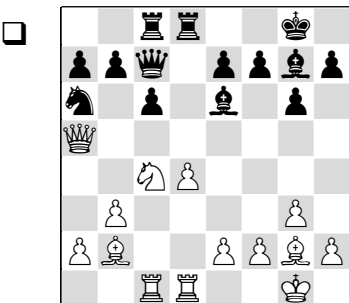
132

Mikhail Tal

Mikhail Botvinnik

Moscow Wch match 1960 (15)

**

The advantage of the two bishops**16. ♖e1!**

White takes the correct decision, based on the principle that if you have more space, superfluous exchanges should be avoided.

Nothing results from going into the endgame with 16. ♖xc7 ♜xc7 17. ♘a5 ♘b4, and Black has no problems.

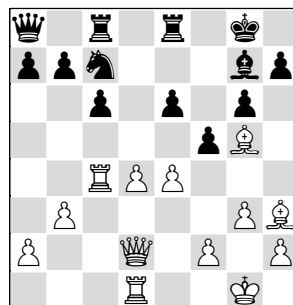
Seizing the centre with 16. e4?! is too sharp. White blocks his light-squared bishop: 16... ♙xc4 17. ♖xc7 ♜xc7 18. ♜xc4 c5! – Black even has some advantage, as after the exchange on d4, the black knight will be more active than White's light-squared bishop.

16... ♖b8 17. e4 ♙xc4 18. ♜xc4 ♘c7

Here, the advance 18... c5 does not bring great dividends because of 19. e5!, opening the path of the light-squared bishop.

19. ♙h3

Also interesting is the immediate 19. ♙c1!? ♘b5 20. ♙h3 e6 21. ♙f4 ♖a8 22. d5±.

19... e6 20. ♙c1 ♖a8 21. ♙g5 ♜e8**22. ♖d2 f5****23. ♙h6?!**

White wrongly solves the problem of exchanges, counting on weakening the dark squares around the enemy king, but this is not the most significant factor in the position.

Clearly preferable was 23. a4! ♜f8 24. b4 a6 25. ♖c2, retaining the advantage of the two bishops.

23... ♙h6! 24. ♖xh6 ♜e7 25. ♙e1 ♜f8 26. ♜c5 ♖d8

The light-squared bishop is shut out by the black pawns. It is not easy for White to develop the initiative.

27. ♜e5 ♜ef7

Black could equalise at once with 27... f4! 28. ♜d1 fxg3 29. hxg3 ♜ef7 30. f4 (30. ♜d2 ♜xf2! 31. ♜xe6 ♜xd2 32. ♜xg6+ hxg6 33. ♖xg6+ ♙h8 34. ♖h6+=) 30... ♜d7 31. ♜xe6 ♜xd4 32. ♜xg6+=.

28. ♖d2 ♖d6

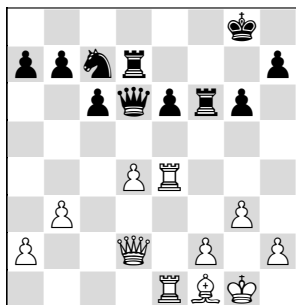
28... f4!?

29. ♙f1 ♜d7 30. exf5 ♜xf5 31. ♙5e4 ♜f6?

Too passive.

31... ♜d5! 32. ♜1e3 c5 33. dxc5 ♜xd2 34. cxd6 ♜7xd6=.

The attack with the rook's pawn



32.h4!

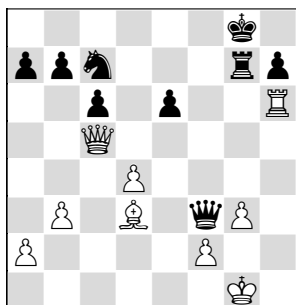
A very important resource.

32...♗g7 33.h5!

Opening up the enemy king, and creating a second weakness on the kingside. Black has a very difficult position already.

33...gxf5 34.♖h4 ♗g8 35.♙d3 ♖g7 36.♙e5 ♙ff7 37.♙h6 ♙e7 38.♙exh5 ♘d5 39.♙d2 ♘f6 40.♙h6 ♙d6 41.♙f4 ♙f8 42.♙e3 ♘d5 43.♙xf7 ♙xf7 44.♙e5 ♘c7 45.♙c5 ♙f3

The sacrifice on h7/h2



46.♙xh7+!

Winning by force.

46...♙xh7 47.♙g5+ ♗h8 48.♙d8+ ♗g7 49.♙xh7+ ♗xh7 50.♙xc7+ ♗g6 51.♙xb7 ♙e4 52.♙a6 ♙e1+ 53.♗g2 ♙e4+ 54.♗f1 ♙b1+ 55.♗e2 ♙c2+ 56.♗f3 ♙f5+ 57.♗e3 ♙g5+

58.♗e2 ♙h5+ 59.♗d2 ♗f6 60.♙xc6 ♙a5+ 61.♙c3 ♙xa2+ 62.♗e3 ♗f7 63.d5 exd5 64.♙c7+ ♗f6 65.♙c6+ ♗e7 66.♙xd5 ♙a1 67.♙e4+ ♗f7 68.♗f4 ♙c1+ 69.♗g4 ♙a1 70.♙d5+ ♗f8 71.♗f5 ♙b1+ 72.♗f6 1-0

133

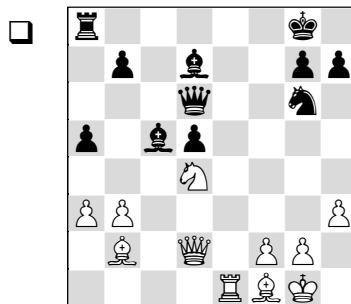
Artur Jussupow

2620

Stefan Kindermann

2500

Munich 1988 (8)



26.♙b5!±

This move underlines the weakness of the square b5, and at the same time meets the threat to take on a3. The apparently powerful 26.♙c3 is met by the calm 26...♙f8! (but not 26...♙xa3? 27.♙xa3 ♙xa3 28.♙c7, with a large advantage to White), bringing the last idle piece into the defence. The various white knight jumps turn out not to be dangerous:

A) 27.♘f5 ♙xf2+! 28.♗xf2 (28.♗h1 ♙f6+) 28...♙xf5+ 29.♗g1 ♙f7. It seems that after 30.♙xa5, Black should be worse, but by playing energetically, he can even seize the initiative: 30...♙g3! 31.♙c3 ♙f2+ 32.♗h1 d4! 33.♙b4 ♙c6 34.♙xd4 ♙g3 35.♙d2 ♘h4 36.♙e5 ♙xf1+ 37.♙xf1 ♙xg2+ 38.♗g1 ♙xf1+ 39.♙xg3 ♘f3+ 40.♗xf1 ♘xd2+ 41.♗e2 ♘xb3 – although the endgame has a drawish

character, White will still suffer a pawn down;

B) 27.♖xa5 ♗xh3 28.gxh3?! ♘h4!
29.♞e3 ♜f4 30.♞e1 ♗xd4.

26...♞f8

It looks more tenacious to play 26...♗xb5!? 27.♘xb5 ♞d7 28.♘d4 ♞a6 (28...♞f8 leads to a position from the game) 29.♘f3 ♗f8 30.♘e5 ♖b5!, with good chances to hold an inferior position.

27.♗xd7 ♞xd7 28.♖xa5 ♞d6!

29.♞d2

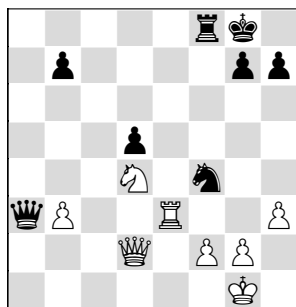
After 29.♞c3 ♘f4∞, the position becomes sharper.

But the shuttle manoeuvre with the white rook is stronger: 29.♞e6!. It is not so easy for the black queen to find a convenient retreat square: 29...♞f4 (this square was clearly intended for the black knight) 30.♞e2! (going back!) 30...♞d6 (30...♗xd4 31.♖xd5+--) 31.♘e6 ♗xf2+ 32.♞xf2 ♖xe6 33.♖c7 ♞f7 34.♞xf7 ♖xf7 35.♖b8+ ♘f8 36.♗e5 d4 37.♗d6+--.

29...♘f4 30.♞e3

30.b4? ♖g6 is dangerous for White.

30...♗xa3 31.♗xa3 ♖xa3



32.♖h2!

Prophylactic thinking in action! White gets his king away in good time, and also prepares to drive the black knight from f4.

32.♞f3 ♞d6!∞.

But the preliminary 32.b4!? ♖a6 33.♖h2 also deserved consideration.

32...♞d6 33.g3

The black knight is driven away from its powerful position on f4.

33...♘g6 34.♞e6 ♞d7 35.♖e3

Now, the difference in piece positioning is clear to the naked eye.

35...♞f7 36.♞e8+?!

But here, the simplification of the position plays into Black's hands.

White would get a more serious advantage by not exchanging one of his active pieces. Stronger was 36.f4! ♘e7!? 37.♖e5 ♘g6 (37...♘c6 38.♘xc6 bxc6 39.♞e8 ♞f8 40.♞e7+--) 38.♞d6 ♘f8 39.♖b8±.

36...♞f8 37.♞xf8+ ♘xf8

Also possible was 37...♖xf8!?±.

38.♖e5 ♖f7

More concrete was 38...♘g6! 39.♖e6+ (39.♖b8+ ♘f8 40.♖g2 ♖e7!=) 39...♖xe6 40.♘xe6, and now the active 40...♘e5 (40...b6?! – passive play in an endgame with many weaknesses just ensures that these will eventually fall to the opponent: 41.♖g2 ♖f7 42.♘c7 ♘e7 43.♖f3 ♖f6 44.♖e3 ♖e5 45.f4±. White has managed to strengthen his position, although Black retains some drawing chances. After all, he has only to eliminate the b3-pawn, in return for his pawns on b6 and d5!) 41.♖g2 (41.♘d4 ♖f7 42.♖g2 ♘c6!?) 41...♘d3 42.♘c7 ♘e1+ 43.♖f1 ♘f3=.

39.h4 ♘e6?

The decisive oversight. 39...♘g6 40.♖b8 ♘f8 41.♘f3 ♖g8 allows Black to hold an unpleasant position.

40.♖f5+! ♖e7 41.♖xh7

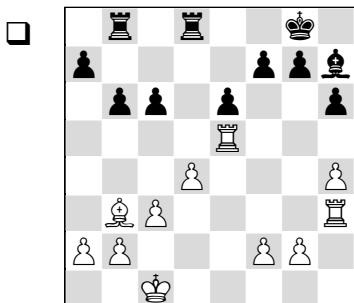
and White won.

134

Mikhail Tal

Mikhail Botvinnik

Moscow Wch match 1960 (15)



In various textbooks, this example is given, starting from Black's 'genius' 33rd move. However, looking at the run-up to this moment, we can see that things are not quite so simple. After going into the endgame, Black has obtained a somewhat passive, but defensible position. The game now proceeds according to the following scenario: White strengthens his position and advances his pawns, whilst Black waits.

25. ♖he3 ♜bc8 26. ♙c4 ♜c7

With the move 26...a5!? Black prevents **space-gaining** on the queenside, but weakens his pawn structure.

The same assessment applies to the move 26...c5 27.dxc5 bxc5 (27...♜xc5? 28.♜xc5 bxc5 29.♞e5 ♜c8 30.♜xe6!+-) 28.g4, seizing space on the kingside. Concrete play after 28...♜c6 29.f4 ♜cd6 30.♞e1 ♜d2 31.f5! is in White's favour.

27.b4 ♙f8 28.g4 ♙g8 29. ♙b3

Interestingly, this position was met many years later in a game between two different players.

29... ♙h7

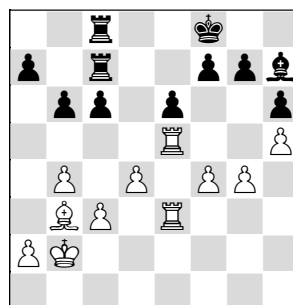
After 29...♜dc8 30.f4 c5 31.dxc5 bxc5 32.b5! ♜d8 33.g5 hxg5 34.hxg5 ♙h7 35.♜h3 ♙f5 36.♜h8+ ♙e7 37.♜xd8 ♙xd8 38.a4 f6 39.gxf6 gxf6 40.♞e2, White obtained the advantage, thanks to his superior pawn structure, and later won the game, Flak-Nickel, GDR corr 1986.

30.f4 ♙g8 31. ♙b2

White quietly strengthens his position.

31... ♙h7 32.h5 ♜dc8

Play on the flank



33. ♙c2?!

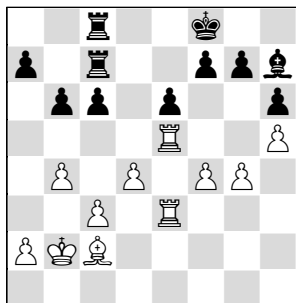
A psychological victory for Botvinnik! The white bishop is stronger in almost any event. The most obvious plan is a further strengthening on the queenside. This aim can be achieved by 33.a4!, and:

A) if the weakening reply 33...c5, then 34.dxc5 bxc5 35.b5 ♜d7 36.♙c2. Now, White should play so as to keep the black pieces out of his camp: 36...♜d2 37.♞e2 ♜cd8 38.♜xd2 ♜xd2 39.f5+-;

B) 33...♜d8 34.b5 ♜dc8 (34...cxb5 35.axb5 ♜cd7 36.♞e1 ♙d3 37.♜d1 ♙h7 38.♞e3 ♜c8 39.♞a1±, and the white bishop later comes to c6) 35.bxc6 ♜xc6 36.a5 ♜b8 (36...bxa5

37.♖xa5 ♜6c7 38.c4±) 37.♞b5±, and White has a clear advantage;

C) 33...♙g8 34.g5 c5 (34...♙h7 35.g6 fxg6 36.♙c2 ♙g8 37.hxg6±) 35.dxc5 bxc5 36.b5±.



33...♙g8?!

Psychologically, one can understand this decision, having seen the previous play, but objectively, the assessment of the move has to be that it is far from deserving an exclamation mark. The most one can say is that it is dubious.

After 33...♙xc2 34.♙xc2, Black is far from forced to find the narrow path to a draw after 34...c5 (adequate and simple is 34...♞d7! 35.f5 (35.a4 ♞d5 36.♙d3 ♙e7=) 35...exf5 36.♞xf5 ♞e8=) 35.bxc5 (35.dxc5 bxc5 36.b5! (36.bxc5 ♞xc5 37.♞xc5 ♞xc5 38.♞e4 f5 39.gxf5 ♞xf5 40.♞xe6 ♞xh5 41.♞a6 ♞h4 42.♞xa7 ♞xf4=) 36...a6 37.c4 axb5 38.cxb5 ♞a7 39.♙b3 c4+ 40.♙b2 ♞ca8 41.a3 ♞b7 42.♞c3 ♞a4 43.f5 f6 44.♞xe6 ♞xb5+=) 35...bxc5 36.d5 exd5 37.♞xd5 c4, and here Black should also hold.

34.g5 f6 35.♞e4 c5 36.♙b3?

This move can be considered a serious mistake. After 36.dxc5 bxc5 37.b5 ♞b8 38.a4 a6 39.c4, Black's position is close to hopeless.

36...cxb4 37.cxb4 hxg5 38.fxg5 fxg5

Nothing remains of White's advantage of a couple of moves ago. A total elimination of material takes place.

39.♞g3 ♞f7 40.♞xg5 ♞f2+ 41.♙a3

Draw agreed. After 41...♞c7 42.♞eg4 ♞f5 43.♞xf5 exf5 44.♞f4 ♙xb3 45.♙xb3 ♞f7 46.♙c4 ♙e7 47.♙d5 ♙f6 48.♙c6, there is the fighting continuation 48...♙g5, with a complicated rook ending, or 48...♞f8!?, with equality, and hoping for the mistake 49.d5? ♙e5! 50.♞f2 ♞f6, with advantage.

135

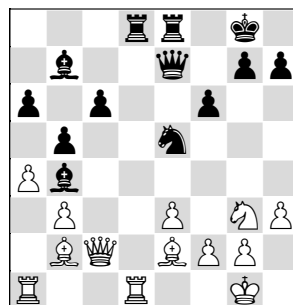
Anatoly Karpov

Alexey Shirov

Biel 1992 (13)

2715

2710



White's advantage is determined by the backward pawn on c6, which shuts in the black bishop, and in the weakness of the light squares around the black king.

21.♙xe5!!

Going from dynamic piece play to a light-square strategy – the knight on e5 prevents White from activating his bishop on e2.

The traditional way to develop the initiative would be 21.♙f5, with the

idea of continuing the battle for the light squares by f2-f4.

21... ♖xe5?!

Now the light squares on the kingside are weakened irretrievably. He should have preferred 21...fxe5, although after 22. ♖f3, the x-ray on the long diagonal is highly unpleasant for Black. White would also get an excellent outpost on e4 for his pieces.

22. ♖d3 h6

Black loses by force after 22... g6 23. ♖xg6 hxg6 24. ♖xg6+ ♖h8 25. ♖h6+ ♖g8 26. ♗h5 f5 27. ♖g6+! ♖f8 28. ♗f6 ♖c3 29. ♖g8+ ♖e7 30. ♗xe8 ♖xe8 31. ♖h7+ ♖g7 32. ♖xf5 ♖c8 33. ♖c5+ ♖f7 34. ♖a1 b4 35. ♖d6, with a decisive advantage.

23. ♖g6 ♖f8 24. ♗f5

Occupying a group of squares, the white pieces have achieved superb coordination. The same cannot be said of Black, one of whose bishops is blocked in by his pawn and the other is firing into the air. Two bishops are not always strong! There are exceptions, and this is one of them.

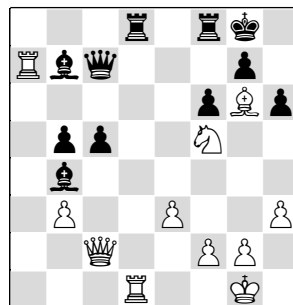
24...c5

24... ♖c5 25. ♖e4 ♖c8 26. ♖dc1 ♖e5 (26... ♖xf5 27. ♖xf5 ♖c3 28. axb5 axb5 29. ♖a6+—) 27. ♖xb4 (also good is the more pragmatic line 27. ♗xh6 gxh6 28. ♖xb4+—) 27... ♖xf5 28. ♖xf5 ♖xf5 29. ♖xc6 bxa4 30. bxa4 does not leave Black any real saving chances in this technical position, as the black a-pawn will be lost.

25. axb5 axb5 26. ♖a7

The immediate 26. ♗h4 also wins.

26... ♖c7



27. ♗h4! ♖xd1+ 28. ♖xd1 ♖a8 29. ♖g4! ♖c6 30. ♖xb7! ♖xb7 31. ♖e6+ ♖h8 32. ♖e4

Black resigned.

Additional material

Simagin-Kotov, Moscow 1945 – White's 37th move

Shishov-Nezhmetdinov, Tbilisi 1947 – Black's 18th move

Kholmov-Flohr, Moscow 1948 – Black's 17th move

Smyslov-Reshevsky, The Hague/Moscow Wch (match-tournament) 1948 – White's 25th move

Weinstein-Muratkuliev, Baku 1973 – White's 23rd move

Petrosian-Golombek, Stockholm 1952 – White's 33rd move

Kortchnoi-Flohr, Yerevan ch-URS 1955 – Black's 16th move

Kasparov-Martinovic, Baku 1980 – White's 18th move

Karpov-Kasparov, New York Wch (match/7) 1990 – White's 15th move

Chapter 18

Weak squares. Control of key central squares or a complex thereof

By weak squares, we mean those that are impossible or difficult to guard with pawns. The opponent's pieces can try to occupy them, and sometimes they can be used as jumping-off places for several pieces. Very occasionally, we can speak of a square on the rook's file as weak, if it can be favourably occupied by an enemy piece.

Whilst weaker players often need little prompting to create weak squares, seeing their pawns as soldiers and loving to throw them forward into battle, stronger and more experienced players usually have to be forced to create weaknesses.

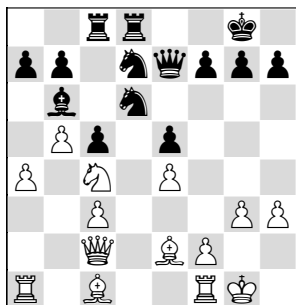
In battling for weak squares in the centre or the opponent's camp, we should try to control these squares, so that the opponent cannot eliminate the weakness by advancing pawns, for example.

136

Mikhail Botvinnik

Gyorgy Szilagyi

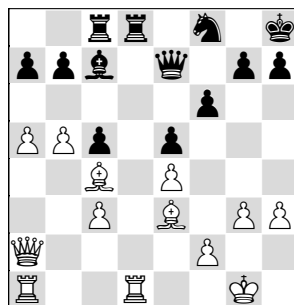
Amsterdam 1966 (1)



White has a clear advantage, because Black's position has a number of weak light squares. After the following manoeuvre, these squares are weakened still further, and the advantage increases to decisive proportions:

18. ♖g5! f6 19. ♜e3 ♜xc4 20. ♜xc4+ ♜h8 21. a5 ♜c7 22. ♜fd1 ♜f8 23. ♜a2

*



From here, the queen defends a5 and prevents Black bringing his knight into play via e6.

23... ♜xd1+ 24. ♜xd1 ♜d8 25. ♜xd8 ♜xd8 26. a6 b6

Black is completely without counterplay, so White strengthens his position without hurrying.

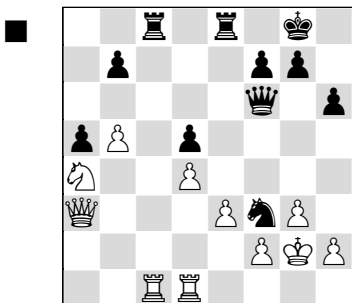
27. ♜g2! ♜d7 28. ♜e2 ♜g6 29. ♜b3 ♜e7 30. ♜c4 h6 31. ♜f7 ♜h7 32. ♜c4 ♜d6 33. h4 ♜d1 34. ♜e8 f5 35. exf5 ♜xf5 36. ♜g8+ ♜h8 37. ♜b3+ 1-0

137

José Gutierrez Castillo 2365

Reynaldo Gonzalez Quevedo 2470

Bayamo 1989 (2)



26...♖g5!

Now, the queen is ready to come in on the weakened light squares.

27.f4 ♖f5!

27...♗e4 allows White to put up resistance: 28.♖xc8 ♖xc8 29.♖c1+.

28.fxg5

28.♗c3 ♖xe3 29.fxg5 ♖f3+ 30.♗h3 ♖xc3+.

28...♖c2+!

Black had to see this move when he left his knight en prise. Now, it is bad for White, whether he takes or not.

29.♖xc2 ♖xc2+--+

138

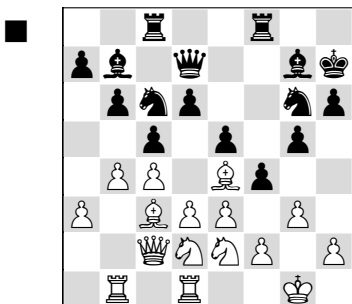
Thomas Henrichs

2473

Robert Fontaine

2552

Germany Bundesliga 2011/12 (10)



A group of light squares around the white king are weakened, and Black can attack these:

20...f3! 21.♗xf3

21.♗xf3 ♖xf3 22.♗xf3 ♗d4 23.♗fxd4 exd4 24.e4 (White loses immediately after 24.♗a1 ♗f3!) 24...dxc3 25.♗xc3 ♗e5 – the weakness of the square f3 tells here too.

21...♖xf3 22.♗xf3 ♗xb4 23.♗xb7

Panic, but after 23.axb4 ♗xf3 24.♗f1 ♖h3+ 25.♗e1 ♖xh2 26.♗d2 ♖xf2 27.♗e1 e4!, Black's attack also assumes a decisive character.

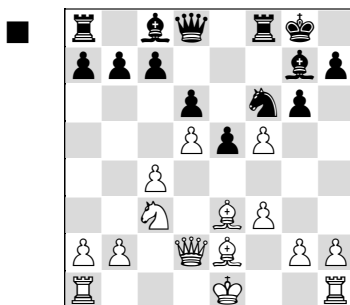
23...♗xc2 24.♗e4 ♗xa3 25.♖b3 ♖a4 0-1

139

Mikhail Botvinnik

Conel O'D Alexander

Munich ol 1958 (8)



As a rule, in the King's Indian, it is bad to give White control of the e4-square, especially with the bishop still on g7. Therefore,

11...♗xf5?

is a strategic mistake. Good or bad, Black should have taken on f5 with the pawn.

The strategy of fighting to control squares

12.g4!

By driving away the bishop, White ensures control of the key square.

12...♙d7 13.h3

Defending the g4-pawn in the event of Black breaking with ...e5-e4.

13...a6

If Black tries to break the grip with 13...e4, White can just take the material with 14.fxe4, exploiting the fact that, to obtain any real compensation for the pawn, Black needs to get his knight to e5, which he cannot conveniently do (also good is 14.f4, intending gradually to surround the e4-pawn with pieces).

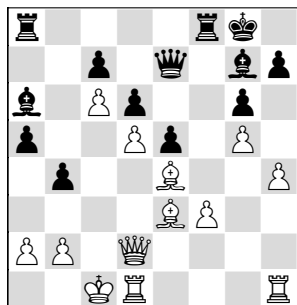
14.0-0 b5 15.c5

White does not allow the b-file to be opened.

15...b4 16.♘e4 a5

More tenacious was 16...♗xe4 17.fxe4 ♙b5 (otherwise ...c5-c6, completely shutting in the light-squared bishop as well). Black's idea is to sacrifice the exchange, for example after 18.h4, he can play 18...♗f4! 19.♙xf4 exf4, sharpening the battle somewhat.

17.♙d3 ♗e7 18.c6 ♙c8 19.h4 ♙a6 20.♗xf6+ ♙xf6 21.g5 ♙g7 22.♙e4



The bishop on g7 takes no effective part in the game.

22...♙c8 23.h5 ♙f5 24.hxg6 ♙xg6
25.♗d3 ♗xf3 26.♙xg6 hxg6
27.♗xg6 ♙f8 28.♗e4 ♗f7 29.g6
♗f5 30.♗xf5+ ♗xf5 31.♗df1 ♗xf1+
32.♗xf1+ ♙g8 33.♗f7 ♗c8 34.♙c2
e4 35.b3 ♙c3 36.♙d1 ♙e5 37.♙e2
♙c3 38.♙a7

Black resigned.

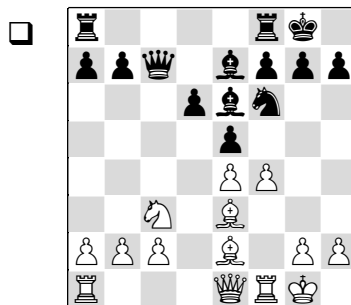
140

*

Vassily Smyslov

Iosif Rudakovsky

Moscow ch-URS 1945 (2)

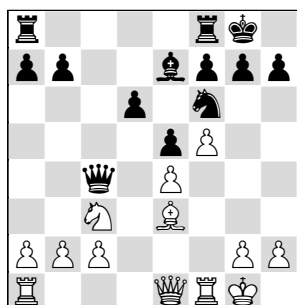


In the typical Najdorf pawn structure, if the white queen has already moved from d1 to e1, it usually continues its journey to g3. From there, the queen takes aim at g7 and exerts pressure on e5. But in this instance, White notices that the knight at f6 lacks a colleague at d7, to replace it, and so he changes his plan:

13.f5! ♙c4

After the exchange of light-squared bishops, there is nothing with which to defend against the entry of the white knight on d5, so Black should have preferred 13...♙d7, later preparing to guard d5 with ...♙d7-c6.

14. ♖xc4 ♜xc4



15. ♖g5!

The battle for d5 is won, and the white knight is assured this great outpost. Now, White's only problem is his pawn on c2, due to which he cannot yet comfortably occupy the d5 outpost.

15... ♜fe8

More logical is 15... ♜ac8, exerting pressure on the c-file.

16. ♖xf6 ♖xf6 17. ♖d5 ♖d8

17... ♜xc2 18. ♜f2 ♜c5 19. ♜c1 ♜d4 20. ♖c7 leads to the loss of the exchange for Black.

18. c3

Thanks to the positional plusses White has obtained, he often sacrifices the c2-pawn, but here he is even able to hang onto it. The outcome of the game is strategically decided.

18... b5 19. b3 ♜c5+ 20. ♖h1 ♜c8 21. ♜f3 ♖h8 22. f6!

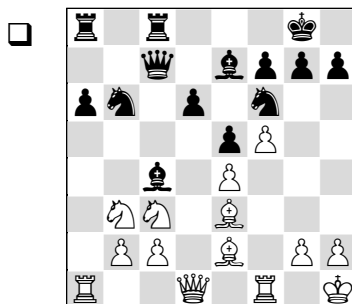
The quickest route to victory, given the undefended black king. If Black had defended against this threat by means of ...f7-f6, White could have switched play to the queenside, trying to create new weaknesses there and create a passed pawn. This could be assisted with the advance a2-a4.

22... gxf6 23. ♜h4 ♜g8 24. ♖xf6 ♜g7 25. ♜g3 ♖xf6 26. ♜xf6 ♜cg8 27. ♜d1 d5 28. ♜xg7 1-0

141

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Efim Geller
Robert Fischer
Curaçao ct 1962 (16)



For the sake of taking control of d5, White parted with his bishop:

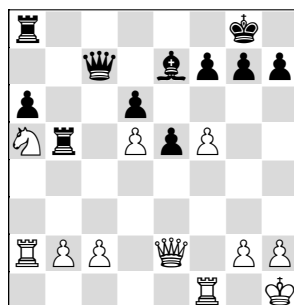
16. ♖xb6! ♜xb6 17. ♖xc4 ♜xc4 18. ♜e2 ♜b4 19. ♜a2

A multi-purpose move. White prepares to double rooks on the a-file, whilst if Black weakens his pressure on the b-file, the knight can find a more active way to participate in the game.

19... ♜b7 20. ♖a5 ♜c7 21. ♖d5! ♖xd5 22. exd5

Instead of an outpost on d5, White now has an even stronger one on c6. Under cover of such a knight, the advance of the c- and b-pawns is especially strong.

22... ♜b5



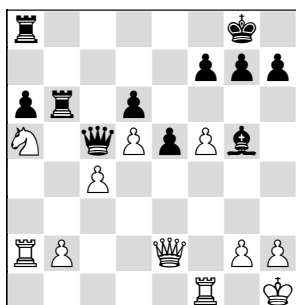
23. ♜d2

Even stronger is 23.♔fa1!, with the threat of c2-c4. The pawn on d5 is untouchable, because after 23...♕xd5, White wins with 24.♖e4 ♖c5 25.c4.

23...♖c5 24.c4 ♕b6 25.♖e2
25.♖d3 ♖f6 26.♗c6 e4 27.♖xe4 ♕xb2 28.♕xa6 ♕f8 leads to a position where it is not realistic to realise the extra pawn.

But a good alternative was 25.♕a4!, with the threat of b2-b4, whilst after 25...♕ab8, a good reply is the simple 26.b3, with the threat of ♗a5-c6.

25...♖g5



26.♕f3

Excellent control of a group of light squares results from 26.♗c6 ♕b3 27.♕f3! ♕xf3 28.gxf3, followed by b2-b4, and a clear advantage.

26...♖f6 27.♗c6 e4!

Black activates his pieces at minimal material cost.

28.♕f4 e3 29.b4 ♕xb4 30.♗xb4 ♖xb4

Black has sufficient compensation for the exchange – his bishop is strong, and his passed pawns hamper the coordination of the white pieces.

31.♖d3 a5 32.♕f1 ♖c3 33.♖xc3 ♖xc3 34.♕b1 h5 35.♖g1 ♕c8 36.♖f1 ♕xc4 37.♖e2 ♖b4 38.♖xe3 ♖h7 39.♕f1 ♖h6 40.♕f3 ♖g5

41.♖d3 ♕c3+ 42.♖e4 ♕c1 43.f6 g6 44.♖d4 h4 45.h3

The position is a mutual fortress, and so a draw.

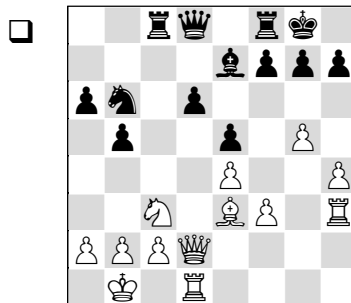
142

Robert Fischer

Julio Bolbochan

Stockholm izt 1962 (21)

*



For total control of d5, White does not begrudge giving up his bishop:

19.♖xb6! ♖xb6 20.♗d5 ♖d8 21.f4!

White increases the space for his pieces, realising that none of the black pieces will be able to occupy the freed-up e5-square.

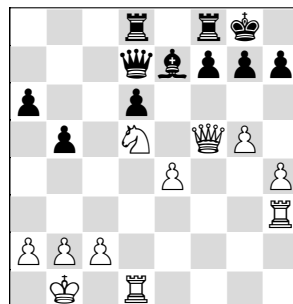
21...exf4

Else, the pawn advances further to f5.

22.♖xf4 ♖d7 23.♖f5 ♕cd8

A) 23...♕fd8 24.♖xd7 ♕xd7 25.♗b6+;

B) On 23...♖b7, there follows 24.h5, with numerous threats.



24. ♖a3!

With the help of his powerful knight on d5, White develops his initiative on all fronts, also exploiting the undefended black pawns on the queenside.

24... ♖a7 25. ♖c3 g6 26. ♖g4 ♖d7
27. ♖f3 ♖e6 28. ♖c7 ♖de8 29. ♖f4
♖e5 30. ♖d5 ♖h8

Black does not even have a single normal square for his queen!

31. a3!

Before the final opening of lines, it is useful to 'make luft'.

31... h6 32. gxh6 ♖xh6 33. h5 ♖g5
34. hxg6 fxg6

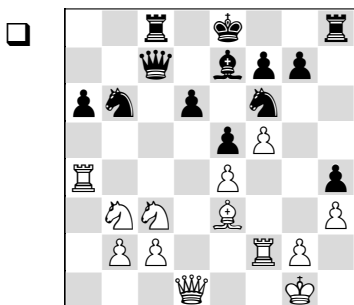
34... ♖xf4 35. gxf7+ ♖xf7 36. ♖xf7
♖xf7 37. ♖h5 ♖g6 38. ♖xf4+ ♖e7
39. ♖g5+.

35. ♖b3! ♖xf4 36. ♖e5+ ♖f8
37. ♖xe8+ 1-0

143

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Efim Geller
Miguel Najdorf
Zurich ct 1953 (13)



The d5-square is undoubtedly the key one in such structures, for the sake of which White is prepared to part with his bishop:

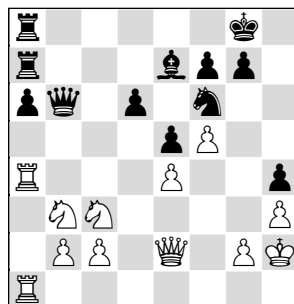
19. ♖xb6!

If 19. ♖xa6 ♖c4, the black pieces are sharply activated.

19... ♖xb6 20. ♖e2 ♖a8 21. ♖h2

The rook is unpinned, and can now transfer to the d- or a-files.

21... 0-0 22. ♖f1 ♖a7 23. ♖fa1 ♖fa8



24. ♖1a2!

And after this move, the ♖b3 obtains freedom of movement.

24... ♖d8 25. ♖a5!

The knight is heading to the key square d5.

25... ♖c8 26. ♖c4 ♖c6 27. ♖e3 a5
28. ♖c4 ♖a6 29. b3 ♖b6

Black's counterplay on the dark squares proves insufficient to offset White's total dominance of the light squares.

30. ♖xc8+ ♖xc8 31. ♖ed5 ♖xd5
32. ♖xd5 ♖c5 33. ♖a1 ♖f2 34. ♖xf2
♖xf2 35. ♖f1 ♖d4 36. c3 ♖c5 37. g4
hxg3+ 38. ♖xg3 ♖b7 39. ♖b1 f6
40. ♖f3 ♖f7 41. ♖e2 ♖b8 42. b4 g6
43. ♖d3

This is perfectly sufficient, although White also had a more effective win: 43. fxg6+ ♖xg6 44. bxc5 ♖xb1 45. c6 ♖b5 46. c7 ♖c5 47. c8 ♖ ♖xc8 48. ♖e7+ ♖g5 49. ♖xc8 a4 50. ♖d3 f5 51. ♖xd6 f4 52. ♖c4, etc.

43... gxf5 44. exf5 axb4 45. cxb4
♖d4 46. ♖c1 ♖g7 47. ♖c7 ♖h6
48. ♖e4 ♖g5 49. ♖h7 ♖f2 50. ♖g7+
♖h4 51. ♖f3 ♖e1 52. ♖g2 ♖f8
53. b5 ♖a5 54. b6 ♖xb6 55. ♖xb6
♖b8 56. ♖g4+ ♖h5 57. ♖d5 1-0

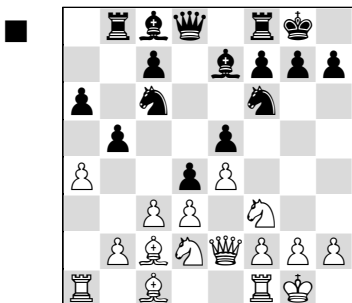
144

Boris Spassky

Mark Taimanov

Leningrad ch-URS 1956 (13)

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White has placed his pieces rather passively, and Black carries out an operation in the centre, aimed at securing control of the d4-square:

11...dxc3! 12.bxc3 b4!

If the white pawn were on a2 rather than a4, White would have a chance to use his light-squared bishop very effectively with Bc2-a4! here. In the position on the board, however, the bishop is badly shut in, and cannot at any moment even come out to b3.

13.dxc4

On 13. Bb2 , a strong reply is 13... Nh5 14. g3 Bg4 , and the pin on the knight is quite unpleasant.

13...Bg4 14.Bb2 Bc5!

Everything for control of d4!

15.Bad1 bxc3 16.Bxc3 Nd4

Even stronger is 16... Bd4! 17. Bd2 Nh5 , with the idea of ... Bd8-f6 .

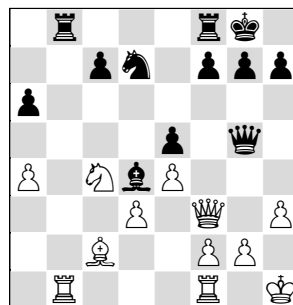
17.Bxd4 Bxd4 18.h3 Bxf3

19.Bxf3 Nd7

Now the knight will travel the long road to d4.

20.Bb1 Bg5 21.Bh1

Losing time. Better was 21. Ne3 , with the intention of putting the knight on f5, or bringing the bishop via b3 to c4.



21...g6

With a dark-squared bishop, the pawn should protect the light squares. This move not only gives the king a bolthole, but also deprives White's pieces of the square f5.

22.Ne3 Bc5 23.Nc4 Kg7

When concrete continuations do not bring any particular benefits, it is useful to carry out such prophylaxis. On g7, the king will not be subject to checks along the diagonal, should Black play ... f7-f5 . In the process, he also takes control of f6.

24.Bxe2 Ne6 25.g3 Bc5 26.Bxb8

Bxb8 27.Bh2 Bf6 28.Bg2 h5 29.h4

Of course, White cannot allow ... h5-h4 , which would lead to the weakening of a whole group of dark squares.

29...Nd4 30.Bd1 Be6 31.Bd2

Bb4 32.Bd1 Be7 33.f4?!

Misplaced activity, because the bishop on c2 is too passive, and one should not open lines with such a bishop.

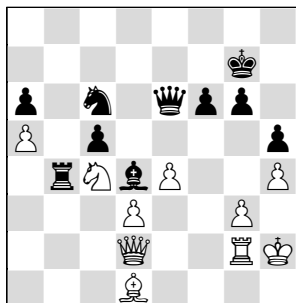
It was better to choose some kind of waiting continuation, such as 33. Bh2 – it would not be at all easy to break down White's defences.

33...exf4 34.Bxf4 f6

Because the Bc2 is so far from the kingside, Black can permit himself

this weakening of the light squares, to strengthen control of e5.

35.a5 ♖d6 36.♞f2 ♜b4 37.♚e1 c5
38.♙d1 ♙e5 39.♚d2 ♘c6 40.♙h2
♙d4 41.♞g2



41...♘e5

After the exchange of the knight on c4, Black gets access to the b2-square, which he can exploit for the entry of his rook.

42.♘xe5 ♙xe5 43.♚e3 ♜b1 44.♞d2

On 44.♙c2, the most technical way is 44...♜b5, taking on a5 and then returning the rook to the first or second ranks.

44...♙c3 45.♞c2 ♜xd1 46.♚xc5
♙e5 47.♚a7+ ♚f7 48.♚xa6 ♚d7

White resigned.

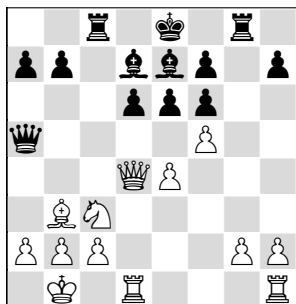
145

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Vlastimil Jansa

Vladimir Simagin

Polanica Zdroj 1968 (8)



The main weakness in Black's position is the e6-square, whilst the undefended pawn on h7 is also a source of concern. White transfers his queen to h3, the ideal square for attacking both targets.

16.♚e3! ♜xc3

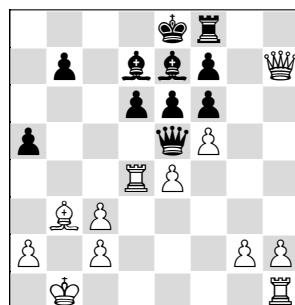
A desperate attempt to generate counterplay, which does not bring success, because Black's pieces are too scattered around the board.

If he tries to defend e6 by centralising the queen with 16...♚e5, he suddenly finds it is the other rook pawn which is under attack: 17.♚xa7! – Black cannot hope to organise counterplay on the open a-file, because the ♙b3 defends everything too solidly.

17.bxc3 ♚c5 18.♚h3

White continues to develop his initiative, although he could also have simplified the position, given his extra material, with 18.♚xc5 dxc5 19.♞d2 b5 20.fxe6 fxe6 21.♞hd1 ♙c8 22.c4 – the light-squared bishop will soon be playing again, and White should easily realise the extra exchange.

18...♚e5 19.♚xh7 ♜f8 20.♞d4 a5



21.a4

Prophylaxis on the queenside, aiming to secure the bishop's

position against an advance of the black queenside pawns.

Another possibility, with the same idea, was 21.♖hd1 b5 22.a3.

21...b5 22.axb5 ♖xb5 23.♖hd1
♙d7 24.♖h3 ♖g8 25.♖d3 ♙b5

If 25...♖xg2, White begins an attack from the other flank with 26.♖a6.

26.♙a4 ♙xa4 27.♖xa4 ♖xg2
28.♖a6 ♖f8 29.♖xa5 ♖xh2
30.♖c7 ♖h5 31.♖c1 ♖e2 32.♖a8+
♖g7 33.♖xe7 ♖h7 34.♖h1+

Black resigned.

146

★★

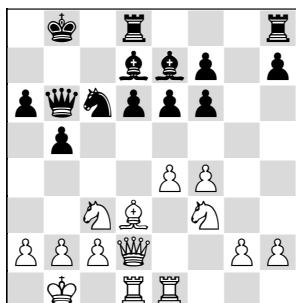
Jan Timman

2610

Bozidar Ivanovic

2525

Bugojno 1984 (4)



Usually in such structures, White plays f4-f5, and after the pawn exchange on e6, he tries by piece manoeuvring to develop pressure on the key square e6. If Black manages to defend the square, he gets a normal game, if not, he suffers. In this game, however, White noticed that the ♙e7 is undefended and is opposite the ♖e1 (Black needs a move to play ...♖h8-e8), and he played an exchanging operation:

15.♙d5! exd5

If he does not take the knight, then after, say, 15...♖b7 16.♙xe7 ♙xe7,

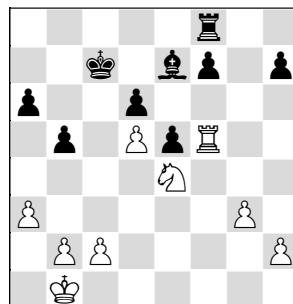
Black is not only bad strategically, but also tactically: 17.♖c3! e5 18.fxe5 fxe5 19.♙xe5!, winning a pawn.

16.exd5 ♙e5 17.fxe5 fxe5 18.♖h6

As a result, White has organised a blockade of the squares e4 and f5, and Black is left with a bad bishop.

18...♖c5 19.♖h5 ♖df8 20.♙f5
♙xf5 21.♖xf5 ♙d8 22.♖f1 ♖hg8
23.g3 ♖g6 24.a3 ♖c4 25.♖d3 ♖c8
26.♙d2 ♖xf5 27.♖xf5 ♖g5 28.♖df3
♖xf5 29.♖xf5 ♖c7 30.♙e4 ♙e7

Control of a complex of squares



31.g4!

The control of a complex of squares is now absolute. Otherwise, Black could play ...h7-h5, and, if the pawn is taken, ...f7-f5, getting some sort of counterplay.

31...h6 32.c3 ♙d7 33.b3 ♙g5
34.♙xg5 hxg5 35.♖xg5 ♖c8 36.♖c2
♖e7 37.h4 ♖f6 38.♖f5+ ♖g7 39.g5
♖c5 40.b4 ♖xd5 41.h5 a5

More tenacious is 41...♖h8, but here too, after 42.♖xf7 e4 43.♖a7 ♖xg5 44.♖xa6 ♖g7 45.♖xd6 ♖xh5 46.♖e6, White should win.

42.h6+ ♖g8 43.bxa5 ♖c5 44.♖f6
♖c6 45.♖b3 e4 46.g6 fxg6
47.♖xg6+ ♖h7 48.♖e6

Black resigned.

147

Sergey Tiviakov

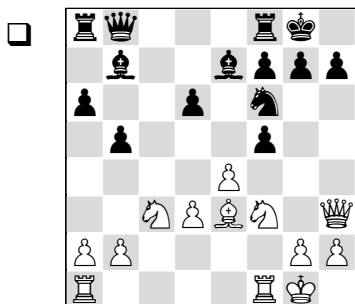
Yury Yakovich

St Vincent Ech 2000 (6)

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2565

2580



The queen on b8 is a long way from the centre, and the bishop on b7 does not guard the important square f5, but stares instead at the white pawns on d3 and e4. The ♖e7 and, especially importantly, the pawn on g7 are both undefended. In such a situation, the knight is just destined for f5:

17. ♖d4! g6

White's idea cannot be ignored: 17... fxe4 18. ♖f5 ♕d8 (on 18... ♗d8, White wins with 19. ♗h4, with the threat of taking on e7, and then ♖e3-d4) 19. ♗g3 g6 20. ♖h6+ ♔g7 21. ♖d4 ♖xh6 22. ♗xf6, mating.

It was essential to bring the sleeping forces into the defence: 17... ♖c8! 18. ♖xf5 ♖xf5 19. ♗xf5 b4 – White has a clear advantage, but it is still possible to defend.

18. ♖xf5! gxf5 19. ♖d4!

The g-file and the dark squares around the black king are irretrievably weak.

19... ♖g4 20. exf5

Also possible is 20. ♗xf5 ♖e5 21. ♗xe5 ♖f6 22. ♖d5.

20... ♖e5 21. f6 ♖e8 22. ♗g3+ ♖g6

23. fxe7 ♖xe7 24. h4 b4 25. ♖d1 ♖e2

26. ♖e3 ♗d8 27. ♗f6 ♗a5 28. ♗af1
♗f8 29. ♗f5 ♗d8 30. h5 ♗h4
31. ♗xh4

Black resigned.

148

Israel Caspi

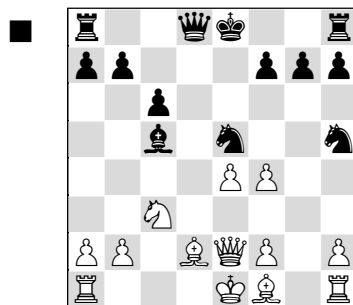
Evgeny Postny

Aix-les-Bains Ech 2011 (7)

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2451

2585



Black had to see the blow that follows, when playing his previous move. How could he have come up with the idea? It is all very simple – he was helped by his understanding of the weakness of the dark squares in White's camp, combined with the agility of Black's knights.

12... ♗xd2+! 13. ♖xd2 ♖xf4

14. ♗d1 0-0-0+ 15. ♖d5

15. ♖c2 ♗xd1 16. ♖xd1 ♖f3, with complete domination.

15... ♖xd5 16. ♖c1

16. exd5 ♗xd5+ 17. ♖e2 ♗xd1 18. ♗xd1 ♗e8 19. ♖h3+ ♖c7 20. ♗hg1 g6 – Black is ready to play ...f7-f5 as well, further restricting the ♖h3. Because of the lack of coordination between his pieces, White faces an unpleasant battle for a draw.

16... ♖f4

Even stronger is 16... ♖e3! 17. ♖h3+ ♖b8. White has to go into a difficult endgame because if he keeps the

queens on, he comes under a strong attack: 18.♖e2 ♘d3+ 19.♙b1 ♘c4 20.♙c1 ♘xc1 21.♖xc4 ♘d3 22.♙f1 ♙d4 23.♖c3 ♙hd8 24.a3 ♙b6 25.♙xd3 ♙xd3 26.♙xg7 ♙d2.

17.♖c2 ♙xf2 18.♙b1 ♙b6

More active is 18...♙e3.

19.a3

Better was 19.a4, with the idea of pushing the a-pawn further, obtaining some sort of counterplay. In addition, the a3-square is available for bringing the rooks into play.

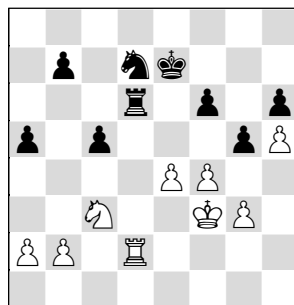
19...♙d6

Black has a strong initiative and his pieces dominate.

Taking away the square d4 is a positive, but now Black has another weakness, on d5. White uses it as a transfer point.

30.♘c3! ♙d6

Do not hurry



149

Anatoly Karpov

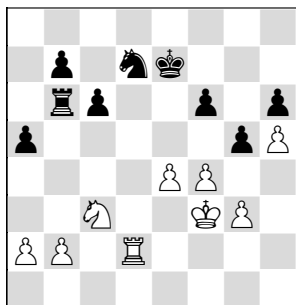
Yasser Seirawan

Skelleftea 1989 (8)

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2755

2585



If one asks oneself which is the ideal square for the white knight, it is hard to not give the correct answer – f5, of course.

29.♘e2!

He could also use a different route: 29.♘d1 gxf4 (29...f5 30.exf5 gxf4 31.g4!) 30.gxf4 ♙b5 31.♙h2 f5 32.e5 – the knight comes to e3 and the f5-pawn cannot be held.

29...c5

31.♙d5!

The most pragmatic.

White can win by choosing the forcing continuation 31.♙d5 ♙xd6 32.♘d5 gxf4 33.♙xf4 ♙e6 34.♘c7+ ♙f7 35.♙f5 ♘e5 36.♘b5 ♙e7 37.g4, with the threat of g4-g5, but in the circumstances of a practical game, it is not so easy to calculate such a variation, and the chances of a miscalculation are considerable.

31...♙xd5

More tenacious is 31...♙c6.

32.♘xd5+

In the knight endgame that arises here, there are no variations to calculate.

32...♙e6

Lines such as 32...♙f7 33.♘e3 ♙g7 34.♘f5+ ♙h7 35.♘d6 ♙b6 36.♙g4 also leave Black with no illusions.

33.♘e3 ♙b5 34.♘f5 ♘b6 35.♘xh6 ♘c4 36.♘f5 ♙f7 37.b3 ♘d2+ 38.♙e3 ♘f1+

And Black resigned.

150

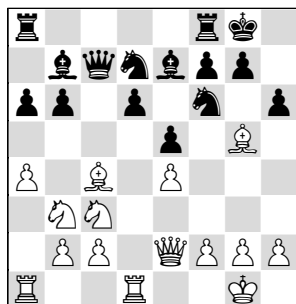
Vladimir Kramnik

Boris Gelfand

Cap d'Agde rapid 2003 (4)

2777

2703



14. Qxf6

White exchanges those black pieces that can control d5 – his ideal is to reach a position with a knight on d5 against the dark-squared bishop.

14... Qxf6 15. Qd5

It is interesting to involve the out-of-play knight with 15. Qd2!?, intending to bring it closer to the key square d5 via f1-e3: 15... Qfd8 16. Qf1. Now, White should not fear the active 16... b5 (16... Qxe4 17. Qd5 Qxd5 18. Qxd5±) 17. axb5 axb5 18. Qxa8 Qxa8 19. Qxb5 Qb7 20. Qd5 Qxd5 21. exd5± – Black has insufficient compensation for the pawn, Simonov-Voitsekovsky, Kazan 2007.

15... Qxd5 16. Qxd5 Qxd5 17. Qxd5 b5

The continuation 17... Qfc8 18. c3 Qc4 19. Qxc4 Qxc4 20. Qd2 Qc5 21. Qxc5 bxc5 22. Qc4 looks quite sad for Black, because of his lack of counterplay and the weakness of his light squares.

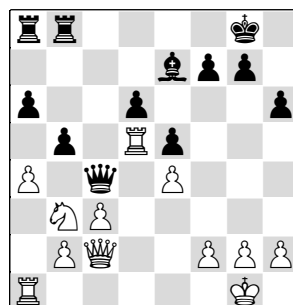
18. c3

The pawn sacrifice should not be accepted: 18. axb5 axb5 19. Qxa8 Qxa8

20. Qxb5 Qa2 and Black's pieces activate sharply: 21. c4 Qa4 22. Qd2 Qg5 23. b3 Qa2 24. Qd5 Qb6=.

18... Qc4 19. Qc2! Qfb8

19... b4 20. Qd2 Qc6 21. c4±.



20. Qd2

After 20. Qc5? Black does not fall into the trap, but plays 20... b4! (20... dxc5? 21. b3+-) 21. Qd3 Qxd3 22. Qxd3 bxc3 23. bxc3 Qb3, and he is the one who is slightly better.

20... Qc6

No better is 20... Qe2 21. Qd3 Qxd3 22. Qxd3 bxa4 23. Qc4 a3 24. b4± (24. Qxa3? d5).

21. a5! Qc8 22. Qd3 Qab8 23. g3 Qb7 24. Qf1 Qc4! 25. b3

Carefully strengthening his position and preventing Black's counterplay. Weaker is 25. Qe3 Qa4!? 26. Qxa4 bxa4 27. Qc4 Qb3 28. Qg2 g6±.

25... Qc6

25... Qc5 26. Qe3 Qbc8 27. Qxc5 dxc5 28. c4 b4 29. Qd5±.

26. Qe3 g6

26... Qbc8 27. c4 bxc4 28. Qxc4±.

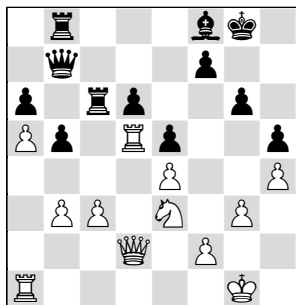
27. h4 h5

After the correct 27... Qc7 28. c4 bxc4 29. Qxc4 (29. bxc4 Qg7 30. Qg2 h5∞) 29... Qb7 30. Qa2!? (30. Qb1 Qb4) 30... Qxb3 (30... Qb4!?) 31. Qb2 Qxb2

32.♖xb2 ♖xb2, it would not be easy for White to win.

28.♜d2! ♕f8

28...♖bc8 29.♞d3±.



29.♞c2! ♜c5

29...♖bc8!? 30.♞d3, freeing for the knight its rightful square d5. The active 30...f5? fails: 31.exf5 e4 32.♞d5 ♖xc3 33.♞e3 ♖xb3 (33...♜g7 34.♞e1 ♖xb3 35.fxg6+-) 34.fxg6 ♕g7 (34...♜g7 35.♞f1 ♖b2 36.♜d1+-) 35.♞f1+-.

30.♞b4 ♖bc8 31.♞d3! ♕h7

A) 31...♜xe4 32.♞xa6 ♜5c6 33.♞b4 ♜c5 34.♞d5+-;

B) 31...f5 32.exf5 (32.f3±) 32...e4 33.♞d5 gxf5 34.♞d1±.

32.♞d5 ♕h6 33.♜d1 ♖f8 34.♞f6+ ♕g7 35.♜f3

There was a forced win with 35.♞xd6! ♖xc3 36.♞xh5+! gxh5 (36...♕h8 37.♞f6 ♖fc8 38.♖b6+-) 37.♜xh5 f6 38.♞ad1 ♖c7 39.♜f5 ♖cf7 40.h5 ♕g8 (40...♕h8 41.♞d7 ♜c6 42.♞xf7 ♖xf7 43.♜g6+-) 41.♜g6+ ♕g7 42.h6+-.

35...b4?

After 35...♜e7 36.♞d5 ♜e6 37.♞ad1 f5 38.♞b6 ♞d8, Black can still fight on.

36.cxb4 ♜xb4 37.♞d7 f5 38.♞xf8 ♕xf8 39.♞xd6

Black resigned.

151

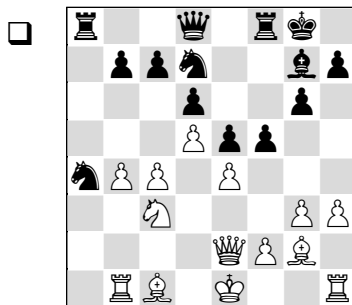
Konstantin Sakaev

Martin Mrva

Istanbul ol 2000 (8)

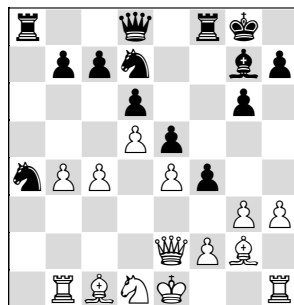
2627

2468



In the event of an exchange of knights, White must constantly consider the possibility of the black rook entering the white position down the a-file. In addition, White has more space, so exchanges are not favourable for him.

18.♞d1! f4



This move takes away the e3-square from White, but further weakens the light squares.

19.h4!

A multi-purpose move: the pawn intends to advance further, weakening the light squares even more, whilst at the same time, the white bishop gets the h3-square, from where it can develop great strength.

19...c5 20.dxc6!

Continuing the light-square strategy. White prepares the ground for play on the queenside – after the advance b4-b5, the weakness of the light squares in Black's camp will become catastrophic. But first, White needs to secure his achievements on the kingside.

20...bxc6 21.h5 g5 22.h6!

The pawn cannot be attacked here, and at the same time it significantly cramps Black.

22...♙f6 23.♙h3 ♖h8 24.♙f5

An excellent outpost for the bishop.

24...♜d6 25.g4!

In case Black plays ...d6-d5, White defends the bishop once again. The king's rook is also ready to come along the third rank to transfer to the queenside.

25...♜c8 26.♜h3 ♜e7 27.♙e6

White wants Black to exchange on f5 in a less favourable situation.

27...♜g6 28.♜a3 ♜e7 29.♙f5 ♜h4

30.♜ba1 ♜b6 31.♜xa8 ♜xa8

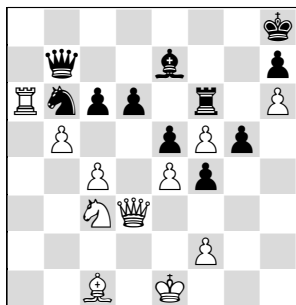
More tenacious is 31...♜xa8 32.♜xa8+ ♜xa8, not giving White the a-file.

32.♜c3 ♜b7 33.b5 ♜xf5 34.gxf5

♜b6 35.♜d3 ♙e7 36.♜a6 ♜f6

And now, the unfortunate position of the ♜b6 tells.

The pin



37.c5! dxc5 38.bxc6 ♜xc6 39.♜b5
Material losses are inevitable.

39...♙d8 40.♜d5 g4 41.♙b2 f3

42.♙xe5+ ♖g8 43.♜a7

Black resigned.

152

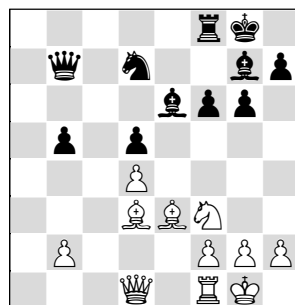
Evgeny Bareev

Peter Leko

Wijk aan Zee 1995 (2)

2675

2555



Despite the almost symmetrical pawn structure, White has a clear advantage. The ♜d7 is poorly placed, the ♙e6 restricted, and the dark-squared bishop would be better somewhere like d6. The weak square c5 is also a serious problem, and the exposed isolated b5-pawn can become an object of attack.

21.♙d2!

A move with many plans. The e-file is opened for the rook, while the bishop can come to b4.

21...♜b6

This move does not help the mobilisation of the pieces, providing White does not grab the b5-pawn prematurely.

The best chance to organise counter-play was 21...♙g4 – Black agrees to part with one bishop, to play ...f6-f5 and activate the other. In this case, even the possible loss of b5 is

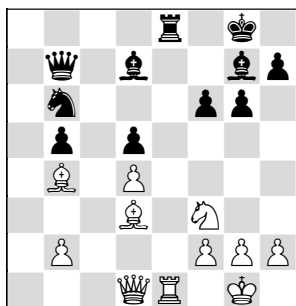
not the end of the world, since with his pieces active, Black will have chances to save the game.

22. ♖e1!

Of course, not 22. ♖xb5? ♜c4 23. ♖xc4 dxc4 – the black bishop will come to d5, with excellent compensation for the pawn.

22... ♖d7 23. ♖b4 ♖e8

Dynamics. The advance of the rook pawn



The black knight has moved a long way from the kingside, making the latter vulnerable.

24. h4!

White is prepared to weaken the protection of the black king by pushing the pawn further, and giving himself the chance to penetrate the black camp with his own knight. In the process, he also makes luft for his own king, which is always a useful thing in a battle with major pieces.

24... ♖xe1+

The attempt to avoid ceding the file does not work: 24... ♖c8 25. h5 ♖xe1+ 26. ♖xe1 ♖e8 27. ♖c1!+–, and the white queen is ready to break into Black's camp.

25. ♖xe1 ♖c8 26. ♖e7 ♖e8

No better is 26... ♖f8 27. ♖xf6 ♖xb4 28. ♖xb6+– – the black king is very weak.

27. h5 gxh5 28. ♖c5

Blocking the c-file, although the immediate 28. ♜h4 is also possible. The checks are not dangerous: 28... ♖c1+ 29. ♖h2 ♖f4+ 30. g3 ♖xf2+ 31. ♜g2+– – Black loses a piece.

28... ♖d7 29. ♖e2 ♜a8

29... ♜a4 30. ♖f5 ♖d8 (30... ♖c6 31. ♖e7+–) 31. ♖e6+ ♖h8 (31... ♖f7 32. ♖xh7+–) 32. ♖e7 ♖b6 33. ♖xd5 ♜xb2 34. ♖a8 ♖c6 35. ♖d8+–.

30. ♖f5 ♖c6 31. ♖e6+ ♖f7

32. ♖xf7+ ♖xf7 33. ♖e7+ ♖g8

34. ♜h4 ♜b6 35. ♖d8+ 1-0

153

Baadur Jobava

2637

Vassily Ivanchuk

2739

Havana 2005 (9)

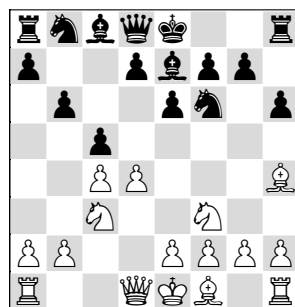
1. d4 ♜f6 2. c4 e6 3. ♜f3 b6 4. ♖g5

A rare line, which is not considered dangerous. The bishop is soon exchanged, which suits Black.

4... h6 5. ♖h4 ♖e7

A double-edged game results from 5...g5 6. ♖g3 ♜e4 or 6...♜h5.

6. ♜c3 c5



7. e4

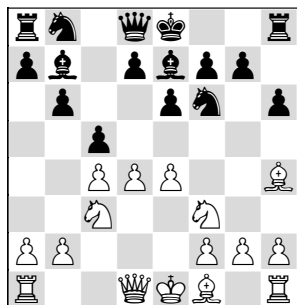
No advantage is promised by 7.d5 ♜xd5! 8. ♜xd5 ♖xh4 9. ♜xh4 ♖b7

10.g3 (10.♘f5 exf5) 10...exd5 11.♙g2 ♗f6 12.♙xd5 ♙xd5 13.♗xd5 ♘c6=. The ♘h4 is too far from the blockading square d5, which means the backward pawn is not really that weak. Black manages to create enough counterplay along the half-open e-file, and on account of his superior development will soon manage to carry out the advance ...d7-d5.

7...cxd4

Black agrees to a decent version of the Hedgehog structure.

A good chance for more active play is 7...♙b7!?



analysis diagram

For example:

A) 8.d5? ♘xd5+;
B) 8.e5 ♘e4 9.♙xe7 ♗xe7 10.♘b5 d5 11.exd6 ♘xd6 12.dxc5 ♘xb5 13.cxb5 ♗xc5=;

C) 8.♗d3 ♘a6 (8...♘c6!?) 9.a3 cxd4 10.♗xd4 ♘c5 11.♘d2 d6 12.b4 e5 13.♗e3 ♘e6=;

D) 8.♗c2 ♘c6 (8...g5!? 9.♙g3 g4 10.♘d2 cxd4 11.♘b5 d6 12.♘xd4∞) 9.d5 ♘d4 10.♘xd4 cxd4 11.♘b5 exd5 12.exd5 (the committal 12.e5?! offers Black a great many tempting possibilities, one promising line being 12...♘e4!? 13.♙xe7 ♗xe7 14.♘c7+ ♘d8 15.♘xa8 ♗xe5 16.♙e2

dx4 17.♗xc4 ♘c5 18.0-0-0 ♙a6 19.♗xd4 ♗xd4 20.♗xd4 ♙xe2+ – the knight on a8 is stranded, and White must fight for a draw) 12...0-0 13.♙e2 ♘xd5 14.♙xe7 ♘xe7 15.0-0 ♘g6 16.♘xd4 ♗c8=.

8.♘xd4 d6 9.♘db5

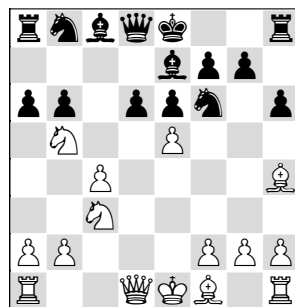
Quieter, more solid and more natural is 9.♙e2. White simply wants to complete his development, retaining a small advantage characteristic of such structures. In developing, he only has to watch for a blow on e4. However, at the moment, it does not work: 9...♘xe4? 10.♙xe7 ♘xc3 11.♙xd8 ♘xd1 12.♗xd1 ♘xd8 13.♙f3 d5 14.cxd5+–.

9...a6!

9...0-0 10.e5 dxe5 11.♙xf6 ♗xd1+ (11...♙xf6 12.♗f3+–) 12.♗xd1 ♙xf6 13.♘c7 ♙b7 14.♘xa8 ♙xa8 15.h4!± and the king's rook comes into play via h3.

10.♙xf6

Naively counting on doubling the enemy pawns. The position required that White plunge into complications: 10.e5!

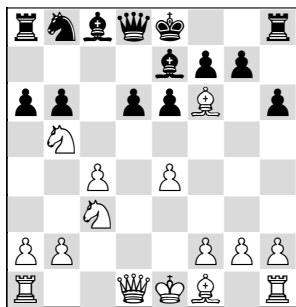


analysis diagram

A) 10...dxe5 11.♙xf6 ♗xd1+ (11...axb5 12.♗f3!±; 11...♙xf6 12.♗f3 axb5 (12...e4 13.♗xe4 axb5 14.♗xa8 ♙xc3+ 15.bxc3 ♗c7 16.♗f3 bxc4

17. ♔g3! ♚xg3 18. hxg3+- 13. ♕xa8
 ♜d7 14. cxb5+- 12. ♖xd1 (12. ♜xd1
 axb5 13. ♙xg7 ♖g8 14. ♜xb5 ♖xg7
 15. ♜c7+ ♜d8 16. ♜xa8∞) 12...axb5
 13. ♙xe5 (13. ♙xg7 ♖g8 14. ♙xh6
 bxc4∞) 13...♜d7! (13...bxc4 14. ♙xg7
 ♖g8 15. ♙xh6±) 14. ♙xg7 ♖g8
 15. ♜xb5 (15. ♙xh6 b4 16. ♜b5 ♖xa2±)
 15...♖xa2 16. ♙c3 ♙b7 17. f3± – Black
 does not have full compensation for
 the pawn;

B) 10...axb5! 11.exf6 (11.♔f3 ♚a5 12.exf6 ♙xf6 13.♙xf6 ♜xf6 14.♜xf6 gxf6 15.♜xb5 ♖e7=) 11...gxf6 (11...♙xf6 12.♙xf6 ♜xf6 13.♜xd6±) 12.♜xb5 ♙b7 (12...♜c6 13.♙g3 ♜e5 14.♙e2 (14.f4 ♜c6 15.f5 ♜e5 16.♙e2 exf5 17.0-0=) 14...♙b7 15.0-0±) 13.♙g3 e5≠ – the light squares in Black's camp are weak, but his central pawn group, which gives him hopes of later playing ...f6-f5 or ...h6-h5, promises him reasonable counterplay.



10...xf6!

10...gxf6 11.♘d4 leads to an advantage for White, despite his having lost a couple of tempi, as the potential positional threat of f2-f4-f5 is very strong.

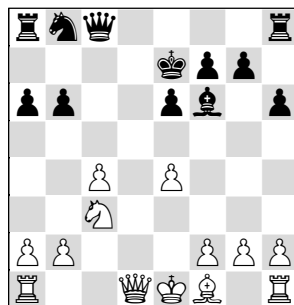
11. xd6+ e7!

Here the king is safe, at the same time assisting with the pressure on

the dark squares and connecting the rooks.

11...♔f8 is wrong, not just out of general considerations, but also concretely, because after 12.f4, White threatens to secure the knight's position with e4-e5.

12. xc8+ xc8



13. a4?

A weak move, demonstrating a neglect of development. White does not want to have his pawns doubled. Under the illusion that he has the advantage, which he does not, he just stores up problems for himself.

A) 13. ♖c2 ♜c5 – then the rook comes to d8 and the knight to c6;

B) 13. ♖e2 ♜xc3+ (13... ♖d8=) 14. bxc3 ♜d8 15. ♔b3 ♜d7=, Black has full compensation, but not more than that, as the b6-pawn needs defending.

13...♖d8 14.♔b3

14. ♔c2 ♕c7 $\overline{+}$.

14...♘d7!

White's position is already difficult – the dark squares in his camp are too weak, and he is behind in development.

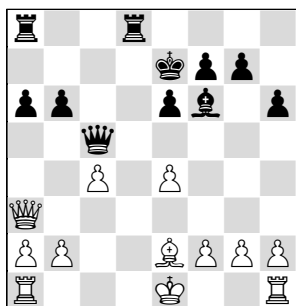
15. ♔a3+

15. ♔b4+ ♘c5 16. ♙e2 ♔c6+.

15...♞c5 16.♚e2

16. ♖xb6 ♖c6 17. ♖a4 ♖xa4 18. ♖xc5+ ♗e8–+.

16... ♖c6 17. ♖xc5 ♖xc5!



18.b4?

It is not clear if this is panic, or just a lack of willingness to suffer in a prospectless defence. But now White simply loses, so it was essential to play 18. ♖xc5+ bxc5 19. ♖d1! (19. ♖b1 ♖ab8 20.b3 ♗c3 21. ♗f1 ♖d2+) 19... ♗xb2 20.0-0 ♗d4+. Black has a clear advantage, but it is not clear if it suffices for victory.

18... ♖g5! 19. ♖d1

19. ♖b1 ♖xg2 20. ♗f3 ♖g5 21. ♗f1 ♖d2 22.b5 ♗e8–+.

19... ♖xg2 20.b5+ ♗e8 21. ♖xd8+ ♖xd8 22. ♗f3 ♖g5 23.bxa6

23. ♗f1 axb5–+.

23... ♖d2+ 24. ♗f1 ♗d4 25. ♗e2 ♗c5!

Here, the bishop is very stable – such outposts are extremely important.

26. ♖g3

26. ♖b3 ♖f4 27. ♖f3 ♖xf3 28. ♗xf3 ♖d2 29.a4 ♖xf2+ 30. ♗e1 b5!–+.

26... ♖xa2 27. ♖xg7

An oversight, which accelerates the end.

On 27. ♖g1, the simplest is the prophylactic 27...g6–+, retaining all the advantages of his position.

The only defence was 27.a7!, but even here, after 27... ♖xa7 28. ♖xg7 ♖a2.

Black should gradually realise his advantage.

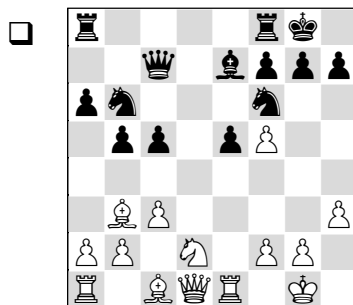
27... ♖d1+ 28. ♗g2 ♖xh1 29. ♖h8+ ♗d7 30.a7 ♖xe2 0-1

154

Robert Fischer

Pal Benko

New York ch-USA 1965 (4)



White has obtained the advantage of the two bishops. With the aid of a kingside pawn advance, he secures total control over the e4-square, which can serve both as an outpost for the knight and also a transit point for other pieces:

16.g4! h6 17.h4 c4 18. ♗c2 ♗h7 19. ♗f3

The pawn on h4 had to be defended, because the threat of g4-g5 forces Black into a further weakening of the light squares, as well as limiting his own knight and bishop.

19...f6 20. ♗d2

The attack on h4 is no longer, so the knight returns to its intended route to e4. At the same time, an excellent post on f3 is freed for the queen, from where it will be more active than on e2.

20... ♖ad8 21. ♖f3 h5

Black opens lines, along which he will himself come under attack.

Instead of this impulsive and unprepared break, he should patiently have defended with 21...♖d7, followed by ...♗f8-d8 and ...♘h7-f8, improving the positions of his pieces.

22.gxh5 ♘d5 23.♘e4 ♘f4 24.♙xf4 exf4 25.♖h1

In view of the terrible position of the ♘h7, Black has no chances to defend.

25...♖h8 26.♖g1 ♗f7 27.♖g6 ♙d6 28.♖ag1 ♙f8 29.h6 ♖e5 30.♖g4 ♖dd7 31.f3 ♙c5 32.♘xc5 ♖xc5 33.♖xg7 ♖xg7 34.hxg7+ ♖g8 35.♖g6 ♖d8 36.♙e4 ♖c8 37.♖e8+

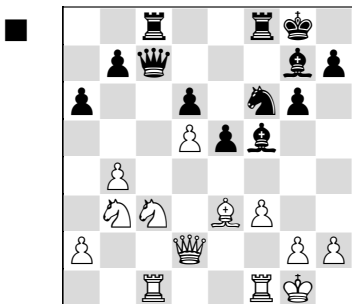
Black resigned.

155

Viktor Kortchnoi

Efim Geller

Moscow tt 1963 (1)



As a rule, in such positions, the advantage lies with the player who has piece control of e4. For example, if instead of the ♘b3 White had a bishop on e2, his position would be preferable, since he would have the light squares protected and could occupy e4. But it is Black's move, and he breaks into White's camp:

19...♖c4! 20.g4

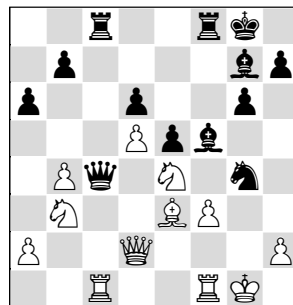
This attempt to drive back the black pieces runs into a tactical refutation.

However, Black is also better after 20.b5 axb5 21.♘a5 ♖d3 22.♘xb7 b4 23.♘e4 ♙xe4 24.fxe4 ♖a6 – the knight on b7 is trapped.

20...♘xg4! 21.♘e4

It seems that this was the move White had been counting on, but disappointment awaits him.

Nor is he saved by 21.fxg4 ♖xg4+ 22.♖g2 ♖xg2+ 23.♖xg2 ♙h3+! 24.♖xh3 ♖xf1 25.♖xf1 ♖xc3 26.♗f3 ♙h6.



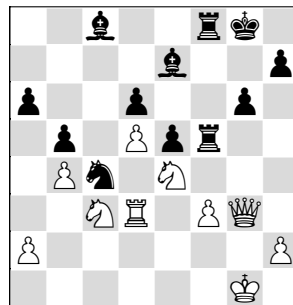
21...♙xe3! 22.♖xc4 ♘xc4 23.♖c1 b5!

A quiet positional move, which underlines the lack of cooperation among the white pieces.

24.♗f2 ♗f7 25.♖g5 ♖cf8 26.♘bd2 ♙f6 27.♖g3 ♙e7

By defending d6, Black frees the knight, which gets an additional possibility to attack the d5-pawn.

28.♖e2 ♘b6 29.♘c3 ♙c8 30.♖e3 ♗f5 31.♘de4 ♘c4 32.♖d3



32...♗d8

And now, we see a typical transfer of the bishop to an active diagonal. Black's position is winning.

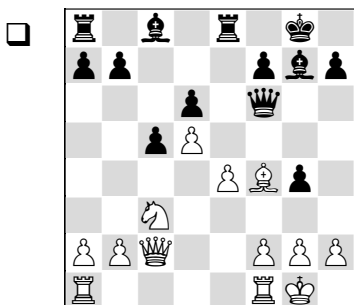
33.♔d1 ♖f4 34.a4 ♙b6+ 35.♔g2
 ♙f5 36.♚e1 g5 37.♜dc3 g4 38.fxg4
 ♙xg4 39.axb5 axb5 40.♔g3 ♙f5
 41.♔g2 ♖h8 42.♖g3 ♙d4 43.h3
 ♙g6 44.♚e2 ♖h7 45.♚e1 ♖7f5
 46.♚c1 ♙xc3 47.♜xc3 ♖f2+
 48.♔g1 ♜d2 49.♚a3 ♖f1+ 50.♖h2
 ♜f3+ 51.♖xf3 ♖5xf3 52.♚a8+
 ♔g7 53.♚c6 ♖1f2+ 54.♔g1 ♖c2
 55.♚d7+ ♖h6 56.♜d1 ♖g3+ 0-1

156

Boris Spassky

Robert Fischer

Reykjavik Wch match 1972 (3)

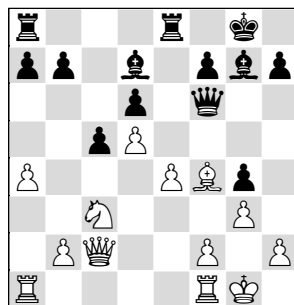


The move that follows not only spoils the integrity of the white pawn formation (the chance to defend the e4-pawn with f2-f3 is lost forever), but also weakens a group of light squares around the king. And although Black cannot exploit this at once, the chronic weakness of these squares eventually tells.

18.g3?

He should have preferred 18.♔g3, intending to strengthen the centre with ♖a1-e1, followed by the break e4-e5, or f2-f3.

18...♗d7 19.a4



19...b6!

The idea of playing ...b7-b5 in two moves is a standard one. If immediately 19...a6, of course there follows 20.a5.

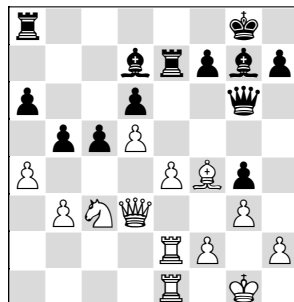
20.♖fe1 a6 21.♖e2

He should have made the black advance ...b6-b5 more difficult by means of 21.♔d3, although after 21...♔g6, with the idea of ...f7-f5, Black has a strong initiative even so.

21...b5 22.♖ae1

The attempt to develop activity with a breakthrough fails: 22.axb5 axb5 23.♙xa8 ♖xa8 24.e5 ♖a1 25.♔g2 dxe5 26.♙xe5 b4-+.

22... ♔q6 23.b3 ♖e7 24. ♔d3



24...♖b8!

Black does not hurry with the preliminary exchange on a4, opening the a-file.

25.axb5 axb5 26.b4 c4

26...cxb4 27.♘a2 allows the white knight to come to c6, giving counter-play.

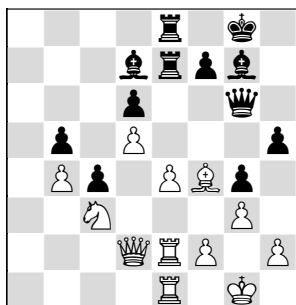
27.♖d2 ♜be8 28.♞e3

He cannot come in along the open lines: 28.♞a1 ♙xc3 (less strong is 28...♞xe4 29.♘xe4 ♙xa1 30.♘xd6 ♞xe2 31.♖xe2 ♖f6 with the idea of ...♖f6-d4, although here too, Black has an undoubted advantage) 29.♖xc3 ♞xe4 30.♞xe4 ♖xe4 – Black's threats on the light squares are much stronger than White's threats on the dark.

28...h5 29.♞3e2 ♔h7 30.♞e3 ♔g8

Repeating moves, to save time before the time control.

31.♞3e2



31...♙xc3!

Black takes a pawn and develops an extremely strong initiative on the light squares.

**32.♖xc3 ♞xe4 33.♞xe4 ♞xe4
34.♞xe4 ♖xe4 35.♙h6 ♖g6
36.♙c1 ♖b1 37.♔f1 ♙f5 38.♔e2
♖e4+ 39.♖e3 ♖c2+ 40.♖d2 ♖b3
41.♖d4**

He also loses after 41.♔e1 c3 42.♖d4 c2 43.♙h6 (43.♙b2 f6) 43...♖b1 44.♔e2 c1♘+.

41...♙d3+

White resigned.

157

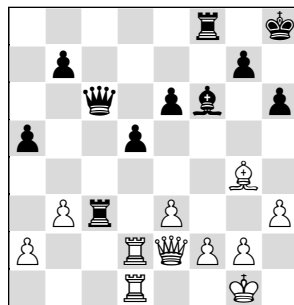
Anatoly Karpov

Garry Kasparov

Moscow Wch match 1985 (4)

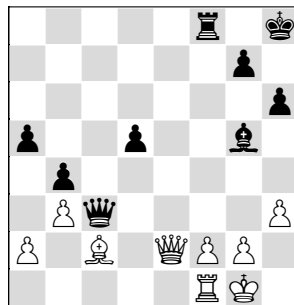
2720

2700



Black's position has some weakened light squares, with his king feeling especially uncomfortable. Therefore, White transfers his bishop to the b1-h7 diagonal, after which Black must keep a careful watch on the activities of the white queen – allowing her onto the same diagonal is tantamount to suicide.

**28.♙h5! b5 29.♙g6 ♙d8 30.♙d3
b4 31.♖g4 ♖e8 32.e4 ♙g5 33.♞c2
♞xc2 34.♙xc2 ♖c6 35.♖e2 ♖c5
36.♞f1 ♖c3 37.exd5 exd5**



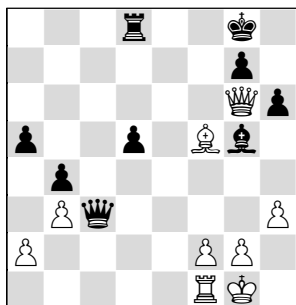
38.♙b1

After various manoeuvres, some additional squares have been freed up on the b1-h7 diagonal, and Black must keep the white queen off it.

38...♖d2 39.♗e5 ♜d8 40.♗f5 ♔g8
41.♗e6+ ♔h8 42.♗g6

Note in passing that White exploits the typical device of repeating moves, to gain time on the clock.

42...♔g8 43.♗e6+ ♔h8 44.♙f5
♜c3 45.♗g6 ♔g8 46.♙e6+ ♔h8
47.♙f5 ♔g8



48.g3!

White has no reason to hurry, since he has no direct win. Therefore, he strengthens his position, and gathers additional small advantages. White restricts the enemy bishop, and ensures his own king a post on g2, where it will not be exposed to checks.

48...♔f8 49.♔g2!

One should pay special attention to such moves – learning to play them is a great art.

49...♗f6 50.♗h7 ♗f7 51.h4
♙d2 52.♜d1 ♙c3 53.♜d3 ♜d6
54.♜f3 ♔e7 55.♗h8 d4 56.♗c8
♜f6 57.♗c5+ ♔e8 58.♜f4 ♗b7+
59.♜e4+ ♔f7 60.♗c4+ ♔f8 61.♙h7
♜f7 62.♗e6 ♗d7 63.♗e5

Black resigned.

Additional material

Keres-Rabar, Munich 1942 – White's 20th move
Kasparov-Ivanchuk, Moscow 1988 – 9th, 12th and 14th moves
Capablanca-Alekhine, Buenos Aires Wch (match/21) 1927
Botvinnik-Alekhine, Amsterdam 1938
Kramnik-Karpov, Frankfurt 1999 – White's 14th move
Ehlvest-Anand, Riga 1995 – Black's 21st move
Karpov-Hjartarson, Seattle (match/2) 1989 – White's 16th move
Geller-Polugaevsky, Portoroz izt 1973
Geller-Bertok, Belgrade 1961 – White's 24th move
Kasparov-Karpov, Seville Wch (match/8) 1987
Pachman-Bronstein, Prague-Moscow 1946
Zita-Bronstein, Prague-Moscow 1946
Reshevsky-Bronstein, Zurich 1953
Lautier-Kramnik, Tilburg 1997 – Black's 16th move
Weinstein-Kantsler, Peterhof 1975 – White's 20th move
Kasparov-Chiburidanidze, Baku 1980 – White's 17th move
Smyslov-Kasparov, Moscow 1981

Chapter 19

Open and half-open files

In chess, there are a great many openings where only one file is opened. Whoever seizes control of it often gains a substantial positional advantage, and if there are entry squares on a file, which can be used to penetrate the defender's position, then his game can become hopeless very quickly.

Open and half-open files are, of course, mainly for rooks. The rooks are rarely pieces whose positions need to be improved. It is usually easy to find good posts for them, because the rook in its actions is simple and direct. From any square on an empty board, it will control 14 squares. If the opponent also has rooks, he will usually try to stop you from seizing the open files, and this frequently ends in mass exchanges, and only the minor pieces remaining on the board. It is possible to prevent the opponent using his major pieces (as the rooks and queens are often called) effectively, if you can close the open files and/or control the entry squares into your position.

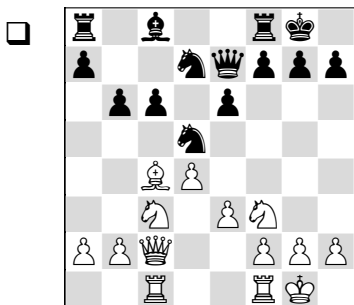
It also happens that after the opening, there are no completely open files on the board. Then, the rooks concern themselves with half-open files, i.e. those on which there are pawns only of one colour. If from our side there are no pawns on a certain file, then why not post our rooks on it, to exert pressure on the opponent's position? In addition, it often happens that such half-open files can be used as avenues of communication to transfer rooks sideways, from one flank to another.

158

José Raul Capablanca

Milan Vidmar

London 1922 (13)



White has a space advantage, but Black has no weaknesses, and if he manages to develop his bishop to b7 and

*

play ...c6-c5, White's advantage will evaporate. Therefore, there followed

12. ♖xd5!

If the black pawn were on h6, rather than h7, this move would not be so strong, because Black could take with the e-pawn and then, when the white bishop moves away, play ...c6-c5, either at once or after the preliminary ...♙c8-b7.

12...cxd5

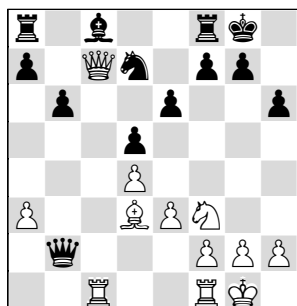
But now not 12...exd5, because of 13. ♙d3, and Black has two pawns hanging simultaneously.

13. ♙d3 h6 14. ♖c7

The firm control of the c-file ensures White a large advantage.

14...♖b4 15.a3 ♗a4

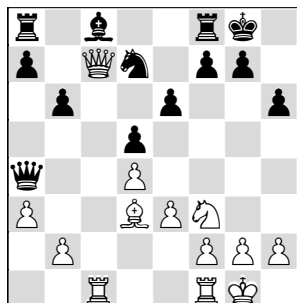
The pawn cannot be taken, because after 15...♖xb2,



analysis diagram

there follows 16.♖a1!, threatening to trap the queen. After 16...♖b3 17.♗c6 ♗xd3 18.♗xa8, White has a decisive advantage.

Black also loses material after 15...♖b3 16.♖fd1 ♖xb2 17.♖a1 ♖b3 18.♗c6.



16.h3!

Black cannot bring out his pieces, so White simply strengthens his position slightly, by making luft.

The immediate strengthening of the pressure on the c-file is too hasty, as after 16.♖c3, the exchange of bishops with 16...♗f6 17.♗e5 ♗a6 eases Black's defence.

16...♗f6 17.♗e5 ♗d7

Black also loses immediately after 17...♗a6, because of 18.b3 ♗a5 19.♗c6 ♗xa3 20.♖a1.

18.♗c2 ♖b5 19.a4 ♖xb2 20.♗xd7 ♖ac8 21.♖b7 ♗xd7 22.♗h7+ ♗xh7 23.♖xc8

White realised his material advantage.

159

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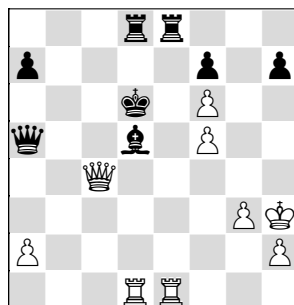
Alexander Rustemov

2537

Martin Neubauer

2431

Germany Bundesliga 2011/12 (13)



The black king is in the middle of the board, which in an open position like this is almost always fatal. With the aid of checks and direct threats, White could have decided the game in his favour:

26.♖xd5+!

In the game, White missed something and forced a draw: 26.♖f4+ ♗d7 27.♖c4+ ♗d6 28.♖f4+, etc.

26...♖xd5 27.♖a6+ ♗c7

The same result comes from 27...♗d7 28.♖xa7+ ♗d6 29.♖a6+ ♗d7 30.♖a4+.

28.♖xa7+ ♗d6 29.♖a6+ ♗c7

Little is changed by 29...♗d7 30.♖a4+ ♗d6 31.♖d1 ♖xd1 32.♖xd1+ ♗e5 33.♖h5+ ♗xf6 34.g4 ♗g7 35.♖g5+ ♗h8 36.♖f6+ ♗g8 37.♗h4 – the black king is in a mating net, and White also has the passed a-pawn in reserve.

30.♖c1+ ♗b8 31.♖b1+ ♗c7 32.♖b5

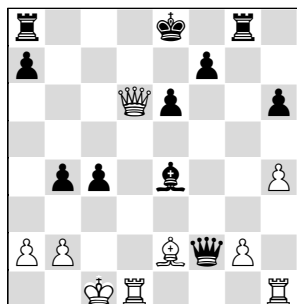
Black has to give up the queen, and White keeps a large number of extra pawns.

160**Konstantin Sakaev****Boris Gelfand**

Kallithea tt 2008 (6)

2640

2719



To clinch the game, White needed to land several strong blows:

23. ♖hf1

White could not calculate the long variation, and after 23. ♖d7+ ♔f8 24. ♖d6+ ♔e8, a draw was agreed.

23... ♜e3+ 24. ♖d2 ♘d5 25. ♙h5 ♜g7 26. ♜c7 c3 27. ♙xf7+ ♜xf7 28. ♜xf7+ ♔d8 29. ♜f8+ ♔c7 30. ♖f7+ ♔b6

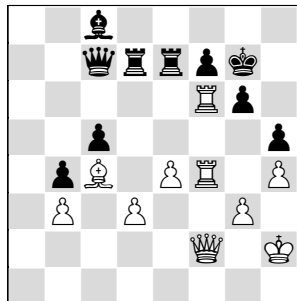
On 30... ♔c6, the rook goes with check after 31. ♜xa8+.

31. ♜xb4+!

It is the fact that the pawn goes with check that both players missed.

161**Efim Geller****Heinz Liebert**

Kapfenberg Ech tt 1970 (6)

******

All of the black pieces are tied to the defence of the f7-pawn, and on the h- and g-files, nothing defends the black king, except a couple of pawns. Of course, White could move the king to g2, preparing to open lines with g3-g4. But if there is the possibility of carrying out a piece offensive, without weakening the pawn cover of one's king, this should be seized:

43. ♜b2 ♔h7 44. ♖f5 gxf5 45. ♖h6+

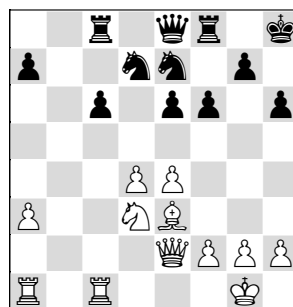
Another version of the mating set-up arises after 45. ♜e2 ♔g7 46. ♜xh5.

45... ♔xh6 46. ♜h8+ ♔g6 47. exf5+

Black resigned, on account of 47... ♔xf5 48. ♜xh5+ ♔f6 49. ♜g5#.

162**Salomon Flohr****Petr Romanovsky**

Moscow 1935 (15)

******

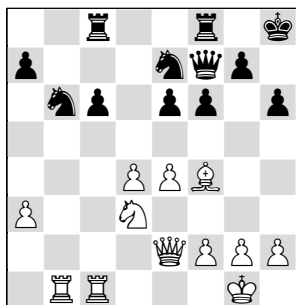
White has a large positional advantage, and it is a question of how to realise it. His next move is multi-purpose:

21. ♙f4!

One idea is to take control of the square b8, so White can penetrate down the b-file. Another is the prevention of possible black counterplay on the light squares, involving ...f6-f5 – the white queen

is now looking down the e-file. And finally, the bishop dreams of landing on d6, pinning the knight, which defends the c6-pawn. This would be very unpleasant for Black.

21... ♖f7 22. ♖ab1 ♖b6



Black hopes that he will be able to close the b-file, but there followed

23.a4! ♖fd8

He loses after 23... ♖xa4 24. ♖b7 – the ♖e7 cannot escape the pin.

24.a5 ♖a8 25. ♖b7! ♖xd4 26. ♖c5 e5 27. ♖e3 ♖dd8 28. ♖xa7

White's domination is absolute, and his passed a-pawn, supported by his pieces, should decide the game. Even so, a more aesthetic way to win was 28. ♖a6!, burying the knight on a8.

28... ♖c7 29.h3 ♖b5 30. ♖b7 ♖d6 31. ♖b2 ♖b5 32. ♖d2 f5 33.f3 fxe4 34.fxe4 ♖g6 35. ♖g4 ♖h7 36. ♖f2 ♖e7 37. ♖cf1 ♖f8 38. ♖e6! ♖xe6 39. ♖xe6 ♖xf2 40. ♖xf2 ♖e8 41. ♖c5 ♖a8 42.a6 ♖g8 43. ♖a2 ♖f8

White's task would be more complicated after 43... ♖f7 – at the first chance, he should bring his forces into the battle. The most precise path to the win is then 44. ♖d7 ♖e6 45. ♖b6 ♖a7 46. ♖c5 ♖f4 47. ♖c4 ♖a8 48.a7 ♖d3 49. ♖a6 ♖xc5 50. ♖xc6 ♖e7 51. ♖xc5 ♖xa7 52. ♖a5+–.

44. ♖f2

Too slow. He wins with 44. ♖d3! ♖d7 45.a7, with the idea of ♖a2-a6!.

44... ♖f7 45. ♖g3 ♖g6

45... ♖e6! allows Black to defend.

46. ♖d2 ♖a7 47. ♖d7+ ♖xd7 48. ♖xd7 ♖e6 49. ♖c5+ ♖d6 50. ♖f2 ♖c7 51.g3 ♖a8 52. ♖g2 ♖e7 53. ♖f3 g6 54. ♖d3 ♖c8 55. ♖c5+ ♖e6 56. ♖b2 ♖d6 57. ♖xd6 ♖xd6 58. ♖c4+ ♖c5 59. ♖xe5 ♖b6 60. ♖xg6 ♖xa6 61.e5 ♖b7 62. ♖e4+ ♖c7 63. ♖f5 ♖d7 64.e6 ♖e8 65. ♖e5 c5 66. ♖d7 c4 67. ♖f6+ ♖f8 68. ♖d5 ♖g7 69. ♖e4

Black resigned.

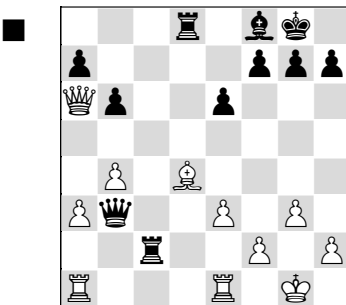
163

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Aron Nimzowitsch

José Raul Capablanca

New York 1927 (2)



The bishop on d4 prevents the other black rook entering the seventh rank, so therefore...

26... ♖e5! 27. ♖xe5 ♖dd2 28. ♖b7?

There is no way White can afford to leave the two enemy rooks on the seventh.

A) 28. ♖f1 is impossible, due to 28... ♖xe3 29. ♖f4 ♖xf2;

B) But it was still possible to hold the balance with 28. ♖f1! ♖e6! (little is given by 28... ♖d5 29. ♖f4 ♖f3 30. ♖ec1 ♖xf2+ 31. ♖xf2 ♖xf2

32.♖xc2 ♜xc2 33.♞d1) 29.♙d4 ♚h6!. Because of the threat to take on f2, White is obliged to complete the weakening: 30.h4 ♚e6 31.♞ed1 (the queenside pawns are lost after 31.♞ac1 ♜xf2 32.♚xf2 ♜xf2 33.♙xf2 ♚a2+) 31...♜xf2 32.♚xf2 ♜xf2 33.♙xf2 – because of the weakness of the light squares and the pawn g3, White has a difficult position.

28...♜xf2 29.g4 ♚e6 30.♙g3 ♜xh2!
31.♚f3 ♜hg2+ 32.♚xg2 ♜xg2+
33.♙xg2 ♚xg4 34.♞ad1 h5 35.♞d4
♚g5 36.♙h2 a5 37.♞e2 axb4
38.axb4 ♙e7 39.♞e4 ♙f6 40.♞f2
♚d5 41.♞e8+ ♙h7

White resigned.

164

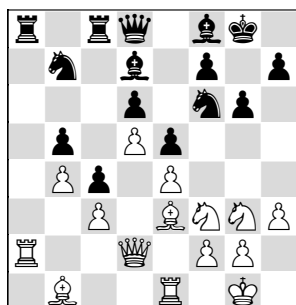
Anatoly Karpov

Wolfgang Unzicker

Nice of 1974 (3)

2700

2535



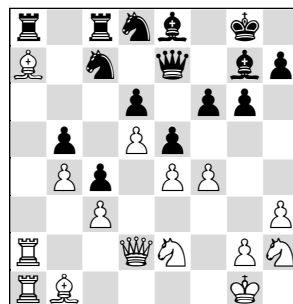
24.♙a7!

In this way, White prevents Black from exchanging rooks on the a-file, and is able to seize it for himself.

24...♞e8 25.♙c2 ♞c7 26.♞ea1
♚e7 27.♙b1 ♙e8 28.♞e2 ♞d8
29.♞h2 ♙g7 30.f4 f6

More tenacious is 30...exf4 31.♞xf4 f6, so as to try to transfer his knight via f7 to e5, and obtain at least some squares for his pieces. Admittedly,

White then obtains the extra square d4.



31.f5 g5

Now, the final stage of the realisation process is carried out. White seizes the g4- and h5-squares.

32.♙c2 ♙f7 33.♞g3 ♞b7 34.♙d1
h6 35.♙h5 ♚e8 36.♚d1 ♞d8
37.♞a3 ♙f8 38.♞1a2 ♙g8 39.♞g4
♙f8 40.♞e3 ♙g8 41.♙xf7+ ♞xf7
42.♚h5 ♞d8 43.♚g6 ♙f8 44.♞h5

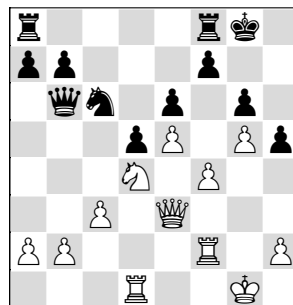
In case of necessity, White can bring his king to f2, play h3-h4, and transfer one of his rooks to the h-file, but Black spared him the need by resigning.

165

Aron Nimzowitsch

José Raul Capablanca

New York 1927 (15)



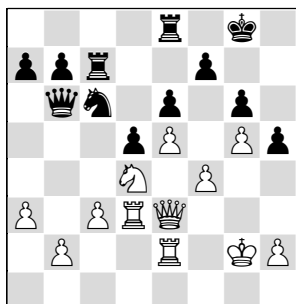
A breakthrough on the kingside is unrealistic, whilst on the queenside,

Black is exerting some pressure, which means that the advantage is on his side.

20...♖fc8

Black intends the following set-up: rooks on c4 and c8, and knight on e7. This needs to be done accurately, so as not to permit the break f4-f5. Once the pieces are in their appointed places, Black will be able to choose between one of the following plans: either ...♘e7-f5, with the idea of eliminating the knight from d4, and getting the chance to manoeuvre the rook along the fourth rank, or playing ...b7-b5-b4, undermining the knight's foundations on c3.

**21.a3 ♜c7 22.♞d3 ♘a5 23.♞e2 ♞e8
24.♔g2 ♘c6**

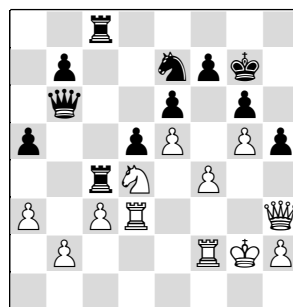


25.♞ed2

White is gaining nothing from the opposition of the knights, so he should have played 25.♘xc6, after which Black has the interesting idea of changing the picture with 25...bxc6!? (he has very little in the rook ending arising after 25...♞xc6 26.♞xb6 ♞xb6 27.♞d4 – the white king soon comes to the defence of the queenside pawns, around c2; and on 25...♞xc6, there follows

26.♞d4 – despite the fact that Black still has the plan of advancing the a- and b-pawns, the exchange of knights makes White's defence easier) 26.♞xb6 (after 26.c4 dxc4 27.♞d4 ♞b7, Black is somewhat better, because the position has opened up and the white king is not so solidly defended) 26...axb6 – Black has the plan of pushing his queenside pawns with ...c6-c5 and ...b6-b5-b4.

**25...♞ec8 26.♞e2 ♘e7 27.♞ed2
♞c4 28.♞h3 ♔g7 29.♞f2 a5**



30.♞e2?!

He should not have allowed the blockade of d4 to be lost, and should have returned with the queen.

**30...♘f5 31.♘xf5+ gxf5+ 32.♞f3
♔g6 33.♞ed2 ♞e4 34.♞d4 ♞c4
35.♞f2 ♞b5 36.♔g3**

Now, the white pawn is drawn to d4, and the rook on d2 turns out to be paralysed.

More tenacious was 36.♞xc4 ♞xc4 37.♞d4, although White's position is difficult in any case.

**36...♞cxd4 37.cxd4 ♞c4 38.♔g2 b5
39.♔g1 b4 40.axb4 axb4 41.♔g2
♞c1 42.♔g3 ♞h1 43.♞d3 ♞e1
44.♞f3 ♞d1 45.b3 ♞c1 46.♞e3 ♞f1**

White resigned.

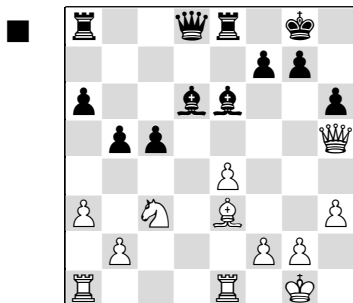
166

Semyon Furman

Ratmir Kholmov

Leningrad ch-URS 1963 (4)

**



Black has the two bishops, which, in the absence of any weaknesses, already gives him the advantage. Another important criterion for the assessment of the position is control of the d-file. If White manages to seize it, he will get counterplay, whereas if Black can control it, this will increase his advantage.

19...♙b3!

Since he cannot himself take control of the file at once, Black stops White from doing so, taking firm control of the square d1. In the process, he opens the e-file.

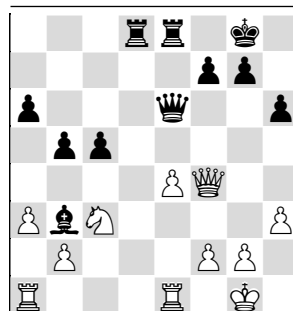
20. ♖g4

The central pawn has to be defended, as on 20. ♖e2, with the idea of ♖e2-d2, there is the strong 20...b4!.

20... ♖c8

The white queen is very active, so Black offers the exchange, as simplifications will not ease White's position.

21. ♖f3 ♖e6 22. ♙f4 ♙xf4 23. ♖xf4 ♖ad8



24.f3

More active is 24. ♖e3, freeing e1 for the other rook. Then, after 24... ♖d2, White has 25. ♙xb5! axb5 26. ♖xb3 ♖xf2 27. ♖xf2 ♖xb3 28. ♖c1! c4 29. ♖f1! c3 30. bxc3 ♖xe4 31. ♖e1.

24... ♖d4 25. ♙e2 ♖d7 26. ♖e3 c4

Black ensures an outpost on d3 for his rook, and prepares to create a passed pawn on the queenside with ...a6-a5 and ...b5-b4.

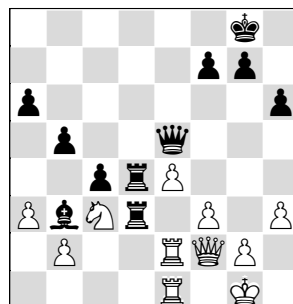
27. ♙c3

If 27. ♙d4 ♖g6 28. ♙xb3 ♖d3, the black rook will be strong on b3.

27... ♖d3 28. ♖f2 ♖e5 29. ♖e2 ♖ed8 30. ♖ae1

30. ♙d5 allows him to close the d-file, but also fails to solve the problems fully – after the simple 30...a5, Black's game is preferable.

30... ♖d4



31. ♖h4?

Firing a blank. Essential was 31.f4!, seizing a bit of space and trying to

create some counterplay on the kingside. Admittedly, after 31...♖f6 32.♘d5 ♕d6, Black retains the initiative.

31...a5 32.♖f2 b4 33.axb4 axb4
34.♘d5 c3 35.bxc3 bxc3 36.♘e3
♙d2 37.♙c1 ♙4d3 38.♘f1 ♙d1
39.♙e1 ♙xe1 40.♖xe1 ♕d4+
41.♖f2 c2 0-1

167

Vassily Ivanchuk

2776

Hikaru Nakamura

2774

Medias 2011 (10)

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.cxd5 cxd5 4.♘c3
♘f6 5.♘f3 ♘c6 6.♙f4 ♙f5 7.♖b3
♖b6 8.♖xb6 axb6 9.e3 e6 10.a3
♙e7 11.♙e2 0-0 12.0-0 ♙fc8 13.♙fc1

White's advantage has a microscopic character, with only the doubled pawns on the b-file being a potential weakness. In other respects, the position is symmetrical.

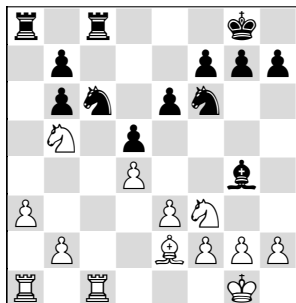
13...♘h5

It was worth considering 13...♘e4, since later the knight on c3 can exert pressure on the queenside from a4 or b5.

14.♙g5 ♙xg5 15.♘xg5 ♘f6 16.♘f3

The immediate 16.♘b5!? ♘e8 17.g4! ♙g6 18.♙c3, arranging seizure of the c-file, is also promising.

16...♙g4 17.♘b5



17...♙xf3?!

An unnecessary concession. In doubling the pawns, Black exchanges his bishop without need and concedes the file, which causes him problems.

Black would have been close to equality after 17...♘a5.

18.♙xf3 ♙d8?!

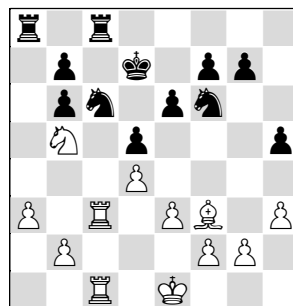
Black underestimates the danger. 18...♘a5 was still necessary.

**19.♙f1 ♙f8 20.♙c3 ♙e7 21.♙ac1
♙dc8 22.♙e1 ♘d7 23.h3**

Having achieved some success on the queenside, White unhurriedly prepares to gain space on the other wing.

23...h5?!

More cautious is 23...♘e8, preparing ...♘c6-e7.



24.h4!

Now, the h5-pawn, fixed on the same colour square as White's bishop, can become an object of attack. Or, after the advance f2-f3 and g3-g4, White may be able to create a passed h-pawn.

**24...g6 25.g3 ♙a5 26.♙e2 ♘e8
27.♙b3 ♙d8 28.f3 ♘f6 29.♘c3 ♙c7
30.♘a2**

The time has come to strengthen the pressure on the c-file.

30...♖g8 31.♘b4 ♘e7 32.♘d3
♙aa8 33.♘e5

By establishing his knight here, White forces new weaknesses in Black's camp.

33...♙f8

After 33...f6 34.♘d3, the white knight heads to f4, attacking Black's pawns and supporting the advance g3-g4.

34.♙d3 f5 35.♙b5 ♙ac8 36.♖f2
♙g8 37.♙a4 ♙gf8 38.♙c2

White is in no hurry, and tries to make every pawn advance in the most favourable circumstances possible.

38...♙fd8 39.♙bc3 ♙d6 40.b4
♖b8 41.♙xc6 bxc6 42.b5 ♖b7
43.bxc6+ ♖c7 44.a4 ♙dd8 45.♙b2
♙a8 46.♙cb3 ♘c8 47.♙a2 ♙g8
48.a5 b5 49.♙xb5 ♘d6 50.♙b4 ♙a6
51.♖g2 g5 52.hxg5 ♙xg5 53.♖h3
♙g8 54.♖h4 ♙h8 55.♙ab2 ♙a7
56.♙b6 ♙ha8 57.♖xh5 ♙g8 58.a6
♙ga8 59.♙b7+ ♖xb7 60.axb7

Black resigned.

168

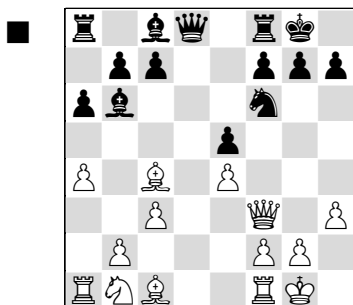
Dmitry Kryakvin

Murtas Kazhgaleev

St Petersburg 2009 (8)

2571

2643

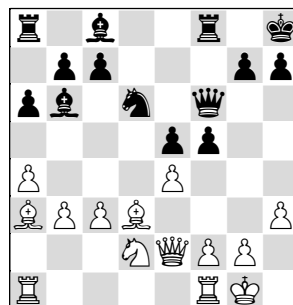


The position looks roughly equal, and the natural way to maintain the balance was 11...h6, not allowing the bishop to g5. Then, he can simplify the position by playing ...♙d8-e7 and ...♙c8-e6. But Black finds another plan – an aggressive one, involving opening the f-file.

11...♘e8! 12.b3

Not sensing the danger. White should already understand that, after Black plays the advance ...f7-f5, the pawn on f2 will be under fire from the bishop at b6, and so this piece should be exchanged: 12.♙e3! ♙xe3 13.♙xe3 ♘d6 14.♙e2, with an equal game.

12...♘d6 13.♙a3 ♖h8 14.♘d2 f5
15.♙e2 ♙f6 16.♙d3



16...f4!

Black suddenly changes plans, now intending to break through on the g-file, in the spirit of the classical system of the King's Indian.

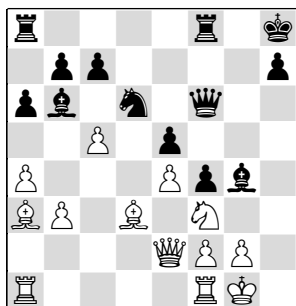
It was also possible to maintain the tension on the f-file by playing 16...♙g6.

17.♘f3 g5! 18.c4 g4! 19.hxg4

This natural move unexpectedly proves to be a mistake. White takes the pressure off the knight, but allows Black to develop, which

turns out to be more important. It was essential to play 19.c5! ♙xc5 (19...gxf3 20.♙xf3 ♙a7 21.cxd6 ♜g8 22.♖h2 cxd6 23.♙c4 ♙e6 24.♙xe6 ♙xe6 25.♞ad1 ♞ad8 26.♞d5 ♞g6) 20.♙xc5 gxf3 21.♙xf3 ♞g8 22.♙xd6 cxd6 23.♙c4 ♙e6 , with approximate equality – the weakness of the d6-pawn compensates for the pressure down the d-file.

19...♙xg4 20.c5



20...♖f7!!

White probably underestimated the effect of the knight joining in the attack.

21.♙b2

21.cxb6 ♖g5 22.♙xf8 ♖xf3+ 23.gxf3 ♙h3+ .

21...♙xc5

Retaining all the advantages of his attacking position. He could win by force with 21...♖g5! 22.♙xe5 ♖xf3+ 23.♙xf3 ♙xf3 24.♙xf6+ ♞xf6 25.gxf3 ♞g8+ 26.♖h2 ♞h6#.

22.♙c4

More tenacious is 22.♞fc1, after which a precise way of winning is to cement the centre with 22...♙d6!, with the idea of ...♖f7-g5.

22...♖g5 23.♙xe5 ♖xf3+ 24.♙xf3 ♙xe5 25.♙xg4 f3

25...♙xf2+-- was also possible.

26.♙e6 ♙f4 27.♙h3 fxg2 28.♖xg2 ♞f6 29.♙c3 ♙xe4+ 30.f3 ♙g6+ 31.♖h1 ♙g7

White resigned.

169

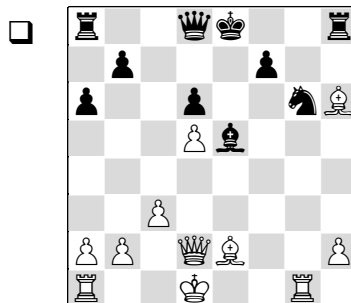
Anatoly Karpov

2540

Vlastimil Hort

2605

Moscow 1971 (11)



White spies out the two main weaknesses of the black position – the unstable position of the knight on g6 and the weakness of the b7-pawn, which can be attacked along the b-file. His rook can work not only on the files, but also along the ranks – a rare example!

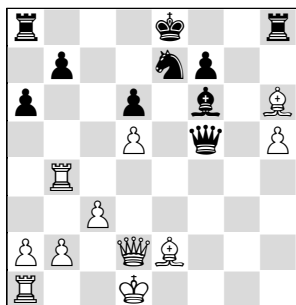
22.♞g4!

From here, the rook supports the advance h2-h4, taking an active square from the black queen, as well as preparing to swing over to b4. One move pursues several ideas at once.

22...♙f6

Black has no time to take the pawn; after 22...♙xh2 23.♖c2 ♙e5 24.♞f1, the white rook goes to b4, and the bishop to g4 or h5, and Black cannot coordinate his forces.

23.h4! ♖f5 24.♜b4 ♕f6 25.h5 ♘e7



26.♜f4!

White drives the queen from f5, so as to get the c2-square for his king.

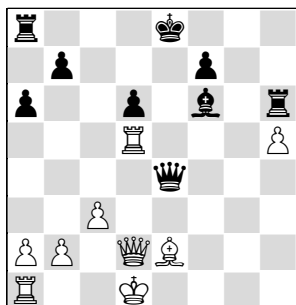
26...♜e5 27.♜f3

Black gets the possibility to complete his development, whilst at the same time, the ♕e2 hangs, and another tempo has to be spent bringing the white king to c2. More accurate was 27.♜f2! 0-0-0 28.♙c2, with a large advantage.

27...♘xd5

Now, the d-file is opened, and the light-squared bishop, which was obstructed by its own pawn, becomes a powerful attacking piece. Stronger was 27...0-0-0!, with excellent chances to hold the position, since 28.♙c2? is impossible because of 28...♜xh6!.

28.♜d3 ♜xh6 29.♜xd5 ♜e4



30.♜d3!

Now, h6 hangs, ♜e3 is threatened, and the white king gets the c2-square.

30...♜h1+

Black fails to find the defensive resource 30...♜h7! – the light squares are creaking, but Black can still resist.

31.♙c2 ♜xa1 32.♜xh6 ♕e5

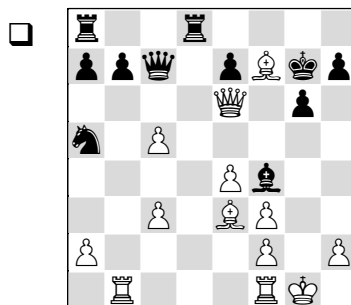
33.♜g5

Black resigned.

170

Training position

Konstantin Sakaev



White has two extra pawns, but his structure is spoiled. The bishop on f7 is in trouble and cannot escape, whilst the tempting 18.♕d4+ ♜xd4 19.cxd4 ♜f8 leads to a complicated, double-edged position. Does White have anything better?

Thinking about how to get at the exposed black king, we find the unexpected

18.♙h1!!

It turns out that White can carry out a mating attack along the open g-file.

18...♕xe3

A technically winning position results from 18...♖e5 19.♙d4 ♜xd4 20.♖xe5+ ♙xe5 21.cxd4 ♙xd4 22.♙d5+–.

19.♙xg6 ♖h8

Or 19...hxg6 20.♖g1+–.

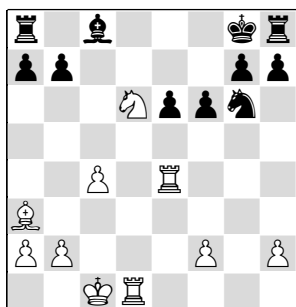
20.fxe3 hxg6 21.♖xg6+–

By exploiting the open g-file, White will give mate.

171

Training position

Konstantin Sakaev



Despite the absence of queens, the position has a middlegame character. One of Black's ideas is ...h7-h5, and then ...♖h7. Another is ...♙c8-d7, so as after the capture on b7 to have ...♙c6. White prevents these ideas, at the same time creating the threat to attack on the half-open g-file, with the move

22.♖g4!

Now, the threat is to exchange on c8, followed by entering with the rook on d7, as well as doubling rooks on the g-file by ♖dg1, followed by the march of the h-pawn.

22...♙e5

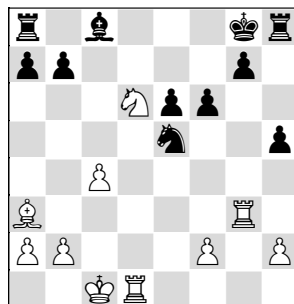
A) 22...b6 allows White to carry out one of his ideas: 23.♖d7 e5 24.♖4g3

♙e6 25.h4, with the decisive threat of h4-h5;

B) 22...e5 23.♙xc8 ♜xc8 24.♖d7 f5 25.♖g5 ♜xc4+ 26.♙d2 – Black temporarily has two extra pawns, but it is very hard for him to defend, because White's rooks dominate, e.g. 26...♖f4 27.♙c5 b6 28.♙e3 ♜f3 29.♙e2 e4 30.♖xa7, and Black is in a bad way.

23.♖g3 h5

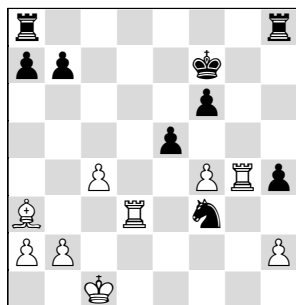
23...♙c6 is bad because of 24.♙xb7!, and the knight is immune because of the rook's entry on d7. Thanks to the activity of his pieces and his superior pawn position, White has a large advantage.



24.f4!

The pawn, as a fully-fledged attacking unit, joins in the assault! Less convincing is 24.♙e8 ♖h7 25.♙xg7 h4 26.♖gg1 ♖h6! – the knight is stranded on g7, although after, say, 27.♙e7 ♙g6 28.♙xf6 ♜f8 29.♙c3 a5 30.f4! ♜a6 31.♖g4 e5 32.f5 ♙xf5 33.♙xf5+ ♜xf5 34.♖d7, White retains the advantage, thanks to his better-coordinated pieces and the pawn hanging on b7.

24...h4 25.♖gg1 ♙f3 26.♖g2 e5 27.♙e8 ♙g4 28.♙xf6+ gxf6 29.♖xg4+ ♖f7 30.♖d3



30...♘d4

Black lands in a mating net after
 30...e4 31.♞d7+ ♔e6 32.♞d5 f5
 33.♞g6+ ♚f7 34.♞gd6 ♜h5 35.b3!,
 for example, 35...♘xh2 36.♞d7+ ♚g8
 37.♞5d6, mating.

31.fxe5 fxe5 32.♙d6

White is close to winning.

Additional material

Alekhine-Rubinstein, Vilnius 1912

Ivanchuk-Aronian, Morelia/Linares 2007 – White's 17th move

Panov-Kan, Tbilisi 1937 – Black's 18th move

Kasparov-Karpov, Seville Wch (match/4) 1987

Karpov-Andersson, Thessaloniki 1988 – White's 20th move

Steinitz-Von Bardeleben, Hastings 1895

Flohr-Romanovsky, Moscow 1935 – White's 21st move

Khalifman-P.Nikolic, Moscow 1990 – White's 16th move

Chapter 20

The advantage of two bishops

Two bishops, working together, can control a huge number of squares, and often represent a great strength. The side that has the bishops usually tries to increase their activity, and to open diagonals.

In the endgame, the strength of the bishop pair is seen especially clearly when there are pawn islands on both flanks. Since they are long-range pieces, the bishops cannot attack these different islands.

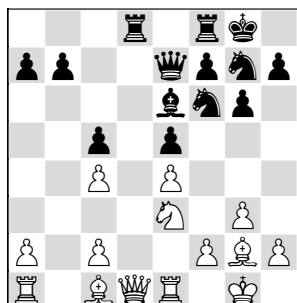
Another of the advantages of the bishop pair is the possibility of exchanging one of them at the right moment.

172

Mikhail Botvinnik

Vasily Panov

Leningrad ch-URS 1939 (9)



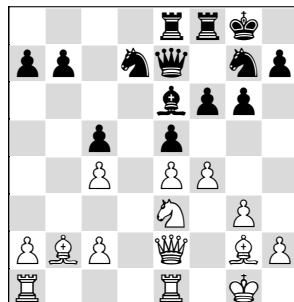
20. ♖e2!

White does not hurry, first completing his development and threatening the advance f2-f4 – after all, the dark squares on the black kingside are weakened. At the same time, the possible knight jump into d5 is kept in reserve.

If White immediately occupies the weakened d5-square, then after 20. ♘d5 ♙xd5 21. cxd5 ♘fe8, Black will occupy the blockade square on d6 with his knight, easing his defence.

20... ♘d7 21. ♙b2 f6 22. f4 ♖de8

*



While White still has one piece that is not in play (the ♖a1), it was necessary to seek counterplay urgently: 22...exf4! 23.gxf4 ♘h5 24. ♖f1 ♙d6!. Admittedly, after 25.e5! (on 25. ♙f2, there could follow 25... ♙a6, reminding White about his own insecure queenside) 25...fxe5 26.f5 ♙f7 27. ♘g4, White has quite a strong initiative.

23. ♖ad1 b6 24. ♖d2 exf4 25.gxf4 g5

White has already strengthened his centre, and this attempt at counterplay is too late.

26.fxg5 fxg5 27.e5 ♙f7 28. ♘d5 ♘h5 29. ♖f1 ♘f4 30. ♙e4 ♙f5 31. ♙xf5 ♙xf5 32. ♘xf4 gxf4 33. ♙d5+ ♙g7 34.e6+ ♘f6 35. ♖xf4

♙g6 36. ♖g2+ ♘g4 37. ♖gxg4+
 ♙xg4 38. ♖xg4+ ♚f5 39. ♖g3 ♖g8
 40. ♙g7 ♖e7 41. ♙f8

Black resigned.

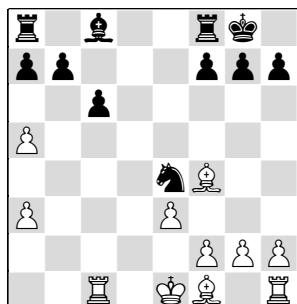
173

Garry Kasparov
Vassily Smyslov

Vilnius match 1984 (9)

2710

2600

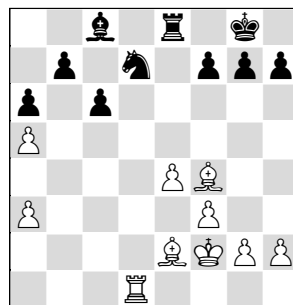


The doubled pawns on the a-file are not a weakness but a strength, because Black cannot attack them, and they blockade the whole black queenside and make the b7-pawn backward. In addition, Black has a restricted bishop, which, in conjunction with White's kingside pawn majority, ensures White a large advantage.

17.f3

First of all, it is useful to seize space in the centre. The pawns move with tempi onto light squares, limiting the enemy bishop at the same time, and taking away the important d5-square from the black pieces.

17... ♗f6 18.e4 ♖e8 19. ♖f2 a6
 20. ♙e2 ♙e6 21. ♖b1 ♖e7 22. ♖hd1
 ♖ae8 23. ♖b2 ♙c8 24. ♖bd2 ♖d7
 25. ♖xd7 ♗xd7



26.g4!

Having completed his development, White seizes space on the kingside.

26... ♗c5

More tenacious is 26...h6, so that after White plays h2-h4 and g4-g5, the h-pawns are removed from the board. The general principle in defending such positions is as follows: the fewer open lines there are on the board, the easier it is for the knight to fight the bishop.

27. ♙e3 ♗d7 28.g5 ♗e5 29. ♙d4
 ♗g6 30. ♖g3 ♗f8 31.h4 ♖d8 32.f4
 ♙e6 33. ♙c3

The exchange of rooks will not ease Black's position, as the difference between the pieces remaining on the board is too great.

33... ♖xd1 34. ♙xd1 ♗d7

If 34...g6, 35. ♙c2, and then f4-f5, further cramping Black.

35.f5 ♙c4 36.h5 h6

36...f6 loses immediately, due to 37.h6!.

**37.gxh6 gxh6 38.e5 ♗c5 39. ♖f4
 ♙d5 40. ♙c2 f6**

Bad, but passive defence, such as 40...♙c4, does not offer any chances of saving the game. 41. ♖e3 ♙d5 42. ♙b4 ♗b3 43. ♗d3, approaching the ♗b3.

41.e6 ♖g7 42.♙b4 ♜b3 43.♚e3 c5
44.♙c3 ♜f8

Black resigned.

174

Boris Grachev

Igor Lysyj

Taganrog ch-RUS 2011 (11)

**

2669

2629



Despite the fact that the c3-pawn is isolated, it is not so bad. It takes away from the black pieces the d4-square, and at the same time cannot be effectively attacked. The first stage of White's plan is to seize control of most of the central squares, by advancing his kingside pawns, seizing space.

18.♖d7 ♖e7 19.♖d5 ♙b6 20.g3 h6
21.h4 ♙c7 22.♙c1

Note that White retains his two bishops.

22...♖e5

On 22...♙e5, there follows 23.♙d2, and White is ready to continue the advance of his kingside pawns.

23.♖d7 ♖e7 24.♖xe7 ♜xe7 25.♙f3
b6 26.♚e2 ♙d6 27.h5 ♜f8 28.g4

It was more accurate to start with 28.♙e4, intending g3-g4 on the next move. In reply, the most precise response is 28...♜g8!, transferring the knight to f6.

28...♚e8

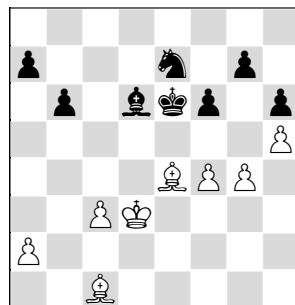
Black leaves the knight on e7, which is very passive. Another not very convincing line was 28...♜g8 29.♙c6 ♜f6 30.f3 ♚e7 31.♙d3 ♜d7 32.f4 – White retains pressure.

A strong, though not obvious, chance to get a draw was 28...f5! 29.g5 (29.gxf5 ♜xf5 30.♙e4 ♜e7 31.♙d3 ♜g8! 32.♙c4 ♜f6 33.♙g6 ♙c5 34.f3 ♚e7 35.a4 (35.♙b5 ♜d5=) 35...♙e6=) 29...hgx5 30.♙xg5 g6! (the number of pawns is reduced, and the draw comes closer) 31.♙d3 (31.♙xe7+ ♚xe7 32.hxg6 ♜f6=; 31.h6 ♜g8=) 31...♙c5 32.hxg6 ♜xg6 33.♚e2 ♙d6=.

29.♙e4 ♜d7 30.f4 f6

Black was doubtless very reluctant to put the pawn on the same colour square as his bishop, but otherwise he has to reckon constantly with the break g4-g5.

31.♙d3 ♚e6



32.♙f3!

White retreats the bishop, so as to be able to meet ...f6-f5 with g4-g5.

32...♙c5

Due to the weakness created by ...f7-f6 and the inability to exchange his knight for the light-squared bishop, Black is in a bad way:

A) 32...f5 33.g5 ♜d5?! 34.♙xd5+! ♚xd5 35.c4+ ♚e6 36.g6! ♙f8 37.♙b2 ♜d7 38.♙c3 ♚c6 39.a4 ♜d7 40.a5.

Later, White will exchange on b6, put his bishop on d4 and transfer his king to a4;

B) 32...♘d5 33.♙xd5+ ♖xd5 34.c4+ ♗e6 35.♗e4 ♙c5 36.♙b2 ♙b4 37.f5+ ♗d7 (37...♗d6 38.g5±) 38.♗d5 ♙c5 39.♙c3 – Black is in zugzwang.

33.♙d1!

The bishop goes to b3, from where it takes important squares away from Black.

33...♗d6

More tenacious is 33...f5, so that after 34.g5, the white king will not have the e4-square.

34.♙b3 b5

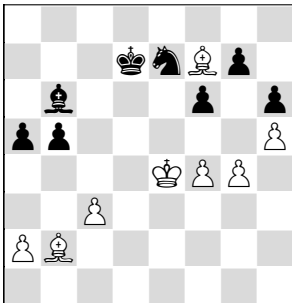
If Black marks time, White will carry out a plan such as this: 34...♗d7 35.♙b2 ♘c8 36.♙d5, followed by c3-c4. After this, he starts to threaten g4-g5.

35.♗e4 a5 36.♙d2 ♙b6 37.♙f7 ♗d7 38.♙c1 ♙c5

If the a3-square is left to the white bishop, play could develop along the following lines: 38...♘c8 39.♙g6 ♘e7 40.♙a3 ♙c7 41.♙c5 (Black is gradually ceding space) 41...♙d6 42.♙e8! ♗xe8 (42...♗c7 43.♙d4±) 43.♙xd6+–.

39.♙b2 ♙b6

39...♗d6 40.c4 bxc4 41.g5 f5+ 42.♗f3 ♘c6 43.♙xg7 ♘d4+ 44.♗g2 c3 45.♙b3+–.



40.♙a3

40.g5! fxg5 41.f5! is a more precise and more effective way to win.

40...♙c7

More stubborn is 40...♙f2! 41.♙b3 ♙e1 42.c4 bxc4 43.♙xc4 ♙b4 44.♙c1! (on 44.♙b2, there follows 44...♙d2!, preventing g4-g5) 44...♙c3 45.♙e3 ♙b4 46.♙b3 ♗d6, retaining chances of saving the game.

41.♙c5 ♙d6 42.♙e8+! ♗c7

43.♙d4

Black resigned.

175

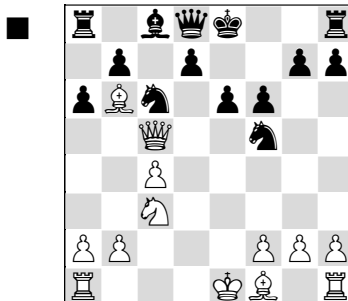
Vladimir Potkin

2671

Nils Grandelius

2536

Germany Bundesliga 2011/12 (8)



We have on the board quite a well-known theoretical position. Black has traded his dark-squared bishop, but has an extra pawn in return.

14...d6

A relatively rare continuation.

After the main line 14...♗e7 15.0-0-0 d6 16.♗a3 0-0 17.g4 ♘h6 18.♖g1, White's compensation is considered more than sufficient.

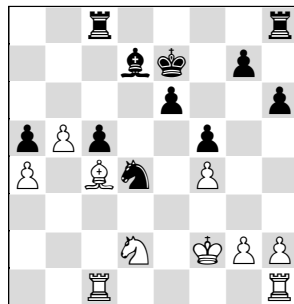
15.♙xd8! dxc5 16.♙b6 ♘e5

17.♙xc5 ♙d7 18.b4 a5!

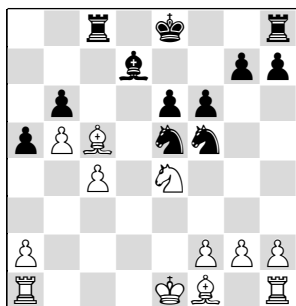
Bad is 18...0-0-0 19.♙b6 ♖de8 20.0-0-0 ♗e7 21.f4±.

And after 18...♖c6 19.f4 ♘d7 20.♕f2, White has a very strong tactical idea: 20...0-0 21.♕e2! ♕xg2 22.♖g1 ♕c6 23.b5 axb5 24.cxb5 ♕d5 25.♘xd5 exd5 26.♕g4 ♖fe8+ 27.♖f1 (suddenly, it turns out that the knight cannot be saved!) 27...g6 28.♕xf5+—.

19.b5 ♖c8 20.♘e4 b6



Counterblow



21.f4!?

Black had been counting on 21.♕xb6 ♘xc4 22.♕c5 ♕xb5 23.♖c1 ♘cd6! (23...♕c6 24.♕xc4 ♕xe4 25.♕xe6 ♖c6 26.♕b3±) 24.♕xb5+ ♘xb5 25.♖b1 ♘c3 26.♘xc3 ♖xc5 27.♖b8+ ♖f7 28.♖xh8 ♖xc3 29.0-0 ♖a3 30.♖xh7 (30.♖a1 h6 31.♖d8 e5) 30...♖xa2 31.♖h8 ♘d4∞, with definite compensation for the exchange.

21...♘xc4 22.♕xc4 bxc5 23.♖f2 ♖e7 24.a4!

White has lost the advantage of the two bishops, but has managed to break up the black queenside, and create weaknesses at a5 and c5. Despite Black's extra pawn, the position must be assessed as being in White's favour.

24...♘d4 25.♖ac1 f5 26.♘d2 h6

27.h4!

Not allowing counterplay with ...g7-g5. White can wait to go after the queenside pawns.

27...♖f6 28.♕a2 ♕e8 29.♘c4 ♕h5 30.♖he1 ♖hd8 31.♘xa5 ♖a8 32.♘b7 ♖xa4 33.♕xe6 ♘e2?

33...♘xe6! 34.♖xe6+ ♖xe6 35.♘xc5+ ♖e7 36.♘xa4 ♖d4 37.♘c3 ♖xf4+ 38.♖e3 ♖xh4 39.b6. The white passed pawn is terribly close to the promotion square, but there is the unexpected (especially from afar) 39...♘d8 40.♘b5 ♖e4+ 41.♖f2 ♖e7!, and Black has good chances of saving the game.

34.♕c4 ♖d2 35.♖xe2 ♕xe2 36.♕xe2 ♖aa2 37.♖e1 ♖db2 38.♘xc5 ♖xb5 39.♘d7+ ♖e7 40.♘e5 ♖f6 41.♖f1

He could also prevent Black exchanging a pair of rooks with 41.♖g3! ♖ba5 42.♖b1 ♖xe2? 43.♖b6+ ♖e7 44.♘c6+—.

41...♖ba5 42.h5 ♖a1 43.♖xa1 ♖xa1+ 44.♖f2

White's further plan is simple: to take f5. The bishop and knight together cope admirably with this task!

44...♖a2 45.♖f3 ♖a3+ 46.♕d3 ♖b3 47.g3 ♖a3 48.♖e3 ♖a2 49.♘d7+ ♖e7 50.♕xf5 ♖a3+ 51.♖f2 ♖b3

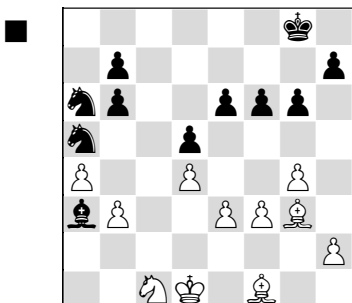
52. ♖e5 ♖a3 53. g4 ♖c3 54. ♗f3 ♖a3
 55. ♗g3 ♖c3 56. g5 hxg5 57. fxg5
 ♖c4 58. ♖e5 ♖a4 59. ♗g6+ ♗f7
 60. ♗f4 ♗g8 61. ♗g4 ♗h8 62. ♗d3
 ♖a5 63. ♗e4 ♖b5 64. ♗d5 ♖a5
 65. ♗f5 ♗h7 66. ♗e6 ♖a6+ 67. ♗f7
 ♖a7+ 68. ♗f8 ♖a6 69. h6 ♖a4
 70. ♗g8+ ♗h8 71. ♗g6#

176

Mikhail Botvinnik

David Bronstein

Moscow Wch match 1951 (23)



35... ♗xc1?!

A risky decision. Black gives up his precious bishop for the sake of a passive knight, which is tied to the defence of b3, whilst the pawn Black wins is not felt at all, since Black's doubled b-pawns cannot advance anyway.

He should simply have brought his king to the centre with 35... ♗f7, and on 36. ♗c2, he can play 36... ♖b4+ 37. ♗b1 ♖a6, driving the white king from the defence of the b3-pawn. White's advantage would be minimal.

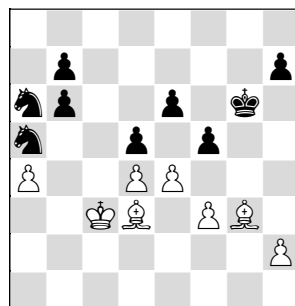
36. ♗xc1 ♖xb3+ 37. ♗c2 ♖a5
 38. ♗c3 ♗f7 39. e4 f5?!

An inaccuracy, because he creates additional pawn islands in his camp.

This is just what the side with the bishop pair needs to do – stretch the defender.

He should have preferred 39... dxe4 40. fxe4 ♗c6, retaining a compact pawn structure, and hopes of defending – Black has many pieces to fight against White's potential passed pawn on the d-file. The immediate 39... ♗c6 also looks better than Black's chosen path.

40. gxf5 gxf5 41. ♗d3 ♗g6



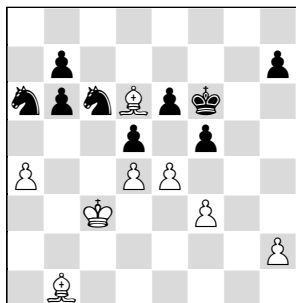
42. ♗d6

More accurate was 42. ♗b1!, setting up the possibility of attacking the d5-pawn from a2. 42... fxe4 (42... ♗c4 43. ♗f4 ♗f6 44. ♗a2; 42... ♗c6 43. exd5 exd5 44. ♗a2 ♖ab4 45. ♗b3) 43. fxe4 dxe4 44. ♗xe4+ ♗g7 45. ♗xb7 ♖xb7 46. ♗c4 ♗f7 47. ♗b5 ♖ac5 48. dxc5 ♖xc5 49. a5+–.

42... ♗c6 43. ♗b1 ♗f6

More tenacious was 43... ♖a7!, with the idea of exchanging queenside pawns with ...b6-b5. White would probably have repeated moves with 44. ♗d3 (if 44. ♗a2 b5, the bishop on d6 turns out to be badly placed, and vulnerable to a fork), and then after 44... ♗c6, would have chosen some move to maintain

the tension, such as 45.♔g3. In reply, Black should again opt for 45...♘a7!, so that if the bishop moves to a2 or b3, he is ready to play ...b6-b5.



44.♔g3!

With play on both flanks, bishops are much stronger than knights, and given the large number of potential targets in his position, Black's game is hard to defend.

44...fxe4

This opens extra space for the bishops, but it was already hard to suggest anything better.

In this position, the defensive plan ...b6-b5 no longer works: 44...♘a7 45.♔e5+ ♔g6 46.exf5+ exf5 47.♔a2 b5 48.♔xd5 bxa4 49.♔xb7 ♘b5+ 50.♔d3 ♘ac7 51.d5 – the central passed pawn decides the game.

45.fxe4 h6 46.♔f4 h5 47.exd5 exd5 48.h4 ♘ab8 49.♔g5+ ♔f7 50.♔f5 ♘a7 51.♔f4 ♘bc6 52.♔d3 ♘c8 53.♔e2 ♔g6 54.♔d3+ ♔f6 55.♔e2 ♔g6 56.♔f3 ♘b6

No better is 56...♘8e7 57.♔c7 ♘f5 58.♔xd5, and then ♔xb6 – the passed a-pawn promotes.

57.♔g5

Black resigned, because he is in zugzwang.

177

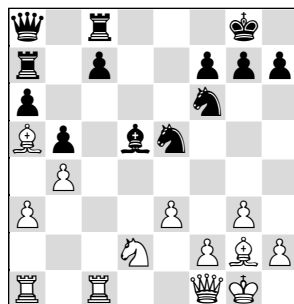
Vladimir Kramnik

Viswanathan Anand

Wijk aan Zee 2007 (6)

2766

2779



22.f3!

Retaining the advantage of the two bishops. White has no reason to make unnecessary exchanges. Clearly, the black pieces will be driven out of the centre by the white pawns.

22...♘c4?!

Other continuations also promise White some advantage:

A) 22...♘c6 23.e4 ♔e6 24.♖f2 ♘xa5 25.bxa5±;

B) 22...♔c4 23.♘xc4 ♘xc4 24.♖xc4 bxc4 25.♖xc4 c6 26.♔h3 ♔e8 27.e4±;

C) 22...♔e8 23.e4 ♔c4 24.♘xc4 ♘xc4 25.♖xc4! bxc4 26.♖xc4±.

23.♘xc4 ♔xc4 24.♖f2!±

There is not yet any need to sacrifice the exchange with 24.♖xc4 bxc4 25.♖xc4 ♖d5±.

White has a quieter way to strengthen his position.

24...♔e8 25.e4 c6

Black must sooner or later give freedom to the ♔a5, otherwise he remains with his rook on a7 out of play.

26.♖d1 ♖d7 27.♖xd7 ♘xd7 28.♖d1 ♖b7

Piece jumps do not improve his position: 28...♖e5 29.f4 ♘b3 30.♖b1 ♗d3 31.♗d4 ♘c2 32.♖f1±.

29.♗d6 f6 30.f4

The immediate queen centralisation was even stronger: 30.♗d4! ♗e5 (30...♗f8 31.♗c5 f5 32.♗xc6+–) 31.f4 ♗f7 (31...c5 32.bxc5) 32.♗d7±.

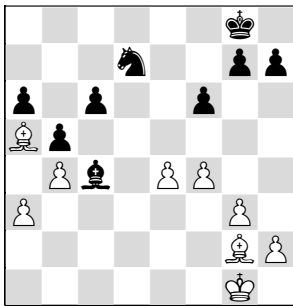
30...♗e6 31.♗d2 ♗e7 32.♗d4 ♗f8

33.♗d8 ♗d7

Going into a cheerless endgame.

It was possible to fight on with 33...♗f7!?. The chances of saving the game are obvious in the line 34.e5 (34.h4!±) 34...♗e6 35.♗b6 ♗xb6+ 36.♘xb6 fxe5 37.fxe5 ♘d5 38.♘xd5 cxd5 39.♖xd5 ♗g5!, with counterplay.

34.♗xd7 ♗xd7 35.♗xd7 ♗xd7



36.e5!

By opening the position immediately, White exploits the power of the ♗g2.

After 36.♘h3 ♗f8 37.♘c8 ♘d3 38.e5 fxe5 39.fxe5 ♗f7 40.♗f2 ♗e6 41.♗e3 ♘c4 42.♘xa6 ♗e7 43.♘c8 ♘d5, Black could set up a fortress, even a pawn down.

36...fxe5?!

White would still have to show a precise win in the variation 36...♘d5 37.♘h3 ♗f8 38.exf6 gxf6 39.♘c8 ♗f7 40.♘xa6 ♗e6 41.♘b6! (41.♘c8 ♗d4)

41...f5 42.♗f2 h5 43.♘c8 ♗e7 44.♗e3 ♘c4.

37.♘xc6 ♗f6

37...♗b8 38.♘b7 exf4 39.♘c7 ♗d7 40.♘xf4+–.

38.♘b7

38.fxe5? ♘d5=.

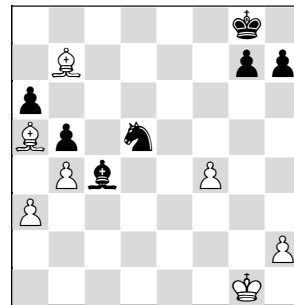
38...exf4

38...e4 39.♘b6! ♗d5 40.♘d4 e3 41.♘xa6 ♗f7 42.♗g2 (42.♘c8) 42...h5 43.♗f3 e2 44.♗f2 g6 45.♗e1+–.

39.gxf4

The game finally opens up. In such situations, the two bishops are especially strong.

39...♗d5



40.♗f2!

40.♘xa6 ♗xf4 41.♗f2 (41.a4 ♗e2+ 42.♗f2 ♗c3 43.axb5 ♗xb5=) 41...♗d5 is more difficult.

40...♗xf4?

The only way for Black not to lose at once was 40...♘b3! 41.♘xa6 ♘a4 42.♗f3 ♗c3 43.♗e3 ♗b1 44.♗d4 ♗xa3 45.♗c5 ♗f7±.

41.♗e3 g5

He also loses after 41...♗e2 42.♗d2! (42.♘xa6 ♗c3 43.♗d4 ♗a4±) 42...♗f7 (42...♗f4 43.♘xa6 ♗d5 44.a4) 43.♘xa6 ♗d4 44.♘b6! ♗f3+ 45.♗c3 ♗xh2 46.a4 ♗g4 (46...♗e6 47.a5; 46...h5 47.♘b7+–) 47.a5 ♗f6 48.♗d4+–.

42. ♖xa6 ♜f7

42...♞e2 43.♞d2 g4 44.a4 g3 45.hxg3
♞xg3 46.♞c7 ♞e4+ 47.♞c2 ♜f7
48.a5 ♞f6 49.♞c8+-.

43.a4 ♜e7

43...♜e6 44.♞xb5 ♞xb5 45.axb5 ♞d5
46.♞c7 ♞e6 47.b6 ♞c6 48.♜e4+-.

44.♞xb5 ♞xb5 45.axb5 ♞d7

46.♜e4 ♞e2

46...♞h3 47.♜f5 h5 48.♜g6 h4 49.♜f5
♞g1 50.♞b6 ♞f3 51.h3+-.

47.♞b6 g4

47...♞c3+ 48.♜f5.

48.♞f2 ♞c3+ 49.♜f5 ♞xb5

50.♜xg4

White has an extra outside passed pawn. The ending takes on a technical character.

50...♜e6

50...♞d6 51.♞g3 ♞e4 52.♜f5 ♞c3
53.♜g5+-.

51.♜g5 ♜f7 52.♜f5 ♜e7

52...♞c3 53.♞c5 ♞b5 54.♜e5 ♞a3
55.♜d6 h5 56.♜c6+-.

53.♞c5+

Black resigned.

178

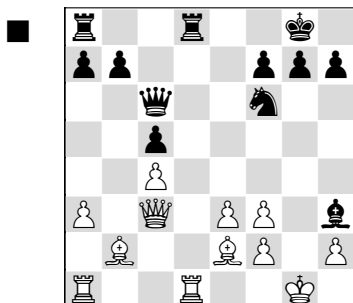
Alexander Khalifman

Vladimir Kramnik

Linares 2000 (1)

2655

2755



The pawn structure is relatively closed, so despite White's two

bishops, the position is double-edged. This example excellently illustrates the possibilities for playing against a pair of long-range bishops. White has a somewhat exposed king, and his bishop on e2 is passive. But the other white bishop exerts unpleasant pressure against g7. To neutralise the ♞b2, Black finds a timely regrouping manoeuvre, which allows him to reduce the bishop's power, and free the knight from defensive duties.

18...♞e8! 19.♞h1

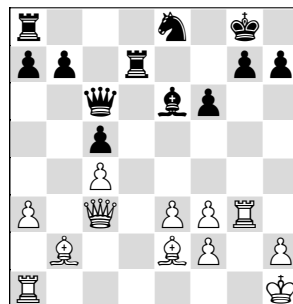
White cannot be happy with 19.♜e5?!
♜g6+ 20.♜g3 ♜c2 21.♜xh3 ♜xe2
22.♞xd8 ♞xd8+-.

19...♞e6 20.♞g1?!

White hopes for activity on the g-file, but as the later play shows, this is in vain.

It was worth considering direct play in the centre with 20.e4 ♞xd1+ (after 20...f6, Black has to reckon with the positional sacrifice 21.♞d5!? ♞xd5, 22.cxd5 ♜b6 23.♞g1 ♞ac8 24.f4 when White's activity compensates for his material deficit) 21.♞xd1 f6 22.♜e3 (22.♜d3 ♞f7 23.♜d7 (23.f4? ♞d6!) 23...♞c8 24.♜xc6 ♞xc6 25.♞d8 ♞d6=) 22...b6 23.e5 ♞f5∞.

20...f6 21.♞g3 ♞d7



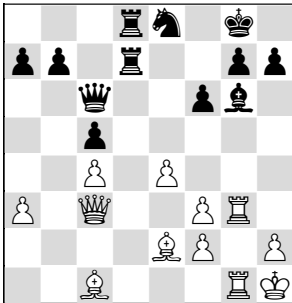
22. ♖ag1

White's pressure on the kingside is going nowhere, so his last move is completely unnecessary.

A) It was still not too late to exchange one rook, so as to reduce Black's activity down the d-file: 22. ♖d1 ♖ad8 23. ♖xd7 ♗xd7 24. ♕c1 ♗f7 25. ♖g1 ♘d6 26. ♖d1=;

B) But he does not equalise after 22. e4 ♖ad8 23. ♗e3 ♕f7 24. e5 ♕g6 25. ♖e1 fxe5 26. ♕xe5 ♘c7 27. ♕f1 ♘e6 28. ♕h3 ♖d1+.

22... ♖ad8 23. ♕c1 ♕f5 24. e4 ♕g6



Black blocks the g-file with his bishop. It becomes even harder to get at the g7-square.

25. h4

White can no longer afford to lose tempi: 25. ♕e3 ♘c7 26. h4 ♘e6 27. h5 ♘d4, and the black knight occupies the key square d4 in time, depriving White of any play: 28. ♕f1 ♕xh5+.

25... ♘c7 26. ♕f1

Pretty, but insufficient for equality, is 26. ♕h6 ♘e6! (the variation 26... gxf6 27. h5 ♘e6 28. hxf6 ♘f4, given by Kramnik, does not work, because of the refutation 29. gxf7+ ♗xh7 30. ♗e3! ♗d6 (the point is that Black cannot take on e2: 30... ♘xe2 31. ♗xh6+ ♗xh6 32. ♖h3#) 31. ♖g4

♘h5 32. ♖h4+–) 27. h5 ♕xh5 28. ♗xf6 ♕g6 29. ♖xg6 hxf6 30. ♖xg6 (now, Black can accurately extinguish White's activity. He has an extra rook in play, and White has a passive bishop on e2) 30... ♖f7! 31. ♗e5 ♗d6 32. ♗h5 ♗e7 33. ♖g2 ♖f6 34. ♖g4 ♗f7 35. ♗h4 ♖g6+.

26... ♘e6 27. ♖h3

The second possibility involves the activation of the bishop by 27. ♕h3, and looks more consequential. Black needs to react accurately.

Prophylaxis

analysis diagram

27... ♕h8!. The king moves away, not only from the potentially dangerous g-file, but also from checks on the a2-g8 diagonal. After the immediate 27... ♖d3, White maintains equality 28. ♗a5 a6 29. ♕e3 b6 30. ♕xe6+ ♗xe6 31. ♗xa6=. 28. ♕g4 (preparing h4-h5) 28... ♖d3 29. ♗a5 a6 30. ♕e3 b6. Now, White does not get to take on e6 with the knight, and after 31. ♗xa6 ♘c7, the queen is trapped.

27... ♕h5 28. ♖hg3

Acknowledging that White's kingside activity has run out of steam.

28... ♕h8 29. ♗e3 ♘d4

Once the knight appears on d4, it is all one-way traffic.

30. ♖g2 ♜e8

All of the white pieces are misplaced.

31. ♜h3 ♜a4 32. ♖f1 ♜d1 33. ♖g2 ♜c2 34. f4 ♘e2 35. ♜f1 ♜d1

White resigned.

179

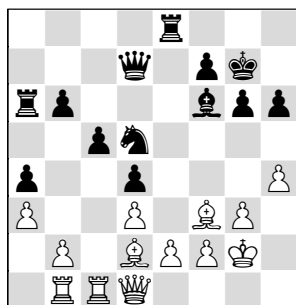
Magnus Carlsen

Sergey Karjakin

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (8)

2861

2780



White has the two bishops, but he is somewhat cramped. Chances are about equal. There is no point in a rapid b2-b3, which weakens c3, where the black knight can head. If there is no favourable way to open lines for the bishops, White must seek other ways to activate his pieces.

29. ♜h1!

Beginning a long series of manoeuvres. From the kingside, the queen begins to exert unpleasant pressure on the light squares. The possible exchange of queens favours White, as he can then play b2-b3, and the appearance of a knight on c3 is no longer dangerous. The rook just moves from c1, and the e2-pawn can be solidly defended by the king from f1.

29... ♖e7 30. ♖g1 ♜d8 31. ♜c2 ♜e6 32. ♜g2 ♜a7 33. ♜e1 ♜ad7 34. ♖h2 ♜c8?!

Allowing the exchange of queens, which he would have done better to avoid. He should have chosen 34... ♘f6, and if 35. ♜h3, then 35... ♜b3! 36. ♜ec1 ♖d6, continuing to manoeuvre.

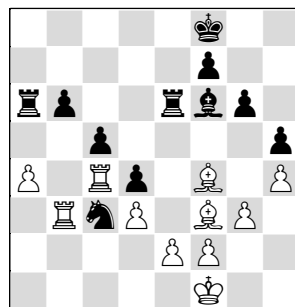
35. ♜h3 ♜xh3+

Continuing not to realise the potential dangers. He should have decided on 35... f5!, and after, for example, 36. g4 ♖d6+ 37. ♖h1 (37. ♖g2 ♘f4+ 38. ♖xf4 ♖xf4=) 37... f4 Black holds the balance, thanks to the idea of ... ♘d5-e3.

36. ♖xh3 h5 37. ♜b1 ♜a8 38. ♖g2 ♜a6 39. b3 axb3 40. ♜xb3 ♖f6 41. ♜c4 ♜d6 42. ♖f1 ♖f8 43. a4 ♘c3

By removing the knight from d5, Black makes it easier for White to play e2-e3. Therefore, the waiting move 43... ♖g7 was better.

44. ♖f4 ♜e6



45. e3!

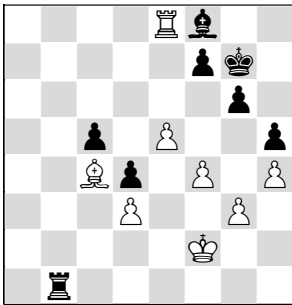
White had long been hoping to achieve this advance. Diagonals are opened, and the bishops come to life.

45... ♘xa4 46. ♖d5 ♜e7 47. ♖d6 b5?!

This regains the exchange, but the pawn structure changes in White's favour in the process. It was worth considering 47...♘c3!?

48.♙xe7+ ♜xe7 49.♞xb5 ♜b6 50.e4 Guaranteeing Black long suffering. Also promising was 50.exd4!? ♜xc4 51.dxc4, and on 51...cxd4, there follows 52.c5!±, and the passed c-pawn is very dangerous.

50...♜xc4 51.♞b8+ ♔g7 52.♙xc4 ♞a7 53.f4 ♙d6 54.♞e8 ♞b7 55.♞a8 ♙e7 56.♔g2 ♞b1 57.e5 ♞e1 58.♔f2 ♞b1 59.♞e8 ♙f8 60.♞c8 ♙e7 61.♞a8 ♞b2+ 62.♔f3 ♞b1 63.♙d5 ♞e1 64.♔f2 ♞d1 65.♞e8 ♙f8 66.♙c4 ♞b1



Thanks to the unfortunate position of the pawn on h4, White lacks

the standard idea of gaining space on his stronger wing with h2-h3, followed by g3-g4 and f4-f5. The last few manoeuvres have not brought White anything, so he decides on a storm.

67.g4! hxg4 68.h5 ♞h1?

He could save himself by a far-from-obvious switch to counterattack: 68...gxh5! 69.f5 h4! 70.f6+ ♔g6 71.♞xf8 ♔f5!±, with the idea of pushing the g-pawn.

69.hxg6 fxg6 70.♞e6 ♔h6 71.♙d5

The pawn on g6 is doomed, and after its unavoidable exchange for the undefended pawn on d3, White is guaranteed a great superiority in piece activity.

71...♞h2+ 72.♔g3 ♞h3+ 73.♔xg4 ♞xd3 74.f5 ♞e3 75.♞xg6+ ♔h7 76.♙g8+ ♔h8 77.♔f4 ♞c3

77...♞e1 78.♙c4 ♔h7 79.♞c6+-.

78.f6 d3 79.♔e3 c4 80.♙e6 ♔h7 81.♙f5 ♞c2 82.♞g2+ ♔h6 83.♞xc2 dxc2 84.♙xc2 ♔g5 85.♔d4 ♙a3 86.♔xc4 ♙b2 87.♔d5 ♔f4 88.f7 ♙a3 89.e6 ♔g5 90.♔c6 ♔f6 91.♔d7 ♔g7 92.e7

Black resigned.

Additional material

Botvinnik-Keres, The Hague/Moscow Wch (match-tournament/10) 1948 – White's 11th move

Alekhine-Fine, Kemer 1937

Kasparov-Karpov, Las Palmas 1996

Chapter 21

'Good' and 'bad' bishops

A 'bad' bishop is one that is obstructed by its own or the opponent's pawns, and that cannot be exchanged off for an equivalent enemy piece. A 'good' bishop, by contrast, usually controls a lot of squares at once or can attack the enemy's weaknesses.

Everyone knows the rule that operates in the majority of cases: «Do not put pawns on the same colour squares as your bishop!». In my observation, among young players, breaking this rule is the most common positional mistake. It always seems to them that, if they put their pawns on the same colour squares as their bishop, those pawns will be more securely protected. Of course, there are exceptions, when a so-called 'bad' bishop fulfils the function of defending its own pawns, but such cases are very rare.

180

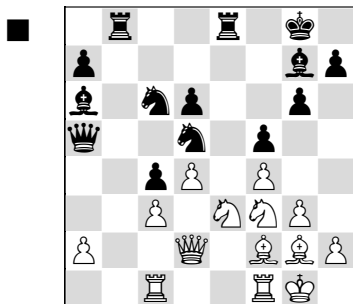
Alexander Krapivin

Artem Ilyin

Moscow 2008 (2)

2483

2548



White's pawns restrict his dark-squared bishop. The placement of some other pieces also has a strong influence on the assessment of the position. The bishop on g2 exerts strong pressure down the long diagonal, in contrast to Black's light-squared bishop, which is obstructed by the pawn on c4. This means that Black should try to exchange light-squared bishops. Black's major pieces are somewhat

more active, but the most important thing here is the position of his knights. The key squares in this structure are e4 and d5, where the knights are most comfortable. On c6, the knight is not only not on one of its desired squares, but it also prevents the exchange of light-squared bishops, so it is logical to transfer this knight elsewhere. Here, Black could secure the advantage by choosing the logical and natural

20...♘xe3

In the game, Black carried out the right idea in the wrong form, and, after 20...♘ce7 21.♙fe1 ♘xe3? 22.♙xe3!, came under a deadly pin on the e-file.

21.♙xe3 ♘e7! 22.♙f2

Sacrificing a pawn, so as to help get the dark-squared bishop into the game, does not help: 22.d5 ♙b7!, taking the pawn without any particular compensation.

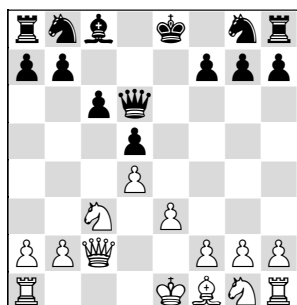
22...♙b7

Later, by transferring his bishop to e4 and his knight to d5, Black would force the exchange of light-squared bishops, after which the technical stage would begin, with White facing a depressing future.

181********Liviu-Dieter Nisipeanu** 2661**Konstantin Landa** 2641

Bad Wiessee 2012 (8)

**1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘e7 4.cxd5
exd5 5.♙f4 c6 6.♚c2 ♙d6 7.♙xd6
♚xd6 8.e3**



The bishop on c8 is relatively bad, and it is hard to see what useful work it can find, other than defending its own pawns. Therefore, if Black does not exchange it early on, he will struggle to equalise.

8...♘e7!? 9.♙d3 g6

Black sticks resolutely to his plan to exchange bishops. The price he pays is a slight weakening of the dark squares on the kingside and a slight delay in development. It frequently happens that strategic ideas are refuted by tactics. But, if one has not made a serious mistake, it is rare for a correct strategic idea to meet a clear refutation.

10.♘f3

A modest move.

A) More principled is 10.f3! 0-0 11.♘ge2 ♘f5 12.♙xf5 ♙xf5 13.e4 dxe4 14.fxe4 ♙g4, with a complicated battle;

B) After 10.♘ge2 ♙f5 11.0-0 0-0, Black has no problems;

C) The most promising may be 10.♚b3!? ♘d7 11.♘f3 0-0, and now 12.h3 ♘f6 13.g4, stopping the possible exchange of bishops once and for all.

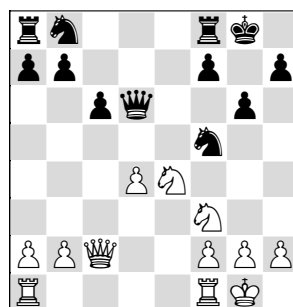
10...♙f5 11.♙xf5 ♘xf5 12.0-0

After 12.e4 dxe4 (12.♚xe4+ ♘f8 (also interesting is 12...♚e7!?) 13.0-0-0 ♘d7 14.d5 ♘f6 only looks dangerous for Black) 13.♘xe4, Black gives the standard check 13...♚b4+, with a good game.

Also insufficient is 12.0-0-0 ♘a6 (12...0-0!? 13.g4 ♘g7 14.h4!) 13.♙b1 0-0-0 (the king stands better on the queenside) 14.♘e5 ♚e6 15.♙a1 ♙b8 16.♘d3 ♚e7 17.♘a4 ♘d6 18.h4 h5 Jobava-Lputian, Yerevan tt 2008.

12...0-0 13.e4 dxe4 14.♘xe4

14.♚xe4 ♘d7 15.♚fe1 ♘f6 16.♚e5 ♚fe8.



14...♚f4!

An important nuance – Black is not afraid of a check on f6.

Black still has problems after 14...♘xd4?! 15.♘xd6 (15.♚c3? ♘e2+) 15...♘xc2 16.♚ad1 b6 17.a3 c5 18.♚c1

♖d8 19.♗b7 ♖d7 20.♗xc5 bxc5
21.♖xc2±.

15.d5

Other moves also fail to pose Black any problems:

A) 15.♖fe1 ♗d7 16.♖b3 ♗b6 17.a4
♖c7 18.♖ac1 ♖ac8 19.♗c5 a5;

B) 15.♗f6+ ♖g7.

15...♗d6!

This simplifying move completely equalises.

16.♗xd6

White can try to fight for an advantage after 16.♖fe1 ♗xe4 (16... cxd5 17.♗c3 ♖f5 18.♖d2 ♗c4 19.♖h6!? ♗d7 20.♖e7 ♗f6 21.h3±) 17.♖xe4, but after 17...♖d6! (17...♖f6 18.d6!? ♖xd6 19.♖d1 ♖f6 20.♗e5±) 18.dxc6 ♗xc6 19.♖d1 ♖f6 20.♖b3 ♖ae8, the position is equal.

16...♖xd6 17.♖b3 cxd5 18.♖xb7 ♗c6 19.♖ac1

Black can equalise in two ways, one being 19...♗b4.

19...♗e5

1/2-1/2

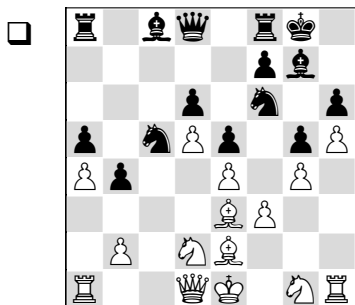
182

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Tigran Petrosian

Samuel Schweber

Stockholm izt 1962 (19)



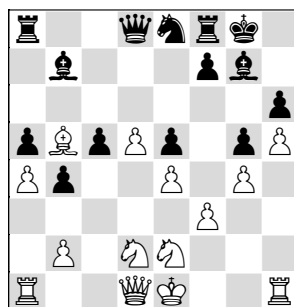
Black's greatest misfortune is the ♗g7, which does not have the slightest prospects. If it stood

somewhere like on a7, it would not be so easy for White to exploit his space advantage. In addition, the light squares c6 and b5 are seriously weakened in Black's camp, and White also has an outpost on f5. After the following move, another outpost appears at c4.

17.♗xc5! dxc5 18.♗b5!

White's last two moves are a typical device in the King's Indian. First Black is landed with additional weaknesses, and then White exchanges his light-squared bishop, which is hampered by his own pawns. In the process, the knight now gets the chance to come via g1-e2-g3-f5. It should also be noted that, if White had not already eliminated any possibility of effective counterplay on the dark squares, this plan would not have been so effective.

18...♗b7 19.♗e2 ♗e8



20.♗xe8!

The ♗g7 is little better than a big pawn, so White has a strategically winning position.

20...♖xe8 21.♗c4 ♗a6 22.♖b3
♖f6 23.♖c1 ♗f8 24.♗g3 ♗c8
25.0-0 ♖d8 26.♗g2 ♖a7 27.♖f2
♗h7 28.♖fc2 ♖a6 29.♗xe5 ♖c7
30.♗c4 ♗g7 31.♖d3 ♗g8 32.♖d2
♖e7 33.e5 ♗xe5 34.♗xe5 ♖xe5

35. ♖xa6 ♙xa6 36. ♖xc5 ♙c8
 37. ♖xa5 f5 38. gxf5 ♙xf5 39. ♗xf5
 ♖xf5 40. ♖b5 ♖df8 41. d6 ♖xb5
 42. axb5 ♙f7 43. d7 1-0

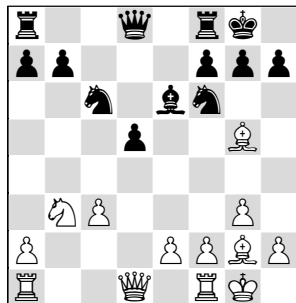
183

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Akiba Rubinstein

Frank Marshall

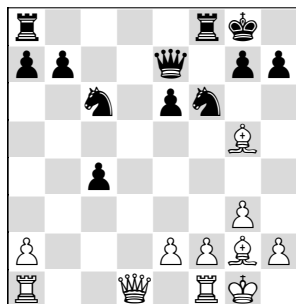
Breslau 1912 (16)



It seems that the ♙e6 is bad, but it supports the d5-pawn, which, in its turn, fixes a white weakness on c3. Therefore, White plays to exchange the bishop, after which his c-pawn gets the chance to act as a battering-ram, creating new objects of attack in Black's camp.

13. ♗c5! ♖e7 14. ♗xe6 fxe6 15. c4!
 After 15.e4 dxe4 16. ♙xe4 ♖c5 17. ♙xf6 ♖xf6, White's advantage is not so great, because he has a weak pawn on c3.

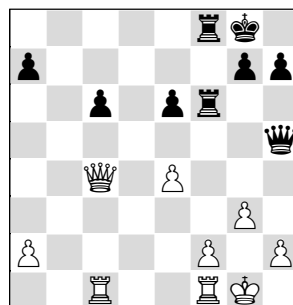
15...dxc4



16. ♙xc6!

It was possible to play 16. ♖a4, also regaining the c4-pawn, and retaining the bishop pair. However, White prefers to ensure himself a static advantage, because the weaknesses on e6 and c6 are chronic.

16...bxc6 17. ♖d4 ♖d8 18. ♙xf6
 ♖xf6 19. ♖xc4 ♖d5 20. ♖ac1 ♖af8
 21. e4 ♖h5



22.f4

White could also have preferred the less sharp way of increasing his advantage, with 22. ♖c2.

22...♖a5

The attempt to activate does not help Black's position: 22...g5 23. f5 ♖f7 24. g4 exf5 25. gxf5 – although Black can organise a blockade on e5 in the rook ending, this is of a temporary character only, since White will soon bring up his king to support the connected passed pawns.

23.e5 ♖h6

Here, the rook turns out to be out of play, and the outcome of the game is decided.

24. ♖c2 ♖b6+ 25. ♙g2 ♖d8 26. ♖ff2
 ♖c8 27. ♖fd2 ♙h8 28. ♖d6 ♖b8
 29. ♖xc6 ♖g8 30. ♖c8 ♖b7+ 31. ♙g1
 ♖b6+ 32. ♖c5 ♖xc5+ 33. ♖2xc5
 g5 34. ♖xg8+ ♙xg8 35. fxc5 ♖h5
 36. h4 h6 37. gxh6 ♖xh6 38. ♖c8+

♙g7 39.♖c7+ ♚g6 40.♖xa7 ♙f5
41.♖a5 ♖h8 42.♙g2

And White won.

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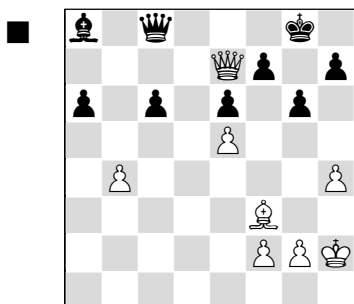
Anatoly Karpov

Joel Lautier

Biel 1992 (1)

2715

2580



Despite his pawn minus, White has the advantage and can play without any risk, principally because of the difference in activity of the two bishops. The black pawns fixed on light squares not only obstruct his bishop and serve as targets, but also allow the white king and queen great freedom of movement. Even so, there is some reserve of solidity in Black's position, and with good defence, he ought not to lose – a pawn is a pawn, after all.

30...h5?!

A serious mistake, since now in a possible bishop ending, White has the chance to play f2-f3 and g2-g4, creating an outside passed pawn on the h-file. In addition, the white king would have a path into g5.

He could instead have attacked the white central pawn with 30...♖b8!?, and left White to decide how to defend it. In such subtleties, there is always a chance of an inaccuracy.

The move 30...h6 looks positionally correct, with the idea of answering 31.h5 with 31...g5!, and then waiting with the queen on the eighth rank – the arrangement of the pawns on dark squares looks more harmonious, and it would not be easy for White to break through.

31.♙g3!

The king heads for f4, from where it will defend the e5-pawn. Later, it will become clear to which flank the king will go further.

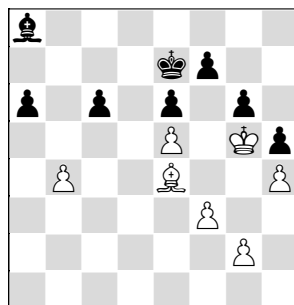
31...♖b7?

This mistake costs the game. It was essential to show patience, by playing, for example, 31...♖b8 32.♙f4 ♙g7. White will choose a suitable time to play g2-g4, but he still has a long way to go to win the game.

32.♖xb7!

The bishop ending turns out to be easily winning.

**32...♙xb7 33.♙f4 ♙f8 34.♙g5 ♙e7
35.♙e4 ♙a8 36.f3**



36...♙b7

On 36...c5, a sufficient line is 37.♙xa8 cxb4 38.♙c6 b3 39.♙a4 b2 40.♙c2+–, and then g2-g4.

**37.g4 ♙a8 38.gxh5 gxh5 39.f4
♙b7 40.♙f3 ♙a8 41.♙xh5**

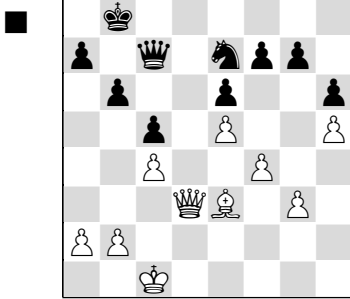
Black resigned.

185

Ljubomir Ljubojevic
Anatoly Karpov

Linares 1981 (5)

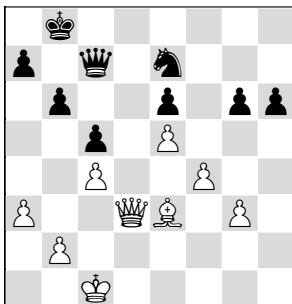
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White's bishop is hampered by its own pawns on g3-f4-e5, and Black starts play on the light squares:

28...g6! 29.hxg6 fxg6 30.a3

There were decent chances of saving the game with 30.g4 h5 31.f5!? (not 31.gxh5 gxh5 32.♖h7 ♜f5) 31...exf5 32.gxh5 gxh5 33.♙f4, sacrificing a pawn, but activating his bishop.



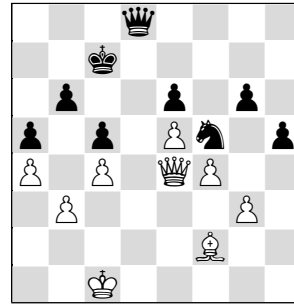
30...a5

This move is prophylaxis against possible counterplay on the queenside with b2-b4.

31.b3

Otherwise, there could follow ...a5-a4, and the pawn on c4 would be cut off.

31...h5 32.♖e4 ♜f5 33.♙f2 ♖d7 34.a4 ♜c7 35.♜c2 ♗d8 36.♜c1



36...g5

Black needs lines for a breakthrough.

37.fxg5 ♗xg5+ 38.♜c2 ♜e7 39.♗h7 ♜d7 40.♗e4 ♗f5 41.♗d3+ ♜c6 42.♗xf5 exf5 43.♙e3 ♜g6 44.e6 ♜d6 45.♙g5 ♜xe6 46.♜d3 f4!

Creating an outside passed pawn, which only the king can stop. However, in this case, the queenside pawns will be without a defender, and Black is able to win them, by exploiting some neat tactical nuances.

47.gxf4 ♜f5

If he begins with 47...h4 (in some databases, this is the move given as having been played, but this is most likely a mistake), White can save the game: 48.♜e4! h3 49.f5+ ♜d7 50.♜f3 ♜e5+ 51.♜g3 h2 52.♜g2 ♜f3 53.♙f6, with a draw.

48.♜e3

Nothing changes after 48.♙d8 h4 49.♜e3 h3 50.♜f2 ♜xf4 51.♜g3 ♜e2+ 52.♜xh3 ♜d4 53.♙xb6 ♜xb3.

48...h4 49.♜f3 h3 50.♜g3 ♜xf4 51.♙d8 ♜e2+ 52.♜xh3 ♜d4 53.♙xb6 ♜xb3 54.♙d8 ♜e4 55.♜g4 ♜d4 56.♜f4 ♜xc4 57.♜e4 ♜c3 58.♙f6+ ♜c2 59.♙e5 c4 60.♜e3 c3 61.♙f6 ♜c5 62.♜e2 ♜b3

White resigned.

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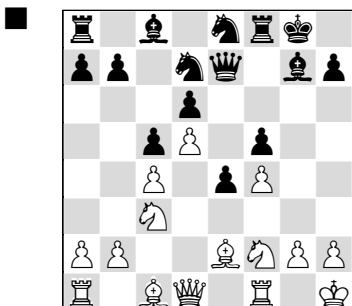
Jan Timman

Mikhail Tal

Tallinn 1973 (9)

2480

2625



The black bishop on g7 looks like the strongest piece on the board, which makes the decision taken by Black all the more paradoxical:

14...♖xc3!!

The basis of this strategic idea, which has become a classic, is as follows: apart from his dark-squared bishop, Black has no other active pieces, nor any active plan. White, meanwhile, has a long-winded but perfectly realisable plan: he will exchange dark-squared bishops down the long diagonal, put his knight on e3, and prepare the break g2-g4. The exchange on c3 puts the maximum difficulties in the way of this plan, because the pawn on c3 closes the long diagonal, and prevents White getting his bishop to that line.

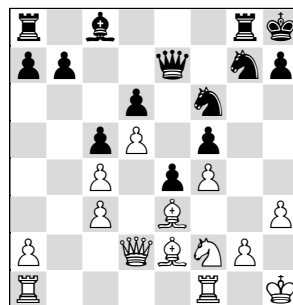
15.bxc3 ♜df6 16.♙e3 ♜h8 17.h3?

In this instance, this move is just an unnecessary weakening of the kingside. More solid is 17.♖d2 ♜g8 18.a4 ♙d7 19.a5 ♜d8 20.♜fb1 ♙c8, with rough equality.

17...♙g8 18.♖d2

18.♜g1 ♜g4

18...♜g7



19.♜d1

White should have prevented the immediate appearance of the knight on h5: 19.♖d1 ♙d7 20.♜b1 b6 21.♜g1 ♜af8 22.g3 ♙e8 23.♜g2, with a reasonable position.

19...♜gh5

Now, the weakening of g3 starts to tell.

20.♙xh5 ♜xh5 21.♙f2 ♙d7

22.♙e1 ♜af8 23.♜e3

White should have kept the knight on d1. Then, it would have been more difficult for Black to carry out the plan used in the game: 23.a4 ♜f6 24.a5 ♜h6 25.♜a2 ♜g3+ (25...♜g4 26.♜h2 ♜xf4 27.♜e3 ♜f6 28.♙g3∞) 26.♙xg3 ♜xg3, and only now 27.♜e3 ♜fg8 28.♜b2.

23...♜f6 24.♜h2 ♜h6

The pawn on f4 is hanging, and White does not manage to defend his kingside.

25.g3 ♜f6 26.♜g1 ♜fg6!

Another possibility was the immediate 26...♜xf4!? 27.gxf4 ♜xf4+ 28.♙g3 ♜h6 29.♙f2 f4 30.♜xg8+ ♜xg8 31.♜g1+ ♜f8 32.♜g4 ♙xg4 33.♜xg4 e3, with a decisive advantage.

27.♜g2 ♜xf4!

Black wins with a direct attack.

28.gxf4 ♜xf4+ 29.♜g1 ♜f3 30.♜f2

♜xh3 31.♜b1 f4 32.♜b2 f3

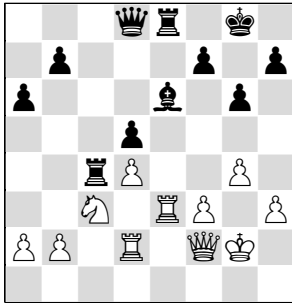
White resigned.

187

Mikhail Botvinnik

Tigran Petrosian

Moscow Wch match 1963 (14)



Black has a bad bishop, and White's strategy is directed towards exploiting this. He puts his pawns on light squares, to hamper the bishop further, and manoeuvres his pieces on the dark squares.

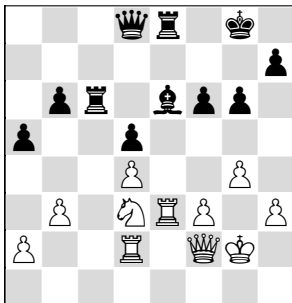
26.b3! ♖c6 27.♘a4 b6 28.♘b2!

The knight has been kept out of c5, so it manoeuvres round to d3, heading for f4 or e5.

28...a5

Having a light-squared bishop, Black puts his pawns on dark squares whenever he can. However, the d5-pawn will not be able to move, and unfortunately for Black, the move ...g6-g7 is against the rules.

29.♘d3 f6



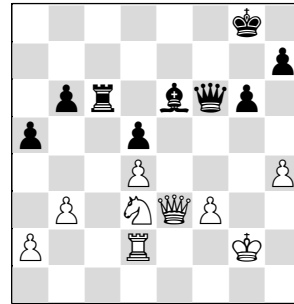
30.h4!

White gradually prepares g4-g5, after which the dark squares in Black's position will really start to creak. At the same time, it is important to keep the pawn on f3, so as not to give the enemy light-squared bishop any chance to develop activity.

30...♙f7 31.♞xe8+ ♙e8 32.♞e3 ♙f7 33.g5 ♙e6 34.♘f4 ♙f7

The 'active' square doesn't bring anything, as after 34...♙f5 35.gxf6 ♞xf6 36.♞e5 ♞d6 37.♞e2, Black's major pieces are tied to the defence of the d5-pawn.

35.♘d3 ♙e6 36.gxf6 ♞xf6



37.♞g5!

In transposing into an endgame, White wants his h4-pawn to move to g5, for additional pressure on the dark squares.

37...♞xg5+

A) 37...♞xd4? loses to 38.♘e5!;

B) After 37...♞g7, there follows 38.♘f4, and because of the threat of ♘f4-h5+, Black has to exchange.

38.hxg5

Now, the white king has a route into the centre, via ♔g2-g3-f4-e5.

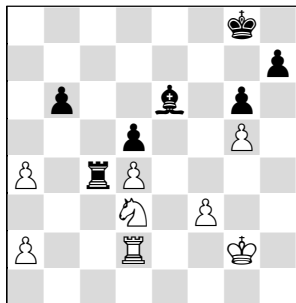
38...a4

This desperate attempt to get some activity brings no relief.

39.bxa4!

Less convincing is 39.♖e5 ♜c3 40.bxa4 ♜a3 – White is tied down to the defence of his pawns. And if he gives them up to activate his rook, the already relatively small amount of material on the board is further reduced, and Black's drawing chances are enhanced.

39...♜c4



40.a5!

White also gets the square c5 for his knight. But most importantly of all, Black loses the chance to attack two white pawns simultaneously with his rook, and White can easily cope with defending just one.

40...bxa5 41.♖c5 ♙f5 42.♙g3 a4 43.♙f4 a3

The square b2 is taken away from the white rook, but the outcome of the game is already decided by the activity of the king.

44.♙e5 ♜b4 45.♖d3!

Of course, White does not let the enemy rook into b2.

45...♜b5 46.♙d6 ♙f7 47.♙c6 ♙xd3 47...♜b8 48.♙xd5 ♙e6+ 49.♙c5 ♜c8+ 50.♙b4 would allow Black few chances of saving the game.

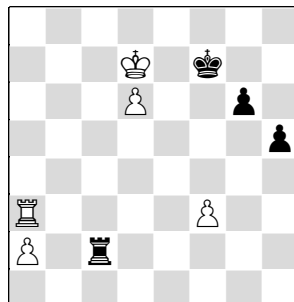
48.♜xd3 ♜b2 49.♜xa3 ♜g2

50.♙xd5

50.♜e3 ♜xa2 (50...♜xg5 51.a4 ♜g1 52.♜a3 ♙e6 53.a5 ♜c1+ 54.♙b6 ♜b1+

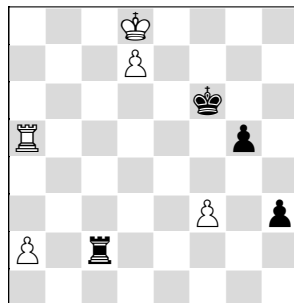
(54...♙d6 55.♜b3 ♜c6+ 56.♙b7 ♜c7+ 57.♙b8+–) 55.♙c7 ♜c1+ 56.♙d8+–) 51.♙xd5 ♜a5+ 52.♙c6 ♜xg5 53.d5 ♜g2 54.d6 ♜c2+ 55.♙b6 h5 56.d7 ♜d2 57.♙c7 ♜c2+ 58.♙d8 g5 59.♜e7+ ♙f6 (59...♙f8 60.♜e5+–) 60.♙e8 ♜d2 – like Black, White too has to give his rook for the passed pawn.

50...♜xg5+ 51.♙c6 h5 52.d5 ♜g2 53.d6 ♜c2+ 54.♙d7



54...h4?

The best chance was 54...g5!, when the winning line is not easy: 55.♜a5 (55.♙d8 h4 56.♜a7+ ♙g6 57.d7 h3 58.♜a6+ ♙f5! 59.♜h6 h2 60.a4 ♙f4 61.a5 ♜a2=) 55...♙f6 56.♙d8 h4 57.d7 h3.



analysis diagram

Now, the only way to win is the study-like 58.♜d5!! (58.♜a6+ ♙f5 (58...♙g7 59.♙e7+–) 59.♜h6 h2 60.a4 ♙f4 61.a5 ♜a2=) 58...♙f7

(on 58...h2, White’s idea works: h2 60.a4 ♖d2 61.♗h1 ♔e6 62.♗e1+ 59.♔e8!+–, and the d-pawn queens ♔f7 63.a5, etc.
with check (59.♗d1 ♗d2=) 59.♗d1 **55.f4 ♗f2 56.♔c8 ♗xf4 57.♗a7+ 1-0**

Additional material

Botvinnik-Reshevsky, The Hague/Moscow Wch (match-tournament) 1948

Bronstein-Petrosian, Amsterdam 1956

Winter-Capablanca, Hastings 1919

Chapter 22

Knight or bishop?

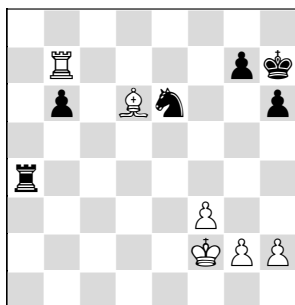
Although in the typical relatively static position, a bishop will usually be slightly stronger than a knight, the knight is generally the better piece in closed structures. Similarly, if a knight is battling a bishop, with a small number of its own or enemy pawns located in the same area. When combined with a queen, a knight is again frequently stronger than a bishop. The bishop needs space – an open centre, play on both wings, a dynamic structure. The knight, on the other hand, loves closed positions and more pawns in the centre of the board. It is also good if it has a secure outpost, from which it cannot be driven away – then, the knight is able to show its full strength.

188

Lev Polugaevsky

Ladislav Alster

Marianske Lazne 1959 (12)



The bishop is stronger than the knight. Given the material balance, this would normally be a draw, but in this position, the location of the pieces decides everything.

43. ♕e5!

Without rooks, Black's position would not be in the least bit worse, thanks to his outside passed pawn. Even if that pawn were lost, the position would be a draw, but as it is, White has spotted a clear weakness in the black position, namely the

*

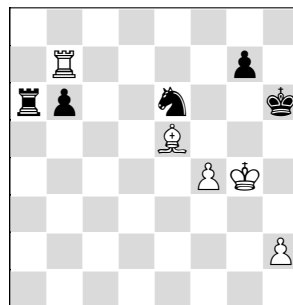
pawn on g7. The b6-pawn is of no significance at all at this moment!

43. ♖xb6 ♖a7±.

43... ♖g8?

A bad mistake, allowing White to win the g7-pawn. Nor is there any help from 43... ♖a6 44. ♖e7 b5 45. f4 ♖g6 46. g4, winning.

The correct defence was 43... ♖a2+! 44. ♖g3! (44. ♖f1 ♖a5 45. f4 ♖g8 46. g3 (46. ♖e7 ♖xf4!=) 46... g5 47. ♖e7 ♖c5∞) 44... ♖a6 45. f4 ♖g6 46. ♖h4! h5 47. g4 (47. h3 ♖f5 48. ♖f7+ ♖e4 49. ♖xh5 g5 50. f5 ♖xe5 51. fxe6 ♖xe6 52. ♖b7 ♖f5 53. g4+ ♖f6=) 47... hxg4 48. ♖xg4 ♖h6,

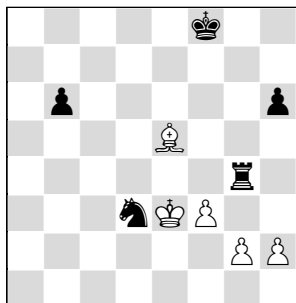


analysis diagram

and here White still has to find...

49.h4! (49.♙b2 ♖a2 50.♚xb6 ♜h7 51.h4 ♜d8=) 49...♜h7 50.♚e7 b5 51.♜f5+–.

44.♚e7 ♜f4 45.♚xg7+ ♜f8 46.♚g4 ♜d3+ 47.♜e3 ♚xg4



48.♙d6+

An important intermediate check.

48...♜f7 49.fxg4 ♜b2 50.♙e5 ♜a4 51.♙d4 ♜g6 52.h4 h5 53.g5 ♜f5 54.♜d3 b5 55.♜c2 b4 56.♜b3 1-0

189

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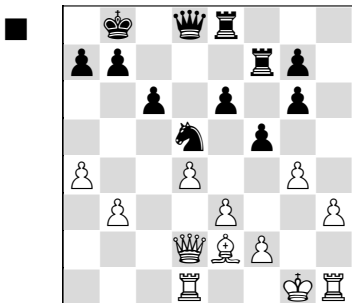
Sergey Shipov

2593

Konstantin Sakaev

2665

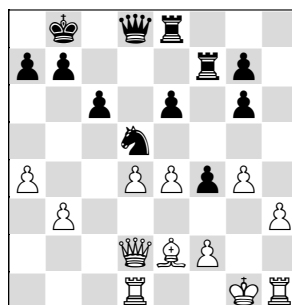
Russia tt 2004 (7)



White has a weak king, and his bishop is severely limited. Black has a clear advantage. But how can it be enhanced? It is important to gain space for one's pieces, without in the process opening up the light squares, and this aim is achieved with the help of a small tactic:

25...f4! 26.e4

Zwischenzug



The only move, because taking on f4 is even worse, and otherwise Black himself takes on e3, and exploits the open f-file for the attack.

26...f3!

With the help of this move, Black ensures his knight the wonderful square f4.

27.♙f1 ♜f4 28.♚e3 e5 29.♚xf3?

Now, Black obtains a central passed pawn, as well as additional squares and lines for the activation of his pieces.

It was essential to play 29.d5. In reply, Black has many promising possibilities, the most attractive of which look to be the activation of the rooks by 29...♚h8 or 29...♚ef8.

29...exd4 30.h4 ♚f6 31.a5 ♜h3+ 32.♚xh3 ♚xf3 33.♚xf3 ♚xf3 34.♚xd4 ♜c7!

The white pawns are not going anywhere. Taking away the entry square for the white rook is a more technical way of converting the advantage. The rest is simple – White cannot defend his scattered pawns.

35.b4 ♚f4 36.♙g2 ♚xg4 37.♜h2 ♚xh4+ 38.♜g3 g5 39.♚c4 ♚e5 40.f3 ♚h8 41.♙h3 g6 42.♙f1 ♚d8 43.♚c1 a6 44.♙c4 ♚d2 45.♙f7 ♚d6

46.♔g4 ♖f6 47.♙c4 ♜f4+ 48.♔g3
 ♜h4 49.♙f7 ♜h6 50.♔g4 ♘d6
 51.♙c4 ♙e7 52.♔g3 ♜h8 53.♙e2
 ♜d8 54.♜h1 ♙f6 55.♙c4 ♜d4
 56.♜c1 ♜d2 57.♜h1 ♔g7 58.♜b1
 ♜e7 59.♔g4 ♙f6 60.♔g3 ♜h7 0-1

190

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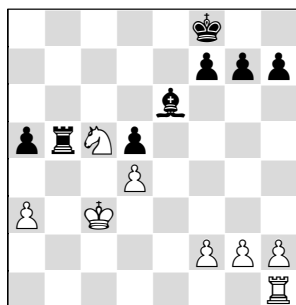
Konstantin Sakaev

2620

Ratmir Kholmov

2475

Moscow 1998 (4)



White has an undoubted advantage. His knight has the excellent square c5, whilst his king on c3 helps his army. By contrast, the black bishop is passive and shut in by the pawn on d5. But possessing a positional advantage is not the same thing as winning the game!

28.♘b3!

White finds a target in the black position – the pawn on a5.

28...♙e7 29.♜a1

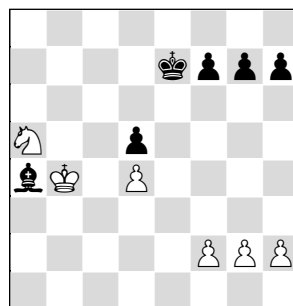
The point of his idea. The intended a3-a4 will decide the fate of the black a-pawn.

White's idea does not work in the other move-order: 29.a4? ♜b4 30.♜a1 ♜c4+ 31.♙b2 ♙d7=.

29...♙d6?

Black should have sought salvation in a minor piece endgame: 29...♙d7!

30.a4 ♜b4 (there is no help from 30...♜b8 31.♘xa5 ♜c8+ 32.♙b3 ♜b8+ 33.♙a3 ♜a8 34.♙b4 ♜b8+ 35.♙c5+–) 31.♘xa5 ♜xa4 (eliminating the main enemy, the outside passed pawn) 32.♜xa4 ♙xa4 33.♙b4.



analysis diagram

Of course, it is hard to enter such an endgame from a distance, and accurate calculation is required: 33...♙c2! (the aim of this bishop manoeuvre is to weaken the white kingside pawns) 34.♙c5 ♙e6 35.♘b7 ♙e4! (35...f6 36.♘d6 ♙a4 37.♘b5+–) 36.f3 (36.g3 g5 37.♘d6 ♙f3 38.♘b5 ♙d7 39.♘c3 ♙e6=) 36...♙d3! (Black should start counterplay before his d5-pawn falls) 37.♘d6 (after 37.♙c6 ♙f1 38.♘c5 ♙e7 39.g3 ♙c4, there is no win) 37...♙f1 38.g3 g5! 39.♘e8 ♙g2 40.♘c7 (40.f4 gxf4 41.gxf4 ♙f5=) 40...♙d7 41.♘xd5 ♙xf3 42.♘e3 f6 43.d5 h5 44.h4 gxh4 45.gxh4 ♙e2, and Black holds the position.

30.a4+– ♜b7 31.♘xa5 ♜c7+ 32.♙d2 ♙d7 33.♘b3 ♜c4 34.a5 ♙c6

34...♙a4 35.a6+–.

35.a6 ♜b4 36.♘a5! ♙a8 37.♙c3 ♜b8 38.♘b3 ♜e8 39.♙d2 ♜b8 40.♙c3 ♜e8 41.♙d3 ♙c7 42.♘c5 ♙b6 43.♜b1 ♙a7 44.♙d2 ♙c6 45.♜b3 ♜e7 46.♜e3 ♜c7

After 46...♖xe3 47.♔xe3 g6, the white king breaks through to the white pawns: 48.♔f4 f6 49.g4 h6 50.h4+-.

47...g3!

Forcing a further weakening.

47...g6

Now, the square f6 is weakened, whilst after 47...f6, White wins with 48.♗e6.

48.♖b3 h5 49.h4 ♖e7 50.♖e3 ♖c7

51.♔c3 ♗b5 52.♔b4! ♔b6

52...♗f1 53.g3+-.

52...♗xa6 53.♖a3+-.

53.♖f3 ♗c6 54.♖f6 ♔a7 55.♔a5

♗a8 56.♔b5 ♔b8 57.♖d6 ♔c8

58.♗a4 ♖e7 59.♗b6 ♔c7 60.♖f6

♔b8 61.g3 ♖e2 62.♗xa8 ♔xa8

63.♖xf7

Black resigned.

191

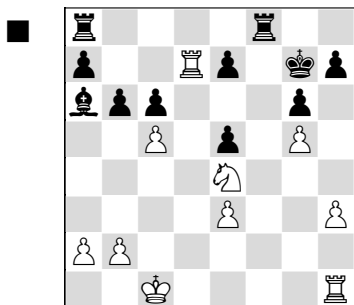
Alexander Ipatov

Arkadij Naiditsch

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (7)

2587

2708



The white pieces are actively placed, with the knight occupying a dominating position in the centre of the board, but even so, one can only speak of a black advantage. Firstly, although not the most wonderful-looking one, the e7-pawn is an extra pawn, and defends the d6- and f6-squares against an entry by the

white knight. Secondly, the knight is on the same colour square as the bishop, which means that it can be driven from its central outpost, and with tempo. Thirdly, the play is going on on both flanks, enabling the bishop to show its best side.

23...♖f7 24.b3

Not allowing the bishop to c4 and then d5.

24...♔f8!

Black should try to exchange rooks, so as to reduce the activity of the white pieces.

25.h4 ♔e8 26.♖d2

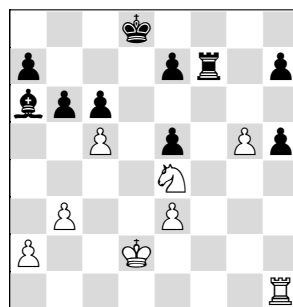
After 26.♖hd1, Black achieves his aim by means of 26...♖f1! 27.♖xf1 ♗xf1 28.♖c7 ♔d8 29.cxb6 axb6 30.♖xc6 ♗g2 31.♖c4 ♖xa2+.

No better is 26.♖c7 ♗d3! 27.♗d2 ♔d8 28.cxb6 (he has to open the a-file, otherwise the rook on c6 dies) 28...axb6 29.♖xc6 ♖xa2, with a winning position.

26...♖d8 27.h5 gxh5 28.♖xd8+

After 28.♖xh5 ♗d3 29.cxb6 axb6 30.♖h4 ♖f1 31.♔b2 ♗xe4 32.♖xd8+ ♔xd8 33.♖xe4 ♖f5, Black retains the advantage.

28...♔xd8 29.♔d2



29...♗c8!

The bishop becomes active, and Black's advantage becomes obvious.

30.cxb6 axb6 31.♖xh5 ♕f5 32.♗f2
 ♕g6 33.♞h2 ♖d7 34.♗e2 ♜f5
 35.♗e4 c5 36.a3 ♖c6 37.♞f2 ♞xf2+
 38.♗xf2 ♕f7!

Forcing a decisive weakening of the queenside.

39.b4 cxb4 40.axb4 ♖b5 41.♖d2
 ♖xb4 42.♗d3+ ♖b3 43.♗xe5 ♕e8

The bishop 'dominates' the knight, and the b-pawn is ready to advance.

44.♗f3 ♖c4 45.♗d4 e5 46.♗f5 ♕g6
 47.e4 b5 48.♗d6+ ♖d4 49.♗xb5
 ♖xe4 50.♗d6+ ♖f4 51.♗c4 ♕f7
 52.♗d6 ♕d5 53.♗b5 ♖xg5 54.♖e3
 ♖g4 55.♗c3 ♕f3 56.♗a4 h5
 57.♗c5 ♖g3 58.♗d7 e4

White resigned.

192

Konstantin Sakaev

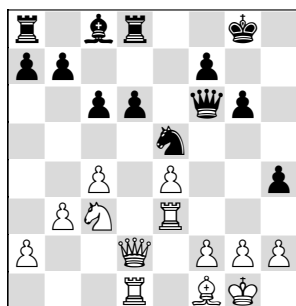
Peter Svidler

St Petersburg 1997 (5)

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2580

2640



Black's only, but very strong, trump is the beautiful knight on e5, and White must constantly beware of possible jumps to g4. But if he plays the tempting move 18.h3, it will become unrealistic ever to win the battle for the kingside dark squares, as Black will at some moment play ...g6-g5, and f2-f4 will be impossible.

The pawn is needed on h2, not h3. Therefore, there followed

18.♕e2! ♕e6

On 18...g5, there would follow 19.c5, winning d6, regaining which would be difficult.

19.g3!

The point of White's play, he threatens f2-f4.

After the direct 19.♞f1, Black would reply 19...g5, and would have no problems.

19...♗g4

The move g2-g3 weakened the light squares, and Black hopes to exploit this, inviting White to part with his bishop.

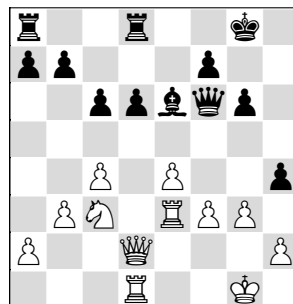
White's idea is revealed in the variation 19...hxg3 20.♞xg3!, and the f-pawn comes into play with great effect.

After 19...♖g7 20.f4 ♗g4 21.♞d3 hxg3 22.♞xg3 (22.hxg3 is also good, but I did not want to allow even an illusion of counterplay on the h-file) 22...♞h4 23.♕xg4 ♕xg4 24.♞f1 – the white pieces are active and he has the advantage.

20.♕xg4!

Exchanging the bishop, but correcting his pawn structure – the light squares will not be weak!

20...♕xg4 21.f3 ♕e6



22.g4!

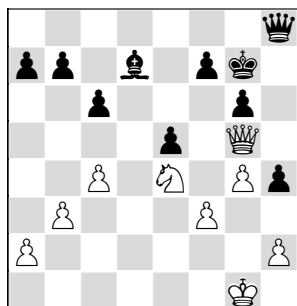
This move is very, very important – the ♕e6 is restricted to the greatest possible extent.

22...♗d7 23.♗d3 ♗ad8 24.♖h6

It turns out that Black's h4-pawn is cut off, and its defence causes problems.

24...a6

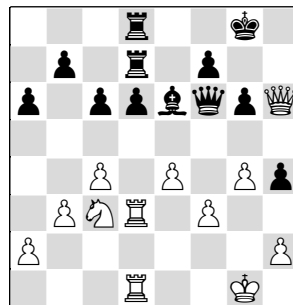
The attempt to cover the kingside dark squares does not work, as on 24...♖h8, there follows 25.♗g5! ♖g7 (with the idea of ...♖h8-h6 – otherwise the knight transfer via e3 to f4 is unpleasant) 26.e5! (but now, the knight comes into the attack with decisive effect) 26...dxe5 (26...d5 27.cxd5 cxd5 28.f4 ♖h6 29.♗f6+ ♖h7 30.h3 – Black is completely paralysed) 27.♗xd7 ♗xd7 28.♗xd7 ♕xd7 29.♗e4.



analysis diagram

This position demonstrates especially clearly the possible difference in strength of the minor pieces – the black bishop is very limited, whilst the white knight rules the roost, controlling many important squares, and is ready to jump to various spots. 29...♖e8 30.♖f6+ ♖g8 31.♖xh4 ♖g7 32.♖f6+ ♖g8 33.h4 ♖e6 34.♖d8+ ♖g7 35.g5! – and by

ensuring his pieces the square f6, White wins.

**25.g5 ♖f4**

Even so, there were more defensive chances from 25...♖h8 26.♖xh8+ ♖xh8 27.♗a4 (blockading the queenside with 27.a4 is less strong, because of 27...♖g7, followed by ...f7-f6) 27...b5 28.♗b6 bxc4 (completely bad is 28...♗b7 29.c5 d5 30.exd5 – the ♗b7 remains stuck) 29.bxc4 (White also retains winning chances in the rook ending after 29.♗c3!? ♗b7 30.♗xc4 ♕xc4 31.♗xc4±) 29...♗b7 30.c5 d5 31.♖f2. White's plan is to exchange on d5, after which his knight comes to d4, supporting the newly-created passed pawn on c5.

26.♗e2 ♖e5 27.♖xh4 d5

On 27...b5, the most precise winning path is 28.f4, forcing transition into an ending (28.cxb5 axb5 29.♗d4± is also possible, but with queens on, Black has greater practical chances) 28...♖h8 29.♖xh8+ ♖xh8 30.cxb5 axb5 31.♗d4 ♕g4 32.♗d2, with a technically winning position.

28.♖f4! ♖xf4

A) 28...♖b2 is a shot in the air, owing to 29.♗d2+–;

B) 28...♖g7.

29.♗xf4 dxe4

29...dxc4 30.♖xd7 ♖xd7 31.♖xd7
♙xd7 32.bxc4 b5 33.♙f2+–.

**30.♖xd7 ♙xd7 31.fxe4 ♙f8 32.e5
♙e7 33.e6!**

Black resigned, because of 33...♙xe6
34.♖xd8 ♙xd8 35.♗xe6+ fxe6 36.c5+–.

193

Vassily Ivanchuk

Garry Kasparov

Linares 1991 (1)

2695

2800

1.e4 c5 2.♗f3 d6 3.♙b5+ ♗d7

This interposition by the knight is usually played to avoid too many exchanges, and to complicate the game as far as possible. However, thanks to his rapid development and greater space, White still obtains a pleasant game.

4.d4 ♗g6 5.0-0 cxd4 6.♖xd4 a6

Securing the bishop pair, but in doing so using precious time, during which White manages to place his pieces and pawns optimally.

If Black tries first to complete the development of his kingside with 6...g6, then after 7.e5, he has to neutralise White's slight pressure on the opened d-file. In other words, Black has to go over to fighting for equality, which is not why he placed his knight on d7 at move 3.

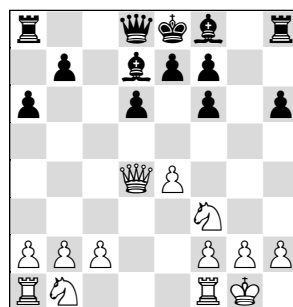
7.♙xd7+ ♙xd7 8.♙g5

With this move, White prevents Black playing ...e7-e5 with tempo, and then ...h7-h6, securing the knight against ♙g5, and continuing the battle for the key square d5.

8...h6

It is hard to describe 8...e6 as more solid, since after 9.♗bd2 ♖c8 10.♖fd1± the threats of ♗d2-c4 and e4-e5 are quite unpleasant.

9.♙xf6 gx6



Thus, Black has two bishops, but White has a space advantage, and the position is relatively closed, so the knights are preferable to the bishops.

10.c4!

A strong positional decision – White continues to seize space.

10...e6

If the queen is transferred to the kingside to attack, White quickly starts pressing on the queenside weaknesses: 10...♖a5 11.♗c3 ♖h5 12.♗d5, and now the move 12...♖g8 is met by 13.♗c7+! ♗d8 14.♗xa8 ♖xg2+ 15.♙h1! ♖xf3 16.♖b6+ ♙e8 17.♗c7+ ♗d8 18.♗e6+ ♙e8 19.♖d8#.

The attempt to open the position quickly and bring the bishops to life is risky: 10...♖g8 11.♗c3 f5 12.exf5 ♙xf5 13.♗d5 – the king is stuck in the centre, and White's initiative on the central files is very dangerous.

11.♗c3 ♖c8 12.♙h1

The king moves off the g-file in advance, and at the same time leaves the a7-g1 diagonal, preparing the advance of the f-pawn.

12...h5 13.a4!

Simultaneously gaining space and prophylaxis against ...b7-b5.

13...h4 14.h3!

Of course, Black should not be permitted to play ...h4-h3, which would potentially weaken the long diagonal.

14...♙e7 15.b4 a5 16.b5

Now, Black's only chance to activate his light-squared bishop is to play ...b7-b6, and transfer the bishop via c8 to b7. But this requires a lot of time.

16...♙c7 17.♘d2 ♙c5 18.♙d3

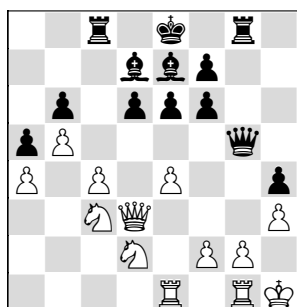
The exchange of queens by 18.♙xc5 was safe for Black – in this case, his king is comfortable in the centre. Black could recapture on c5 with either the pawn or the rook.

18...♙g8 19.♞ae1

Strengthening the position in the centre is useful in itself, and White also prepares in advance against any possible activation by Black with the move ...f6-f5.

19...♙g5 20.♙g1 ♙f4

If he carries out the plan of transferring the bishop to b7 with 20...b6, White has a pleasant choice.

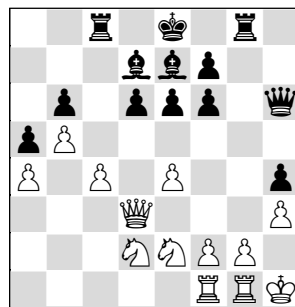


analysis diagram

The strongest line is the powerful blow 21.e5! (21.♘b3 ♞c7 22.g4!, gradually preparing f2-f4; also good is 21.♘f1, placing the knight on e3) 21...dxe5 22.♘de4 ♙f4 23.♞d1 ♞d8 24.♘e2 ♙f5

(24...♙h6 25.♘d6+ ♙f8 26.♘b7+–) 25.♙e3!+–. The threat is the simple ♘e4-d6+, immediately or after the preliminary ♘e2-c3 – Black's queenside is broken, and he has no counterplay on the kingside.

21.♞ef1 b6 22.♘e2 ♙h6



23.c5!?

An interesting positional pawn sacrifice, ensuring White an excellent square on c4 for his knight. However, this sharp decision was not obligatory, as there is also the quiet and strong continuation 23.f4, with the idea of putting his knight on d4 and playing f4-f5 – the weakness on e6 is notable.

23...♞xc5?

Black did not want to close the c-file for his rooks, but this was essential. 23...dxc5! 24.♘c4 ♞b8 25.f4 ♙c8 26.f5 leads to a position with the initiative for White, but Black would have counterplay.

24.♘c4 ♙f8 25.♘xb6 ♙e8 26.f4 f5

Otherwise, White himself plays f4-f5.

27.exf5 ♞xf5 28.♞c1!

The rook is ready to penetrate to the eighth rank with decisive effect. Black's position is lost, since his bishops cannot get any working space.

28...♟g7 29.g4

White also wins with 29.♘c8 ♜d5 30.♞b3+–, and the passed b-pawn advances.

29...♜c5 30.♞xc5 dxc5 31.♘c8 ♙f8
32.♞d8 ♞g6 33.f5 ♞h6 34.g5 ♞h5
35.♞g4 exf5 36.♘f4 ♞h8 37.♞f6+
♟h7 38.♞xh4+

Black resigned.

194

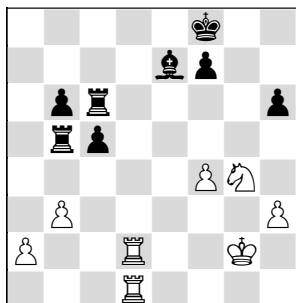
Vladimir Kramnik

Magnus Carlsen

Bilbao 2010 (1)

2780

2826



In an endgame with play on both flanks, a bishop is usually stronger than a knight, but when there are possible threats against the king,

the combination of rook and knight is frequently more dangerous than rook and bishop. In this example, Black has a misplaced rook, and White manages to create serious threats against the enemy king.

34.♘e5! ♞e6 35.♟f3 ♞a5?

35...♞b4 36.♞d7 (he cannot play by analogy with the game 36.♞g2 ♙f6 37.♘d7+ ♟e7 38.f5 ♞ee4 – Black has good squares on the e-file) 36...b5. This allows him to create counterplay and chances of saving the game, e.g., 37.♞b7 ♙d6! 38.♞xf7+ ♟e8 39.♞f5 ♙xe5 40.♞xe5+ ♞xe5 41.fxe5 c4.

36.♞g2! f6

A) 36...♞a8 37.♘d7+ ♟e8 38.♞g8+–;

B) 36...♙f6 37.♘d7+ ♟e7 38.f5+–.

37.♘c4 ♞a7

37...♞a8 38.f5 ♞c6 39.♞dg1 ♟e8 40.♞g8+ ♙f8 41.a4!, and Black is defenceless: 41...♞d8 (41...♟f7 42.♞h8) 42.♞1g7 ♞d3+ 43.♟e2 ♞xb3 44.♞b7+–.

38.f5 ♞c6 39.a4 ♞b7 40.♞g6 h5

41.♞dg1 ♟e8 42.♘e5 ♞c8 43.♞g8

♙f8 44.♘g6 ♞f7 45.♞d1 1-0

Additional material

Alekhine-Vaidya, Portsmouth 1923

Kasparov-Karpov, Leningrad Wch (match/14) 1986 – White's 24th move

Kasparov-Miles, Dubai 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, Leningrad Wch (match/22) 1986

Kasparov-Karpov, Seville Wch (match/16) 1987

Chapter 23

Opposite-coloured bishops

Like parallel lines, the actions of opposite-coloured bishops never cross one another! In both the middlegame and endgame, the presence of major pieces means that an attack on the king can be especially effective, because the attacking player can concentrate on squares controlled by his own bishop, effectively giving himself an extra piece. In the endgame, where there are no dynamics, opposite-coloured bishops usually exacerbate drawing tendencies, as passed pawns are unable to cross squares controlled by the enemy bishop. This is the reason for those well-known cases where even a large superiority in pawns is not enough to win an opposite-coloured bishop endgame.

195

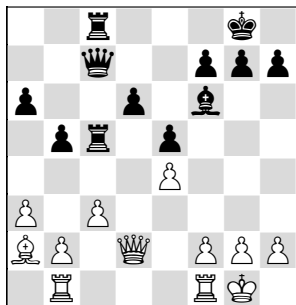
Konstantin Landa

Lubomir Ftacnik

Germany Bundesliga 2005/06 (8)

2597

2606



We have an opposite-coloured bishop position that is typical of various Sicilian lines. Black's bishop is useless, but White's can occupy the key square d5. The difference between the two bishops is obvious, and in many cases, this is enough to decide the game.

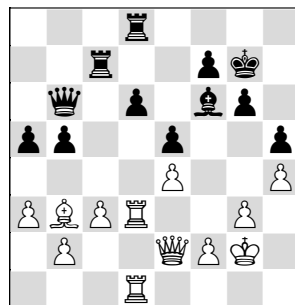
22.♖bd1 ♜d8 23.♙d5 h6 24.♚e2 g6 25.♞d3 ♚a7 26.g3!

The correct set-up for the pawns, aiming to restrict the black bishop's scope, is f2-g3-h4.

26...♙g7 27.♞fd1 ♜c7 28.♙g2 ♚b6 29.♙b3 a5 30.h4

The unpleasant threat of h4-h5, breaking up his kingside, hangs over Black. His reaction is predictable.

30...h5



It is well-known that the presence of opposite-coloured bishops enhances the attack.

31.g4!

The white pieces quickly break through to the enemy king.

31...hxc4 32.♚xc4 ♜c6 33.h5 ♜d7 34.♚g3 ♚e7 35.♞f3?

Mutual time-trouble starts to affect the players. White could win at once with 35.hxc6! fxc6 36.♚g4

♖h8 (36...♙g5 37.♖g3+-; 36...♙d7 37.♙e6+-; 36...a4 37.♙a2) 37.♖xd6 ♖h4 38.♖g3 ♖h5 39.♖f3+-.

35...♙h4 36.h6+

36.♖g4 ♖g5 37.♙h3 fails to 37...♖h8!

36...♙h7

36...♙xh6? 37.♖h1 g5 38.♖xf7+-.

37.♖g4 ♖g5?

After 37...♙f6 38.♖h1 ♖cd7 39.♖hh3 ♖a7 40.♙d5, White has only a small advantage.

38.♙h3! ♖xg4+ 39.♙xg4 g5 40.♖f6!

Black cannot defend all his weaknesses.

40...b4 41.cxb4 axb4 42.♙xf7 bxa3

43.bxa3 ♖c2 44.♙e6 ♙xf2 45.♖b1

Black resigned.

196

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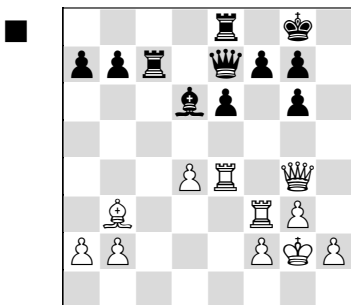
Sergey Tiviakov

2655

Robin van Kampen

2581

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (9)



29...g5?

Black fails to sense the danger. In positions with opposite-coloured bishops, there are sharply increased tactical chances involving the exploitation of the diagonals.

But even after the correct 29...♙d8 30.h4!±, White retains pressure, thanks to the more active position of his major pieces.

30.♖xf7!!

An unexpected blow.

30...♖xf7

30...♙xf7 31.♖xe6 ♖xe6 32.♖f5+-.

31.♖xe6

It turns out that Black has no satisfactory defence.

31...♙e7 32.♖e3

The computer's 32.♖e4 also wins.

32...♖c4 33.♖d7 b5 34.♖xb5 ♖ec8

35.♙xc4 ♖xc4 36.♖xe7 1-0

197

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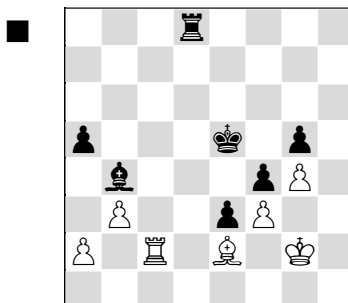
Boris Alterman

2595

Anatoly Karpov

2775

Tyniste tt 1995 (3)



45...♖d2! 46.♖xd2 exd2

When there are no other pieces on the board, to assess the ending correctly, one must understand which squares the defender's bishop will occupy. In this case, because of the blocked-in white king, his bishop lacks enough space in which to operate, and both queenside pawns are lost.

47.♙d1 ♙d4 48.♙f2 ♙c3 49.♙e2 ♙b2 50.♙d3

Zugzwang

50...♙b1!

But not 50...♙xa2 51.♙c2, with a draw.

51.a3 ♖c1 52.♔e2 ♙xa3 53.b4
axb4 54.♙a4 ♖b2 55.♗d1 b3
56.♙c6 ♖a1 0-1

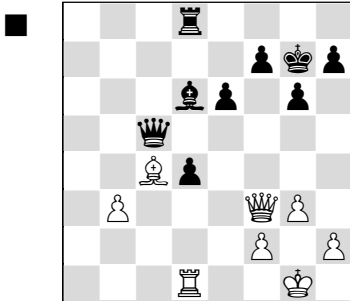
198

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Andor Lilienthal

Mikhail Botvinnik

Moscow ch-URS 1941 (17)



It is not easy for Black to set his pawn centre in motion, because his opponent rules the light squares. His long-term aim is to play ...e6-e5 and ...f7-f5, but this requires long preparatory work. First, Black strengthens the d4-pawn and activates his major pieces, with the help of the seizure of the a-file.

26...♙e5 27.♖b7 ♜b8 28.♖e4 ♙f6
29.♗g2 ♖a5 30.♖e2 ♜a8 31.♞d3
♖c5

The rook will be the first to enter the white camp, so the queen makes way for it.

32.♖e4 ♜a1 33.♞d2 ♖a5 34.♖e2

Somewhat more tenacious was 34.♞e2, not weakening the long diagonal.

34...♖a8+ 35.♗h3

35.f3 leads to a weakening of the dark squares.

35...♞g1 36.f4 ♖c8

Black has managed to weaken White's position and create threats,

without even getting his pawns moving. This is all the result of skilled manoeuvring.

37.♙a6 ♖c5 38.♙d3 ♖d5 39.♞d1
♞g2 40.♖e4 ♜xh2+ 41.♗xh2
♖h5+ 42.♗g2 ♖xd1

White loses another pawn and, with it, any chance of saving the game.

43.♙c4 h5 44.♖f3 ♖xf3+ 45.♗xf3
♙e7 46.♗e4 ♙c5 47.♙b5 ♗f6
48.♙e2 ♗e7 49.♙b5 ♙b4 50.♗xd4
♙e1 51.♗e4 ♙xg3 52.♗f3 ♙e1
53.♙c6 ♙b4 54.♙a4 ♙d6 55.♙c6
f5

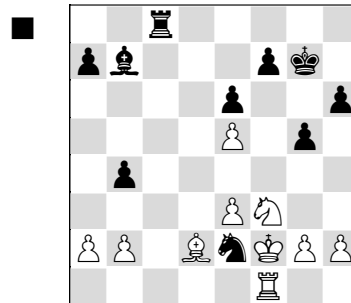
White resigned.

199

Borislav Ivkov

Bent Larsen

Bled match 1965 (6)



It is well-known that opposite-coloured bishops hamper the defence against an attack. Black carelessly played

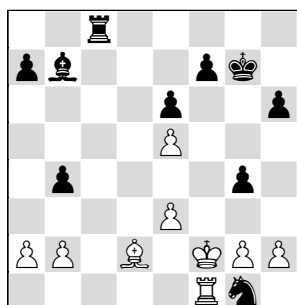
26...g4?

Correct was 26...♙a6!, followed by playing the rook to c2 and only then ...g5-g4, trying to exchange knights, but not rooks. However...

27.♞g1!

Black had only counted on 27.♞e1 ♙a6 28.♙xb4 ♜c1, with a strong initiative.

27...♖xg1



Like lightning from a clear sky,
there followed...

28.♞c1!! ♜xc1 29.♞xc1

And when there are no other pieces left except opposite-coloured bishops, the drawing tendencies frequently predominate. This is often true even when it is not obvious, and here the drawn outcome raises no doubts.

29...♞xg2 30.♞xg1 ♞d5 31.♞d2
♞xa2 32.♞xb4 ♞g6 33.♞g2 ♞f5
34.♞c3 h5 35.♞g3 ♞g5 36.h4+
♞f5 37.♞d4 a5 38.♞c3 a4 39.♞d4
♞e4 40.♞f2 ½-½

Additional material

Smyslov-Ivanchuk, Moscow 1988

Karpov-Larsen, Tilburg 1980

Karpov-Spassky, Leningrad (match/7) 1974

Kasparov-Petrosian, Niksic 1983 – White's 37th move

Alekhine-Tartakower, Vienna 1922 – White's 21st move

Ivanchuk-Kasparov, Linares 1990

Kasparov-Karpov, New York Wch (match/6) 1990

Chapter 24

Secure points, outposts

A secure point or outpost is a square that can be used to transfer pieces, or simply a well-defended square, from which the opponent is unable to drive away one's piece with a pawn. Exchanging pieces on the square is also either impossible or has negative consequences for the opposing side. It is often possible to build a strategic plan for the entire game around such an outpost.

200

Jonathan Tisdall

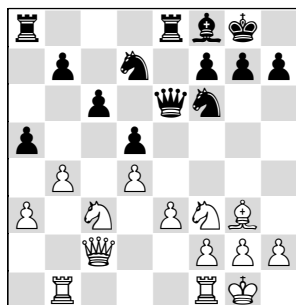
Evgeny Sveshnikov

Hastings 1977 (12)

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2375

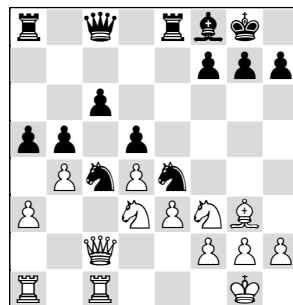
2520



White has played a minority attack on the queenside in rather stereotyped fashion. The light-squared bishops have been exchanged, which is almost always unfavourable for White in the Carlsbad structure.

White's hopes are associated with the advance b4-b5, so as to weaken Black's pawn structure. However, the c4-square has been seriously weakened and Black now creates a secure post there. In the process, he fixes weaknesses on a3 and b4.

16...b5! 17.♘e2 ♘b6 18.♙f4 ♔c8
19.♙d3 ♙c4 20.♚a1 ♙e4 21.♚fc1



The main events are taking place on the queenside, and that is where Black sends his reserves:

21...♚e7! 22.a4

White eliminates his weakness, but now Black gets a passed b-pawn, which is well supported by his minor pieces.

22...♚e7 23.axb5 cxb5 24.bxa5
♚xa5 25.♚xa5 ♚xa5 26.♙fe5 ♔a8
27.♙d7 ♚a2 28.♔b3 ♚a3 29.♔b1
♙c3 30.♔c2 b4 31.♚f1 ♚a2
32.♔b3 ♙d2

White resigned. It is noteworthy how the ♙g3, cut off from the queenside, played practically no role in the game at all.

201

Bent Larsen

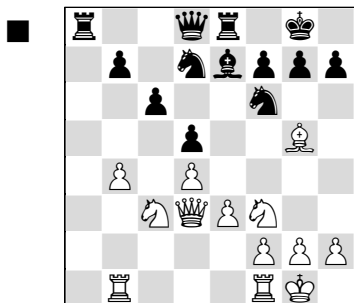
Efim Geller

Linares 1983 (8)

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2555

2575



White has put his pawns on the colour squares of his remaining bishop, and Black now fixed the weakness on b4 with the move

14...b5!

ensuring himself at the same time an outpost on c4.

15. d2e5

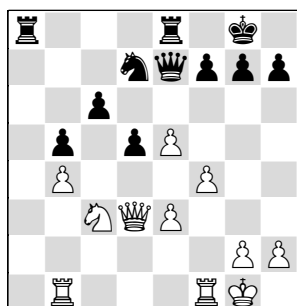
Trying to organise counterplay.

If 15. d2xf6 d2xf6 16. e4 d2b6, White's centre remains shaky, and Black organises counterplay.

15... d2xe5! 16. d2xe5 d2d7 17. d2xe7

On 17. d2f4, the strongest is 17... d2a3!, not allowing e3-e4, and preparing the transfer of the knight via b6 to c4.

17... d2xe7 18. f4



18... d2a3!

The a-file has been taken under firm control, and at the same time, there is unpleasant pressure on the d2c3.

19. d2fd1 d2ea8 20. d2d4 d2f8 21. d2dc1 d2e6 22. d2d2 d2a7 23. f5 d2f8

Now, the pawn on e5 becomes a target.

24. d2d4 d2d7 25. d2d1 d2c7! 26. d2xd5

White could have retained chances of a successful defence with 26. e6!, weakening the black king's cover, and provoking pawn weaknesses.

26... d2xe5 27. d2xb5 d2g4 28. d2xc6?

This loses at once, but even after 28. g3 d2xg3+ 29. h2xg3 cxb5, Black's advantage is great

28... d2xh2+ 29. d2f1 h5 30. d2b3 d2a2 31. d2b2 d2xb2 32. d2xa8+ d2h7 33. d2xb2 d2h1+ 34. d2e2 d2xc1 35. d2d1 d2c4+ 36. d2d2 d2xb4+ 37. d2e2 d2b5+ 38. d2e1 d2xf5 39. d2f3 d2e6 40. d2d2 d2a2+ 41. d2e1 g6 42. e4 d2g8 43. d2e2 d2a5+ 44. d2d2 d2b6 45. d2e2 d2c7 46. d2c3 d2h2 47. d2f3 d2g1 48. d2c3 d2d4 49. d2d5 d2b2+ 50. d2d1 d2g7 51. d2e2 d2f2+ 52. d2e1 d2xe2+ 53. d2xe2 d2xe4

And Black won.

202

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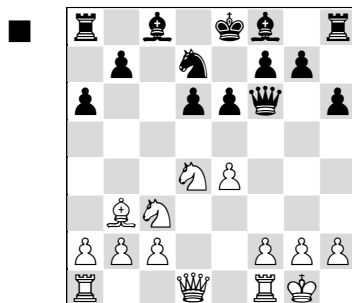
Arkadij Naiditsch

2623

Ian Nepomniachtchi

2634

Dortmund 2008 (1)



For the sake of the most rapid possible development, White has parted with his dark-squared bishop, and now intends by f2-f4-f5 to attack the light squares in Black's camp. But Black puts a stop to this:

10...g5!

This move not only secures an outpost on e5 for his pieces, but also starts play on the kingside, for which the queen is well placed on f6.

11.♘de2 ♖g8 12.f4 gxf4 13.♘xf4 ♖g5 14.♙h1 ♘e5

It was also worth considering another scheme of development – 14...♘c5 – having the square e5 is any event favourable for Black, and on c5, the knight also fulfils important functions, in particular, preventing the white knight coming to a4 and b6.

15.♘a4 ♙d7

A good choice was 15...♘d7, with the intention of playing ...b7-b5, and inviting White to repeat moves with 16.♘c3.

16.♘b6 ♜d8 17.♖e2 ♙b5

Black forces c2-c4, so as not to allow the knight to use this square to reach b6, as well as to restrict the ♙b3.

18.c4 ♙c6 19.♞ae1 ♙g7 20.♙d1

The white bishop eyes up the h5-square and frees the path for the b-pawn to advance.

20...♘g6 21.♘h5 ♙e5 22.♘d5 exd5 23.exd5 ♙d7 24.♘f6+ ♖e7 25.♘e4 ♖h4

It was hard to decide on 25...♖c1, but this was possible, and could lead to a draw after 26.♖f2 f5 27.♘xd6 ♙xd6 28.♖b6+ ♖e7 29.♞xe5+ ♘xe5 30.♖c5+ ♖f6 31.♖d6+ ♖g7 32.♖xe5+ ♘h7 33.♖e7+ ♘h8 34.♖f6+ ♘h7.

26.g3 ♖h3 27.♘f2

White also had the interesting possibility 27.♖f3!? f6 28.♘xf6 ♞gf8 29.♙c2 ♖xf1+ 30.♖xf1 ♞xf6 31.♖g1, with an unclear battle.

27...♖f5 28.♘e4 ♖h3 29.♘f2 ♖f5 30.♘e4

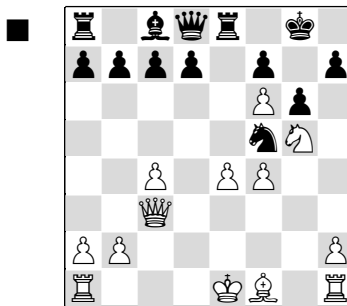
Draw.

203

Vladimir Kramnik

Peter Leko

Tilburg 1998 (6)



Black's knight is hanging, but he finds a great way of entrenching it in the centre:

18...c5!

Not 18...h6 19.0-0-0 ♘h4 20.♖g3! hxc5 21.e5!!, and White gradually breaks through to the black king.

19.0-0-0 ♘d4 20.e5

White tries to maintain the 'bone' in Black's throat at f6, but opening the central lines helps Black.

Nor does it help to sacrifice the exchange to try to keep hold of the central squares: 20.♞xd4 cxd4 21.♖xd4 h6! (less convincing is 21...d6, because of 22.f5) 22.♘f3 (no better is 22.h4 hxc5 23.hxc5 d5 24.♖f2 ♙g4 – White's attack on

the h-file is too late) 22...d5! 23.exd5
 ♖f5.

It was essential to play 20.♖h3! h5
 21.f5! ♖xf6 22.♖g1, exerting pressure
 on the kingside, and retaining
 compensation for the pawn.

20...d6 21.♖f3

He could have maintained the
 sharpness of the position with
 21.♖e1! ♖f5 (on 21...h6 22.♖f3 ♖f5
 White has the far-from-obvious
 resource 23.♖h3! (23.♖xd4? cxd4
 24.♖xd4 ♖a5+) 23...♖xh3
 24.♖xd4) 22.♖d3! ♖d7 23.h4!,
 although Black's central play still
 looks the more dangerous.

**21...♖g4 22.♖xd4 ♖xd1 23.♖b5
 dxe5 24.fxe5 ♖a4 25.♖d6 ♖e6
 26.♖g2 ♖xd6! 27.exd6 ♖xd6
 28.♖xb7 ♖e8**

The black pieces have occupied active
 positions, and the f6-pawn has gone
 from a strength to a weakness.

29.b3 ♖f4+ 30.♖b2

If 30.♖d2 ♖xf6 31.bxa4 ♖a1+
 32.♖c2 ♖xa2+ 33.♖c1 ♖a1+ 34.♖c2
 ♖xa4+ 35.♖c1 ♖xc4+ 36.♖c2
 ♖f4+ 37.♖d2 ♖e3, Black has a
 decisive attack.

30...♖e3 31.♖d1 h5

The simplest was 31...♖e8 32.♖d8 h5.

32.♖a5

More dangerous is 32.♖d2!, although
 after 32...♖xf6+ 33.♖a3 ♖e7
 34.♖d8+ ♖e8!, Black should realise
 his extra pawn anyway.

**32...♖e2+ 33.♖a3 ♖f2 34.♖d8+
 ♖e8 35.♖d2 ♖xd2 36.♖xe8+
 ♖h7 37.♖xf7+ ♖h6 38.♖a4
 ♖xa2+ 39.♖b5 ♖e3 40.♖d5
 ♖xb3+ 41.♖c6 ♖a6+ 42.♖d7
 ♖h3+ 43.♖e6 ♖d3+ 44.♖e8 ♖d6
 45.♖e7 ♖xe6**

0-1

204

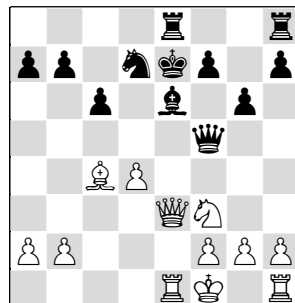
Anatoly Karpov

Artur Jussupow

Moscow ch-URS 1988 (9)

2725

2615



16.d5!

To a large extent an intuitive
 sacrifice, with which White prevents
 simplification along the e-file, which
 would ease Black's position. White
 gets an outpost at d4, and exposes a
 group of dark squares, on which the
 white queen can march around in
 comfort.

Thanks to his greater manoeuvring
 space, White would retain a minimal
 advantage after 16.♖xe6 fxe6 17.h4
 ♖d8.

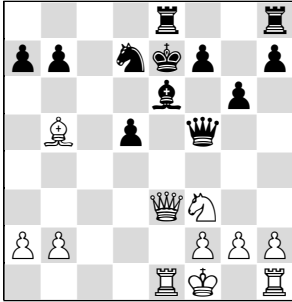
There is an interesting attempt to get
 the ♖h1 in play with tempo, but it is
 insufficient, because of the exposure
 of White's king: 16.g4 ♖xg4 17.♖g5
 ♖b6 18.♖xe6 fxe6 19.♖g1 ♖f5
 20.♖a3+ ♖d7 21.♖e5 ♖c2 22.♖xa7
 ♖c7 23.♖a5 ♖c4+ and Black has
 good counterplay.

16...cxd5 17.♖b5

Black is left with a bad bishop on e6.
 For honesty's sake, one must admit
 that Black has a satisfactory game if
 he defends with complete accuracy,
 because White needs time to get his
 ♖h1 into the game.

On 17.♘d4, Black confidently defends with 17...♖e5.

Another possible way to maintain the initiative is 17.♙b3!? ♜f8 18.h4!↑.



17...a6?

A) Black loses immediately after 17...d4? 18.♘xd4 ♕d5 (or 18...♖c5 19.♞d1) 19.♞d1! ♜f6 20.♖c3!;

B) The only defence, although completely unexpected, is 17...♖c2!, with the idea of preventing a check from c3. Now:

B1) After 18.♖a3+ ♜f6!, we see the point of Black's last move;

B2) After 18.h4 ♖xb2 19.♘d4 ♘d8! (19...♜f8 20.h5 ♘g8 21.♞h4 and White retains a strong initiative) 20.♞e2 ♖b1+ 21.♞e1 ♖b2, the game ends in a repetition of moves;

B3) 18.b3 ♖xa2 19.♘d4 ♖a5 20.h4 ♘d8 21.b4 ♖xb4 22.♖f4 ♖c5 – White's initiative is dangerous, but Black's three extra pawns are also a strong counter-argument;

B4) On 18.♘d4, a possible line is 18...♖xb2 19.♖g5+ ♜f8 20.♘xe6+ ♞xe6 21.♙xd7 ♞xe1+ 22.♜xe1 ♜g7 – here, the most likely outcome is a draw by perpetual check;

B5) Finally, after, say, 18.b4! a6 19.♘d4 (equality results from 19.♙xd7 ♜xd7 20.♞c1 ♙f5 21.♖f4 g5 22.♖xg5 f6 23.♖g7+ ♞e7 24.♖xe7+

♜xe7 25.♞xc2 ♙xc2 26.♜e2) 19...♖c7, Black retains sufficient defensive resources for equality.

18.♖a3+

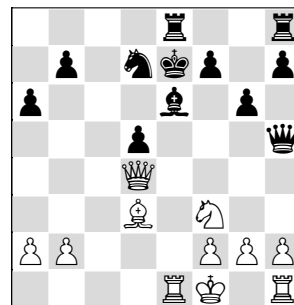
White also had a more forcing path: 18.♘d4 ♖f6 19.♘xe6 fxe6 20.♖a3+ ♘d8 21.♖a5+ ♜c8 (even worse is 21...b6 22.♖xa6 ♞hf8 23.f3, and Black loses the ♘d7) 22.♞c1+ ♜b8 23.♙xd7 ♞d8 24.♙a4 ♖xb2 25.♞c2 ♖d4 26.♙b3 ♞c8 27.♖d2 – White should gradually realise his extra pawn.

18...♘d8 19.♖a5+ ♜e7 20.♖b4+ ♜f6

Better is 20...♘d8, although after 21.♘d4 ♖f6 22.♙e2!, White has a clear advantage – the pawn on b7 is hanging, and the problem of developing the ♞h1 can be solved by pushing the h-pawn (22.♙xa6 ♙g4, and White goes from being the attacker to the defender – the black rooks come into play, whilst White's rook remains on h1).

21.♖d4+ ♜e7 22.♙d3 ♖h5

22...♖f6 23.♖b4+ ♘d8 24.♖xb7 ♖xf3 25.♖a8+ ♜e7 26.♖xe8+ ♞xe8 27.gxf3 – in the endgame an exchange down, Black's chances of holding are minimal.



23.h4!

The g5-square is now available for the knight, and at the same time

the ♖h1 comes into play, whilst the manoeuvring space of the black queen is restricted.

23...♔d8 24.♘g5 ♖hf8 25.♙e2
♚h6 26.♙f3

On a board full of pieces, Black has no moves!

26...♙e7 27.♚b4 ♘f6 28.♚d6+ ♔d7
29.♚f4 ♘g8 30.♙g4 ♔c8 31.♙xe6
fxe6 32.♚c1+ ♔d8 33.♘xe6+ ♔e7
34.♚xf8+ ♚xf8+ 35.♘xf8 ♔xf8
36.♚h3 ♘e7 37.h5 ♔g7 38.h6+
♔f6 39.♚f3+ ♔e6 40.♙e1+ ♔d6
41.♚f6+ ♔c7 42.g4 ♘c6 43.♙e8

Black resigned.

205

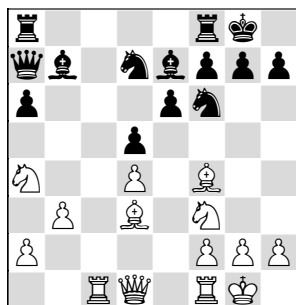
Boris Gelfand

Sebastien Feller

Ohrid tt 2009 (7)

2756

2570



Bringing the rook into c7 brings White nothing, as Black simply plays ...♚a8-c8, not conceding the c-file. And how nice it would be to secure c5 for the knight! Black seems to be preventing this, but even so, it is possible.

15.b4!

If White quietly completes his development, the position is roughly equal after 15.♚e2 ♚ac8.

15...♙xb4!

It is essential to find a way to stop the opponent's plan, especially when such a serious bind is threatened.

In the game, Black tamely allowed the outpost at c5 to be exploited, and White obtained a large advantage, which he realised easily: 15...♚fc8 16.♘c5 ♚b6 (more tenacious is 16...a5, although after 17.♘xb7 ♚xc1 18.♚xc1 ♚xb7 19.b5 ♚c8 20.♚b1, White has two bishops and a protected passed pawn) 17.a4! (the black pieces on the queenside, especially the queen and ♙b7, are cramped) 17...♙xc5 (now, 17...a5 is completely bad, because of 18.bxa5! ♚xa5 19.♚b1) 18.bxc5 ♚a5 19.♘e5 ♘xe5 20.♙xe5 ♘d7 21.♙d6 ♙c6 22.♙c2 (White controls the b8-square and Black cannot activate even his rooks) 22...♚b4 23.♚b1 ♚c4 24.♚d2, and White won.

16.♚b3 ♘h5!

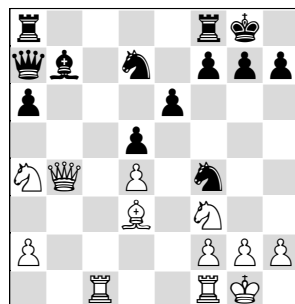
Naturally, this jump had to be seen on the previous move, otherwise Black simply loses a piece.

17.♚xb4

On 17.♙e3, there is 17...♙d6, not allowing the white rook into c7.

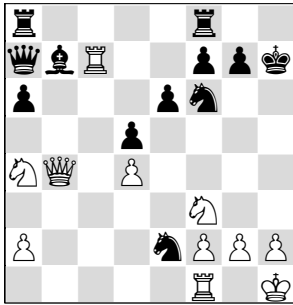
17...♘xf4

The sacrifice on h7



18.♙xh7+! ♔xh7 19.♚c7 ♘e2+
20.♔h1 ♘f6

Double attack



21. ♕b2!

The queen goes to a square defended by the knight, and now both the ♖b7 and the ♘e2 are hanging. White has no advantage after 21. ♙xb7 ♙ab8.

21... ♘e4!?

If 21... ♙ab8 22. ♕xe2 ♙bc8 23. ♙e7 ♙ce8 24. ♙xe8 ♙xe8 25. ♘c5 White's play on the dark squares is very strong.

22. ♘c5!

A) Bad is 22. ♙xb7? ♙xb7 23. ♙xb7 ♙ab8 24. ♙xa6 ♘xf2+ 25. ♙xf2 ♙b1+, and mate;

B) After 22.h3, Black emerges in one piece: 22...a5! 23. ♙xb7 ♙a6 24. ♙e1 ♘f4 25. ♘c5 ♘xc5 26. dxc5 ♘d3 27. ♙b1 ♙g8 28. ♘g5 ♘xf2+ 29. ♙g1 ♙d3 30. ♙e3 ♙xb1+ 31. ♙xb1 ♘e4 32. ♘xe4 dxe4 33. ♙xe4 ♙fb8 – and the rook endgame should end in a draw;

Additional material

Lasker-Capablanca, St Petersburg 1914

Smyslov-Geller, Moscow (match/7) 1955

Pilnik-Geller, Gothenburg 1955 – Black's 22nd move

Kasparov-Martinovic, Baku 1980 – White's 16th move

Kholmov-Uhlmann, Halle 1978 – Black's 35th move

Smyslov-Nunn, Tilburg 1982 – White's 22nd move

Keberl-Szabo, Budapest 1951 – Black's 23rd move

Benko-Petrosian, Los Angeles 1963

Spassky-Petrosian, Moscow 1969 Wch (match/11) – Black's 30th move

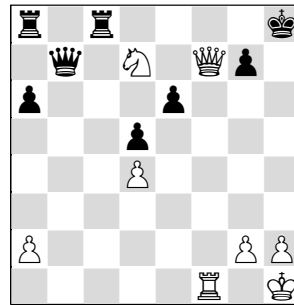
C) Admittedly, the quiet 22. ♕xe2 ♙ac8 23. ♙d7 ♙cd8 24. ♘c5 ♙xd7 25. ♘xd7 retains the initiative for White.

22... ♘c3 23. ♘g5+ ♙g8 24. ♘gxe4 ♘xe4 25. ♙d7 ♙fc8

If 25... ♘d6 26. ♘xf8 ♙xf8 27. ♙d7 ♙b8 28. ♙b6, Black loses the exchange.

26. ♙xb7 ♘xf2+ 27. ♙xf2 ♙xb7 28. ♙xf7+ ♙h8

Quiet prophylactic moves in the middle of an attack



29.h3!

Threatening to bring the rook into the attack.

29... ♙c7

He loses after 29... ♙ab8 30. ♙f4 ♙c1+ 31. ♙h2 ♙c7 32. ♙h5+ ♙g8 33. ♘e5+.

30. ♙f4 ♙b1+ 31. ♙h2 ♙h7 32. ♙e7 ♙xd7 33. ♙xd7

White retains good winning chances.

Chapter 25

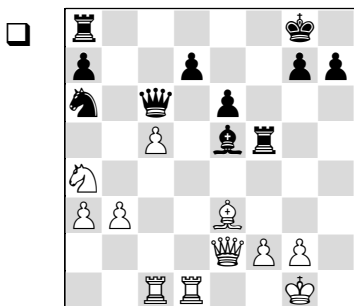
A knight on the edge of the board stands badly/well

'A knight on the rim is dim', as Dr Tarrasch taught. This is explained by the geometry of the chessboard. In the centre, a knight controls eight squares, in the corner only two. Therefore, the knight is rarely well-placed on the edge of the board – usually, it goes there only to perform a concrete task, and then returns to the game again. Exceptions to this general rule are met mainly in closed positions, in which the knight can be well-placed on the side of the board where the main action is taking place.

206

Tigran Petrosian
Aleksandar Matanovic

Kiev tt 1959 (1)



The knight on a6 is bad and needs two tempi to reach d5, time which Black does not have. The ♗e5 is unstable, and the ♖a8 not yet in play. The queen is a poor blockader, and one must always look for ways to dislodge her from the key square, often with the help of tactics. All of these considerations lead White to a forcing way of realising his advantage:

21.f4!

*

21.♗b2 ♖af8 22.♗c4 ♗b8 23.b4 retains a clear advantage, but allows Black to resist.

21...♗c7

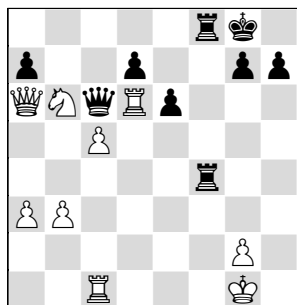
A) 21...♗f6 22.♖d6+–;

B) 21...♗xf4 22.♗xf4 ♖xf4 23.♖d6+–;

C) Slightly tougher is 21...♖xf4, after which the most precise path to a win is as follows: 22.♗xf4 ♗xf4 23.♖c4! ♖f8 (23...♗c7 24.♗e4, breaking through to d7 with the rook, after the queen exchange) 24.♖xf4! ♖xf4 25.♖d6 ♗b7 26.c6!+–.

22.♗b6! axb6

Black chooses the line of least resistance, ending the game at once. It was essential to exploit his last chance, bringing a piece into play and setting a cunning trap: 22...♖af8!. Here, the most convincing way to win is 23.b4! – the black pieces are tied up on the queenside (the direct 23.♗xa6 unexpectedly allows Black to save himself: 23...♗xf4 24.♗xf4 ♖xf4 25.♖d6



analysis diagram

25...♖f1+! 26.♔h2 ♕xg2+!! 27.♔xg2 ♕8f2+, with perpetual check).

23.cxb6 ♖b7 24.♙d7 ♙f7 25.♙xf7

♔xf7 26.bxc7 ♙c8 27.♙h5+ ♔f8

28.♙d1 ♕xc7 29.♙xh7 ♙c3

30.♙d4

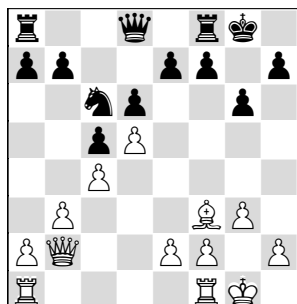
Black resigned.

207

Paul Keres

Laszlo Szabo

Hastings 1954 (8)



Thanks to his space advantage, White's chances are preferable, but not significantly so – the exchanges of various minor pieces mean that Black has a fair bit of space to manoeuvre. But suddenly there followed

13...♞a5?!

The knight moves a long way from the centre and the kingside, and it takes a lot of time to bring it back.

Correct was 13...♞e5 14.♙g2 ♞d7, keeping the knight in play.

Pawns are the soul of chess. The attack with the rook pawn

14.h4!

A typical idea. The rook pawn threatens to go all the way to h6, or to exchange on g6, in both cases leaving the black king with problems.

14...b5!?

Black decides to break out at all costs, in search of counterplay.

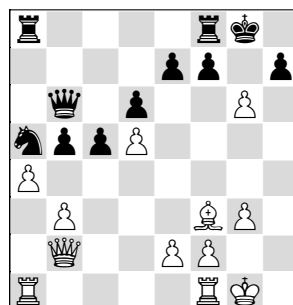
If 14...h5, stopping White's initiative on the kingside, White goes over to play in the centre, such as 15.♙c3, followed by the advance of the e-pawn (after the tempting 15.g4, there is 15...hxg4 16.♙xg4 e5 17.dxe6 ♙xh4 18.exf7+ ♙xf7 19.♙e6 ♙g5+ 20.♔h2 ♙h4+ with perpetual check).

15.cxb5 ♖b6 16.a4

Now, Black gets a target; White should not have weakened the b3-pawn.

Stronger was the immediate 16.h5 ♙xb5 17.♙d2, with the idea of ♔g1-g2 and ♙f1-h1.

16...a6 17.h5 axb5 18.hxg6



18...hxg6?

Now White's attack develops of its own accord.

Correct was 18...fxg6!, weakening the light squares, but keeping the h-file closed.

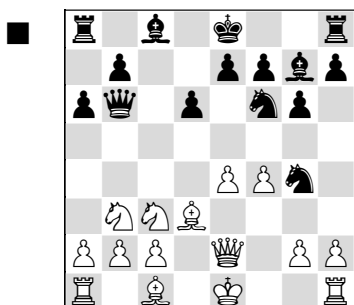
19.♔g2 f6 20.♖h1 ♔g7 21.axb5
 ♚xb5 22.♚d2 g5 23.♚e3 ♚d7
 24.♔g4 ♚c7
 24...♚xg4 25.♚xe7+ ♖f7 26.♖h7+-.
 25.♔f5 ♔f7 26.♖h7+ ♔e8 27.♖ah1
 ♚b7 28.♖h8 1-0

208

Veselin Topalov
 Vladimir Kramnik
 Belgrade 1995 (6)

2670

2730



The opening of this game was unusual, and both sides have problems comfortably developing. Whoever solves this problem better will seize the initiative. Black in particular faces a big question, as he has to deal with the threat of h2-h3, when moving the knight to h6 is prospectless. In addition, White can play g2-g4, further cramping Black and threatening g4-g5.

14...♔h5!

Despite the fact that the knight moves to the edge of the board and gives up control of d5, the plusses of the move outweigh its defects – it strengthens the pressure on the kingside dark squares. White no longer has the move h2-h3, thanks to which the position

of the ♔g4 becomes stable. The ♔h5 fulfils several concrete functions, and for this reason, its move to the edge of the board is justified.

15.♔d5 ♚d8 16.♔d2!

Continuing the fight for the initiative, threatening ♔d2-a5 and provoking complications.

On 16.0-0, a good reply is 16...0-0. The black knights still work well together on the kingside, and on 17.f5 ♔hf6 18.♔xf6 ♔xf6, we reach a roughly equal, quiet game, with naturally placed pieces.

16...e6

16...b6 17.0-0-0 would be a concession, leading to the loss of a tempo, and a weakening of the queenside. White's advantage in development becomes obvious.

Probably the objectively strongest was 16...a5!?, which after, say, 17.f5 a4 18.♔b5+ ♔f8 19.♚xg4 axb3 20.cxb3 e6 leads to a position no less complicated than the game, but with sufficient counterplay for Black.

17.♔a5!

Correct and strong.

17.♔e3 ♔xe3 18.♚xe3 ♔xb2 19.♖b1 ♔g7 leads to a position in which White needs to show that his compensation for the sacrificed pawn is sufficient.

17...♚h4+ 18.g3 ♔xg3 19.♔c7+!

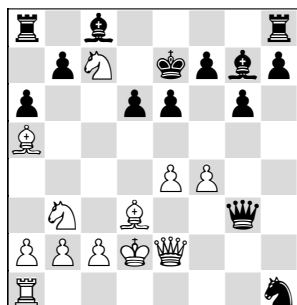
A less satisfactory alternative is 19.hxg3 ♚xg3+ (19...♚xh1+ 20.♔d2 ♚h3 21.♔c7+ ♔e7 22.♔xa8 ♚xg3 23.♖f1±) 20.♔d2 exd5+ 21.♖af1 ♔f6 22.exd5+ ♔f8 23.♔c1, with compensation for the pawn, in a complicated struggle.

19...♔e7 20.hxg3 ♚xg3+ 21.♔d1!

So far White has played brilliantly.

He could have made a draw with 21.♔d2 ♖xf4+ 22.♕e1, and there is no sense in Black declining the repetition of moves with 22...♗g3+ 23.♔d2 ♖f4+=.

21...♗f2+ 22.♔d2 ♗xh1



23.♗xa8?

But this is a mistake – in trying to take as much material as possible, White loses the initiative. Now, the black knight is ready to return to the game with tempo, whereas the rook on a8 was not participating in the game and was hanging, so it should have been left there. Furthermore, the white knight itself ends up in the corner, where it is badly placed. Correct was 23.♖xh1!. Here, all the white pieces are in play, which cannot be said of Black's. It would be very hard to fight against White's ever-growing initiative, e.g.: 23...♖xf4+ 24.♔d1 ♖b8 25.♔d2 ♗g3 26.♔e1 ♖f4 27.♖f1 ♗g5 28.♖f2 ♖f8 29.♖g1 ♖f6 30.♖a7 ♔d7 31.♔c3, and White wins.

23...♖xf4+ 24.♖e3 ♖h2+ 25.♖e2 ♖f4+ 26.♖e3 ♖h2+ 27.♖e2 ♔h6+!

Correctly assessing the position, now Black refrains from a repetition of moves.

28.♔c3

No better was 28.♔d1 ♗f2+ 29.♔e1 ♔f4 30.♔b6 ♖g1+ 31.♖f1 ♗xd3+ 32.cxd3 ♖xf1+ 33.♔xf1 ♔d7 34.♗c7 h5+ – the knight on c7 is cut off, whilst Black's pawn mass in the centre and on the kingside develops real strength.

28...♖e5+

Also good is 28...♖xe2 29.♔xe2 ♗g3 30.♔f3 ♔d7 31.♗b6 ♔c6, threatening ...♗g3xe4 and ...f7-f5.

29.♔b4 ♗g3 30.♖e1 ♔g7 31.♗b6 d5 32.♔a4

With the hope of exploiting the b4-square for the bishop or queen, but White will not manage this.

It was not easy to find the best defence: 32.♖d1! ♗xe4 33.c4!, with counterplay.

32...♔d7+! 33.♗xd7 b5+! 34.♔b4 ♗xd7

Both kings are on the march, but White's is open and is in rather greater danger.

35.♔b6

More tenacious is 35.♗c5+, but here too, after 35...♔c6 36.exd5+ ♖xd5 37.♖f2 ♔d4 38.♖xg3 ♔xc5+ 39.♔c3 b4+ 40.♔d2 ♔d6 41.♖f2 ♖xa5 42.♔e4+ ♔b5 43.♖xf7 ♖d8, Black keeps a clear advantage.

35...♖xb2 36.exd5 ♖c8 37.dxe6+ ♔e8!

The black king reaches safety, whilst White's has no such possibility.

38.♔c5 ♔c3+! 39.♖xc3 a5+ 40.♔xb5 ♖xc3

White resigned. A very entertaining and complicated battle.

Additional material

Spassky-Petrosian, Moscow Wch (match/5) 1969

Chapter 26

Play on the wing. Do not attack on the wing if the centre is insecure!

The geography of the chessboard is not limited to the central squares. When the centre is blocked by pawns or the central structure is determined, the main thrust of the battle is moved to the wings. Attacks on the flanks may be directed towards the enemy king or merely at accruing some positional advantage. But in either case, one must always remember the golden rules: 'Do not attack on the wing if the centre is insecure!', and 'The best reply to a wing attack is a counter in the centre!'. Sometimes, each of the players plays on the flank where he is strongest, in which case the winner is usually whoever manages to get his attack in first and most effectively.

209

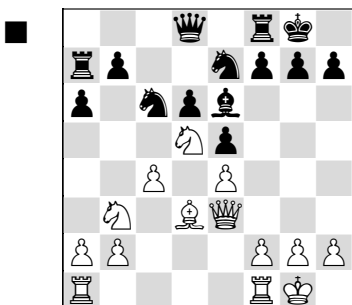
Sergey Kasparov

Konstantin Landa

Deizisau 2004 (7)

2486

2563



White has more space, and his pieces are positioned in the centre. In the event of an exchange of the ♖d5, White will take with the c-pawn, and Black will have problems with his queenside. The whole of Black's opening conception would be destroyed, if he could not play on the queenside and 'sidestep' the ♖d5.

14...a5 15.♖ac1

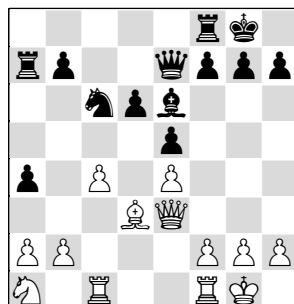
The move 15.a4?! would give the black knight the b4-square: 15...♖a8

16.♖fd1 ♙xd5! 17.cxd5 ♘b4 18.♖ac1
f5∞

15...a4 16. xe7+

Black would be happy with such a development of events as 16.♘a1 ♘d4 17.♘c2 ♘ec6 18.f4 f6! 19.♚g3 ♘xc2 20.♚xc2 ♖h8, or 16.♘d2 ♘d4 17.♘xe7+ ♚xe7 18.♘f3 ♘c6!?

16... ♔xe7 17. ♘a1



17...♔c7!

Black directs his queen to the key square c5, where it occupies an active position.

18. ♘c2 ♔a5 19. ♖fd1 ♕c5 20. ♕d2 ♖a6!

Defending the d6-pawn along the 6th rank, and activating the rook.

21.b4

After 21.♙f1 ♜b6 22.♞c3 ♜c8 23.b3 ♘b4 24.♘xb4 ♜xb4 25.♞d3 ♜c6, Black's pieces are very active, and he is in no way worse.

21...axb3 22.axb3 ♞a2 23.♞c3 h6

Prophylaxis. Now, there will be no back-rank mate.

Things could end badly for Black in the lively variation 23...b5 24.b4 ♘xb4 25.♞xb4 ♜xc2 26.♞xc5 ♜xc1 27.♜xc1 dxc5 28.cxb5 c4? (28...♞d8 29.♙f1 c4 30.f4 exf4 31.♙xc4 ♜b8!=) 29.♙xc4 ♜c8 30.b6! (suddenly, the weakness of the back rank tells) 30...♙xc4 31.b7 ♞d8 32.♜b1 ♙b5 33.f4+-.

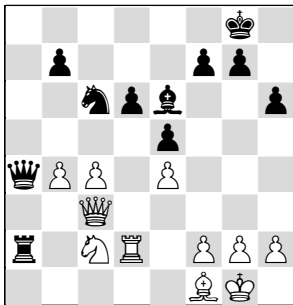
Equality results from 23...♘d4 24.♙f1 (24.b4 ♞b6 25.♘xd4 exd4 26.♞e1 ♜c8 27.f4 f6-) 24...♘xc2 25.♜xc2 ♜xc2 26.♞xc2 b5=.

24.♞a1

24.b4? ♘xb4! 25.♞xb4 ♜xc2 26.♞xc5 ♜xc1 27.♜xc1 dxc5-.

24...♞fa8 25.♞xa2 ♞xa2 26.b4 ♞a7

27.♙f1 ♞a4 28.♞d2



Black makes maximum use of the queenside and the a-file, to get his pieces into White's position.

28...♘e7

Chances of success were offered by the paradoxical blow 28...♘xb4!! 29.♘e3!? (29.♘xb4 ♞a3 30.♞a2 (30.♞b2 ♜b3 31.♞a2 ♞xb4 32.♜xd6? ♜b1-+) 30...♞xa2 31.♘xa2 ♞xa2 32.♞b4 ♞a6! (32...b6 33.♞xb6 ♙xc4 34.♙xc4 ♞xc4 35.♞d8+ ♖h7 36.f3 ♞d4+ 37.♖f1-) 33.c5 dxc5 34.♞xc5 ♞a1 35.♞b5 b6- with his next move, Black defends the pawn with ...♞d4; 29.♞xb4? ♞xb4 30.♘xb4 ♜xd2-+) 29...♘c6 30.♜xd6 ♘d4 31.♜b6 ♞a1 32.♜b2 ♙d7 33.h3 ♙c6 34.f3 ♞a7. Black has a clear positional advantage.

29.h3 ♘c8 30.c5!? dxc5 31.♞xc5 ♖h7 32.♞e2 ♞b3 33.♘e3 ♜xe2 34.♙xe2 ♞b1+ 35.♙d1 f6 36.♖h2 ♞d3 37.♙g4 ♙xg4 38.hxg4 ♘d6 39.♞c7 ♞d2 40.f3 ♘b5 41.♞xb7 ♘d4 42.♘f5 ♘xf3+ 43.♖h3 ♘g5+ 44.♖h2

Draw.

210

Jan Smeets

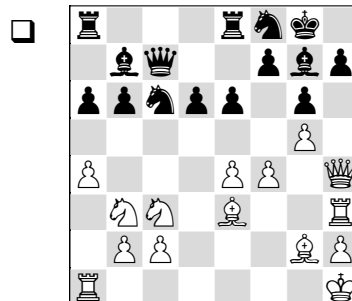
René Wendt

Amsterdam 2000 (1)

*

2183

2373



We have a tabiya from the Sicilian. White begins a direct attack on the enemy king.

21.f5! ♙xc3

Let us also look at other moves:

A) 21...gxf5 22.exf5 ♖e7 23.f6 ♘f5 24.♞f2 ♙xg2+ 25.♞xg2 ♙h8 26.♞f1 ♘xe3 27.♞xe3 ♞ac8 28.♘d4±, and Black is effectively playing a piece down, I Popov-Grekh, Lviv 2006;

B) 21...exf5 22.♘d5 ♞c8! 23.♘f6+ ♙xf6 24.gxf6 h5 25.♞g3 ♙h8 26.♞f4 ♘h7 27.exf5 ♘e5 28.♞h6 ♞g8 29.fxg6 fxg6 30.♙xb6±;

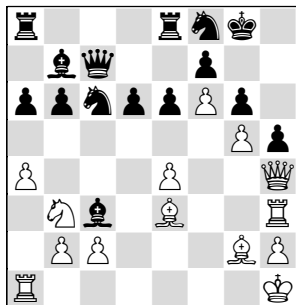
C) 21...♘e5 22.f6 ♙h8 23.♙d4± – White has an extra piece in the game.

22.f6!

A very important move. The threat is ♞h6.

After 22.bxc3? exf5 23.exf5 ♘e5±, Black seizes the initiative.

22...h5



23.♙f3!

White, ignoring the chance to re-establish material equality, simply continues the attack. The threat is to shatter the king's pawn cover with 24.♙xh5 and give mate. Black has to react energetically.

23...♘d4

23...♘e5 24.♙xh5 gxf5 25.♞xh5 ♙xe4+ 26.♙g1 ♘f3+ 27.♞xf3 ♙xf3 28.♞h6+–.

24.♙xd4 ♙xd4 25.♘xd4 ♞c5 26.♙xh5 gxf5 27.♘f3

Maybe 27.c3! ♙xe4+ 28.♞xe4 ♘g6 29.♞xh5± is stronger.

27...♙xe4 28.♞xe4 ♞f5 29.♞xf5 exf5 30.♘d4! ♘g6 31.♘xf5

White was close to a decisive advantage, which he went on to realise.

211

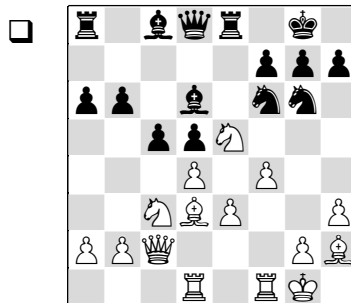
Konstantin Sakaev

2635

Darius Ruzele

2475

Elista ol 1998 (6)



The pawn structure in the centre is quite stable, which enables White to launch an attack on the flank.

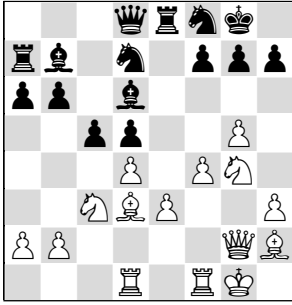
16.g4! ♙b7 17.g5 ♘d7 18.♘g4!

From this square, the knight defends e3 and supports the idea of f4-f5. The square is also good because in the future, if the queen comes to g2, there will be threats involving ♘h6+.

18...♘gf8

18...c4 slows up the attack, but also cements the central position, which plays into White's hands. After 19.♙f5 b5 20.♙xd7 ♞xd7 21.f5 ♙xh2+ 22.♞xh2 ♘f8 23.♞g3 b4 24.♘e2↑, the white pieces grouped on the kingside are a serious threat.

19.♞g2 ♞a7

**20.h4!**

Despite the lack of pawn cover, the white king feels quite safe, because of the many pieces that protect it. The same cannot be said of the black king, which is protected almost entirely by pawns, and is not entirely secure.

20...b5

Black's counterplay is clearly too late.

21.h5

21.f5 ♖xh2+ 22.♔xh2, and the threat of f5-f6 is very strong.

21...♔h8

A) 21...♖b6 22.♖h6++-;

B) Black misses the chance at least to activate one piece and reduce White's strength in the centre. It made sense to play 21...cxd4 22.exd4 ♖e6, although even here, after 23.♖b1 or 23.♔h1, it is hard to cover all of White's numerous attacking ideas.

22.♖e5 ♔g8 23.♖g4

Repeating moves to gain time is a typical device.

23...♔h8 24.♖e5

It was also possible not to repeat here. Full domination of the centre results from 24.h6 g6 25.dxc5 ♖xc5 26.♖xd5, but White was reluctant to pin himself.

24...♔g8 25.♖e2 ♖b6

25...cxd4 26.exd4 ♖xe5 27.fxe5 b4, somewhat driving back the white pieces.

26.♖f3 ♔a8 27.b3

This is a good prophylactic move, eliminating the possibility of the black knight appearing on c4. The energetic 27.♖g4 was also possible, increasing the threats on the kingside.

27...b4 28.♖e2 ♖c8

Very passive, and now the game ends quickly. But, Black's pieces are very limited and hard to activate. Even so, more tenacious was 28...♖xe5 or 28...c4.

29.f5

Now, the attack develops of its own accord, and Black is defenceless against White's armada of pieces.

29...♖xe5 30.♖xe5 ♖d7 31.♖f4

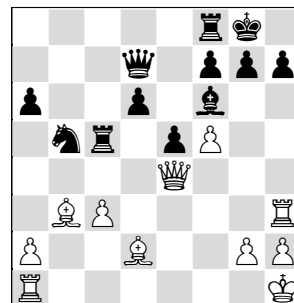
He could also win with a direct attack: 31.g6 ♖xe5 (31...fxg6 32.hxg6 h6 33.f6+-) 32.gxf7+ ♔xf7 33.dxe5 ♖xe5 34.h6+-, but White has no need to hurry.

31...♔h8 32.♖g3 ♖e7 33.f6 1-0**212**

*

Robert Fischer**Vassily Smyslov**

Bled/Zagreb/Belgrade ct 1959 (21)



White was counting on mating on the h-file, but already, Black's next move takes full control of the centre, at the same time limiting the actions of the sniper at b3.

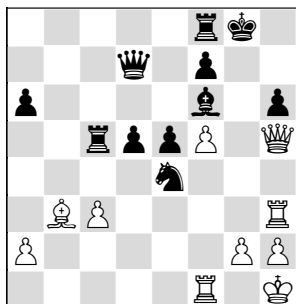
24...d5! 25.♖f3 ♘d6!

Black does not try to engage in prophylaxis on the kingside, as he is too weak there anyway. Instead, he further strengthens his centralisation, and it is from the centre that Black influences the kingside as well.

26.♞f1

26.♖h5 ♖xf5—+.

26...♘e4! 27.♖h5 h6 28.♙xh6 gxh6



29.♙c2

In the event of the most tenacious line 29.♖xh6 ♞d8 30.♙c2 ♙g7 31.♖h7+ ♗f8 32.♙xe4 dxe4 33.f6 ♙xf6 34.♞h6!! ♖c6! 35.♖f5 ♞d6 36.♞xf6 ♞xf6 37.♖xf6 ♖xf6 38.♞xf6 ♗e7 39.♞xa6 f5, the rook ending should be winning for Black, as his pawn armada is very strong.

29...♙g5

29...♞xc3! wins immediately.

30.f6

Once again, White does not take the chance Black has accidentally offered him: 30.♙xe4 dxe4 31.♞g3 f6 32.h4. Potentially, White is 'only'

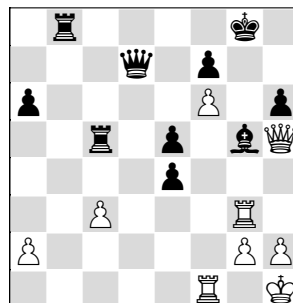
a pawn down, and still has hopes of saving the game.

30...♞b8

Now, however, White's attacking resources are too few.

31.♙xe4 dxe4 32.♞g3

Back rank weakness



32...♖f5! 33.♙g1 ♖g6 34.♖e2 ♞c6 35.h4 ♞xf6 36.♞xf6 ♖xf6 37.♖h5 ♖f4 38.♙h2 ♙g7 39.hxg5 hxg5 40.♖xg5+ ♖xg5 41.♞xg5+ ♙f6 42.♞h5 ♞b1 43.♙g3 ♞f1 44.♞h4 ♙f5 45.♞h5+ ♙e6 46.♞h6+ f6 47.♞h4 e3 48.♞e4 f5

White resigned.

213

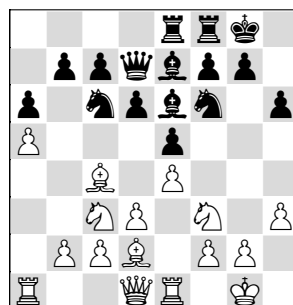
Zoltan Almasi

2691

Penteala Harikrishna

2668

Reggio Emilia 2007 (1)



12.♘d5

Before beginning play on the kingside, White secures his position in the centre! He shuts off once and for all the possibility of ...d6-d5.

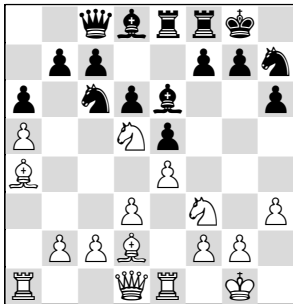
12...♙d8 13.♙b3

After the 'standard' 13.c3 ♙xd5 14.exd5?! (maybe, 14.♙xd5= is more solid) 14...♗e7 15.♖b3 c6! 16.dxc6 ♗xc6, Black is doing very well.

13...♗h7

Now, the exchange 13...♙xd5 14.exd5 ♗e7 is not so strong, because of 15.♙a4! c6 16.c4±. The pin stops the counterplay, and it is not clear what Black can do next.

14.♙a4 ♖c8



15.b4 f5 16.c4

White had every reason to play 16.b5! axb5 17.♙xb5. Now, he threatens to destroy Black's queenside completely with a5-a6. 17...fxe4 18.dxe4. Almasi did not like 18...♖xf3? (18...♗f6±) 19.♖xf3 ♗d4 20.♖d3 c6 (20...♗xb5 21.♖xb5 c6 22.♖a4±) 21.♙a4 ♖f8 22.♗b6 ♙xb6 23.axb6 ♙xh3 24.♖xh3 ♗f3+, but after 25.♖xf3! ♖xf3 26.gxf3, White should win.

16...♙d7?

Too slow. Black cannot hold back the white initiative on the queenside.

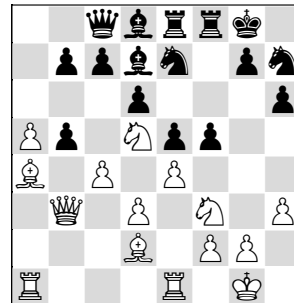
He had to seek relief at the enemy's gates: 16...fxe4 17.dxe4 ♙xh3! 18.gxh3 ♖xh3 19.♖e3 ♖e6 20.♗g5 (20.♗xe5 ♖h4!∞) 20...♖h4 21.♗xe6 ♖xf2+ 22.♗h1 ♖h4+ 23.♗g1 ♖f2+=.

Black's attack is less strong after 16...f4 17.b5 ♙xh3 18.♗h2! ♗d4 (18...axb5 19.cxb5 ♗d4 20.gxh3 ♖xh3 21.♖g4 ♖xg4+ 22.♗xg4 ♗f3+ 23.♗h1 ♗xd2 24.a6+–) 19.bxa6 bxa6 20.♙xe8 ♖xe8 21.♙c3 f3 22.♙xd4, and White should repulse the attack.

17.b5 ♗e7 18.♖b3 axb5?

Accelerating defeat. Black gives his opponent a fearsome passed pawn on the a-file.

18...♗xd5 19.cxd5 ♖f7 was relatively best for Black (19...fxe4 20.bxa6! bxa6 21.dxe4 ♙xa4 22.♖xa4±).



19.♗xe7+ ♖xe7 20.cxb5+ ♖ef7 21.a6 fxe4 22.dxe4 ♗h8

The last chance to muddy the waters was 22...♙xh3!? 23.gxh3 ♗h8 24.♖e3 ♙g5, but even here, White wins after 25.♖c3 ♙xd2 26.♗xd2 bxa6 (26...♗g5 27.a7 ♖xf2 28.b6!) 27.b6 ♖xf2 28.♗f3+–.

23.a7 ♖a8 24.b6 c6 25.♖e3

The pawn on a7 is worth a queen. The rest is technique.

25...♗f6 26.♖d1 ♙e8 27.♙a5 ♖d7 28.♖a3 ♙e7 29.♙b4 c5 30.♙a5

♖d8 31. ♙xe8 ♜fxe8 32. ♘h4 ♙h7
33. ♜b3 ♙f8 34. ♜f7 ♜c8 35. ♜f3
♙d7 36. ♜g6+ ♙h8 37. ♙d2 d5
38. ♜xf6 gxf6 39. ♜a1 dxe4 40. a8 ♜
 Black resigned.

214

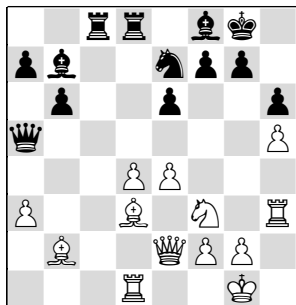
Evgeny Bareev

Zbynek Hracek

Pardubice 1994 (6)

2675

2530



Undoubtedly, White's chances are on the kingside, where his pieces are all pointing. The following pawn sacrifice is standard in such structures, opening lines for the white pieces, and securing d4 as a jump-off point for the knight.

19.d5!

An interesting idea is 19.g4, with the idea of ♜h3-g3 and g4-g5. The black queen and knight are badly placed, thanks to which a quick counterblow in the centre is not possible. Even so, the plan chosen by White, which is traditional in such positions, is more reliable, because the black kingside is weakened.

19...exd5 20.e5

Threatening e5-e6, whilst the rook is ready to occupy the square g3.

20...d4

By returning the pawn, Black hopes to get counterplay on the open lines. However, White's position in the centre is very strong, and the Black king is very weak.

A) 20...♜c6 21.♘d4+—;

B) 20...♜a4 21.e6 f6 22.♘d4+—;

C) 20...♙h8 21.♘d4 ♘c6 22.e6+—.

21.♘xd4 ♜d5 22.♜g3

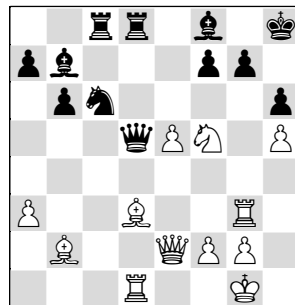
It is hard to imagine a better square for the rook – from there, it attacks and defends simultaneously.

22...♘c6

Now, the white knight is included in the attack with decisive effect, but it is hard to suggest anything else for Black.

23.♘f5 ♙h8

The attempt to blockade the e5-pawn with the queen fails, as after 23...♜e6, White wins in various ways, such as 24.♘d6 ♙xd6 25.exd6 ♜xe2 26.♜xg7+ ♙f8 27.♙xe2+—.



24.♘xh6!

The number of units defending the black king is reduced further.

24...♜e6 25.♘xf7+! ♜xf7 26.e6

♜f4 27.h6 ♘d4 28.hxg7+ ♙xg7

29.♜h5+ ♜h6 30.♜xh6+ ♙xh6

31.e7 ♙d5 32.♙e4

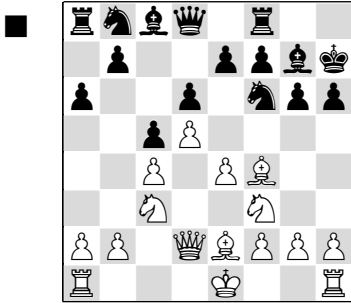
Black resigned.

215

Wolfgang Uhlmann

Efim Geller

Palma de Mallorca izt 1970 (9)



Despite the fact that White has occupied the centre, his structure does not look harmonious – the ♔f4 is poorly placed, and the queen belongs on c2, so as not only to defend the queenside, but also to strengthen the e4-pawn. White's centre cannot be challenged by ...e7-e6, and therefore Black must play on the queenside:

10...b5!

In this case, the Benko Gambit-style pawn sacrifice is effective.

11.cxb5 axb5 12.♙xb5 ♖b6!

Black exerts pressure on the b-file, and threatens to take on e4.

13.♙e2

White underestimates Black's central pressure, else he would have chosen 13.♙d3.

13...♖b4! 14.e5 ♘h5 15.♙g3

The bishops need to be kept, so he should have preferred 15.♙e3! dxe5 16.a3 ♖b3 17.0-0, with a double-edged position.

15...♙a6 16.♙xa6

There was not much difference after 16.exd6 exd6 17.0-0 ♘xg3

18.hxg3 ♙xe2 19.♖xe2 ♘d7 20.♖c2 – Black has full compensation, but White has every chance to hold equality.

16...♙xa6 17.exd6 exd6 18.0-0 ♘d7 19.♖ae1

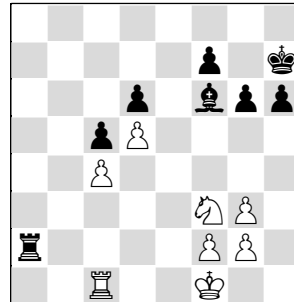
On 19.♖fe1, 19...♘xg3 20.hxg3 ♘b6 is also good.

19...♘xg3 20.hxg3 ♘b6 21.♞e2

White misses his last chance to equalise: 21.♞e4! ♙xc3 22.♖d3! c4 23.bxc3 cxd3 24.cxb4 ♙xa2 25.♞d1 ♙c8 26.♞xd3 ♙c1+ 27.♞e1 ♙cc2 28.♞e7 ♙g7 29.♘d2 – thanks to the idea ♞d3-f3, he manages to draw.

21...♘c4 22.♖d3 ♙fa8 23.b3 ♖xc3**24.♖xc3 ♙xc3 25.bxc4 ♙xa2****26.♙xa2 ♙xa2**

Black has the more active rook, and in White's camp the c4-pawn is weak and the white knight lacks prospects.

27.♞c1 ♙f6 28.♙f1**28...h5**

Black seizes space, but this is a little slow, and gives White a chance to become active. More accurate was 28...g5!, immediately threatening ...g5-g4. Then, 29.g4 does not solve the problem, because of 29...♙g6 with the idea of ...h6-h5.

29.♘e1?

Active play with 29.♖b1!, intending ♖b1-b6, gives some defensive chances.

**29...g5! 30.♖c2 ♖a1 31.♙e2 ♙g6
32.♘f3 ♙f5 33.♘d2 g4!**

It is useful to seize even more space, and take the f3-square from the white knight. Now, Black has created the threat of ...♖a1-f1, which previously made no sense in view of ♘d2-f3.

34.♘f1 ♙d4 35.♘d2

The rook ending is also lost, e.g.: 35.♘e3+ ♙xe3 36.♙xe3 ♖a3+ 37.♙e2 ♙e4 38.♖b2 ♘d4 39.♖b6 ♖a2+ 40.♙f1 ♙xc4 41.♖xd6 ♘d3 42.f3 ♙e3 43.♙g1 gxf3 44.gxf3 ♙xf3 45.♖f6+ ♙xg3 46.♖xf7 ♖d2.

**35...♙g1 36.♘b3 ♙e5 37.♘d2 ♖xg2
38.♙f1 ♖h2 39.♙g1 ♖h3 40.♘f1 h4
41.♙g2 hxg3 42.fxg3 ♙e4 43.♖f2
f6 44.♖a2 ♖h8**

White resigned.

216

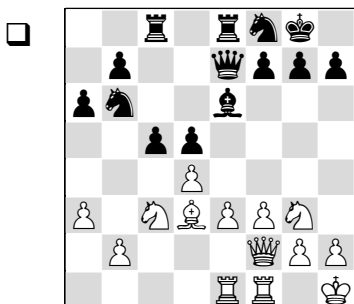
Evgeny Bareev

Artur Jussupov

Frankfurt rapid 2000 (14)

2709

2628



White's pieces are concentrated on the kingside. Given the strength of his centre, he has valid grounds for developing his initiative:

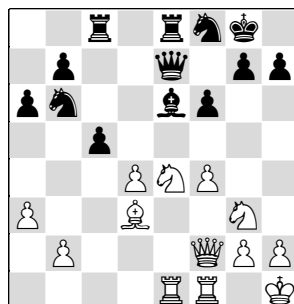
18.f4! f6

Otherwise, the white pawn comes to f6, and Black is weak on g7.

19.e4!

A good moment to open the game – while the enemy queen is under the eye of the rook on the e-file, White brings new forces into the attack, with tempo.

19...dxe4 20.♘cxe4



20...cxd4?

Black strives for simplification, but this costs him another tempo, which he could have spent on organising his defences.

Essential was 20...c4, although after 21.♙c2, the isolated d-pawn is a strength, not a weakness, since it helps with piece play, especially by granting the outpost on c5 for a white knight.

21.♘h5 ♙f7

More tenacious was 21...f5, although after 22.♘g5 ♙d6 23.♙g3 ♘g6 24.♙h3 ♘f8 25.♖xe6 ♖xe6 26.♙xf5 ♖ee8 (26...♖e3 27.♘g3+–) 27.♙xc8 ♖xc8 28.f5→, White's attack is still very dangerous.

22.♙h4

There is no defence against the simultaneous threats of ♘e4xf6+ and ♘d6.

22...♙c4 23.♘d6 ♖d7 24.♖xe8
 ♙xd3 25.♖g3 ♙g6 26.♖b3+
 ♚h8 27.♘xc8 ♖xe8 28.♘d6 ♖d7
 29.♖xb6 ♙xh5 30.♖xd4 ♖c6
 31.♗e1 h6 32.h3 ♘g6 33.♗e8+
 ♚h7 34.♖c4 ♘xf4 35.♖xc6 bxc6
 36.♗e7 ♙g8 37.♚h2 ♘d5 38.♖a7
 ♙e2 39.♘f5 g5 40.♘h6+ ♚f8
 41.♘f5 ♙e8 42.♘d4

Black resigned.

217

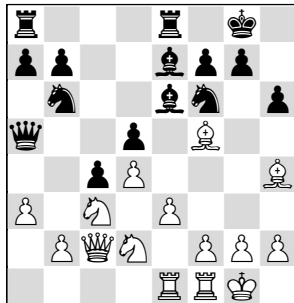
Vladimir Kramnik

2685

Grigory Serper

2590

Dortmund 1993 (3)



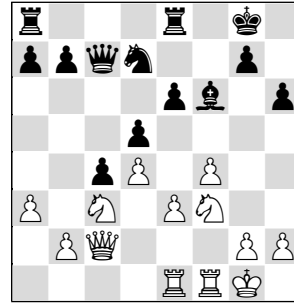
Usually in such structures, White tries to play e3-e4, and then play on the e-file and support his d-pawn with pieces. But in this example, he notices the subtlety that the black king is weak, and sharply changes his plan:

16.♙xe6! fx6 17.♙xf6!

An unstereotyped, brilliant positional decision! This exchange is strategically justified, because White is prepared not only to cement the pawn structure in the centre, but also to play to limit his opponent's bishop, by placing his pawns on dark squares.

17.e4 dxe4 18.♘dxe4 ♘xe4 19.♗xe4
 ♙xh4 20.♖xh4 ♖ad8 gives White only a minimal advantage – despite the defects in his pawn structure, Black's major pieces are active.

17...♙xf6 18.f4 ♘d7 19.♘f3 ♖c7



20.g4!

This is the real point of White's play! The dark-squared bishop is not a piece that can help much with the defence of the black king. White's attack develops of its own accord.

20...♘f8 21.g5

The knight on f8 is very passive, whilst White's position is so strong that he can even manage without 21.h4. Mind you, the latter was also strong – White builds up the attack, whilst keeping the centre closed.

21...h5 22.f5 23.e4

All of White's pieces are in the game, whilst Black's are spectators on the sides.

23...dxe4 24.♖xe4

He also wins with 24.♖xe4, with the idea of transferring the rook to h4.

24...♖ad8 25.♗e2 a6

Bad, but it is hard to suggest any other useful move.

26.♖g4 ♖a5 27.♘e5

Black resigned, since after 27...♖xd4 there follows 28.♖h5, and his king is defenceless.

218

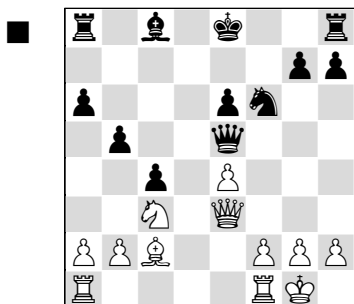
Vladimir Tukmakov

Evgeny Bareev

Elista 1998 (1)

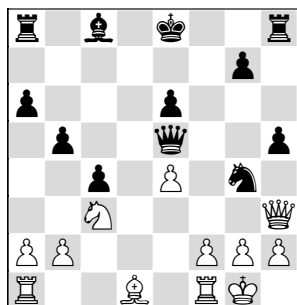
2610

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White is counting on playing f2-f4 and then e4-e5, opening up his bishop and ensuring e4 for his knight. Black, naturally, prevents this, but the method he uses is unsteretyped and aesthetically pleasing:

17...♖g4! 18.♗h3 h5 19.♙d1



19...g5!

The rook is defended, and f2-f4 is now impossible! But, where will the black king escape to? Actually nowhere, because it is safe where it is. And how will Black connect his rooks? This has also been thought about, and the answer is seen on the following move.

20.♙c1 ♖a7!

Very ambitious. The rook transfers to the kingside, where Black will

have a powerful pawn and piece mass.

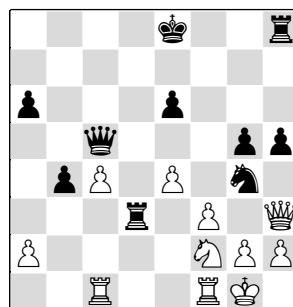
Also possible was the traditional 20...♙b7, with a good game.

21.b3

White tries to set up counterplay, but it is too late.

21...♖f7 22.♙f3

22.bxc4 b4 23.♙a4+ (23.♖b1 ♖xf2 24.♗e3 ♖g4 25.♙xg4 hxg4 26.g3 ♖f3 27.♖xf3 gxf3 28.♖d2 g4 29.c5 ♗b2 30.♖b1 ♗c2) 23...♙d7 24.♙xd7+ ♖xd7 25.♖d1 ♖d3 26.f3 ♗c5+ 27.♖f2



analysis diagram

27...♙d7!! 28.♗g3 ♖xf2 29.♗xf2 ♖c6. The queenside pawns are weak, so the resulting rook ending is dangerous for White.

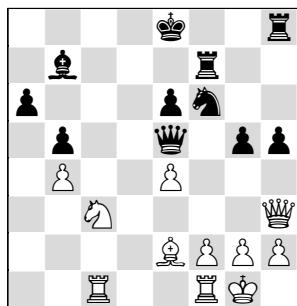
22...cxb3 23.axb3 ♙b7

All of Black's pieces have occupied harmonious positions.

24.b4 ♖f6 25.♙e2

Here, the bishop is shut in and badly placed.

It was better to simplify the game by 25.♗g3! ♗xg3 26.hxg3 g4 27.♙d1 h4 28.gxh4 ♖xh4 29.f3 gxf3 – although, despite the small number of pawns remaining, White is not guaranteed a draw, and he faces a long and unpleasant defence.

**25...0-0!**

The fact that the black pawns have advanced in front of the king is not serious, as he has many pieces round him. White's pieces, on the other hand, are far away and poorly placed.

26. ♖e3 ♘g4!

After the exchange on g4, it becomes hard for White to defend the pawn on e4, as he loses the chance to play f2-f3.

27. ♙xg4 hxg4 28. ♘e2?

White settles for the loss of a pawn, but somewhat prematurely. More tenacious was 28. ♖g3!, after which Black does best to answer 28... ♖f4!±, offering to go into the endgame in a more favourable form (28... ♖xg3 29. hxg3 gives Black only a minimal advantage).

28... ♖xe4 29. ♖xe4 ♙xe4

As a result of the simplifications, Black has an extra pawn, which, in conjunction with his more active pieces, gives him a decisive advantage.

30. ♘d4 ♙d5 31. ♘c6 ♖f4 32. ♘e7+ ♙g7 33. ♘xd5 exd5 34. ♖fd1 ♖8f5 35. ♖c6 ♖f6 36. ♖c7+ ♙g6 37. ♖xd5 ♖xb4 38. h3 gxh3 39. ♖cc5 ♖g4 40. g3 b4 41. ♙h2 b3 42. ♙xh3 b2 43. ♖d1 ♖b4 44. ♖b1 ♖xf2+

White resigned.

Additional material

Nimzowitsch-Capablanca, St Petersburg 1914

Petrosian-Geller, Moscow 1961

Ljubojevic-Beliavsky, Tilburg 1984 – Black's 23rd move

Petrosian-Spassky, Moscow Wch (match/20) 1969

Capablanca-Marshall, Morristown (match/6) 1909

Botvinnik-Alatortsev, Leningrad 1934

Taimanov-Najdorf, Zurich 1953

Botvinnik-Smyslov, Moscow Wch (match/2) 1954

Gligoric-Larsen, Havana 1967

Spassky-Geller, Sukhumi (match/6) 1968

Dolmatov-S.Ivanov, St Petersburg 1998 – White's 17th move

Kasparov-Csom, Baku 1980 – White's 14th move

Yuferov-Kasparov, Minsk 1978

Kasparov-Miles, Basel (match/1) 1986

Kasparov-Tal, Brussels 1987

Piket-Kasparov, Tilburg 1989

Gelfand-Kasparov, Linares 1990

Kortchnoi-Kasparov, Amsterdam 1991

Karpov-Kasparov, Skelleftea 1989

Karpov-Kasparov, Reggio Emilia 1991/92

Chapter 27

Transferring the king from flank to flank

In the endgame, where the king is a self-sufficient fighting unit, manoeuvring it from flank to flank is a perfectly ordinary thing, but in the middlegame, this happens quite rarely. More often, the king is chased out of its hiding place by enemy pieces and forced to flee into the centre, where it usually ends up getting mated. Such themes will be examined under 'Dynamics'. But here, we will look at cases where the king goes on a voluntary journey, with a board full of pieces, in search of a safe refuge elsewhere on the board. This occurs most often in closed positions, with the aim of preparing a storm on the flank the king has left.

219

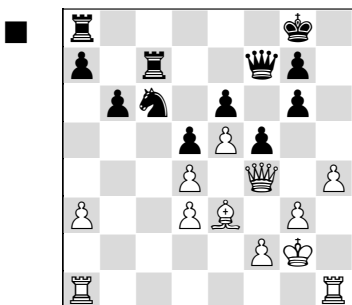
**

35. ♖c3 ♜c8 36. ♔d2

Jesus Diez del Corral

Tigran Petrosian

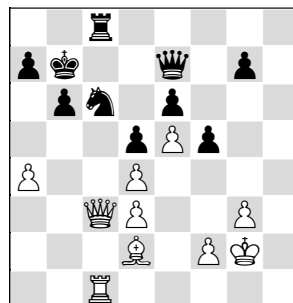
Palma de Mallorca 1969 (14)



White is preparing to open the h-file and give mate. But the position is closed, and so Black uses the tempi at his disposal to evacuate the king to a safer zone:

22... ♖f8! 23. ♖g5 ♖e8 24. ♜ac1 ♖d7 25. h5 gxf5 26. ♜xf5 ♜g8 27. ♜h7 ♖c8 28. ♖h4 ♖g6 29. ♜h8 ♜xh8 30. ♖xh8+ ♖b7 31. ♖f8 ♜c8 32. ♖d6 ♖e8 33. a4 ♜d8 34. ♖a3 ♖e7

The endgame favours Black, and, exploiting this fact, he drives the enemy queen out of his camp.



36...g5!

Not long ago, the g7-pawn needed defending, and the dark squares on the kingside were weak. Now, however, the threat is ...f5-f4, restricting the dark-squared bishop, and breaking open the white king's pawn cover. And Black also has in reserve the move ...g5-g4, getting the pawn out from under attack, and intensifying his grip on the light squares.

37. ♖c2 f4! 38. gxf4 gxf4 39. ♔xf4 ♜g8+ 40. ♔g3 ♜xd4 41. ♖c3 ♔e2 42. ♖c6+ ♖b8 43. ♔e1 ♜f4+ 44. ♖f1 ♜xd3 45. ♔b1 ♖f7! 46. ♖d6+ ♖b7 47. ♔e2 ♜c8

47...♖h7 was also winning.

48.a5 ♖c2+ 49.♟f1 ♜xf2 50.♞xb6+ axb6 51.♞xb6+ ♟c8 52.♞a6+ ♟b8 53.♞b6+ ♞b7 54.♞d6+ ♞c7

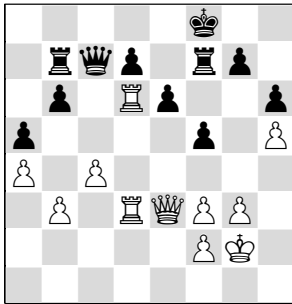
White resigned.

220

Konstantin Landa
Mircea Parligras
France tt 2009 (4)

2627

2586



As a result of the opening battle, White has obtained an advantage in the middlegame. The game could be decided by an unhurried transfer of his king to the opposite flank.

35.♞e5!

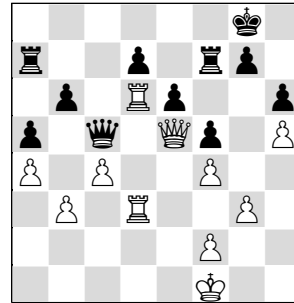
In the game, White was in a hurry to grab 'what he was due': 35.g4? fxg4 36.fxg4 ♟g8 37.♞d4 ♞b8 38.f3 ♞c7 39.♞e3 ♞b8 40.♞e4 ♞c7 41.♞g6?! (allowing the activation of the black queen; slightly stronger was 41.♞e5±). 41...♞c5! 42.♞xd7 ♞bxd7 43.♞xd7 ♞xd7 44.♞e8+ ♟h7 45.♞xd7 ♞e3 46.♞d1 e5! (White still has a small advantage, but he is not winning) 47.♞b1+ ♟g8 48.♞c2 ♟h8 49.♞e4 ♞xb3 50.♞xe5 ♞xa4 51.♞b8+ ♟h7 52.♞xb6 ♞c2+ 53.♟g3 a4 54.♞a6 ♟h8 55.♟f4 ♞c1+ 56.♟e4 a3, with a draw.

35...♞a7

35...♞c5? leads to the loss of a pawn: 36.♞xc5 bxc5 37.♞a6±.

36.f4 ♟g8 37.♟f1 ♞b7

On 37...♞c5, White wins beautifully:



analysis diagram

38.♞xe6! dxe6 39.♞b8+ ♟h7 (39...♞f8 40.♞xa7 ♞c6 41.♟g1+–; 39...♞f8 40.♞d8 ♞xd8 41.♞xd8+ ♟h7 42.♞xb6+–) 40.♞d8+–.

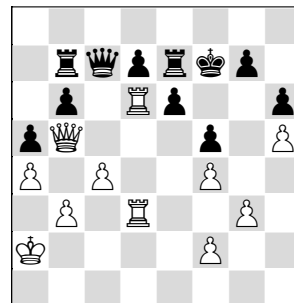
38.♟e2 ♞e7 39.♟d2 ♞c8

The black king is not able to emulate his opposite number by fleeing to the queenside: 39...♟f8 40.♟c2 ♟e8 41.♟b2 ♟d8? 42.♞xe6+–.

40.♞b5

40.♟c2 ♞e8 41.♞d4±.

40...♞c7 41.♟c2 ♟h8 42.♟b2 ♟g8 43.♟a2 ♟f7



44.f3!

With his king on the queenside, White can calmly prepare a breakthrough on the kingside.

44...♟g8 45.g4 ♞f7

Or 45...fxg4 46.fxg4 ♖f7 47.f5!
exf5 48.gxf5 ♜b8 49.♗d5 ♜bf8
50.f6+–.

46.g5 ♜e7 47.♗e5 ♜c8 48.♞d2

White has excellent winning chances (analysis).

221

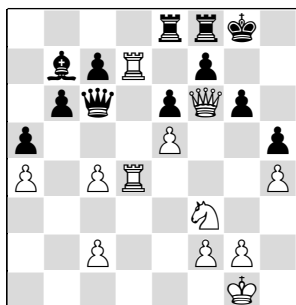
Nigel Short

Jan Timman

Tilburg 1991 (4)

2660

2630



Black is completely tied up, but landing the final blow is not easy, as the ♖f3 is pinned. Seeing the open road on the dark squares, White decided with decisive effect to include in the attack... his king!

31.♔h2!!

On a wide-open board, with all of the pieces on, the king launches a long raid into the heart of the enemy position – a very rare thing!

31...♜c8

If Black takes the pressure off the long diagonal with 31...♜c8, White wins by 32.♞g5! ♜xd7 33.♜f4+–.

32.♞g5! ♜ce8 33.♞f4 ♜c8 34.♞g5

There is no defence against the king's arrival on h6, so Black resigned.

222

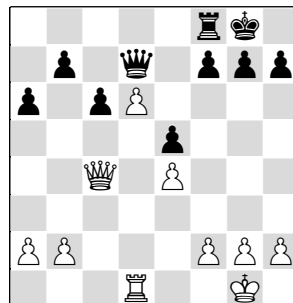
Vladimir Genba

Alexander Moiseenko

St Petersburg 2000 (8)

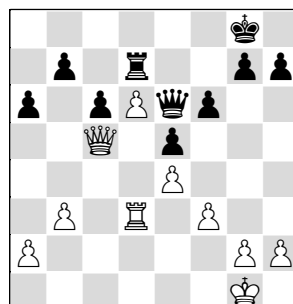
2450

2570



White has a clear advantage – the passed pawn on d6 is very strong, but as often happens, it is not so easy to win. There are no weaknesses in the black camp.

**25.♗c5 f6 26.f3 ♞d8 27.♞d3 ♗e6
28.b3 ♞d7**



So, Black has taken full control of the d6-pawn, and defended his base at b7.

Many players would have decided that it was time to sign the scoresheet, as it seems that White's position cannot be strengthened, but the white player found a way to complicate his opponent's life. Of course, after careful preparation.

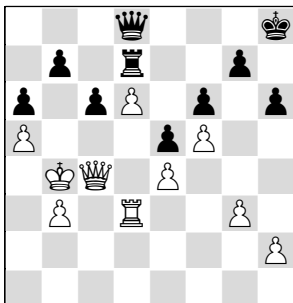
29.♔f2! h6 30.♖e2 ♘f7 31.♙d2
 ♘g6 32.♙c3 ♘f7 33.a4 ♘g6
 33...a5? 34.♚xa5 ♚xd6 35.♚c7+-.
34.a5!

He cannot get right through the eye of the needle: 34.♙b4 ♘h7 35.♙a5 ♚e8!, and the king must go back.

34...♘h7 35.♙b4 ♘h8 36.♙a3
 ♚e8 37.♙b4 ♚g8 38.g3 ♚e8
 38...♚e6 39.♚d2 ♘h7 (39...♙g8?
 40.♚c4 ♘f7? 41.♙c5 ♚xc4+ 42.bxc4
 ♙e6 43.♙b6+-) 40.♙a3 (40.♚c4
 ♚e8 41.♙c5 ♚b8!) 40...♘h8 41.♚c4
 ♚e8 (41...♚xd6 42.♚xe6 ♚xe6
 43.♚d7), and White can return to the plan used in the game: 42.f4 ♘h7 43.f5±.

39.♚c4 ♘h7 40.f4 ♘h8
 40...exf4 41.gxf4 ♘h8 42.♚d4 ♚e6
 43.e5+-.

41.f5 ♚d8

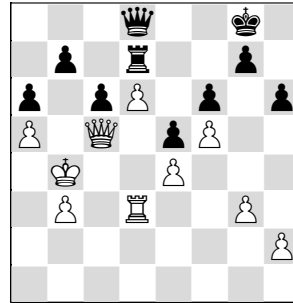


42.♚e6?!

The critical moment. White deviates from the correct path, although this becomes apparent only after analysis.

Correct was 'do not hurry!'. Black has to await his fate anyway. Strong here was 42.♚c5! ♘g8, and now strengthen the position on the kingside:

The principle of two weaknesses



analysis diagram

43.g4! ♘f8 44.h4 ♘g8 (44...♚e8
 45.♚c4 ♚d8 46.♚e6 b6 47.g5 bxa5+
 48.♙a3 a4 49.gxf6 gxf6 50.♚g3 ♚f7
 51.b4 a5 52.bxa5!+-) 45.g5 – and
 White should win.

42...c5+?

Black misses a chance to equalise the game: 42...b6! 43.g4! (43.axb6 ♚xb6+ 44.♙c3 ♚c5+ 45.♙b2 ♚f2+ 46.♙a3 ♚c5+ 47.b4 ♚c1+=) 43...bxa5+ 44.♙a3. (Black cannot wait, as the terrible threat of g4-g5 is on the agenda) 44...a4! (44...♘h7 45.g5! fxg5 46.♚xe5 ♚b6 47.♚c3+-; 44...♚c8 45.g5+-) 45.b4 (45.bxa4? c5! 46.g5 c4 47.♚xc4 ♚xd6=; 45.♙xa4 c5 46.g5 fxg5 47.♚xe5 ♚b6 48.♙a3 ♚b4+ 49.♙a2 c4, with sufficient counterplay) 45...a5 46.bxa5 ♚xa5 47.♚xd7 ♚c5+ 48.♙b2 ♚f2+ 49.♙c1 ♚c5+ 50.♙d1 ♚g1+ 51.♙c2 ♚c5+ – White cannot avoid perpetual check.

43.♙c4! ♘h7 44.g4 ♚c8 45.♚d5

Now, Black has no chance of surviving.

45...♚d8 46.♚xc5 ♚d7 47.♙b4
 ♚c8 48.♚d5 ♚c1 49.♚c3 ♚e1
 50.♚c7 ♚d8 51.♙c5 ♚c1+ 52.♙b6
 ♚c6+ 53.♙xb7 ♚xd6 54.♚f7 ♚g8

55. ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 56. ♖c6 ♖d3 57. b4
♖d4 58. b5

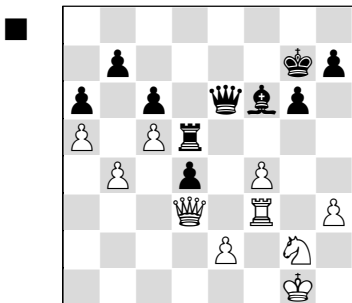
Black resigned.

223

Max Euwe

Efim Geller

Zurich ct 1953 (17)



In the event of any lines being opened, the black king will come under unpleasant checks. Taking into account the passivity of White's pieces, which are tied to the defence of his weak pawns, Black transfers his king to safety:

42... ♖f7! 43. ♖f2

White also had available a subtle transfer, which could have eased his defence: 43. ♖e1!, with the idea of ♖e1-c2-a3-c4.

43... ♖e7! 44. ♖f1 ♖d8 45. ♖e1

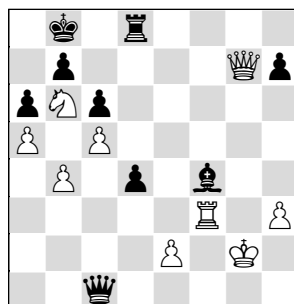
White finds the correct plan, a little late.

45... ♖c7 46. ♖c2 ♖b8 47. ♖a3 ♖d8

48. ♖c4 ♖c7 49. ♖b6 ♖d8 50. f5

The black king has already fled, and White opens lines along which his own will come under attack. It was more tenacious to run on the spot, although it is hard to defend against a plan such as ... ♖b8-a7 and the activation of the rook.

50... gxf5 51. ♖xf5 ♖h6 52. ♖f7
♖c1+ 53. ♖f2 ♖h2 54. ♖g7 ♖f4
55. ♖g2



55... ♖e3?

The most precise path to the win was to complete the general strategic idea: 55... ♖a7!, with numerous unstoppable threats.

The active 55... ♖d2 56. ♖f2 ♖e3 57. ♖g4 ♖c7 also retained a decisive advantage.

56. ♖f1?

White misses his fleeting chance. He could have saved himself with the paradoxical 56. ♖f7! ♖g1+ 57. ♖f3 – the king comes into the centre! Black has nothing better than perpetual check.

56... ♖d2 57. ♖f7 ♖xe2+ 58. ♖g3
♖e1+ 59. ♖f3 ♖h1+ 60. ♖g3 ♖g1+
61. ♖f3 ♖f2+ 62. ♖e4 ♖e8+ 63. ♖e7
♖h4+ 0-1

224

Vugar Gashimov

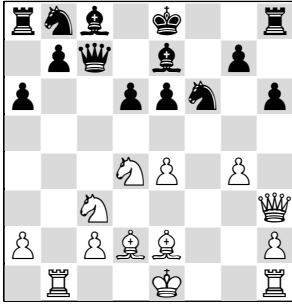
2759

Alexander Grischuk

2736

Bursa Wch tt 2010 (4)

1. e4 c5 2. ♖f3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. ♖xd4
♖f6 5. ♖c3 a6 6. ♖g5 e6 7. f4 ♖b6
8. ♖d3 ♖xb2 9. ♖b1 ♖a3 10. f5
♖e7 11. fxe6 fxe6 12. ♖e2 ♖a5
13. ♖d2 ♖c7 14. g4 h6 15. ♖h3



The game has started with one of the sharpest of Sicilian variations. In this line, one of the most topical, White has a dangerous initiative for the pawn. But it is of a non-concrete character, consisting of superior development and a potential attack on the light squares. Black, however, as well as his extra pawn, also has his positional trumps – his position is compact, and his pieces quite well centralised.

The threat now is g4-g5. Black has a wide choice of defensive ideas, but it is hard to prefer one above all, as White has compensation in all lines. As a result, Black's choice was the far from obvious, original, but also unfortunate move:

15...♖h7?!

Let us consider other possibilities:

A) He does not solve his problems with the direct 15...♖c6 16.♖xc6 bxc6 (16...♗xc6 17.g5) 17.g5 e5 18.♗h4 ♖d7 19.♗h5+ ♖d8 20.♗f7 ♗f8 21.♗xg7 ♖xg5 22.♖xg5+ hxc5 23.♗xg5+ ♖f6 24.♗f1 ♗e7 25.h4! – White has the initiative;

B) If 15...g5, 16.♗f1!, and the ♖f6 becomes unstable;

C) A double-edged position results from 15...♗f8 16.g5 e5 17.♖e6 ♖xe6

18.♗xe6 hxc5 19.♖d5 ♖xd5 20.♗xd5 ♖c6 21.♖h5+ ♖d8∞;

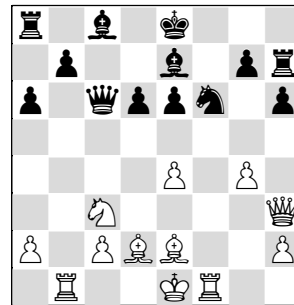
D) One other possibility consists of 15...e5 16.♖f5 ♖xf5 17.gxf5 ♖bd7 18.♗g1 ♗g8 – White retains compensation for the pawn, but Black has kept the position closed and avoided the attack. The king has chances to evacuate to the queen-side, whilst the break ...d6-d5 can in the future start counterplay on the dark squares.

16.♗f1!

The battle for the initiative continues.

16.g5 hxc5 17.♖xe6 ♗c6 18.♗f5 ♖xe6 19.♗xe6 ♗d7 could soon have led to an endgame, with good equalising chances for Black.

16...♖c6 17.♖xc6 ♗xc6



18.e5!

Forcing play.

A good and quieter continuation was 18.♗d3, after which White probably did not like 18...e5 (18...♗h8 19.e5 dxe5 20.♗g6+ ♖f8 21.♖e4 ♗e8 22.♗xf6+ ♖xf6 23.♖b4+ ♖e7 24.♖xe7+ ♗xe7 25.♗b3 ♖g8 26.♗f3 ♖d7 27.♖f6+ ♗xf6 28.♗xf6 ♖e8 29.♗e4 gxf6 30.♗xb7 ♖d8 31.♗e7+–). However, after 19.♖d5 ♖e6 20.♗b6 ♖xd5 21.♗xc6 ♖xc6 22.♗h3!, the

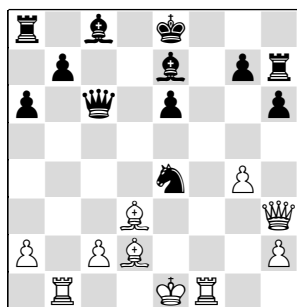
initiative remains on his side. It is not even a question of the queen, for which Black has sufficient material equivalent, but of the disruption of his piece coordination (it is hard to connect his rooks).

18...dxe5 19.♔d3 e4!

An excellent defence.

19...♖h8 20.g5 ♘d7 (20...♘d5 21.♙g6+ ♔d8 22.♘xd5 exd5 23.♙a5+ b6 24.♖xb6+→) 21.♘e4→ would permit White to increase the attacking potential of his pieces.

20.♘xe4! ♘xe4



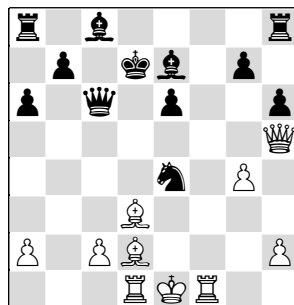
21.♞h5+

White cannot resist the chance to strand the black king in the centre. But this is precisely what Black was counting on, as now his pieces start to counterattack, whilst his king is safe on a board full of pieces, in the middle of events. The numerous checks do not bother him – a rare case!

Stronger was 21.♞e3! ♘xd2 (21...♙h4+ 22.♔d1 ♘f6 23.♙g6+ ♔e7 24.♖b6+→; 21...♘f6 22.♙g6+ ♔d8 23.♙a5+ ♔d7 24.♖d1+ ♘d5 25.♖f7 ♖h8 26.♞e5+→) 22.♙g6+ ♔d8 23.♞xd2+ ♔d7 24.♙xh7 ♖c8± – White's chances are superior, but the whole battle lies ahead.

21...♔d7 22.♖d1 ♖h8!

Very calm. The rook moves away from the attack at just the moment when White cannot crush Black down the d-file.



23.♙f4?

Now, White has problems with his king.

23.♞e5 retains compensation, when the possible continuation 23...♙h4+ 24.♔e2 ♙f6 25.♞xe4 ♞xe4+ 26.♙xe4 ♔e7 27.♙b4+ ♔f7 leads to an equal endgame.

A logical conclusion to the battle could be 23.♖f7 ♘d6 24.♙b4 ♖f8 25.♙xd6 ♖xf7 (25...♞c3+ 26.♔e2 ♙xd6 27.♙e4+ ♔c7 28.♖xf8 ♙xf8 29.♞f7+ ♔b8 30.♞xf8 ♞e5 31.♔f3=) 26.♞xf7 ♞c3+ 27.♔f2 ♙xd6 28.♙g6+ ♔c7 29.♞xe7+ ♔b6 30.♖d6+ ♔a7 31.♙d3 ♞d2+, with perpetual check.

23...♙b4+! 24.c3 ♘xc3 25.♙d2 ♞d5!

White has pieces hanging, whilst the black king has an open road to the queenside.

26.♖f7+ ♔c6 27.♖c1 ♔b6

The bishop could also have been taken: 27...♞xd3 28.♞e5 a5! 29.♖xc3+ (29.♙xc3 ♔b6+→) 29...♙xc3 30.♖c7+ ♔b6 31.♖xc3 ♞b1+ 32.♖c1 ♞b5

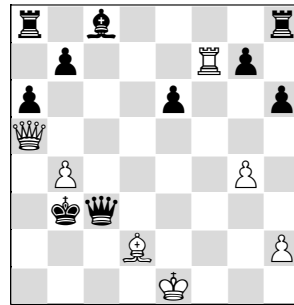
33.♔d4+ ♚a6 34.♖c5 ♜b1+ 35.♖c1
♜d8 36.♜xd8 ♜e4+ 37.♚f2 ♜d5
38.♜xd5 exd5, leading to a winning
endgame.

28.♙e3+

More tenacious was 28.♖xc3,
although after 28...♙xc3 29.♙xc3
♜d8 30.♜xd5 exd5 31.♙d4+ ♚a5
32.♖xg7 b5±, White has few chances
of saving the game – the black king
is ready soon to break through to
the a2-pawn.

**28...♚a5 29.a3 ♚a4! 30.axb4
♜xd3 31.♜a5+ ♚b3 32.♖xc3+
♜xc3+ 33.♙d2**

Dynamics – zwischenzug



33...b6!

Removing the white queen from
her active position, and winning a
decisive tempo for development.

**34.♜xb6 ♜e5+ 35.♚d1 ♙b7!
36.♜xb7 ♜hd8 37.♖f3+ ♚a2
38.♖f2 ♚b1 39.♜f3 ♜ac8 40.♜b3+
♜b2 41.♜xb2+ ♚xb2 0-1**

Additional material

Schlechter-Lasker, Vienna Wch (match/5) 1910

Chapter 28

'Superfluous' pieces

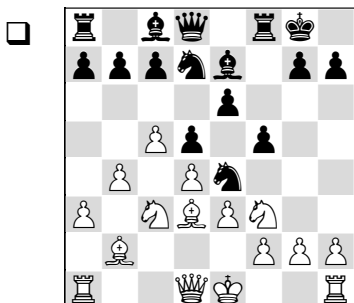
This term was coined by the well-known chess researcher Mark Dvoretsky. It refers to a situation when two different pieces (usually knights) are after the same well-protected square. Since both cannot occupy it at the same time, it is useful to exchange one of the pieces, since otherwise it will have to occupy some inferior post. The defending side in such a case should usually avoid the exchange.

225

Tigran Petrosian

Robert Fischer

Bled/Zagreb/Belgrade ct 1959 (9)



Black would like to exchange off his knight at e4, and then bring the knight from d7 to that square, or, after protecting the centre with ...c7-c6, to play ...e6-e5. White does not allow this, avoiding the exchange of the strong-looking centralised knight:

11. dxe2!

This move has several ideas:

- 1) The diagonal of the ♖b2 is opened somewhat;
- 2) The ♘e4 is not there forever, but can be expelled by a later f2-f3;
- 3) White has a space advantage, so he does well not to exchange pieces for no particular reason.

*

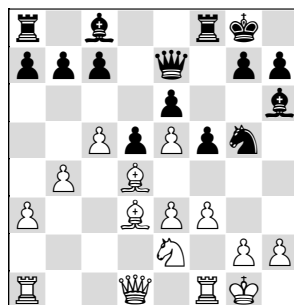
11... ♖f6 12. 0-0 ♜e7 13. ♘e5!

Now, Black can forget about playing ...e6-e5.

13... ♘xe5 14. dxe5 ♙g5 15. ♙d4

Whiter cements the centre, covering the square e3.

15... ♙h6 16. f3 ♘g5



17. c6!

Now, Black's queenside is well and truly sealed up.

17... b6 18. b5

The ♙c8 has no chance to come into play, and Black's position is hopeless.

18... a6 19. a4 axb5 20. axb5 ♜xa1 21. ♜xa1 ♘f7 22. ♜c3 ♜h4 23. ♜a1 ♘g5 24. ♜e1 ♜h5 25. ♜a7 ♜g6 26. ♘h1 ♜h5 27. f4 ♘e4 28. ♜xc7 g5 29. ♙xb6 ♘h8 30. ♙xe4 fxe4 31. ♙c5 ♜g8

Black resigned. Looking at this game, some readers may be surprised

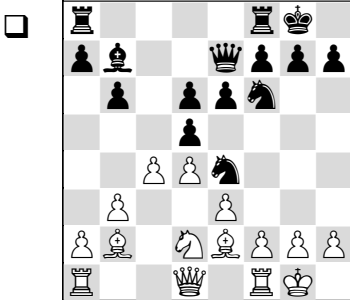
by its one-sidedness, and the low level of Black’s play, since, after all, it was Bobby Fischer playing Black! But the point is that, at the time of this game, Fischer was only 16, and at such an age, stability is often not a quality that is well-developed. Only constant effort and work can produce real results.

226

Johannes Zukertort

Joseph Blackburne

London 1883



The pawns on c4 and d5 will inevitably be exchanged, which will open some space and slightly enliven the ♗b2. With two bishops and more space, White has some advantage. Black does not even have counterplay on the light squares, since at any moment, White can play f2-f3, restricting Black’s minor pieces. One can also note that the two black knights get in each other’s way – they cannot both occupy e4 at the same time, yet there is no decent retreat square for the knight on e4.

13. ♖b1!

With a space advantage, it usually pays to avoid exchanges. The knight comes here, so as on the next move

to kick the knight on e4 with the move f2-f3, and drive it to a passive position.

In the game White played less strongly, agreeing to the exchange after 13.f3 ♘xd2 14. ♖xd2±.

Now, the knight on e4 is in trouble, and after, for example,

13...h6

(or 13...♘d7 14.f3 ♘ef6 15.♘c3 dxc4 16.bxc4±)

14.f3 ♘g5 15.♘c3 dxc4 16.bxc4 e5

17. ♖d2±

White, not the least bit behind in development, has retained all the advantages of his position.

227

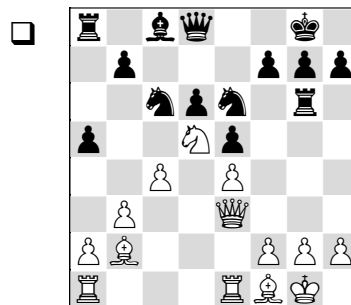
Alexander Khalifman

2655

Ruslan Sherbakov

2520

Elista ch-RUS 1995 (1)



One of the black knights will inevitably land on the outpost d4, but the other will have to stay where it is, to defend its colleague. This circumstance is what determines White’s advantage.

20. ♘b6!

The exchange of his queen’s bishop deprives Black of any hope of developing an initiative on the kingside.

20...♖b8 21.♘xc8 ♜xc8 22.♖ac1
♙h4 23.g3 ♙h5 24.♙g2 ♜h6 25.h3
♜f6

On 25...♘g5, there would follow
26.h4 ♘e6 27.♙f3 ♙g6 28.h5 ♙f6
29.♙g4, seizing space.

26.♙e2 ♙h6?!

With queens on the board, the
prospect of White playing f2-f4 is
unpleasant. In addition, Black has
less space, and exchanges in general
help him. 26...♙xe2! 27.♖xe2 a4
would have left White with only a
minimal advantage.

27.♙c3 ♘ed4 28.♙e3 ♙h5?!

Now, going into the ending is worse
for Black than it was a couple of
moves ago, but even so, he should
have done it.

29.f4 exf4

Otherwise, the pawn comes to f5,
cramping Black.

30.gxf4 ♙c5 31.♘h1 ♜h6 32.f5!

The knight on f4 has its retreat cut
off and is now lost.

32...♜e8 33.♙a1 f6 34.♙d3

Black resigned, because he has no
defence against ♜c1-d1.

228

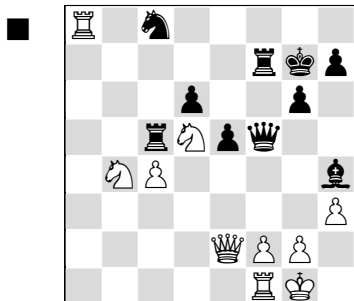
Anatoly Karpov

Sergey Dolmatov

Amsterdam 1980 (5)

2725

2535

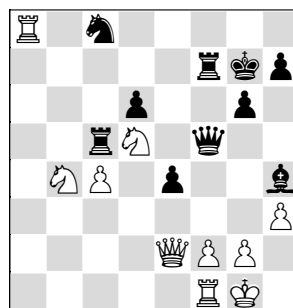


White has a solid advantage, thanks
to his control of the light squares.
The only thing that makes it hard
to realise his advantage is the
'superfluous' knight on b4, which
cannot get to d5, because this square
is already occupied. It must be said
that the position of Black's ♘c8
is also very unfortunate – if, for
example, he could play the move
...♘c8-e6, Black would get excellent
counterplay. After the exchange in
the game,

34...♘e7

... Black landed in a classic position
with no counterplay, and a bad
bishop against a great blockading
knight. Defending such a position is
very hard, as White's play is easy and
pleasant.

From a practical point of view, it
was worth considering 34...e4!?,
potentially bringing his ♙g7 to
life, and giving his queen the good
square e5.



analysis diagram

Admittedly, after 35.♖a3!! ♘e7
36.♜e3 ♘xd5 37.♘xd5 ♜a5 38.g3! ♙g5
39.f4, White has excellent winning
chances, but it would be far from
easy to find such a narrow and far
from obvious path. Consequently,
we can conclude that Black missed

an excellent chance to complicate the struggle, and instead remained in a passive position, without counterplay. When in a difficult position, it is essential to make the opponent's task as difficult as possible, and present him with practical problems.

35. ♖a6

The knight c8 was fulfilling a function after all – defending the d6-pawn!

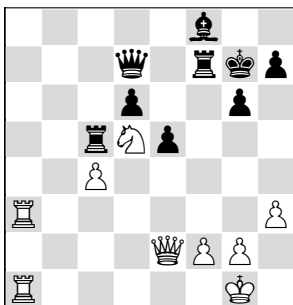
35... ♖d7?!

If the knight returns to c8, White regroups his forces with 36. ♘c3! – from b4, the knight goes to d5, whilst its colleague on e4 is no longer ‘superfluous’, since it has a direct path to e4.

But it was now essential to seize the chance of activating his position by playing 35... ♘xd5! 36. ♘xd5 ♙e4!. Thanks to the activity of his pieces, Black retains good prospects of a draw.

36. ♖e4 ♘xd5 37. ♘xd5 ♙e7
38. ♖fa1 ♙f8 39. ♖e2 ♖c6 40. ♖a3
♖c5

Dynamics – the importance of the 7th rank



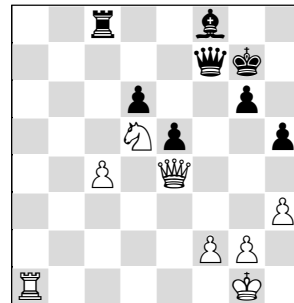
41. ♖f3!

By exchanging the king's most important defender, White lays the grounds for a mating attack.

41... ♖xf3 42. ♖xf3 ♖f7 43. ♖g4

43. ♖b3 would have won more rapidly, by immediately preparing the penetration of White's major pieces into the enemy camp, down the a- and b-files.

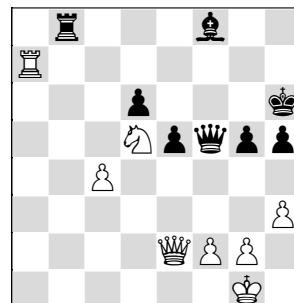
43... h5 44. ♖e4 ♖c8



45. ♖a3!

From here, the rook is ready to transfer to the kingside also.

45... ♖f5 46. ♖a7+ ♙h6 47. ♖e3+ g5
48. ♖e2 ♖b8



49. g4!

Looking at this move, the bishop must have been remembering with regret the missed opportunities to activate itself at moves 34 and 35.

49... hxc4 50. hxc4 ♖b1+ 51. ♙g2
♖b7 52. ♖xb7 ♖xb7 53. ♖f3 ♖c8
54. ♖f6+ ♙h7 55. ♖f7+ 1-0

Chapter 29

Paying attention to the opponent's possibilities. Loss of concentration

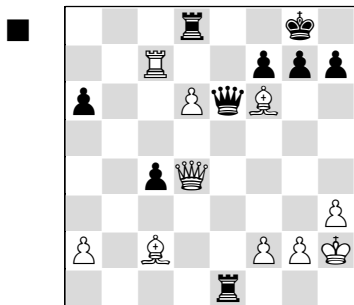
In this chapter, we will look at a very common phenomenon – underestimating the opponent, or prematurely relaxing in a winning or favourable position. Of course, it is useful mainly to look at examples where players conduct their advantage to victory, without any lapses. But as Emanuel Lasker correctly pointed out: 'the hardest thing in chess is to win a winning position!'. All the while, the opponent has not resigned, the game is still continuing, and one cannot lose concentration!

229

Mikhail Tal

Efim Geller

Riga ch-URS 1958 (12)



Both players had conducted the game at a very high level, and now after 25...Qxf6 26.Qxf6 gxf6 27.d7 Qg7 (Black is also not better after 27...Qf8 28.Qxh7= – the bishop will soon entrench itself on f5) 28.Qf5 Re5 29.Rc8 Rxf5 30.Rxd8 Rd5, a draw should have resulted.

However, for a moment, Black thought he could win, and he played

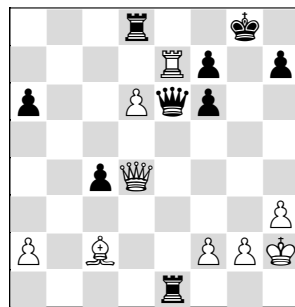
25...gxf6??

The fact that such a strong opponent would hardly allow such

★

a simple win should have warned Black that something might be wrong. Before playing the 'winning move', one should always check two or three times that one has not missed anything. If Black had done this here, he would not have lost.

26.Re7



26...Qxd6+

What Black had missed was that after 26...Qxe7, the white queen moves out of the pin with check: 27.Qg4+!

27.Qxd6 Rxd6 28.Rxe1 Rd2 29.Rc1 Rxf2 30.Qe4 Rxa2 31.Rxc4 a5 32.Rc8+ Qg7 33.Rc7

Black resigned.

230

David Navara

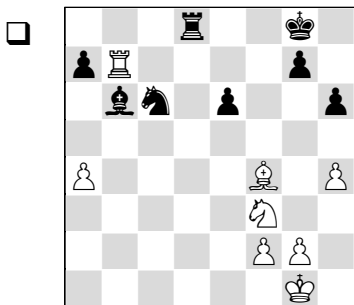
2705

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Anish Giri

2732

Warsaw Ech tt 2013 (6)



The small amount of material remaining and the absence of serious weaknesses on either side suggests a strong drawing tendency. However, there followed

27. ♖e3?

He could have played the strengthening move 27.g3, after which a logical reply is 27...♗d5, preparing ...e6-e5 – the position is equal.

Quicker simplifications could have resulted from 27.♘e5, and then, for example, 27...♗f8 28.♘g6 ♗f7 29.♗xf7 ♕xf7 30.♘e5+ ♘xe5 31.♖xe5, with a draw.

27... ♗d1+!

White probably only counted on something such as 27...♖xe3 28.fxe3 ♗b8 29.♗c7 ♗b6, with a slightly more active, though still drawn position. Or maybe, he thought he could play whatever he liked, as it would still be a draw.

28. ♖h2 ♘d8!

It turns out that the white rook has no safe square. A rare thing, but it happens! After

29. ♗xb6

(nothing much is changed by 29.♗e7 ♕f8)

29...axb6 30. ♖xb6 ♘c6 31.a5 ♗a1

Black realised his extra exchange.

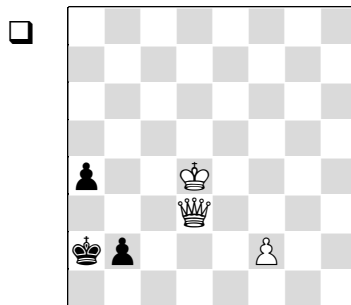
231

Frederick Yates

Frank Marshall

Carlsbad 1929 (9)

*



White has a winning position, but in chess, it is never quite as easy to win a position as it first seems. White had either already mentally chalked up the point, or he had never seen Réti's famous pawn ending study.

1. ♖c2

In the game, there followed 1.♕c4?? b1♗ 2.♗xb1+ ♕xb1 3.♕b4

Reti's idea

3...♕b2!! 4.♕xa4 ♕c3, and it turned out that the black king was in the square.

1...a3 2. ♕c4

Also possible is 2.♕c3 ♕a1 3.♕b3 b1♗ 4.♗xb1+ ♕xb1 5.♕a3 ♕c2 6.f4+-.

2...♕a1 3. ♖c3

3.♕b3+-.

3...♕a2 4. ♖b3+

Winning.

232

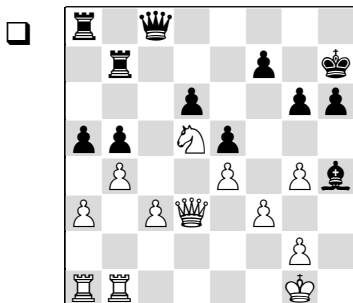
Zbynek Hracek

2595

Zoltan Almasi

2590

Odorheiu Secuiesc zt 1995 (4)



White has an obvious positional advantage, as his knight is very strong, and he has great chances to develop his initiative on the queenside.

However, he needs to develop a plan, and also to pay some regard to his opponent's intentions. Black has only one active idea, namely to play ...♗h4-g3, with the threat of bringing his queen to h4. With his next prophylactic move, White not only prevents this, but also removes his king from possible checks on the diagonal.

34.♖h2! ♕d8 35.g3!

Now, not only does the white king feel safe, but Black's bishop is restricted.

35...♗g5 36.a4!

If this energetic move had not been so strong, White would have chosen the general reinforcing move 36.♖g2.

36...axb4 37.♖xb4 ♖b8 38.♖b1!

Black cannot escape from the pin on the b-file.

38...♖a7 39.a5

The other winning line was 39.axb5 ♖xa1 40.♖xa1 ♖xb5 41.♖a6 ♖xb4 42.cxb4 – the passed pawn decides the outcome of the game.

39...♖a6 40.c4 ♗d8 41.♖xb5 ♖xb5

42.cxb5 ♖xa5 43.♖xa5 ♗xa5 44.b6

Black resigned.

233

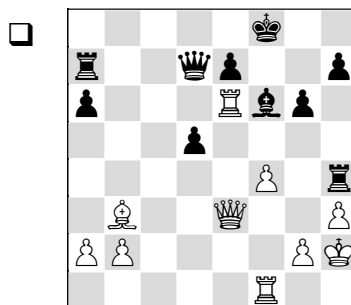
Konstantin Landa

2639

Laszlo Gonda

2520

Germany Bundesliga 2011/12 (3)



White has an overwhelming advantage. This consists not only in the possibility of an attack on the king, with opposite-coloured bishops, but also in Black's rooks, scattered on opposite sides of the board. In addition, Black was in serious time-trouble.

28.g3

A move made on general considerations. 'Push the pawn to g5, driving the bishop off the f-file, then f4-f5 and mate' – White thought, absolutely correctly.

The move 28.♗xd5 was rejected, because it seems the game should end more quickly after 28.g3!. Even so, after 28...♖xd5 (28...♗g7 29.♖d1+–) 29.♖xf6+! exf6 30.♖xa7 ♖d6 31.♖h1! (an important move,

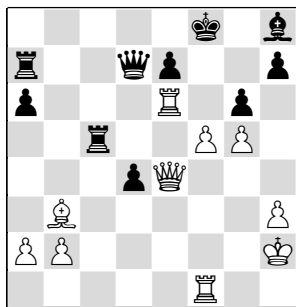
but well within a GM's capacity to find) 31...♖xf4 32.♖c1 ♗e4 33.♗xh7, White wins without any particular adventures.

28...♗h5 29.g4 d4 30.♗e4?!

Failing to pay attention to the opponent's possibilities.

If White had seen his opponent's 32nd move, he would have chosen the accurate 30.♗d3! ♖c5 31.g5 ♗g7 32.f5+–. White was already anticipating victory, and was in a good mood.

30...♖c5 31.g5 ♗h8 32.f5



Expecting Black to resign, White suddenly noticed to his horror that there is a defence.

32...♗b5!

A psychological blow. White still has a win, even a forced one, but in such situations, it is extremely difficult to switch the brain on again and return to serious work.

33.♖e1?

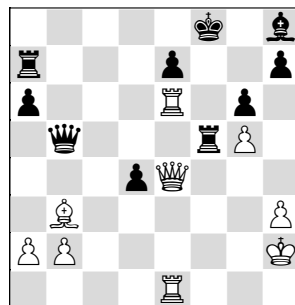
Another move played 'by eye', and based on the opponent's time-trouble. White simply could not believe that the opponent's scattered forces could pose any real resistance. In such situations, this mindset is simply not permitted! If you have missed something, then

maybe you will miss something else in later calculations. In such cases, it is useful to switch off your attention for a short while, and then regain full concentration and look at the position afresh, this time calculating variations carefully.

Had White been in the mood to look for nuances and calculate properly, he would probably have found 33.f6! ♗xf1 (33...exf6 34.♗xd4 ♗xf1 (34...♗b8+ 35.♖h1 ♗b7+ 36.♖e4+–) 35.♗d8+ ♖g7 36.♗g8+ ♖xg8 37.♖e8+ ♖g7 38.♖g8#) 34.fxex7+ ♖e8 (34...♖xe7 35.♗a8+ ♖f7 36.♗g8+ ♖xg8 37.♖xg6+ ♖f8 38.♖g8#) 35.♖a4+ ♖b5 (35...♗b5 36.♖xb5+ axb5 37.♗f4+–) 36.♗c6++–. This last check and mate is what White missed.

33...♖xf5!

He loses after 33...gxf5 34.♗h4 ♖e5+ 35.♖6xe5 ♖xe5 36.♗xd4+–.



34.♖xe7?

Mistakes rarely come in singles.

A) White loses after 34.♖xg6?? hxg6 35.♗e6 ♗b8+! 36.♖h1 ♖g7+–;

B) But after 34.h4! ♗b8+ 35.♖g2 ♖f4 36.♖b6! (36.♖f1 ♖xf1 37.♖xf1 ♗g3 38.♗d5!?) 36...♗a8 (36...♗c7 37.♗xe7+ ♗xe7 38.♖b8++–) 37.♗xa8+ ♖xa8 38.♖b7 ♖e8 39.♖g3 ♖f5 40.♖e6 ♖e5+ (40...♖e5 41.♖f1+ ♖g7 42.♖f7+

♔g8 43.♚f6+ ♔g7 44.♙b3!+—)
41.♔g2 ♙d6 42.♙xf5 gxf5 43.♚d1
♙e5 44.♚f1 e6 45.♚xh7, White still
obtains a decisive advantage.

34...♚f2+

Now, there is no win.

35.♔g3

An unpleasant discovery for White is that his intended 35.♔h1 is met by 35...♚f1+ 36.♔g2 ♚xe1—+.

35...♚xg5+ 36.♔xf2 ♚xe7

A draw arises after 36...♚xe7 37.♚a8+ ♔g7 38.♚g8+ ♔h6 39.♚f8+ ♚g7 40.♚xh8 ♚h4+ 41.♔f1 ♚xh3+ 42.♔g1 ♚g3+ 43.♔f1 ♚h3+ 44.♔g1 (44.♔e2? ♚e7+ 45.♔d2 ♚g2+ 46.♔d1 ♚f3+ 47.♔d2 ♚f2+—+) 44...♚g3+=.

37.♚g4

Continuing to play for a win.

Correct was 37.♚d5! ♚h4+ 38.♔g2 ♚xe1 39.♚g8+ ♔e7 40.♚xh7+ ♔d6 41.♚xa7 ♚e2+ 42.♔g1 ♚e1+=.

37...♚c5 38.♔g2?!

Now, White does not even have a clear draw.

38.♚e6! ♚f5+ 39.♚xf5+ gxf5 40.♙c2= was more solid.

38...♙f6 39.h4 ♚e7?

After this penultimate move before the time control, an equal position is reached.

Correct was 39...♔g7 40.♚e8 ♚c6+, when White must work for a draw.

40.♚xe7 ♚xe7 41.h5 ♔g7 42.hxg6 hxg6 43.♙c2 ♚b7+ 44.♔g1 g5 45.♚f5 ♚e7 46.♔f1 ♚e5 47.b4 ♚xf5 48.♙xf5 ♙e7

48...♙d8 49.♔e2 ♔f6 50.♙d3 g4 51.♙xa6.

49.a3 ♔f6 50.♙d3 a5 51.bxa5 ♙xa3 52.♔g2 ♔e5 53.♔f3 ♔d5 54.a6 ♙c5

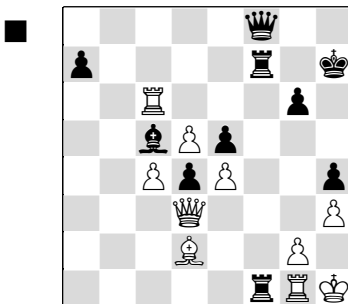
Draw.

234

Anatoly Karpov

Garry Kasparov

Seville Wch match 1987 (23)



White has a slight advantage, because of his more compact pawn structure. However, Black's major pieces are active, and his outside passed a-pawn cannot be left out of account. Black momentarily thought he could solve all his problems in one move.

50...♚f3??

Correct was 50...♙b4! 51.♚a6! (the a-pawn should be blockaded. He loses after 51.♚e2? ♙xd2 52.♚xd2 ♚xg1+ 53.♔xg1 ♚f1+ 54.♔h2 ♚a3 55.♚c7+ ♔g8 56.♚g5 ♚g3+ 57.♚xg3 hxg3+ 58.♔xg3 d3—+; Black has some initiative after 51.♙g5?! ♙e1↑ 52.♚a6 ♚xg1+ 53.♔xg1 ♙f2+ 54.♔h1 ♙g3 (54...♙e1=) 55.♚a1a5!) 51...♔g7!—by retaining the dynamic tension, Black could feel sufficiently confident.

51.gxf3 ♚xf3 52.♚c7+ ♔h8 53.♙h6!

This counterblow is what Black had 'forgotten about', although he had seen it in his preliminary calculations – this happens in chess, even at the very highest level!

53.♚xg6 ♚xd3 54.♚h6+ ♔g8 55.♚g6+ led to a draw.

53...♖xd3 54.♙xf8 ♜xh3+ 55.♔g2
♜g3+ 56.♔h2 ♜xg1 57.♙xc5 1-0

235

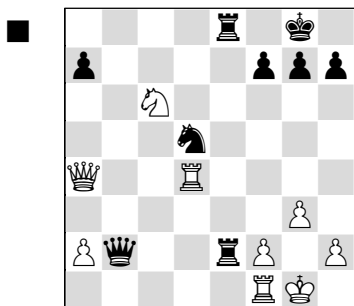
Anthony Wirig

Murtas Kazhgaleev

France tt 2003 (4)

2347

2600



If nothing happens, the a-pawns will be exchanged, and it will be a draw. But now, there followed a striking blow:

25...♜e3?

Striking does not always mean effective...! What is it that should

have alerted Black to the dangers and made him suspicious? Of course, the lack of a bolthole for his king. A counterblow lies in the wings.

26.♜e7+!

The player playing White lost his head, and after 26.♜b4? was knocked out by 26...♜xf2!. Mate is unavoidable, and after 27.♜e7+ ♜xe7, White resigned.

Finding White's refutation certainly requires some imagination, but another method of exploiting Black's back-rank weakness is easier to find: 26.♜e5 ♜b8 (if 26...♜f8 27.♜d3!) 27.♜c6 ♜xf2 28.♜xf2 ♜b1+ 29.♜d1 ♜xd1+ 30.♜xd1 ♜xd1 31.♜d2 ♜c3 32.♜c2, with a probable draw.

26...♜f8 27.♜g6+! hxg6

On 27...fxg6, there follows 28.fxe3 – check!

28.♜h4

And there is no defence against the check on h8.

Additional material

Jussupow-Fries Nielsen, Skien 1979 – White's 9th move

Sax-Kovacevic, Sarajevo 1982 – Black's 32nd move

Stein-Bronstein, Moscow 1971 – White's 22nd move

Karpov-Timman, Amsterdam 1981 – White's 16th move

Jussupow-Lputian, Frunze 1979 – White's 23rd move

Ruderfer-Butler, Odessa 1972 – White's 58th move

Karpov-Kasparov, Seville Wch (match/9) 1987

Karpov-Kasparov, Seville Wch (match/11) 1987 – White's 33rd and 35th moves

Chapter 30

Methods of defence

The various methods of defence can be split into the following categories:

1. Sharpening the game / the 'best chance' principle
2. Exchanging the opponent's key attacking pieces
3. Perpetual check
4. Tenacious patient defence

When falling into a bad or even lost position, many players simply 'swim with the tide', abandon any attempt at serious resistance, and accept the inevitable. In reality, when in such a position, one should seek a way to change the character of the game, and pose the opponent maximum practical problems in realising his advantage. Sometimes, to sharpen the game, one needs to decide on some sort of sacrifice – this is especially sensible when the quiet course of the game will see one defeated inevitably anyway. Even if the sacrifice is not entirely correct, the psychological effect of a sudden change in the nature of the struggle can throw the opponent off his stride. Sometimes, one can try to catch the opponent in a carefully-hidden trap – this requires the ability to calculate variations well. But even if there are no such chances, success often comes from patient, tenacious defence. Only a computer program can realise an advantage totally without nerves or other distractions. A human can always make a mistake or commit an inaccuracy, after each of which the defender's chances increase.

Defence is significantly less interesting for most players than attack, but it is essential to know the main principles and methods of defence, and be able to implement them in practice. One of such devices is perpetual check. Sometimes, one can give up several pieces to get one's queen through to the opponent's king, and save half a point.

In the final analysis, the best results are achieved by those players who are not only able to convert advantages effectively, but also defend difficult positions.

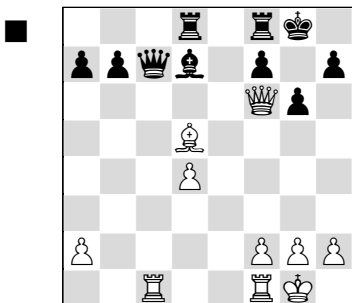
236**Konstantin Landa**

2571

Igors Rausis

2498

Düsseldorf 2004 (5)



One of the most important defensive devices is exchanging.

20... ♖b6!

Black gravely spoils his pawn structure – White effectively has an extra passed d-pawn after this. But, since the black king will be able to come to the centre quickly, once the queens are off, the d-pawn is not actually going anywhere.

White would retain minimal pressure after 20... ♖b8 21. ♕b3!?

21. ♖xb6 axb6 22. ♕b3

22. ♕xb7 ♕e6=.

22... ♕e6!

Forcing a transition into a drawn rook ending.

23. ♖fd1

After 23. ♕xe6 fxe6 24. ♖fd1 ♖f5 25. g3 ♖fd5 26. ♖c7 ♖xd4 27. ♖xd4 ♖xd4 28. ♖xb7 ♖a4 29. ♖xb6 ♖xa2=, it is also a draw.

23... ♕xb3 24. axb3 ♖d5 25. ♖d3 ♖fd8 26. ♖cd1 ♕f8 27. h4 ♖8d6 28. g3 ♕e7 29. ♕g2 ♕d7 30. ♖f3 f5

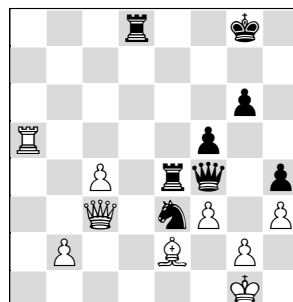
White is not at all better, and the passed pawn is not felt at all!

31. ♖fd3 h6 32. ♕f3 g5 33. hxg5 hxg5 34. g4 ♖f6 35. ♖1d2 fxg4+ 36. ♕xg4

♖f4+ 37. ♕g3 ♕c6 38. f3 ♕d6 39. ♖d1 ♕c6 40. ♖1d2 ♕d6 41. ♖d1 ♕c6 42. ♖c1+ ♕d6 43. ♖cd1 ♕c6 1/2-1/2

237**Vladimir Liberzon****Mark Taimanov**

Tbilisi ch-URS 1966 (4)



White had a chance to exploit Black's carelessness in leaving his king exposed:

36. ♖f6!

In the game, White naively took the rook, and resigned after 36. fxe4 ♖d1.

36... ♖ed4 37. ♖xg6+ ♕h8 38. ♖f6+ ♕h7 39. ♖f7+ ♕h6 40. ♖f6+

allows White to force perpetual check.

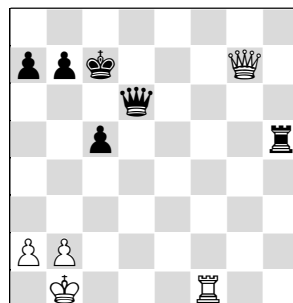
238**Nicolas Lubbe**

2422

Rüdiger Seger

2412

Bonn ch-GER 2011 (5)



White will win the queen, but will he win the game?

37...♖d7!

Covering the important square a4. Other moves do not save the game:

A) 37...♖c6 38.♖f6 ♖h1+ 39.♖c2 ♖h2+ 40.♖b3 ♖h3+ 41.♖a4 b5+ (41...♖h4 42.♖a3 ♖h3+ 43.b3+-) 42.♖a5+-;

B) 37...♖b6 38.♖f6 ♖h1+ 39.♖c2 ♖h2+ 40.♖b3 ♖h3+ 41.♖a4 ♖h4+ 42.♖a3 ♖h3+ 43.b3+-.

38.♖g3+

After 38.♖f7, Black has a simple perpetual check: 38...♖h1+ 39.♖c2 ♖h2+ 40.♖c3 ♖h3+ 41.♖c4 ♖h4+=. Of course, not 42.♖xc5?? b6#.

38...♖d6 39.♖f7+ ♖c6 40.♖xd6+ 40.♖f3+ ♖d5 41.♖f6+ ♖c7 42.♖f4+ ♖e5 does not promise White anything.

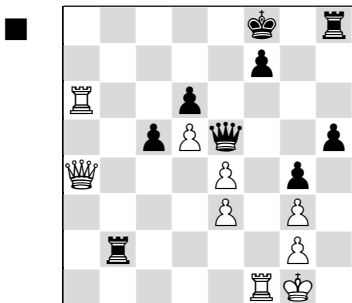
40...♖xd6 41.♖xb7 a5 42.♖a7 c4 43.♖c2 ♖c6 44.♖c3 ♖b6 45.♖a8 ♖b5 46.♖b8+ ♖a6 47.♖xc4 ♖h4+ 48.♖b3 ♖h3+ 49.♖a4 ♖h4+ 50.♖a3 ♖h3+ 51.♖b3 ♖h6 52.♖c3 ♖g6 53.b3 ♖h6 54.♖a4 ♖h4+ 55.♖c4 ♖h6 56.a3 ♖g6 57.♖f4 ♖h6 58.♖f8 ♖h4+ 59.b4 1/2-1/2

239

Wolfgang Pietzsch

Guido Cappello

Havana ol 1966 (6)



*

White's pressure on the f-file is very dangerous, and it is impossible to defend comfortably against the threats of ♖a6-a7 and ♖a4-d7. Therefore, instead of the tame surrender to the inevitable seen in the game, it was essential to abandon passive defence in favour of counterattack:

29...h4! 30.♖a7 ♖xg2+ 31.♖xg2 ♖xg3+ 32.♖h1 ♖h3+

with the idea of perpetual check.

240

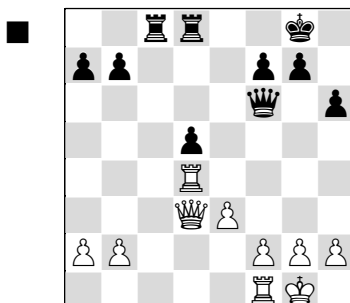
**

Salvador Del Rio de Angelis 2531

Jan Gustafsson

2643

Gibraltar 2012 (8)



Things are not great for Black, and with a normal development of the game, he will face a long and ultimately fruitless defence of the pawn on d5. Instead, the black player plays a series of moves that allow him to steer the game into a theoretically drawn endgame a pawn down.

22...♖b6!

Provoking White to weaken squares on the c-file, which Black currently controls.

23.b4

If White places his rook passively with 23.♖b1, there are two possibilities:

A) Playing for activity with 23...♙c4 24.♙xc4 dxc4 25.♙xc4 ♗d2=;

B) It is also worth considering the interesting idea 23...♗d6 24.g3 ♖a6! 25.♙xa6 (25.♙d1 ♙dc6!?) 25...♙xa6 26.a3 ♙c2 27.♙xd5 ♙f6 28.f4 ♙e6 29.♗d3 ♙e2=.

23...♙c6! 24.e4 ♖c2 25.exd5 ♙xd3 26.♙xd3 ♗d6!

The rook is excellently placed on the 6th rank. Also possible was 26...♙f8, after which he has to reckon with 27.d6 ♙c6 28.♙fd1 a6 (28...♙e8 29.b5 ♙b6 30.d7+ ♙e7 31.f4 a6 32.a4 axb5 33.axb5 g6) 29.a3 ♙e8 30.h4!, seizing space on the kingside (after 30.f4 ♙d7 31.f5 ♙dc8, the black rooks are very active, which gives him very considerable drawing chances; 30.♙e3+ ♙f8 31.♙ed3 ♙e8), 30...♙d7 (30...h5!? 31.♙e1+ ♙f8 32.♙e5 g6 33.♙ed5 ♙e8 34.♙h2 ♙d7 35.♙f3 f5 36.♙g3 ♙e6 37.♙c5±) 31.h5 ♙f8!? (31...♙e8 32.♙f3 f6 33.♙g3 ♙g8 34.♙d4 ♙xd6 35.♙dg4±) 32.♙h2 g5±. It seems that even with the pawn on d6, Black has good drawing chances, but why allow it that far?

27.♙fd1 ♙f8 28.♙f1?!

An inaccuracy. The only move to maintain the intrigue was 28.a3. White needs to keep all the rooks on the board for now. 28...a5! (exchanging off the queenside pawns is the simplest decision; 28...♙c2 29.♙e1 (29.h4 ♙f6! 30.♙3d2 ♙xd2 31.♙xd2 ♙e7=) 29...b6 30.g4 (30.g3 g5 31.♙g2 a5 32.bxa5 bxa5 33.♙b1 ♙c5 34.♙bd1 ♙e7=) 30...♙f6 31.f3 ♙d6 32.h4 g6=), 29.bxa5

♙c5 30.g4 g5 31.♙g2 ♙xa5±. White retains minimal chances of winning, but with accurate play, Black's drawing chances are significantly greater.

28...♙c2 29.♙3d2

After the exchange of rooks, the black king comes to d6 unhindered, attacking the white pawn, and the passive rook on d6 is freed for active operations.

29...♙xd2 30.♙xd2

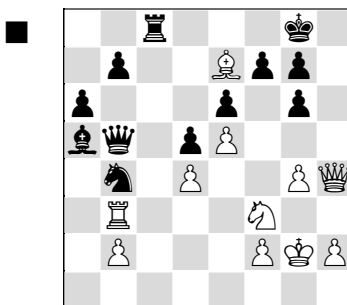
Draw. There could follow 30...♙e7 31.♙e2 ♙d7 32.♙e3 ♙d6 33.♙d4 ♙e7! and with his rook active, Black does not risk losing.

241

Maxime Vachier-Lagrave 2715

Wang Hao 2731

Wijk aan Zee 2011 (1)



Storm clouds are gathering over the black king. The threat is ♗g5 and mate.

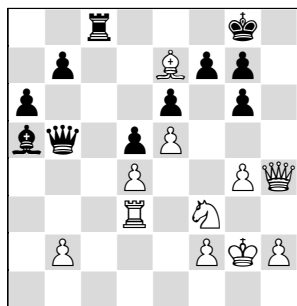
32...♗d3!!

Black finds a brilliant defence, based on the idea of perpetual check.

33.♙xb5

Other continuations are simply bad for White:

33.♗g5? ♗f4+ 34.♙g3 ♙xb3+ 35.♙xf4 ♗d2#. 33.♙xd3?



analysis diagram

33...g5!, an important intermediate move, changing the assessment of the position to 'winning for Black'.
34.♖xg5 ♜xd3-+.

33...♜f4+ 34.♔g3

At a minimum, unclear play results from 34.♔h1 ♜c1+ 35.♜g1 ♜e2 36.h3 (36.♔g2 ♜xg1 37.♔f3 ♜xd4+ 38.♔e3 ♜xb5∞) 36...♜xg1+ 37.♔h2 axb5 38.♜g5 ♜b1 – Black has excellent compensation for the pawn.

34...♜e2+ 35.♔h3 ♜f4+ 36.♔g3 ♜e2+ 37.♔g2 ♜f4+ 1/2-1/2

242

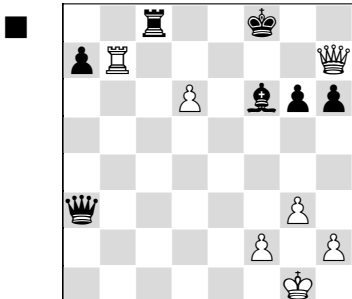
Vassily Ivanchuk

Boris Gelfand

Monaco rapid 2011 (8)

2779

2733



31...♜a1+?

Involving an oversight. From this square, the black queen can do little to help her king.

Correct was to send the queen on a different route: 31...♜c1! 32.♔g2 ♜c6+ 33.♔h3 (33.f3? ♜c2+-+; 33.♔g1 ♜c1+=) 33...♜e8!. From here, the queen defends the most important pawn on g6. White cannot create decisive threats. 34.♜xh6+ ♔g8 35.♜h7+ ♔f8. Now or shortly after, White will have to give perpetual check: 36.♜h6+ ♔g8 37.♜h7+ ♔f8 38.♜xa7 (38.f3 ♜d8 39.♜xa7 ♜xd6 40.♜h6 ♔g8 41.♜h7+ ♔f8=) 38...♜e6 39.♔g2 ♜e4=.

32.♔g2 ♔g7 33.♜xg6 ♜f6

34.♜xg7!

Black resigned.

243

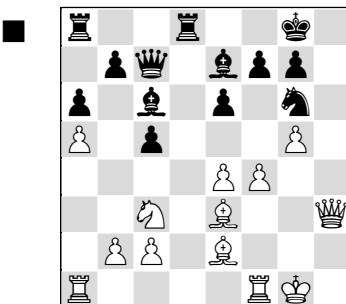
Ivan Saric

Niclas Huschenbeth

Germany Bundesliga 2011/12 (10)

2643

2510



Black has played the whole game passively, and now his position raises serious concerns. He has no space, and his pieces have no decent squares. And, worst of all, White threatens to transfer his rook to the h-file, when there will be no defence to mate.

Black must seek counterplay. The queenside is blocked, and 24...b5

leads only to a loss of time and a weakness after 25.axb6 (25.♖f2+—also wins) 25...♗xb6 26.f5 exf5 27.♗xf5+—, and ♕e2-c4 gives White a decisive attack.

In the game, Black continued messing around within his own camp, and after 24...♕d6 25.e5 ♕e7 26.♖f2 c4 (on 26...♗f8 the simplest is 27.f5 exf5 28.♖xf5, with a decisive attack) 27.♖h2 ♕b4 28.♕b6 lost feebly.

In order to obtain some sort of counterplay, he needed to decide on a

sacrifice on d3. There is also the idea of transferring the bishop via d8 to c7, freeing the e7-square for his king.

26. ♕xd4 cxd3

Here, White can only win in a problem-like manner, which would be extremely hard to demonstrate in a practical game.

27. cxd3!

If 27.♗xd3 ♖d8! 28.♗e3 ♖xd4! 29.♗xd4 ♖xf4, despite being two exchanges down, Black has counterplay.

27... ♖xf4 28. ♖xf4!!

In the event of the natural queen retreat, Black has positional compensation for the exchange.

28... ♗xf4 29. ♕e3 ♕c5

29...♗d6 30.♖f2—there is no defence to mate. The same is true after 29...♗e5 30.d4 ♗d6 31.♖g2.

30.d4 ♕xd4 31. ♕xd4 ♗xg5+ 32. ♖f2 ♗f4+ 33. ♗f3 ♗h2+ 34. ♗g2

There are some small technical difficulties in realising the extra piece, but that is not the point—Black had a real practical chance, which he did not exploit.

Positional sacrifice

24... ♖d4!

The rook exerts pressure on e4, and the black pieces become noticeably freer. If White takes the rook at some moment, his knight has to retreat to a passive square, and already Black may have reasonable compensation. One must add that such a device is quite standard, especially in the Sicilian Defence.

The strongest reply is

25. ♕d3

Defending e4, creating the threat of e4-e5, and planning, if the chance arises, simply to take the exchange. White cannot afford to ignore Black's play, because after 25.♖f2, there follows 25...♕d6! 26.e5 ♕xe5 27.fxe5 ♖h4, and it is Black who mates down the h-file!

Here, Black has a difficult choice. He can pose White practical problems with

25...c4!?

Another possibility is 25...♗d7, with ideas of ...c5-c4 and an exchange

244

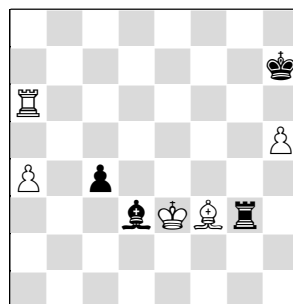
Loek van Wely

Hikaru Nakamura

Wijk aan Zee 2013 (8)

2679

2769



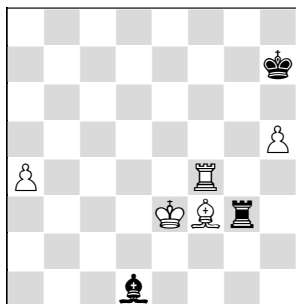
60. ♖c6?

To all appearances, White wins with 60.a5 ♖g5 (60...c3 61.♖c6+–) 61.♖a7+!. An important check, ensuring the heroic life of the h5-pawn. 61...♙h6 62.♖a8 ♖e5 63.♙d4 ♖f5 64.♙d5 c3 (64...♖xh5 65.♖h8 ♙g5 66.♖xh5+ ♙xh5 67.a6+–) 65.♙xd3 ♖xd5 66.♙xc3+–.

60...♙c2!

The continuation 60...♖g5 allows White to return to his main plan – the advance of the rook pawns: 61.♖a6 ♖e5+ 62.♙d4 ♖f5 63.♙d5 ♖xh5 64.a5± – the passed a-pawn is very dangerous.

61. ♖xc4 ♙d1 62. ♖f4



62...♖xf3+!!

A brilliant defence, based on a good knowledge of important endgame positions.

On 62...♙xf3, there follows 63.♖xf3 ♖g5 64.♙d2 ♖xh5 65.♖a3+–.

63. ♖xf3 ♙xa4

Such a position is winning only if the white pawn is no further forward than the fourth rank. In this instance, White's large material advantage is insufficient for victory.

64. ♖f6 ♙e8 65.h6 ♙g6 66. ♖xg6 ♙xg6 67.h7 ♙xh7

Draw.

245

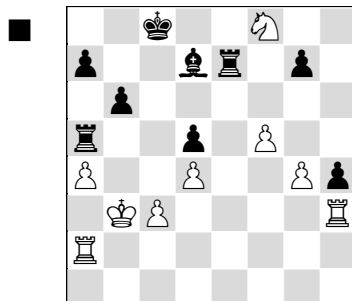
Peter Leko

Alexander Khalifman

Istanbul ol 2000 (3)

2743

2667



There are weak squares around the white king, but how does Black's bishop get to c4? It turns out that there is a way:

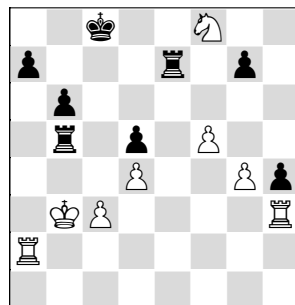
56...♙b5!

In the game, Black missed this chance, and was unable to hold the pawn-down rook ending arising after 56...♖e4 57.♙xd7 ♙xd7 58.♖xh4.

57.axb5

If the bishop is allowed to get to c4, Black is out of danger, e.g., 57.♖a1 ♙c4+ 58.♙a3 ♙b5 59.♙b4 ♖e2 60.♙g6 ♖b2+ 61.♙a3 ♖g2 62.♙b4 ♙c4 63.♙a3, with a repetition.

57...♖xb5+



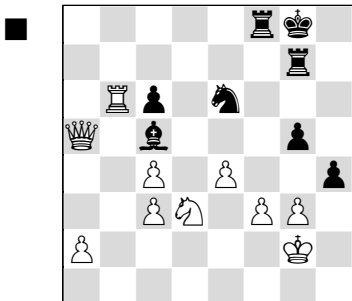
58.♙a4 ♖a5+ 59.♙b3 ♖b5+ with a draw by perpetual check.

246**Teimour Radjabov****Vassily Ivanchuk**

London 2013 (2)

2761

2779



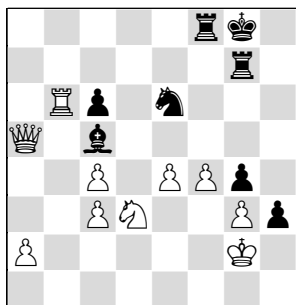
As often happens, the last chance was to try to attack the white king. After

33...g4!

the game could have ended in a draw. In extreme time-trouble, Black instead played 33...♙xb6?, and resigned a move later.

34.f4

White loses after 34.♘xc5? gxf3 35.♙f1 hxg3 36.♘d3 f2+; 34.fxg4 ♜xg4 35.♘xc5 ♜xg3+ 36.♙h1 ♜f1+ 37.♙h2 ♜f2+ 38.♙h1 ♜f1+=.

34...h3+**35.♙h2**

Other possibilities:

35.♙f1 ♜h7 36.♘f2 h2! 37.♘h1 ♜d8 38.♜xc6 ♜d1+ 39.♙e2 ♙xh1 40.♜xc5 ♜e1+ 41.♙f2 ♜f1+ 42.♙e2=.

35.♙h1 ♜d8 36.♘b2 ♜gd7!±.

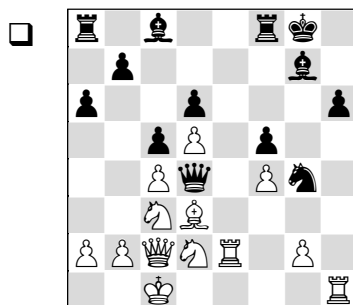
35...♜d8 36.♘xc5 ♜d2+ 37.♙g1 h2+ 38.♙h1 ♜d1+ 39.♙xh2 ♜h7+ 40.♙g2 ♜d2+ 41.♙g1 ♜d1+ with perpetual check.

247**Magnus Carlsen****Anish Giri**

Wijk aan Zee 2012 (5)

2835

2714

**23.♘a4!**

White has been completely outplayed in the opening. The black pieces occupy dominating positions in the centre. He only needs a couple more moves to complete the development of his queenside, and White's position will no longer be tenable. Black will play ...b7-b5, and open up the position of the white king. White decides to sharpen the position, sacrificing the exchange, but getting definite compensation.

23...♘e3

Black could take the exchange in other ways. After 23...♘f2 24.♜xf2 ♜xf2 25.♘b6 (25.♘f3!?) 25...♜xg2 26.♜f1 ♜b8 27.♘f3 ♜xc2+ 28.♙xc2 ♙f6 29.♜g1+ ♙f7 30.♘xc8 ♜bxc8 31.♙xf5 ♜b8 32.♘d2, White retains counterplay, since his pieces are very active.

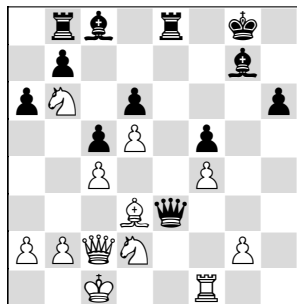
24.♜xe3!

24.♖b3 is grist to Black's mill: 24...b5! 25.cxb5 ♖b8 26.♙b1 (26. b6? ♙d7—+) 26...♗xd5 27.♗c3 ♙b7+.

24...♖xe3 25.♗b6 ♖b8 26.♙f1

It was also possible to play the prophylactic 26.♙b1 ♖xf4 (now, 26...♙e8 is no use, because there follows 27.♗xc8 ♖e1+ 28.♖c1 ♖xc1+ 29.♙xc1 ♙exc8 30.♙xf5=) 27.♗f3 ♙e8 28.♗xc8 ♖bxc8 (28... b5!?, attack before everything! The kings are on opposite sides, and the opposite-coloured bishops may also strengthen the attack. 29.cxb5 c4 30.♖xc4 ♖xc4 31.♙xc4 ♙exc8 32.♙d3 ♖c5 33.b3 ♖c3 34.♙xf5 ♖xb5 35.♙e6+ ♙f8 36.♙f1 ♙e8+; 28...♙exc8 29.♙xf5 ♙e8 30.♙e6+ ♙xe6 31.dxe6 ♖f6 32.♙e1 ♙e8 33.♖e2 ♙h8 34.♙c1!, prolonging the game) 29.♙xf5 ♖c7 30.♙e6+ ♙xe6 31.dxe6 ♙e7 32.♙e1 ♖f6 33.♖e2 ♙f8 34.♙c1 ♙e8, Black has an unquestioned advantage – the pawn on e6 is not a strength but a weakness, and the result of the game is unclear.

26...♙e8!



The key to the position – White wants to take on c8, win the pawn on f5, and get his bishop to e6 with check. He would also

like to exchange queens, for the simple reason that Black's pieces have more attacking potential. In addition, White would like, when exchanging queens, to retain a pair of rooks, otherwise he will not be able to hold the endgame. The bishop on e6 will do an excellent job of keeping both Black rooks out of the game.

27.♙b1

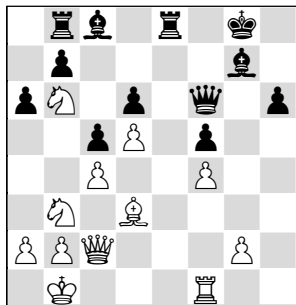
Weak is 27.♙d1? ♙h8!. The prophylaxis 28.♗xc8 ♖bxc8 29.♙xf5 ♖e2 30.♙c1 is met by 30...♖b8!, with the strong threat of ...b7-b5. He should not play 27.♗xc8?!, because of 27...♙exc8!. Black keeps the other rook on b8, and after ...b7-b5, White has to defend b2 (27...♖bxc8? 28.♙xf5 ♖e1+ 29.♖d1 ♖xd1+ 30.♖xd1 ♖b8 31.♙e6+ ♙f8 32.♙c2 b5 33.♙e1 – and the powerful bishop on e6 ensures White sufficient chances: 27...♖e1 28.♖d1 ♖xd1 29.♙xd1 ♖bxc8 30.♙xf5=) 28.♙xf5 ♖f8 29.♙e6+ (29.g4 b5!) 29...♙h8 30.♖b3 ♖d4! 31.g3 b5 and with queens on, Black has a powerful attack.

27...♖d4

Strong here was 27...♖e1+! 28.♖c1 (mass exchanges favour Black: 28.♖xe1 ♖xe1+ 29.♖c1 ♖xc1+ 30.♙xc1. As well as queens, White has also exchanged a pair of rooks, which is very important, and has a major effect on the result of the game: 30...♙d4 31.b3 h5 32.♙d1 ♙e3 33.g3 ♙xd2!? (the simplest) 34.♙xd2 ♙f7 35.♙e3 ♙e7 36.♙f3 ♙d7 37.♗xd7 ♙xd7 38.♙xf5+ ♙e7, with excellent winning chances) 28...♖g3! (Black does not want to

exchange queens) 29.♔c2 (29.♖c2 ♕e1+!; 29.♘xc8 ♖xd3–+) 29...♖xg2 30.♕e1+ ♖f8 31.♕e7 ♖h2! 32.♗f1 ♖h4 33.♕e3 ♗f6 34.♖c1 ♗d8!–+. The black queen has done enormous work over the past few moves.

28.♘b3 ♗f6



Despite the fact that Black did not play in the most accurate way at move 27, White's position remains dangerous. He does not fully equalise in a single variation.

29.♘c1

Let us look at other moves:

A) 29.♖h1 ♕e7 (29...♗d8? 30.♘xc8 ♖xc8 31.♕xf5 ♖c7 32.♕e6+ ♖h8 33.♘d2 ♗f6 34.f5 b5 35.♘e4 ♗e5 36.g4 bxc4 37.f6 ♕f8 38.g5+–; 29...♕e3 30.♘c1!) 30.♘c1 (30.a4 ♕d7 31.♘xd7 ♖xd7 32.♕xf5 ♕e7 33.♕e6+ ♖h8 34.♗d2 b5 35.cxb5 axb5 36.a5 c4 37.♘d4 c3!–+) 30...♕d7 31.♘xd7 ♖xd7 32.♕xf5 ♕e7 33.♕e6+ ♖h8 34.g4 b5 35.g5 ♗xf4 36.gxh6 ♕f6–+;

B) 29.♘xc8 ♖exc8 30.♕xf5 ♖f8 31.♕e6+ ♖h8.

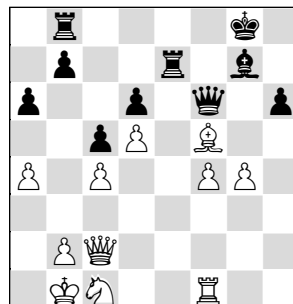
29...♕e7

29...♗d8?! removes the queen from her active position. There follows 30.♘xc8 ♖xc8 31.♕xf5 ♖b8 32.♕e6+ ♖h8 33.♗g6!, not letting the queen reach f6 without being exchanged.

30.♘xc8?!

Too early! White could use a tempo to eliminate the bishop on d7.

The right idea was 30.a4! ♕d7 31.♘xd7 ♖xd7 32.♕xf5 ♕e7 33.g4!



analysis diagram

33...b5 34.cxb5! axb5 35.a5!, closing the b-file, and hoping to create counterplay on the kingside. 35...♖a8 36.g5 hxg5 37.fxg5 ♗xg5 38.♕e6+!∞.

30...♖xc8 31.♕xf5 ♖ce8?

The wrong square! Correct was 31...♖b8! 32.g4 (32.♕e6+ ♖f8 33.g4 b5 34.cxb5 ♖xb5 35.♖f2 ♖eb7 36.♘b3 ♗xb2 37.♗xb2 ♕xb2 38.♖xb2 c4 39.♖f3 cxb3 40.axb3 a5 41.♖a3 ♖g7+. It is hard to give a definitive assessment of this endgame, but Black's winning chances are considerable) 32...b5 33.g5 hxg5 34.fxg5 ♗e5 35.♕h7 (35.♘d3 ♗e2 36.♗xe2 ♖xe2 37.♕e6+ ♖xe6 38.dxe6 bxc4 39.♘f4 ♖xb2 40.♖c1 ♖xa2 41.♖f3 ♖a1 42.♖d2 c3 43.♖d3 ♖d1 44.♖c2 ♕e1–+) 35...♖h8 36.♖h1 bxc4, and Black's trumps are the stronger.

32.♕e6+ ♖xe6 33.dxe6 ♗xe6

Now, the position is equal.

34.♖f2 ♗e4 35.♕e2 ♗xc2+ 36.♖xc2 ♖f8!

By swimming with the tide, Black could even find himself with

problems: 36...♖xe2? 37.♜xe2 ♔f7 38.g4 ♕e6 39.♜c3 ♜xc3? 40.♜xc3 d5 41.cxd5+ ♜xd5 42.♜d3+—.

37.♜d3 b5 38.b3 ♜f7 39.♜f2 ♜d8 40.♜e4 d5! 41.♜xc5

Now, 41.♜d2 ♜d4 42.cxd5 ♜xd5 43.g4 gives Black problems, but he can solve these by 43...♜g6! 44.♜d1 h5 45.♜xc5 ♜xc5 46.gxh5+ ♜xh5 47.♜xd4 a5, and he should hold the endgame a pawn down.

41...dxc4 42.♜xa6 ♜a8 43.♜b4 ♜f8 44.♜c3 ♜g7+ 45.♜c2 ♜f8 46.♜c3 ♜g7+ 47.♜d2 ♜f8 48.♜c2 ♜xa2 49.bxc4 bxc4 50.♜e4 ♜a4 51.♜e2 ♜c5 52.♜f3 ♜f6 53.g4 ♜f7 54.f5 ♜e7 55.♜e3 ♜a3 56.♜xc4 ♜g5 57.♜e4 ♜f6 58.♜e8 ♜xe3+ 59.♜xe3 ♜xe3 60.♜xe3 h5 61.gxh5 ♜xf5 62.h6 ♜g6 63.h7 ♜g7 64.♜e2 ♜xh7

Draw.

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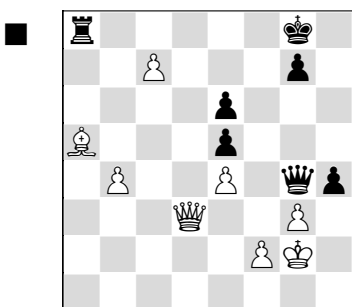
Viswanathan Anand

Vladimir Kramnik

Dortmund 2004 (1)

2782

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Not without reason, it looks as though Black is in serious trouble, as he has nothing with which to oppose the c-pawn and the b-pawn, which is hurrying to its support. The majority of players would have given up by

now, and just be awaiting the trivial promotion of the pawn. But at the very highest level, players seek every last chance to offer resistance. The only weak spot in White's position is his king. Black should ensure that the c-pawn does not promote with check, and so there followed:

55...♜h7!

The only chance.

56.♜b6

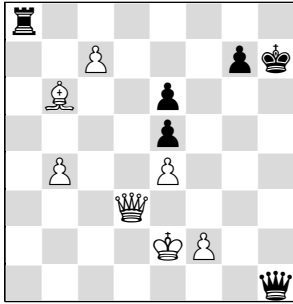
Pushing the pawns is not so simple: 56.b5 ♜f8 (56...hxg3? 57.♜xg3! ♜xe4+ 58.♜f3 ♜g6+ 59.♜h2 ♜h6+ 60.♜h3+—) 57.♜e1 (57.♜e3 hxg3! 58.♜xg3 (58.fxg3 ♜d1—; 58.f3 ♜h4 59.♜g1 ♜g6!) 58...♜xe4+ 57...♜f3 58.♜c2! ♜f7! 59.f4!? exf4 60.c8♜ fxg3 61.♜8c4 ♜f3+ (61...h3? 62.♜g1+—) 62.♜g1 ♜e3+ 63.♜g2 ♜f3+ (63...♜xe1 64.e5+ ♜g8 65.♜g6 h3+ 66.♜xh3 ♜h1+ 67.♜g4 g2 68.♜c8+ ♜f8 69.♜gxe6+ ♜h7 70.♜f5+ ♜xf5 71.♜xf5+ ♜g8 72.♜c8+=) 64.♜g1 (64.♜h3? ♜h1+ 65.♜g4 g2 66.e5 ♜f5—+) 64...♜e3+=. In this variation, one can suggest various deviations, but they do not lead to a win either, as you can check for yourself.

Even so, I would like to suggest an alternative. Since White cannot push his pawns, and his king is in danger on the kingside, why not transfer it to the other flank? Thus, one can find the strong idea:

Transferring the king to the other flank

56.♜f1! ♜f8 (White exchanges the h-pawn, reducing Black's attacking potential. The key variation is 56...h3, but this move makes the white king comfortable again in his own

home on the kingside, 57.♔g1!, and now Black cannot create any threats. 57...♖f8 58.♙b6 ♗f3 59.♖f1! ♗f8 60.♔h2 ♖f3 61.♖xh3+–) 57.gxh4 ♗f3 (57...♖xh4 58.♙b6 ♖h1+ 59.♔e2 ♗a8



analysis diagram

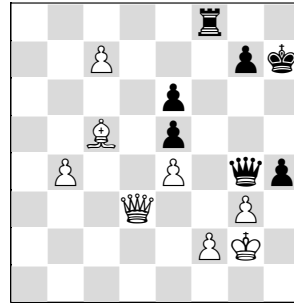
60.♖c2!. By forcing Black to go passive, White wins easily. 60...♖c8 61.b5 ♖h5+ 62.f3 g5 63.♙e3 g4 64.b6 gxf3+ 65.♔d3+–) 58.♖e2 ♖h3+ 59.♔e1 ♗f8! (59...♖c3? 60.♔d2. It turns out that the rook has no squares on the c-file. 60...♔g6 (60...♖c6 61.♖h5+ ♔g8 62.♖e8++–) 61.f3+–) 60.♔d1!, an important move – the white king wants to break through to the queenside to its passed pawns. It is also important to avoid putting a pawn on f3, so as to keep the possibility of a check on h5 (the following variation is not fully clear: 60.♖e3 ♖h1+ 61.♔e2 ♖b1∞; 60.♔d2? ♖b3!)=) 60...♖c3 (60...♖b3+ 61.♖c2 ♖f3+ 62.♔c1 ♖a3+ 63.♔b1 ♖c8 64.♖c5!, the ideal square for the queen. From there, it not only defends f2, but also stops the Black rook reaching f8. 64...♖b3+ (64...♔g6 65.♖xe5+–) 65.♔c1 ♖a3+ 66.♔d2 ♖b2+ 67.♔d3 ♖b1+ 68.♖c2 ♖f1+

69.♖e2 ♖b1+ 70.♔c4+–) 61.♖c2 ♖d4+ 62.♔e1 ♖a1+ 63.♔e2 ♖d4 64.♔f1!, and now the king can return to his kingside with a clear conscience (64.f3 ♖g1 65.♖c5 ♖h2+ 66.♖f2 ♖h1 67.♖f1 ♖xh4 68.b5 ♖e7 69.♖c1 ♖d7 70.♖c5+–), 64...♖a1+ 65.♔g2 ♖a3 66.♖e2 ♖c3 67.h5 ♔g8 68.♖e3+–. White has not only secured his king, but also eliminated the important h-pawn.

56...♗f8 57.♙c5

A) 57.♔h2 ♖h5! 58.gxh4 (58.g4? ♖xg4 59.b5 ♗f3+–; 58.♔g1? ♗f3! 59.♖e2 ♗xg3+ 60.♔f1 ♗g1+ 61.♔xg1 ♖xe2 62.c8♖ ♖g4+ 63.♔f1 h3+–) 58...♗f3! 59.♖xf3 ♖xf3 60.c8♖ ♖f4+=;

B) 57.b5 ♗f3! 58.♖f1 hxg3 59.♖h1+ ♔g6 60.c8♖ ♖xe4+=.



57...♗f3!

Black's counterplay is now enough.

58.♖b1 ♗xg3+

58...hgx3 59.♖h1+ ♔g6 60.c8♖ ♖xe4!! (60...gxf2+? 61.♔f1 ♗f7 62.♖d8+–) 61.♖e8+ (61.♖b1 ♗d3+ 62.f3 ♗d2+ 63.♔xg3 ♖xb1 64.♖xe6+=) 61...♗f7+ 62.♔g1 ♖e1+ 63.♔g2 ♖e4+=.

59.fxg3 ♖xg3+ 60.♔f1 ♖f3+ ½-½

Black can give perpetual check: 61.♔g1 (but not 61.♙f2? h3! 62.c8♖ h2+–) 61...♖g3+=.

Additional material

Dvoretsky-S. Sokolov, Moscow 1973 – White's 26th move
Dvoretsky-Averkin, Odessa 1974 – White's 28th move
Plaskett-Hebden, England 1982 – Black's 28th move
Geller-Polugaevsky, Portoroz 1973
Tal-Polugaevsky, Alma-Ata (match/2) 1980
Kasparov-Petrosian, Moscow 1981
Kasparov-Petrosian, Tilburg 1981
Spassky-Geller, Sukhumi (match/4) 1968 – Black's 35th move
Kasparov-Karpov, Moscow Wch (match/1) 1985 – Black's 18th move
Dorfman-Dolmatov, Rostov-on-Don 1980
Romanishin-Dvoretsky, Leningrad 1974 – Black's 17th move
Ivanchuk-Dolmatov, Manila 1990 – Black's 10th move
Cvitan-Short, Mexico 1981 – Black's 21st move
Zviagintsev-Ljubojevic, Pamplona 1995 – White's 26th move
Forintos-Vukic, Zemun 1980 – White's 34th move
Dolmatov-Podgaets, Kharkov 1985 – White's 22nd move
Kasparov-Petrosian, Tilburg 1981
Kasparov-Petrosian, Moscow 1981
Kasparov-Karpov, New York Wch (match/8) 1990 – Black's 30th move

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